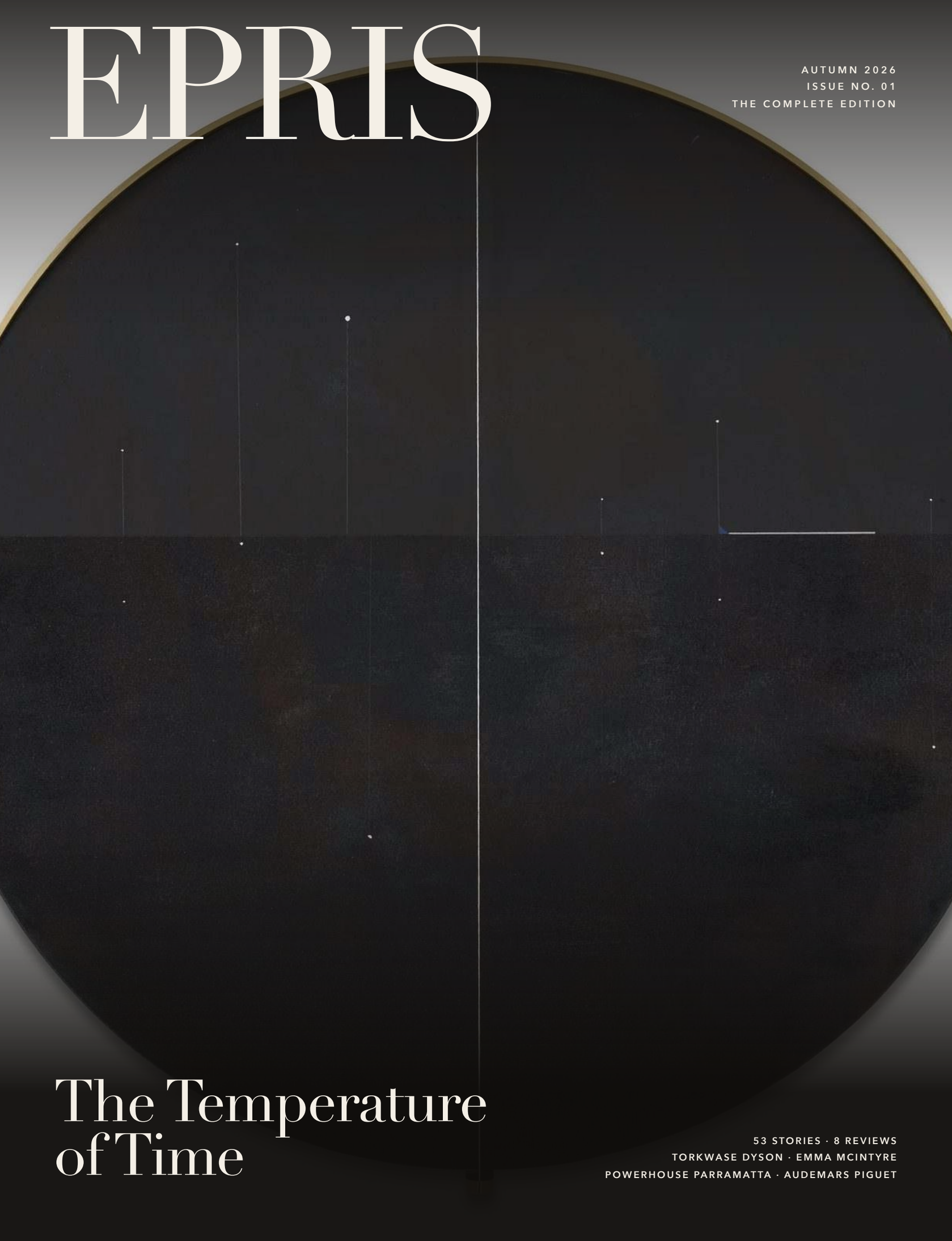
EPRIS

AUTUMN 2026
ISSUE NO. 01
THE COMPLETE EDITION



The Temperature of Time

53 STORIES · 8 REVIEWS
TORKWASE DYSON · EMMA MCINTYRE
POWERHOUSE PARRAMATTA · AUDEMARS PIGUET

“Nothing is timeless.
Some things simply learn how to carry time beautifully.”

The Temperature of Time

An issue about matter after the first touch: paintings that continue to change, buildings that expose their forces, objects that turn labour into memory, and the people who refuse to separate beauty from duration.

THE COMPLETE EDITION GATHERS EVERYTHING EPRIS PUBLISHED FROM SPRING TO THE FIRST DAYS OF OCTOBER 2026: 53 STORIES AND 8 REVIEWS, IN SIX SECTIONS.

Dear reader,

There are seasons we experience as weather, and others we understand through objects. Autumn is both. Light lowers and suddenly every surface begins to disclose its age: metal remembers the hand, stone keeps the rain, paper becomes warmer, and a room acquires shadows it did not possess in summer.

This issue began with that change in attention. We wanted to look at art, architecture and design not as finished images, but as things that remain in time. Emma McIntyre allows oxidation to continue after the painting leaves her hand. Torkwase Dyson gives abstraction the weight of bodies, movement and environmental pressure. Powerhouse Parramatta makes structural force visible across its skin. Audemars Piguet turns hours of nearly invisible labour into an object that can travel between generations.

These stories are different in scale, geography and medium, but they share a refusal of smoothness. They ask us to notice joints, revisions, stains, patience and uncertainty – the evidence that a work has passed through a human life.

This complete edition holds every story we have published so far, from the doors of Tbilisi in spring to the museum we open this October. I hope you will move through it slowly, return to its images, and find that one page changes the temperature of the next.

Maria Ivanova

EDITOR IN CHIEF · EPRIS JOURNAL

FROM THE AUTHOR

Against the timeless object

I have always distrusted the word *timeless*. It is offered as the highest compliment to a building, painting or object, yet it asks us to admire the work by removing the very condition that made it possible.

Everything in this issue has a date, a material history and a set of hands behind it. A perpetual calendar remembers a cultural convention about February. An exposed exoskeleton records how enormous rooms are held open. An oxidised field of colour keeps reacting with air. Even the quietest interior contains decisions shaped by distance, illness, migration, war and return.

Researching these stories meant following those conditions rather than polishing them away. It meant asking who receives authorship when an object is made by many specialists, what conservation should preserve when change is part of the work, and whether corporate support for art can create real freedom without pretending to be innocent.

The result is not a catalogue of beautiful things. It is an argument for attention. Beauty becomes more demanding when we can see its structure, cost, labour and vulnerability. It becomes less like escape and more like knowledge.

Viacheslav Munister

AUTHOR AND RESEARCHER · EPRIS JOURNAL

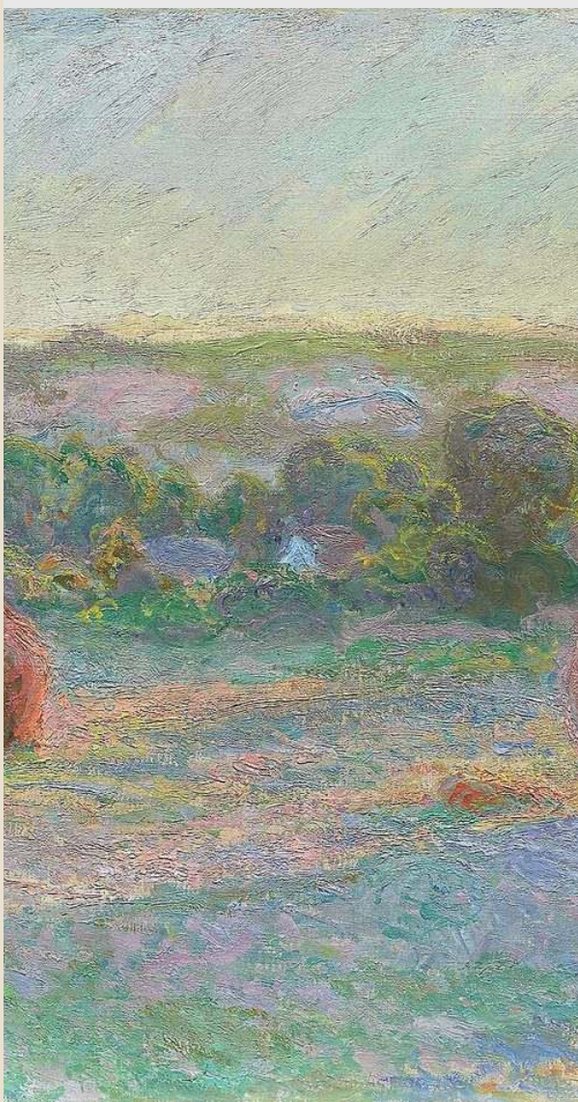
INTRODUCTION

Why temperature?

Temperature is the point where perception becomes physical. We recognise it before we explain it. A cold surface, a warm shadow, the blue of distance or the red-brown bloom of oxidation tells the body how to enter an image.

The autumn issue uses temperature as a way of reading time. Not chronology, but contact: what changes because air, weather, labour and memory have touched it.

Time is not outside the work. It is one of its materials.



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Made by many hands

Maria Ivanova

EDITOR IN CHIEF

Architect and designer exploring the invisible threads between contemporary art, design and the built environment.

Viacheslav Munister

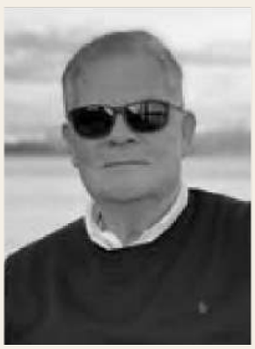
AUTHOR AND RESEARCHER

Writer and digital heritage specialist working across architecture, urban culture and collective memory.

Edward Nesterov

DIRECTOR OF COMMUNICATIONS · USA

VOICES IN THIS ISSUE



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Olha Wood

INTERIOR ARCHITECT · KYIV

Also in conversation: Winnie Tam of 28 a.m., Veronika Chernienko, Oksana Dzhuman, Diana Aleshchenko, DIHLUST, Chora Practice, Souv and Museo Nivola.

SECTION I

Painting & Matter

A painting is not an image laid upon matter. It is matter learning how to remember pressure, weather, touch and revision.

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CONTEMPORARY PAINTING OCT 2, 2026

The Painting Is Still Wet: Emma McIntyre and Art That Refuses to Finish

Emma McIntyre paints with rust, oxidised copper, bone black, gravity and time—making works that continue to change after the artist has stopped touching them.

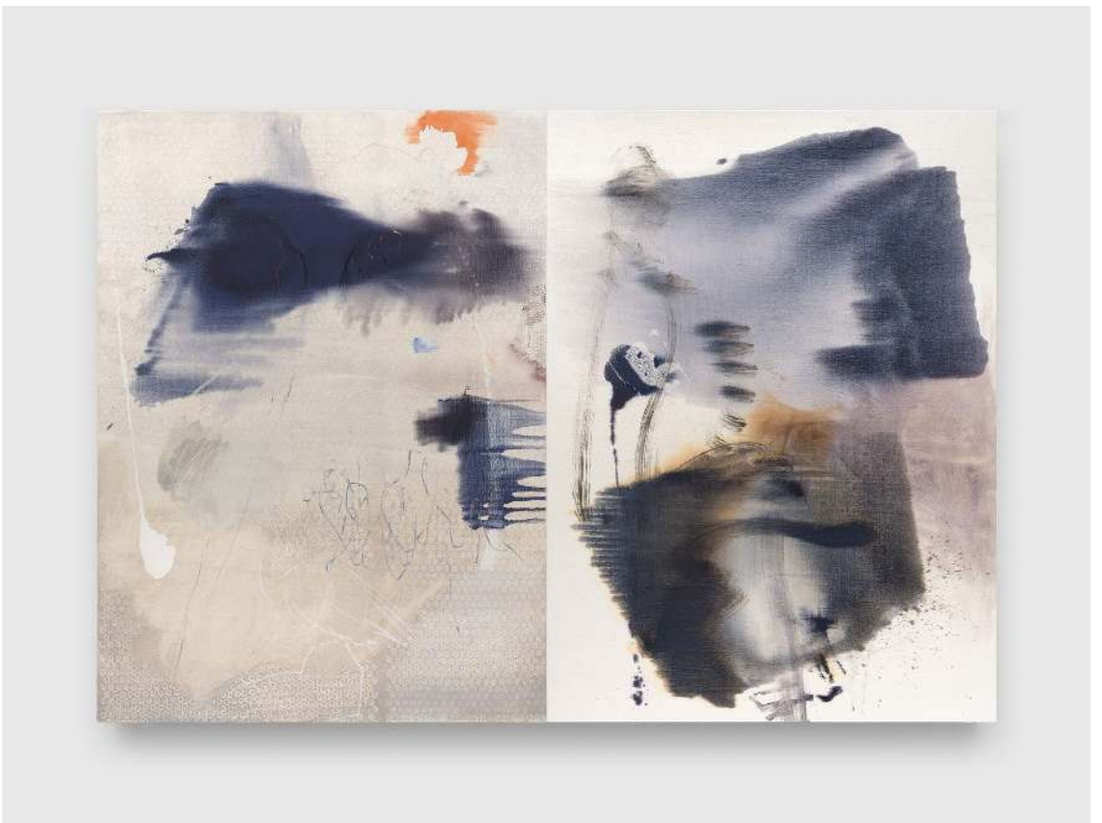
WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · CONTEMPORARY PAINTING · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Emma McIntyre paints with rust, oxidised copper, bone black, gravity and time—making works that continue to change after the artist has stopped touching them.

The fiction of a finished painting is useful. It gives the museum a date, the market a stable object and the art historian a boundary: before completion, the artist was deciding; after completion, the work began to mean. Emma McIntyre's paintings disturb that sequence. Rust keeps blooming. Copper continues to oxidise. A surface changes after the hand has withdrawn.

In *This body holds / swamp stuff*, at David Zwirner's 52 Walker in New York, McIntyre treats painting less as the execution of an image than as the temporary organisation of reactions. Oil, iron, copper, bone black, solvent, pressure, gravity and bodily contact meet on canvas. The artist initiates conditions, but matter retains the right to answer.



Emma McIntyre, Violet for the temple veil, 2026, oil, Flashe, iron oxide and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

I Who finishes the painting?

Western painting has long attached authority to the final touch. Completion confirms authorship: the painter has decided that no further mark is necessary. McIntyre replaces this sovereign model with collaboration. She pours and tilts, presses bubble wrap into

wet pigment, oxidises metal-based paint and takes impressions from her own palette and body.

None of this means surrendering intention. Chance is prepared, watched and edited. The relevant distinction is not control versus accident, but complete control versus responsive control. McIntyre makes a move, observes what the material does, and composes the consequence.

Emma McIntyre, Solve et coagula, 2026, oil, oil stick, copper paint and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

II Alchemy without mysticism

Solve et coagula names the alchemical instruction to dissolve and recombine. The phrase can sound mystical, but McIntyre's process is stubbornly physical. Iron meets an oxidising solution and becomes rust. Copper produces blue-green compounds. Pigment thinned with solvent follows gravity across a horizontal support.

Alchemy here is not a fantasy of turning base matter into gold. It is a method for letting substances disclose behaviours that conventional studio technique tries to stabilise. Paint ceases to be colour carried by a neutral medium; it becomes an active chemistry with duration, incompatibility and risk.

III Rust is a clock

Emma McIntyre, Pearls of ambergris, 2026, oil, iron paint and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

Rust is usually understood as failure: evidence that a protected surface has been breached and time has entered. McIntyre makes that breach productive. Oxidation creates orange and brown blooms whose edges record the movement of liquid and air. The mark is not painted to resemble corrosion. It is corrosion.

This difference collapses representation into event. A landscape painter may depict weather; McIntyre allows atmosphere to participate chemically in the work. Each oxidised passage is a clock whose units are moisture, oxygen and exposure. The painting possesses a time that does not coincide exactly with the artist's labour.

Emma McIntyre, This iliaster flowers like the wind, 2026, oil and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

IV

A body made of swamp stuff

The exhibition title comes from Diane di Prima's poem "Show Me Your Other Body": "this body holds / swamp stuff / thick viscous / life-generating Mud." The body imagined here is not a sealed figure separated from environment. It is porous, mineral, wet and generative.

McIntyre's abstractions repeatedly move between bodily and geological scales. A stain can resemble bruised skin, a cloud system, pond water or a microscopic culture. None of those readings becomes definitive. The painting behaves like a body precisely because it cannot be reduced to anatomy: it absorbs, reacts, scars and changes state.

Emma McIntyre, Bright medusas, 2026, oil, oil stick and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

V

The body without a figure

Abstract expressionism made gesture into evidence of the artist's body, but often converted that body into heroic signature. McIntyre uses bodily contact differently. Impressions, drags and pours appear alongside repeated industrial patterns and chemical reactions. Agency is distributed among hand, tool and substance.

In *Bright medusas*, a bubble-wrap grid crosses a vivid pink field. The humble packing material produces a cellular pattern that can read as skin, eggs, pixels or a protective membrane. Mechanical repetition and sensuous colour are not opposites. The painting's body is built from their collision.

VI Giotto enters through copper

Emma McIntyre, Beautiful old lies, 2026, oxidised copper paint, oil and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

Beautiful old lies turns oxidised copper into a saturated blue field. The colour invokes the prestige of lapis lazuli in Giotto's Scrovegni Chapel while arriving through an entirely different material history. Medieval blue signified the expense of mineral pigment and the authority of the sacred image. McIntyre's blue is produced by change, exposure and corrosion.

A semiabstract angel's wing derived from Giotto enters the surface as a recognisable fragment. Figuration does not organise the painting; it alights briefly within a material weather system. The historical reference is therefore neither quotation nor homage. It tests whether the sacred can survive when its image and substance no longer guarantee permanence.

VII Painting against the screen

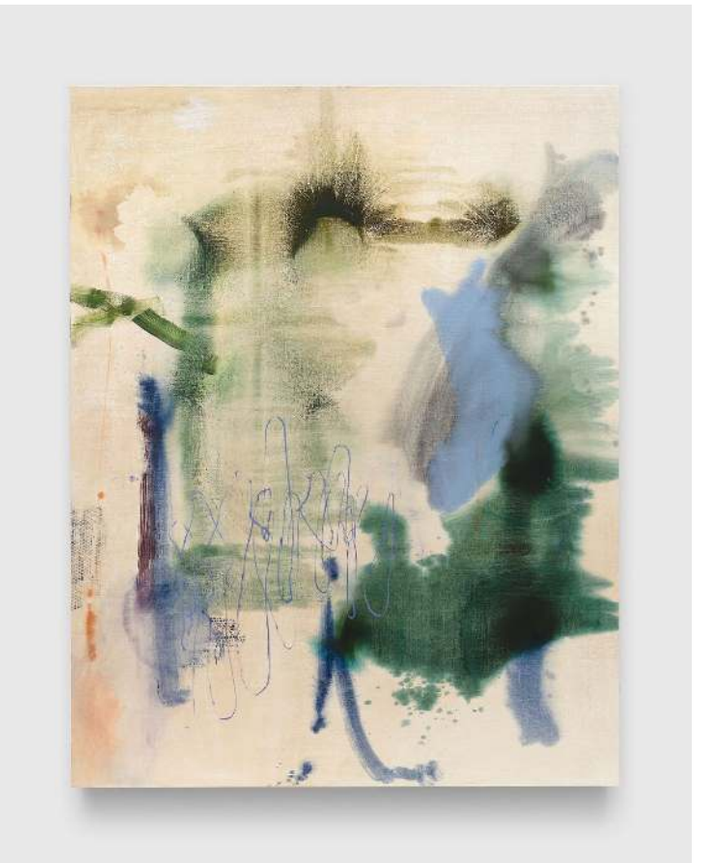
A digital image promises consistency. The same file can appear on thousands of screens, varying in calibration but not in its underlying data. McIntyre's paintings resist this form of identity. Their colour depends on reflected light; metallic and oxidised passages shift with angle; slow chemical change separates the object of tomorrow from the photograph taken today.

Emma McIntyre, Swear it by the shadows, 2026, oil and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

This does not make them pure or technologically innocent. They circulate online, through fairs and as market images. But the reproduction contains an honest failure: it cannot fully stabilise its subject. At a moment when synthetic images can imitate almost any pictorial style, material duration becomes more than craft. It becomes a form of difference.

VIII

Monochrome as weather



Emma McIntyre, Those muted those rain tones, 2026, oil and mixed media on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

Several paintings lean toward monochrome without accepting its historical claim to purity. A McIntyre monochrome is crowded with temperature, stains, buried marks and competing densities. It does not remove the world from painting. It lets the world arrive as weather.

The atmospheric field changes as the viewer's attention moves. A pale zone thickens into a body; a dark wash becomes space; a scratched line briefly reads as writing and dissolves again. Perception repeats the material process: forms coagulate and disperse.

IX

Bone black and the ethics of material

In *Crackle and drag*, white paint crosses a ground made with bone black – a pigment traditionally produced from charred animal bone. The name forces an awareness that colour is never merely optical. Pigments have bodies, sources, trade routes and residues.

Contemporary painting often speaks about materiality as tactile pleasure, but materials are also evidence of extraction and transformation. Copper must be mined; iron corrodes; bone becomes carbon. McIntyre does not turn every ingredient into an explicit moral argument. She keeps its prior life audible inside the painting.

X

The diptych as experiment

Violet for the temple veil began as two panels poured separately with blue-black paint before being joined. The resulting symmetry resembles a Rorschach test, an open book or a body split along a vertical axis. Yet the halves do not mirror one another perfectly. Material variance interrupts the desire for equivalence.

The diptych makes method visible. Joining is not the final concealment of difference but its display. Painting becomes comparative: two surfaces receive related conditions and produce distinct outcomes. The viewer looks not for a single image but for the interval between reactions.

XI

Paper remembers the palette

McIntyre's works on paper are not preparatory illustrations for larger canvases. They often begin with leftover mixtures from earlier paintings or direct impressions of the palette itself. A by-product becomes a beginning. Waste becomes an archive of possible colour.

This cyclical studio economy complicates the fantasy of the isolated masterpiece. Each work shares matter and decisions with others. Paint travels between supports; motifs migrate; an ending leaves the residue from which another composition starts. The practice is rhizomatic because influence moves sideways rather than down a clean line from sketch to finished work.

XII

The romance of chance

Process-driven abstraction carries a familiar danger: chemical effects can become spectacle, and "letting materials speak" can disguise weak decisions. Rust, blooms, pours and imprints are visually persuasive before they are compositionally necessary. Accident is not automatically freedom.

McIntyre's best paintings avoid this trap by making contingency answer to structure. A crisp figurative fragment cuts through a dispersed field; a hard edge halts a wash; an ugly colour prevents atmosphere from becoming tasteful. The work succeeds when material surprise is not the conclusion but the next problem.

XIII

What remains unfinished

No artwork literally escapes completion. At some point the painting leaves the studio, receives a title, enters an exhibition and becomes an object of ownership. Conservation may eventually work to slow the very transformations the artist invited. Institutional life rebuilds stability around unstable matter.

But McIntyre's work retains a productive remainder. Completion becomes a negotiated threshold rather than a natural fact. The artist stops composing; the chemistry does not entirely stop. The collector acquires an object but not perfect control over its future appearance. Time is not damage arriving from outside. It is one of the materials already included.

McIntyre does not paint an image of change. She gives change a limited authorship inside the painting.

XIV

Verdict

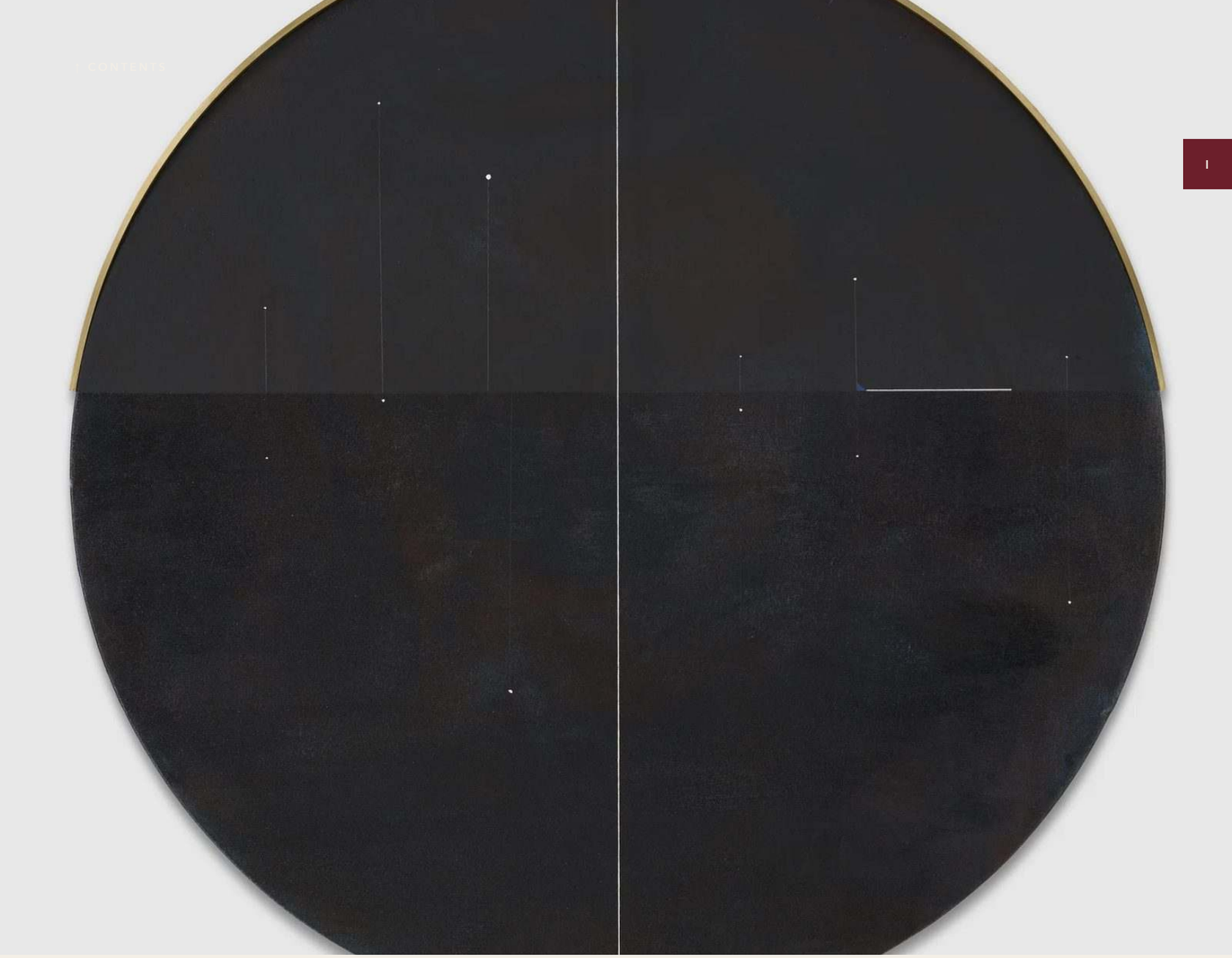
This body holds / swamp stuff offers a compelling answer to a central problem in contemporary abstraction: how can a painting remain materially intelligent after the language of gesture, stain and chance has become familiar? McIntyre's answer is to make those marks consequences of real reactions, bodily procedures and historical materials.

The paintings are not alive, but neither are they inert in the way their digital reproductions suggest. They oxidise, reflect, absorb and age. Their refusal to finish is modest rather than theatrical. It reminds us that every stable image is a temporary agreement between matter, time and the conditions under which someone is looking. ■

Emma McIntyre: This body holds / swamp stuff is at David Zwirner, 52 Walker Street, New York, from 18 September to 24 October 2026. All works in the exhibition were made in 2026. This article was prepared from official exhibition materials and published interviews; it does not claim an in-person visit. Images are reproduced for editorial review with credits supplied by David Zwirner.

FURTHER

This body holds / swamp stuff — David Zwirner	davidzwirner.com/exhibitions/2026/emma-mcintyre
Exhibition press release — David Zwirner	davidzwirner.com/exhibitions/2026/emma-mcintyre/press-release
Emma McIntyre interview — David Zwirner / Flaunt	davidzwirner.com/news/2023/emma-mcintyre-interviewed-in-flaunt
If not, winter: oxidation and printmaking — David Zwirner	davidzwirner.com/exhibitions/2024/emma-mcintyre-if-not-winter



CONTEMPORARY PAINTING SEP 30, 2026

The Ocean Is Not Blue: Torkwase Dyson and the Politics of Abstraction

In Seeing in Blue, Torkwase Dyson asks whether painting can hold the ocean as physics, memory, extraction and freedom at once—and whether abstraction can make climate crisis felt before it becomes an image.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · CONTEMPORARY PAINTING · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

In Seeing in Blue, Torkwase Dyson asks whether painting can hold the ocean as physics, memory, extraction and freedom at once—and whether abstraction can make climate crisis felt before it becomes an image.

The ocean is not blue. Water has no colour of its own; it borrows, scatters, absorbs and returns light. Blue is therefore not a property but an event – a relation between depth, distance, matter and an eye. This unstable fact is the beginning of Torkwase Dyson's new paintings, and it prevents them from settling into the category that their beauty initially suggests.

At Pace Gallery in New York, *Seeing in Blue* presents paintings informed by more than a decade of swimming and deep-sea diving. Their dark aquatic fields are crossed by arcs, strings, seams, brass bars and small apertures. They appear at once as maps, instruments, night skies and fragments of architecture. Yet they illustrate none of these things. Dyson's question is more demanding: can painting carry the physical knowledge of water – and the political histories contained within it – without reducing either to an image?

Torkwase Dyson, Daydreaming, 2026, acrylic, ink, graphite, bronze and cotton string on canvas, 48 × 48 × 5 in. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

I

Against the climate image

Contemporary culture has developed a stable visual language for ecological crisis. Aerial photographs show burning forests, retreating ice, poisoned rivers and coastlines seen from satellites. These images are necessary as evidence, but their repetition produces a paradox: the more completely catastrophe is pictured, the more easily it becomes scenery. The viewer is placed safely outside the event, looking down.

Dyson removes that distance. Her paintings do not show an ocean; they ask what it means to have a body inside one. Pressure replaces panorama. Buoyancy replaces horizon. Breath becomes a measure of time. Navigation is no longer a line drawn over a map but the continuous negotiation between density, darkness and movement.

Torkwase Dyson, To Plunge, To See, To Never, To Time, To Shadow, To Remember, 2026, acrylic, ink, graphite, brass and cotton string on canvas. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

II

Physics and memory

Dyson describes working with water as moving "between physics and memory." The phrase resists the division between objective environment and subjective experience. Water obeys pressure, gravity and temperature; it also stores histories of transport, extraction, labor, migration and death. To enter it is to meet both systems at once.

Her studio process repeats this double movement. She begins with canvases laid on the floor, allowing washes of diluted colour to spread, pool and escape complete control. She then answers that errancy with measured geometric construction. Flow is followed

by structure; accident by decision. The painting becomes a negotiation between what matter does and what a body asks it to do.

Side view of To Plunge, To See, To Never, To Time, To Shadow, To Remember, showing the painting's constructed depth and brass element. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

III Abstraction is the subject

Dyson has made an essential distinction: she does not describe herself simply as an abstract artist; she has chosen abstraction as a subject. The difference matters. Abstraction is not a style applied after the political content has been decided. It is itself a political operation: the process by which bodies, territories and resources are converted into categories, property lines, statistics and zones of control.

A map is an abstraction. So is a shipping route, a flood-risk boundary, a prison plan, a deed, an insurance district and the financial instrument that makes extraction profitable before anything has been removed from the ground. Abstraction can erase lived specificity. It can also allow a person to imagine space otherwise. Dyson works inside this conflict rather than pretending abstraction is innocent.

Torkwase Dyson, Hand to Hand, Heart to Heart (Unknown of Us 1), 2026, acrylic, ink, graphite, brass, bronze and cotton string on canvas. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

IV

Black geography is not a theme

For Dyson, ecology cannot be separated from Black spatial history. The Atlantic is a living system and a historical structure: a medium of forced movement, trade, colonial extraction and diaspora. Land is never only landscape when plantations, property and environmental exposure have determined which bodies may occupy it safely.

This is why "Black geography" in her work is not iconography to be located in a picture. It is a way of thinking about movement under unequal conditions. Her shapes draw from histories of self-emancipation and improvised shelter: how to hide, turn, pass, breathe, build and remain indeterminate inside systems designed to make a body legible and controllable.

Torkwase Dyson, Hand to Hand, Heart to Heart (Unknown of Us 3), 2026, acrylic, ink, graphite, brass, bronze and cotton string on canvas. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

V

Geometry after freedom

Dyson calls parts of her formal vocabulary "hypershapes." Curves, wedges, apertures and compressed rooms are distilled from liberation strategies rather than from geometry as an autonomous language. Their sources include the spatial intelligence through which enslaved and fugitive people survived: the hull, the garret, the hidden route, the narrow opening and the architecture made usable against its intended purpose.

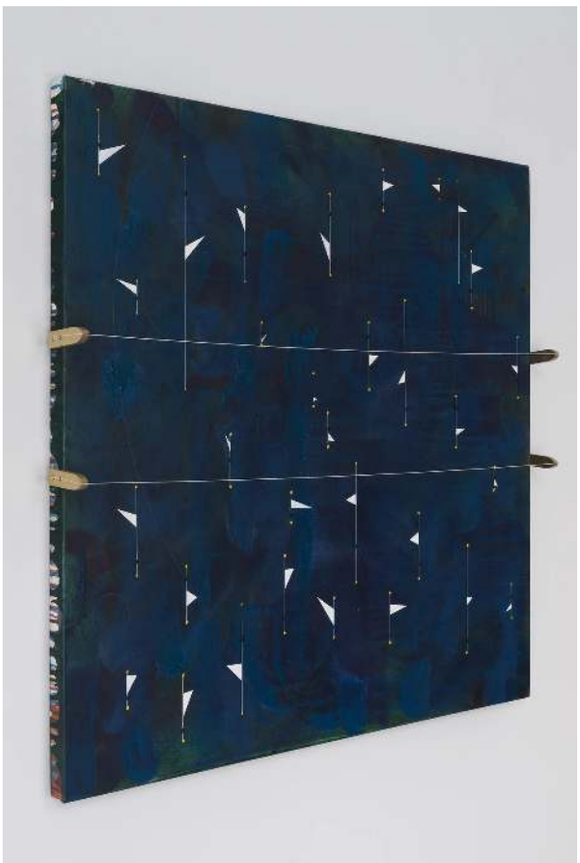
The forms do not decode into a single story. That refusal is crucial. A symbol becomes governable once its meaning is fixed. Dyson's geometries remain available for movement; they can be read as enclosure and exit, pressure and protection, structure and breach. Freedom appears not as unlimited open space but as the ability to compose within constraint.

Torkwase Dyson, The Distance Inside Us, 2026, acrylic, ink, graphite, brass and cotton string on canvas. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

VI

A painting with an edge

Photographed frontally, these works can look restrained and almost immaterial. Seen obliquely, they disclose their objecthood. Cotton string stands away from the surface; brass and bronze interrupt the painted field; canvases possess substantial depth; circular and irregular supports reject the neutral rectangle.



Oblique view of Daydreaming, 2026. The bars, string and deep support turn the painting into a spatial proposition. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

The side view changes the argument. A line is not only drawn; it is tensioned across space. A bar is not only a colour; it has weight, conductivity and resistance. The work oscillates between diagram and construction. It does not depict architecture so much as make the viewer encounter painting architecturally – through distance, position and bodily scale.

VII

Blue without innocence

Dyson's earlier paintings often approached blackness through layered mixtures rather than a single black pigment. In *Seeing in Blue*, aquatic colour comes forward, but the blue is equally impure. Titanium white can make it seem incandescent; green flickers below it; rust-red passages suggest oxidation, sediment or an atmosphere losing equilibrium.

Torkwase Dyson, A Blue Tongue, A Blue Song, 2026, acrylic, ink, graphite, brass, bronze and cotton string on canvas, 42 in diameter. Courtesy the artist and Pace Gallery.

The blue therefore refuses the cultural promise commonly attached to it: serenity, infinity, escape. Dyson rejects what she calls the merely "vacation beautiful." Her oceanic beauty is prehistoric, vulnerable and terrifying. It includes artificial reefs and living ecologies, but also seafloor drilling, military posts, acoustic surveillance and the ruins of the built world.

VIII Beauty as a method of staying

There is a temptation to treat beauty as politically suspect whenever the subject is disaster. The fear is understandable: beauty can aestheticize damage and make violence consumable. Dyson proposes another function. Beauty can hold attention where spectacle exhausts it. It can keep a viewer inside complexity long enough for relations to emerge.

Her surfaces do not reward a quick scan. Near-black passages require the eye to adjust; fine strings and graphite marks disappear and return; metallic interruptions alter with the viewer's position. Looking becomes slow, physical and incomplete. That incompleteness is not evasive. It is a rehearsal for encountering an ecology that cannot be mastered from a single point of view.

IX The scale of intimacy

Much of Dyson's practice has moved across monumental painting, sculpture, architecture and collective study. These new works compress that research into a more intimate register. Their scale does not make the subject smaller. It changes the relation from public address to proximity.

Blue Worlding for Love pushes beyond the wall as a support. Its layered planes and brass member resemble a compact shelter, instrument or incomplete model. The title matters: "worlding" names the active construction of relations rather than the passive occupation of a given world. Love enters not as sentiment but as a spatial practice – the work of making conditions in which another body can live.

X What the paintings cannot do

No abstract painting can explain climate science, repair an ecosystem or redistribute environmental risk. Dyson's theoretical vocabulary is dense enough that the works can appear inaccessible without prior knowledge. The gallery context adds another contradiction: objects concerned with liberation and unequal space circulate through one of the most exclusive spatial economies in culture.

But demanding that a painting solve the crisis it addresses would repeat the instrumental logic the work opposes. Its function is different. Dyson makes visible the habits through which knowledge is organized: the preference for views from above, for clean boundaries, for catastrophe rendered as an image happening elsewhere. Her paintings shift knowledge back toward the body – not as pure feeling, but as a sensing instrument implicated in history.

Dyson does not paint the ocean as a place to look at. She paints what happens to knowledge when the body is already inside it.

XI Verdict

Seeing in Blue succeeds because it refuses to make ecological painting legible through familiar signs of nature. There are no waves to admire, no horizon to lose oneself in and no ruined coastline to confirm what the viewer already knows. Instead, water becomes a method for rethinking painting: fluid and constructed, material and mnemonic, beautiful and compromised.

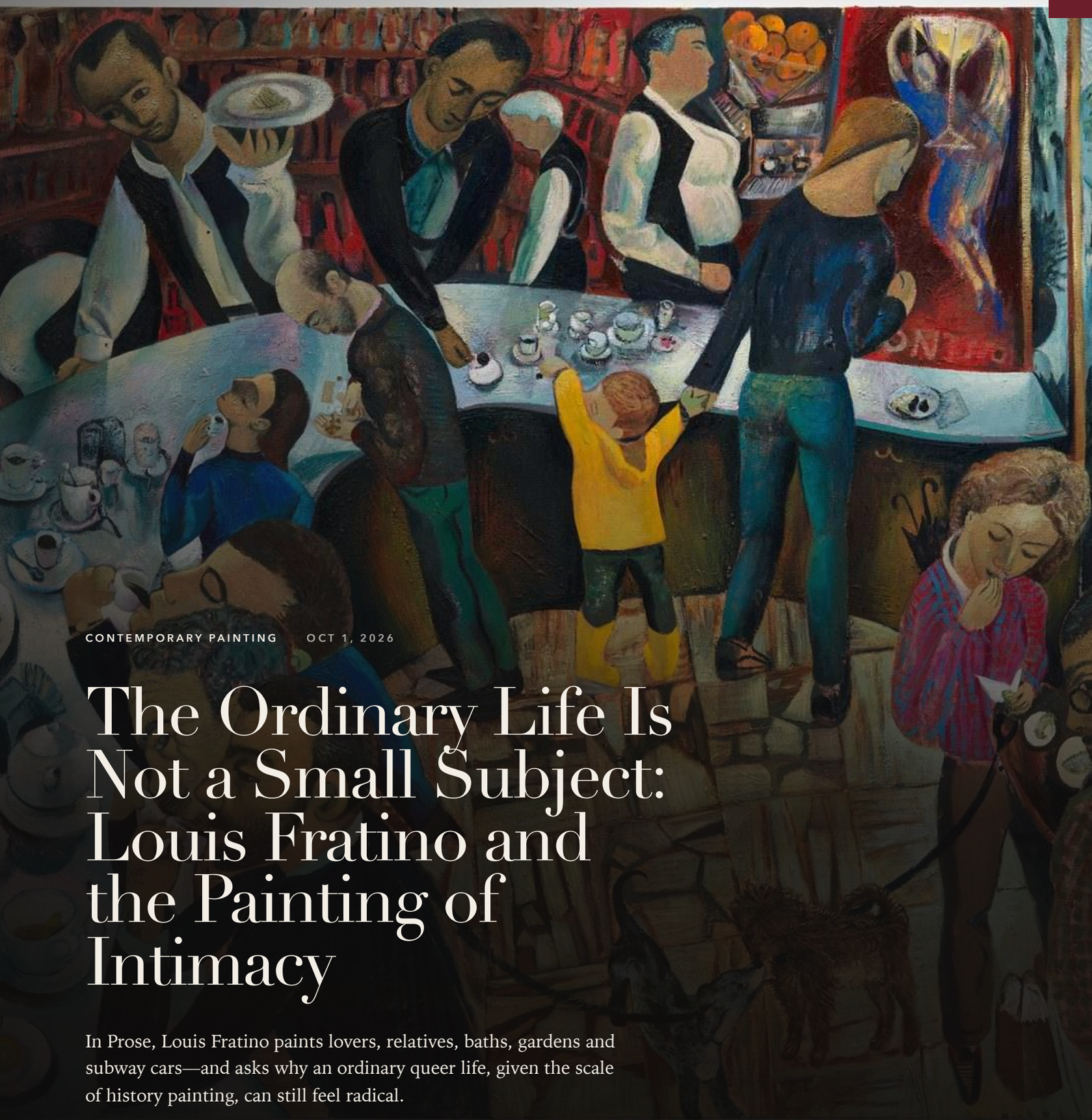
The deepest proposition is that abstraction does not move away from reality. It reveals how reality has already been abstracted – into territory, infrastructure, value and risk – and asks whether those systems can be recomposed. In Dyson's hands, a line can

be a route, a barrier, a breath or a relation. Blue can be light and depth, but never innocence. ■

Torkwase Dyson: Seeing in Blue is at Pace Gallery, 540 West 25th Street, New York, from 11 September to 24 October 2026. The exhibition presents new paintings informed by Dyson's experiences as a swimmer and deep-sea diver. This article was prepared from the artist's writings, interviews and official exhibition materials; it does not claim an in-person visit. Images are reproduced for editorial review with credits supplied by Pace Gallery.

FURTHER

Seeing in Blue — Pace Gallery	pacegallery.com/exhibitions/torkwase-dyson-seeing-in-blue
Bird and Lava: artist's research notes — Torkwase Dyson	torkwasedyson.com/bird-and-lava
Torkwase Dyson in conversation with Hamza Walker — BOMB	bombmagazine.org/articles/2024/12/16/torkwase-dyson-by-hamza-walker
Torkwase Dyson interview — The Brooklyn Rail	brooklynrail.org/2020/09/art/TORKWASE-DYSON-with-Robert-Shane



CONTEMPORARY PAINTING OCT 1, 2026

The Ordinary Life Is Not a Small Subject: Louis Fratino and the Painting of Intimacy

In Prose, Louis Fratino paints lovers, relatives, baths, gardens and subway cars—and asks why an ordinary queer life, given the scale of history painting, can still feel radical.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · CONTEMPORARY PAINTING · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

In Prose, Louis Fratino paints lovers, relatives, baths, gardens and subway cars—and asks why an ordinary queer life, given the scale of history painting, can still feel radical.

A life becomes visible in fragments: coffee cups on a crowded table, a lover turning in bed, a mother's garden seen at the hour when colour begins to loosen, a naked body folded into bathwater, strangers packed into a subway car. None of these events announces itself as history. Louis Fratino paints them as if the distinction between a major and minor subject were no longer useful.

His new exhibition *Prose*, at David Zwirner in London, contains paintings, drawings and sculpture made from observation and memory. The title is exact. Prose is what carries most of a life: not the exceptional line preserved for quotation, but the continuous language between moments. Fratino's paintings ask what happens when this ordinary continuity – especially the continuity of queer life – is granted the concentration once reserved for mythology, power and public catastrophe.

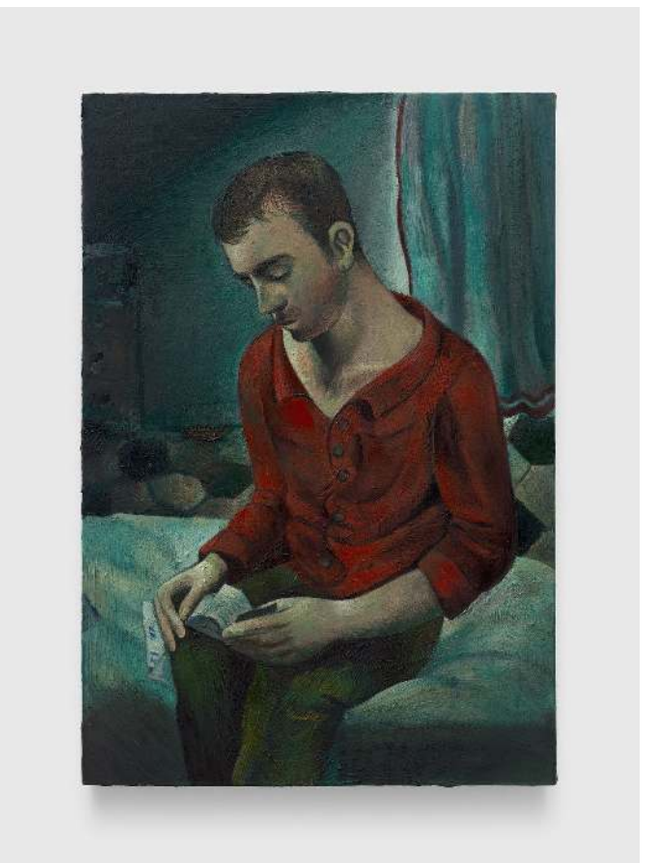
Louis Fratino, Jasmine, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

I

After visibility

Queer figurative painting has often been discussed through visibility: which bodies were absent from museums, which desires were concealed, and what political work is performed when they enter the frame. Fratino belongs to a generation for whom the problem has changed without disappearing. The male body can now be shown desiring another male body, but visibility alone no longer guarantees complexity.

The harder task is to paint queer life without requiring it to remain exemplary, transgressive or tragic. Fratino's figures eat, wait, bathe, read, travel and become bored. Sex appears, but it belongs to a larger ecology of domestic life. The radical claim is not simply that these bodies deserve representation. It is that their uneventful time deserves form.



Louis Fratino, Ale in his mom's bedroom (after Corot), 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

II

Memory is not an archive

Fratino paints from memory, even when observation begins the process. This does not mean retrieving an intact mental photograph. Memory edits scale, exaggerates colour, compresses rooms and brings emotionally adjacent moments into the same field. A body can become too large for the bed because its felt presence was larger than the room.

In *Ale in his mom's bedroom (after Corot)*, the seated figure is held inside greens and muted reds that make the room feel remembered rather than measured. The parenthetical "after Corot" identifies an artistic ancestor while also admitting that influence reaches the present through private experience. Art history is not outside the bedroom. It is one of the things remembered there.

III The crowded picture

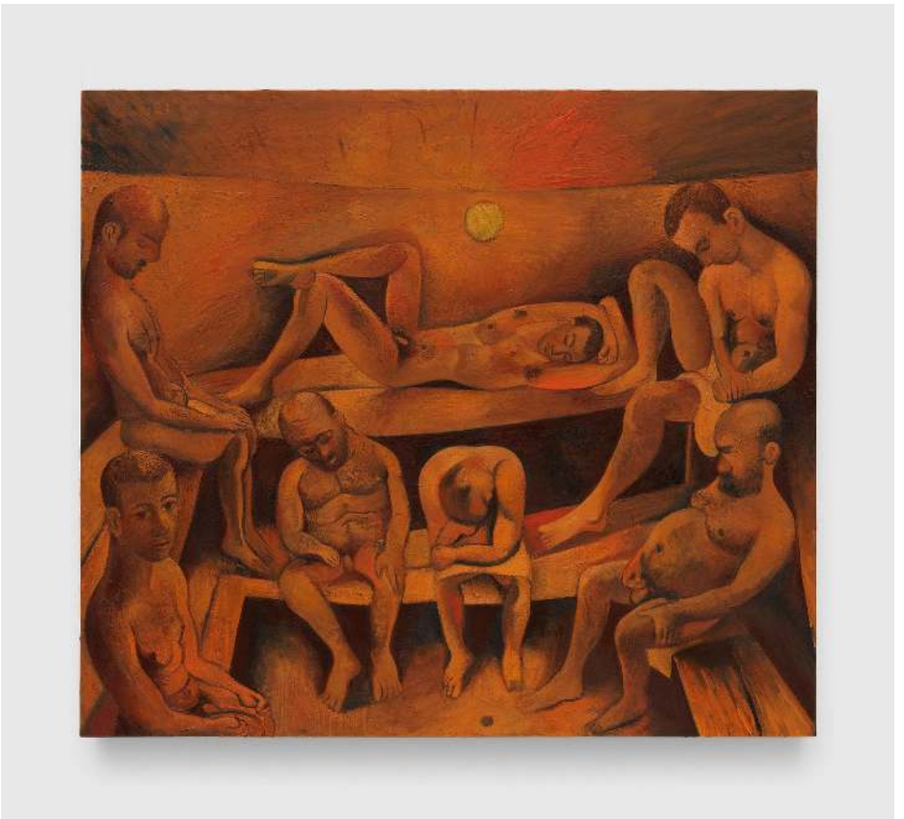
Louis Fratino, Coffee, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

Coffee is a social painting structured by objects. Cups, glasses, chairs and bodies compete for the same shallow space. The table does not organise the gathering so much as record its aftermath. Fratino's compressed perspective allows every detail to insist on itself: the drink, the hand, the face partly hidden behind another person.

This density carries an ethical position. No figure becomes the sovereign subject around whom the scene is arranged. Intimacy is distributed. A gathering is made from simultaneous acts of attention and distraction, and the painting refuses to decide which one matters most.

IV Pleasure without defence

Pleasure in contemporary art is frequently asked to provide its own alibi. It must be critical pleasure, wounded pleasure, pleasure made acceptable by an explanatory structure. Fratino resists this economy. He has said that he wants to remain vulnerable in the studio and to work without embarrassment – as if the private dialogue of painting should not begin by anticipating prosecution.



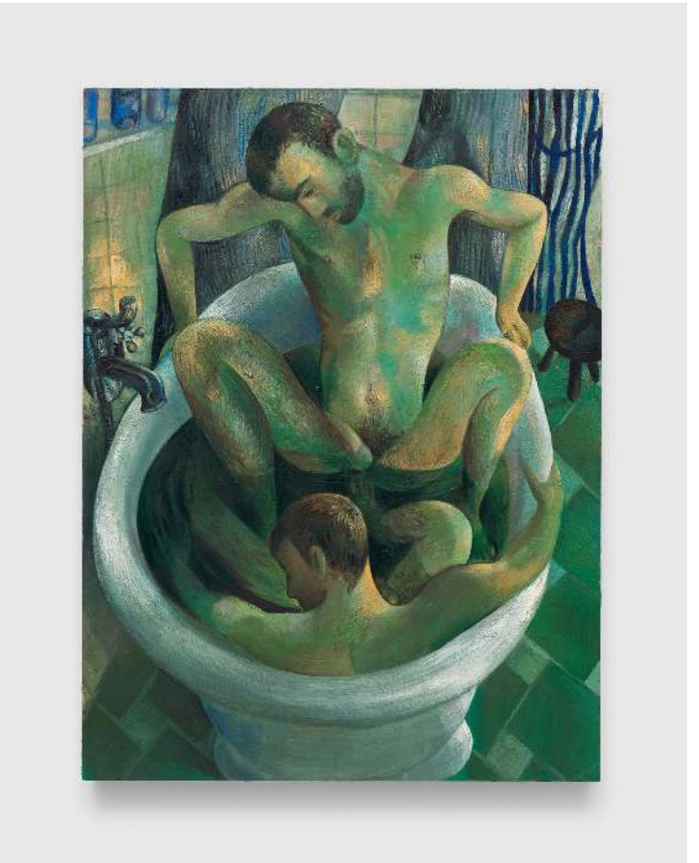
Louis Fratino, The sauna, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

The sauna turns a communal interior into a field of orange and red bodies. Anatomy is elastic; limbs intersect; heat seems to deform the room. The painting is erotic, but its eroticism does not depend on a single exposed act. It comes from proximity, repetition and the temporary suspension of distance between bodies.

To paint pleasure without defence is not politically naïve. Queer culture has been made visible through histories of prohibition, medicalisation and loss. An image of ease can therefore carry historical pressure even when it refuses to illustrate suffering. The right to appear unafraid is not the absence of politics; it is one of politics' unfinished outcomes.

V

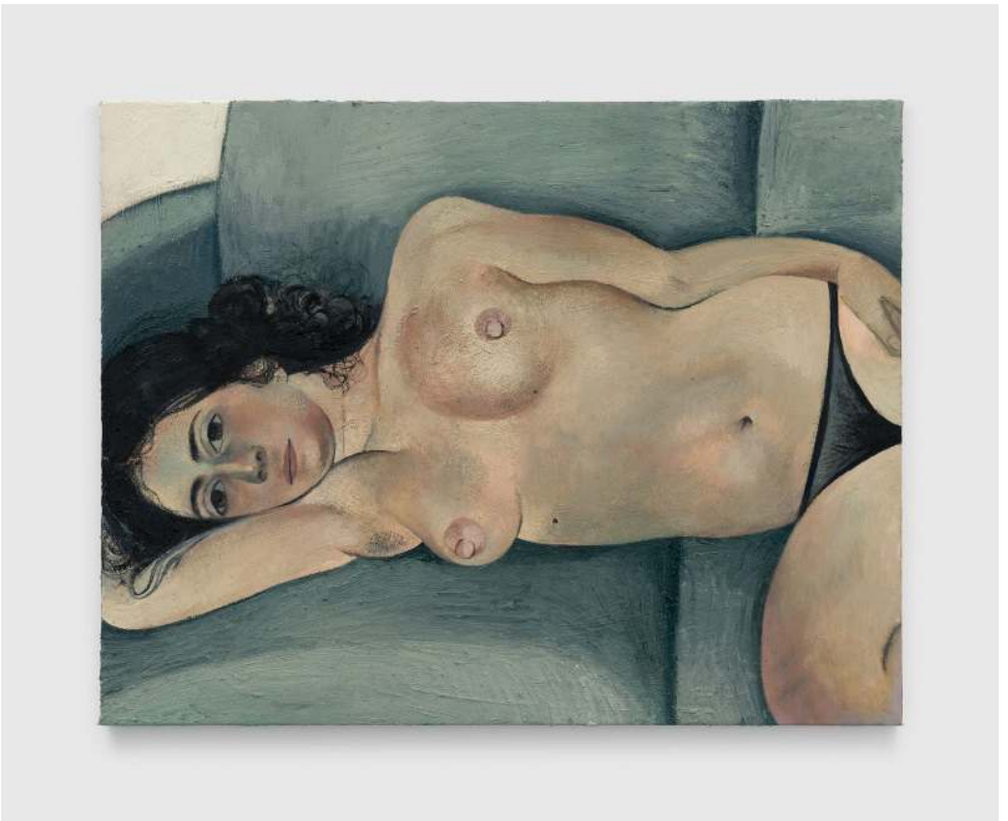
The body as landscape



Louis Fratino, The green bath, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

In *The green bath,* a body folds so completely into the vessel that figure and container begin to share a contour. The view from above abolishes a stable horizon. Knees, chest, water and enamel become a single knot of green volumes.

Fratino's distortions are sometimes placed in a lineage running through Picasso, Matisse and Marsden Hartley. The references are real, but resemblance can become a lazy conclusion. What matters is how inherited distortion changes when the body being painted is not an anonymous model but a lover, friend or self. Formal freedom becomes inseparable from relational knowledge.



Louis Fratino, Nude with black hair, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

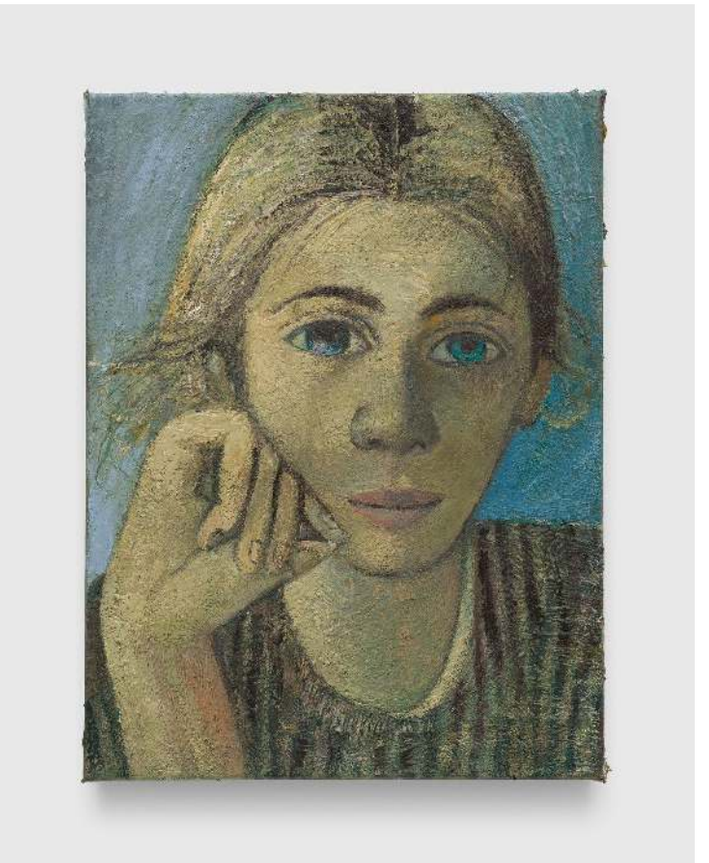
VI Looking without possession

The reclining nude is among Western painting's most burdened formats. It converts a body into an available surface and assigns the viewer a privileged position outside the scene. Fratino inherits this structure and makes it unstable. His nudes are often aware of being seen, yet they do not organise themselves for the viewer's control.

In *Nude with black hair*, the figure's horizontal body occupies almost the full canvas, but the face does not offer access. Flesh is painted with tenderness without becoming smooth. The image distinguishes intimacy from possession: familiarity allows the painter to remain close, not to claim total knowledge.

VII Painting as a form of care

Fratino has described painting as an act of respect or care because it demands time, skill and a kind of abasement. The formulation is useful in an era when images are made and discarded with almost no friction. A painting holds someone in attention for longer than convenience requires.

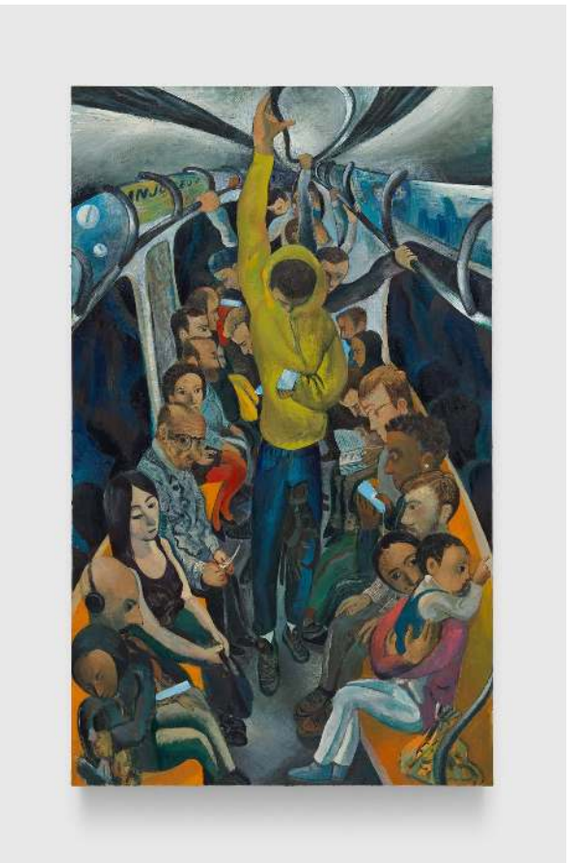


Louis Fratino, Chrissie, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

Chrissie is small enough that the face must be approached rather than consumed at a distance. The surface remains worked and unresolved; likeness is constructed through accumulated decisions rather than photographic completeness. Care appears not as idealisation but as sustained looking.

VIII

The city enters the room



Louis Fratino, The subway car, 2026, oil on canvas. Courtesy the artist and David Zwirner.

Domestic intimacy is not sealed off from public life. *The subway car* compresses strangers, reflections, advertisements and metal structure into a vertical chamber. The transit system becomes another interior – shared without being private, physically close without promising recognition.

The picture complicates the comforting idea that Fratino paints only a protected world of lovers and family. Urban queer life is shaped by public codes of looking: the glance that tests safety, the body that recognises another body, the practiced indifference of strangers. The subway car is a social composition in which everyone sees and avoids being seen.

IX

Art history at home

Fratino's paintings openly converse with European and American modernism: Matisse's decorative interiors, Corot's figures, Picasso's compressed bodies, Hartley's masculine charge, Bonnard's domestic colour and Alice Neel's psychological line. The risk of such fluency is that citation can become a certificate of seriousness attached to private life.

His strongest works reverse that relation. They do not use art history to legitimise queer experience; they use queer experience to test what art history can still do. A modernist distortion that once signalled formal revolution is returned to the kitchen, bath and bed, where it must become emotionally specific again.

X Why "prose" matters

Poetry is conventionally granted compression, intensity and transformation. Prose carries sequence: one sentence after another, one day following the previous day. By calling the exhibition *Prose*, Fratino chooses duration over climax. A life is not proven by its most dramatic image. It accumulates through repeated rooms, bodies and objects.

This is also a theory of painting. Each canvas is discrete, but the subjects age and return. A niece appears first as a baby and later as a child; partners and relatives occupy new rooms; the artist imagines painting himself when he is old. Autobiography becomes serial rather than confessional. The work's meaning lies not only in disclosure but in continuity.

XI The still life is never still

A bowl of fruit seems to suspend politics entirely. Yet still life has always been a record of access: what could be bought, stored, displayed and allowed to decay. Fratino's apples and pears are compressed into a dark bowl on striped cloth, painted with the same bodily pressure as his nudes.

The equivalence is important. Fruit, flowers and flesh belong to one visual world because intimacy is not confined to interpersonal drama. It is a way of assigning attention. The ordinary object is not elevated out of ordinary life; ordinary life is revealed as already dense with form.

XII The problem of the beautiful life

Fratino's work is easy to love, and that ease creates suspicion. The paintings are colourful, sensual, art-historically literate and highly desirable within the market. The intimacy they depict can be converted into a style: the queer domestic interior as a recognisable and collectible genre.

The problem is not that the work is beautiful or commercially successful. It is whether vulnerability survives repetition. When the same compressed anatomy and saturated palette move from lover to flower to city scene, they risk becoming a guarantee of authorship rather than a fresh encounter. The paintings remain alive where the subject resists the painter's known solution.

Fratino's answer appears to be expansion rather than reinvention. The world of the paintings grows as his world grows: family, travel, public space, aging and new forms of attachment. This is a modest strategy, but modesty is the premise of the work. A style changes because a life does.

Fratino's most consequential claim is not that queer intimacy belongs in art history, but that ordinary time is one of history's primary materials.

XIII Verdict

Prose matters because it refuses the hierarchy that makes public violence historically serious and private pleasure merely personal. Fratino does not deny conflict; he declines to let conflict monopolise the meaning of queer life. His paintings preserve affection, boredom, appetite, embarrassment and rest as forms of knowledge.

The ordinary life is not a small subject. It is where political victories and failures become inhabitable: in who can share a room, touch without fear, build a family, age visibly and expect another morning. Painting cannot secure those conditions. It can insist that they are worth the time required to see them. ▪

Louis Fratino: Prose is at David Zwirner, 24 Grafton Street, London, from 18 September to 31 October 2026. The exhibition is the artist's first solo presentation in London and his first with the gallery since representation was announced. This article was prepared from official exhibition materials and published interviews; it does not claim an in-person visit. Images are reproduced for editorial review with credits supplied by David Zwirner.

FURTHER

Louis Fratino: Prose — David Zwirner	davidzwirner.com/exhibitions/2026/louis-fratino
Louis Fratino: Alive and About Life — Louisiana Channel / David Zwirner	davidzwirner.com/news/2026/louis-fratino-film-for-the-louisiana-channel
Louis Fratino in conversation — Baltimore Museum of Art	stories.artbma.org/louis-fratino-in-conversation-with-virginia-anderson-and-katy-rothkopf
Come Softly to Me: an interview with Louis Fratino — Columbia Journal	columbiajournal.org/archive/2019-come-softly-to-me-an-interview-with-louis-fratino

INTERVIEW SEP 28, 2026

The Forms That Refuse a Name: Richard Pearson on Painting Other Worlds

Somerset painter Richard Pearson on returning to art after Covid, learning to question what a painting is for, building oil over acrylic, and why the forms in Other Worlds must remain unrecognisable.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & RICHARD PEARSON

SECTION I · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & RICHARD PEARSON

Somerset painter Richard Pearson on returning to art after Covid, learning to question what a painting is for, building oil over acrylic, and why the forms in Other Worlds must remain unrecognisable.

Richard Pearson does not describe the return to painting as a career plan. It began during Covid, then accelerated after he and his partner David moved to Somerset: a bolt out of the blue, followed by the discipline and companionship of a local art group. The work that emerged there is abstract but not detached from experience. Childhood years in the Middle East return as desert light and sandstorms; lessons from Wolverhampton Polytechnic return as questions about intention; years spent near textile designers return as a memory of colour being adjusted by hand until it was ready for the world.

His recent series, *Other Worlds*, is built around forms that resist becoming objects. They may suggest rocks, bodies or organisms, but Pearson keeps them unresolved so that a viewer has room to recognise an emotion rather than a thing. Paintings are layered, revised and sometimes nearly destroyed before they settle. Acrylic can become an illuminated ground beneath oil; a first image may survive only as pressure under what replaces it.

We spoke with Richard about the education that stayed with him, the slow and fast times of oil and acrylic, and why a painting sometimes has to be made before it can be painted over.

Untitled abstract painting by Richard Pearson. Courtesy of the artist.

01 Learning to ask why

Viacheslav Munister [VM]: You grew up in the West Midlands, spent eight years in the Middle East and later studied on the foundation course at Wolverhampton Polytechnic. Which part of that life most clearly shaped how you paint now?

Richard Pearson [RP]: I couldn't name one part of my life that shaped my practice. I think all your life experiences shape how you now work, and even more recent things will contribute. But if I had to name one, it would have to be Wolverhampton Polytechnic. It was a great college, led by some very inspirational teachers and filled with wonderful students.

VM: After the foundation course you moved to London and spent years working for creative organisations. What did that work teach you about how art and design actually get made?

RP: My first job was with a fabric manufacturer, and I worked in the same office as the designers. I used to watch them work. The process was all by hand then: no computers, just drawing, paints and a wonderful eye for detail. The designs, painted in gouache, would go into manufacturing, and eventually we would receive the fabrics from the printers. The colours went through adjustments until they were commercially ready.

02

The shift back into painting

VM: You committed seriously to art only in the last few years. What tipped the balance?

RP: I started painting again during Covid, but the real shift came when my partner David and I moved to Somerset. I just started. It was a bit of a bolt out of the blue. Then I joined the local art group, which has been amazing and has really opened my mind to so much.

VM: Was there a specific lesson in that group that changed how you approached the canvas?

RP: The moment was when our tutor, Vera, asked us to really question why we were making the work, how we were going to do it and what message we wanted to communicate. It made me think seriously about what we do and why we paint and create.

Richard Pearson with his work during a two-week group exhibition. Courtesy of the artist.

03

A series that had to grow naturally

VM: How did *Other Worlds* begin?

RP: I didn't set out to paint a series, but the forms I started creating in *Other Worlds* seemed to multiply. The first painting was called *Drifting Forms*, and it went from there. The ideas needed to flow naturally without being at all contrived. It was a lovely process

to go through, and hopefully more works will be added in an organic way. It can't be planned; it has to happen naturally.

Drifting Forms, from the Other Worlds series. Photo courtesy of Richard Pearson.

VM: You work in oils and acrylics. What does each medium let you do?

RP: Sometimes I mix them, starting with an acrylic underpainting and following with oil. Acrylic can add a wonderful light that shines through the oil, and oil can do the same through lovely thin glazes. The great thing about oil is that it dries so slowly, so you can move the paint around. Acrylic is more immediate; it depends on what you want to do. I recently made a large painting in acrylic and then added oil on top, which enabled lots of layers.

Oil and acrylic layers in a painting by Richard Pearson. Courtesy of the artist.

A large painting in progress, photographed in Richard Pearson's garden. Courtesy of the artist.

04 Making in order to destroy

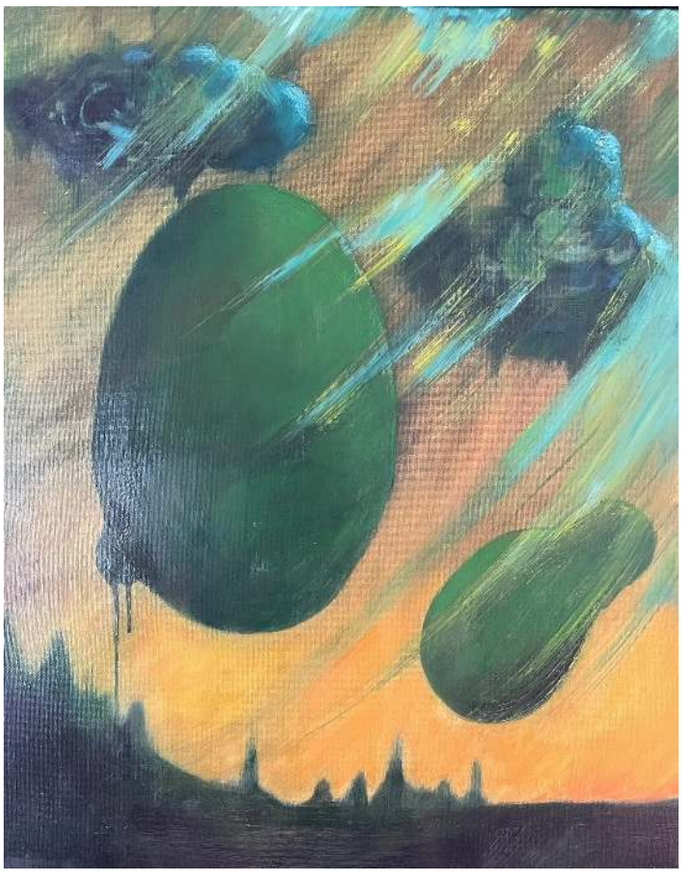
VM: Do you know how a piece will end before you start?

RP: I never know where it will end. Quite often I paint over the original and more or less start again. It's almost as if I have to create something in order to destroy it. Hopefully something better comes out of it. I have to go through this process to reach something I'm happy with.

A densely revised abstract painting by Richard Pearson. Courtesy of the artist.

VM: Can you trace anything in the work back to your childhood in the Middle East?

RP: A lot of what an artist paints comes from memory and the subconscious. I couldn't pinpoint a single source, but desert landscapes appear in *Other Worlds*. One painting I titled *Desert Storm* comes close. We quite often had huge sandstorms that lasted for days.

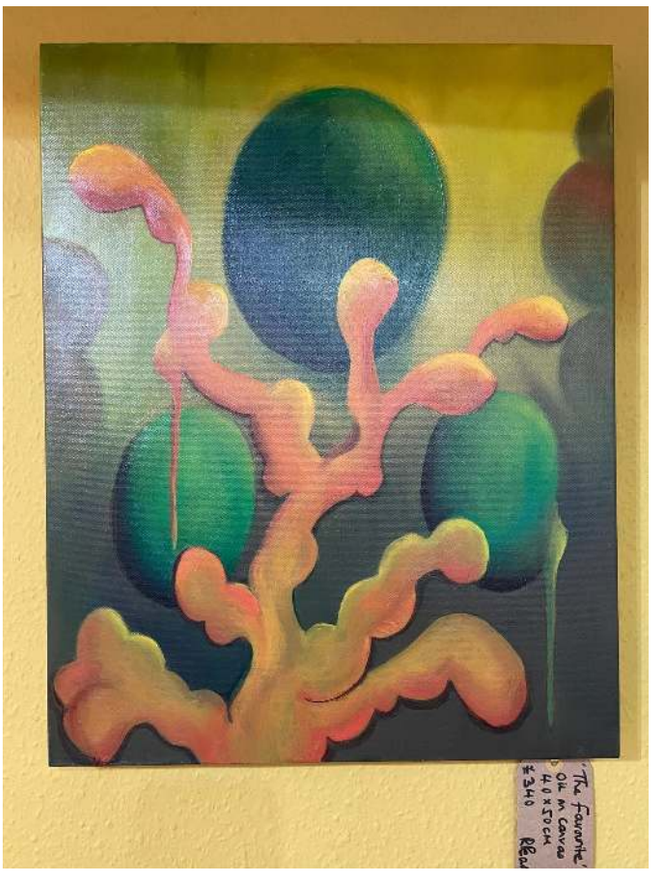


Desert Storm, from the Other Worlds series. Photo courtesy of Richard Pearson.

05 What an unnamed form can hold

VM: What would the forms in *Other Worlds* lose if you made them recognisable – as a rock, body or building?

RP: The amorphous forms in the series are metaphors for our emotions rather than tangible or recognisable objects. That allows viewers to make up their own minds and leave with their own answers, or with more questions. If a form were made recognisable, I think the viewer would move on rather than think about what they were seeing.



A work from Richard Pearson's Other Worlds series. Courtesy of the artist.

VM: You recently showed alongside Ksenia Cieslak and Rosaria Valenti at Ilminster Arts Centre. What did you notice about your own work when it shared the room with theirs?

RP: It was great to have my paintings next to my friends' work. We are all very different, but somehow it worked together – mainly because we all use strong, saturated colour. I noticed that my colours were darker and that my paintings were smaller compared with some of the others, but that was fine. It was a cool contrast, and I loved it. ■

It's almost as if I have to create something in order to destroy it. Hopefully something better comes out of it.

Interview by Viacheslav Munister. Answers by Richard Pearson, lightly edited for clarity and punctuation. All artworks and photographs courtesy of Richard Pearson.

INTERVIEW SEP 21, 2026

The Red Thread: Veronika Chernienko on Painting What Words Can't Reach

Ukrainian painter Veronika Chernienko, trained at the Kyiv academy and based on Cyprus since 2014, on why she calls herself a colourist before anything else, the recurring red thread that runs through her most personal work, and the biennial sketch about home and distance that she still can't look at without crying.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & VERONIKA CHERNIENKO

SECTION I · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & VERONIKA CHERNIENKO

Ukrainian painter Veronika Chernienko, trained at the Kyiv academy and based on Cyprus since 2014, on why she calls herself a colourist before anything else, the recurring red thread that runs through her most personal work, and the biennial sketch about home and distance that she still can't look at without crying.

Veronika Chernienko paints the way she was trained to at the Kyiv academy she still calls home, and paints against it in the same breath. A colourist first, she says, before she is anything else – someone who works from the conviction that colour, not drawing, carries what she actually wants to say.

She left Ukraine for Cyprus in 2014, and for years her painting barely registered the move: the palette stayed hers, the subjects stayed the human figure. What changed the work was not geography but the war. Since 2022 she has painted more, and differently – not always about the war directly, but carrying its aftershock in every canvas: vulnerability, the need for shelter, a search for roots and for the people left behind. A recurring red thread, tied around a wrist or trailing into water, is not a fixed symbol for her so much as a nerve that different paintings touch for different reasons.

One of those paintings – a child curled in the exposed roots of a tree, a red thread running through the whole composition – was made for a 2023 biennial in Larnaca on the theme of a home far from home. It was not selected. She still cannot look at it without crying.

01 Where the training came from

Viacheslav Munister [VM]: Could you introduce yourself and outline the path that brought you from your training to your practice today, based in Cyprus?

Veronika Chernienko [VC]: I've been painting since early childhood – it was always a natural part of my life. At twelve I entered an art boarding school in Kyiv, and later graduated from the National Academy of Fine Arts and Architecture with a master's in easel painting. Toward the end of my studies I joined the National Union of Artists of Ukraine and took part in Ukrainian and international exhibitions.

When my family and children came along, I focused for a while on painting for myself. In 2014 we moved to Cyprus, where I joined the local art community, painted portraits on commission, did wall murals, and taught children – including preparing them for entrance to art school. The circumstances and forms of the work kept changing, but the daily practice never left me. I always felt painting was my profession and my calling.

With the start of the full-scale war in Ukraine, I began painting especially intensively – painting helped me live through what I had no words for. Even when a work doesn't address the war directly, it carries an echo of what I've lived through: a sense of vulnerability, a need for protection, a search for support and for connection to my roots. Through the human body and its gestures, I speak about an inner pain that isn't always visible from outside.

It was on Cyprus, among artists from many countries, that I understood more deeply the distinctiveness of the Ukrainian school of painting that shaped me – I saw the richness of our palette and the boldness of our colour and imagery with new eyes. Today it matters to me to keep developing that inheritance in my own work and to pass it on to my students, to keep a living connection to the culture that raised me and that I carry with me.

VM: Could you place your training within a specific pedagogical tradition, and how much do you see your current work as a continuation of it, or a departure from it?

VC: My education belongs to the Ukrainian academic school of painting. I studied in the workshop of Oleksandr Lopukhov – our graduating class was, sadly, his last. Composition and the genre picture were the foundation there. At the same time we worked a great deal with Ihor Yulianovych Melnychuk, whose approach is marked by decorative sensibility and a bold, saturated palette. It was the combination of the two that formed how I see a painting.

Field practice mattered enormously. We spent long stretches in the Carpathians and in Transcarpathia, painting from life, studying the local culture and customs. Ukrainian motifs became part of my personal experience. Even in those student years, when many were looking for themselves outside the academic school, I was glad to belong to the Ukrainian tradition of realism and impressionism. The human being, and the theme of Ukraine, have stayed with me since.

At the same time, I feel today that I've moved away from academicism and from the need to follow rules. In a world that keeps changing, with so much creative freedom available, I've allowed myself to do what I want – to trust my own sense of colour and form, and to follow where the work itself leads. I rely on intuition more and more, but it's an intuition that grew out of deep training and years of practice. The school became an inner foundation that gives me the freedom to experiment. And the simple joy of the process itself matters enormously to me – I get real pleasure from what I do.

02 A colourist's worldview

VM: How would you describe your practice as a whole to someone encountering it for the first time – what should they understand before anything else?

VC: My practice begins with an attentive, enamoured look at the world. I have a weakness for admiring everything alive – I love watching nature, the movement of light, reflections and colour echoes. Seeing the world through a painter's eyes feels natural to me: I'm constantly noticing combinations of colour and barely perceptible shifts that I want to carry onto canvas.

Above all, I feel myself to be a colourist. It's through colour, more than through form, that I convey my perception and what I'm living through. Even when the world holds so much pain, I'm captivated by how everything alive around us keeps changing without pause, and I want to carry that feeling into my painting.

I want to show the viewer what I see, and what they might otherwise pass by. To invite them to stop, look closer, and feel. What matters most to me is that the colour touches a person – that it calls up a memory of their own, a feeling, a new sense of something familiar.

03 Cyprus and what geography did not change

VM: Displacement from Ukraine to Cyprus is a fact of your biography. Is it also a fact of your painting – does geography enter as subject, as light and palette, or does it stay outside the work itself?

VC: A different culture and landscape can certainly change how an artist works. But I can't say the move to Cyprus significantly changed my palette or my range of subjects. I keep painting what is close to me, drawing on a way of seeing that formed in Ukraine.

Even when I turn to the Cypriot landscape, I see it through my own experience, and render it in my own manner and colour relationships. What interests me is what image of this place can be born from that particular gaze – I feel it will differ from the Mediterranean painting I encounter here. It's precisely on Cyprus, among artists from different countries, that I notice most clearly the differences in our painterly approaches, and recognise what the Ukrainian school gave me.

Plein-air practice never really took root for me here, though I've tried more than once to return to it. I mostly work at home, and paint a great deal of figurative work. The human being and their inner world stay at the centre of my attention.

With the start of the full-scale war I joined volunteer work at the Ukrainian House in Cyprus, where I teach Ukrainian children. Together we keep our artistic tradition alive, turn to Ukrainian imagery, work with colour. It matters to me that children growing up abroad feel a living connection to their culture and can develop it in their own work. I see this, too, as a continuation of a path that began in Ukraine.

Veronika Chernienko, three women in traditional headdress, oil on canvas

04 Sources, and standing apart from lineage

VM: Beyond direct observation, what is your primary source of visual reference – art-historical precedent, photography, something else – and how consciously do you place your own work within a lineage of painters?

VC: My paintings are born from a combination of sources: studies, photographs, gestures I've seen, observation. Most often I turn to photography – it's convenient working material, and experience lets me reinterpret it freely. But working from life remains irreplaceable. Here on Cyprus, in our art community, we still work with a live model, and I value that greatly. When a photograph isn't enough, I go back to life, to look closer, to clarify, to feel what the image can't carry. Without that living experience, painting doesn't feel complete to me.

I often return to Ukrainian painters – Oleksandr Murashko, Viktor Zaretsky, Tetiana Holembievska, Tetiana Yablonska. My teachers had a great influence on me too. I also follow contemporary artists with interest, including those working alongside me on Cyprus. Everything I admire stays, to some degree, in my visual memory and shapes me.

At the same time, I don't place myself within any particular style, and I don't consciously try to follow a specific artist. While working I don't think about who my painting should resemble, or which tradition it continues. The knowledge, impressions and influences are already part of me – standing at the canvas, I trust my own sense of things and focus on what I want to convey.

05 Still life and the figure one language, not two

VM: Your still lifes pursue an almost hyperrealist finish, while the figurative work stays looser and more painterly. Are these two different languages for you, or one language used at different pressures?

VC: For me it's really one approach, in which the balance between precision and looseness shifts depending on what I want to convey. Academic training gives me an understanding of form, but photographic accuracy on its own isn't my goal. What captivates me is the chance to intensify what I've seen many times over – to sharpen colour, to underline the body's plasticity, to make felt what caught my attention.

Our everyday life is saturated with images, and I want to give the viewer a reason to let their eye linger. I take in the world through colour and plasticity, and I want to show what usually goes unnoticed. Sometimes that calls for careful modelling of form, sometimes for a large flat field of colour. The choice is often intuitive, made in the process of working.

The human figure remains an inexhaustible source of beauty and fascination for me. Through the body, its movement and gesture, I want to build an emotional connection with the viewer. At the same time, I'm captivated myself by painters who notice even finer nuances and show me things I hadn't seen before. That ongoing deepening of the eye is one of the greatest joys painting gives me.

Veronika Chernienko, still life with antiquities, oil on canvas

06 Wall and canvas

VM: Working across mural and easel painting means moving from a public, site-specific scale to an intimate one. How does your approach change?

VC: Monumental and easel painting call for different approaches to composition, scale and the organisation of space – they're separate specialisations, and the academy has a dedicated monumental painting workshop. But I approach a wall as an easel painter: I treat it as a large canvas and carry my own way of working onto it.

It isn't natural for me to build an image out of large generalised masses and flat fills. I work with brushes, keep the painterly stroke, and build form, transitions, a sense of air through it. Even in black-and-white murals, that liveliness of the stroke matters to me. There's a particular appeal in that approach, one my clients value.

Of course, on a large surface that kind of work takes far more time, and I always warn people about that in advance. But I enjoy the process itself – I love working with a brush, watching an image slowly come alive. The scale changes; the pleasure of painting and my own approach stay with me.

07 A turning point

VM: Looking at your practice over time, is there a specific body of work you'd identify as a turning point?

VC: There was a period of deliberate experiment in my practice. During the pandemic I became absorbed in the work of American realist painters – their restrained, dark palette, complex colour nuance, the fine handling of the painted surface. I tried to change both my colour range and my technique. A number of darker, more delicately rendered works came out of that period.

Over time I felt that manner wasn't close to me. The work found less response from viewers, and I understood, more and more clearly, that in that search I was moving away from myself. Now I'm returning to what I loved since childhood, and what captivates me in Ukrainian painting: bold, exaggerated colour, a broad stroke, freedom.

What turned out to be the real turning point was realising how important it is to trust my own nature. This is a return to myself, but with different experience and greater confidence in my own language.

My most personal works are born from a deep inner feeling. Knowledge and experience support me, but every time, something happens at the canvas that I can't fully predict or explain. Sometimes I feel it as a connection to something larger than myself – to God, to the world, to the very energy of life. What matters to me is staying open to that state and letting it guide my hand.

Veronika Chernienko, figure on the shore, oil on canvas – the work Veronika names as her turning point

08 The red thread

VM: A recurring motif – a red thread bound around the wrist – punctuates an otherwise restrained body of work. What does it mean to you, and has its meaning shifted from painting to painting?

VC: I wouldn't call this motif a sign with one fixed meaning – it's born from the feeling behind each specific work.

I imagine you mean, first of all, the girl among the roots – the sketch for the 2023 Larnaca biennial on the theme 'a home far from home.' That painting still brings me to tears. In it, helplessness and a deep connection to home, to the people close to me, to Ukraine, come together. The red thread makes that invisible connection visible. Far from home it sometimes feels even stronger, even more painful – you can't embrace the people you love, but everything that happens to them passes through you. And at the same time, it's exactly that closeness that gathers us into a community, that helps us hold on to one another.

Sadly, the sketch wasn't selected. I don't know why. Perhaps the organisers didn't want to focus specifically on the Ukrainian experience of war and distance from home – but that's only my guess.

If you also mean the girl in the water, with a red ribbon in her hair – that painting is my reflection on the terrible violence in Bucha. Even now it's hard for me to talk about it: painting became a way to express a pain I had no words for.

So the meaning of the red accent shifts along with the painting itself. These images arose intuitively, from different experiences. What unites them is human vulnerability, and my own deep, personal response.

Veronika Chernienko, untitled (in the water), oil on canvas – a reflection on the violence in Bucha

VM: Certain works – like the piece addressing children's bound hands – engage directly with violence and vulnerability. Does that content change how you paint, technically?

VC: You may be thinking of the painting with the girl embracing her own shoulders, a red ribbon from her hair trailing down into the water. That work arose as my reflection on the terrible violence in Bucha.

That content certainly affects how I paint, even though my painterly vision stays recognisable. I become especially attentive to human vulnerability, and try to render it as gently and tenderly as I can. Some fragments of the figure I render more carefully, lingering longer on a gesture, on subtle value shifts and colour transitions. Through that attentiveness to the body, I try to convey an inner pain.

These shifts arise from the feeling itself, intuitively. Colour, stroke, and how far I take a form are all subordinated to what I feel in front of the canvas. I think the viewer can sense that tenderness and pain before they even learn the story behind the painting.

Veronika Chernienko, untitled, oil on canvas

09 What she cannot look at without crying

VM: Is there a work you consider technically or conceptually significant beyond its public reception?

VC: For me, that work is the girl among the roots with the red thread, which I've already mentioned. That sketch for the Larnaca biennial became a very personal statement about home, distance, and a bond that cannot be broken. In it, a person's helplessness meets the strength of their belonging – to the people close to them, to their land, to their community. I still can't look at that painting without tears.

The sketch wasn't selected, and it's painful to me that it didn't get the chance to be heard in the context it was made for. I don't know the reasons for that decision and can't explain it with any certainty. A work's personal significance doesn't always match its outside recognition.

Its value for me hasn't changed: in it I managed to convey a feeling that's still hard to put into words. I'd like that work to still have the chance to meet its viewer.

Veronika Chernienko, detail of the untitled roots painting

10 Knowing when to stop

VM: Your still-life practice pursues an almost hyperrealist finish, while the figurative work is much freer – how do you know when a painting is finished?

VC: For me a painting's completeness is decided by whether I've managed to convey what matters most. I often work alla prima, trying to capture the image at once, to keep the force of the first impression. Working fast matters to me. I used to see that impatience as something of a flaw, but over time it became a distinctive feature of my painterly language.

That's tied to my training too – we painted a great deal of studies en plein air, worked from live models outdoors, often in one or two layers. That practice taught me to focus on the essential. Long, many-layered work on a canvas isn't close to me, though commissioned still lifes, with their specific brief, sometimes demand more detail.

In my own work I stop when I feel I've said what I wanted to say. Areas of the canvas can stay unresolved, brushstrokes free, forms only suggested. For me those are spaces of the unsaid, where the viewer can feel and complete the image themselves. I don't want

to overload the canvas – it matters to me that it breathes.

So what looks unfinished can, for me, be an entirely finished painting. I trust my own sense of that boundary, and I trust the viewer, too – not every detail needs explaining.

Veronika Chernienko, wedding scene, oil on canvas

Veronika Chernienko's work can be followed on Instagram at @artveronika_painting.

FEATURE AUG 21, 2026

Where We Meet Ourselves - interview with Keisuke Azuma

Artist Keisuke Azuma on washing paint back off the canvas, the Japanese aesthetics of shadow and emptiness behind his work, and why art has no right to be exclusive.

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA & KEISUKE AZUMA

SECTION I · FEATURE · MARIA IVANOVA & KEISUKE AZUMA

Artist Keisuke Azuma on washing paint back off the canvas, the Japanese aesthetics of shadow and emptiness behind his work, and why art has no right to be exclusive.

Born in Japan, trained in London, and now based in Lithuania, Keisuke Azuma builds his canvases by taking away rather than adding – washing pigment back, dissolving the body until only a hand, a foot, or a fragment of gesture survives against raw, unfinished canvas. His recent series, currently on show in KIAF Seoul, and exhibited recently in solo shows in New York and Paris, strips the human figure down to its most universal parts, leaving the rest as an invitation: a blank the viewer fills with their own reflection.

Keisuke Azuma in his studio · Courtesy of Keisuke Azuma

Epris met Azuma over a video call from his studio in Vilnius, where he lives with his wife and their dog and cat. Below you can find our conversation on the Japanese aesthetics of deduction that shaped his method and why he thinks art has no right to be exclusive.

01

Becoming a painter

Maria Ivanova [MA]: What was the starting point for you to become an artist – were you immersed in art from childhood, or did the desire come later?

Keisuke Azuma [KA]: It's always a funny story, because I never actually wanted to be an artist. I loved art, obviously – I read a lot about artists from the Baroque period, and it always said they were poor. There were exceptions, but in general it looked like such a difficult profession. Still, I loved it, even though I was pretty much alone in that in my community. No one else in my family cared about art.

I was doing marketing work in a shop, and someone asked if I could do an illustration. I saw how customers reacted, and I was fascinated by that power art has to deliver a concept. I was into film too, so for a while I thought I'd combine the two through illustration. That's why I chose art school in the first place. During my studies I found this other love – expressing my own words, my own sense of identity. So it was a gradual thing. I kept trying to make excuses not to be a painter, and I kept coming back to it anyway.

Eventually I started showing in London while I was still studying, and having a gallery or two consign my work convinced me it might actually be possible. My wife's support mattered enormously too – she married me knowing I wanted to be an artist. That's how I built myself into one.

I kept trying to make excuses not to be a painter, and I kept coming back to it anyway.

Soliloquy, Keisuke Azuma, 2026, oil on canvas

MI: Do you think that pull toward art is something innate, or something your surroundings gave you?

KA: It feels a bit cheeky to just say "I was born this way," but – my mother is an architect. My sister collages, just for her own journaling. My father doesn't do anything art-related, and neither does anyone else in the family, really. So I'd say it's more innate than not, with maybe a small hint of it in the bloodline. I actually tried hard *not* to go this way. In high school an art teacher personally called me to join his club, and I told him I wanted to do music instead. There was always a little sign pointing at it, even when I wasn't looking for one.

Ring, Keisuke Azuma, 2025, oil on canvas

02 Method

MI: You were born and raised in Japan, then moved to London to study. You've said your work is rooted in Japanese culture – how does that show up in your practice?

KA: There's a book, *In Praise of Shadows* – about how traditional Japanese houses use light and shadow, with a strong emphasis on negative space. A single shelf holding flowers becomes the whole focal point of a room precisely because everything around it is empty. Even a living space gets treated like a complete art expression. I was already interested in the contrast of light and shadow – I used to take a lot of photographs – and at some point that merged with my painting.

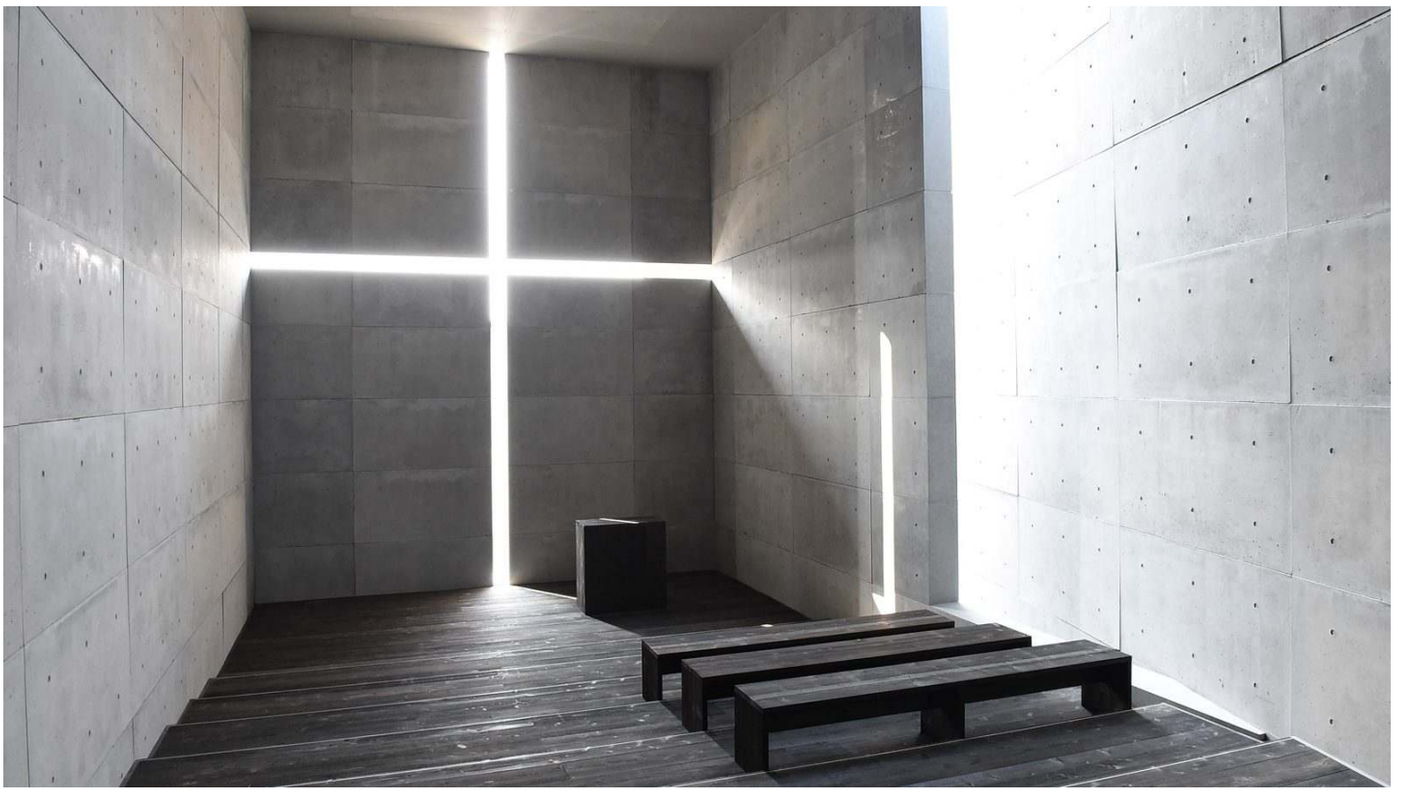
I take classical paintings as a reference, most of the time, and I manipulate them. In the process I try to eliminate elements so I can focus on what actually matters, what I want to deliver. All of my paintings have white space – that's the raw canvas itself. I wash the paint off. It's not perfectly clean; you can still see lines underneath. I do it because I love the physical act of taking the colour back out. In Japanese Zen culture, what matters is minimalist expression, and I wanted an immersive, physical process for myself.

All of my paintings have white space – that's the raw canvas itself. I wash the paint off.

Most Things in Between, Keisuke Azuma, 2026, Oil on Canvas

MI: When I first saw your paintings I immediately felt that Japanese influence – that emphasis on essence over material, on how a space makes you feel rather than what's placed in it.

KA: You're right. I once visited a Tadao Ando church – a concrete box with two thin lines of glass standing in for a cross. Walking in, I felt completely safe, precisely because there was nothing there. That kind of minimalist emptiness matters because it's one of the few places left to actually see who we are – we spend so much of our lives on our phones, immersed in content instead. I keep a monotone background in most of my paintings for the same reason: when you wash off paint there are traces everywhere, and every one of them matters. And I still love how Baroque paintings use darkness – not as absence, but as a presence in the frame.



Church of the Light, Tadao Ando, 1989 · Dezeen

MI: Your recent body of work, *Human Metaphors*, showed in Paris – it deals with vulnerability, identity, and change. Is it a response to the pressure of constant self-presentation we live under now?

KA: I think so. This series is a statement against that kind of validation-chasing. In London I felt I had to fit a certain format – what's trendy, what's popular, what's seemingly correct. Living in Lithuania changed that. I barely see anyone – my wife, our dog, our cat. Lithuanians, and Slavic people generally in my experience, are very true to themselves. They don't even say hello to me half the time, which I actually find refreshing – there's no pretending. People chase influence and money, and it matters, but at the end of the day you're the most important person in your own life, and it's easy to forget that. *That's the question I'm trying to leave in the painting – which is also why I leave so much empty space. It has to become the viewer's own experience.*

Details of "Soliloquy", 2026

MI: Through the abstraction, but with hands and feet still present, are you gesturing at something like consciousness or soul – a self that can be detached from the body?

KA: Exactly. The title *Human Metaphors* was for the New York show; the Paris one was called *Metamorphosis*, which I love just as much. I erase the body because I think we've stopped paying attention to it as a physical scale – we live in our heads, on our phones, and the body becomes almost incidental next to the face, which carries the first impression. Hands and feet, though, are strangely universal. Bodies vary enormously, but a hand stays a hand. So I keep them as a kind of anchor – something everyone can recognise – and erase the rest so people can enter the painting without needing permission first.

Contemporary art has become elite-focused in places. Art should be accessible. When I see people say "I hate this painting," it makes me a little sad, because it's still a human creation, even the ones I personally don't like. So the hands and feet are also an invitation – I don't want anyone standing in front of my work feeling like they don't belong there.

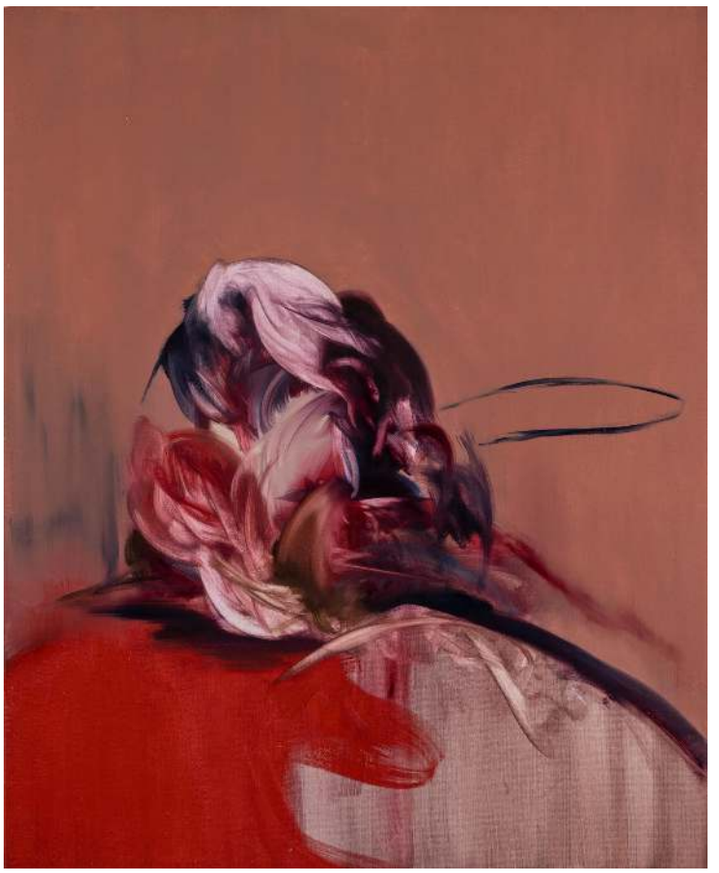
I don't want anyone standing in front of my work feeling like they don't belong there.

Union, Keisuke Azuma, 2026, oil on canvas

MI: You have an earlier series titled *Eggs*, more centre-oriented – something about transformation, maybe rebirth?

KA: Exactly that. After graduating in London I moved straight to Lithuania, into a basement studio, in winter, with nobody around – it felt like an art prison, just me and my art. That's was the moment when I made the Eggs series. Before that I was doing abstract landscape painting, which I loved, but I was following what people said was good without fully expressing myself.

I initially started making art through figurative compositions, working in realism. I wanted to combine this with my abstract expression, Japanese aesthetic, deduction. To do this, Eggs series was very important. In this work I tried to create something out of my landscapes - by folding them or experimenting with their physical form.



Distant Plea, Keisuke Azuma, 2025, oil on canvas

After Eggs series it tooks roughly eight months to reintroduce realistic elements - hand and feets. Eggs series was a transformation for myself.

MI: Do you think abstraction is the purest form of painting – more powerful because it forces self-reflection rather than reading a figure?

KA: I mostly agree. I remember a Monet retrospective in Kyoto – he's technically figurative, very pictorial, but there was one unfinished canvas from the Water Lilies series on show, barely any colour, just a few strokes. It affected me more than his finished work. That's one of the paintings that broke my resistance to abstraction.

Abstraction also has this democratic quality – it makes people feel like they could do it too, and I think that's valuable, even if it sounds naive. I still believe in the power of high realism, Caravaggio and that kind of work – we still go to the cinema for scale and craft – but abstraction fills a gap between the public and elite realism. It has its own contradictions – some abstract work is just as exclusionary – but at its best, it opens things up.

It has its own contradictions – some abstract work is just as exclusionary – but at its best, it opens things up.

05

Why art should be for everyone

MI: You've said art should have a function. What function, in your view?

KA: Art has always had one, I think. Probably the earliest paintings – the Lascaux cave paintings in France, drawings of cattle – already had a narrative function: "this is what I saw today, this is where the hunting spot is". We still use illustration that way, in guides and encyclopedias. I love Baroque painting particularly because it moved away from portraits of the powerful and started introducing ordinary civic life. It always have a function to talk about something beyond words. For example, Picasso's Guernica is the extreme version of that – painfully, brutally honest, and it makes me sad every time, it has a function to be against the world.

Art can deliver emotions beyond the skills to understand - books can be more efficient, but maybe some people don't know how to read - and painting can be more universal – it's even older than language itself.

MI: Do you think everyone has an innate capacity to understand art, or is it something learned?

KA: Both, I think, but I lean toward "learned." I hated abstraction as a kid – I loved realism, and when I first saw work by a well-known abstract painter I genuinely didn't get it. Now I *did* cried in front of a Rothko.

I do believe everyone has a capacity to understand aesthetic and beauty in general - everyone can learn to recognise beauty in a face or in clothing – it doesn't have to be about painting specifically.

My own family still doesn't really understand my abstraction, but they're supportive. My wife's father, who has no art background, once looked at a painting and said, "Oh, he can draw hands and feet – he must be good." [*laughs*] That was very important reaction as well - this connection with a work - even if it only lasts a second.

MI: What was your own first major encounter with a work of art – the moment you thought, this is it?

KA: Probably Rothko, in Tate Britain. I already knew his work, but seeing it in person, in a room that was much darker than the rest of the museum, was different. I felt something beyond humanity – like the painting had taken something out of me. One of the black-and-red canvases, almost like a gate to somewhere else. That's probably the painting that made me want to paint.

MI: Do you paint daily, or wait for inspiration?

KA: Daily now – I have a lot of shows this year, so I don't have the luxury of waiting anymore. I work on an iPad first, manipulating a classical painting, then come to the studio around lunchtime to paint. I keep notes constantly, mostly title ideas – whenever something occurs to me, I write it down so it's there when I need it.

MI: So the starting point now is memory or emotion, recalled, rather than something you're seeing in the moment?

KA: Largely, yes. I still use classical paintings as inspiration when they can help carry a concept, but recently I've been trying to step slightly away from purely personal memory, toward something more generic – I've started making more explicitly political work

lately, thinking about what's happening more broadly rather than only in my own life.

MI: Do you plan meticulously, or let the canvas decide in the moment?

KA: I'd say about half and half. Nothing ever repeats exactly – temperature, texture, everything shifts between the iPad sketch and the actual canvas. The painting I showed you earlier was originally dark blue; I didn't like it, went back to the iPad, mocked up something lighter, and ended up loving the mistake – you can still see the blue underneath. On the iPad everything looks matte and controlled; in reality it gets dirtier, more human. I like that.

MI: What's your biggest non-visual source of inspiration?

KA: Honestly, everything, but music and film especially. Even our dog – she has no capacity for overthinking, she's just happy, and there's something inspiring about that raw, unfiltered expression. In film I love things that confuse me – David Lynch, work that leaves a question instead of answering it. In music I listen mostly to instrumental or classical pieces, and to a Japanese band whose lyrics are deliberately mysterious – *the mystery does more work than an explanation would*.

MI: Do you have any hidden gems in London that you can share with us. Doesn't need to be art-related. A bar, a bench, a street.

KA: Not exactly hidden, but there's a bar in London, called Nickel Bar, inside a former bank building near Bank station, that they gutted and rebuilt – it looks a bit like Hogwarts inside. Very dark, very spacious, more like a grand hotel lounge than a typical bar, and dark enough that you can actually have a private conversation. I only found out about it near the end of my time in London, and I'd go back for that alone.

In Japan, I'd point people toward Nara – everyone goes for the deer and the giant Buddha, but if you climb further up the mountain behind the main temple, maybe twenty minutes past where most tourists stop, there's a much quieter temple with a view over the whole city. It feels like stepping back a few centuries. More generally: any small, minor temple you find on a map rather than a "best of" list – somewhere you're actually allowed to walk inside. Kyoto has thousands of them. If you can get matcha there afterward, even better.

08 · On life

MI: You mentioned earlier how much the move from Japan, through London, to Lithuania shaped you – can you say more about that?

KA: As Japanese, we're raised not to express ourselves too openly. Lithuanians, like a lot of Slavic people in my experience, hold onto their independence fiercely, and value both family and a very solid sense of self at the same time. London never really got under my skin that way – it's too much of a melting pot to leave a single mark. Lithuania taught me how to listen to myself. When I go back to Japan now, once a year, I notice how much self-suppression is baked into daily life there, and it feels strange in a way it didn't used to. I still love the culture deeply, but I needed the distance.

MI: And for someone young who wants to be an artist but is afraid to start?

KA: I believe anyone can be an artist, in principle – sustaining yourself entirely on it is a different, harder question. But it takes real guts and commitment, especially now, when the economics of it are unstable and art isn't something society treats as essential. *Nobody hands you the opportunity – you make your own*. From my first year at university I was applying to every open call I could find, because I was terrified of graduating with no show history. That network, built early, is what let me keep practicing once I moved abroad.

If art feels optional to you, it might not be the right path – it has to be closer to the centre of things than that. It doesn't matter if you're rich or poor going in. You just have to keep the spirit.

If art feels optional to you, it might not be the right path – it has to be closer to the centre of things than that. It doesn't matter if you're rich or poor going in. You just have to keep the spirit.

MI: If you had to give one piece of life advice, what would it be?

KA: Quit being a people-pleaser. I think a lot of people struggle with that, at different levels. It matters, because we only get one life, and I've heard the same thing from a lot of older people in interviews: just do what you actually want. Knowing your own voice, even in small daily decisions, is the whole thing. ▪

…just do what you actually want. Knowing your own voice, even in small daily decisions, is the whole thing.

This interview has been edited and condensed for length and clarity.

INTERVIEW SEP 12, 2026

Where the Souls Become Cranes

Nataliia Maloh, painter and curator, on her anniversary exhibition at ArtLab, the space she built from nothing on the shore of Lake Maggiore, and why she believes the deepest bridges between cultures come from the fact that none of them has ever been one thing.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & NATALIIA MALOH

SECTION I · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & NATALIIA MALOH

Nataliia Maloh, painter and curator, on her anniversary exhibition at ArtLab, the space she built from nothing on the shore of Lake Maggiore, and why she believes the deepest bridges between cultures come from the fact that none of them has ever been one thing.

Verbania sits on the shore of Lake Maggiore, in Piedmont, in the shadow of the Alps. At Via Baiettini 53, in a space that did not exist eighteen months ago, thirty five paintings by thirty five Ukrainian artists now hang under the title *Ukraine. A Memory That Continues*, one work for every year of Ukraine's independence, on view from 24 August through 30 September 2026. The space is called ArtLab, and it belongs to Nataliia Maloh, a Ukrainian painter and curator who arrived in Italy as an emigrant, found seasonal work, lost a winter to unemployment, and used the four idle months that followed to finally do what she had spent years postponing in a Kyiv office during her lunch breaks: paint.

The exhibition did not begin with the paintings. It began with a story Maloh wanted to tell, of land, of mothers, of cranes rising over cities left behind, and only afterward did she go looking for the works that could carry each part of it. The result reads less like a survey than a book, one canvas per page: a section called *Madre Terra*, Mother Earth, on the fields that fed generations and are now mined or occupied; a mother giving her sons a last kiss before their souls lift away as cranes; Italian landscapes that stand, in the show, as a quiet thank you to the country that took Ukrainians in.

Da sinistra a destra: Luciano Paretti – Assessore alla Cultura della Città di Verbania. Olena Gryshchenko – Console d'Ucraina presso il Consolato Generale d'Ucraina a Milano. Giovanni Rodari – Consigliere comunale della Città di Verbania. Marisa Cortese – Curatrice e critica d'arte. Nataliia Maloholovko – Fondatrice del progetto "ArtLab by Nataliia Maloh" e organizzatrice della mostra "35. Ucraina. Una memoria che continua". Olha Pylypenko – Vice Console presso il Consolato Generale d'Ucraina a Milano.

"Madre Ucraina," the work that gives its name to the exhibition's central section. Courtesy ArtLab. Anastasiia Hrudka, "Teneri abbracci," 2024, acrilico su tela, 70×55 cm

We spoke with Maloh about the half basement room in Italy where she first picked up a brush again, the stranger at a Christmas market who pointed her toward the local art association, and why she believes the deepest cultural bridge between Ukraine and Italy has nothing to do with the two countries at all, and everything to do with the fact that neither of them has ever been culturally one thing.

Intervento di Luciano Paretti, Assessore alla Cultura della Città di Verbania, durante l'inaugurazione della mostra. Alla sua sinistra: Olena Gryshchenko – Console d'Ucraina presso il Consolato Generale d'Ucraina a Milano; Nataliia Maloholovko – Fondatrice del progetto "ArtLab by Nataliia Maloh" e organizzatrice della mostra "35. Ucraina. Una memoria che continua". Opera sullo sfondo: Anzhelika Volkanova, "Volo verso sé stessi," 2025, olio su tela, 90×120 cm.

Let's start with your own story. How did your path in art take shape, from your first creative instincts to your practice, your curatorial work, and your life in Italy? Was there a moment after which you stopped seeing yourself only as a painter, and began seeing yourself as someone who could build a space for other artists?

I can point to three moments that probably describe my path best.

The first is still in Ukraine. I had a normal office job in the city centre, nine to six, and during lunch breaks I kept finding myself in an art supply shop, buying paints and brushes and sketchbooks I would carry home and put in a cupboard, telling myself I would get to them eventually. Spoiler: in Ukraine, I never did.

The second is already in Italy. I worked through the summer season, and when it ended I registered for unemployment benefits. At some point it struck me, quite simply, that I was being paid and had four free months ahead of me, which meant I could finally do the thing I had wanted to do for years. I set up a small corner for myself in the half basement of the house we lived in. It was about thirteen degrees in there, so I worked in a coat, but after that there was no going back.

The third moment was my entry into the local Italian art scene, and it happened almost by accident. For a long time I thought nothing was happening in our city, no listings, no posters for anything interesting, apart from the Christmas markets. So I found

out, stubbornly, who organised them, what paperwork I needed, even borrowed a proper market tent since they all had to match. I turned up at the 2024 Christmas market on the lakefront with a fifty by fifty sign, in Italian: "Looking for a place to exhibit my flower paintings." At some point the town eccentric walked up, gave me the name and address of an association, and told me to go there. That chance encounter is, in fact, how I entered the local art world.

The desire and the ability to build something for other artists, I think, comes largely from my earlier professional life. In Ukraine I organised events for international technical assistance projects, so running an event, connecting people, carrying an idea from concept to execution, was a craft I already knew well before I ever thought of art as a profession. At some point those two halves of my life simply met: the need to create, and the experience of organising and bringing people together. That is when I understood that I was interested not only in making my own work, but in making a space where other artists could be seen.

What place has Italy come to occupy in your story? What changed in your understanding of art once you encountered Italian culture: its relationship to history, beauty, urban space, local heritage and everyday life? And has that experience changed how you look at Ukraine?

Italy, quite literally, warmed me. That is probably the most accurate way I can put it.

The sun here is so warm and there is so much light that at some point it became impossible to keep living and working the way I had before. When I first arrived I carried on, for a while, with the kind of work I had brought with me from Ukraine. But I started to feel a real dissonance: sun, a lake, mountains, extraordinary beauty, a completely different pace of life all around me, and I was still sitting in front of a computer, on the old script. At some point I simply asked myself: why keep doing something that no longer brings me joy, when life itself seems to be pushing me toward the thing I always wanted to do? So I consciously gave up my old work, and art arrived very naturally in its place, first the wish to paint, and later the wish to help other artists find their own way into the Italian art world.

Inaugurazione della mostra, 24 agosto 2026. ArtLab, Verbania, Italia.

Italy also changed how I see art itself. Here it does not exist apart from everyday life. It is in the architecture, on the streets, in small churches, old buildings, town squares. What struck me most, though, is how many ordinary people practise art in one form or another. A nurse, a doctor, a shop assistant can work all day at their profession and come home in the evening to paint, work in ceramics, take photographs, make music, make something with their hands, and nobody asks whether they are a real artist. Creativity is woven into life here in a very natural way. I think that gave me a kind of inner freedom: art does not have to start with permission, a diploma, or the day you decide to call yourself an artist. You can simply begin, because it is a need, and see where the path takes you.

I am also drawn to how carefully people here treat local history and heritage. Even a small town or a small association can have its own cultural tradition that people maintain and consider important. Which is probably why I started looking at Ukraine differently. When you live far from it, you begin to see, more sharply, the value of things that once seemed ordinary: our culture, our history, our local traditions. And you start wanting not just to talk about Ukraine, but to create opportunities for people to see it through art. What matters to me is that this should not run in one direction only, not just showing Ukrainian art inside my own space, but Ukrainian artists gradually entering the Italian cultural environment itself, meeting local artists, associations and curators, taking part in exhibitions beyond ArtLab. A simple example: today, 11 September, another exhibition opens featuring an artist whose work is currently showing at ArtLab

as part of this show. That, to me, is one of the most important results of this work: when an acquaintance that began in my space goes on to have a life of its own in the wider Italian art scene.

So when I say Italy warmed me, it is not just a metaphor. I sometimes think it was literally the sun and the light here that pulled me out of my old life and made me ask myself a very simple question: if you have finally ended up somewhere good, why not let yourself do what you actually love? For me, the answer was art.

ArtLab in Verbania joins your own initiative with curatorial and public work. What cultural need was missing when the idea for ArtLab came to you? And what do you want the project to become in the long run: an exhibition space, a laboratory of exchange, a meeting point between cultures, or a mediator between artist, city and community?

It is simple and complicated at once. When I arrived in Verbania, one of my first impulses was to find a gallery and see contemporary Italian art. To my surprise, a Google Maps search for the whole city turned up almost nothing. Later, once I got to know the local scene better, I found the annual shows, the announcements for collective projects, the artists and associations. The art life here does exist, it is just somewhat fragmented. What was genuinely missing was a permanent, open space where contemporary art and the public could meet regularly. And it turned out I was not the only one who felt that. After ArtLab's first exhibition opened this July, many visitors told me almost the same thing: the town had been missing exactly this kind of place.

Inside ArtLab, Via Baiettini 53, Verbania. Courtesy of ArtLab. Olha Kovalyk, "Sera" – l'eco delle case lasciate in Ucraina rimane per sempre nella nostra memoria. 2025, olio su tela, 80×50 cm.

So I would not want to limit ArtLab to the word "gallery." For me it is first of all a living space, one where art can be shown, but where it is just as important to introduce people to each other, to build new connections, to give artists the chance to be seen and

heard. In the long run, I would like ArtLab to become a genuine meeting point: between artist and viewer, between the city and contemporary art, between different cultural environments, and, for me personally, above all between Ukraine and Italy. I like the idea that ArtLab does not have to be an endpoint for an artist, but rather a place where something begins for them: a new acquaintance, participation in another show, a collaboration with a local association or curator, a new project. When that happens, ArtLab is doing exactly what I built it to do: not just hanging art on a wall, but building an environment around it.

Italy is hard to understand through the idea of a single national culture. Piedmont, Lombardy, Veneto, Tuscany, Sardinia and Sicily each carry their own historical memory and visual language. Ukraine, too, is made up of many local cultural experiences. Do you see a shared model between the two countries, in which national identity is born not from flattening regional difference, but from preserving it?

Oh, absolutely, and it is one of the things about Italy that fascinates me most. Local identity here is extraordinarily strong. Dialects differ from region to region, sometimes entire regional languages differ, along with tradition, cuisine and architecture. A person can feel deeply Piedmontese, Sicilian, Venetian or Sardinian, and still be entirely Italian. There are other interesting parallels too. Many southern Italians have long moved north for work and better economic prospects, so within one country there are very different historical, social and economic experiences.

And yet, alongside all of that, “Italian-ness” is everywhere. Made in Italy, the tricolour, you see them on clothes, products, packaging, signage, even, absurdly, on a box of eggs. Behind it is a very clear message: this is ours, made here, and we are proud of it. Regional difference does not undermine national identity here. If anything, it seems to fill it. Italians are keenly aware of the enormous historical inheritance of their land, from antiquity and Rome to each region's own traditions, and they treat all of it as shared cultural capital.

Parte dell'esposizione dedicata al commovente addio delle madri ai propri figli. Courtesy of ArtLab.

That is where I really see a parallel with Ukraine. We too have never been culturally uniform, and I do not think we need to become so. Hutsulshchyna does not have to resemble Slobozhanshchyna, Odesa does not have to resemble Poltava, Zakarpattia does not have to resemble Donetsk. Every region has its own history, intonation, architecture, cuisine, music, tradition, even its own sense of space. I think the strength of a national culture lies not in making everyone the same, but in learning to see that difference as shared wealth. Perhaps that is what Italy has additionally taught me: you can love your small corner of a country deeply, protect its dialect, its traditions, its history, and it does not contradict a strong national identity at all. On the contrary, when a person knows exactly what they bring to the shared culture, that shared culture becomes stronger. I would like us to look at Ukraine the same way: not trying to erase our differences for the sake of unity, but understanding that Ukraine is precisely made of them.

The Italian idea of territorio joins geography, architecture, craft, landscape, family memory and a way of life. For Ukraine, after occupation, displacement and the destruction of cities, the bond between a person and a specific place has taken on particular weight. Could this category become one of the languages through which an Italian viewer comes to understand contemporary Ukrainian art more deeply?

Yes, absolutely. The exhibition has a section called Madre Terra, Mother Earth, and through it I try to explain to Italian visitors that for a Ukrainian, land is far more than territory in the geographic sense. I talk about our fields, the fertility of Ukrainian soil, the symbolism of our flag's colours, blue sky over golden wheat fields, and then explain that today part of those fields is occupied, part is mined, part is contaminated by the war. Land that fed generations becomes, literally, dangerous to human life. I think

Italians understand this through territorio particularly well, because there is also a very strong emotional bond here between a person and their land, their city, their house, their local landscape.

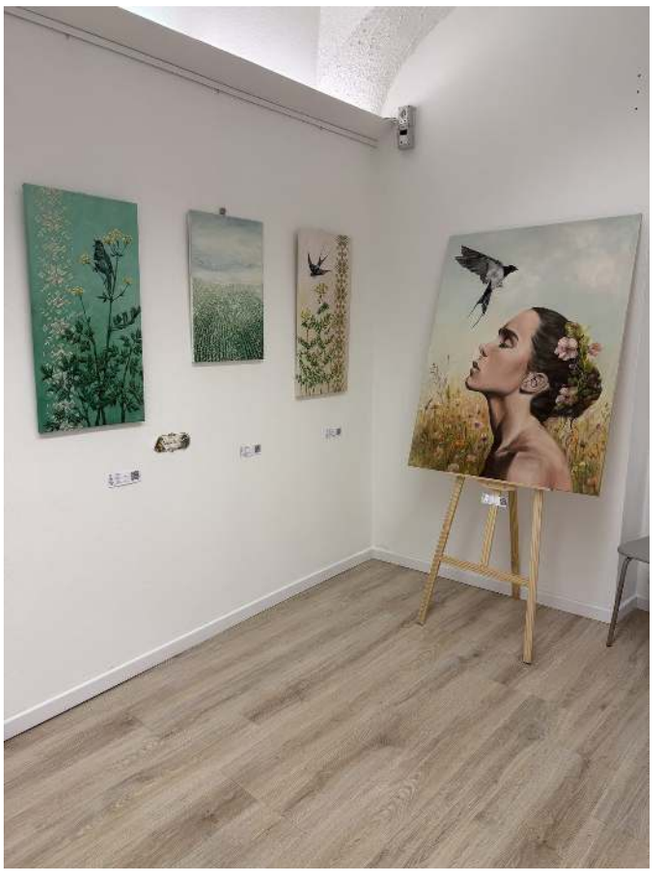
But in this exhibition I try to speak less in the language of facts than in the language of symbols and universal human emotion. I talk about the war through the image of a mother giving her sons a last kiss, their souls lifting away as cranes into eternity. You do not need to be Ukrainian to understand that image, or even to know the history of this war in detail. Almost everyone, in their own life, has lost someone, and knows what the pain of loss feels like, and so can come close, at least emotionally, to what Ukrainian mothers losing their children are living through today.

One moment at the exhibition stayed with me. An Italian woman came in with her three children, and as I told her about this work, the cranes, the mother, the last kiss, I watched her eyes fill with tears. In that moment I understood I had given her something far larger than information about the war in Ukraine.

That is why I believe so strongly in symbolism. Symbols do not need translating the way words do. Land, home, mother, child, road, water, bird, parting, return: these are images that exist in almost every culture. I do not think I could convey the Ukrainian experience to an Italian viewer as well through dates and figures and chronology as I can through the image of land you love and might lose, a home you cannot return to, a mother saying goodbye to her child. Through these, the distance between the Ukrainian and the Italian experience suddenly becomes much smaller. So yes, territorio can be one such language. But more broadly, I would say art lets you speak about a very specific Ukrainian experience through universal human feeling. And that is the moment a viewer stops treating Ukraine as something distant they hear about in the news, and starts to feel it through their own life.

The exhibition's title itself treats memory not as a finished past but as a process. When you present Ukrainian artists to an Italian audience, how do you handle the difficult curatorial problem of speaking about the war and the contemporary Ukrainian experience, without letting the war become the only lens through which Europe reads Ukrainian culture?

I try to speak through symbols and emotions available to anyone, regardless of nationality. Everyone has lost someone, so everyone can understand the pain of the thousands of Ukrainian mothers saying goodbye to their sons today. I speak about Ukrainian land through the image of a woman in a field, the earth as mother, as the source of life, as part of our identity. I speak about forced emigration through cranes rising over cities and fields, leaving familiar places behind and setting out in search of a new home. Through Italian landscapes I thank Italy and Italians for the shelter they gave us, and tell the story of how many of us found a second home here. But alongside that there remains a memory of the first one. In our memory the echo of our apartment blocks lives on, our familiar streets, the lights of our cities, all the everyday life we left behind one day.



Angolo dedicato al sottotema “Madre Terra” – la terra madre che nutre, protegge e offre rifugio.

La sofferenza delle donne che danno l’ultimo bacio ai propri figli, le cui anime volano verso l’eternità trasformandosi in gru. Khrystyna Pasichna, “Le donne mirofore,” 2025, tempera, gesso, tavola, 47×60 cm.

So the war is present in this exhibition, and it would be dishonest to try to avoid it. It is today part of the Ukrainian experience. But for me it is essential that Ukraine is not represented only through war, destruction and death. Ukraine in this show is also land, home, motherhood, love, memory, the road, the search for a new home, the ability to begin life again. It is longing for what was left behind, and gratitude toward those who took us in. It is a country living through war, whose culture did not begin with that war and will not end with it.

The exhibition itself was built in a somewhat unusual way. First I had the story I wanted to tell, and only afterward did I start choosing the works to fit under it, moving from concept to painting rather than the other way round. Each work became something like an illustration of one part of that story, almost like an image in a book: one speaks of land, another of loss, the next of emigration, of the search for home, of memory, of hope. Together they form one continuous narrative. That is probably why the title carries the words "a memory that continues." Memory, for me, is not only what stayed in the past. It keeps shaping our present: how we see new places, how we build a new home, how we perceive the people around us, and how we tell our own story to others. I would like an Italian visitor to leave not simply thinking, "I saw an exhibition about the war in Ukraine," but feeling: "I understand a little better the people living through this, and the country they carry with them."

Ukraine and Italy share unexpectedly many structural parallels: strong craft traditions, a cult of material, local schools, sacred art, knowledge passed down through families, a particular weight given to home and land. At the same time, twentieth century Italian art, Arte Povera in particular, taught artists to treat simple materials as carriers of memory and meaning. Where do you personally see the most interesting ground for a genuine Ukrainian Italian artistic dialogue, one that goes beyond formal cultural diplomacy and surface resemblance?

I think the most interesting dialogue begins exactly where we stop deliberately looking for similarities between Ukraine and Italy. Cultural diplomacy often works to a familiar formula: bring Ukrainian art, show it to an Italian audience, talk about Ukraine, and the meeting of the two cultures more or less ends there. That is not enough for me. I am far more interested in creating a situation where a Ukrainian and an Italian artist end up in the same space and start talking about things that matter to both, but each from their own cultural experience. It could be the theme of home, land, memory, family, migration, loss, water, landscape. Even the same material can carry an entirely different memory in two cultures. Earth means something different to a Piedmontese artist and to a Ukrainian one, and it is precisely that difference that creates a real dialogue.

I find it especially interesting to work not only with the big national categories of "Ukraine" and "Italy," but to move down to a local level. For example, placing side by side the experience of a Ukrainian artist for whom the steppe, the field or an industrial city matters, and an artist from the shores of Lake Maggiore, for whom the formative childhood images are mountains, water, stone, small old towns, and seeing what emerges between those two experiences. The same applies to craft and material. I am deeply drawn to the idea that an ordinary thing, wood, cloth, metal, stone, earth, an old object, can be not just material to work with, but a carrier of memory. There is a great deal of common ground between Ukrainian and Italian traditions here, without needing to force the resemblance. That is why it matters to me that ArtLab gradually becomes more than a place where Italians are shown Ukrainian artists. I would like to build genuine Ukrainian Italian projects, where artists work around a single theme but speak

about it each in their own language. Real cultural dialogue, for me, is not when we say "look how alike we are," and it is not one culture explaining itself to another. It begins when two different cultures ask each other questions, and each ends up seeing itself a little differently as a result.

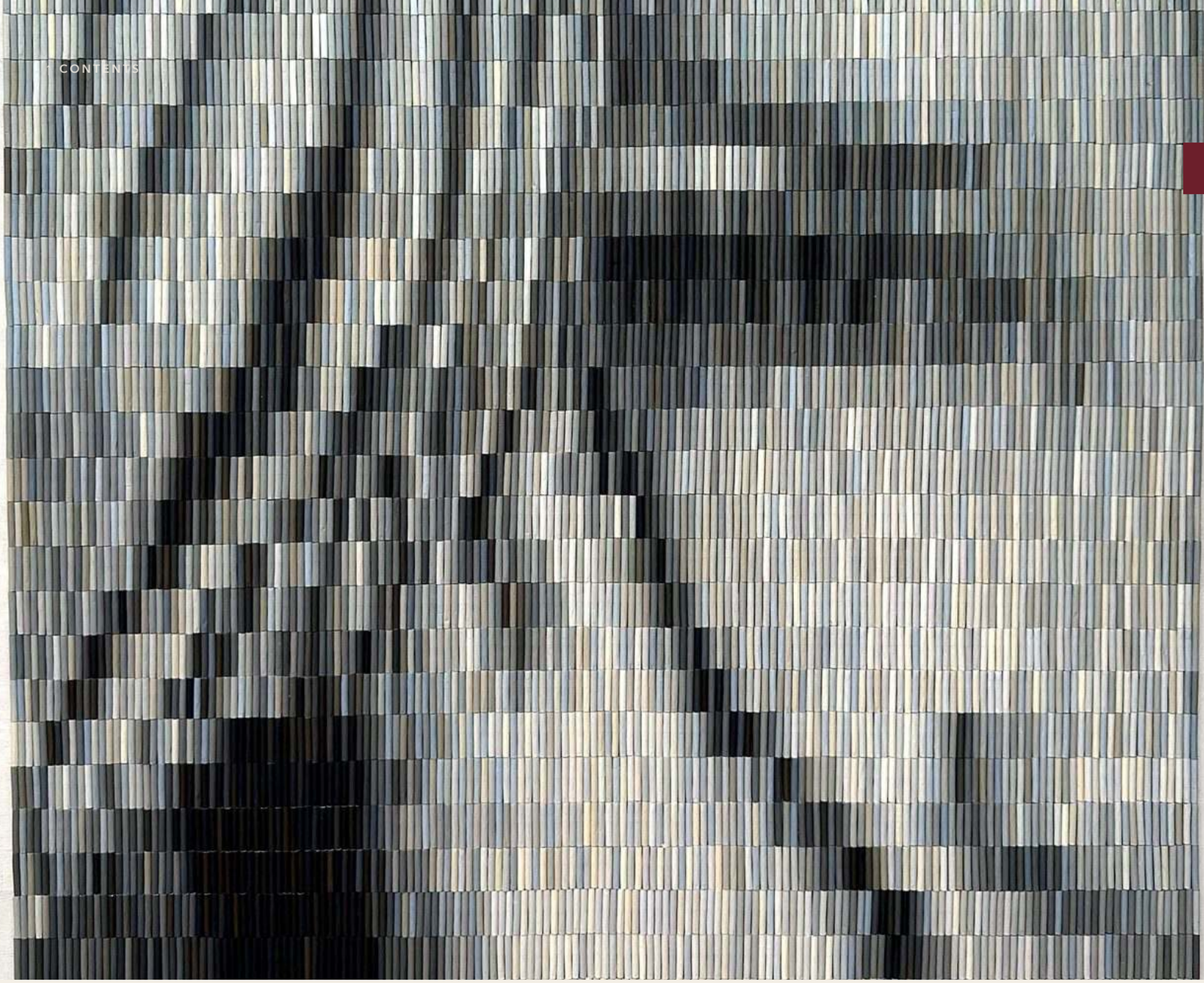
Much of today's Ukrainian European cultural connection is, understandably, built around support and solidarity. But what should come next? If you imagined a permanent cultural route between Ukraine and Italy, between artists, small towns, workshops, independent spaces and local communities, what shared questions would you build it around? And what role could ArtLab play in that longer term dialogue?

I think the next important step is the move from support and solidarity toward a full professional exchange. Today, quite understandably, many Ukrainian cultural projects in Europe arise in the context of war and the wish to support Ukraine, and we are endlessly grateful for that support. But in the long run, I would like a Ukrainian artist to be invited not because they represent a country at war, but because they are interesting as an artist: for their language, their ideas, their technique, their way of seeing the world.

That is why I see real potential in ongoing exchange: residencies, joint exhibitions, exchanges between artists, workshops, independent spaces and local communities. I am particularly interested in the level of small towns. Cultural exchange does not have to happen only between Kyiv, Milan or Rome. Small towns have their own memory, cultural energy, their own artists and their own audience. I would build such a route around very simple and universal questions: what does home mean to us? How does the place where we were born or live shape who we are? How do we hold on to memory? What happens to a person when they change countries? How can tradition live inside contemporary art? How does a local culture become part of a global one without losing its own voice?

In that system, I see ArtLab as one small point on a much larger cultural route. In the long term, I would like to expand ArtLab's format into an artist residency, so I could invite artists from around the world, and especially from Ukraine, to live and work here for a time, meet local artists and cultural institutions, exchange experience and create joint projects. And I have one further goal: for ArtLab to become a kind of springboard for Ukrainian artists into the international art world. Not a place where an artist shows one work once, but a place after which the next contact, the next exhibition, the next collaboration follows. That work, in fact, is already under way. Over time, I would like us to talk less about "supporting Ukrainian art" and more about its natural presence in the European cultural space. For me, that will be the real sign that we have moved from solidarity to a genuine, long term cultural dialogue.

Ukraine. A Memory That Continues (35. Ucraina. Una memoria che continua) is on view at ArtLab, Via Baiettini 53, Verbania (VB), Italy, from 24 August to 30 September 2026. Guided visits are available by appointment. ■



INTERVIEW SEPTEMBER 16, 2026

Oksana Dzhuman: A Self-Portrait in 5,500 Sticks

The Valencia-based artist on turning used tobacco sticks into mosaic portraits, painting each one by hand, and showing the work to the public for the first time at Russafa Art.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & OKSANA DZHUMAN

SECTION I · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & OKSANA DZHUMAN

The Valencia-based artist on turning used tobacco sticks into mosaic portraits, painting each one by hand, and showing the work to the public for the first time at Russafa Art.

Oksana Dzhuman trained as an interior designer, then studied graphic design, then spent several years as a tattoo artist. Today she lives in Valencia and works as an artist, repeatedly returning to an unusual material: used tobacco sticks, disinfected, painted individually by hand and assembled into large mosaic portraits.

The series began at the end of 2024 with a small box on her table. Her largest work so far, a self-portrait, is made from around 5,500 sticks. In 2026 the mosaics were shown publicly for the first time, at Russafa Art in Valencia. EPRIS Journal spoke with her about the long road to this material, the process behind a single portrait, and the painting she calls La Guerra.

Oksana Dzhuman with one of her mosaics.

You trained as an interior designer, then studied graphic design, and today you work as an artist in Valencia. How did these different stages of study and

experience shape the way you see composition, form and space in your work?

At university, I wasn't exactly the most serious student. I realised quite quickly that interior design itself didn't really interest me, and if an assignment didn't grab me, I did it simply because it had to be done.

But there was one exercise I really liked. We had to paint sheets of paper ourselves in different shades, cut them into small squares and rectangles, and assemble an image from them. I made two ravens sitting on a branch in purple tones. Only now do I realise how close it was to what I do today, just with a completely different material.

Later I went to study graphic design. That was already part of searching for what I wanted to do, but in the end that wasn't mine either. After that I came to tattooing and worked in that field for several years. I think that experience influenced me much more strongly. Tattooing definitely taught me patience, attention to detail and how to work with composition.

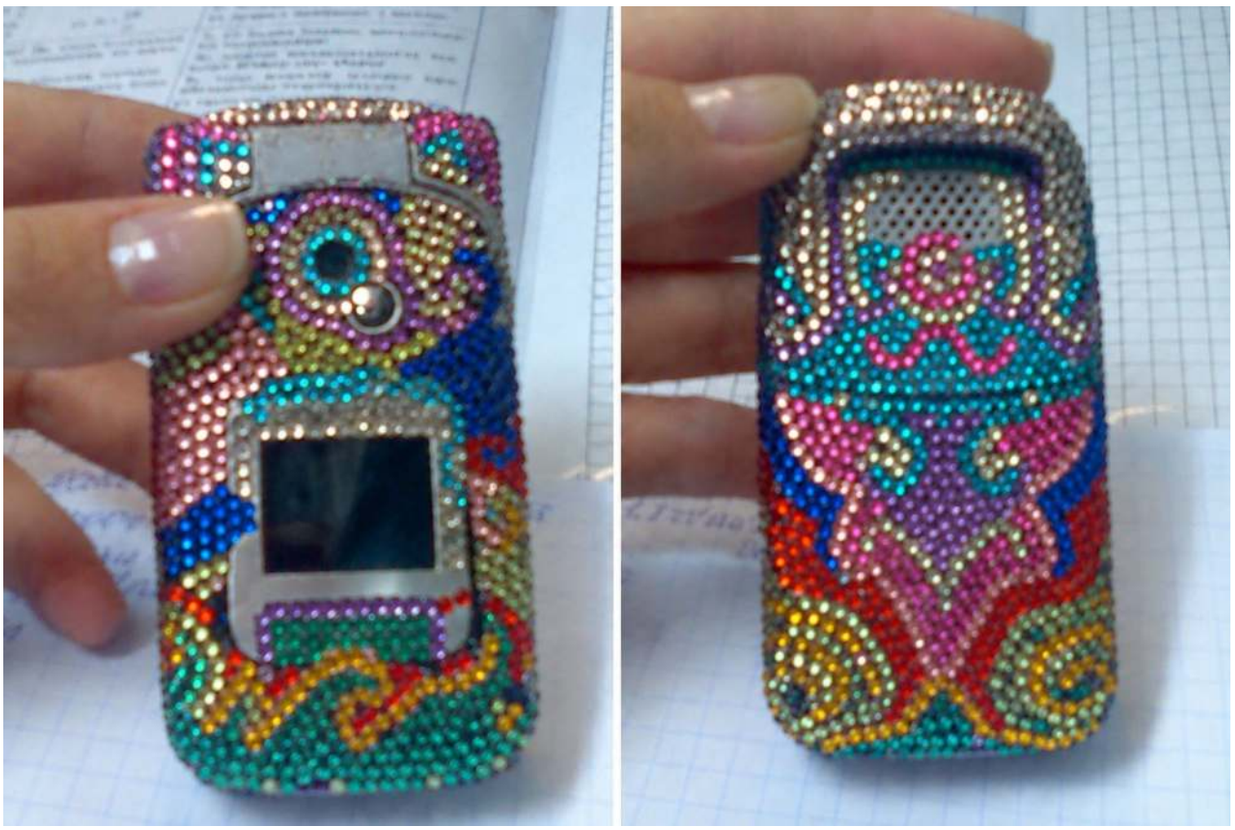
Looking back, your path in art reads like several different chapters: drawing, tattoo, and now portraits from recycled materials. How do you connect these chapters into one story for yourself?

For a long time I didn't see it as one story at all. I was constantly trying something new: I could get absorbed in one thing, then switch to something completely different, and after a while come back to something again.

Only when the mosaics appeared did I start looking back and noticing things that repeat. I have always loved details, long manual work, colour, and the process itself, when a whole gradually emerges from separate elements.

And that pull appeared even before university. At school, I remember spending a whole night covering my phone by hand with hundreds of tiny rhinestones, inventing the pattern as I went and not noticing the time at all. Later the phone was, fittingly, stolen. Perhaps all that sparkle did its job after all.

So now I see it all as a rather chaotic path, in which only after years did I begin to listen to myself more and understand what I actually love.



The phone she covered in rhinestones over one night as a schoolgirl.

Do you remember the moment you first thought that an ordinary used stick could become something more than rubbish? What caught your attention then?

It all began at the end of 2024, unfortunately, with smoking. I kept a small box nearby and started collecting used sticks in it. That was when I first noticed how quickly they accumulated. When you stop seeing them as one or two sticks you simply throw away and instead see how many collect in just a few days, you become uncomfortably aware of the scale of your own habit.

That same evening I started looking at the sticks themselves, and at some point something just clicked: what if I tried to make something out of them? The idea came very suddenly, almost like a light bulb switching on. They were waste, there were a lot of them, and they were small, light and all the same shape. I immediately wanted to know whether they could become a material to work with.

The first box of used sticks.

At first your works were made only from your own sticks, but over time other people began to join the project. How did that happen naturally, and what changed for you personally when the material stopped being only yours?

Until 2026 I used only my own sticks, so collecting material took a very long time. The first person to help me was a Spanish friend of mine, and I'm very grateful to her for the support. Then other people gradually joined in, and there was noticeably more material.

Later I posted on social media that I was collecting used sticks for my work, and unexpectedly quite a lot of people responded. People even gave me whole cartons of new sticks. It changed the pace of the work a great deal: before, I had to wait for months until enough material piled up for one piece, and now several thousand sticks can be collected much faster.

And I now see the works themselves a little differently. I look at them and understand that they are no longer made only from my own material. In a sense, many people take part in making each of them, and I'm very grateful to everyone who helps me collect it.

Material arrives from friends and followers: packs, bags and whole collections.

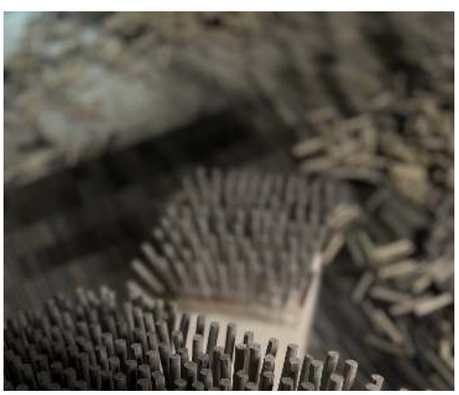
If we take our time and describe the whole journey of one work, from the first stick to the finished portrait, which part of the process gives you the most pleasure, and which demands the most patience?

It all starts with collecting. Then comes a rather long preparation process: several stages of disinfection and treatment to remove the smell.

While the sticks are being treated, I prepare the canvas at the same time: I make the layout and a colour map, so I understand which shades I'll need and roughly how the work will look.

Then I paint the sticks in the shades I need. Many people are surprised that I paint every stick by hand, but for me this is the most meditative part of the process. After that, I begin assembling the image on the canvas.

The whole process requires patience, but preparing the material probably takes the most. It takes quite a lot of time.



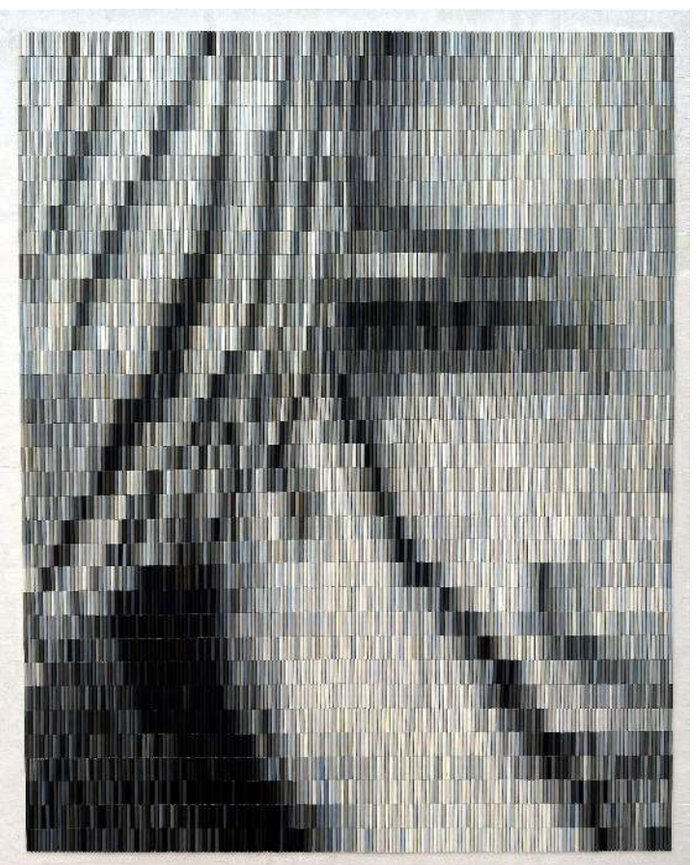
From sorted material to painted rows: stages of a work in progress.

You assembled your self-portrait from 5,500 painted sticks; it is the largest work in the series. If it isn't too

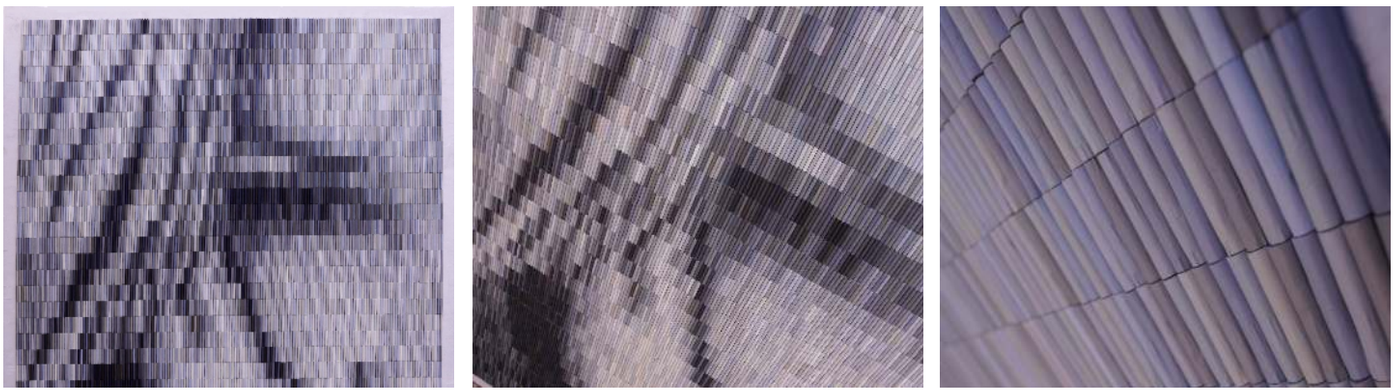
personal a question: what did you feel as you gradually recognised your own face in this unusual technique?

While I work, I almost can't see the image. The canvases are large, and you work with them however you can: from the side, from above, sometimes almost lying down. Up close it all looks like a set of separate shades, and the image simply doesn't come together. You can only understand what's emerging by stepping back. With the self-portrait it was even harder, because it is practically black and white.

And when the work was finished, the emotions were very mixed. I was glad I'd finished it, I was proud of myself, and at the same time I wanted to cry and not show it to anyone at all. I think the realisation hit me: this is my face, made of sticks that I smoked myself. It all began with a small box that didn't even hold fifty sticks, and now there were around 5,500 of them in front of me.



Self-portrait, 5,500 hand-painted sticks.



Self-portrait, details. Up close the face dissolves into separate shades.

One of your works refers to Vermeer's Girl with a Pearl Earring, a very recognisable image. What brought you to this portrait in particular, and did your relationship with it change while you were working on it?

I had liked Girl with a Pearl Earring for a long time. Back in Ukraine I painted my own version with a cat, and in Spain the image kept turning up everywhere. At some point I decided that she would be my first portrait made of sticks. A familiar image, familiar colours.

Before her I had made only two works from sticks, both abstract and with a fairly simple palette, so a portrait with so many shades was a big step for me.

When I finished the layout and realised how many shades and thousands of sticks I would have to paint by hand, I thought I had taken on too much. I even considered leaving it as elongated coloured pixels. It stayed in that state for quite a long time, until I finally talked myself into finishing what I'd started.

That is probably why I have a special love for this work. It was my first work on that scale, and the first that took me so long to complete, and in the end it became my favourite.

After Vermeer's Girl with a Pearl Earring, her first portrait made of sticks.

Besides mosaic, you work in oil painting, graphite studies and the series Elongated Pixels. Do you feel these languages as different voices in the same conversation, or does each one lead you somewhere else entirely?

In general I try not to divide my work into separate directions or tie everything together into one story. I simply like switching between different materials and techniques. I can finish a work in sticks, pick up watercolour or go back to oils, and then return to the sticks again.

Sometimes one thing grows directly out of another. Elongated Pixels, for example, were born while I was working on Girl with a Pearl Earring. At the layout stage I saw that the image looked interesting even without the sticks, and later I made Frida in this technique.

But it's still the sticks that I keep coming back to. Right now this is the material and the process I like most of all.

Among your works there is a canvas called La Guerra. I understand this may be a difficult subject, so I ask

carefully: if you feel comfortable talking about it now, what stood behind this work?

For me this work is probably about the pain that stays inside because of the war. Life goes on, you do ordinary things, but it doesn't go away.

At first I wanted to leave hope in this work, the thought that after darkness light always comes. That was meant to be the sun. But in the process, instead of a ray of light, it began to bleed.

Even now I look at this work and feel everything tighten inside. For me, La Guerra is probably that very wound, the one that stays inside even when life around you goes on.

In 2026 your works were shown to the public for the first time at Russafa Art in Valencia. What was it like when people stood next to your mosaics and looked at them in person, rather than on a screen?

At Russafa Art I caught myself feeling a little out of place. There was a lot of painting around, and here I was with my used sticks. I felt awkward, and at the same time I was glad to finally be showing them, and afraid: how would people even take this?

The most interesting part was watching the reactions. Many people didn't understand what the works were made of. Some guessed pastel or chalk, but practically no one guessed used sticks.

The images themselves were also read in different ways. Girl with a Pearl Earring was recognised immediately, because almost everyone knows that image. The self-portrait was harder: people could look at it for a long time without understanding what was in front of them, but as soon as I showed them a photograph, the portrait became visible.

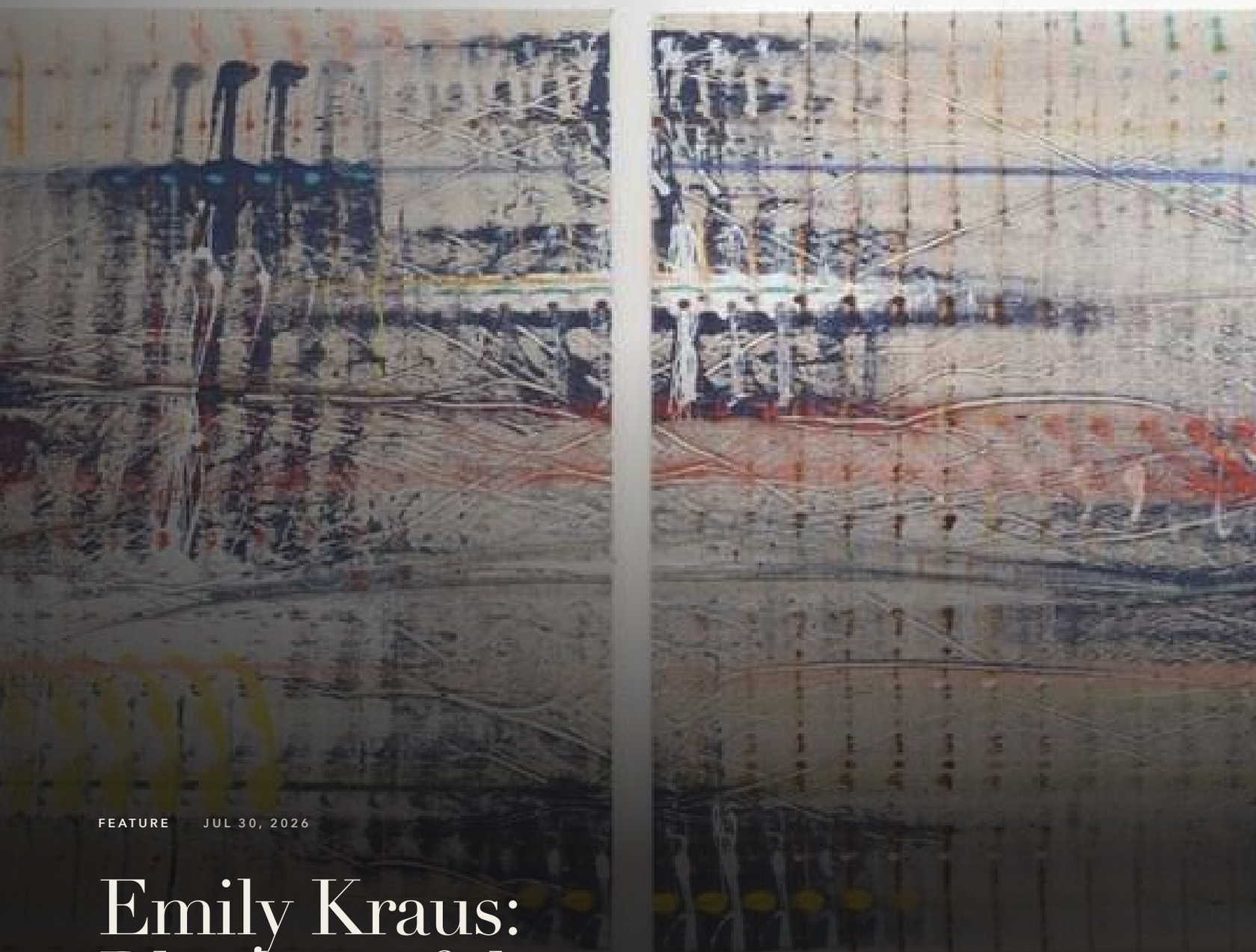
For me it was a very valuable experience. I saw live reactions to my work, received a lot of support and met new people. It's much easier for me to make works than to show them and talk about myself. Even keeping up with social media isn't easy for me, so taking part in Russafa Art was quite a big step. And I'm very grateful to everyone who supported me.

Allow me one last, slightly dreamy question: is there an image, a theme or a material you would like to take on one day, but for now lack the courage or the time?

One day I would like to try making a large-scale portrait out of much smaller elements. For now the complexity, the number of elements and the time it would take scare me a little. But once, a few thousand sticks also seemed far too complicated, and now with every new work the process becomes clearer and more precise for me.

In parallel I collect various materials that should have ended up in the rubbish but caught my attention for some reason. I don't know myself yet what they will become, or when. My ideas usually appear quite unexpectedly.

Photographs courtesy of Oksana Dzhuman. Interview conducted in writing for EPRIS Journal, September 2026. ■



FEATURE JUL 30, 2026

Emily Kraus: Rhythm of the Moment

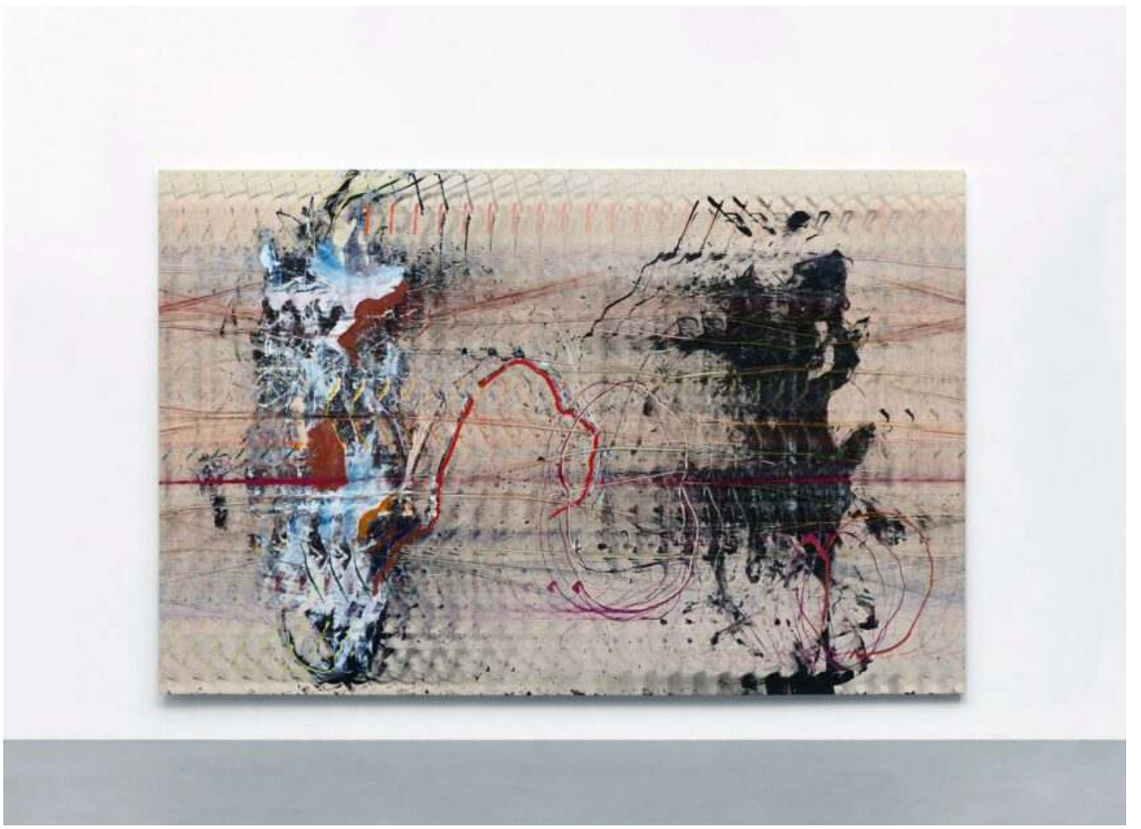
Inside the Canvas Cube, Emily Kraus Paints the Rhythm of the Present Moment

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

SECTION I · FEATURE · MARIA IVANOVA

Inside the Canvas Cube, Emily Kraus Paints the Rhythm of the Present Moment

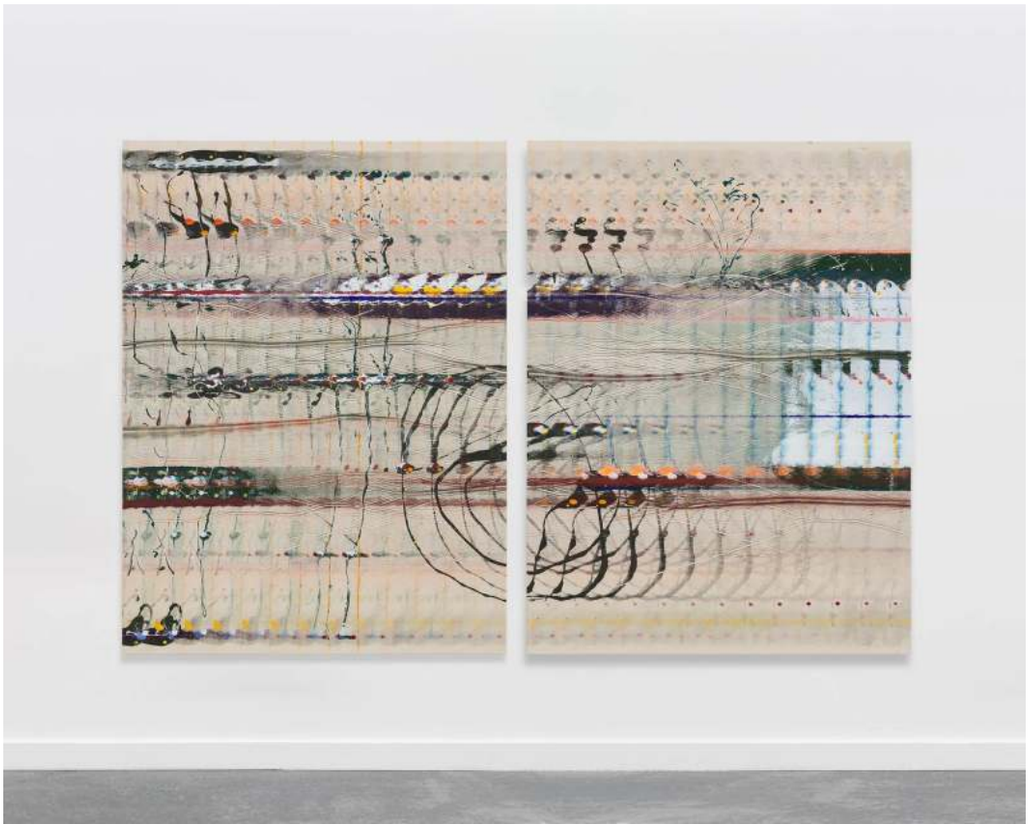
Emily Kraus's (New York, 1995) works left me unbothered by anything externally existing. I am frozen, trapped and stunned by the unidentified. It's almost like falling in love – you were not prepared, you didn't ask for it, yet it's one of the best feelings that can happen to the human being.



Emily Kraus, Each in the other what each has to give, 2026. Photo by Ollie Hammick

When the art is a part of the artist's mind, body and soul – you can feel it from the innermost dedication to the practice. That form of connection can be compared to the billions of invisible thinnest threads that remain unbroken between the artist and the artwork, even when they are far apart. They are mutually nourishing and will never be independent again.

When you look at the painting and can almost physically feel the presence of the author - that's when the purest form of revelation is unfolding in front of you.



Emily Kraus, Stochastic 20, 2023. Photo by Ollie Hammick

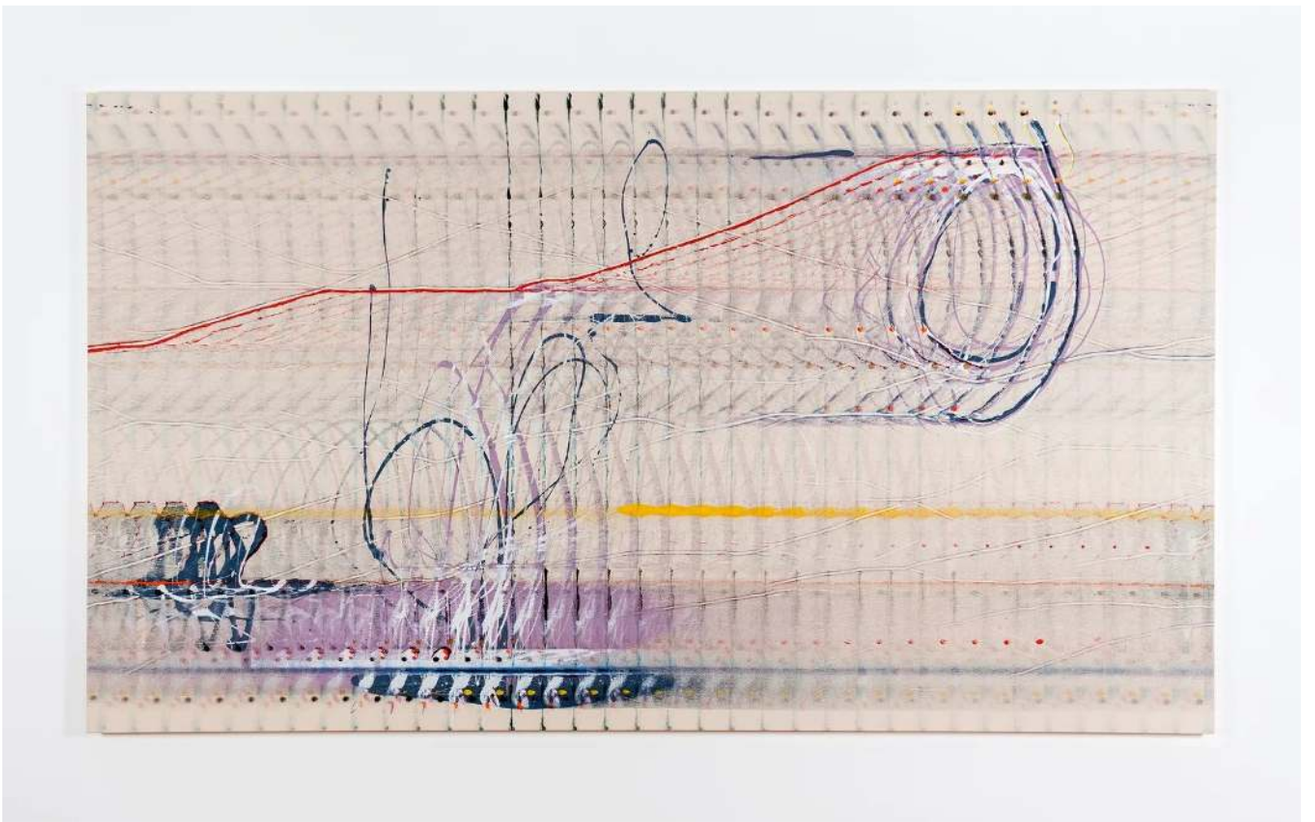
The first glance was not followed by the question "How?". I was too occupied dealing with jitters. The second one brought me back to consciousness, ready to be curious about how it was achieved.

Lack of immediate curiosity about technique corresponds to the artist's belief that the work should live on its own – the communication with the viewer relies on an individual reflection as the clearest translator of visuals.

Emily Kraus works in tandem with a self-invented structure, made of a scaffold with planks and rotating poles, on which the canvas is stretched. This approach gives a unique opportunity to rotate the surface and at the same time creates a cube-like enclosed space. From inside, the artist is applying the oil paints, and then rotates the canvas before the paint dries – as it moves through the poles, the paint gets smudged. The repeated steps result in the glitchy signature visual code.

As the canvas is geometrically structured, the result of the whole image is unknown until the end of the work, which takes approximately one month.

There is a beauty in the uncontrollable. The nature of each painting is not in the pursuit of visual appeal, but in a momentary decision, whether the following gesture belongs to this emerging artwork or not. Through this profound significance of the process, based purely on the artist's feelings, the painting accumulates a powerful, spiritual memory.



Emily Kraus, Fwooooop, 2024

This mechanism was influenced by the time when Kraus was studying in her second year at the Royal College of Art, which coincided with COVID-19 and the lockdown. She was assigned a cube studio 2.5 by 2.5 metres. The limited area of the room hampered Kraus's intention to paint with large gestures, experimenting with her body and space. To expand the possibilities of her practice in existing conditions, she stretched the canvas along all the walls using shower poles and wooden brackets. The canvas could be rotated, erasing the boundaries of the contained space.

The concept of confinement as part of a wider perception of space was on the artist's agenda before. Emily Kraus explored the boundaries of objects, places, and the relations between them. Moreover, she practiced meditation, which ultimately reconfigures the whole existing world, making it seamlessly broad and possible to totally fit in one's mind at the same time. Accumulating reflections along with a small studio space prompts a question about how one can find freedom when physically confined and how space cannot free us from the mind's cage.

As Lucian Freud stated – "Everything is a self-portrait". These words can't be more accurate when talking about art. The sublime essence of Emily Kraus's oeuvre is definitive, rather than chaotically formed – she holds a BA in Religious Studies from Kenyon College. The choice was influenced by Kraus's self-questioning of the meaning of life.

The profound influence of Emily Kraus on the contemporary art world is reinforced through the recognition by major institutions: as one of the Artsy Vanguard 2026, recipient of the Hopper Prize, and shortlisted for both the Hopper Prize and the John Moores Painting Prize, she continues to make discoveries through every new work, establishing her strong path. ■

FEATURE JUL 17, 2026

Art that makes you smile

I believe that when you introduce playful objects into an environment, it expands the boundaries of the mind. It gives you nonverbal permission to think freely - not just to push against conventional frames, but to forget they even exist.

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

SECTION I · FEATURE · MARIA IVANOVA

I believe that when you introduce playful objects into an environment, it expands the boundaries of the mind. It gives you non-verbal permission to think freely - not just to push against conventional frames, but to forget they even exist.

There is a preconception that pleasure derived from an art piece, or the smile it evokes, somehow lowers its value and strips it of the grand title of "Art." However, this is simply not true.

Art can speak loudly without words, making it an indisputable instrument for materializing self-reflection or addressing social and political concerns. Yet, if we look at the etymology of the word, "art" is not historically related to "seriousness" or anything of the sort; it takes its roots in hand-related craft, brilliantly mastered and executed. This origin automatically deprives art of any mandatory obligations and legitimizes its right to just be.

As was mentioned, art serves as a reflection of social, political, gender, or other issues. It can be a medium for personal introspection or a vehicle to deliver complex ideas in diverse shapes and forms. But an artist still can create playful objects following an intrinsic desire to feel the material, to experiment with shapes and colors, to master techniques, and to bring a piece of joy to everyday life. And being playful is not synonymouswith being superficial. All objects carry the background, beliefs, vision, intentions, and concerns of their creators - they are simply expressed through a different lens.

Taking everything too seriously is a dead end - and it certainly shouldn't cross your mind when you are choosing a new piece for your home. Ultimately, the baseline is your personal preference. If you only approve of strict beige and black forms, or conventional mediums and subjects, that is wonderful! My only concern is when people don't even allow themselves to consider a piece that might spark a moment of delight. We constantly hear: "It looks so great, it will go beautifully with my walls and my other paintings." But next time, try asking yourself a different question: Does it make me smile? Colorful and playful objects possess a unique quality that others lack - they inject pure happiness into a room. We don't think about this often enough, focusing instead on how trendy a piece is or how it makes our home look. But how does it make us feel?

Colorful and playful objects possess a unique quality that others lack - they inject pure happiness into a room.

Interior design is not just a setting, a static picture, a composition, or a color palette. It is a living environment that embraces and enswathes you. We are used to considering an interior as an external component of our existence, positioning ourselves merely as spectators. In reality, the moment we step into a space, we are absorbed by it, invisibly adopting its mood and yielding to the irresistible influence of its atmosphere. There is

even a specific branch of science - neuroarchitecture - that studies how the environment affects our cognitive performance, as well as our psychological and physical well-being. Mostly, these effects are triggered by spatial characteristics, color psychology, and the tactile properties of materials. However, there is one element that often falls off this scientific list but still has a major impact on how we experience a space: *details filled with irony and fun*.

In reality, the moment we step into a space, we are absorbed by it, invisibly adopting its mood and yielding to the irresistible influence of its atmosphere.

I believe that when you introduce playful objects into an environment, it expands the boundaries of the mind. It gives you non-verbal permission to think freely - not just to push against conventional frames, but to forget they even exist.

Below, you will find a selection of artists whose objects are guaranteed to bring an unexpected smile to your face.

Lola Mayeras

French designer Lola Mayeras grew up in the South of France with a ceramist father, so her artistic heritage and exploration of colors and shapes began to form in early childhood. She worked as a fashion designer before launching her own design studio in 2020. During the lockdown, she rediscovered her father's workshop in her hometown and followed an inner desire to create in a medium familiar to her since youth.

Her background in fashion preserved her love for draping, but now her target objects are furniture and sculptures. Her most frequent signature element is the button-down shirt - it stands still in the form of a vase, is modestly stacked in a sculpture, or effortlessly draped over the corner of a wooden table. The latter is my personal favorite among all her amazing pieces: a restrained, natural ceramic mass with a wrinkled, azure-blue shirt seemingly falling onto the floor.

Lola Mayeras also manages to create anthropomorphic vases with ears and earrings that look perfectly natural an all senses. The balance of form and scale is so fine that it makes you question why other vases lack these symmetrical details. It is bold yet in harmony.

Recently, she has expanded her practice to work with metal and textiles. If you are in search of unique bedding, you can order the “It’s a Mess” set, featuring a trompe-l'œil print of scattered clothes. The light-hearted essence of her objects, along with chosen color palette, is deeply inspired by her childhood in the South of France, where enjoying a sun-filled life was a daily routine.

The light-hearted essence of her objects, along with chosen color palette, is deeply inspired by her childhood in the South of France, where enjoying a sun-filled life was a daily routine.

Erwin Wurm

Erwin Wurm's work is a prime example of playful irony masking serious social themes – messages that are difficult to read at first glance, but become an inseparable part of the experience once uncovered.

As a pioneer of conceptual humor who has won the hearts of art lovers worldwide, Wurm famously gifts bags, sausages, sweaters, and other everyday items with arms and legs. He is the creator of puffed cars, bloated houses, and anthropomorphic pickles, all reconsidered through simple shapes and actions. This simplicity should by no means diminish the artist's value; rather, it reflects a genuine mastery of a highly readable visual language, which then collides with absolute unpredictability.

Ultimately, the absurdity in Wurm's art serves as a sharp response to the pressures of contemporary society, such as overconsumption, the overwhelming weight of public opinion, and our obsession with self-representation through the things we own. Underneath the cheerful packaging lies a profound commentary on the modern human condition. Yet, the presence of this hidden depth never compromises the pure, joyful look of his pieces – they remain effortlessly delightful objects that you want to return to again and again.

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Funny Ollas

Swedish designer Fanny Ollas has a background in textile and fashion, that reflects in her elegantly ornamented vases. Each vessel looks like a fairy character, who live by your side rent-free and has all the rights to do so.

The gentle tones and integration of faux fur, lacing, strass and pearls shape the magical tinkling appearance to every piece, yet they carry a certain state of melancholy. Her work revolves around thoughts about vulnerability, body, demands, fears, relationships and what is hidden behind our facades.

Pablo Picasso

The legendary Spanish artist always called himself an experimenter, and there can't be a more accurate description for the vast broadness of his work. Although he didn't focus on irony as a core theme, the vessels he produced in large quantities in the South of

France at the Madoura Atelier are a perfect reflection of the playful component in the artist's oeuvre.

By the end of World War II, Picasso was already a living legend, an acclaimed genius, and a millionaire. But this success had a backfire effect - he grew tired of academicism and the solemn, rigid attitude toward art. In turning to clay, he seemed to permit himself to become a child again.

"I can draw like Raphael, but it took me a lifetime to learn to draw like a child," - Pablo Picasso

The comical faces he painted on pitchers were an act of pure play and an expression of the absolute happiness he felt while living on the sunny coast with his young muse, Françoise Gilot. After the horrors of war, the tragedy of Guernica, and deep personal crises, creating vibrant, humorous tableware became a form of art therapy for him.

The comical faces he painted on pitchers were an act of pure play and an expression of the absolute happiness he felt while living on the sunny coast with his young muse, Françoise Gilot. After the horrors of war, the tragedy of Guernica, and deep personal crises, creating vibrant, humorous tableware became a form of art therapy for him.

These pitchers were never meant to sit behind glass in dusty museums. Picasso originally intended for his ceramics to be affordable and used in everyday life - for pouring wine or holding fruit - so that people could smile at those amusing, hand-painted faces over breakfast.

Matthew Centeno

Improvisation and an open-minded approach sit at the heart of Matthew Centeno's creative process. Through highly detailed craftsmanship, he transforms ordinary balloons into captivating shapes that instantly speak directly to the inner child in everyone. His ultimate goal is to break through the monotony of daily life, nudging the audience to rediscover their forgotten sense of curiosity.

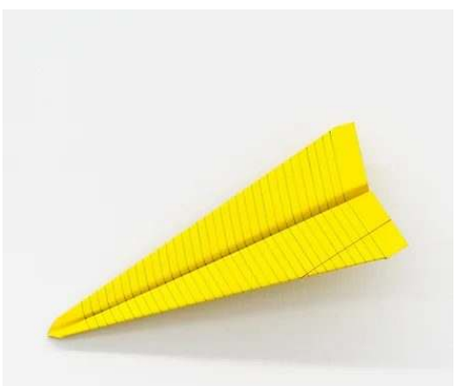
While foil balloons are the ultimate indicators of celebrations and holidays, they are inherently temporary. Unlike flowers, which have already become a staple of casual home decor, balloons still belong firmly to the category of special occasions. Centeno's

wall-mounted porcelain balloon with a smiling face serves as a permanent reminder that every single day is special.

Sébastien Gaudette

What can be more pleasent than the sticky notes with cheerful inscriptions, that make you feel warm every time you see them? Sebastien Gaudette creates the tromp-l'œil sculptures from aluminium, which will stay on your wall forever. It's the kind of art that doesn't have to suit your interior but rather contribute to your mood and emotional well-being. I need to admit that the small size of the work adds to the spark of discovering it around - it's like a piece of magic which you unexpectedly run into and freeze for a moment to smile for a second and go back to the errands.

The central pillar of the Gaudets' work is not the inscriptions but the recreation of paper folding. However, even within this framework, we find the component of delightful familiarity combined with childish excitement. For example the paper planes of different colors, made from a lined notebook sheet. Finding it on the chest of drawers or coffetable among books and vases would be a wonderful time machine to the carefreeness of youth.



It seems like we are frightened to let the art entartain us.

Whether you are an art - collector, - lover, - enthusiast or just start your acquaintance with bounderless art world, start noticing the objects that not only challange you, question or provocate, but also can evoke warmful memories, create a new one or simply makes you smile almost unreasonably.

Sometimes your joy is an artist goal - surrender to its power. ■

SPECIAL FEATURE JULY 18, 2026

Sandra Kantanen: Beyond the Lens of Traditional Photography

Finnish artist Sandra Kantanen approaches photography as a gateway to the imagined, rather than a tool for capturing objective reality. Her work reveals a unique, boundary-less technical…

WORDS BY EPRIS JOURNAL

SECTION I · SPECIAL FEATURE · EPRIS JOURNAL

Finnish artist Sandra Kantanen approaches photography as a gateway to the imagined, rather than a tool for capturing objective reality. Her work reveals a unique, boundary-less technical…

Finnish artist Sandra Kantanen approaches photography as a gateway to the imagined, rather than a tool for capturing objective reality. Her work reveals a unique, boundary-less technical philosophy, that pushes the medium beyond the constraints of the lens, challenging the viewer to question where the photograph ends and the painting begins.

At first glance, one might assume her ethereal landscapes are the result of mixed oil paints and traditional layering. In reality, these are photographs of natural environments-ranging from the forests of her native Finland to the mountains of Asia-subjected to profound digital and physical manipulation.

Sandra Kantanen, Still life (Flowers 3), 2020

Born in Helsinki in 1974, Sandra Kantanen emerged as a key figure within the internationally celebrated Helsinki School of Photography. Her academic foundation was built at the Aalto University School of Arts, Design and Architecture in Helsinki, but the pivotal shift in her artistic trajectory occurred around the year 2000, when she moved to China as an exchange student.

Studying traditional Chinese landscape painting at the Central Academy of Fine Arts in Beijing, Kantanen became deeply influenced by Eastern philosophy. She was struck by how ancient masters did not aim to document the landscape, but to idealize and sublimate it.

Sandra Kantanen, "Untitled (pink flowers) , 2013 · Sandra Kantanen, "Untitled (Sakura 3)", 2011

During her travels through China's sacred mountains, she witnessed the stark tension between the pristine, spiritualized nature depicted in ancient silk scrolls and the harsh realities of modern industrial pollution and tourism. This dissonance became the catalyst for her practice: a lifelong pursuit to capture an "impossible" landscape – a space existing somewhere between memory, myth, and optical distortion.

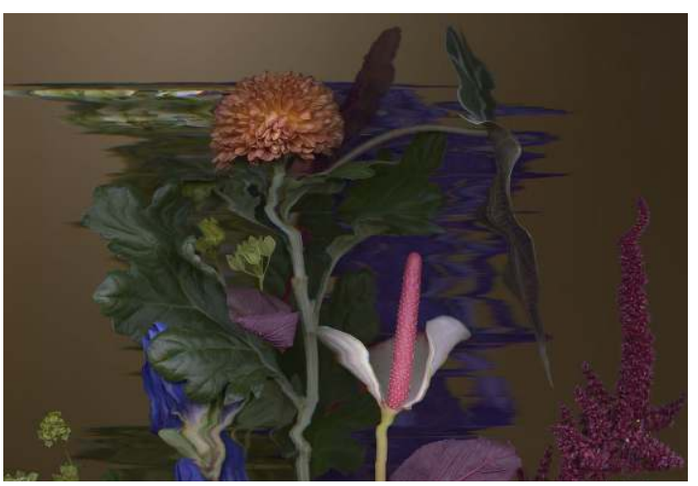
Sandra Kantanen, "Untitled (Mountain 7)", 2010

While pixel-distorted landscapes are her most famous signature, Kantanen's broader photographic practice is remarkably diverse. She does not rely on a single technical trick; rather, she experiments across different series, constantly redefining how a photographic image can behave:

The Smoke Works and Pixel Manipulation: In her most renowned series, Kantanen physically intervenes in nature before the shutter even clicks. By releasing colored smoke bombs into remote forests – such as those near her home in Hango, Finland-she creates a surreal, psychedelic atmosphere that disrupts the mundane scenery. She then takes these digital files and subjects them to deep manipulation: blurring horizons, stretching data, and manually forcing pixels to flow so that the photograph mimics the fluidity of liquid paint.

Sandra Kantanen, "Untitled (Forest 21)", 2021

Botanical Studies and Scanners: Shifting away from vast landscapes and pixel-stretching entirely, her floral still lifes and botanical works explore organic decay up close. For these, she often utilizes large-scale formats, long exposures, or even flatbed scanners instead of traditional camera lenses. These methods evoke the rich, allegorical depth of Dutch Golden Age painting, focusing on the intimate textures and slow passage of time in nature.



Sandra Kantanen, "Untitled (Distortion 9)", 2016 · Sandra Kantanen, "Untitled (Distortion 6)", 2017

By moving fluidly between physical staging, scanner art, straight capture, and digital distortion, Kantanen constantly destabilizes our perception of what a photograph can be.

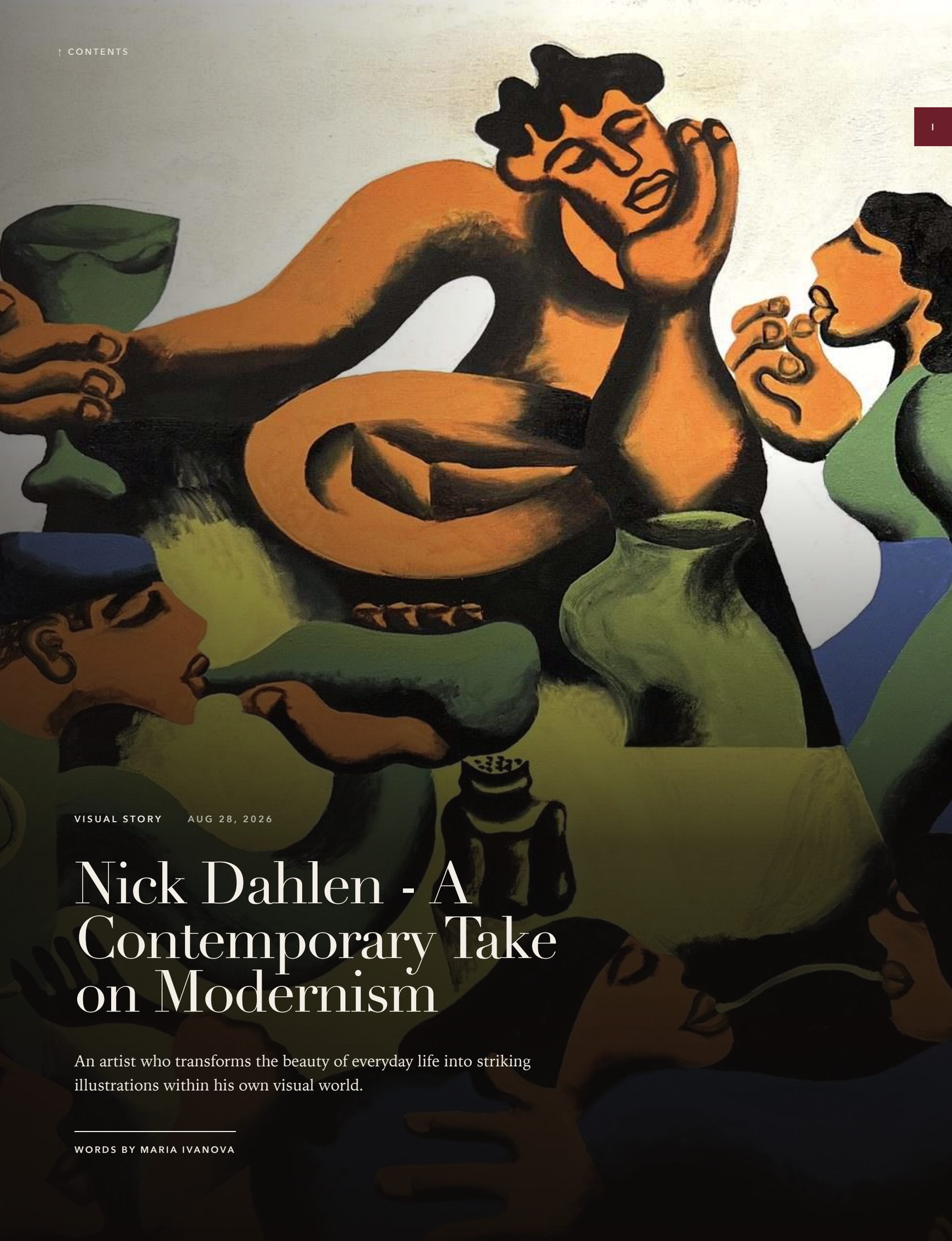
Sandra Kantanen, “Horizon”, 2005

Sandra Kantanen, "Rain", 2005

Over a career spanning more than two decades, Sandra Kantanen has earned widespread international acclaim for her innovative contributions to contemporary visual arts.

Her work has been showcased globally, with major exhibitions at venues like the Purdy Hicks Gallery in London, Paris Photo, and a comprehensive retrospective at the Turku Art Museum.

Kantanen's influence is cemented by her inclusion in the permanent collections of some of the world's most respected institutions, including the J. Paul Getty Museum in Los Angeles, the Brooklyn Museum, the Los Angeles County Museum of Art (LACMA), and the Kiasma Museum of Contemporary Art in Helsinki. Her monographs, published by Hatje Cantz, serve as a testament to an artist who does not merely use technology, but bends it to the eternal service of beauty. ■



VISUAL STORY AUG 28, 2026

Nick Dahlen - A Contemporary Take on Modernism

An artist who transforms the beauty of everyday life into striking illustrations within his own visual world.

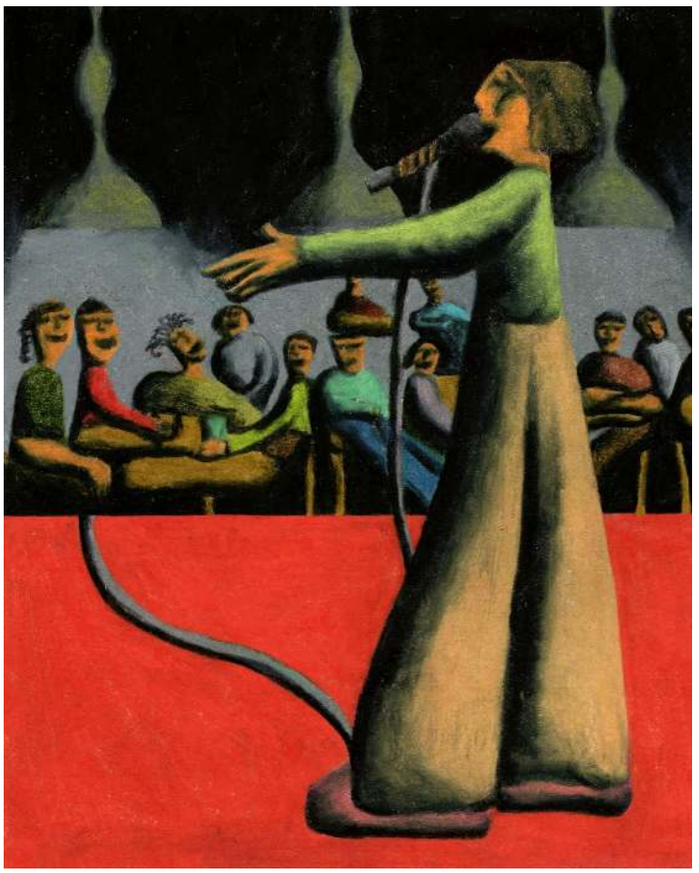
WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

SECTION I · VISUAL STORY · MARIA IVANOVA

An artist who transforms the beauty of everyday life into striking illustrations within his own visual world.

Nick Dahlen is an artist and illustrator from Minneapolis whose work revives the spirit of modernism through a contemporary lens.

With a background in graffiti and a degree in Graphic Design, Dahlen has developed a visual language that combines the strength of modernist aesthetics with a sense of nostalgia – perhaps for a visual era we instinctively long for without even realizing it.



The foundation of Dahlen's style is remarkably consistent, and that consistency only makes it more compelling. Once you encounter one of his images, you immediately want to move on to the next, drawn in by the pleasure of clean, simplified forms covering otherwise ordinary, everyday subjects.

Style & Influences

This visual accessibility – in the best possible sense of the word – is largely created through saturated, contrasting shadows that immediately establish the contours of each form. We can read the scene effortlessly, and that clarity makes it instinctively appealing.

The simplification of forms, combined with deliberate distortions and an authorial sense of proportion, recalls Cubism, particularly the work of Fernand Léger and Pablo Picasso. It is worth lingering on this idea of simplification because, in Dahlen's work, it exists hand in hand with complexity. This dichotomy is rooted in the distortion of form and in a belief in its inherent plasticity.

The distortions – and particularly the enlarged proportions – make his figures feel monumental, almost sculptural. Here, one can trace an affinity with the work of Brazilian artist Tarsila do Amaral, whose figures similarly acquire a powerful, almost sculptural presence through their simplified and exaggerated forms.

Boldness is balanced by a certain fluidity, which keeps the work visually inviting. All of these elements come together through a palette of muted tones, transforming familiar subjects into instantly arresting compositions.

The visual impact happens almost immediately. Contrasting shadows and simplified figures allow us to read the image effortlessly, while simultaneously presenting a reimagined form of figurative painting.

Dahlen's background in graphic design – particularly his attention to the visual language of twentieth-century posters – seems to have played an important role here. A strong awareness of hierarchy, direct communication, and the clear transmission of both image and meaning coexist with his distinctive treatment of form.

Subjects

Dahlen uses this visual language to depict ordinary objects and everyday scenes: preparing food, playing dominoes, cutting with scissors, assembling a puzzle. He has a particular fascination with food.

There is something striking about the way we can look at the same object every day, while an artist can present it to us in a way that feels completely unfamiliar – beyond the limits of our imagination.

Dahlen's work ultimately seeks to communicate a sense of positive energy while subtly reflecting certain tensions and difficulties, leaving their interpretation to the symbolism of form and colour.

■

ESSAY AUG 31, 2026

Where the Warmth Lives: How Two Traditions Measured the Turn from Summer to Autumn

Autumn does not make the light warmer. Measured region by region, two canvases of the same field show the sky staying where it was while the ground swings seventeen points warm, and the shadows, all summer filled with blue skylight, turn into the warmest passages in the picture. With three pastels in which the medium is held still and only the season moves. And a second half in which autumn is not a light at all: a calendar that declares it on the seventh of August, a season carried by one grass, and a moon with no horizon to rise from.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

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The usual way to describe autumn in painting is to say that the light turns warm. It is the wrong description, and a series of measurements taken from the paintings themselves shows why. The light does not turn warm. The *ground* does, and once it does, it takes over the job the sky had been doing all summer. What changes is not the colour of the light but the address of the warmth in the picture.

This piece works through that claim on ten paintings and pastels, most of them measured region by region: two canvases of the same field before and after the turn, three pastels in which the medium is held constant and only the season moves, and a set of comparisons that ends somewhere useful for anyone who paints, photographs or simply looks.

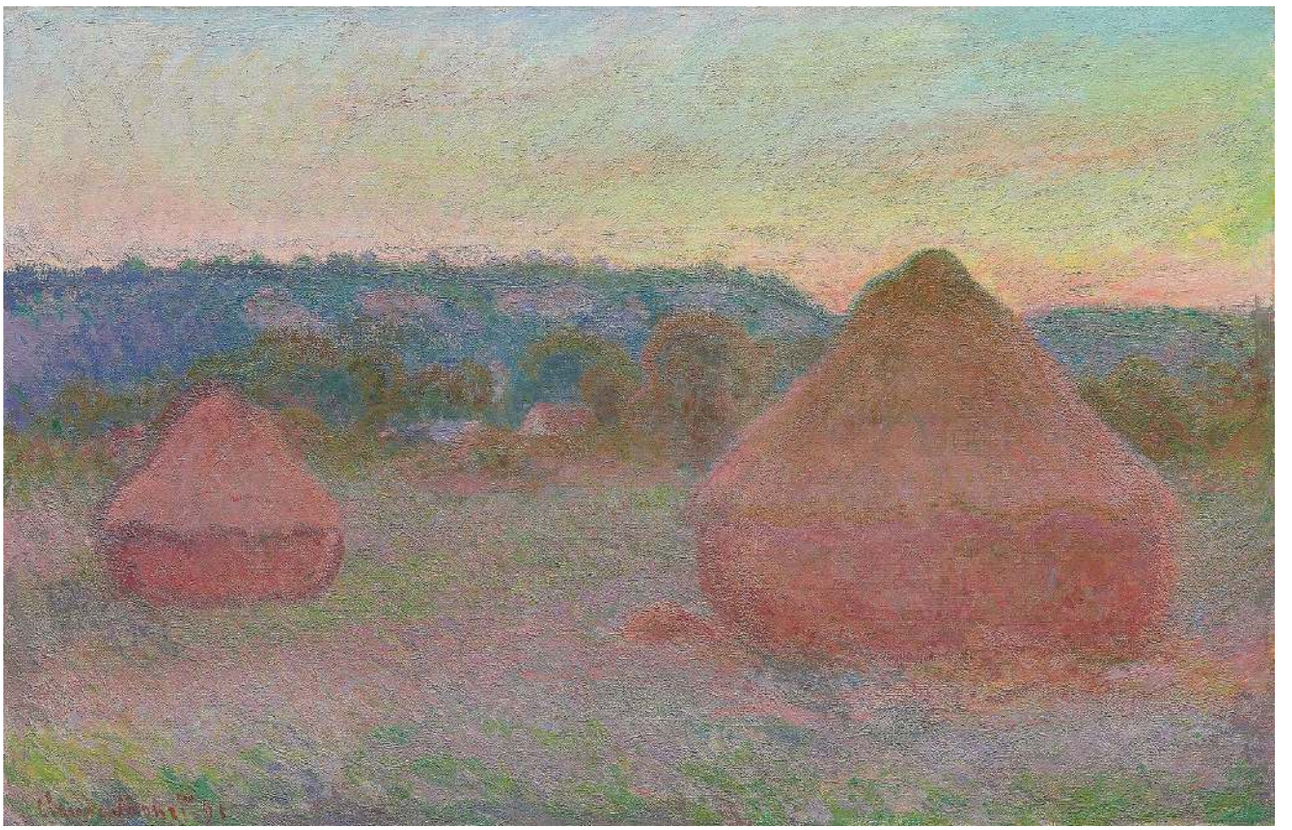
One field, twice

In 1890 and 1891 Monet painted the wheat stacks in a field a few minutes from his house at Giverny, returning to the same shapes at different hours and in different weather. Six of those canvases are in the Art Institute of Chicago. That makes it possible to compare not two subjects but one subject twice, with everything except the season held still: same field, same stacks, same painter, same distance, same box of colours.

We measured four regions in each canvas: a strip of sky across the top, the band of trees at the horizon, the foreground field, and the body of the large stack. The measure is simple, the red channel minus the blue channel, which is a serviceable proxy for whether a passage leans warm or cool. Positive means warm.

Sky: minus 3.9 in late summer, plus 1.6 in autumn. Almost no movement.
Treeline: plus 22.4, then plus 10.7. The distance gets *cooler*, not warmer.
Foreground field: plus 1.0, then plus 18.2. A swing of seventeen points.
The large stack: plus 36.9, then plus 47.6.

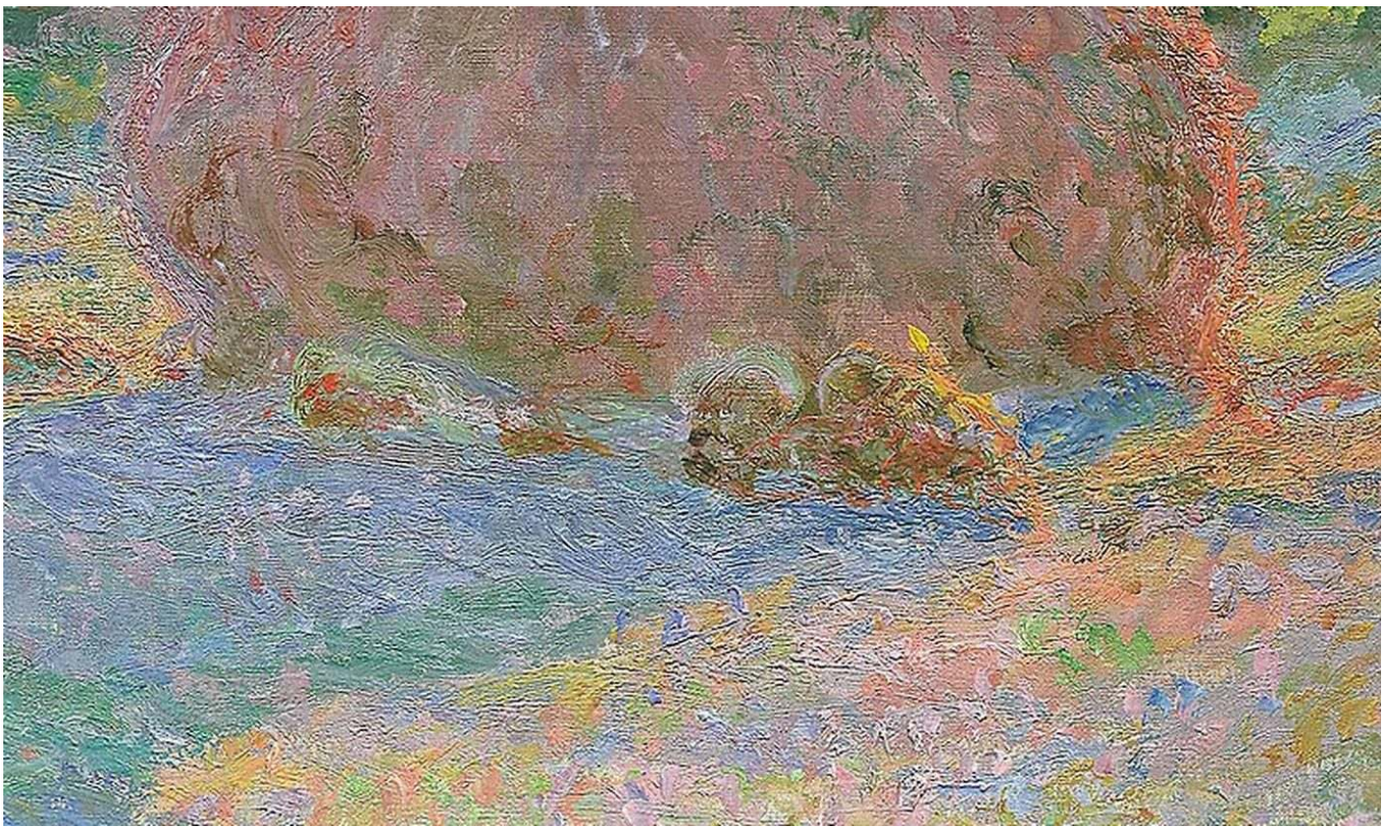
The sky is not the variable. The field is. Between the two canvases the ground moves from neutral to distinctly warm while the sky stays where it was, and the horizon actually goes bluer as thicker air pushes the far trees back. Whatever the season is doing, it is doing it at ground level.



Claude Monet. Stacks of Wheat (End of Day, Autumn), 1890 to 1891. Oil on canvas, 65.8 by 101 cm. Art Institute of Chicago, Mr. and Mrs. Lewis Larned Coburn Memorial Collection.

The same square metre, close up

Crop the identical patch out of both canvases, the foot of the large stack and the field running away from it, and enlarge it. This is where the argument stops being a table of numbers.



End of Summer, detail. The stubble is built from blue, violet and turquoise strokes with pink and yellow-green flecks laid between them.

In the summer detail the field is blue. Not blue-ish: in the lower strip of this crop, 26.5 per cent of the surface sits in the blue and violet band and only 13.5 per cent in the rose and red. The stubble is drawn in short chopped strokes running in three or four directions, each one a separate decision, with the canvas breathing between them. The stack sits on that cool ground as a warm object, and the contrast between them is the subject.

End of Day, Autumn, detail of the same passage. Blue has fallen to 0.6 per cent of the strip; rose and red have risen to 37.2.

In the autumn detail the blue is gone. Six tenths of one per cent of that same strip is still blue or violet, against 37.2 per cent rose and red. The handling has changed with it: the strokes are longer, dragged more horizontally, and the paint has become a continuous crust rather than a mesh of separate marks. The stack and the field are now the same temperature, plus 47.6 against plus 18.6, and the picture has lost the contrast that organised the summer version. It has to be organised by something else, and Monet organises it by value, the dark mass of the stack against a pale field, and by the one surviving cold note along the treeline.

Why the warmth moves

The mechanism is not mysterious once the numbers point at the ground. Any shadow is lit by whatever the sky and the surroundings bounce into it. In high summer, with a high sun and a large area of clear sky, the dominant fill light is skylight, which is blue, and shadows go blue. That is the physical basis of the whole Impressionist habit of painting violet shadows on a green field. It is not a stylistic tic; it is a measurement.

By late October two things have changed. The sky is more often a diffuser than a source, an even grey ceiling with no strong directional beam and no strong blue. And the ground under everything has turned into an enormous warm reflector: dry stubble, fallen leaves, bare soil, all of it ochre. The secondary light in the landscape stops being blue and becomes orange. The shadow, which is nothing but secondary light, warms up accordingly.

Measured across the whole set, this reversal is the most consistent thing we found. In Boudin's summer sky study the darkest fifth of the picture is 24.8 points *cooler* than neutral and the lightest fifth is 11.4 points warmer: a gap of 36 points in the textbook direction. In Lhermitte's October river the relationship is inverted, the shadows warmer than the lights by 45 points. Levitan's Golden Autumn: inverted by 20. Monet's own two canvases move from a gap of 0.4 to a gap of 7.6 in the same direction.

Summer keeps its warmth in the light and its coolness in the shadow. Autumn does the opposite. The season is not a change of colour, it is a change of where the colour lives.

Against the word muted

Autumn is habitually called muted, and the paintings disagree. Mean saturation in Monet's late summer canvas is 0.169; in the autumn canvas it is 0.204. At the ninetieth percentile, that is, in the most intense tenth of the surface, the figures are 0.312 and 0.372. The autumn picture is the more saturated of the two by roughly a fifth.

What actually narrows is the hue range, not the intensity. The palette closes toward a smaller arc of the colour wheel and then works harder inside it. Jean-Charles Cazin's October Day is the limit case: measured across its whole surface it contains no green at all, 54 per cent yellow and ochre, 46 per cent orange and red, and a warm bias of 61 points, five times Monet's late summer. It is not a quiet picture. It is a loud picture made of three colours.

Jean-Charles Cazin. October Day, 1890 to 1893. Oil on canvas, 38.4 by 46.7 cm. Art Institute of Chicago, Henry Field Memorial Collection. No green anywhere on the surface.

Which colours survive the closing is worth noticing. Ochre, raw and burnt sienna, umber, red earth. These are the oldest pigments in use anywhere, ground out of the ground, in the caves tens of thousands of years before anyone had a blue that did not cost more than the panel it went on. Autumn returns painting to its first palette, and paints the season in the colours of the material it is depicting.

Where the yellow comes from, and why the red behaves differently

A green leaf is not green because green has been added. It is green because chlorophyll is dominant, and the carotenoids and xanthophylls that give the yellows and yellow-oranges have been sitting inside the leaf all summer, masked. When the tree begins withdrawing nutrients and chlorophyll production stops, the mask lifts and the yellow is revealed. It arrives by subtraction.

The reds are a different event. In many species anthocyanins are manufactured in autumn, made new in the leaf as sugars are trapped there by the closing of the vascular channels. So the two halves of the autumn palette come from opposite processes, one an unmasking and one a production, and this shows up in how they distribute. The yellows spread evenly through a whole mass of foliage, because they were already everywhere.

The reds appear in patches: on particular trees, on the sunlit side, in the crown before the base. A painter who spreads red evenly through a wood has painted something that does not happen.

Jean-Francois Millet. Haystacks: Autumn, about 1874. Oil on canvas. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, Open Access. Measured here: the sky reads 105, 109, 97 and the ground 131, 104, 61. The field is brighter than the sky above it.

Millet's picture contains the other autumn inversion, the one that follows from the first. Under a diffusing overcast, a field of cut stubble becomes the brightest surface in view and the sky above it goes dull. In a summer landscape this is close to impossible, because the sky is the source. Here the source has been spread out and the ground is doing the reflecting, so the picture is effectively lit from below. It also solves an old compositional problem: the figure no longer has to compete with a brilliant sky and can be drawn as a dark shape on a bright ground.

Pastel, and why this season belongs to it

If one medium owns the three weeks of the turn, it is pastel, and the reason is optical rather than sentimental. Oil paint is pigment suspended in a film: light enters the film, is partly absorbed inside it, and comes back out having been changed on the way. That is what gives oil its depth and its capacity to be glazed. Pastel is pigment with almost no binder, a little gum, pressed into a stick and then abraded onto a toothed surface. It sits there as loose grains with air between them. Light does not travel through a medium; it scatters off the surfaces of dry particles and returns immediately, in all directions, with almost no specular component.

That is, in the exact optical sense, the same behaviour as an overcast autumn sky, which is a diffuser rather than a source. Pastel does not imitate the light of the season. It reproduces its physics.

Three pastels make the case better than any argument, because the medium is held constant and only the season moves. All three are drawn on toned paper, which is the second half of the story.

Eugene Boudin. Seascape with Open Sky, 1860. Pastel on grey wove paper mounted on board. Cleveland Museum of Art, CC0.
Measured: the darkest fifth of this sheet is 24.8 points cooler than neutral, the widest cool-shadow gap in our entire set.

Boudin is the summer state of affairs in its purest form. He made hundreds of these sky studies on the Normandy coast, dated and timed on the sheet like meteorological records, and Corot called him the king of skies for it. What the measurement finds is exactly the summer signature: brilliant lights, and shadows filled with blue from an enormous open sky. The grey of the paper is doing the work of the middle tone, and the white chalk is spent only on the cloud tops.

John Henry Twachtman. Pastures, Branchville, Connecticut, about 1888 to 1891. Pastel on composition board. Cleveland Museum of Art, CC0.

Twachtman shows the second thing pastel can do that oil cannot. Almost nothing here is drawn. The tan of the support *is* the dry grass, the light and the season all at once, and the pastel is spent only on what departs from it: the dark trees at the left, the blue-violet shadows raking across the middle distance, a few strokes of white cloud, some surviving green. The artist chose the colour of the light before making a single mark, and then made as few marks as possible. In oil that ground would have vanished under the picture.

Leon Augustin Lhermitte. Quai au Sable, Chartèves, 1904. Pastel on grey wove paper. Cleveland Museum of Art, CC0. Shadows 52 points warm, lights 6.6: the reversal at its most extreme in our set.

And Lhermitte is the autumn state, in the same medium, on the same kind of toned sheet. Yellow poplars, a bank of ochre mud, a cold river holding the last blue in the picture, and shadows that are the warmest passages on the sheet by a distance of 45 points. Put the Boudin and the Lhermitte side by side and the entire argument of this piece is visible in two objects made of the same dust.

There is one more consequence of the medium worth stating, because it explains why pastel suits a transition specifically. A pastel cannot be repaired the way an oil can. There is no glaze, no scumble over a dried layer, no lifting with turpentine, no painting out. A passage from one colour to the next has to be built by laying dust over dust and by stumping, that is, by rubbing the pigment into the tooth of the paper with a rolled paper stub until one hue hands over to the next. The transition is made by abrasion. For a subject whose whole character is a gradual handover between two palettes, the method and the motif are the same gesture.

The sheets have had their own autumn

Read the catalogue descriptions of nineteenth-century pastels to the end and something quietly remarkable appears. The Art Institute records Alfred Sisley's A Corner of Moret-sur-Loing, 1895, as pastel with stumping on grey wove paper with blue fibers,

discoloured to tan. Mary Cassatt's Sleepy Nicolle, about 1900: blue-grey wove paper, faded to tan. Odilon Redon's Flower Clouds, about 1903: blue-grey wove paper with multicoloured fibres, altered to tan.

The cool half of each of those pictures, the part the artist chose precisely because it would carry the coldness of the light, is the part that has gone. Paper yellows: lignin oxidises, sizing degrades, and blue dyes are among the least lightfast materials in the room. So these works have themselves travelled from summer to autumn, in the same direction as their subject, over a century, in storage.

This is not a footnote for conservators. It changes the reading. A Sisley pastel that today looks like a warm October afternoon may have been drawn as a cold one, its greys held up by a blue support that no longer exists. Anyone measuring a faded pastel is measuring two events at once: the light the artist saw, and the hundred and twenty years since.

Autumn begins on the seventh of August

Everything above assumes that a season is a lighting condition, something you detect by looking at the sky and the ground. One tradition organises it the other way round, and holding the two side by side is the fastest way to see that the European nineteenth century made a choice rather than a discovery.

In the Japanese calendar inherited from China, the year is divided into twenty-four solar terms, and the one called risshu, the beginning of autumn, falls around the seventh or eighth of August. Not the equinox, not the first cold night: the seventh of August, when the heat in Kyoto is at its worst. Autumn is declared. From that date onward a poem that mentions cicadas, dew, geese or the moon is an autumn poem, whatever the thermometer says, and a painter who signs a screen of grasses in September is working inside a season that officially began five weeks earlier.

The terms are then subdivided again, into seventy-two ko of roughly five days each, every one named after a single natural event. The Japanese set was revised into its familiar form by the court astronomer Shibukawa Shunkai in the seventeenth century. The three that make up risshu are, in order: cool winds arrive, evening cicadas sing, thick fog descends. A month later, under white dew, comes the unit called dew glistens white on the grass.

This deserves attention from anyone who has just read four thousand words of measurements. It is the same instinct, an attempt to resolve the turn at the finest grain available, but the instrument is a name rather than a number, and the resolution is five days rather than a hue percentage. The tradition that supposedly does not measure the season has divided it into units so short that most European calendars have no word for them at all.

The season is a plant, not a light

If autumn is a date rather than a condition, then a picture cannot announce it by the angle of the sun, and it does not try to. It announces it with a plant. The Man'yoshu, the eighth-century anthology, fixes the seven grasses of autumn in a pair of poems by

Yamanoue no Okura: bush clover, miscanthus, kudzu, pink, patrinia, boneset, bellflower. For the next twelve hundred years those seven, and above all the miscanthus called susuki, carry the season in poetry, on lacquer, on ceramics and across screens.

This screen is three and a half metres of one plant. There is no ground line, no horizon, no sky, no cast shadow, no hour of the day. Measured, the green pigment covers 2.4 per cent of the surface: the remaining ninety-seven and a half per cent is the prepared paper, doing exactly what Twachtman's tan board does in Connecticut three hundred and sixty years later, except that here it is a settled convention rather than a discovery, and the empty ground has a name and a theory behind it.

Put the two next to each other and the rhyme is almost embarrassing. A Muromachi painter and an American Impressionist arrive at the same solution, that the support should carry the season and the pigment should only mark what departs from it. One got there through a tradition of negative space and the economics of gold leaf, the other by picking up a pastel stick and noticing what happened when he stopped filling the sheet.

The moon rises out of the grass

The other half of the Japanese autumn is not the sun at all. It is the moon. The full moon of the eighth lunar month is the autumn moon, viewed at parties held for the purpose, and the plain called Musashino, west of Edo, is the place-name attached to it: a plain so flat and so thick with susuki that in the poetic formula the moon has nowhere to rise from except the grass itself.

The screen does what the formula says. A silver moon sits low in a field of miscanthus, and there is no horizon behind it, because the ground it would rise from has been replaced by gold leaf. Measured, the gold band reads plus 99.7 on the same warm-cool scale that gave Cazin's extreme European autumn plus 61. Nothing painted from observation in this article comes close to it.

More telling is the direction of travel inside the picture. The gold at the top is plus 99.7, the grass band across the middle is plus 73.3, and the foreground is plus 25.6. The screen gets *cooler* as it comes forward, which is the exact inverse of Monet's autumn field, where the ground was the warm end and the sky stayed neutral. In Giverny the warmth had moved down into the stubble because that is what October does to a field. Here the warmth is at the top because the top is metal, and metal is warm regardless of the month.

Two cautions on that number. Gold is a specular surface, so a photograph of it records one particular raking light in one gallery, and the figure describes a warm metallic ground rather than a colorimetric fact. And the silver of the moon has tarnished over four centuries, which is why it now reads as a dark grey disc rather than a bright one. As with the faded pastel papers, the object has aged in a direction that changes the reading: the picture was made with a bright moon and now has a dull one.

Light you can wipe onto a block

In the woodblock print the question of where the light comes from has an unusually literal answer. It comes from the printer's cloth. The graded washes in Hiroshige's skies are bokashi: ink is wiped onto the block by hand in a gradient before each impression, so no two sheets in an edition are identical and the entire atmosphere of a print is a manual gesture performed hundreds of times.

Sampled in strips down the sky, the ramp is unmistakably manufactured rather than observed. It runs from a saturated blue at the top, hue 214 with saturation 0.30, through hue 171 at saturation 0.12, to a near-neutral pale at hue 59 and saturation 0.07 by the horizon: one pigment, one wipe, saturation falling smoothly and value rising smoothly. Monet's sky over the stacks does not behave like that. It changes hue as it crosses the canvas, because it was matched to something being looked at.

And the way this sheet says autumn is worth listing, because not one item on the list is a lighting effect. There is a moon, cropped by the eaves so that you register it as a fact rather than a spectacle. There is a line of geese, the standard autumn arrival. There is a room after the party: dishes pushed aside, a lantern, a shadow on the paper screen, the guests gone. The season is a date in the calendar, a bird, a plant and a social occasion, recorded in a print whose light was applied with a rag.

Tosa Mitsuoki's maples close the argument. Measured across the whole surface the screen is 83.5 per cent yellow and ochre, the highest concentration of warm colour anywhere in this set, higher than Cazin, higher than Millet, and yet there is no sun angle in it, no aerial perspective, no cast shadow, nothing that could be called an observation of light. What there is instead is a species, and slips of poetry paper tied to the branches by people who came out to look at the leaves and wrote something down. Momijigari, leaf-hunting, is an outing with a literature attached.

Even the colour vocabulary is codified rather than observed. Traditional Japanese colour names include kuchiba-iro, decayed-leaf colour, a specific brown-yellow with a fixed dye recipe and a fixed place in the wardrobe calendar. A European painter mixes a colour that matches what a leaf is doing this week. A court painter reaches for the colour the season is agreed to have.

Neither system is more accurate. They answer different questions. The European tradition asks what the light is doing right now and builds an instrument, the canvas, sensitive enough to record it. The Japanese tradition asks what season it is according to the calendar and the poems, and then names the plant, the bird and the colour that belong to that answer. The first produces twenty-five wheat stacks in one field. The second produces three and a half metres of a single grass, and a moon with no horizon to rise from.

Where the road ends

The last of the Chicago stacks answers the question the first two open. Measure the snow canvas and the warm bias goes negative, minus 4.3, the only picture in this set whose average is cooler than neutral. Blue and violet take a quarter of the surface. Green is gone to a tenth of one per cent. The orange and red band survives at 15.5 per cent, and almost all of it is inside the stack itself.

That is the end of the sequence. The warmth withdraws from the field and concentrates in the one built thing standing in it, and the ground hands the light back to the sky. Autumn is the interval in which that handover is visible, which is why it repays a series rather than a single canvas, and why Monet needed twenty-five of them.

Four questions to take outside

Which is brighter, the sky or the ground. Where is the warmth, in the light or in the shadow. How many planes of distance survive, three or two. And is the yellow spread through the mass while the red arrives in patches, which tells you how far the process has gone. The first two will date a landscape painting to within about six weeks, and they work equally well on the street outside.

Method and sources

Colour figures were computed from open-access reproductions, sampled at reduced resolution, with red-minus-blue used as a warm-cool proxy and pixels grouped into hue families reported as a share of surface. Regional figures come from fixed rectangles in each image, described in the text. These are measurements of photographs, not of paint: museum photography is colour-managed but interpretive, and century-old varnish shifts everything slightly warm. They are meant for comparison between images in the same set. Works from the Art Institute of Chicago, the Cleveland Museum of Art and the Metropolitan Museum of Art appear under their open-access programmes; Levitan's Golden Autumn is in the public domain. Medium and support descriptions, including the records of discoloration, are quoted from the holding institutions' own catalogue entries. ■

EXHIBITION SEP 28, 2026

In Praise of Shadow: Colour and Light in Clair-obscur at the Bourse de Commerce

For six months the most luminous building in Paris agreed to go dark. A work-by-work reading of Clair-obscur at the Bourse de Commerce, and what Polke, Victor Man, Frank Bowling, Carol Rama and Laura Lamiel teach about colour in an age of too much light.

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> The contemporary is the one who keeps his gaze fixed on his own time, to perceive not its light but its darkness. – Giorgio Agamben, What Is the Contemporary?

For six months this year, the most luminous building in Paris agreed to go dark. From 4 March to 24 August 2026 the Bourse de Commerce, where Tadao Ando set a concrete cylinder inside the old grain exchange beneath its painted dome, gave itself over to *Clair-obscur*: around a hundred works from the Pinault Collection by some twenty-seven modern and contemporary artists, arranged, in the words of its curator Emma Lavigne, as a landscape at once luminous and crepuscular. The exhibition has now closed. It deserves a second look, because it asked a question our screens have taught us to forget: what does colour mean when it is not simply bright?

We live inside an excess of light. Phones glow at the brightness of noon; advertising has made saturation the default voice of the visible world; the colours of our century arrive already lit from behind. *Clair-obscur* proposed the opposite discipline, the one Italian painters called *chiaroscuro*: colour that is measured, withheld, allowed to emerge from shadow rather than shouted into it. What follows is a reading of the exhibition work by work, as a lesson in how the art of our own time handles colour, light and their absence.

I The inheritance: a ray of light, a wall of black

The title looks back four centuries. When Caravaggio painted *The Calling of Saint Matthew* for San Luigi dei Francesi in Rome, he did not light the whole scene; he cut it with a single diagonal beam. The tax collectors sit in a tavern gloom, and the colour of their sleeves, their hats and their faces exists only where that beam falls. Colour, in chiaroscuro, is not a property of objects. It is an event, something that happens to an object when light reaches it.

Caravaggio, The Calling of Saint Matthew, 1599–1600, oil on canvas. Contarelli Chapel, San Luigi dei Francesi, Rome. Photo: Gleb Simonov, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

The second ancestor is Goya. Between 1820 and 1823, in his house outside Madrid, the Quinta del Sordo, the old painter covered the walls with what we now call the *Pinturas negras*, the Black Paintings. The press notes of the exhibition describe their palette precisely: blacks tempered with ochre and earth tones. It is a palette of almost nothing, and it produced some of the most frightening images in European art. Here colour is not taken away to make light dramatic, as in Caravaggio; it is taken away because the world it describes has lost its daylight.

Francisco de Goya, Saturn Devouring His Son, 1820–1823, one of the Black Paintings from the Quinta del Sordo, transferred to canvas. Museo del Prado, Madrid. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons

Philippe Parreno took Goya literally. His film *La Quinta del Sordo* (2021), shown in the Studio of the Bourse, reconstructs the room where the Black Paintings were made and lets a single beam of light travel across it in the dark. At moments the light only grazes the surface, so that the paint becomes dust and relief rather than image; at others it breaks through to reveal the haggard faces on the walls. Nothing is shown whole. In thirty-nine minutes of darkness Parreno teaches the first rule of the exhibition: **a colour we are allowed to see only partly is a colour we look at twice**.

Philippe Parreno, La Quinta del Sordo, 2021, 4K film (colour, multi-channel soundtrack), 39 min. Pinault Collection. Image: Pinault Collection, Clair-obscur press kit (2026)

II

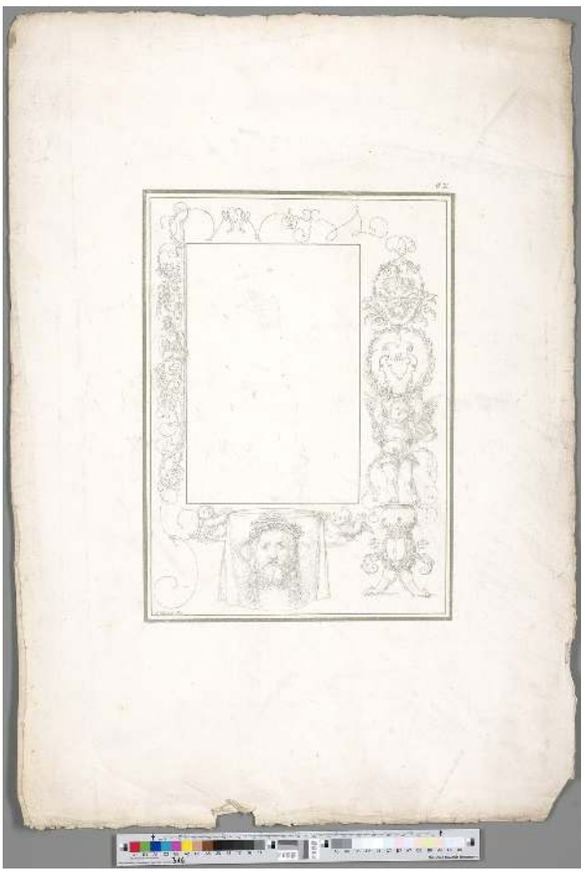
Sigmar Polke: colour held in suspension

If one work justified the exhibition, it was Sigmar Polke's *Axial Age* (2005–2007), nine panels painted for the 52nd Venice Biennale and shown in Gallery 2. Its title comes from Karl Jaspers, who called the centuries of Confucius, the Buddha, Homer and Plato the axial age of human thought. Its technique is its argument. Polke did not lay colour on the canvas; he suspended dry pigment in artificial resin on fabric, so that the support becomes a translucent screen and light passes through the picture as well as falling on it.

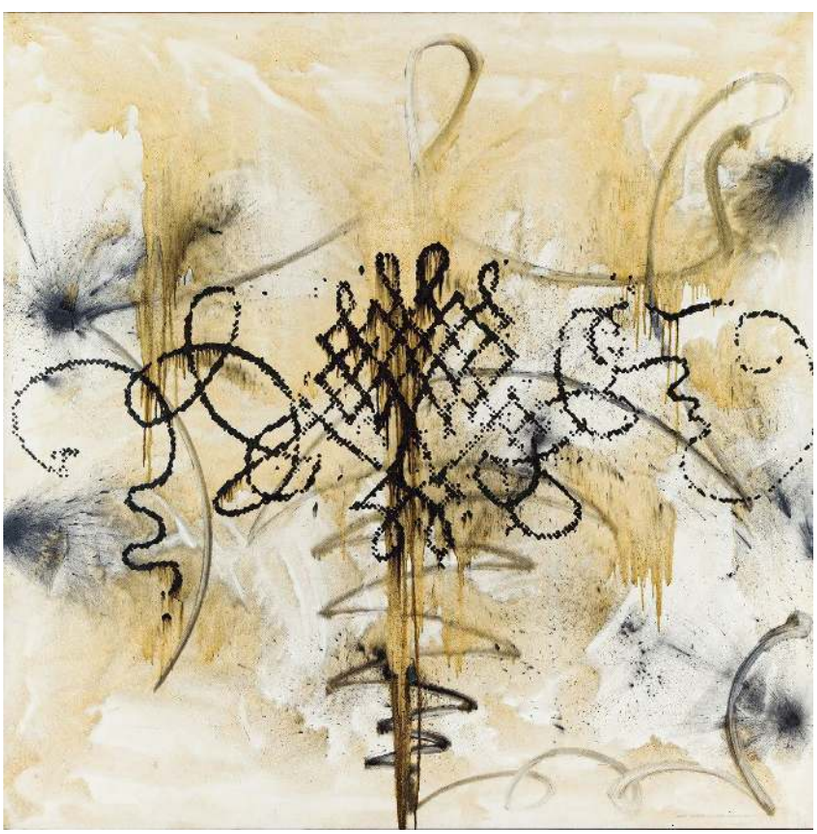
The result is colour that seems to be forming rather than finished: pools of amber and violet, smoky blues, areas where the resin clouds like breath on glass and areas where it clears into something close to a window. The curators describe the cycle as a vast liquid mirror from which ghosts of the past emerge. Standing before it, one understands why Polke, a lifelong alchemist of materials, spoke of painting as a chemical as much as an optical art. The lesson for anyone who works with colour is exact: **transparency is a colour too**, and the most living hues are the ones we see through.

Sigmar Polke, Axial Age (detail), 2005–2007, nine panels, artificial resin and dry pigment on fabric. Pinault Collection. © The Estate of Sigmar Polke, Cologne / ADAGP, Paris, 2026. Image: Pinault Collection, Clair-obscur press kit (2026)

In the Salon, two earlier Polkes carried the same idea into dialogue: *Stairwell* (1968) and *Loop – The Prayer Book of Maximilian* (1986). The second is a homage to the pen flourishes Albrecht Dürer drew in the margins of the prayer book printed for the Emperor Maximilian I in 1513. Polke enlarged those loops onto a canvas two and a half metres square and set them in semi-transparent varnish, where darker areas read, in the words of the critic Bice Curiger, like traces of gunpowder. Dürer's marginalia were already a lesson in shading done with a single line. Polke turned them into weather.



After Albrecht Dürer, marginal drawing from the Prayer Book of the Emperor Maximilian I (1513), lithograph by Johann Nepomuk Strixner, 1808. CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

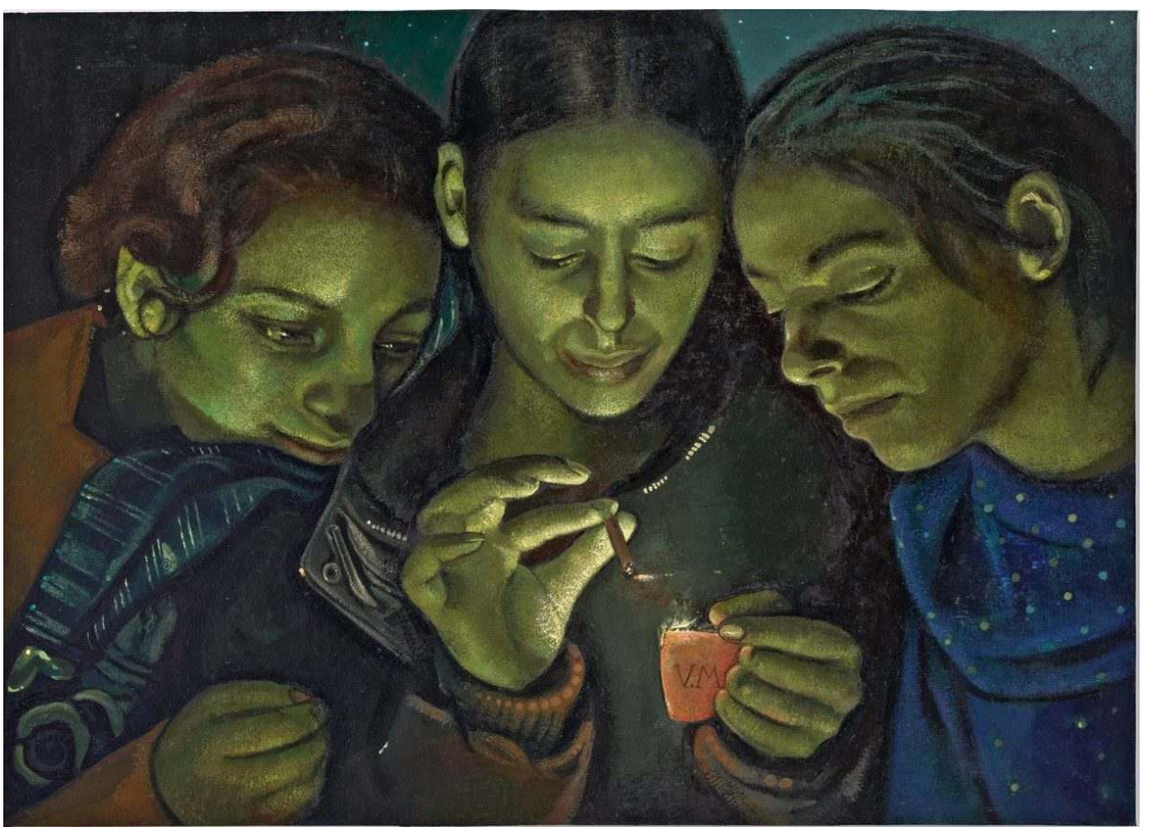


Sigmar Polke, Loop – The Prayer Book of Maximilian, 1986, resin, graphite, pigment and emulsion on canvas, 250.2 × 250.2 cm. Pinault Collection. © The Estate of Sigmar Polke, Cologne / ADAGP, Paris, 2026. Image: Pinault Collection, Clair-obscur press kit (2026)

III

Victor Man: the palette of distance

Gallery 3 belonged to one painter, the Romanian Victor Man (born 1974), in a room curated by Jean-Marie Gallais, who calls him the contemporary painter of chiaroscuro. Man's pictures are small, often painted on cardboard, and nearly monochrome: olive darks, bruised greens, a flesh that seems lit by a single candle in a far room. *Titiriteros* (2023), oil on cardboard, 60 by 84 centimetres, takes its Spanish title from the puppet masters who pull the strings; *Maternity with Legend* (2024) sets a penitent saint crawling on all fours in its foreground.



Victor Man, Titiriteros, 2023, oil on cardboard, 60 × 84 cm. Pinault Collection. © Victor Man © ADAGP, Paris, 2026. Photo: def image. Image: Pinault Collection, Clair-obscur press kit (2026)

His method is instructive precisely because it is so restrained. Man takes an image, often from the history of painting, and passes it through what Gallais calls two filters: art history, and his own dusky palette, which places the subject at a distance. He has reworked El Greco's *Fábula*, the enigmatic scene of a boy blowing on an ember between a monkey and a fool; and he makes darkened copies of Italian Trecento scenes of the Passion, by Sassetta, Lorenzetti and Giovanni di Pietro, deliberately *desaturating* them into a group of black paintings. The gold grounds and lapis blues of the fourteenth century go out, and what remains is the violence they once decorated.

El Greco, An Allegory (Fábula), c. 1580–1585, oil on canvas. National Galleries of Scotland, Edinburgh. Public domain, via Wikimedia Commons. One of the images Victor Man has repainted in his own darkened palette.

It would be easy to call such painting gloomy. It is better described as a refusal of seduction. Man uses colour the way a careful writer uses adjectives: rarely, and only where a sentence would collapse without one. His pictures pull the eye first to the texture of the surface and only then to the subject, so that we meet the image, as Gallais writes, without illusion.

IV Colour as climate: Bowling, Tillmans and a room of fog

If Man withholds colour, Frank Bowling floods it. Gallery 6 was called *Fog*, and there the curators set what they describe as a vaporous map painted by Bowling, born in Guyana in 1934. The Pinault Collection's own Bowling is *Texas Louise* (1971), acrylic on canvas nearly seven metres wide, one of the Map Paintings he made in New York between 1966 and 1971: a field of incandescent pink-red through which the outlines of the American continents, sprayed through stencils, rise and dissolve like coasts seen at dusk. The collection's own description is exact: one geography concealing another.

Here colour is not the light on a thing; it is the air itself. Bowling's pinks and oranges have no source and cast no shadow. They behave like a climate, and the continents float in them the way memory floats in feeling. The exhibition read the painting as an Afro-diasporic counter-map, where fog erases the borders of territories and recalls ocean crossings marked by the violence of uprooting. Chiaroscuro survives here in a new form: not light against dark, but clarity against haze.

Beside it hung Wolfgang Tillmans's *Day/Night II b* (2010), from the vertical landscapes he began photographing in 1995 to record the variations of colour and light in the sky, and nearby works by Trisha Donnelly and Bruce Conner, whose film of the 1946 nuclear test at Bikini turns a catastrophe into slow, pale billows of spray. And as summer came, the Rotunda itself filled with fog: the Japanese artist Fujiko Nakaya, who has been sculpting water vapour since the 1970s, let a cloud gather and dissolve beneath Ando's concrete ring and the painted dome. In the brightest room in Paris the colours went out altogether, and came back one by one as the cloud thinned. Before the fog, the same circular stage had held Pierre Huyghe's *Camata* (2024), a film of a metaphysical ritual shot in the Atacama desert and edited in real time by self-learning algorithms: night turning to day, shadow to light, earth to sky.

V

Colour as matter, colour as fire

Gallery 5, *Incandescence*, turned from atmosphere to substance. Carol Rama, who worked for decades in her apartment in Turin, was represented by three of her *Bricolages*. The one reproduced in the press kit, *Untitled* (1967), is made of tempera, bronze dust, pigmented plaster, glue, glass pearls and dolls' eyes on Masonite: a crust of coagulated paint in which marks of blue and red surround the staring eyes. Colour here is not described; it is stuck on, crusted, found. It has weight, and it looks back.

Beside her, the Swiss Louis Soutter, confined to a home for the elderly poor as the Second World War began, drew his hallucinatory rites with his fingers in ink and gouache; the collection's *Dusk of the Gangster* (1937–1942) belongs to that late, dark period. And filling the main space, Bill Viola's *Fire Woman* (2005), made for his Tristan Project at the Opéra Bastille, showed a dark silhouette advancing before a wall of flame and dissolving at last into waves of glowing red: chiaroscuro reversed, the figure dark and the light consuming it.

Gold had its own chapel. James Lee Byars, for whom gold was the colour of the sublime and the immortal, was present with *The Golden Tower* (1974), a cylinder of gold leaf, a sphere of 3,333 red roses, and *Byars Is Elephant* (1997), camel-hair rope and golden fabric conceived in Cairo shortly before his death. Next to Polke's resins, Byars's gold was a reminder that the oldest colour of the sacred is also the one that most depends on darkness: gold is only gold where there is shadow for it to shine against.

VI

Light used as a brush

The subtlest room was not a room at all. In the twenty-four vitrines of the Passage, the ring corridor that survives from the old grain exchange, and in the Machine Room below, Laura Lamiel (born 1943) built a sequence of installations curated by Alexandra Bordes under a line from Beckett: *They make a sound like wings, like leaves, like sand*. Children's shoes, gloves, compressed fabric, enamelled bricks, bird bones, the gilded edges of stacked missals; and fluorescent tubes that reveal some objects and leave others in shadow. Lamiel says she uses light in a vital way, as though she were working with brushes.

That phrase could serve as the motto of the whole exhibition. In Lamiel's cases, as in Parreno's film and Polke's resin, colour is not a coat applied to a surface. It is a relation between light, material and time: black paint beside immaculate white cotton, a sliver of gilt catching a tube of cold light. The work asks the viewer to slow down until the eye can tell a white from a white.

VII What the exhibition got wrong, and why it still mattered

Clair-obscur was not a flawless show. Writing for Slash, the critic Guillaume Benoit praised its philosophical ambition around the question of the gaze, and singled out the pure sobriety of Polke's *Axial Age*, but found the construction haphazard: themes stretched thin, artists spotlit without a real monographic commitment, some works reduced to accessories. We share part of that verdict. The organisation by keyword, *Germination*, *Incandescence*, *Fog*, *Shadows*, sometimes set works side by side because they rhymed rather than because they spoke to one another, and the post-war sculpture of Giacometti, Richier, Dubuffet and Maria Martins in Gallery 7 deserved a room with its own argument.

And yet the exhibition did something few institutions dare: it made a whole building quieter than its visitors' phones. In doing so it showed four ways in which the art of our time thinks about colour, and they are worth carrying out of the museum.

Colour withheld. Victor Man and Parreno show that the absence of colour is itself a palette, and that a desaturated image keeps its distance and so keeps its mystery. **Colour in suspension.** Polke's resins show that transparency and depth are properties of colour, not of drawing. **Colour as climate.** Bowling, Tillmans and Nakaya make colour into air and weather, a field we stand inside rather than an object we look at. **Colour as matter and as light.** Carol Rama crusts it, Byars gilds it, Lamiel paints with the light itself.

> Colour is not what we add to the world. It is what the light allows us to find in it.

Caravaggio's beam and Goya's black walls were not lessons in darkness for its own sake. They were lessons in attention: in how a single lit sleeve can carry the whole meaning of a picture. Four hundred years later, in a building made to shine, twenty-seven artists made the same case. In an age that lights everything at once, the most radical colour may be the one that waits for us in the shadow. ■

Clair-obscur was shown at the Bourse de Commerce – Pinault Collection, 2 rue de Viarmes, Paris, from 4 March to 24 August 2026. General curator: Emma Lavigne, with Nicolas-Xavier Ferrand; Victor Man room curated by Jean-Marie Gallais; Laura Lamiel by Alexandra Bordes (her installation remained on view in the Passage until 21 September 2026). Images of the works in the exhibition come from the Pinault Collection's press kit for Clair-obscur and are reproduced for review with the credits it gives; the works remain the property of their artists and estates. The historical images are in the public domain or under open licences, credited in their captions. Frank Bowling's map painting is not illustrated here: the press kit carries no image of it.

FURTHER

The exhibition at the Bourse de Commerce	pinaultcollection.com/en/boursedecommerce/clair-obscur
Guillaume Benoit's review for Slash (in French)	slash-paris.com/critiques/clair-obscur-bourse-de-commerce-paris

CRITICAL ESSAY SEP 7, 2026

The Seam That Isn't There: Anish Kapoor's Cloud Gate

Anish Kapoor's Cloud Gate has no front, no seam and, its maker insists, no fixed subject beyond the skyline and the crowd currently caught in its surface. On the engineering problem that took two extra years and $23 million to solve, the omphalos underneath that turns the trick on the viewer, and why the solution still works two decades on.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · CRITICAL ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Anish Kapoor's Cloud Gate has no front, no seam and, its maker insists, no fixed subject beyond the skyline and the crowd currently caught in its surface. On the engineering problem that took two extra years and $23 million to solve, the omphalos underneath that turns the trick on the viewer, and why the solution still works two decades on.

Cloud Gate has no front. Walk Millennium Park from any direction and the sculpture that Chicago calls the Bean turns to meet you: a continuous, gateless loop of polished steel, 20 metres long and 13 metres wide, sitting on the Michigan Avenue lawn like a drop of mercury caught mid-fall before it can spread. The city's public art program asked, in 1999, for a landmark for a new plaza on top of a rail yard. What it received, after a jury reviewed an international shortlist and Anish Kapoor's design was chosen over more conventional proposals, was his first permanent outdoor work built in the United States, and a piece of sculpture whose entire content is the city looking at itself, bent.

A surface with no seam to hide behind

The engineering problem was the whole project. Kapoor's design called for a mirror-polished skin with no visible joints anywhere on its surface, which meant 168 stainless steel plates had to be welded edge to edge and then ground and buffed by hand until the welds disappeared entirely. There is no trim, no gasket, no seam moulding to break the reflection and remind a viewer that the object in front of them was assembled rather than poured. Underneath that skin sits an independent steel frame engineered to breathe with Chicago's weather: the whole structure grows and shrinks by several centimetres between a July heat wave and a January cold snap, and the polished plates have to move with it without ever telegraphing a crease to the surface. Reaching that standard took two years longer than scheduled. Millennium Park opened in 2004; Cloud Gate, still hidden behind construction fencing, opened to the public in 2006, and the roughly $23 million the sculpture and its plaza eventually cost ran well past the original estimate, almost entirely on account of the polishing.

That decision is the piece's real subject. A seamed surface reads as construction: an object built by people, in time, out of parts. A seamless one reads as a phenomenon, less a sculpture of something than a hole cut in the world where a 110-tonne solid ought to be, through which the sky, the Aon Center and several thousand tourists a day pour continuously. Kapoor had spent much of the previous two decades chasing this effect at gallery scale, in the pigment-filled voids of the 1980s and the concave mirrored discs that followed, works where the viewer's own reflection curls back distorted rather than sitting flat on a surface. Cloud Gate is the moment that vocabulary met a civic budget and a skyline large enough to be worth swallowing, and it set the pattern for the mirr-

ored public commissions Kapoor would go on to build elsewhere: Sky Mirror in London and New York, the C-Curve at Kensington Gardens, Turning the World Upside Down in Jerusalem. None of the later pieces attempt the same trick at the same scale.

Sky Mirror (for Hendrik), 2017, at Museum de Pont, Tilburg: one of several later Kapoor mirror commissions that work at a fraction of Cloud Gate's scale and budget, and none aim for its seamless, walk-around continuity. · Photo: Peter Cox, courtesy Museum De Pont, CC BY-SA 4.0

Cloud Gate against the Michigan Avenue skyline, on AT&T Plaza. The kidney-bean profile that gave the sculpture its nickname, never Kapoor's own name for it, is legible only from outside; the work itself has no single correct viewing angle. · Photo: EightySixFilms, CC BY 2.0

Underneath, the plates curve inward to form what the artist calls the omphalos, an eight-metre concave chamber that gathers the reflections back on themselves and multiplies them into a compressed, curling vortex of tile, sky and crowd. It is the one part of the sculpture where the mirror stops behaving politely. Everywhere else, Cloud Gate flatters its surroundings, stretching the skyline into something taller and stranger than it actually is. Under the arch, the same surface turns on the viewer instead, folding dozens of people into a single circular frame with no horizon and no fixed vantage point to stand at and call correct.

Looking straight up into the omphalos: the concave underside compresses the plaza, the crowd and the sky into a single continuous ring with no horizon. · Photo: Kevin Dooley, CC BY 2.0

Public sculpture as infrastructure

What makes Cloud Gate an unusually successful piece of public art, rather than merely a popular one, is how little it asks of anyone who did not come to look at sculpture. It has no plaque-length argument to absorb, no fixed reading distance, no correct time of day. A tourist photographing their own reflection and a critic tracing Kapoor's debt to Brancusi's polished bronzes and to the biomorphic abstraction of Jean Arp are using the same object for the same reason: because its surface changes with whoever is standing in front of it and never resolves into one fixed image to be checked off and left. That is a harder trick to engineer than the seamless steel. Most large civic commissions settle for legibility from a bus window; this one was built to reward the two minutes someone spends walking around it far more than the two seconds someone spends driving past, which is also why it survives being photographed several million times a year without wearing out as an experience the way a static monument would.

Two decades on, the sculpture has absorbed a nickname it was never given by its maker, appeared in more amateur photographs than almost any other work of contemporary art, and remained, underneath all of that circulation, a genuinely difficult object: a solid with the visual behaviour of a liquid, a monument with no fixed subject except the crowd currently caught in its surface. Cloud Gate did not need an anniversary or a retrospective to prove the seamless finish was worth the extra two years and the extra cost. Every clear afternoon in the plaza does that instead. ■

EXHIBITION SEP 29, 2026

The World Is Not What It Says: Magritte's Afterlife at Gagosian London

At Gagosian London, René Magritte is placed beside more than forty artists to test not who copied his motifs, but who inherited his deeper proposition: that an ordinary image can become unreliable without ceasing to look ordinary.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · EXHIBITION · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

At Gagosian London, René Magritte is placed beside more than forty artists to test not who copied his motifs, but who inherited his deeper proposition: that an ordinary image can become unreliable without ceasing to look ordinary.

A pipe is useful until it becomes an image. Then it stops carrying smoke and begins carrying doubt. René Magritte understood that the smallest distance between a thing, its picture and its name could be made wide enough to contain an entire philosophy. At Gagosian's Grosvenor Hill gallery, *This Is Still Not a Pipe: The Afterlife of Magritte* asks what happened after that distance entered visual culture and never closed again.

Organised with the Fondation Magritte and curated by Jasper Sharp and Bernard Lagrange, the exhibition brings paintings, works on paper and sculpture from across Magritte's career into contact with more than forty artists. The important word is not influence but *afterlife*. This is less a family tree of quotations than a test of which of Magritte's problems remain active: the unreliable word, the theatrical object, the scale that turns familiarity into menace, and the image that withholds exactly what it appears to show.

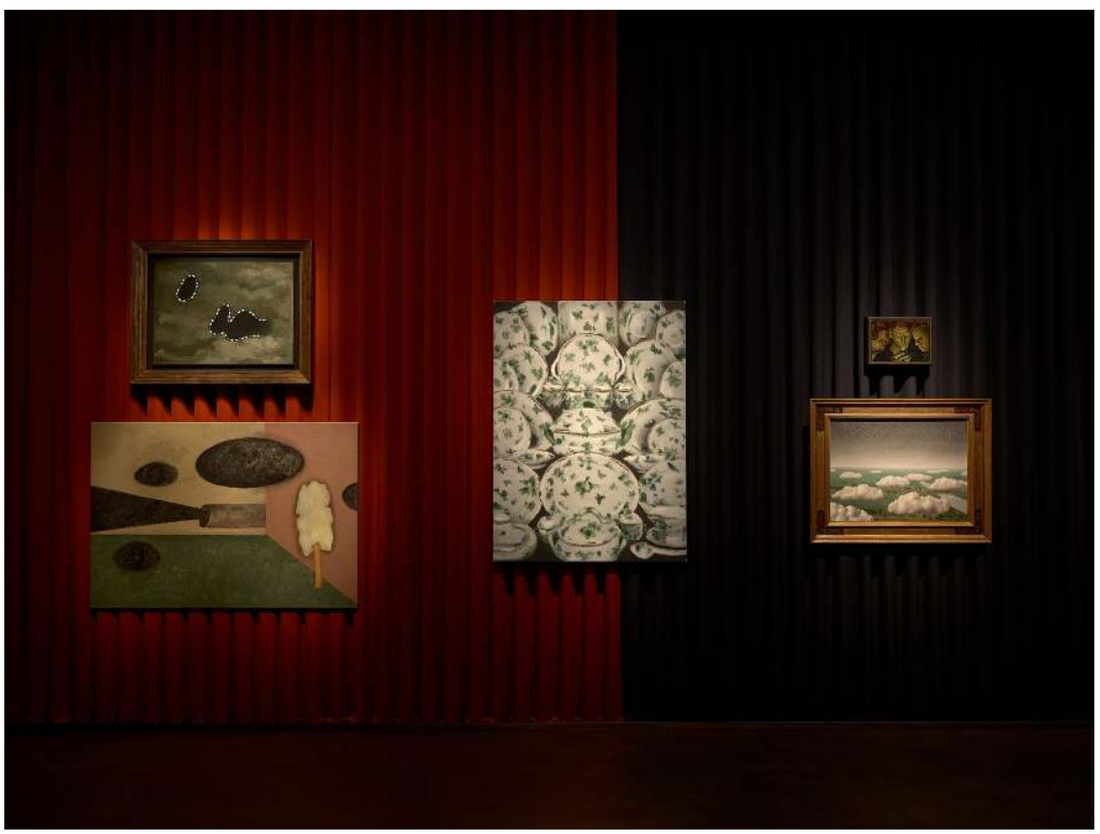
This Is Still Not a Pipe: The Afterlife of Magritte, installation view, Gagosian Grosvenor Hill, London, 2026. Photo: Prudence Cuming Associates Ltd. Artwork credits: Gagosian/Fondation Magritte.

I

Not a retrospective, but a pressure test

The exhibition begins with a historical span that is unusually broad without becoming dutiful. Its earliest Magritte, *Les Fleurs du voyage* (1926), appeared in his first one-person exhibition in Brussels. Nearby works carry the painter through the Paris years, the cloud-filled sky of *La Malédiction* (1931), the word-image puzzles of the 1930s, the deliberately coarse *vache* period of 1948 and the late, polished paradoxes for which he became globally recognisable.

Placed alone, these works might describe the evolution of a career. Placed among objects and paintings made decades later, they behave differently. They become propositions waiting for replies. The gallery's installation makes that argument spatially: Magritte is not given a sealed historical room. His pictures keep reappearing between Robert Gober, Vija Celmins, Maurizio Cattelan, Mona Hatoum, Sarah Lucas, Jeff Koons, Issy Wood, Victor Man and newly commissioned works.



Installation view with works by René Magritte, Pol Taburet, Issy Wood and Victor Man, Gagosian Grosvenor Hill, London, 2026. Photo: Prudence Cuming Associates Ltd.

II

The painting that behaves like evidence

L'Apparition (1928) demonstrates the structure beneath Magritte's familiar imagery. A dark field holds forms that seem to have arrived from incompatible systems: fragments of landscape, bodily suggestion, diagram and object. The surface does not ask to be admired as brushwork. It asks to be inspected as if it were evidence from an event whose rules have not been disclosed.

René Magritte, L'Apparition (The Apparition), 1928, oil on canvas, 54 × 73 cm. © 2026 ADAGP, Paris, and DACS, London. Image courtesy Gagosian.

That evidentiary flatness matters. In a conversation published by Gagosian Quarterly, Alex Da Corte distinguishes Magritte from painters whose thinking is visible in the movement of paint. Magritte often appears to have the image already decided and then executes it with the cool precision of an illustration or a distorted camera. The lack of painterly confession is not an absence of thought. It is what transfers the burden of thought to the viewer.

III A sky becomes an object

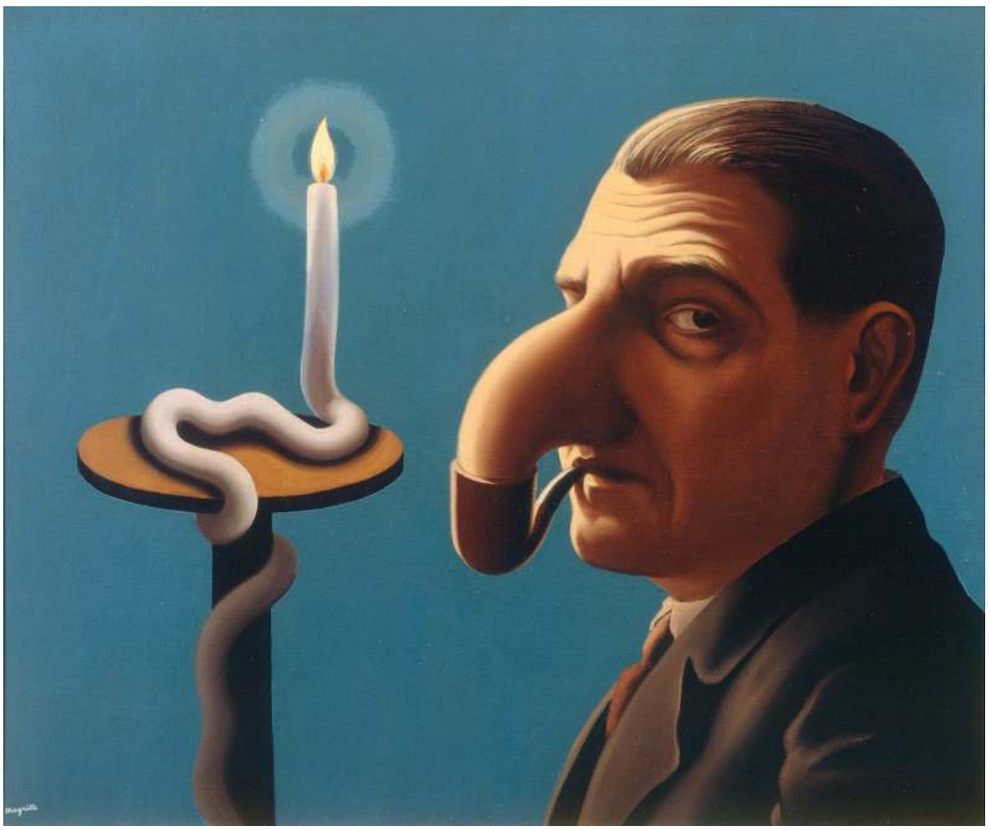
La Malédiction (1931), the earliest single-panel canvas in which Magritte devoted the entire field to a cloud-filled sky, removes the ground without turning the painting into pure atmosphere. The sky becomes a thing: bordered, transportable, owned. Once framed, even infinity acquires edges.

René Magritte, La Malédiction (The Curse), 1931, oil on canvas, 54 × 73 cm, Museum Voorlinden, Wassenaar. © 2026 ADAGP, Paris, and DACS, London. Photo: Antoine van Kaam.

This is one reason Magritte's clouds survive so easily in advertising and design. They are both weather and graphic device, nature and ready-made backdrop. But the commercial afterlife can conceal the original disturbance. His sky is not freedom. It is a surface pretending to be depth.

IV The artist as his own impossible object

La Lampe philosophique (1936) is often understood as a conceptual self-portrait. A face, a pipe and a candle are locked into a circuit of looking and consumption. The nose enters the pipe; the candle bends with an almost bodily exhaustion. Nothing in the scene is painted as a dream effect. Every component is materially plain, and the impossibility lies only in their relation.



René Magritte, La Lampe philosophique (The Philosopher's Lamp), 1936, oil on canvas, 50 × 66 cm. © 2026 C. Herscovici/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York. Photo courtesy Private Collection, Brussels.

Magritte repeatedly called ordinary objects "problems": the problem of the window, the door, the mountain. The formulation remains useful because it denies symbolism an easy victory. A pipe does not need to stand for one stable idea. It becomes a problem because painting separates it from use while leaving its identity intact.

V

Day and night refuse to take turns

The late *L'Empire des lumières* (1961), loaned by the Heidi Horten Collection, is the final painting in Magritte's celebrated sequence of landscapes where a bright daytime sky hangs above a nocturnal street. It is also the only one in the series to include a bowler-hatted figure silhouetted against the sky.

René Magritte, L'Empire des lumières (The Dominion of Light), 1961, oil on canvas, 50 × 73 cm, Heidi Horten Collection, Vienna. © 2026 ADAGP, Paris, and DACS, London. Photo: Prudence Cuming Associates Ltd.

The device is famous because it is instantly legible. It is lasting because legibility does not resolve it. The sky and street are both convincing, and therefore their coexistence cannot be dismissed as fantasy. Magritte does not invent a new world; he forces two true descriptions of this one to occupy the same moment.

VI What the descendants inherited

The strongest contemporary responses do not reproduce the apple, cloud or bowler hat. They inherit Magritte's method of making an object betray its category. Vija Celmins's *Pink Pearl Eraser* (1966–67) enlarges a disposable correction tool into a painted balsa-wood sculpture. It remains recognisably an eraser while becoming incapable of erasing. Use has been displaced by scale.

Vija Celmins, Pink Pearl Eraser, 1966–67, acrylic on balsa wood, 17.1 × 49.5 × 8.3 cm. © Vija Celmins. Image courtesy Gagosian.

Dana Schutz's new painting *The Singer* (2026) operates further from Magritte's iconography but close to his theatrical logic. The figure and the picture plane seem to negotiate which one is permitted to contain the other. It is not a quotation; it is a continuation of the same distrust in stable pictorial space.

Dana Schutz, The Singer, 2026, oil on canvas, 203.2 × 175.3 cm. © Dana Schutz. Photo: Stephen Arnold.

VII

Why Magritte now

Magritte's relevance is often explained through ubiquity: his images anticipated advertising, music videos, fashion and the visual shorthand of the internet. That is true but insufficient. Ubiquity can make an artist harmless. What the exhibition restores is the friction beneath recognition.

Our contemporary image systems promise transparency while producing uncertainty. AI-generated pictures can be entirely plausible and entirely without a photographed event behind them. Interfaces label objects, faces and places with increasing confidence. Magritte's old separation between word, image and thing no longer reads as a philosophical joke; it reads as basic media literacy.

Da Corte identifies something still more unfashionable in Magritte: opacity. These pictures do not reveal the artist's inner process, supply a correct interpretation or reward the viewer with full access. They remain clear and withholding at once. In a culture organised around explanation, disclosure and instantly searchable context, that refusal feels newly contemporary.

Magritte's pictures do not ask whether the world is real. They ask why an image should be trusted simply because it looks familiar.

VIII Verdict

This Is Still Not a Pipe succeeds when it treats influence as a working problem rather than a resemblance game. With more than forty contemporary artists, the exhibition inevitably produces uneven lines of descent. Some works sit close to Magritte's vocabulary; others require the curatorial premise to make the relationship visible. But that unevenness is productive. It shows that Magritte's afterlife is not a style. It is a set of permissions: to let the ordinary become unstable, to make scale carry meaning, to allow an image to contradict its caption, and to leave the central mechanism unexplained.

The exhibition is therefore most useful not as a celebration of a canonical Surrealist, but as a manual for looking at images now. The pipe is still not a pipe. The more urgent discovery is that the photograph may not be evidence, the label may not be knowledge, and the familiar may be the least trustworthy category of all. ▪

This Is Still Not a Pipe: The Afterlife of Magritte is at Gagosian, 20 Grosvenor Hill, London W1K 3QD, from 24 September to 12 December 2026. Tuesday–Saturday, 10am–6pm. Curated by Jasper Sharp and Bernard Lagrange in collaboration with the Fondation Magritte. This article was prepared from the exhibition materials and official installation photography; it does not claim an in-person visit. All artworks and photographs are reproduced for editorial review with the credits supplied by Gagosian.

FURTHER

Exhibition page — Gagosian gagosian.com/exhibitions/2026/this-is-still-not-a-pipe-the-afterlife-of-magritte

Alex Da Corte on René Magritte — Gagosian Quarterly gagosian.com/quarterly/2026/08/17/interview-alex-da-corte-on-rene-magritte

SCULPTURE & OBJECTS OCT 3, 2026

Cathy de Monchaux: The Poise of Wounds

At the Palais de Tokyo, Cathy de Monchaux turned metal, velvet, dust and fragile armatures into a sculptural language of desire, danger and extraordinary beauty.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · SCULPTURE & OBJECTS · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

At the Palais de Tokyo, Cathy de Monchaux turned metal, velvet, dust and fragile armatures into a sculptural language of desire, danger and extraordinary beauty.

Some exhibitions make sculpture look monumental. Cathy de Monchaux's first major retrospective at the Palais de Tokyo made it look alive. Across roughly fifty works dating from 1984 to the present, metal, velvet, dust, tracing paper, straps, rivets and delicate armatures formed an unsettled ecology of bodies. Nothing simply stood still. Even the most rigid structure seemed to be breathing, bracing itself or remembering an injury.

Studio, wounds and battles, desire is the reiteration of hope closed on 13 September 2026, but its images remain unusually difficult to put away. The exhibition was beautiful in the way a thorn, a relic or a half-remembered dream can be beautiful: not because it reassures, but because it gives form to the contradiction between vulnerability and force.

> Independent editorial review by Viacheslav Munister. Exhibition dates, descriptions and image credits are based on official Palais de Tokyo materials. Images are reproduced from the institution's press visuals; rights remain with Cathy de Monchaux, ADAGP and the credited photographers.

The sculpture that refuses a clean edge

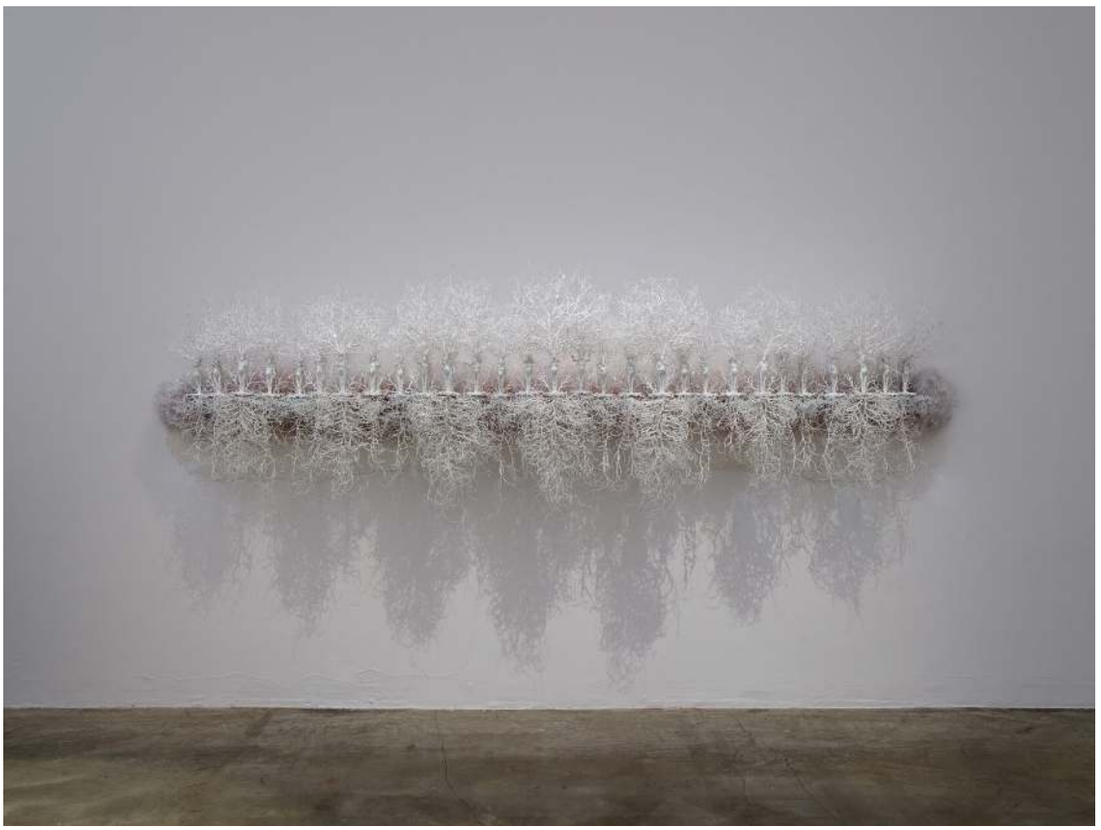
De Monchaux's objects are never satisfied with a single category. They can be sculpture, reliquary, anatomical fragment, stage set, machine, shell or weapon. They often occupy the wall like a drawing that has thickened into matter, or the floor like a body that has not decided whether to crawl, stand or disappear.

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, "Studio, wounds and battles, desire is the reiteration of hope", Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Aurélien Mole. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

This refusal of a clean edge is central to the exhibition's sensuality. A surface may appear soft until the eye notices its armour. A metal structure may look severe until it begins to resemble a rib cage, a flower or a nest. The works are made from transitions. They live in the moment when one material becomes another kind of image.

An intimacy made from metal

The most striking quality of de Monchaux's work is not its darkness but its intimacy. The sculptures seem to know the scale of the body. They bend, clasp, fold and open like gestures that have been enlarged without losing their private origin. Even the more spectacular installations retain the feeling of something handled, repaired or protected.



Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Aurélien Mole. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

Her vocabulary is full of structures that support and restrain at the same time. Straps can hold a form together, but they can also bind it. Ribs can protect, but they can also become a cage. The work does not decide which reading is correct. It makes the viewer feel the pressure between them.

That pressure is why the sculptures never become decorative, even when they are extraordinarily refined. Beauty is not a surface applied to difficult material. It is the exactness with which difficulty has been given a body.

The forest inside the gallery

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Quentin Chevrier. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

In the gallery, pale branches and clustered forms project from the wall like a forest translated into nerves. The effect is both natural and artificial. It recalls roots, antlers, coral, lace and the architecture of an inner organ, yet every part remains visibly made. The eye moves from the overall silhouette to the individual joint, then back again, as if the work were asking to be read at two speeds.

De Monchaux's sculptures often create this double scale. From a distance, they become landscapes or battle scenes. Up close, they reveal minute acts of construction: a rivet, a fold, a seam, a rough edge. Grandeur is built from attention. The monumental is not the opposite of the intimate; it is the intimate carried carefully to another register.

Desire is never innocent

The exhibition's title places desire beside wounds and battles, and the pairing is exact. De Monchaux's work is sensual, but never passive. Its surfaces invite the eye and then make the eye cautious. The viewer is drawn toward velvet, cavities, polished metal and soft-looking forms, only to discover a hidden threat: a spine, a point, a hard seam, an opening that refuses to explain itself.

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Quentin Chevrier. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

This is not the eroticism of smooth surfaces. It is an eroticism of hesitation. The body recognises something in the work, but cannot immediately decide whether that recognition means attraction, fear, memory or all three at once. De Monchaux makes sculpture out of the delay between these responses.

The archive of the damaged

The retrospective included technical drawings and archives of destroyed works, and this widened the exhibition's emotional range. The finished sculptures were not presented as isolated miracles. They were surrounded by evidence of trial, failure, disappearance and reconstruction. A destroyed work still has a body in the archive. Its absence becomes another material.

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Antoine Aphesbero. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

This matters because de Monchaux's work is fundamentally about what holds. An armature holds a form; a memory holds an event; a title holds an image open; a museum holds a fragile object long enough for strangers to encounter it. But every support can fail. The exhibition never hides that fact. It gives failure a quiet dignity.

A sculpture of the almost-human

The works often hover near the human figure without becoming figurative in any conventional sense. A vertical structure suggests a torso. A cluster becomes a group of bodies. A protrusion feels like a limb, a horn or an architectural brace. This almost-human quality is where the sculptures become most psychologically intense.

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Quentin Chevrier. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

The viewer begins to project a story onto the object, then the object withdraws. It refuses to become a character in a simple narrative. It remains matter, and that refusal is liberating. The sculpture does not have to represent a person in order to carry the pressure of a person's life.

Against the straight line

The Palais de Tokyo presentation was also a quiet critique of the straight line: the straight line of the pedestal, the clean line of progress, the hard line of authority. De Monchaux bends, tangles and interrupts those lines. Her forms make room for asymmetry, softness and the intelligence of the detour.

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Aurélien Mole. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

The effect is not chaos. It is a different order. The sculptures are carefully composed, but their order is organic rather than administrative. It grows by repetition, pressure and response. One shape touches another; one material changes the temperature of the next. The gallery becomes a field of relations rather than a sequence of isolated objects.

The elegance of resistance

Cathy de Monchaux, installation view, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photo: Aurélien Mole. © Adagp, Paris, 2026.

There is a particularly British severity to de Monchaux's sensibility: a willingness to let elegance coexist with discomfort, and to let humour appear at the edge of the grotesque. But the exhibition's emotional geography is wider than national style. These works speak to the body under pressure, to the architectures that protect and confine it, and to the strange optimism of continuing to make something delicate after damage.

The beauty of Cathy de Monchaux is never innocent. It is beauty that has learned how to brace itself.

That is why the exhibition stayed with me after its closing date. Not as a catalogue of forms, but as a physical intelligence: the knowledge that fragility can be engineered, that a wound can become an aperture, and that a sculpture can be both warning and shelter.

Studio, wounds and battles did not ask to be admired from a safe distance. It made the distance unstable. The closer one looked, the more the works changed register – from ornament to anatomy, from relic to threat, from private memory to collective ima-

ge. Their beauty was not an escape from the world. It was a way of remaining awake inside it. ■

Image credits: Cathy de Monchaux installation views, Palais de Tokyo, 2026. Photos by Antoine Aphesbero, Aurélien Mole and Quentin Chevrier. © Adagp, Paris, 2026. Images reproduced from official institutional press materials for editorial purposes; rights remain with the respective copyright holders.

FURTHER

Palais de Tokyo – official exhibition page palaisdetokyo.com/exposition/studio-wounds-and-battles-desire-is-the-reiteration-of-hope/?t=true

SCULPTURE & OBJECTS OCT 4, 2026

How to Stand in an Unstable World: Mona Hatoum at Fondazione Prada

Three rooms, more than thirty thousand glass spheres and a metal tower that repeatedly loses its balance: Mona Hatoum turns sculpture into an instrument for measuring instability.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · SCULPTURE & OBJECTS · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Three rooms, more than thirty thousand glass spheres and a metal tower that repeatedly loses its balance: Mona Hatoum turns sculpture into an instrument for measuring instability.

Mona Hatoum's new installation at Fondazione Prada begins with a simple correction to the way exhibitions are usually seen. The visitor does not stand outside the work and interpret it from a stable position. The floor may be clear, the walls may be still, but the body is already implicated: looking upward through a suspended web, circling a world map that could scatter underfoot, listening to a nine-storey metal frame strain against its own collapse. "Over, under and in between" is less a sequence of objects than a set of physical propositions about how it feels to occupy a world whose structures remain visible while their promises have become unreliable.

Installed in the three rooms of the Cisterna, the project brings together two new works made for Milan, Web and Map (red), with all of a quiver from 2022. The economy is severe: glass, cable, aluminium, hinges, a motor; transparency, geometry, repetition. Yet this restraint does not produce calm. Hatoum takes the inherited language of Minimalism – the grid, the module, the industrial surface – and returns to it everything the modernist ideal attempted to exclude: the vulnerable body, the unstable border, the possibility of rupture, the noise of fear.

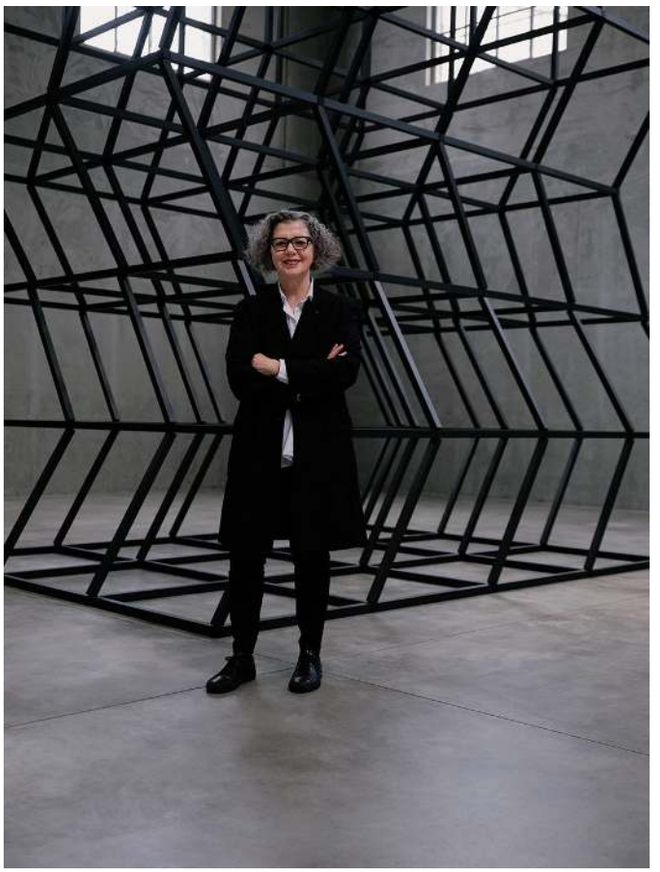
Independent editorial review by Viacheslav Munister. "Mona Hatoum. Over, under and in between" is on view at Fondazione Prada, Milan, from 29 January to 9 November 2026. Factual details and work specifications are based on the institution's official exhibition materials.

A building that remembers containment

The Cisterna was built in 1909 to contain three storage tanks for the former distillery. Its conversion into exhibition space did not erase that history. Each tall concrete chamber still feels like a vessel: enclosed, vertical, slightly disproportionate to the person entering it. Hatoum's decision to give one installation to each room turns the architecture into more than a backdrop. The visitor moves through three distinct conditions of containment – caught beneath a network, held at the edge of a diagram, and confronted by a structure that cannot keep its composure.

This matters because Hatoum has never treated space as neutral. Since moving from performance and video toward installation and sculpture in the early 1990s, she has made familiar forms behave strangely: domestic objects become threatening, maps refuse political certainty, grids become cages or nervous systems. Born in Beirut in 1952 to a Palestinian family and based in London since the Lebanese Civil War made her ret-

urn impossible in 1975, she works from a biography marked by displacement without reducing every object to autobiography. The political force of her art lies precisely in this refusal of illustration. History enters as pressure, scale, temperature and distance.



Mona Hatoum with all of a quiver at Fondazione Prada, Milan, 2026. Photo: Marta Marinotti. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Photo: Marta Marinotti. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

Web: beauty becomes a condition of capture

Mona Hatoum, Web, 2026. Hand-blown clear glass spheres and stainless-steel cable. Installation view, Fondazione Prada, Milan. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Installation view of "Mona Hatoum. Over, under and in between", Fondazione Prada, Milan, 2026. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

Web spans the first chamber overhead. Clear hand-blown spheres, irregular in size, are threaded along stainless-steel cable into a network that appears both precise and improvised. From the doorway it can resemble a constellation or a molecular model. Walking beneath it changes the register. The sparkling points become droplets under tension; the geometry lowers itself into the visitor's field of movement. What looked celestial begins to feel adhesive.

Mona Hatoum, Web, 2026. The suspended installation is calibrated against the scale and movement of visitors. Installation view, Fondazione Prada, Milan. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

The work succeeds because its seduction is not incidental to its menace. A web is simultaneously a home and a trap, an image of connection and a technology of capture. Hatoum does not choose between these meanings. Nor does she allow transparency to stand for innocence. Every glass sphere receives light, but every sphere also marks a node in a structure that holds. The room is visually open and psychologically occupied.

There is a risk, in work about precarity, that fragility becomes an elegant effect – danger made beautiful enough for institutional display. Hatoum acknowledges that risk and folds it into the piece. The blown glass is genuinely vulnerable, yet the web is engineered and taut. Its beauty does not soften the contradiction; it makes the viewer remain inside it. One looks longer because the object is beautiful, and that prolonged attention is exactly when beauty reveals its disciplinary edge.

Map (red): no border is the same as no violence

Mona Hatoum, Map (red), 2026. Clear red glass balls, 25 mm diameter. Installation view, Fondazione Prada, Milan. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Installation view of "Mona Hatoum. Over, under and in between", Fondazione Prada, Milan, 2026. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

In the second room, more than thirty thousand loose red glass balls form a world map directly on the floor. There are no national borders. The projection is Gall–Peters, which preserves the relative area of landmasses more accurately than the familiar Mercator projection and therefore refuses one of cartography's most persistent hierarchies: the visual inflation of Europe and North America at the expense of regions closer to the equator.

Mona Hatoum, Map (red), 2026. Visitors move around more than thirty thousand unfixed glass spheres. Installation view, Fondazione Prada, Milan. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

At first, Map (red) seems to offer a repaired image of the world – borderless and proportionally corrected. But Hatoum does not confuse correction with resolution. The continents are made of identical units that are not fixed to one another or to the floor. A careless step, a vibration or a small displacement could deform a coastline. Geography appears legible only because the room is temporarily calm.

The red is crucial. It can suggest warning, blood, heat, ideology or emergency, but the balls remain translucent; light moves through them. The colour does not assign a single message. Instead, it denies the map the cool authority of information. This is not a neutral diagram seen from nowhere. It is a world at the viewer's feet, vulnerable to proximity and power.

Mona Hatoum, Map (red), 2026, detail. Loose 25 mm clear red glass balls form a geography that can be physically disturbed. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

Hatoum has returned to maps across decades because they compress political decisions into apparently natural shapes. Here she removes borders but leaves the problem of territory intact. The work's most difficult insight is that a world without drawn boundaries is not automatically a world without domination. Scale can be corrected while movement remains unequal; a border can disappear from an image while becoming harder in lived experience. The installation does not illustrate this argument. It gives the argument a material condition: one beautiful arrangement, maintained only by collective restraint.

The map is most political at the point where it stops pretending to be permanent.

all of a quiver: the grid develops a nervous system

Mona Hatoum, all of a quiver, 2022. Aluminium square tubes, steel hinges, electric motor and cable. Installation view, Fondazione Prada, Milan. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Installation view of "Mona Hatoum. Over, under and in between", Fondazione Prada, Milan, 2026. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

The final chamber contains the exhibition's loudest and most explicitly animated work. all of a quiver is a nine-level frame made from aluminium square tubes connected by steel hinges. At full height it resembles scaffolding, a skeletal tower or the diagram of a building stripped of everything but its claim to order. Then a motor and cable initiate its transformation. Levels fold, the frame lowers and the geometry gives way with a metallic creak before the structure is drawn upright again.

Mona Hatoum, all of a quiver, 2022, during its motorised cycle of collapse and re-erection. Installation view, Fondazione Prada, Milan. Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. · Photo: Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada.

Nothing literally falls. That distinction is essential. The sculpture performs collapse while remaining held inside a system designed to repeat it. Disaster is not a single event but a cycle: tension, failure, suspension, reconstruction. Watching the work, one begins to notice how much confidence is usually invested in the right angle. The grid has long signified rationality, repeatability and control. Hatoum leaves its logic visible but makes every joint articulate. The abstract frame becomes bodily – it braces, buckles, groans and rises.

Of the three installations, this is the most theatrical, yet it is also the most exact. Its drama comes from engineering rather than illusion. The mechanism never permits complete catastrophe, and that limit makes the work more disturbing rather than less. It recalls infrastructures maintained just above failure, institutions that survive by rehearsing crisis, and bodies asked to recover without being allowed to change the conditions that exhausted them.

Minimalism after certainty

Hatoum's relation to Minimalism is often described through resemblance: modular structures, industrial materials, repeated units, the removal of expressive gesture. But resemblance is not allegiance. Historical Minimalism frequently offered the object as a self-contained fact and the gallery as a field for phenomenological encounter. Hatoum

keeps the encounter and removes the security. Her modules can scatter, her grid can fail, her transparent surface can ensnare. The supposedly universal viewing body becomes a particular body aware of risk.

This is why the exhibition feels current without chasing topicality. Its materials do not name a war, a migration route, a border regime or a collapsing institution, yet they sharpen the sensorium through which those realities are experienced. Uncertainty is not represented as fog. It is given structure. There are clear lines, measurable spheres, visible joints and identifiable mechanisms. Everything can be described, and still nothing feels secure.

The show is also a corrective to the idea that political art must deliver a readable position at first glance. Hatoum's politics are spatial before they are declarative. The visitor discovers them through posture: the neck tilted upward, the feet held back from the glass map, the body waiting for the tower's next movement. Interpretation follows sensation rather than replacing it.

The body as a measuring instrument

Across the three rooms, the body repeatedly becomes an instrument for measuring what cannot be trusted. Under Web, height is felt as exposure. Beside Map (red), distance becomes an ethical decision not to disturb. Before all of a quiver, time is counted through expectation: when will the structure move, how far will it give way, will it return? The works do not immerse the viewer through spectacle. They make perception responsible.

That responsibility distinguishes Hatoum's use of fragility from a broader contemporary taste for ruins, broken grids and precarious materials. Here instability is never merely a look. It governs the viewer's behaviour and the object's survival. The installations remain austere enough to resist narrative illustration, yet sensuous enough to prevent detachment. Glass catches light; metal produces sound; scale works on the lungs before language has settled.

How to stand

"Over, under and in between" does not offer resilience as a comforting conclusion. The tower rises again because a cable pulls it. The map remains intact because people keep their distance. The web is beautiful because its tension holds. Every equilibrium is conditional, supported by labour, restraint or force that the work makes visible.

What Hatoum finally asks is not whether the world is stable. It plainly is not. The more difficult question is how to stand inside instability without mistaking survival for safety or order for justice. In the Cisterna, sculpture becomes a rehearsal for that position: alert but not paralysed, implicated but still capable of attention. The exhibition's deepest achievement is to make precarity neither abstract nor spectacular. It becomes the space between the object and the body – the interval in which looking turns into responsibility. ■

Image credits: installation views of “Mona Hatoum. Over, under and in between”, Fondazione Prada, Milan, 2026. Photos by Roberto Marossi. Courtesy Fondazione Prada. Images reproduced from official institutional materials for independent editorial review; rights remain with the artist, photographer and institution.

FURTHER

Fondazione Prada — official exhibition page fondazioneprada.org/project/mona-hatoum-over-under-and-in-between/%3Flang=en

PHOTOGRAPHY & VISUAL CULTURE OCT 6, 2026

The Second Exposure: What Photography Does to Architecture, Sculpture and Painting

From the measured neutrality of architectural typologies to Medardo Rosso's dissolving sculpture and Ann Hamilton's tactile scans, the camera does not merely reproduce art – it rebuilds it in light.

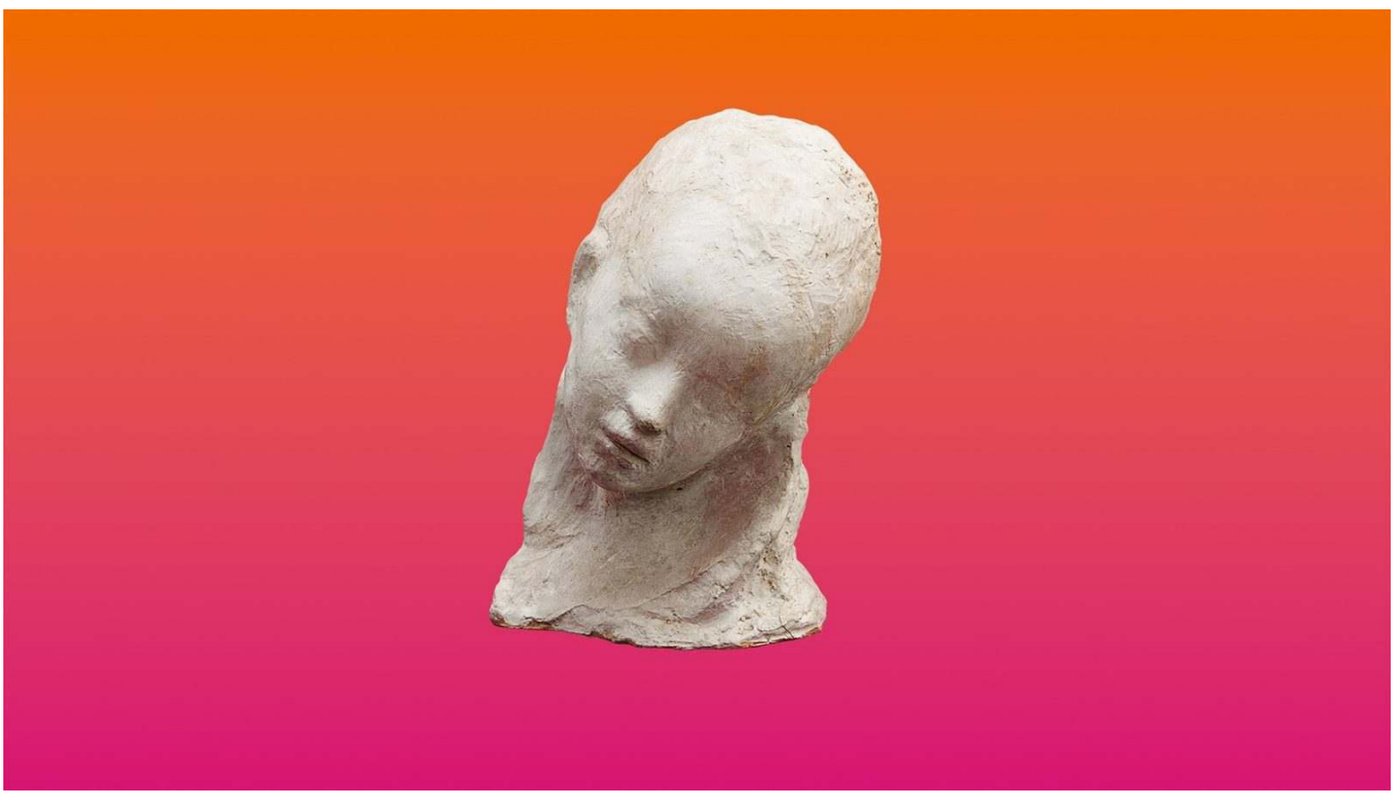
WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION I · PHOTOGRAPHY & VISUAL CULTURE · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

From the measured neutrality of architectural typologies to Medardo Rosso's dissolving sculpture and Ann Hamilton's tactile scans, the camera does not merely reproduce art – it rebuilds it in light.

A photograph of an artwork is often introduced as evidence: proof that an object existed, that an exhibition happened, that a building looked a certain way before the weather, the public or the next installation altered it. Yet every serious photographer knows that evidence begins with a refusal. The camera excludes almost everything. It converts depth into a plane, duration into an instant, atmosphere into exposure and the wandering body into one fixed point of view. What we call documentation is therefore already an argument.

This argument has become more urgent as exhibitions are increasingly encountered first – and sometimes only – through images. Architecture travels as a frontal elevation emptied of people. Sculpture becomes a silhouette, a gleam, a dramatic shadow. Painting is detached from the wall, corrected into a perfect rectangle and made to emit the same light as the screen on which it appears. The camera does not stand after the work and report on it. It produces a second work: portable, repeatable, searchable and often more culturally powerful than the first.



Installation view, Medardo Rosso: Inventing Modern Sculpture, Kunstmuseum Basel, 2025. Courtesy Kunstmuseum Basel.

The photograph is not the artwork's shadow. It is a second object made of light, with its own scale, exclusions and authority.

The photograph is never after the work

Three recent exhibitions make that second object unusually visible. *Typologien: Photography in 20th-Century Germany*, presented at Fondazione Prada in Milan from April to July 2025, assembled more than six hundred works by twenty-five artists. Its subject was not simply a national history of photography but the typological impulse: the desire to compare, order and stabilise the visible world. At Kunstmuseum Basel, *Medardo Rosso: Inventing Modern Sculpture* placed roughly fifty sculptures beside some 250 photographs and drawings, insisting that Rosso's images were not secondary records but part of his sculptural thinking. In Cleveland, Ann Hamilton's *still and moving • the tactile image* enlarged handheld scans of small historic figures until touch became architecture.

Together these exhibitions shift the question from whether a photograph is faithful to what stood before the lens to what kind of reality it builds. Typology claims knowledge through repetition. Rosso makes solidity unstable through light. Hamilton turns scanning – a procedure associated with administrative capture – into an intimate choreography of hand, object and delay. Each case exposes a different politics of looking.

Sculpture and photograph share the gallery as parallel forms of inquiry in Medardo Rosso: Inventing Modern Sculpture. Installation view, Kunstmuseum Basel, 2025.

Architecture and the fiction of neutral light

Architectural photography has long depended on a fiction of neutrality. The exemplary image is clear, vertical, spacious and apparently inevitable. It suppresses the inconvenience of use: open doors, moving bodies, temporary signs, cleaning equipment, the shifting colour of daylight. Perspective correction makes walls stand straighter than vision experiences them. A long exposure erases pedestrians or converts them into translucent traces. Weather is waited out. Furniture is moved by centimetres. The result can be precise in every measurable respect and false in every social one.

The German tradition gathered in *Typologien* complicates this fiction because its discipline is explicit. Bernd and Hilla Becher photographed industrial structures under flat skies, from consistent positions, with minimal theatrical incident. Their grids make comparison possible: water towers, blast furnaces and winding towers become families of form. The method appears objective, but the exhibition's typological structure reveals the paradox. A type does not exist naturally in the world. It is produced by selection – by deciding which objects belong together, which differences matter and which context can be removed.

The Bechers' influence on Candida Höfer, Thomas Struth, Andreas Gursky and Thomas Ruff did not create one style so much as a sustained argument about distance. Höfer's empty libraries, theatres and museums are never merely empty. Their vacancy makes institutional order visible: furniture aligned for absent users, routes of circulat-

ion, ornament calibrated to authority. Struth's museum pictures reverse the convention. Instead of isolating the painting, they include visitors looking, waiting, drifting and blocking one another's view. The museum becomes an image-making machine in which the public is both audience and material.

The exhibition design refuses a single ideal viewpoint; sculpture is encountered through changing distances and obstructions. Kunstmuseum Basel, 2025.

Luisa Lambri takes another route. Her photographs of modernist interiors avoid the building's iconic totality and move toward windows, corners, joints and the thin membrane where daylight meets a surface. Architecture is no longer a heroic object but a psychological aperture. The photograph measures what a room permits the body to sense. Light is not there to explain the building; it becomes the building's most unstable material.

To photograph architecture responsibly is therefore not to eliminate interpretation but to make interpretation legible. A picture can acknowledge use, season, security, access and decay. It can preserve the difference between a room designed for contemplation and a room temporarily cleared for the camera. It can show that the polished image is a condition produced by labour. Neutrality is not the absence of style. It is a style whose choices have been made difficult to see.

When sculpture becomes weather

Sculpture creates an even sharper conflict. It occupies the same space as the viewer, yet the photograph must reduce that shared space to one surface. Scale becomes relative to the frame; weight becomes tonal contrast; the back of the work disappears. A camera can make plaster monumental and bronze weightless. It can detach a figure from its plinth, compress several objects into one silhouette or allow a cast shadow to become more active than the material that produced it.

Installation view, Medardo Rosso: Inventing Modern Sculpture. Light, vitrines and sightlines are treated as part of the work's reception. Kunstmuseum Basel, 2025.

Medardo Rosso understood this not as a limitation but as a medium. His wax, plaster and bronze figures appear to emerge from and return to their surrounding atmosphere. Faces are incomplete; shoulders merge with bases; surfaces catch illumination unevenly. In person, the object shifts as the viewer moves. In Rosso's photographs, movement is replaced by another instability. He cropped, rephotographed, altered contrast and allowed light to veil the sculpture. The photograph does not clarify the object. It extends its refusal to become fully knowable.

The Basel exhibition was important because it resisted the familiar hierarchy in which sculpture is original and photography is supporting material. Rosso's photographs stood as experiments in perception. The same figure could seem tender, spectral, damaged or

almost abstract depending on angle and exposure. Repetition did not stabilise identity; it multiplied it. The work existed between states, and the camera was one of the instruments that kept it there.

A gallery sequence in the Basel retrospective. Rosso's figures change character as illumination and viewing distance change.

Constantin Brâncuși later treated photography with comparable seriousness. He objected when professional photographers made his sculptures look like discrete, well-lit commodities. His own images accepted flare, shadow and spatial ambiguity because the relation among object, base and studio mattered more than descriptive completeness. The photograph became an extension of installation. It instructed the future not only what the sculpture looked like, but how it wished to be seen.

This is why contemporary sculpture photography so often fails when it is merely spectacular. The dramatic black background, hard spotlight and low angle may produce a powerful object while destroying the sculpture's actual relation to gravity and room. A good image need not imitate ordinary eyesight, but it should understand what it transforms. The question is not whether the photograph beautifies the work. The question is whether its beauty discovers a condition already latent in the work or replaces the work with an advertising effect.

Rosso's sculptural surfaces hold and scatter light rather than presenting a stable contour. Installation view, Kunstmuseum Basel, 2025.

Touch without possession

Ann Hamilton's Cleveland installation begins where conventional object photography is supposed to end: at the moment of contact. Using a handheld scanner, Hamilton moved across small ceramic and crèche figures from the museum's collection, many rarely displayed. The scanner does not observe from a distance. It requires proximity, a paced movement and a narrow band of attention. What it records is not a single instant but the duration of a hand travelling over an object.

Ann Hamilton, image from still and moving • the tactile image, Cleveland Museum of Art, 2025–26. Courtesy the artist and Cleveland Museum of Art.

Enlarged from hand-sized objects to floor-to-ceiling images, the scans produce a strange reversal. The historic figure is no longer a miniature to be mastered by the gaze. It exceeds the viewer. Seams, abrasions and distortions become landscape. The scanner's failures – drag, doubling, temporal discontinuity – are not defects to be corrected. They register the negotiation between a moving hand and a resistant form.

Hamilton calls the result tactile because sight is made to remember touch. Yet the installation also preserves distance. The visitor cannot handle the collection object; conservation protocols and museum authority remain. The enlarged image mediates that denied contact. It offers intimacy without possession and magnification without pretending that scale is unchanged. In this sense the work is an ethics of reproduction: it makes the transformation visible rather than hiding it beneath seamless technical competence.

Painting under surveillance

Painting appears to be the easiest art to photograph because both painting and photograph are flat. That resemblance is deceptive. Paint reflects light; screens emit it. Varnish produces glare, impasto casts shadows, matte passages absorb illumination and metallic pigments change with position. A single exposure may render the colours plausibly while cancelling the physical decisions that made them. The perfect digital rectangle is often a very incomplete painting.

Museum documentation usually removes the frame, corrects perspective and balances colour against a calibration target. These procedures are indispensable for scholarship, conservation and access. But they also produce a peculiar image: the painting as if seen from nowhere, under light that belongs to no hour, without the wall or body that establishes its scale. Such an image is less a view than a data model. Its authority comes from suppressing the conditions of looking.

Installation view, Kunstmuseum Basel, 2025. The photograph records not an isolated object but an arrangement of surfaces, intervals and reflected light.

Thomas Struth's museum photographs restore those conditions by placing paintings inside crowded acts of attention. The viewers' backs, clothes, gestures and hesitations become part of the image. Scale returns through bodies. So does conflict: one person's contemplation is another's obstruction. The painting is neither autonomous icon nor passive backdrop; it is a social event continuously reorganised by those who stand before it.

This social dimension matters in the age of the installation shot. Exhibitions are routinely photographed before opening, when every label is aligned and every surface untouched. These images are useful and often beautiful, but they portray an institution without friction. The public later enters a room already imagined as empty. Photography establishes the ideal state, and lived experience arrives as a disturbance.

Exposure has three meanings

The word *exposure* joins the problems at the centre of these exhibitions. In photography it names the quantity of light that reaches a sensitive surface. In display it means making something available to view. In ordinary speech it also means vulnerability: exposure to weather, judgment, danger or loss. Every reproduction of an artwork operates across all three meanings.

To expose a sculpture is to illuminate it, to place it before a public and to make it vulnerable to a framing it cannot control. To expose architecture is to transform occupied space into a claim about order. To expose a painting is to move colour from reflected light into a reproducible system. The technical decision is inseparable from the institutional one. What receives light receives attention; what remains outside the frame risks remaining outside history.

Typologien demonstrates how seriality can become knowledge, but also how knowledge becomes power. A grid persuades because it appears to treat every image equally. Yet the equal format intensifies the curator's decisions: these are the examples chosen to represent a category; these are the differences the viewer is invited to compare. Typology is never innocent. It can preserve threatened forms, reveal industrial histories and discover affinities. It can also turn singular places into specimens.

Rosso uses repetition against that stability. His sequences do not define a type; they dissolve certainty. Hamilton, meanwhile, turns the capturing device back into a bodily instrument. Together they suggest that responsible photographic practice does not renounce ordering, framing or transformation. It makes those operations available to thought.

The ethics of the perfect image

The contemporary image economy rewards immediate legibility. An exhibition photograph must function at the scale of a phone, survive cropping, leave space for text and announce its subject before the next swipe. Architecture is pushed toward symmetry; sculpture toward silhouette; painting toward saturated colour. The most distributable image becomes the exhibition's unofficial cover, regardless of whether it represents the experience of the work.

There is nothing inherently dishonest about seduction. Art has always required invitations, and photography can make inaccessible collections available across distance. The ethical problem begins when the image conceals the degree of its invention. Extreme tonal editing is presented as natural light. An empty room is presented as ordinary access. A temporary viewpoint is presented as the building's essence. The camera's rhetoric disappears behind the word *documentation*.

A more exact practice begins with captions. Who made the photograph? When was it taken – during installation, at opening, after conservation? Is the pictured state permanent? Has the image been cropped or composited? What does the credit line call the object: work, installation view, detail, rendering, archival photograph? Such language is not bureaucratic decoration. It tells the reader what kind of evidence is being offered.

Exactness also requires plurality. One frontal image can describe proportion but not movement. A detail can explain material but not scale. A crowded view can reveal social use while obscuring the work. The answer is not a mythical perfect photograph but a sequence in which the limits of one image are corrected by another. The serious visual essay is therefore closer to an exhibition than to an icon: it constructs relations across difference.

A second object made of light

The most consequential photographs of art do not disappear in service to their subjects. They establish a productive distance. Höfer makes institutional space visible by withholding its users. Struth makes looking visible by including them. Lambri fragments architecture until light and enclosure become psychological. Rosso photographs sculpture until material becomes weather. Hamilton scans touch until a small object becomes an environment.

None of these practices offers neutrality. Each offers a position clear enough to be examined. This is the distinction between interpretation and distortion. Distortion pretends that its transformation is the world. Interpretation reveals a way of moving through the world and permits another viewer to disagree.

The camera is often described as preserving what time will destroy. It does preserve, but never without building something new. A building becomes a plane of decisions. A sculpture becomes an event of illumination. A painting becomes a proposition about colour under controlled conditions. An exhibition becomes an archive before it has finished happening.

The task is not to force the photograph back into obedience. It is to demand more intelligence from the second object: enough formal precision to deserve attention, enough historical context to resist spectacle, enough transparency to disclose its choices and enough imagination to show what ordinary looking misses. The artwork does not survive in the image unchanged. It survives as a renewed problem – exposed again. ■

A responsible photograph does not say: this is how the work was. It says: this is the encounter I have constructed, and these are the conditions under which you may judge it.

Essay by Viacheslav Munister for EPRIS Journal. The text draws on official exhibition materials for *Typologien: Photography in 20th-Century Germany* (Fondazione Prada, Milan, 3 April–14 July 2025), *Medardo Rosso: Inventing Modern Sculpture* (Kunstmuseum Basel, 29 March–10 August 2025), and Ann Hamilton's *still and moving • the tactile image* (Cleveland Museum of Art, 14 December 2025–19 April 2026). It does not claim in-person attendance. Images are reproduced for editorial and critical discussion and remain credited to their institutions and authors.

FURTHER

Typologien – Fondazione Prada	fondazioneprada.org/project/typologien/?lang=en
Medardo Rosso: Inventing Modern Sculpture – Kunstmuseum Basel	kunstmuseumbasel.ch/en/exhibitions/2025/medardo-rosso
Ann Hamilton: still and moving • the tactile image – Cleveland Museum of Art	clevelandart.org/exhibitions/ann-hamilton-still-and-moving-tactile-image

SECTION II

Architecture & Memory

A building remembers through joints, repairs, voids and the routes bodies repeat.

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CONTEMPORARY ARCHITECTURE OCT 2, 2026

The Building Wears Its Forces: Inside the Radical Structure of Powerhouse Parramatta

Powerhouse Parramatta puts a three-layer steel lattice outside the museum so that its vast rooms can remain almost impossibly free—a building in which structure, spectacle and civic promise become the same argument.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · CONTEMPORARY ARCHITECTURE · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Powerhouse Parramatta puts a three-layer steel lattice outside the museum so that its vast rooms can remain almost impossibly free—a building in which structure, spectacle and civic promise become the same argument.

Most buildings conceal the labour that keeps them standing. Columns disappear into walls; trusses retreat above ceilings; mechanical systems are tidied into zones the public never sees. Powerhouse Parramatta reverses that etiquette. Its white steel lattice wraps the museum like an enlarged scientific diagram, turning load, span and resistance into the first thing the city encounters.

Designed by Moreau Kusunoki with Genton, and engineered across more than twenty disciplines by Arup, the new institution in Western Sydney is due to open on 7 November 2026. Before a single object is interpreted inside, the building has already made an audacious claim: engineering is not the mute servant of architecture. It can be architecture's public language.

I A museum built from incompatible demands

The brief asked for seven enormous presentation spaces, some capable of holding machines and objects that ordinary galleries cannot admit. It also asked for openness to the city, a generous public ground, views toward the Parramatta River, future adaptability and the environmental discipline expected of a major public project. Each ambition pressures the others.

A large span wants depth and mass. A transparent edge wants slenderness. Museum conservation wants sealed, controlled interiors; civic life wants porosity. A flood-adjacent site demands resilience, while the institution promises intimacy and ease. Powerhouse Parramatta is compelling because it does not smooth these contradictions into a neutral box. It lets their negotiation determine the form.

The primary frame during construction. The steelwork carries gallery volumes while preserving unusually large clear interiors. Courtesy Genton.

II

The exoskeleton is not an ornament

The diagonal façade can be mistaken for a graphic pattern applied after the fact. Structurally, it is the opposite. Developed from the competition concept with engineer Jun Sato and advanced by Arup, the "lattice³" system is a three-layered exoskeleton: large V, X and N arrangements manage forces at the scale of the building, while finer chords and diagonals work as laced columns.

This hierarchy matters. A conventional frame repeats columns through the plan and asks exhibitions to adapt around them. Here, structure migrates toward the perimeter so that the interior can become radically available. The image of freedom inside is purchased by an exceptionally specific discipline outside.

Full-scale exoskeleton prototype. The apparent irregularity is governed by force paths rather than by a decorative grid. Courtesy Genton.

III

Freedom has a shape

Architects often describe flexible space as though flexibility meant absence: fewer walls, fewer columns, fewer decisions. Powerhouse Parramatta reveals the hidden cost of that word. To make a room capable of receiving changing exhibitions, performances and exceptionally large objects, the building must make hard decisions elsewhere – about transfer, bracing, tolerances, access and the route of every service.

The largest presentation volume is column-free and comparable, according to Arup, to fifteen Olympic swimming pools in volume. Its northern elevation can open toward the river through an immense mechanical hoisting door. The room therefore operates less like a conventional gallery than a piece of civic machinery: enclosure can become aperture, and a controlled interior can momentarily address the city.

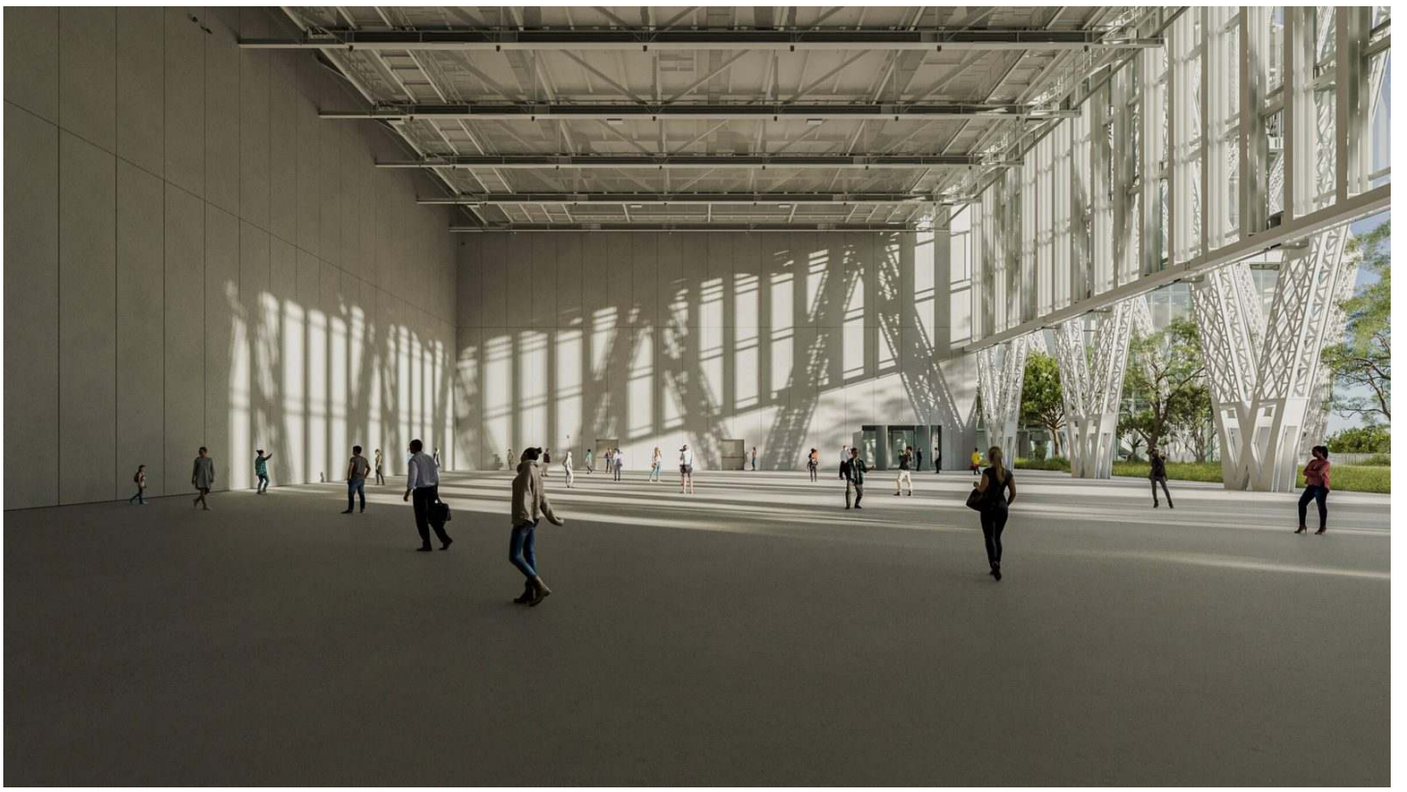
Presentation Space 1, conceived as a vast column-free volume for objects, installations and events that exceed the scale of a conventional gallery. Courtesy Moreau Kusunoki, Genton and Powerhouse Parramatta.

IV

The door is architecture at the scale of infrastructure

A domestic door separates two rooms. The hoisting façade at Parramatta separates two environmental regimes and two ideas of publicness. When closed, it helps maintain the conditions a museum requires. When open, it converts the gallery into a stage facing the river and turns the building envelope into an event.

This is kinetic architecture without the usual fantasy that movement alone makes a building alive. The important fact is not that a huge wall can move, but that the institution must decide when to expose itself. Openness becomes operational, scheduled and negotiated – not a permanent transparency rendered harmless in glass.



The opening of Presentation Space 1 toward the river. The façade acts as an environmental boundary, loading interface and urban proscenium. Courtesy Genton and Powerhouse Parramatta.

V

A stack, not a procession

The seven presentation spaces are conceived as distinct boxes stacked into a compact body. This abandons the classical museum's orderly sequence of galleries. Visitors move among volumes with different scales, proportions and atmospheres; circulation looks across a shared interior and toward the public realm.

Stacking is both an urban and structural act. It reduces the footprint, releasing more of the site as public space, but intensifies the transfer of loads through the building. It also produces intervals between rooms – those ambiguous zones that Moreau Kusunoki connects to the Japanese idea of *ma*, the active space between defined things.

A discovery and learning space within the stacked museum. Courtesy Moreau Kusunoki, Genton and Powerhouse Parramatta.

VI The difficult politics of lightness

The competition jury praised the proposal's lightness. Yet a building of 34,000 square metres, made from major quantities of steel and concrete, is not materially light. Architectural lightness here is perceptual and organisational: the ground is opened, the frame appears porous, and huge rooms are lifted away from a forest of supports.

That distinction should remain visible. Contemporary architecture frequently converts engineering intensity into an image of effortless elegance. At Parramatta the effect is beautiful, but the lattice also gives the effort a face. Its density registers that openness is constructed, calculated and materially expensive.

Detail of the multi-scale steel lattice. Large braces and finer laced elements make different orders of force legible on the same elevation. Courtesy Genton.

VII A science museum that demonstrates itself

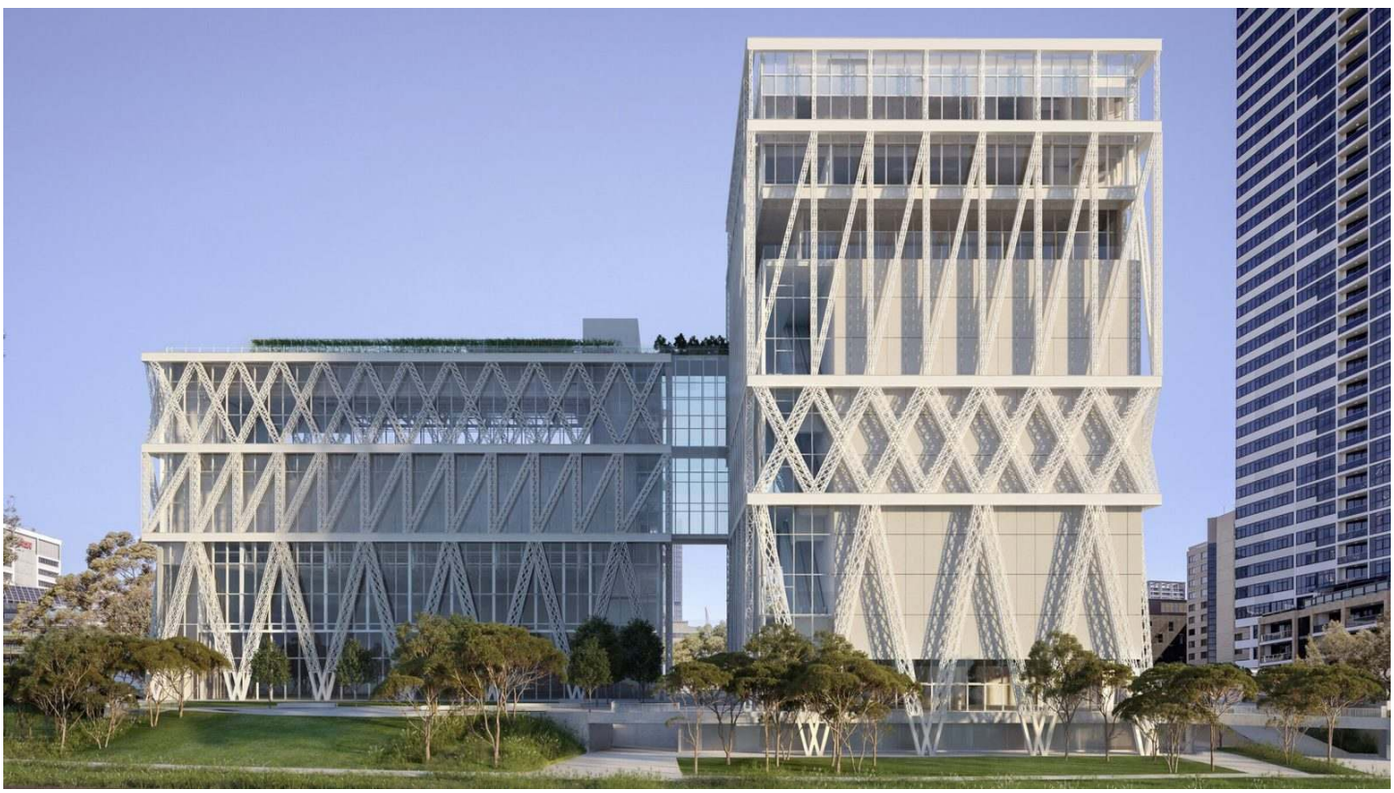
For a museum devoted to applied arts and sciences, exposed structure carries an unusual pedagogical charge. The building does not merely contain accounts of engineering; it offers itself as an argument about how engineering can work. Load paths become spatial experience. A visitor may not calculate the frame, but can sense that the diagonals are doing more than composing a façade.

This is not the old modernist promise of total legibility. The structure remains profoundly complex, dependent on digital modelling, fabrication tolerances and specialist coordination invisible to most visitors. What becomes public is not a complete explanation, but evidence that the building has an intelligible logic.

VIII Twenty disciplines in one envelope

Arup records more than 240 staff working across structural, civil, flood, fire, façade, acoustic, mechanical, electrical, security, blast, pedestrian-flow and other fields. That list is not incidental project trivia. It describes the true authorship of a contemporary building of this complexity.

The romantic image of architecture begins with a singular sketch. Powerhouse Parramatta begins there too, but survives only through coordination: ducts must pass without weakening the frame; façade tolerances must meet structural movement; fire strategy must accommodate monumental voids; crowds and enormous objects need separate yet intersecting routes. Complexity is less a spectacular geometry than the sustained resolution of dependencies.



North view toward the Parramatta River. The exoskeleton must coordinate structure, façade, environmental control and the public identity of the museum. Courtesy Moreau Kusunoki, Genton and Powerhouse Parramatta.

IX The river is not scenery

Architectural descriptions often turn water into a view. At Parramatta, the river is also a dynamic system and a source of flood risk. The project's public promise – to reconnect the city centre with the river – therefore cannot be separated from civil engineering, landscape levels, evacuation planning and the design of resilient infrastructure.

This produces an important tension. The museum presents itself as porous and river-facing, while the institution's collections and technical systems depend on protection from environmental instability. The architecture must make contact and defence coexist. Its civic openness is credible only because harder layers of risk management support it.

The compact museum footprint beside the Parramatta River releases ground for a new civic landscape while intensifying the demands placed on the building. Courtesy Powerhouse studio.

X

Sustainability beyond the badge

The completed project has received a 6 Star Green Star Design rating and is planned as an all-electric building supplied by renewable energy, with a climate-positive operational ambition. These are significant commitments for a museum, a building type burdened by long hours, high visitor loads and strict environmental conditioning.

Yet operational targets are only one part of the environmental account. A steel exoskeleton and vast controlled volumes contain substantial embodied carbon. The more difficult question is whether the adaptability promised by the frame can extend the building's useful life enough to repay that initial investment. Flexibility becomes an ecological claim only when institutions actually use it to avoid premature demolition and refit.

XI

The institution and the city

Powerhouse Parramatta is described as a cultural platform for Western Sydney, a region historically underserved by the metropolitan distribution of major institutions. The architecture answers through scale and visibility: this is not a satellite or a modest local annex, but a building intended to alter the cultural map of Sydney.

Such claims deserve both recognition and scrutiny. Monumental investment can create access, employment and civic identity, but a public building does not become socially generous through transparency alone. Its schedules, ticketing, programming, employment, transport connections and relationships with local communities will determine whether the open ground is truly public.

XII The risk of the icon

The lattice gives Powerhouse Parramatta an instantly recognisable image, and recognisability is a powerful currency for a new museum. The danger is that structural honesty hardens into branding: a complex system becomes a logo, photographed from the same angles until the institution and its city disappear behind white diagonals.

The building's best defence against that fate lies in use. If the enormous rooms accept unruly programmes, if the river opening alters how events meet the city, and if the public spaces remain hospitable without requiring consumption, the exoskeleton will be more than an icon. It will be the apparatus that enables institutional change.

XIII A building that explains its price

Public architecture is always asked to justify itself twice: first through what it provides, and then through what it visibly symbolises. Powerhouse Parramatta makes its expenditure legible as capacity. The span, the opening wall, the suspended volumes and the public ground are not finishes applied to a standard container. They are difficult things the building can do.

That does not settle every debate about cost, site or institutional priorities. Architecture cannot answer political questions with engineering virtuosity. But it can prevent complexity from becoming mere opacity. Here, part of the answer stands outside, in full view, bearing the loads.

> The building's freedom is not the absence of structure. It is the result of moving structure to the edge, multiplying its intelligence and allowing the public to see the bargain.

XIV Verdict

Powerhouse Parramatta belongs to a lineage of buildings – from Centre Pompidou onward – that turn technical systems into civic theatre. Its contribution is subtler than simple exposure. The lattice does not display every pipe and duct. It concentrates a vast field of coordination into a single structural language capable of appearing intimate in detail and monumental across the skyline.

The result is contemporary architecture at its most ambitious and most vulnerable: technically exact, institutionally symbolic, environmentally accountable, politically loaded and dependent on future use for the fulfilment of its promises. When the museum opens, the decisive question will not be whether the exoskeleton photographs well. It will be whether all that visible force has created room for forms of public life the architects could not predict. ■

Powerhouse Parramatta is scheduled to open on 7 November 2026. Designed by Moreau Kusunoki with Genton; multidisciplinary engineering by Arup, with the competition-stage exoskeleton developed with Jun Sato Structural Engineers. This article was prepared from official project, architect and engineering sources and does not claim an in-person visit. Images are reproduced for editorial review with credits supplied by Genton and the project team.

FURTHER

Powerhouse Parramatta — Moreau Kusunoki	moreaukusunoki.com/project/powerhouse-precinct-at-parramatta
Powerhouse Parramatta — Genton	genton.com.au/projects/powerhouse-parramatta
Powerhouse Parramatta — Infrastructure NSW	infrastructure.nsw.gov.au/projects-nsw/completed/powerhouse-parramatta
Structural Engineering Year in Review 2025 — Arup	arup.com/globalassets/downloads/services-and-tools/structural-engineering/arup-structural-engineering-year-in-review-2025.pdf

ESSAY SEPTEMBER 20, 2026

The River Valencia Turned Into a Park

In 1957 the Turia drowned Valencia. The city moved the river out, planned motorways for the empty bed, and was talked out of them by its own citizens. The story of the Turia Garden runs from Roman irrigation to a dictator's stamp tax, a fallas artist's giant and the night in 2024 when the new channel held.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

In 1957 the Turia drowned Valencia. The city moved the river out, planned motorways for the empty bed, and was talked out of them by its own citizens. The story of the Turia Garden runs from Roman irrigation to a dictator's stamp tax, a fallas artist's giant and the night in 2024 when the new channel held.

In the middle of Valencia there is a river with no water in it. Its stone embankments are still there, and so are its bridges, some of them standing on foundations more than four centuries old, but below them, where the Turia once ran, there are orange trees, football pitches, a running track, ponds, a concert hall and a giant lying on his back while children slide down his hair. The Jardí del Túria follows the old riverbed for about eight and a half kilometres, dropping from 19 metres above sea level at the zoo on the western edge of the city to one metre at the Oceanogràfic near the port.

It looks like a gift of nature. It is the opposite: the product of a disaster, a colossal piece of engineering, a road plan that was never built and a civic campaign that insisted a city could decide for itself what to do with its own scar. Few public spaces in Europe explain so clearly how a city is actually made.

A river the city was built around

The Romans founded Valentia in 138 BC beside the Turia, and for the next two thousand years the city lived from the river and in fear of it. Its water fed the acequias, the irrigation channels of the Horta, the market gardens that surround Valencia; the farmers who share that water still settle their disputes every Thursday at the Water Tribunal outside the cathedral, one of the oldest courts of justice in Europe. From the fifteenth century a special municipal body, the Fàbrica Vella de Murs i Valls, built and maintained the stone parapets that still line the riverbed. They did not stop the floods. Valencians named them after the saints on whose days they came, the flood of Saint Michael, of Saint Martin, and historians count dozens between the fourteenth and nineteenth centuries. One of them, in 1589, swept away the bridge to the sea; its stone replacement, the Pont del Mar, was built in 1591 and still stands.

October 1957

The flood that changed the city came after three days of a gota fría, a cold drop, in October 1957. Rain fell on Valencia and the mountains upstream from Saturday the 12th; the river rose on the 13th and, after torrential rain around midday on Monday the 14th, burst into the city. The old centre around the cathedral largely escaped, but newer districts such as Zaidía and Campanar were devastated, in Marxalanes some streets stood under five metres of water, and Natzaret, by the port, was cut off. Valencia was left

without water, gas or electricity; around 5,800 homes were destroyed, some 3,500 families lost their homes, three quarters of the city's commerce and industry stopped, and at least 81 people died.

The Turia in flood, October 1957, and clearing the mud from Calle Pintor Sorolla.

Franco visited the city on 24 October and promised government money. It was slow to come, and the mayor said so. Tomás Trénor Azcárraga, who by an unkind coincidence held the title Marquis of the Turia, protested in public about the missing aid. In 1958 he was removed from office, and with him the editor of the newspaper Las Provincias, Martín Domínguez Barberá, and the president of the Ateneo Mercantil, Joaquín Maldonado. The regime would rebuild Valencia, but on its own terms.

Moving a river

Engineers had studied the problem for years; the architect Fernando García Ordóñez had been working on alternatives since 1946. After the flood, the minister Vicente Mortes commissioned a detailed study of three options. The Northern solution would have joined the Turia to the Carraixet ravine; the Central one would have improved the existing course and added a reservoir upstream at Vilamarxant. The Southern solution was the most expensive and the most colossal: to dig an entirely new river across the Horta, from Quart de Poblet to the sea near Pinedo. The Council of Ministers chose it on 22 July 1958, and a law of 1961 set out how it would be paid for, including a detail every Valencian of that generation remembers: for as long as the works lasted, every letter and parcel posted in Valencia carried an extra 25-céntimo stamp for the river.

Work under the Júcar River Basin Authority began in the mid-1960s. Franco inspected the finished channel on 22 December 1969, and by around 1973 the Turia no longer ran through the city. The new course is 11,868 metres long, 175 metres wide for most of its length and 200 metres near the sea, and was designed to carry 5,000 cubic metres of water a second. Its banks became a ring road, today's V-30. And in the middle of Valencia it left a long, dry, empty space, which the plans of the 1960s had already assigned to motorways and a transport axis linking the port and the airport.

The riverbed is ours

The motorway was never built, for two reasons that reinforced each other. The ring road along the new channel made a highway through the centre less necessary. And the city began to argue. From 1973 Las Provincias ran campaigns defending the riverbed, its five-hundred-year-old parapets and its bridges as heritage. Neighbourhood associations, in one of the first examples of organised citizen participation in Francoist Valencia, took up a slogan that is still painted into Valencian memory: El llit del Túria és nostre i el volem verd, the Turia riverbed is ours and we want it green. In 1976, a year after Franco's death, a decree signed by King Juan Carlos transferred the old bed to the city. In 1979 it was formally designated as green space and a public park.

What to plant there was another question. In 1981 the city commissioned a plan from Ricardo Bofill's Taller de Arquitectura, but only part of it was built; the final scheme approved in 1984 divided the riverbed into eighteen numbered sections, from Mislata to Natzaret, and gave them to different teams. Work began in 1985, and the first sections opened to the public in 1986 and 1987.

Bofill's own section is the most monumental: orange trees, palms, water and white neoclassical colonnades in front of the Palau de la Música. The concert hall was built under a national plan of 1983 to give every Spanish region an auditorium, and the site chosen for it, beside sections X and XI of the future garden, was a derelict industrial plot known as la Azufrera, the sulphur works. José María García de Paredes designed a glass-vaulted building that opened in 1987 and sits in the riverbed like a winter garden; Eduardo de Miguel extended it in 2003.

Colonnades and water in front of the Palau de la Música.

The rest of the garden changes character every few hundred metres, because it was designed by many hands. Vetges Tu i Mediterrània laid out sports pitches, meadows and fountains between the Casa del Agua and Nuevo Centro; the regional agriculture department planted an urban forest of thousands of pines between Nuevo Centro and Serranos; the architects Otegui, Gisbert and Noguera and the landscape architect Ángel

rage width of 160 metres; the last sections towards the port, where groundwater still seeps into the old bed, are unfinished, and when they are done the park will be almost ten kilometres long and 160 hectares in size.

Sports pitches, pines and palms: different sections of the same riverbed.

A giant for the Lilliputians

In 1986 the city and the regional government commissioned a playground under a programme called Un riu de xiquets, a river of children. The architect Rafael Rivera and Manolo Martín, an artist who built falles, the enormous satirical figures Valencia burns every March, produced a design by Sento Llobell: Lemuel Gulliver, seventy metres long, tied to the ground at the moment he wakes in Lilliput. Children become the Lilliputians, climbing his coat, sliding down his hair and hiding in his pockets. It cost 220 million pesetas, entry is free, and after a renovation it reopened in November 2022. It is a playground, and also a quiet joke about the whole project: a city discovering what to do with a space that had suddenly become far larger than itself.

The Gulliver playground, seen from a bridge and from the ground.

Crossing a river that isn't there

Because the garden is still a river in the city's mind, Valencia crosses it on bridges, more than twenty of them. The Pont del Mar, with ten pointed arches and 160 metres long, was for centuries the road to the port; in 1933 it became a footbridge, with stairs by the architect Javier Goerlich, and when the garden was made a round pool was placed beneath its arches. The Serranos bridge leads to the medieval city gate. Santiago Calatrava, born in Valencia, built his first bridge here, the Nou d'Octubre in 1989, and later the Pont de l'Exposició above the Alameda metro station, which locals call la peineta, the comb, and the Assut de l'Or, known as el jamonero after the stand used to slice ham.

One of Santiago Calatrava's bridges over the garden. · Wikimedia Commons: JavierOlivares, CC BY-SA 4.0

The eastern end belongs to Calatrava's City of Arts and Sciences, raised in the riverbed from the 1990s: L'Hemisfèric opened in 1998, the science museum in 2000, L'Umbracle in 2001, L'Oceanogràfic, with thin concrete shells by Félix Candela, in 2003, the Palau de les Arts in 2005 and L'Àgora in 2009. It became Valencia's postcard and one of its most argued-over projects: budgeted at around 300 million euros in 1991, it ended up costing about 1.2 billion. Seen from the garden, it reads as the loudest chapter of a story that began with mud in the streets.

L'Hemisfèric and the Palau de les Arts; L'Àgora and the Assut de l'Or bridge; the garden near the Palau de les Arts.

October 2024

On 29 October 2024 another gota fría stalled over the region. The new channel of the Turia, dug after 1957, carried the flood past Valencia and the city centre stayed dry. South of it, the Poyo ravine, normally a dry bed running parallel to the river, rose past the maximum alert threshold of its single flow sensor; at 18:05 it registered almost 994 cubic metres a second, and the water poured through the towns of l'Horta Sud. More than two hundred people died in the province. In the following days thousands of volunteers walked from Valencia to the flooded towns across a footbridge over the new channel; it has since been named the Pont de la Solidaritat. Some experts point out that the channel protected the capital but not the wider plain around it, and that the lesson of 1957 was learned for one river rather than for the whole landscape.

What the garden teaches

The Turia Garden is usually described as a park. It is closer to an argument about what a city owes the people who live in it. The same empty bed could have become a fast road between the edges of Valencia; instead it became a slow line joining its neighbourhoods, where people walk, run and cycle from one end of the city to the other without meeting a car, and where the old bridges still frame views of a river that is no longer there.

Many cities now try to uncover buried rivers, tear down urban motorways or turn railway lines into parks. Valencia did something similar half a century ago, before it was fashionable, and for a reason that 2024 made painfully clear: people who had lived through a flood asked that the place of the disaster be given back to them green. The water was sent elsewhere. The memory stayed in the riverbed, and the city chose to walk through it every day.

Text: Viacheslav Munister for EPRIS Journal. Sources include the Spanish Wikipedia entries on the Plan Sur, the Jardín del Turia, the Parque Gulliver, the Palau de la Música and the October 2024 floods, and the Colegio Territorial de Arquitectos de Valencia. Photographs: Wikimedia Commons, authors and licences are given with each image. ■

ESSAY SEPTEMBER 10, 2026

Eighteen Inches of Sky: The Interiors of the World Trade Center

Twenty five years on, the towers are remembered as a silhouette. Inside they were three buildings stacked on each other, a lobby seventy four feet high, an office floor of nearly an acre, and a window eighteen inches wide that decided how the city was allowed to be looked at.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Twenty five years on, the towers are remembered as a silhouette. Inside they were three buildings stacked on each other, a lobby seventy four feet high, an office floor of nearly an acre, and a window eighteen inches wide that decided how the city was allowed to be looked at.

Everyone knows the outline. Two flat topped verticals, aluminium turning pink at the end of an afternoon, printed on more posters than any other pair of buildings in the world. What almost nobody describes, twenty five years on, is what it was like to be inside them. About fifty thousand people worked in the World Trade Center on an ordinary day and tens of thousands more passed through it. Their subject was never the silhouette. It was a lobby, an elevator transfer, a floor of grey carpet where the view arrived in slices.

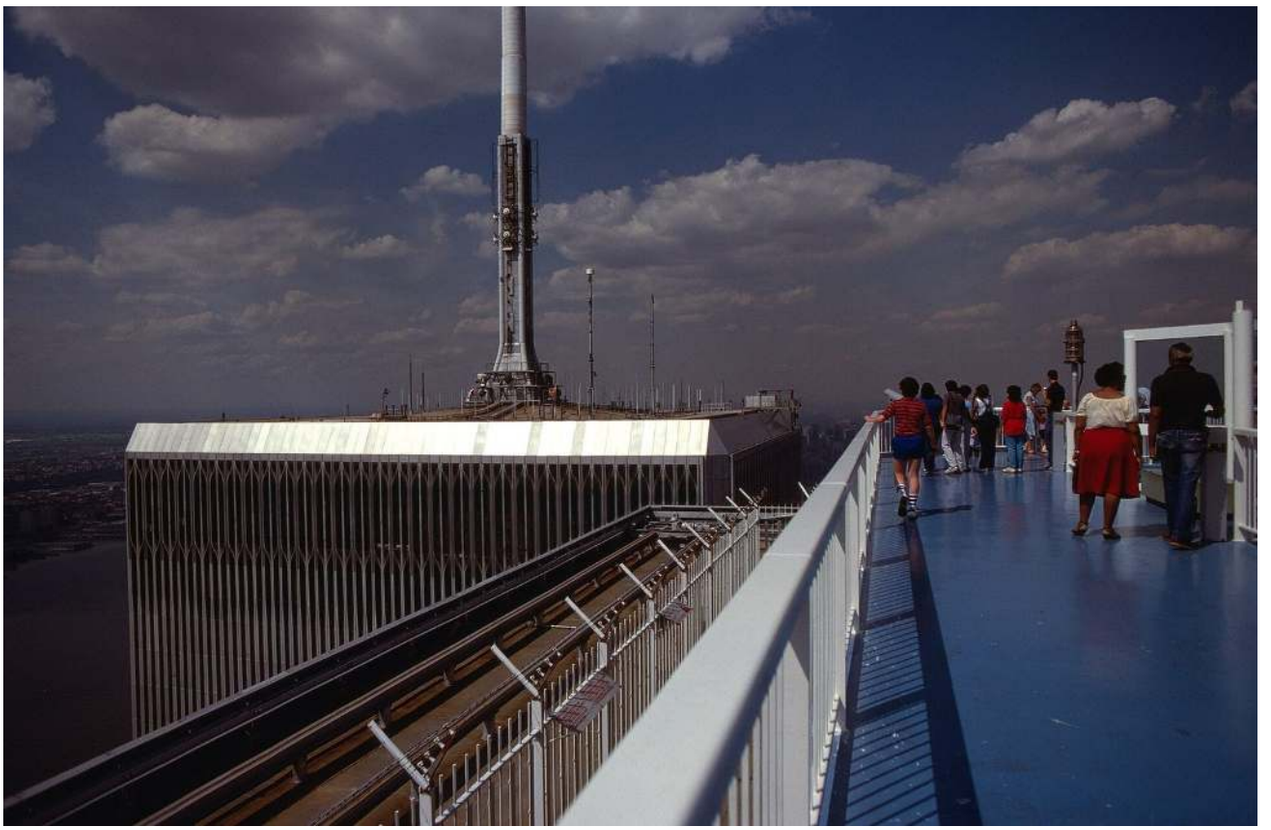
01Eighteen inches

Start with the window, because the rest of the interior follows from it. Minoru Yamasaki wrapped the towers in closely spaced steel columns, and the glass between them is eighteen inches wide, narrower than the shoulders of the person looking through it. The stated reason is disarmingly personal. Yamasaki was afraid of heights, and he did not think a tenant should be asked to stand at a sheer wall of glass a thousand feet in the air. The structural reason ran alongside it, since those same columns were holding the building up.

From inside, the effect is precise and strange. You cannot take in the room and the view at the same time. The city arrives in vertical strips, edited by aluminium. To look down you have to walk right up to the glass and put your face into the opening, and the column takes your weight while you do it. The building makes you commit to looking.

There was one exception, and it proves the rule. On the observation deck near the top of the South Tower the columns were narrowed so the glass could open to twenty eight inches. Ten inches is the entire difference between a place where people work and a place where people come to look.

The deck was a designed attraction rather than a window someone happened to leave open. Top of the World, as the Port Authority called it, opened in December 1975 with an indoor floor at the hundred and seventh level and an open roof deck above it, reached by escalator. It held two dozen video monitors, a film called Manhattan Magic, a model of the city with seven hundred and fifty buildings in it, and a food court with a Sbarro and a Nathan's Famous. A visitor was sold the view in the way a museum sells a collection, with an interpretation attached.



The open deck on the roof of the South Tower in 1984, with the North Tower and its mast beyond. Here the parapet is chest high and the view is the point. · Photo: Lars Plougmann, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Coin telescopes and a queue for them. Two floors below, the same building gave its office tenants eighteen inches of glass and no railing to lean on. · Photo: Tequask, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

02A nave at the door

At the bottom the same columns do something else entirely. Near the ground each group of three merges into one, which let the lobby glass run wide and tall between them and let the elevator shafts stack economically above. The lobbies were seventy four feet high. The effect was a pointed arcade, and critics reached for the word Gothic, sometimes admiringly and often not. What matters for the interior is the sequence. The building narrows the world to eighteen inches upstairs and greets you with something like a nave at the door.

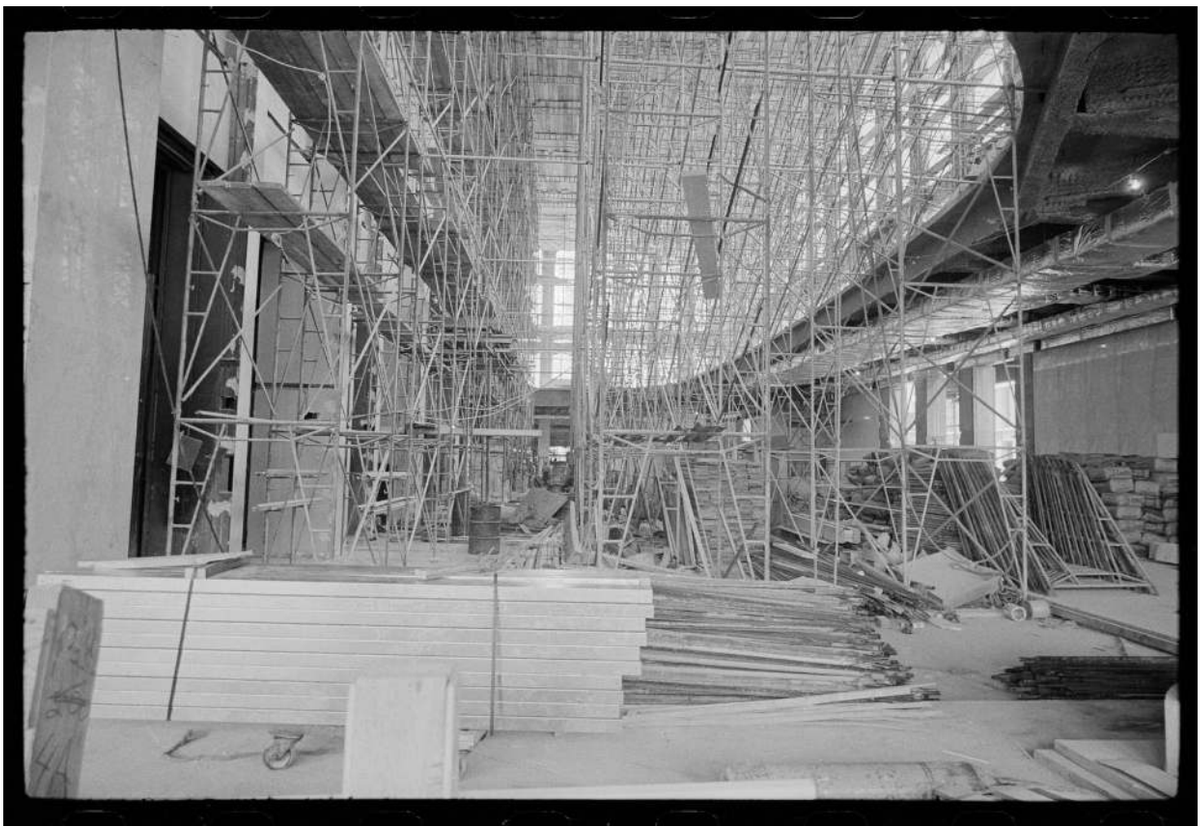
Where three perimeter columns merge into one, the wall opens. Fritz Koenig's bronze Sphere stands in the plaza fountain beyond. · Photo: Balthazar Korab, public domain, via the Library of Congress and Wikimedia Commons

03Three buildings, stacked

Inside, each tower was not one building but three sitting on top of one another. Floors one to forty three, forty four to seventy seven, seventy eight to one hundred and ten: three zones, each with its own local elevators, reached by express cars running to sky lobbies on the forty fourth and seventy eighth floors. The express cars carried fifty five people at sixteen hundred feet a minute, roughly twenty seven feet every second.

This was arithmetic before it was architecture. In a conventional scheme a tower of this height spends its lower floors on elevator shafts and the rentable area collapses. Splitting the journey the way a subway line splits into express and local raised usable floor area from sixty two to seventy five percent. Thirteen percent of a hundred and ten floors is a great deal of building. The consequence was social. A sky lobby behaved like a station: people changed there, queued there, ran into each other there, and the tower acquired two interior addresses that were neither the street nor an office.

Eight of the hundred and ten floors were never let to anyone. They went to machinery, in four two floor bands spaced up the building, because a tower this size is a utility company that happens to have tenants: its own water, its own air, its own power distribution, its own drainage lifted back down. The complex even had postcodes of its own, 10048 and 10047, which is the plainest possible statement of what it was. Not a building on a street, a settlement with an address.



A tower lobby under construction in 1971. Two years later the same volume held stone, glass and a queue for the express elevators. · Photo: Warren K. Leffler, U.S. News & World Report collection, public domain, via the Library of Congress

04An acre of ordinary

The floors themselves were plain and enormous. Each plate is a square of two hundred and eight feet with a service core of eighty seven by one hundred and thirty five in the middle, and the ring of space between core and facade runs uninterrupted, which was the whole commercial argument: close to an acre a floor with nothing in the way. What tenants did with that was what tenants do. Partitions, carpet tile, a wall of filing, meeting rooms pushed into the corners where two views meet.

It is worth saying plainly that most of the interior of the World Trade Center was ordinary. That is not a complaint, it is the fact that has been hardest to hold on to. A building remembered only through catastrophe loses its Tuesdays.

05The room at the top

One interior was not ordinary at all. Windows on the World opened on the hundred and sixth and hundred and seventh floors of the North Tower on 19 April 1976, across fifty thousand square feet designed by Warren Platner. Platner worked in brass, mirror and fabric covered walls, with tufted banquettes, discs set into the columns and dish shaped brass lights above them. Milton Glaser designed everything a guest touched or read: the dinnerware, the rugs, the light fittings, the menus. Paul Goldberger called the result sensuous modernism, which was accurate and, at the time, faintly disapproving.

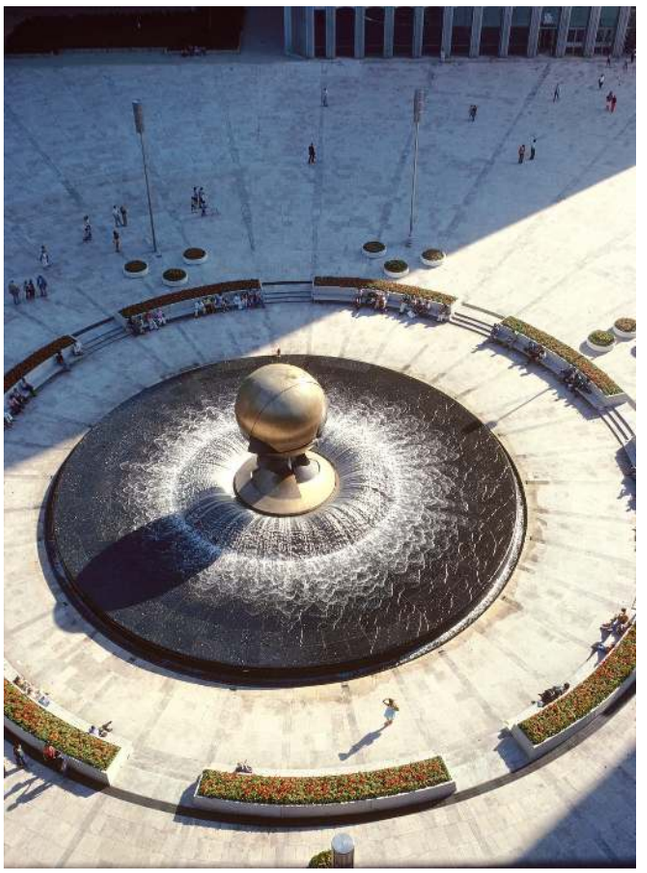
The clever move was structural rather than decorative. Platner stepped the dining room in tiers, so that the view through that eighteen inch glass belonged to every table instead of to the row beside the window. A jacket was required and the restaurant kept a rack of them for men who arrived without one. On the south side sat the Cellar in the Sky, a small room with a fixed menu and its own wine list. After the 1993 bombing the space was rebuilt for twelve and a half million dollars and reopened on 26 June 1996. In its last full year it took thirty seven million dollars and was the highest grossing restaurant in the United States.

Around the dining room sat the rest of it: a wine school that ran for decades under Kevin Zraly, and on the hundred and seventh floor the Hors d'Oeuvrerie, which in the nineties became the Greatest Bar on Earth, full length windows and a dance floor. The bomb of February 1993 went off in the garage six levels down, and it was the underground that took it, the concourse and the station and the plant. The towers stood, but the restaurant at the top stayed shut for three years.

The tiers were the design. A window that narrow gives the view to whoever sits closest, unless the floor itself is arranged to hand it back.

06What hung in the lobbies

Art was distributed through the interiors as deliberately as the elevators. In the lobby of the South Tower hung a tapestry made by Joan Miro with Josep Royo, wool and hemp, twenty feet by thirty five and four tons of it, in place from 1974. On the mezzanine of the North Tower stood Louise Nevelson's Sky Gate, New York, black painted wood, finished in 1978. Alexander Calder's red stabile stood outside on the north side of the site, and Masayuki Nagare's Cloud Fortress sat on the plaza itself, a low black granite mass that people used as a wall to sit against. At the centre of the plaza fountain, Fritz Koenig's bronze Sphere turned once every twenty four hours, slowly enough that you could not watch it move and surely enough that it was never quite where you had left it.



Austin J. Tobin Plaza from above, with Fritz Koenig's Sphere at the centre of the fountain. The bronze turned a full circle every twenty four hours. · Photo: Balthazar Korab, public domain, via the Library of Congress and Wikimedia Commons

Masayuki Nagare's Cloud Fortress on the plaza, with the perimeter columns rising behind it. · Photo: Balthazar Korab, public domain, via the Library of Congress and Wikimedia Commons

07The street underneath

Below all of this lay the part of the complex most people actually used. Six levels of substructure held a shopping concourse, the PATH station, parking and the plant that ran the towers. The plaza above was exposed and frequently unkind in wind, so the mall became the real street of the World Trade Center. For a great many people the building was entered from underneath, without ever crossing the open ground it was famous for.

08What is left

Tomorrow is the twenty fifth anniversary. Everything described here, with one exception, now exists only as description: the seventy four foot lobbies, the two sky lobbies, the acre floors, the brass and the tiers of Windows on the World, the tapestry, the Nevelson. Koenig's Sphere came through, dented and torn open, and stands today in Liberty Park a short walk from where it used to turn.

The Sphere stood at the centre of the plaza fountain and turned once a day. Damaged and deliberately never repaired, it stands now in Liberty Park. · Photo: Bernt Rostad, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons

There is a habit of remembering buildings by their outlines, and it is convenient, because an outline has no rooms in it and therefore nobody inside. The World Trade Center was a place people went to work in the morning: through the concourse, up in an

express car, out at a sky lobby, into a floor with a window eighteen inches wide. Keeping hold of that is not nostalgia about architecture. It is the only way the description stays about people.

Photographs, in order: the 107th floor of the North Tower in 1979 (Guerinf, CC BY-SA 3.0); the roof deck of the South Tower in 1984 (Lars Plougmann, CC BY-SA 2.0); the deck telescopes (Tequask, CC BY-SA 4.0); the entrance arches, the lobby under construction in 1971, the plaza from above and Cloud Fortress (Balthazar Korab and Warren K. Leffler, public domain, Library of Congress); the Sphere in Liberty Park (Bernt Rostad, CC BY 2.0). All via Wikimedia Commons. ■

ESSAY AUG 2, 2026

Against the Right Angle

Five buildings that talked their way out of the grid – and the software, the metal, the money and the sheer nerve it took to build them.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Five buildings that talked their way out of the grid – and the software, the metal, the money and the sheer nerve it took to build them.

Every architecture student is taught to revere the right angle, and every architecture student eventually notices that nothing outside the studio is at ninety degrees. Not the coastline, not the ribcage, not the river, not the way people cross a square – they cut the corner, always, which is why the grass on any campus dies diagonally before it dies anywhere else. The grid is not nature. The grid is a filing system. It won because it was cheap to draw with a T-square, cheap to price by the square metre, and cheap to defend in a planning meeting to a committee that had already stopped listening.

So for a century the curve was something you paid extra for and then justified in writing. Curved wall, custom formwork, a contractor breathing through his teeth, and a quantity surveyor wearing the expression of a man reading a hospital bill in a foreign currency. You were allowed exactly one – in the lobby, where visitors would see it and investors would feel it – and then the building went back to being a filing cabinet with windows, a nice reception desk and a coffee machine nobody had specified.

What ended the arrangement was not a manifesto. Manifestos had been available since 1919 and had built almost nothing. It was arithmetic. Between roughly 1990 and 2015, software borrowed from people who make aeroplanes and cars got good enough to describe a doubly curved surface precisely enough to cut it, cost it, insure it and – the unglamorous miracle at the bottom of this entire story – get a fabricator in a shed outside Zaragoza to produce panel 3,417 so that it meets panel 3,418 on a wet Tuesday in October, with a tolerance measured in millimetres and a foreman who does not care about your concept.

The five buildings below all sit inside that window, and they are habitually filed together under words designed to prevent thought: blob, parametric, organic, iconic – the last one deployed almost exclusively by people who want your signature on something. Look closer and they agree on nothing at all. One is a sculpture that happens to contain a museum. One is a landscape doing an impression of a building. One is a shopping centre having an existential crisis at 330,000 square metres. One is a traffic diagram that grew a skin and a Mercedes badge. One is a snowdrift with excellent acoustics and a free roof.

In every case the shape is the argument, not the wrapping paper. The interesting work – the part that survives the photograph – is establishing what each one is arguing for, who paid for the argument, and what it cost after the ribbon was cut. Because all five arrived with an invoice, and only some of them were worth settling.

01 Frank GehryGuggenheim Museum Bilbao

Bilbao · opened 18 October 1997 · the sculpture that ate a city’s reputation

Reconstruct the pitch meeting for a moment. It is the early nineties. Bilbao is a port city with dying shipyards, a poisoned river, serious unemployment and a security situation that kept tourism reliably elsewhere. The Basque authorities propose that the remedy is a franchise of a New York museum, built on the derelict docks, designed by a Californian known internationally for chain-link fencing and an unresolved personal thing about fish. And they will pay for it themselves: eighty-nine million dollars.

The commission itself was decided in three weeks. Guggenheim director Thomas Krens shortlisted three architects – Gehry, Arata Isozaki, Coop Himmelblau – handed each ten thousand dollars, and asked for a concept. Isozaki sent sketches of an elliptical, four-storey block. Coop Himmelblau proposed transparent cubes. Gehry sent something that looked like nothing anyone had asked for, and got the job.

By every reasonable standard this should have ended in a public inquiry. Instead it became the most imitated urban gesture of the century, and the taxes it generated covered the construction bill inside three years.

$89mconstruction cost€100min taxes, first three years4 millionvisitors, first three years1.3 millionvisitors in 2025

Read those four figures in sequence, because they are the entire reason every mayor on earth has since wanted a strange building. Within three years the museum had generated an estimated €500 million of economic activity and about €100 million in taxes – the building paid for itself and then started sending money home. Almost no piece of public architecture in history can produce that receipt. It is why the phrase “the Bilbao effect” exists and why it has been misapplied roughly once a month ever since.

The design myth – Gehry crumples paper, hands it to an engineer, engineer weeps – gets the direction of travel exactly backwards. His office did work obsessively in physical models. The reason those models became a building rather than a lawsuit is CATIA, software written for the aerospace industry and adapted by his team to digitise the model and hand fabricators surfaces they could genuinely produce. Every panel is a numbered, tolerance-checked object with somewhere to be. The building looks like it was assembled during an argument. It is in fact among the most disciplined objects of its decade: a jazz solo that took nine months to write out in full.

It looks improvised. It is the most disciplined thing on the river.

Then there is the skin, which is the finest story in twentieth-century cladding and almost nobody tells it properly. Gehry originally intended stainless steel. What stands there is 33,000 titanium sheets, four-tenths of a millimetre thick, sixty tonnes in total – titanium being an aerospace metal nobody had ever used on a building at that scale, for the excellent reason that it costs a fortune.

Titanium, close up – sub-millimetre sheets, each curved individually, overlapping like fish scales. Photo: Jules Verne Times Two, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Except that in the early 1990s, briefly, it didn't. The Soviet Union had built the Alfa-class attack submarine with a titanium hull; when Russia decommissioned the last of them, the metal flooded the world market and the price collapsed, undercutting stainless steel at precisely the moment Gehry was choosing a material. Which means the most photographed building of the late twentieth century is wrapped in decommissioned Cold War submarine stock. That shimmer over the Nervión is the peace dividend, rolled to 0.4 mm and bolted to a museum. No architectural historian would have dared invent it.

What Bilbao actually proved is more qualified than the export edition admits. The city also rebuilt its metro, cleaned the river, moved port functions downstream and ran a long, dull, properly funded regional plan into which the museum was inserted as the photogenic component. Cities that ordered the sculpture without the accompanying twenty years of work received a sculpture. Several received a very expensive empty sculpture – a lesson available free of charge and almost never taken.

My favourite thing about the building is the doorman. Guarding the entrance is Jeff Koons's Puppy: a twelve-metre West Highland terrier upholstered in live flowering plants, watered and gardened continuously so that it never goes bald. A titanium cathedral of the international avant-garde, defended by an enormous dog made of petunias. Bilbao understood the thing its imitators never did – the whole enterprise works far better when it declines to take itself entirely seriously.

Jeff Koons's Puppy on duty at the entrance – the avant-garde's least serious doorman. Photo: Jules Verne Times Two, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

02 Zaha Hadid ArchitectsHeydar Aliyev Center

Baku · opened 10 May 2012 · the floor that ran away up the wall

Zaha Hadid spent the first two decades of her fame as the most celebrated architect alive with almost nothing standing. She won Hong Kong's Peak competition in 1983 with paintings that looked like shattered glass caught in flight; unbuilt. She won Cardiff Bay Opera House in the mid-nineties and watched the funding dissolve beneath a campaign that had a great deal to say about her being difficult and nothing intelligent to say about the design. For years she was the profession's designated genius-in-waiting: brilliant, unbuildable, foreign, female – take your pick of which of those the committees were actually objecting to.

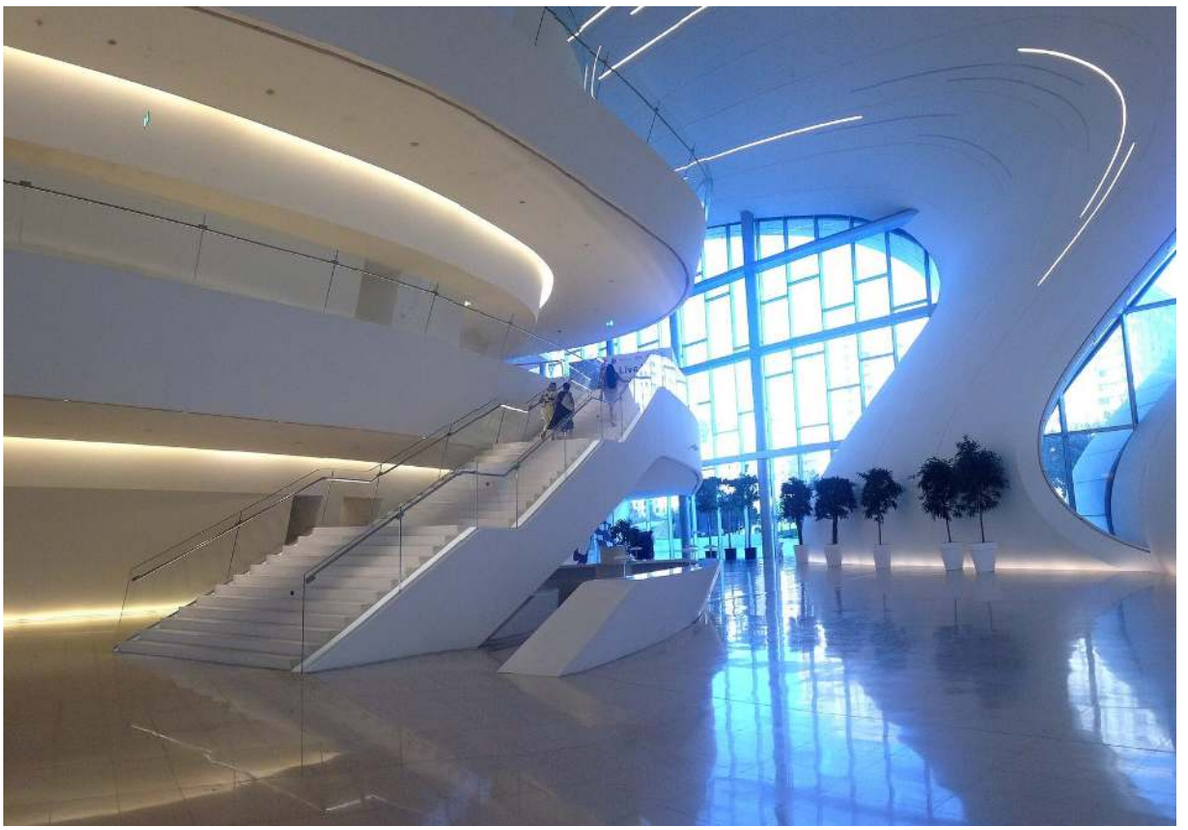
Baku is what happens when that imagination is finally handed a hillside and a quarter of a billion dollars.

Heydar Aliyev Center, Zaha Hadid Architects, 2012. Locate the wall – there isn't one. Photo: lumoplank, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

57,500 m²floor area over eight levels74 mat the crest of the fold1,000seats in the auditorium~$250mestimated cost

The move is single and absolute: take the ground, lift it, fold it over the auditorium and the library, bring it back down. Plaza, façade and roof are one continuous surface and the building flatly refuses to say where any of them begins. Nothing performs visible heroics – the structure is a space frame concealed behind the white skin, sweating quietly, while the architecture out front maintains that none of this required effort. It is the swan principle, executed across 57,500 square metres.

Then you go inside, which is where the imitators are exposed. Curving the outside is now easy; the tell is whether the geometry survives the front door, or whether you are handed a rectangular room with a suspended ceiling and a fire escape sign. Here the auditorium is carved from identical logic – oak flowing from balcony to ceiling with no joint anywhere confessing that several different trades were involved. Hadid had been painting rooms like this since the 1980s, when they existed only as canvases in group shows. In Baku the painting and the building are the same object, which very few architects in history have got to say.

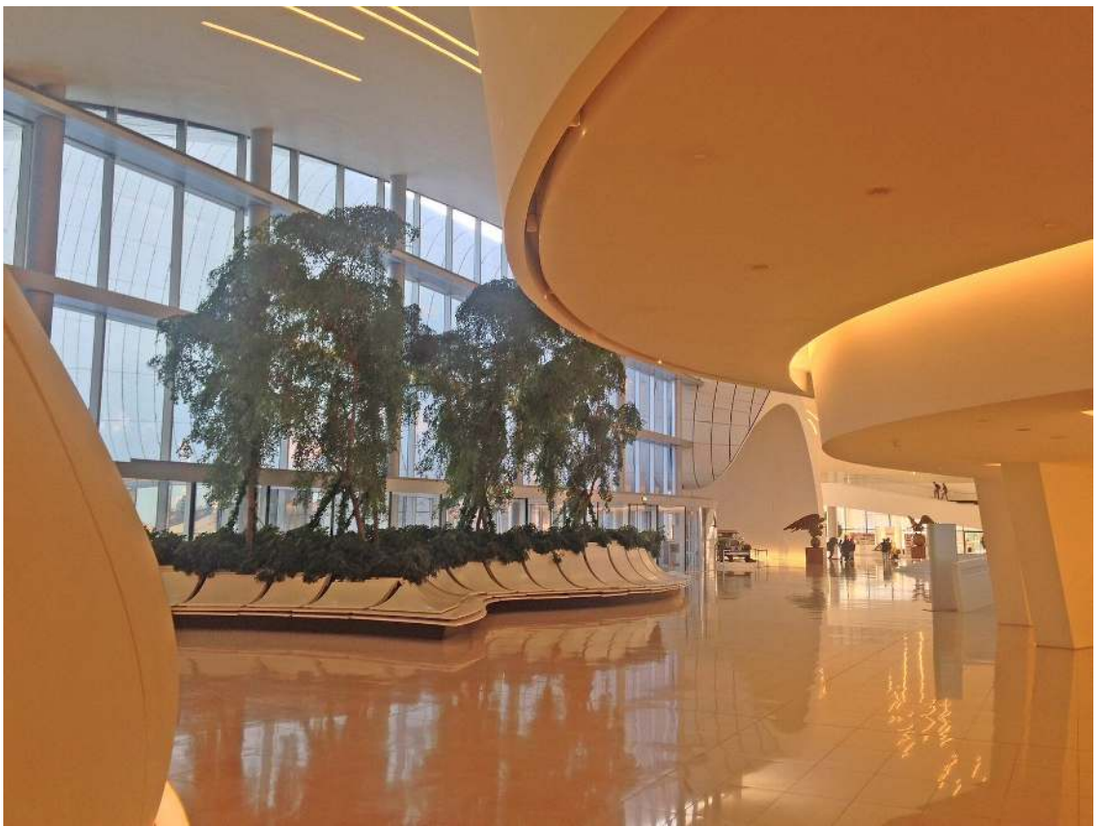


Inside the fold: stairs, balustrade and ceiling poured from the same continuous surface. Photo: Mahmoodrezamo, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

One thousand seats and not a right angle among them. Photo: Emin Allahverdi, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Now the paragraph the coffee-table books leave out. The building is named for the late president of Azerbaijan and was commissioned under the government of his son, who succeeded him in office. It belongs to a very old genre – the national culture palace as portrait of the ruling family – and it went up in a city being remade at speed, with residents in the wider redevelopment area reporting demolitions and evictions they had not agreed to. When London's Design Museum gave it Design of the Year in 2014, the prize arrived with a public argument attached, and the argument was not about the roof.

The swan-neck logic even extends to comfort. Tucked inside the folds are enclosed winter gardens several storeys tall, planted with real trees under glass, so the white curves have somewhere warm and green to land. It is an odd thing to grow indoors in a city built on oil rather than water – and it works precisely because nothing about the building apologises for the extravagance.



One of the enclosed winter gardens – real trees, under glass, inside the curve. Photo: Mahmoodrezamo, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Both things are true simultaneously, and the discomfort is the honest response rather than a failure of criticism. It is a masterpiece of surface geometry, probably the purest built expression of everything Hadid spent thirty years drawing. It is also a monument financed by an oil state to the father of its sitting president. A magazine that prints only the first sentence isn't publishing criticism, it is publishing a brochure – and the building is strong enough to survive being described accurately, which is more than most monuments manage.

03 Zaha Hadid ArchitectsGalaxy SOHO

Beijing · completed 2012 · four moons over the second ring road

Same office, same year, entirely different client: SOHO China, the developer run by Zhang Xin, which buys architecture the way other people buy watches – visibly, expensively, and with a clear understanding of what the signature does for resale. The brief was offices and retail on a major artery in central Beijing. The answer was four rounded volumes fused by bridges at several levels: 330,000 square metres across eighteen floors, with the space between them shaped into flowing courtyards instead of the customary windswept nothing developers leave between towers.

The bridges that fuse Galaxy SOHO's four volumes into one continuous route. Photo: Francesco Bini, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Galaxy SOHO, 2012. The gap between buildings – normally where the bins live – promoted to principal room. Photo: HoweyYuan, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

330,000 m²floor area – near six Heydar Aliyev Centers18floors67 mheight4fused volumes, bridged at several levels

The interiors are the genuine achievement and also the most quietly sinister thing in this essay. Balconies sweep past one another in unbroken bands; nothing squares off; the eye is never handed a corner where it can stop and rest. Stand on the third level and your gaze slides around the atrium like water going round a bath, and your feet follow, because that is what bodies do when the geometry keeps moving. It is genuinely beautiful. It is also, in retail terms, a machine engineered to stop you standing still long enough to decide you would rather go home.

Which brings us to the fight, and it was a real one. In 2013, when the building was nominated for the RIBA's Lubetkin Prize, the Beijing Cultural Heritage Protection Centre publicly objected, arguing that the development had "caused great damage to the preservation of the old Beijing streetscape, the original urban plan, the traditional hutong and courtyard houses, the landscape formation, and the style and colour scheme of Beijing's unique vernacular architecture." That is not a complaint about taste. It is a complaint about manners – a heritage body informing an international jury that the object under celebration had bulldozed the argument rather than won it.

And it lands, because a continuous, self-resolving geometry is superbly equipped to ignore whatever it happens to stand beside. A building made entirely of curves has no edges with which to meet anybody. It does not argue with the street; it declines to concede that the street was speaking. You can admire the object and still grant the point – I do both – and then notice the detail that settles it: everything generous about Galaxy

SOHO faces inward. The courtyards are lovely, and they are private. That is an accurate description of a great deal of twenty-first-century development, and it is not a compliment.

None of which stopped Galaxy SOHO winning the RIBA International Award that same year – the letter and the trophy arrived within months of each other. International juries and municipal heritage bodies were, and still are, answering two entirely different questions.

04 UNStudioMercedes-Benz Museum

Stuttgart · opened 19 May 2006 · the traffic diagram that grew a skin

Ben van Berkel and Caroline Bos do not begin with a shape. They begin with a problem in movement, draw the problem, and let the form be the consequence – which is why the practice is called UNStudio rather than something with two surnames on the door, and why this is the least self-indulgent building in this essay by a comfortable margin.

UNStudio won the competition for the site in 2001. The museum took five years to build – long enough that half of Stuttgart watched the trefoil rise out of a hole in the ground and had an opinion about it before a single car went on display.

The problem: Mercedes-Benz wants to tell two stories at once. The chronological one – here is 1886, here is the first automobile, keep walking through a century – and the thematic one, in which racing cars live with racing cars and delivery trucks with delivery trucks. Two narratives, one volume, and a visitor who will be justifiably furious if made to walk the first one twice to reach the second.

The answer is a double helix. Two ramps wind down through the building around a central void, never meeting, each carrying one of the stories, with crossings at every level. You ride to the top and descend. You may be a completist and take the century in order, or defect to the trucks whenever the mood strikes, and either way you are always going downhill and never lost. The plan is a cloverleaf of three overlapping circles with the middle removed – and the triangular atrium that produces is, quite deliberately, the shape of a Wankel rotary engine.

A shrine to the engine, in the shape of an engine, organised as a double helix. Corporate architecture is rarely this literate about itself.

16,500 m²of exhibition space4,800 m²the footprint it stands on160+vehicles on display800,245visitors in 2023

Hold the first two numbers against each other, because they contain the whole trick: 16,500 square metres of exhibition standing on a footprint of 4,800. The building is nearly three and a half times larger than the ground it occupies, and it manages that not by stacking flat plates but by winding a continuous ramp through the air, so circulation

and exhibition are the same square metre used twice. There is no wasted corridor anywhere in it. In a museum full of objects weighing as much as small buildings, it also means the twisting concrete has to span with almost nothing in the way of a bus.

So this is, technically, the hardest object in the group and the only one whose difficulty is entirely invisible. The showmanship went into the structure and none of it into the photograph, which is presumably why it has never had the magazine career of Bilbao or Baku and – I suspect – exactly how the engineers wanted it. Eight hundred thousand people a year walk down it without once wondering how it stands up. That is not a failure of the architecture. That is the highest compliment the discipline has to give.

05 MAD ArchitectsHarbin Opera House

Harbin · broke ground 2011, opened 2015 · a snowdrift you can buy tickets for

Ma Yansong worked in Hadid's office before founding MAD, and the inheritance is legible in every surface. What he added is an argument about where the curves come from. MAD's recurring claim is shanshui – mountain-water – that the Chinese building tradition is about landscape rather than object, and that architecture should behave like terrain instead of standing on it like a trophy. That is an easy thing to say in an interview and a hard thing to prove in aluminium. Harbin is the proof.

Consider the site. Harbin sits on the Songhua river in a province where winter is a six-month administrative fact, where the great annual festival is built from ice blocks sawn out of that same river, and where the temperature does things that make a Central European feel warmly towards his own miserable January. MAD gave it a low white mound in the wetland, clad entirely in white aluminium and read explicitly as a drift – a building at ease with snow because it is already shaped like snow. There are 470 parking spaces underneath it, because terrain is a metaphor and this is still China in 2015.

MAD won the project the ordinary way, for once: an open international competition in 2010, for a masterplan covering roughly 180 hectares of wetland along the Songhua – not just the theatre. The opera house is the one building from that plan the world actually looks at, but it was never meant to stand alone. It's the punctuation mark on a much longer sentence about the river.

1,600+seats in the grand theatre400seats in the studio theatre~79,000 m²building area0tickets required for the roof

That last figure is the one that earns my respect, and it isn't a joke. A public path is carved into the façade and climbs the outside of the building to a rooftop plaza anyone may walk up: no ticket, no performance, no dress code, nobody at the top checking whether you belong there. An opera house – the single most status-anxious building type in existence, a typology whose entire architectural history consists of staircases designed to be seen ascending – hands its best view to people who will never buy a seat. Every other opera house on earth spends its budget teaching you that the foyer is not for you. This one gives away the roof and asks for nothing.

Then you step inside and the temperature of the architecture changes completely. The main hall is lined in Manchurian ash, milled into surfaces that read as eroded rather than assembled; MAD have described the guiding image as a block of wood hollowed out by hand. After all that arctic aluminium, walking into that warm grain does somet-

hing almost physical – the pupils adjust, the shoulders drop. Ice outside, hearth inside. It is the oldest move in northern architecture, performed at the scale of a 1,600-seat theatre with a CNC mill.

That division of labour is the thing I keep returning to. Outside, curvature is climate. Inside, curvature is acoustics and warmth. Nowhere in the building is curvature merely curvature-because-it-photographs-well – and after two decades of buildings that were precisely that, the difference is not subtle. It is the difference between a form with a reason and a form with a publicist.

Afterwordwhat the curve costs

Twenty-five years on, the technology won and the rhetoric aged like milk. Nobody says "parametricism" aloud any more without a small apologetic cough. Doubly curved surfaces are ordinary industrial output; a competent mid-size practice can model, cost and procure one before lunch. The revolution succeeded so completely that it stopped being interesting, which is the customary fate of successful revolutions.

What has not become ordinary is keeping the results alive. A panelised skin is thousands of joints, and joints are where water goes to work. Sealant has a service life measured in years, not centuries, and 33,000 panels means 33,000 opportunities to be wrong. Masonry fails slowly and legibly – a stain, a crack, a conversation with a mason. A curved composite skin fails invisibly, then suddenly, then expensively. That invoice never appears next to the renderings, and it is the most reliable omission in architectural publishing.

Stone ages in public. Cladding just quietly stops being waterproof.

The second bill is urban, and much larger. A continuous surface is a closed argument: it resolves internally and leaves the street almost nothing to hold on to. Bilbao gets away with it by anchoring a waterfront that had nothing else and repaying its own construction cost in tax within three years. Harbin gets away with it by handing over the roof. Galaxy SOHO – on the evidence of the neighbourhood it landed in and the objection its own heritage body filed in public – does not. Curvature is not inherently generous or hostile. The only question that has ever mattered is whether the geometry left anywhere for the city to touch it.

So, a bet on which of these five reaches 2100 with its reputation intact. Stuttgart, because two stories genuinely needed to share one volume and a helix is the honest answer – the only building here whose shape could not be exchanged for a different one. Harbin, because a free public roof in a city that cold is a gift rather than a gesture. Bilbao survives on its receipts and its dog. The other two are magnificent, and magnificence, as any facilities manager will tell you, arrives with a maintenance schedule and a sealant contractor on speed dial.

None of which is an argument for returning to the filing cabinet. It is an argument for asking the question almost nobody asked between 1997 and 2015, in the euphoria of discovering that the software would let you draw anything at all: what is the curve for? Answer it honestly and you get Harbin, where the shape is the weather and the roof belongs to everybody. Fail to, and you get a spectacular photograph, a leak on the third floor, and a building that was better before it was finished.

Sources**Guggenheim Museum Bilbao** – the museum on its own building: areas, galleries and the titanium skin – guggenheim-bilbao.eus**Association for Project Management** – the project economics, and why titanium was briefly cheaper than steel – apm.org.uk**ArchDaily** – Heydar Aliyev Center – drawings, structure and project data – archdaily.com**Dezeen** – the open letter from Beijing's heritage body over the Lubetkin nomination, 2013 – dezeen.com**UNStudio** – Mercedes-Benz Museum – the trefoil plan and double-helix circulation, from the architects – unstudio.com**MAD Architects** – Harbin Opera House – building area, seating and the public rooftop route – i-mad.com-Photographs: freely licensed via Wikimedia Commons, each credited in its caption. ■

CRITICAL ESSAY AUGUST 15, 2026

Rooms That Watch You Back

Glass once promised freedom, honesty and light. Then the walls learned to collect data. An essay on transparent architecture, controlled visibility and the radical luxury of being allowed to disappear.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · CRITICAL ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Glass once promised freedom, honesty and light. Then the walls learned to collect data. An essay on transparent architecture, controlled visibility and the radical luxury of being allowed to disappear.

At night, every glass building changes allegiance. By day it borrows the sky and returns a clean image of the city. After dark the reflection collapses. Desks, lifts, kitchens and bodies appear in stacked rectangles, each room lit like evidence. A person working late becomes part of the elevation. Someone washing a glass becomes a moving detail in an architect's drawing. The promise was openness. The sensation is exposure.

There is a particular unease in spaces that refuse to keep a secret. You feel it in the lobby where the receptionist can see the lift before the lift can see the receptionist; in the meeting room whose glazed wall has been decorated with a polite stripe of frosting at eye level; in the apartment where the curtain is treated as an aesthetic failure. These interiors are beautiful, controlled and faintly accusatory. They suggest that privacy is something one requests after behaving suspiciously.

The promise of seeing everything

Modern glass arrived carrying a moral argument. Weightless walls would replace the defensive opacity of the old institution. Sunlight would enter the factory, the school and the office. Structure would become legible. Work would be visible, therefore honest. The Bauhaus Building in Dessau gave this faith an unforgettable body in 1926: a workshop wing wrapped in steel and crystal plate glass, its corners apparently dissolved, its rooms offered to the outside world as a continuous field of activity.

The workshop façade of the Bauhaus Building in Dessau. Glass makes the structure legible while turning work into a public image. Photo: Wikimedia Commons, public domain.

The façade was not merely a technical demonstration. It proposed a new social character. Transparency looked hygienic, collective, forward-moving. The wall no longer had to announce authority through stone; it could perform authority through apparent absence. This is the first trick of transparent architecture: the less material the boundary appears to contain, the easier it is to forget that the boundary still decides who may enter, who may look and who must remain visible.

A transparent wall does not abolish power. It edits the direction in which power can look.

A house with nowhere to hide

Philip Johnson's Glass House of 1949 is usually photographed as pure release: a dark steel frame, a brick cylinder and a glass perimeter placed with unnerving precision in the Connecticut landscape. The countryside seems to pass through the room. Furniture floats. Weather becomes wallpaper. Yet the house is less innocent than its photographs. To inhabit it is to accept that every domestic gesture has acquired an audience, even if that audience is only imagined.

Philip Johnson's Glass House, New Canaan, completed in 1949. The landscape appears to pass through the room, while the inhabitant remains permanently on display. Photo: Carol M. Highsmith / Library of Congress, public domain.

The crucial object is not the glass pavilion alone but its companion across the lawn: the Brick House. Opaque, heavy and private, it held bedrooms, services and the mechanical systems that supported the transparent icon. The two buildings operate like a split psyche. One performs clarity; the other absorbs sleep, plumbing, disorder and retreat. The Glass House can look effortless because the Brick House keeps the evidence offstage.

The body in the perfect frame

Mies van der Rohe's Farnsworth House sharpens the same question. Designed in 1945 and completed in 1951 for the physician Edith Farnsworth, the weekend house is raised above the Fox River floodplain as two white horizontal planes with a single transparent room suspended between them. The image is almost impossibly calm. In winter, bare branches continue through the glazing until the house seems less built than temporarily outlined.

Farnsworth House in winter, Plano, Illinois. The curtains are not a betrayal of the concept; they are evidence that a concept eventually meets a body. Photo: Carol M. Highsmith / Library of Congress, public domain.

The plan appears universal, but living is specific. Morning arrives from one direction. Clothing has to go somewhere. A person becomes ill, angry, tired or simply unwilling to perform the landscape. Shortly after moving in, Farnsworth added screens around the west porch. Later restoration removed them to recover the canonical 1951 image. The sequence is revealing: the occupant modified the masterpiece to make life more tolerable; preservation modified it again to make the masterpiece more legible.

This is not an argument against the house. It is an argument for reading its beauty without erasing the negotiation required to inhabit it. Architectural photography rewards the uninterrupted plane. Daily life produces interruptions: a curtain half drawn, a chair turned away from the view, condensation at the edge of a pane. Those marks are not visual noise. They are the resident writing back.

Inside the Glass House, furniture and landscape share one visual plane. The circular brick core is the only solid interruption. Photo: Carol M. Highsmith / Library of Congress, public domain.

This arrangement reveals a truth that contemporary interiors often conceal: transparency is never complete. It is curated. The cable is hidden, the storage wall is closed, the back office has no window, the camera is black and small. What looks like openness is usually a redistribution of opacity. Someone gets the glass view; someone else manages what must not appear in it.

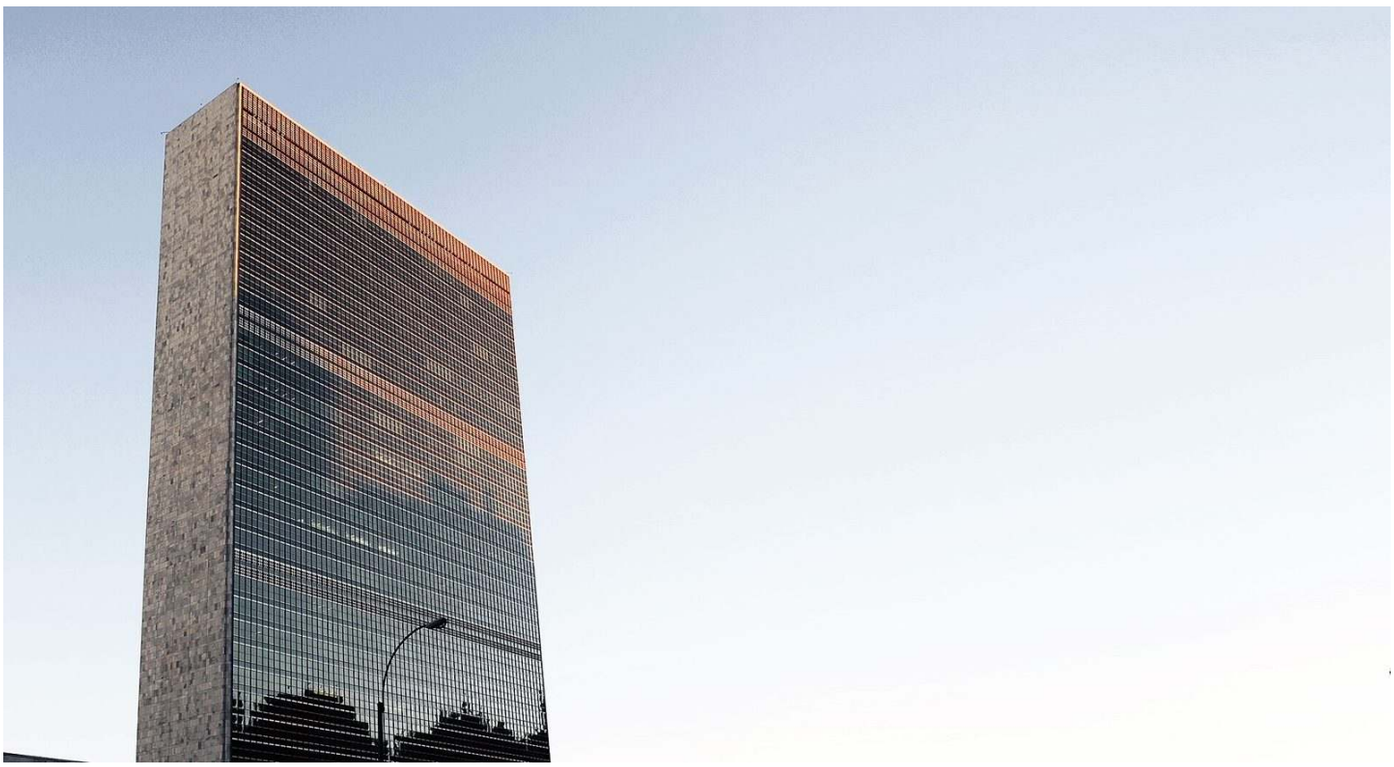
The corporation discovers a face

By the middle of the twentieth century, glass had become corporate grammar. Lever House in New York, completed by Skidmore, Owings & Merrill in 1952, replaced the masonry weight of the commercial block with a blue-green curtain wall and a raised slab hovering above a public plaza. The building looked precise, clean and almost frictionless. It made administration photogenic. The company could be understood as a cool surface rather than a room full of decisions.

The institution as immaculate image

The United Nations Secretariat Building made the symbolism explicit. When its blue-green glazed slab rose beside the East River in 1950, transparency could stand for an institution willing to expose its workings to the world. The façade offered a moral picture

before it offered information: international order as a luminous grid, bureaucracy transformed into light.



The United Nations Secretariat Building at sunset. The curtain wall turns an institution into a single luminous image while individual rooms remain unreadable. Photo: Daryan Shamkhali, CC0.

From the street, however, the grid performs equality by making every bay appear equivalent. Inside, rooms differ in access, security and influence. The curtain wall flattens those distinctions into one consistent skin. That is the political seduction of the glass tower: it can represent openness without surrendering hierarchy. You see the organisation everywhere and its decisions nowhere.

Lever House on Park Avenue: the curtain wall turns corporate organisation into an abstract, immaculate skin. Photo: Seth Tisue, CC BY-SA 2.0.

This is where transparency becomes branding. A glazed headquarters says: nothing is hidden here. But the statement is visual, not procedural. You can see people walking behind the façade without seeing how authority moves between them. The transparent building offers access to bodies and withholds access to systems. It is possible to watch an entire floor at work and learn nothing about what the work is doing.

When the building starts taking notes

The smart office completes the transition from window to interface. At The Edge in Amsterdam, employees use an app to locate colleagues, find desks and adjust local lighting or temperature, while sensors monitor occupancy, movement, humidity, carbon dioxide, light and climate. The design is genuinely useful. Rooms can respond to demand; energy is not spent pretending that an empty floor is occupied. Comfort becomes precise.

But precision has a shadow. Once a building knows where a person sits, how long a room is used and which route fills after lunch, space becomes behavioural data. The employee no longer moves through a neutral container. The container records movement, predicts demand and quietly defines what counts as normal. No villain needs to sit behind a wall of monitors. The unease comes from the fact that the system can be efficient, pleasant and invasive at the same time.

Reflections multiply the office façade into an uncertain field of interior, exterior and observer. Photo: Dietmar Rabich, CC BY-SA 4.0.

> The most persuasive surveillance architecture does not look punitive. It looks convenient. It remembers your preferred light level, opens the correct door and suggests the nearest desk. Control arrives dressed as service.

Designing the right to disappear

The answer is not a sentimental return to thick walls and tiny windows. Opacity can protect, but it can also isolate and intimidate. The more interesting task is to design adjustable visibility: spaces that allow a person to decide when to appear, when to blur and when to vanish. Privacy should behave less like a bunker and more like a dimmer.

Transparency without the interrogation

SANAA's Glass Pavilion at the Toledo Museum of Art offers a more ambiguous model. Its transparent walls do not simply divide interior from exterior. More than 360 large panels, many of them curved, form rooms inside rooms. Reflections overlap with silhouettes; a person appears, disappears behind a bend and returns as a pale double in another surface. Visibility is continuous but never stable.

Inside SANAA's Glass Pavilion, Toledo Museum of Art. Curved walls make visibility layered and uncertain rather than total. Photo: Kiko 2709 / Adam C Nelson, CC BY-SA 3.0.

The difference is subtle but important. A straight glazed partition behaves like a diagram: here, there, observed, observer. Curved glass introduces delay and error. It gives the eye too much information to master at once. The architecture remains open, yet the body is not pinned to a single field of vision. Openness becomes atmospheric rather than disciplinary.

This suggests a richer brief for contemporary design. Do not ask only how much daylight or visual connection a partition can deliver. Ask what kind of relationship the pane produces. Who receives the first view? Can the person inside anticipate an approach? Does reflection protect or expose after dark? Can the surface change state without summoning facilities management? The ethical quality of transparency lives in these small asymmetries.

This changes the status of ordinary elements. A curtain is no longer decoration but a user-controlled façade. Ribbed glass transmits light while refusing a complete image. A deep reveal lets someone stand near a window without becoming a display. A turn in a corridor delays the view by one second, enough to replace surprise with consent. Acoustic absorption prevents transparency of sound even where visual connection is useful. A warm pool of local light can make a desk feel inhabited without illuminating the entire room.

Good spatial privacy is not the absence of contact. It is the ability to modulate contact without asking permission from the building. The best rooms offer several states between exposed and sealed: visible, silhouetted, reflected, screened, withdrawn. They recognise that human attention is not an unlimited public resource.

The radical luxury of the next interior may be simple: a room that notices you without reporting you.

The last lit window

Glass remains irresistible because it turns architecture into weather. It catches clouds, dissolves corners and lets a room borrow a horizon. None of that beauty is false. The mistake is to confuse visual openness with ethical openness, or technical intelligence with care. A building can reveal its structure and still conceal its politics. It can know exactly where you are and understand nothing about what you need.

The city after midnight makes this contradiction visible. Towers become grids of private scenes; transparent homes become lanterns; the office continues to glow for nobody. Somewhere behind one pane, a person reaches for a switch. The room goes dark. For a moment the façade loses a piece of information. That small disappearance feels less like retreat than control. ■

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FURTHER

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ESSAY AUGUST 29, 2026

Soft Modernism: Bryn and Ellefsen's Physics Building at Blïndern

They won the competition with a Roman temple, went to look at what Europe was building, and came home to strip their own drawing bare. What stands at Blindern is functionalism that kept the brass, the colour and the curve.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · ESSAY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

They won the competition with a Roman temple, went to look at what Europe was building, and came home to strip their own drawing bare. What stands at Blindern is functionalism that kept the brass, the colour and the curve.

The story modernism tells about itself is a story of conversion: the young architect sees the new work, throws out the mouldings and never looks back. Fysikkbygningen at Blindern is that story with the receipts attached, because both halves of it survive on paper. Finn Bryn and Johan Ellefsen won the University of Oslo competition in 1926 with a Roman temple: a columned facade in the centre, a round vestibule ringed by galleries, a dome on top, all of it in red brick and granite. Then they went to Germany, France and the Netherlands to see what was being built, came back and took their own drawing apart.

The physics building seen from the open field, Oslo, early 1950s. Photographer unknown, National Library of Norway, public domain

What they kept was the symmetry and the materials. What went was everything that made the building an argument about Rome. The tall windows dropped, the dome and the temple front disappeared, and the facade was regrouped into the harder geometry that stands there now. The building was finished in 1935 and opened in 1936, ten years after they won it, which means the design that made their reputation was quietly demolished by its own authors somewhere between the competition and the scaffolding.

It helps to remember what Blindern was at the time. Not a campus: a farm. The university had bought agricultural land north-west of the city and was moving out of its neoclassical quarter downtown, and the first buildings stood in a meadow with a dirt track running past them. There was no context to answer to, only a field, a brief and a decade that believed a building should be honest about its purpose.

The approach to the physics building, late 1940s. National Library of Norway, public domain · The same front in 2009, with the garden grown in. Photograph: Kjetil Ree, CC BY-SA 3.0

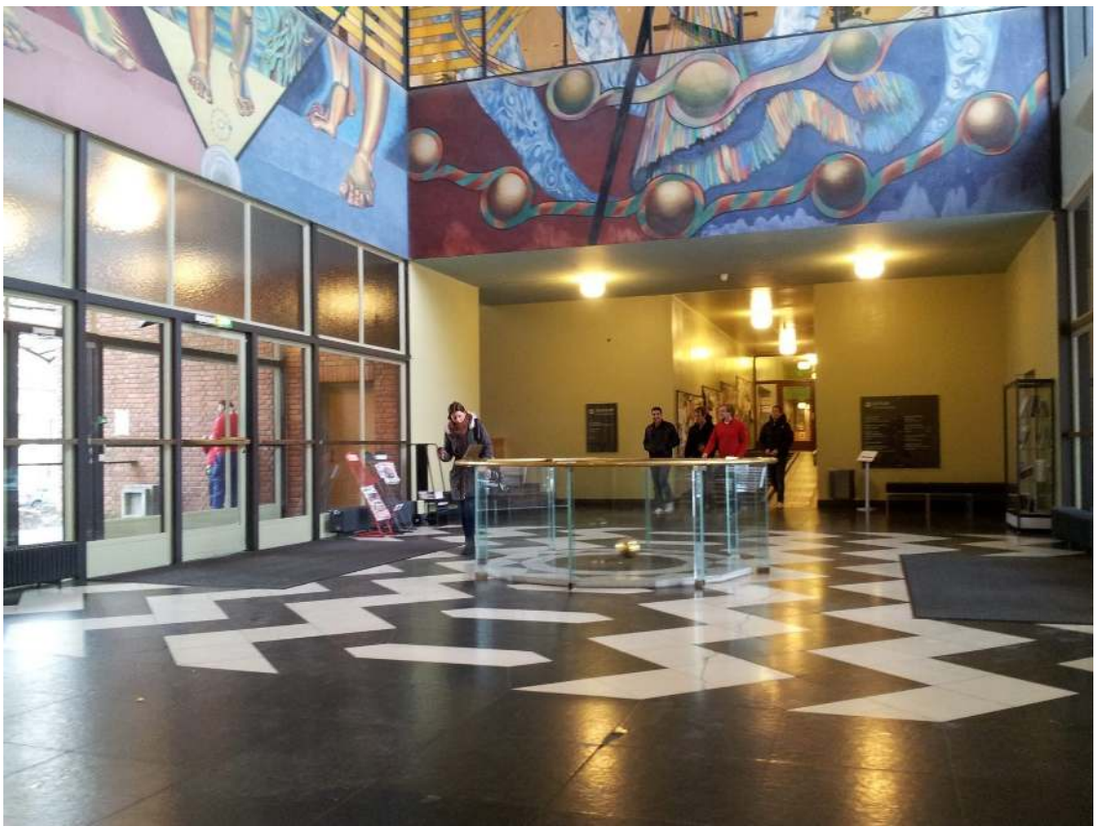
Even stripped, the building reads as civic architecture rather than as a laboratory. A central tower rises out of a long horizontal block, its top floor cut open by a continuous band of glazing, and the brick is laid dark and warm rather than rendered white. Norwegian functionalism arrived through Sweden and Denmark rather than direct from Dessau, and it arrived softened: less manifesto, more craft, willing to keep the material a country already knew how to build with. Bryn and Ellefsen had been in partnership since 1922 and would go on to design the Norwegian pavilion for the 1939 World's Fair in New York.

Nedre Blindern from the air, around 1955. Photograph: Fjellanger-Wideroe, Oslo Museum, CC BY-SA 4.0 · The same ground in 2015, with the city grown around it. Photograph: GAD, CC BY-SA 4.0

The plan is disciplined where discipline pays. A physics faculty in the 1930s needed vibration-free floors, long service runs, blackout rooms and a lecture hall that could seat a generation of students, and the building solves all of it with the efficiency the period demanded. It housed chemistry too, until that institute moved out in the 1960s and the name shortened to the one it carries now. Then, at the point where circulation happens, where people actually meet the building, the geometry loosens. Stairs sweep rather than turn. Handrails are brass. Ceilings lift. Colour appears where a purist would have left plaster.

The glazed stair volume on the garden side, held in Virginia creeper. Photograph: Punkmorten, public domain

The vestibule is the whole argument in miniature, and it is the one room where the demolished 1926 scheme still shows through. Bryn and Ellefsen had promised a domed rotunda; what they built instead is a double-height hall with a black and white zigzag floor, closer to a 1930s ocean liner than to a laboratory, opening on both sides so that the space worked as a public passage between Majorstuen and the campus rather than as a lobby.



The vestibule, looking towards the entrance. Photograph: Mysteriumen, CC BY-SA 3.0

Through the middle of it hangs a Foucault pendulum: a gilded ball bearing twenty centimetres across and weighing thirty-two kilograms, on a wire of 14.1 metres. Foucault's original in Paris in 1851 was a 28-kilogram weight on 67 metres of wire, the first demonstration in a room rather than a sky that the earth turns. At Oslo's latitude of sixty degrees north the plane of the swing takes 27 hours and 43 minutes to come back round. It is a working instrument and a piece of interior design at once, the one object here that explains the discipline housed in the building without a single word.

The brass bob, the brass rail and the explanatory plate, over the star-cut stone floor. Photograph: Bernt Rostad, CC BY 2.0 · The same bob in 2005, with the ring marking the swing. Photograph: Mads Bodker, CC BY 2.0

Above it, across three walls around the main entrance, Per Lasson Krohg painted 260 square metres of fresco with glass inlays and painted glass. He won that competition in 1935, the year the building was finished, and the work was completed in the autumn of 1938, paid for by the consul general Peter Krag. It is called Atomet i verdensrommet, the atom in space: the sun and the planets ringed by galaxies drawn as a woman and a man, with the aurora running through the composition. Krohg would later paint the mural in the United Nations Security Council chamber in New York.

Atomet i verdensrommet, Per Krohg, completed 1938, on the eastern wall. Photograph: Bernt Rostad, CC BY 2.0

Note what that means for the chronology. The classical scheme was abandoned in the late twenties as too decorative for the new century, and then, with the functionalist building standing finished, the university ran a competition to cover its entrance in painted cosmology and hung a brass weight in the middle of it. The glazing bars of the stair window cut straight through the picture. The grid and the painting hold each other rather than compete, and the conservators from NIKU who cleaned the work in 2015 were maintaining something no purist reading of the 1930s can quite account for.

That is the reason the building still teaches something. The heroic version of the decade asks a structure to be honest, and honesty gets understood as bareness. Fysikkbygningen accepts every functional demand of its brief, drops its own columns to do so, and then treats warmth, colour and curvature as functional demands too, on the grounds that the people inside are also part of the programme. Nearly a century on, with the creeper turning scarlet over the entrance each October and the pendulum still swinging, it looks less like a compromise with modernism than a correction to it.

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ESSAY SEP 5, 2026

Neobarocco: Five Buildings That Confess What They Want You to Believe

No seventeenth-century architect ever had to build a case for absolute power. The power was already absolute, and the architecture only had to make it beautiful. Today's patrons aren't so lucky. A state that isn't sure of its own legitimacy, a brand selling heritage it never had, a city that needs the world to stop laughing at it: each has hired a very different architect to do Bernini's old job. Five buildings, five confessions.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

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Nobody in Hamburg asked for the Elbphilharmonie to be beautiful. For most of a decade they asked, loudly and in print, for it to stop. A concert hall budgeted in 2001 at €77 million and meant to open in 2010 crept to €114 million by 2005, to €241 million when the schedule slipped again in 2007, past €450 million after the construction contract was renegotiated in 2008, past €500 million by 2012, and finally opened in January 2017 at a confirmed €866 million, on top of a squat 1960s brick warehouse that had spent those same years gutted down to its four outer walls while the number kept climbing. Herzog & de Meuron's answer to a decade of civic fury was not an apology. It was a curved glass crown, faceted like sea ice, that catches the harbor and the sky in whatever light happens to be passing, and does the one thing an over-budget public building is never supposed to manage. It makes the argument about the money evaporate the moment you actually look at it. Within a year, the same city that had wanted somebody fired was posting sunset photographs of the thing.

That is not resilience. That is a very old trick, running on new material, and it worked exactly as designed. A building that makes you feel something is true before you have had time to ask whether it was a good idea: Bernini would have recognized the move on sight, and would not have been remotely surprised that it worked twice.

Inside the Elbphilharmonie: the curved escalator tube rising toward the Großer Saal. · Photo: Arths-at / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

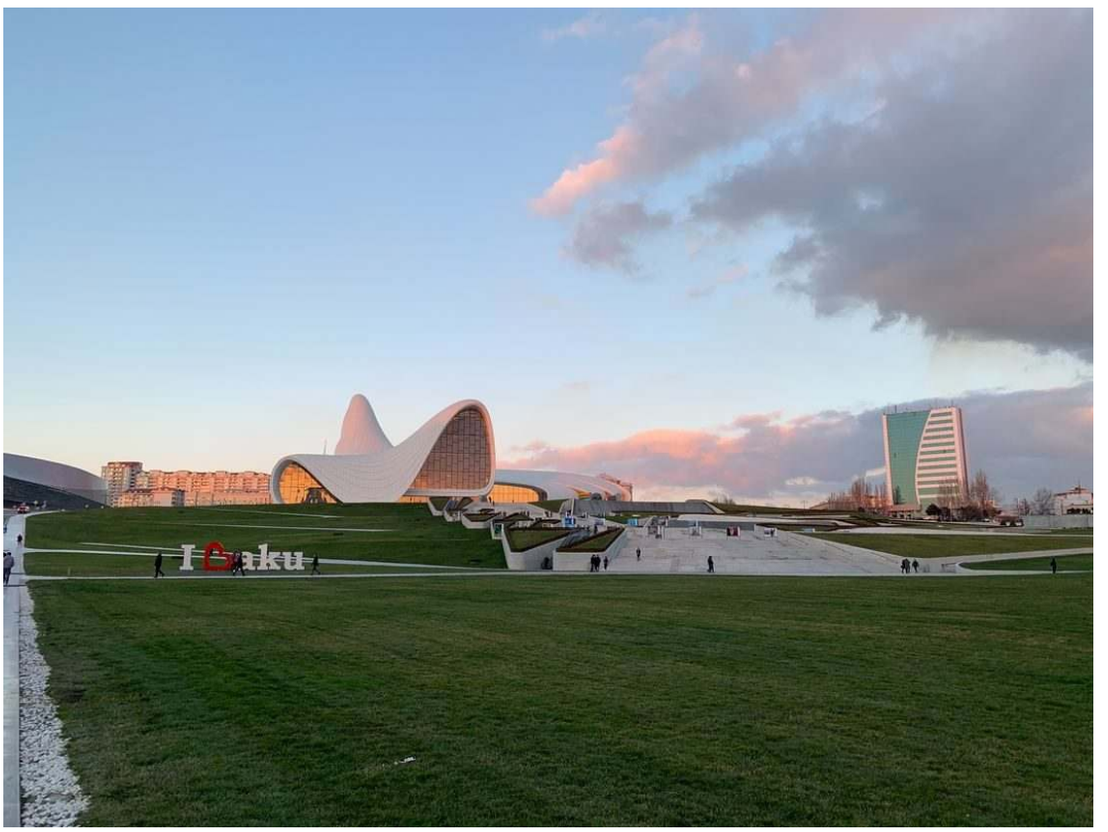
What the word meant before it became a compliment

"Baroque" gets thrown around now as a synonym for ornate, curved, expensive: an adjective for a feeling, not a claim about how a building actually works. The historical style was a great deal more specific, and a great deal more useful as a lens than the loose modern usage suggests.

Take the single clearest demonstration of it: Bernini's Cornaro Chapel in Santa Maria della Vittoria, finished in 1652. At its center, the marble *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa* shows the saint mid-vision, an angel about to drive a golden arrow through her, her whole body gone slack with a pain she described as indistinguishable from the love of God. Bernini did not simply carve a sculpture and set it in a niche. He cut a hidden window into the wall above the group and ran gilded bronze rods down through the marble like frozen sunlight, so that real daylight and sculpted light arrive at the same figure at once. On either side, members of the Cornaro family are carved leaning out of what are unmistakably theater boxes, watching the ecstasy the way an audience watches a stage. Architecture, sculpture, hidden engineering and stage lighting are fused into a single continuous event with no seam anywhere between the craft and the persuasion. Art historians have a term for exactly this ambition, *bel composto*, the beautiful whole, and it describes something considerably more disciplined than "ornate."

So the useful question about anything called neo-baroque today has nothing to do with curves. It is: who commissioned the disappearing act, and what exactly were they hoping the audience would feel before it had the chance to examine the argument underneath.

Zaha Hadid, Baku: the argument is the country



Heydar Aliyev Center, Baku. Zaha Hadid Architects with Werner Sobek, 2012. · Photo: Robot8A / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

The Heydar Aliyev Center has no facade, no roofline, no wall in the ordinary sense: plaza and building are one continuous white skin, roughly 39,100 square meters of it plus another 9,000 of plaza, that lifts off the ground, folds through the interior and lies back down on the far side. Werner Sobek's office engineered the whole envelope from around 15,000 individually curved fiber-reinforced panels, no two alike, some as long as seven meters, without a single straight structural line doing the actual work of holding the thing up. Zaha Hadid built it in open opposition to the Soviet concrete still standing across Baku: block after honest, humorless block asserting permanence through mass. The Center asserts the opposite: a young petrostate telling the world, in one unbroken gesture, that it has moved on. The Architectural Review's verdict on first contact was that the building is “a shock to the system,” which is precisely the effect a persuasive building is built to produce.

The Center was originally budgeted at around $250 million for 57,500 square meters, a number that still puts it among the most expensive buildings ever raised per square foot, on a site cleared, according to Human Rights Watch, by force: roughly 250 homes

removed to make room for the gesture. Put those two facts beside the white curve in any photograph and the building stops reading as architecture and starts reading as what it actually is: a receipt for how much a country will spend, and who it will move, to make sure the world watches it curve instead of asking why.

Inside the Center: the same unbroken curve continues into the concert hall. · Photo: Eminn / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Calatrava, Valencia: the skeleton performing innocence

City of Arts and Sciences, Valencia. Santiago Calatrava, 1998–2005. · Photo: Cateecatee / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0

Nothing in the City of Arts and Sciences needs to look the way it looks. A planetarium does not require ribs. A science museum does not need to resemble the picked-clean skeleton of a whale, which is exactly what Calatrava's Museu de les Ciències resembles, on purpose, across two kilometers of Valencia's drained Turia riverbed. This is engineering doing a painted ceiling's job: performing an illusion of structural necessity where there was only choice, the same way Baroque fresco performs a hole in a flat surface opening onto open sky.

It is gorgeous. It is also, in the most literal sense, a magic trick that started coming apart. A complex estimated at roughly €300 million landed near €1.1 billion, with Calatrava's own fees for the project alleged at around €100 million on top, a pattern repeating itself closely enough across his career, from Valencia to Venice to a transit hub built over the ruins of the World Trade Center, that the press settled on calling him "the world's most hated architect." In 2013, ceramic tiles began detaching from the roof and mosaic facade of the Palau de les Arts opera house at the complex's center; by mid-2014 the regional government had filed suit against Calatrava's firm over the defects. The skeleton, it turned out, was shedding its skin. Someone always pays extra for the sky to look this open: first in the invoice, and later, it seems, in the roof.

Inside the Palau de les Arts: the same structural drama, indoors and unpainted. · Photo: Kippelboy / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0

Neo-baroque architecture is not a style. It is what a client pays for when the truth alone will not get the reaction they need.

Ma Yansong, Harbin: the one building here that owes Rome nothing

Harbin Opera House. MAD Architects (Ma Yansong), 2015. · Photo: EditQ / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Every essay like this one risks smuggling in an unstated assumption: that the appetite for movement and illusion under discussion is a European inheritance, waiting somewhere to be exported. The Harbin Opera House refuses the premise outright. Ma Yansong has described the building as shaped by wind and water rather than by any Italian precedent: white aluminum panels sweeping across the wetlands beside the Songhua River on the outside, a warm, wind-eroded mass of Manchurian ash inside the main hall, the whole thing closer to a mountain range dissolving into mist in a Song dynasty scroll than to anything Bernini ever touched. MAD won the international competition for the surrounding Harbin Cultural Island in 2010; the opera house itself, roughly 850,000 square feet of it, opened in December 2015 to a city better known internationally, until then, for winter ice sculpture festivals than for architecture.

It belongs in this company anyway, and that is the point worth sitting with. The instinct this essay is tracking, fuse a building into one continuous sensation, argue through the body before the mind gets a vote, is not a Roman export. It surfaces wherever an architect has the tools, a client willing to fund wonder rather than only shelter, and a visual tradition of their own to spend that funding on. Harbin owes the Vatican nothing. It still speaks the same underlying language, fluently, in an accent entirely its own.

Peter Marino: the one who stopped pretending

Hadid, Calatrava and Ma each arrive at a Baroque effect by other means and other materials, translating the seventeenth century's tools of persuasion into fiberglass, structural steel, aluminum. Peter Marino skips the translation and imports the source text directly. Since the early 1980s his flagship stores for Chanel and Dior have set genuine eighteenth-century bronzes and actual Venetian mirrors against blunt, contemporary architectural shells, on purpose, and by his own account with some relish: he has spoken about how rarely anyone dares put something fully modern next to something fully Baroque, and about the collision being the entire exercise, not an accident of taste. The 2004 Chanel tower in Tokyo's Ginza district takes the house's signature black-and-white tweed and detonates it across an entire glazed facade at architectural scale. The reworked Dior flagship on Avenue Montaigne in Paris wraps the boutique itself in a two-thousand-square-meter museum and three private gardens, in case the point somehow wasn't landing already.

This is the case that makes the essay's real question impossible to keep dodging politely. A handbag does not require eighteenth-century provenance to function as a handbag. The bronzes and the mirrors are there to argue, silently and at considerable expense, that the object for sale is heir to a grandeur the brand behind it did not actually inherit: it purchased the props and installed them under gallery lighting, the way a museum installs a period room. Marino is the only architect in this set who is not hiding that this is what he is doing. Whether that honesty is the most respectable thing about his work, or the most cynical, does not seem like a question with room for a third answer.

30 Avenue Montaigne, Paris, 2016, before Marino's 2022 renovation, the same address already staging its own excess directly on the street. · Photo: Frédéric BISSON / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.0

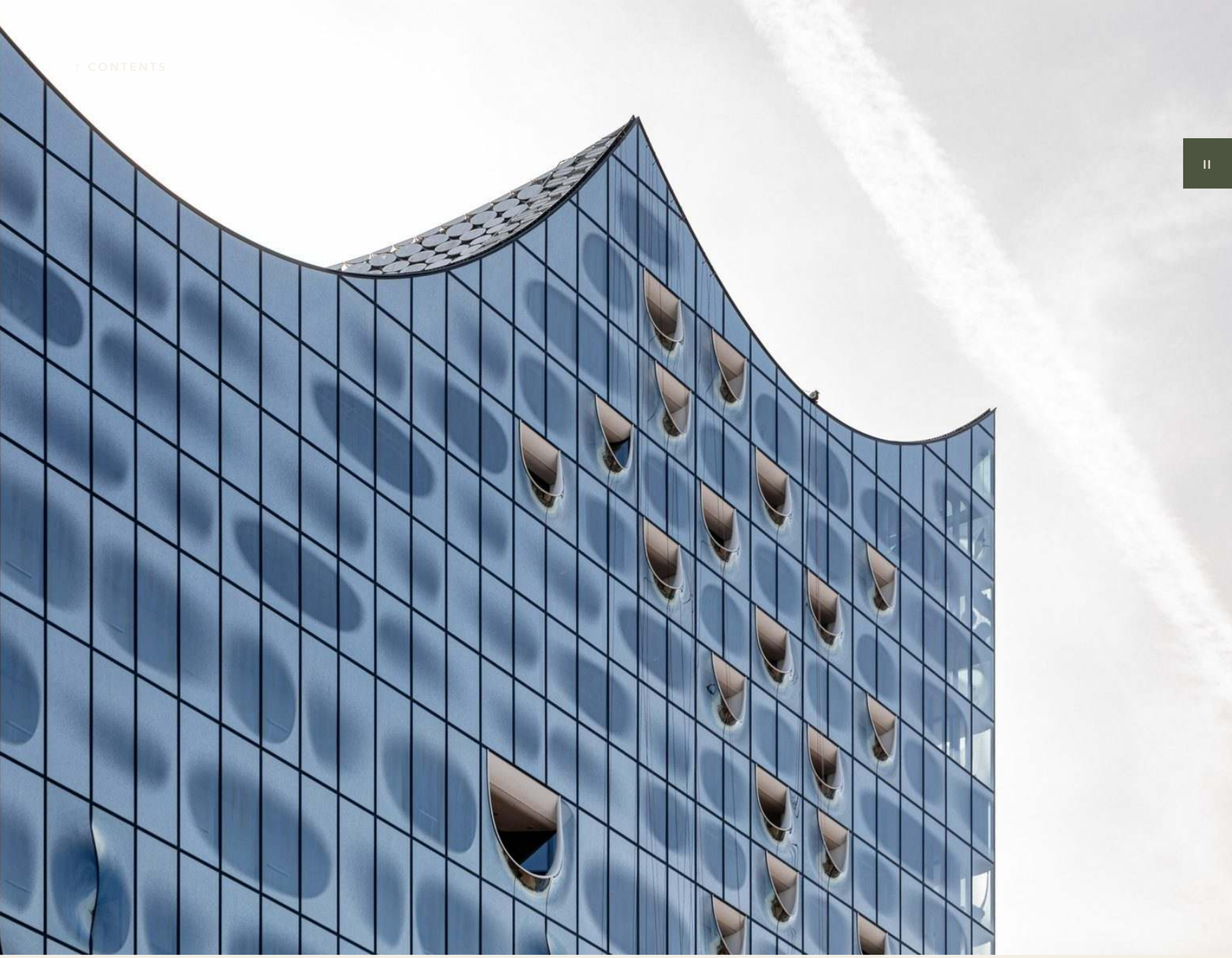
Where the word stops being useful

Not everything curved and expensive has earned the comparison, and it is worth refusing the lazy version of it on principle. A building deserves “neo-baroque” when its movement and illusion are doing real rhetorical work: arguing for a state's legitimacy, or a brand's inherited weight, or a city's right to stop being laughed at. A building that simply runs parametric software to arrive at an unusual silhouette, with nothing riding on the shape beyond novelty, is not neo-baroque. It is just curved, and calling it baroque performs the same flattening the word already suffers everywhere from real-estate listings to Instagram captions.

What earns these five their place is not a family resemblance of surface. It is that each is trying to make a viewer feel an argument before they have had the chance to interrogate it, in the exact visual grammar the seventeenth century invented for that specific purpose, which three and a half centuries of intervening architecture mostly tried, and largely failed, to argue its way out of.

Bernini never had to build a case for the Pope's authority. The authority was already absolute; the architecture only had to make it beautiful. Nobody commissioning a building today has that luxury, which is exactly why digital fabrication's cheap, borrowed freedom of form keeps ending up in the hands of clients who need an audience feeling something before it starts asking questions: a state without a settled story about itself, a brand selling a history it bought rather than lived, a city that would rather be phot-

ographed than interrogated. The style survived the collapse of absolute power by outliving the thing it was built to defend. What is left standing is the technique, and the technique, it turns out, does not need to believe in anything at all in order to work. ■



ESSAY SEPTEMBER 8, 2026

Built to a Score: Three Buildings Where Music Wrote the Architecture

Most buildings host music: a stage, walls, a program, good acoustics. A handful of buildings do something stranger, and let a piece of music design them outright, or let the problem of holding sound decide everything from the roof down to the seats. Three buildings, three different bargains between the two disciplines.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

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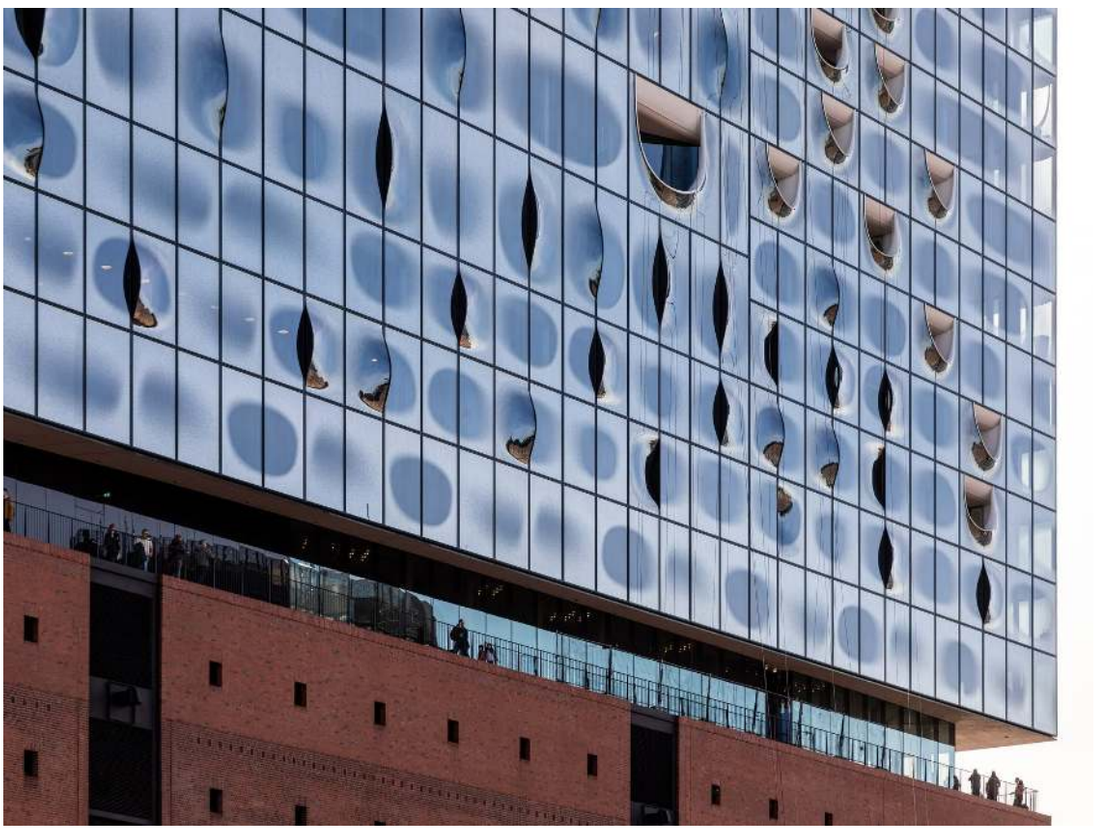
In 1958, Le Corbusier's studio built a pavilion for Philips at the Brussels World's Fair that had no straight walls at all: nine curved concrete shells, tent-like and pointed, standing over a single dark hall built for eight minutes of music. The shape did not come from a sketch of a building. It came from a piece of music.

The shells were the work of Iannis Xenakis, a composer working as an engineer in Le Corbusier's atelier, and their geometry traces back to his orchestral piece Metastaseis (1953-54). Xenakis had scored a passage for forty-six string instruments sliding continuously between pitches, glissando lines drawn as straight lines on paper that, taken together, described curved surfaces: what a mathematician would call a ruled surface, and what an engineer would recognise as a hyperbolic paraboloid. Xenakis modelled the pavilion's walls the same way he had modelled the glissandi, string and stiff wire standing in for sound. The building is, in a fairly literal sense, a piece of music built at architectural scale.

The Philips Pavilion at Expo 58, Brussels: nine concrete shells, each one a ruled surface of the kind Xenakis had drawn as glissandi. Photo: Anefo, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons.

Inside, some 350 loudspeakers set into those walls spatialised Edgard Varèse's Poème électronique, an eight-minute tape piece routed live around the audience by technicians at a control desk, timed to shifts of coloured light. The pavilion was demolished on 30 January 1959, three months after the fair closed, its purpose used up with the event that paid for it. What survives is the method: music read not as a soundtrack for a room, but as a set of instructions for building one.



Elbphilharmonie, Hamburg: the glass upper storeys, each pane curved or cut, sitting directly on the brick of the Kaispeicher warehouse. Photo: Dietmar Rabich, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons. · Photo: Dietmar Rabich, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Nearly sixty years later, Herzog & de Meuron's Elbphilharmonie in Hamburg, opened 11 January 2017, made the opposite bargain: instead of letting music generate the building's form, it let the requirements of hearing music decide almost everything else. Acoustician Yasuhisa Toyota laid the main hall out as a vineyard, terraces of seating climbing around a central stage in the manner Hans Scharoun had used for the Berlin Philharmonie in 1963, so that no listener among 2,100 sits more than 30 metres from the conductor. The hall's inner surface, some 10,000 individually milled gypsum-fibre panels, is cut with a different profile at every point to scatter sound evenly rather than let it collect in one place. The whole structure floats on 362 spring bearings, mechanically isolated from the building around it so that a passing train never reaches the stage. Above a converted brick warehouse, the concert hall's glass upper storeys read from outside as a wave, or a crown. From inside the hall, that image is almost beside the point: the room's actual job is acoustic, and its shape is a diagram of that job.

Casa da Música, Porto: one of the folded concrete planes, with the corrugated glass that lights the hall behind it. Photo: Dale Cruse, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons. · Photo: John Samuel, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Rem Koolhaas and Ellen van Loon's OMA took a third position with Casa da Música in Porto, opened in 2005. The office wanted to avoid the concert hall's standard shoebox shape, tried alternatives, and measured them against the shoebox on acoustics it could not beat. So OMA kept the box and hid it: a rectangular hall seating around 1,200, glazed at both ends, sits inside an irregular white polyhedron that looks folded rather than built, as if the shoebox had been quarried out of a single asymmetric block. The shape the building wears on the outside has no obvious logic until you know there is a straight, acoustically correct room sitting inside it, and that everything faceted and irregular on the exterior is the architecture finding a public form for a decision it was not free to make.

Three buildings, three different relationships to the same problem. Xenakis let a piece of music become a roof. Toyota and Herzog & de Meuron let the physics of hearing dictate a room, then wrapped a building around the result. Koolhaas kept the one shape acoustics insists on and spent the rest of the building arguing with it. None of the three is really about music in architecture. They are about what happens when a discipline that runs on sequence and proportion is allowed to give orders to one that runs on load and material, or is made to answer to it instead.

Photographs: cover, Elbphilharmonie on its opening night, 11 January 2017, Alexander Svensson (CC BY 2.0); Philips Pavilion, Anefo (CC0); Elbphilharmonie facade, Dietmar Rabich (CC BY-SA 4.0); Casa da Música, Dale Cruse (CC BY 4.0). All via Wikimedia Commons. ■

STUDIO PROFILE SEP 15, 2026

Architecture That Listens

How multi-layered context shapes identity across three projects by US Architecture Studio, from a steppe town, through rolling hills, to a small cafe.

WORDS BY US ARCHITECTURE STUDIO

SECTION II · STUDIO PROFILE · US ARCHITECTURE STUDIO

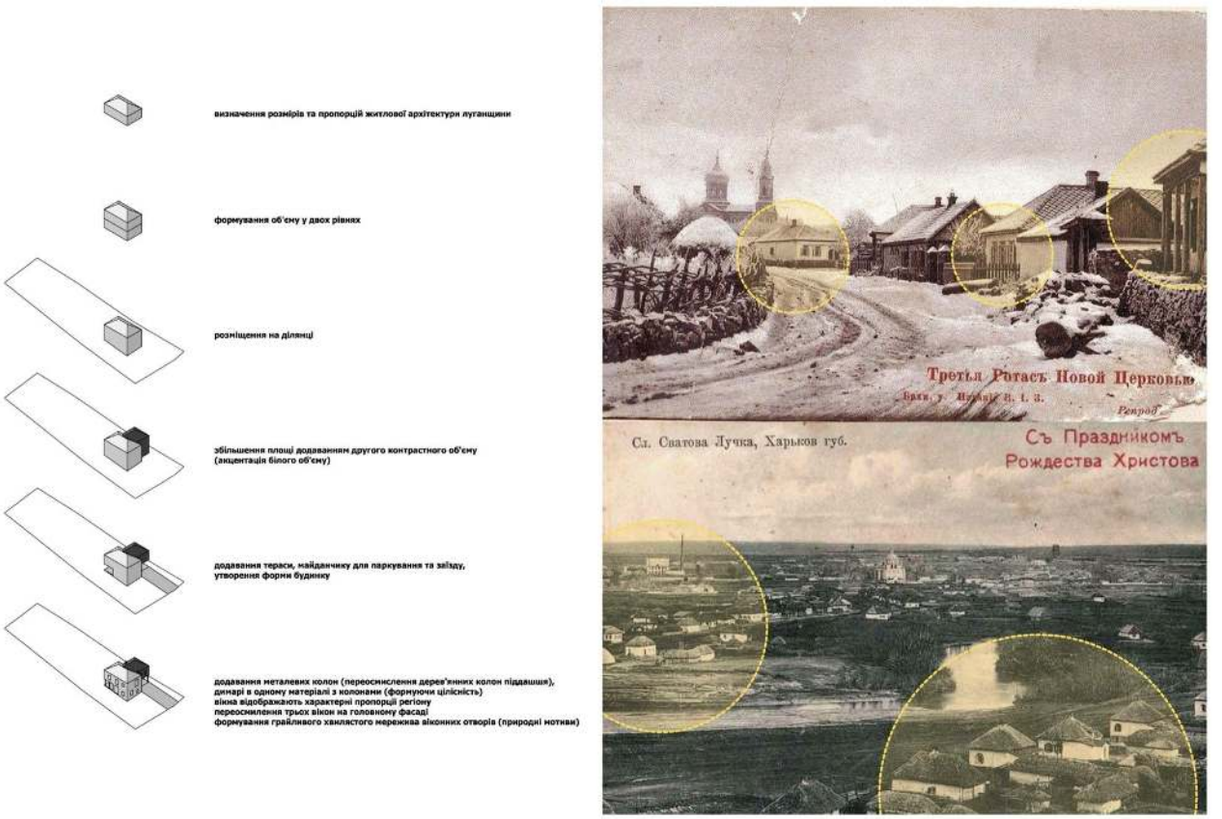
How multi-layered context shapes identity across three projects by US Architecture Studio, from a steppe town, through rolling hills, to a small cafe.

Architecture is something considerably larger than physical walls. It is the ability to give material form to a place's memory, its climate, its habits, the routes people walk every day without thinking about them. A building that knows how to listen to its surroundings becomes a natural extension of the ground it stands on. From the open steppe of the east, through the textured hills of Galicia, to the restless center of the capital, the Ukrainian practice US Architecture Studio works from layered context rather than applied style, arriving at three different answers to the same underlying question. Three geographies, three projects.

A building's identity is not decoration added afterward. It is a precise spatial answer to the character of a place, one that gathers up meanings already latent in a site and makes them visible. Before drawing a single wall, the studio works through a set of deliberately basic questions: what is this plot? What does the street it sits on say? What is the town, the region, the culture around it? Does the result read as part of the country's own identity? The answers, an arid climate, a local domestic habit, the constant transit of a city block, end up shaping a building far more convincingly than any decoration laid on top of it afterward. What that method looks like in practice can be traced across three projects spanning very different parts of the country: the eastern steppe, the western landscape, and the pulsing center of the capital.

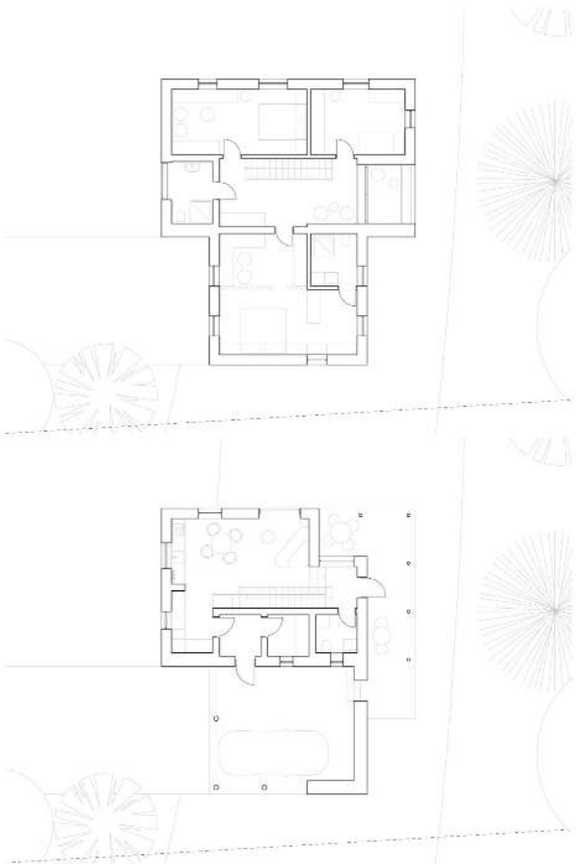
Svatove: the memory of a form

A private house on the outskirts of Svatove grew out of close study of the underlying logic, rather than the literal image, of traditional housing in the Luhansk region. The plot's narrow shape, together with local custom, climate and the historical proportions of the surrounding buildings, dictated a compact white volume set back from the road. To give the plan a livable, contemporary scale, the composition is completed by a contrasting dark block on the north side, its pitched roof kept visually unified by a single membrane covering. The overall form is further shaped by two carved out niches, one for a terrace, one for parking.



The house's form, developed step by step from the proportions of local vernacular housing and a nearby historic settlement. Courtesy US Architecture Studio.

Tradition and continuity of form show up here in details easy to miss. The slender metal columns of the terrace and the parking canopy restate, in a new material, the idea of the old wooden porch post. Three differently sized windows on the white facade reinterpret a traditional local arrangement, and their placement sets up a wavelike rhythm that echoes the course of a nearby river. Inside, the plan avoids conventional corridors in favor of one continuous, flowing space: the kitchen and living room open upward into the second floor hall and its loggia. Working with the site's own slope, the house keeps its paved surface to a single driveway leading to the parking spot, leaving the rest of the plot free for a garden further up the hill.

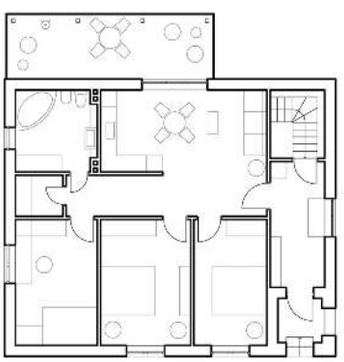


Ground and second floor plans, Svatove. Courtesy US Architecture Studio.

Ternopil region: building from what was already there

Context is not only cultural or natural. On a plot in the Ternopil region, it was a literal constraint: an existing stone plinth and foundation left over from a generic house of the 2000s. That given became the starting point for a deliberately rational home, built for a family who chose to move out into the surrounding countryside. Every window and every square meter here answers directly to function. The restraint and the palette of the facades draw straight from vernacular building tradition, and the roof, a half hip form with a series of breaks in its slope, does most of the formal work.

That silhouette runs deep in the visual culture of Galicia and reads as instinctively familiar to anyone from the region. It also produces a far more articulated volume than a plain gable or hip roof would allow, while solving a purely practical problem: it keeps the attic usable at full height without resorting to dormer windows. Working with the site's pronounced slope, the house's strict practicality settles into something closer to comfort, and its local character grows directly out of function rather than being applied over it.



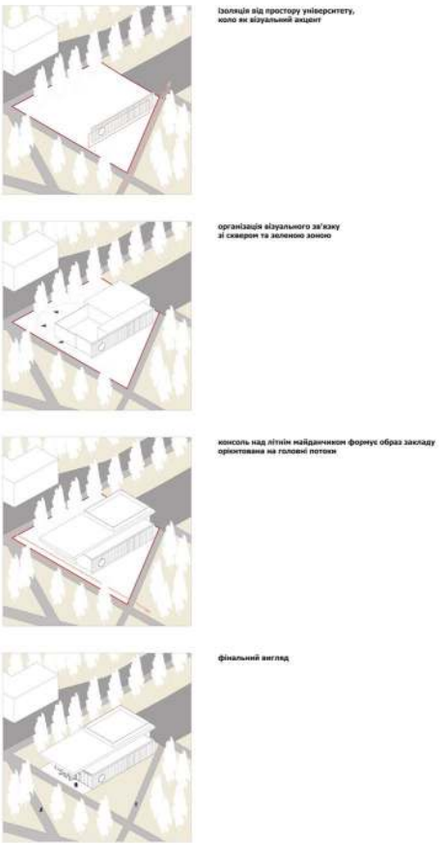
Ground and attic floor plans, a house in the Ternopil region built on an existing foundation. Courtesy US Architecture Studio.

Kyiv: designing for a city in motion

In a large city, natural terrain and history are joined by something else: constant movement. A cafe project in Kyiv's Solomianskyi district sits inside a green strip along Povitrianykh Syl Avenue, wedged between student dormitories and university buildings that see a steady flow of foot traffic between them. The building answers that transit with a wavelike, insulating wall that shields the interior from the street, breaking its surface only once, for a single round window. The cafe's main visual draw is a heavy cantilevered roof whose wave motif carries inward, turning into a series of convex vaults overhead. The ceiling's dynamic vertical lines tie the terrace to the interior, running the length of the room and cutting into the wall behind the bar. That same shape structures the space outside too, setting a rhythm of three arches across the facade's glazing.

Soloma, a cafe for Kyiv's Solomianskyi district, set inside a green strip along Povitrianykh Syl Avenue. Courtesy US Architecture Studio.

Inside, the column free volume splits visually into an intimate zone and a main hall offering five distinct ways to sit: half private nooks, a long communal table, a run of seats along the panoramic windows, and a central island of smaller tables. From outside, the building's overall geometry answers to the rhythm of traffic and pedestrians passing by, while a screen of existing trees gently separates it from the avenue. Inside, the main hall faces the opposite corner of the plot, keeping its calm and its open, panoramic view of the square across the street.



Isolating the plot from the university grounds, then opening a visual line toward the square and the green beyond, before the cantilevered roof settles into its final form. Courtesy US Architecture Studio.

A building that is genuinely alive always grows out of a deep reading of its place, its culture, its spatial surroundings, becoming a natural extension of the ground beneath it. It is exactly that connection that gives architecture real content, gives it a value that does not date, and makes the space around it easier to notice and understand.

US Architecture Studio is a Ukrainian practice working across architecture and identity consulting, and also runs the media project UkrArchStyle. More of their work: us-arch-studio.framer.website. ■

FEATURE JUL 19, 2026

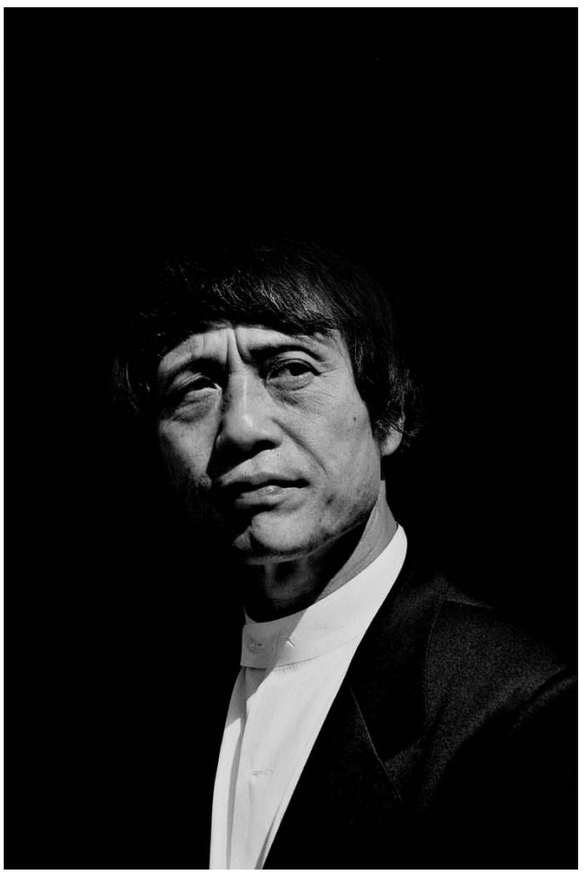
Tadao Ando

Architecture beneath the tangible

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

SECTION II · FEATURE · MARIA IVANOVA

Architecture beneath the tangible



Tadao Ando is one of the most influential architects of 21st century, who challenges the conventional definition and boarders of architecture. His unique approach showcased the rethinking of traditional Japanese principles through bold shapes, materials and spatial organizations. In this article we are going to reveal the core principles of his philosophy and its cues.

Background and Influences

Tadao Ando was born in Osaka (once called the “City of Water”) in 1941. He was born as the first twin, but then his parents decided to separate them. Tadao Ando was raised by his maternal grandmother in a simple neighborhood with a variety of craftsmen, woodworkers, and others. He spent days in their workshops working with materials, builds airplanes and ships. It would be fair to say that this environment served as a foundation for the life-learning the renowned architect pursued.

From the age of 17, being influenced by his twin, Ando started to take up boxing. This sport has shaped his fighting spirit, which helps him in the future life.

In the early 20s, during the period of 1962-1969, after the Japanese ban was lifted, Tadao Ando took a trip to Europe, United States and Africa. He took a ship from Japan to the Soviet Union, where he went to Moscow with a week-long Trans-Siberian

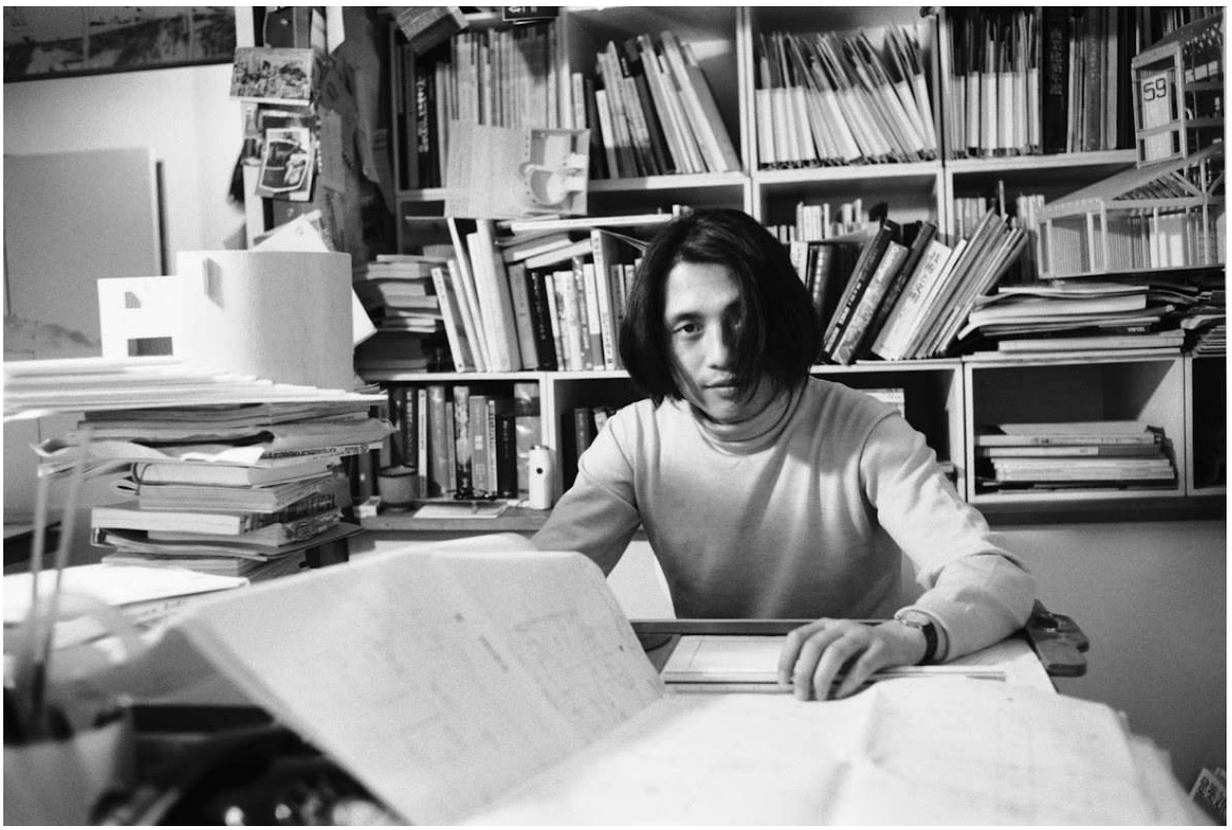
Railway. During that trip, he saw many countries and had an indisputable architectural experience, which would later become the basis of his famous quote:

> "Architecture encompasses things that cannot be captured through the media. This is why architects must travel; architects are made through traveling"

Despite an acquaintance with numerous buildings in different countries, his desired destination for this journey was the heritage of Le Corbusier, who nourished his interest in architecture.

He got to know a French iconic architect by chance, finding his manuscript in an old secondhand bookshop. The value of this book lies not in the actual price but entirely in the footprint it left on Tadao Ando's life and career. The architect was fascinated by the projects and recalled that he had traced Corbusier's early sketches so many times that the paper had become almost black. Furthermore, he admitted that while thinking about his own projects, he thinks about what Le Corbusier would have said about it and how he would evaluate it.

Tadao Ando didn't receive formal training in any field, but opened his firm, "Tadao Ando Architect & Associates," in 1969 in Osaka, after returning from his long "field-study" in various countries, that, along with the Japanese spatial philosophy and books about architecture, shaped his way of thinking. Ando didn't pursue an empirical way of learning by being a student of other architects, as his stubbornness and temper always led to dismissal.



The first attempts in design were with small wooden houses, interiors, and furniture. However, it's been 6 years of his practice before he completed the Row House (Azuma House), which gave him praise and recognition through the prize from the Japanese Architectural Association.

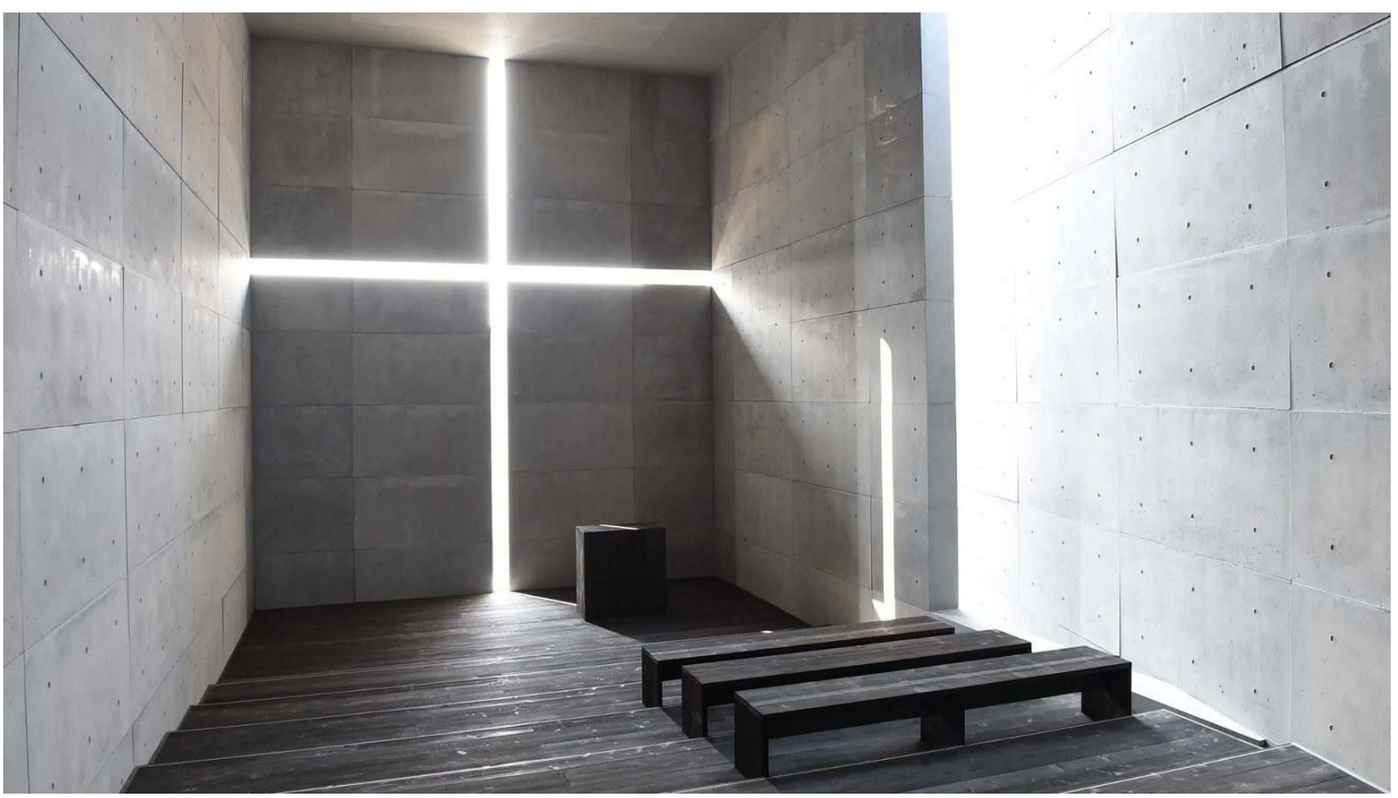
Row House, 1976

Rokko Housing, 1981-1998

Another project executed in the late 1970s, the Rokko Housing complex, was widely published and emphasized its importance in the architectural field beyond the local context. It's inserted into a slope at the foot of the Rokko Mountains, allowing panoramic views. Remaining loyal to the rigid grid and geometry, Tadao Ando nonetheless worked in a more elaborate form and composition, proving that simplicity is a *conscious, but not limiting, choice for his philosophical embodiment*.

The following projects strengthened the tendency for transboundary recognition. Such buildings as Church on the Water (1988) in Tomamu, Hokkaido or Church of the Light (1988-89) in Ibaraki, Osaka promote their author as an architect with a deep spiritual understanding of the space and nature connection. In spite of Japan being the only country to host his projects by the end of 1980, the influence has changed the status quo, and in 1991 the Modern Museum of Modern Art gave an exhibition dedicated to Tadao Ando, indirectly labeling him “one of the preeminent living architects in the world”.

Church on the Water (1988)



Church of the Light (1988-89)

Throughout the whole career till nowadays Tadao Ando designer more than 300 constructed projects all over the world.

We can name three main pillars of his approach, influenced by the background:

Traditional Japanese architecture. Growing up in Japan in residential common dwellings inevitably influences the perception and the initial idea about certain aspects. However, according to Tadao Ando's words in the interview with Toshio Okumana, he doesn't use any traditional architectural elements, but wants to evoke the feeling of it, through adaptation of emotional sensitivity, rather then direct physical elements. The last is an artificial addition to the building, which nevertheless keeps it standardized without enhancing the perceptive depth and significance, which are laid between the obvious presence of elements. The approach is not mimicry of the form, but the mimicry of feeling.

Ephemeral and intangible over physical. Tadao Ando is inclined to give a predominant role to the ephemeral elements in architecture, which is commonly recognized as solid and structural matter. However, the consistent presence and monumentality perform as a background for important factors, such as light, which deal with subtle susceptibility. Most probably this intention is directed by the experience which architect exposed himself to at teenage years: around the age 15, he went to study old rural houses to impress upon himself the traditional Japanese space.

Study of architecture through travelling and experience of the space. As it was a major part of his self-taught architectural education, the concentration on the feeling and emotions in his own projects keep the same significance.

Architectural Philosophy and Design Principles

"Tension in acceptance"

There is a strong belief penetrating the Japanese architecture framework, concerning the blend of the outside environment and the interior space. The borders between the above-mentioned dual definitions are meant to be softened, visually and physically melting into each other to avoid the rigid division. This idea of harmonious coexistence of antagonist spaces found its base in philosophy and historical relationship with nature, and it is supported by many strategies in the Nippon Koku.

However, Tadao Ando had directly defined, both verbally and in his projects, that his mindset is occupied with the idea of the necessity of rejection. According to his words, acceptance means setting down one's guards, allowing for excessive inflow into the interior, which by these means is losing its certainty. *The reason lies in the absence of tension in the act of rejection.* Thus, the renowned architect is convinced that tension should be an indisputable part of acceptance as well as in the architectural context, tension signifies the confrontation between exterior and interior, underscoring the importance of the places in a building of their contest.

Walls, as the strongest border between the intrinsic and extrinsic, play a significant role in Tadao Ando's approach ﬀ he works with thin materiality and by specific positions with intervals creates openings to allow the structure accept even in the act of prime rejection. Walls are perceived as a "sword", which cuts the landscape, sky, wind,

and sunlight in order to promote new disclosure. This act of manifestation is not seen as a cruelty to the exterior, but as a ceremonial and sacred deed, with assimilating nature as an equal part of architecture.

"Essentials of human life"

Tadao Ando is known for his minimalist approach, reflected by the boldness and fine clarity of his ideas. It touches upon walls and the spatial arrangement. However, the simplicity of the walls and their raw forms and finishes is not based on mere aesthetic considerations; its foundation is deeply rooted in Ando's philosophy of life. He believes that contemporary culture is characterized by a loop of satisfying unconstrained and never-ending desires, so he raised a silent question about what contributes to the richness of life and what is essential. Through his projects, he is conveying a supposed answer with the underlying meaning of true abundance, which is translated in simplification, elimination of surface decoration, and employment of symmetrical compositions.

Architectural silence

The striking quietude of the architect's projects is defined by his faith that architecture should remain silent and let the presence of changing nature to be dominant, staying tolerant to the passage of time, hourly, daily, and seasonal transformations, that nurture a finer sensitivity in humans.

Revitalization of nature connection

According to Tadao Ando, the population growth and urbanization after World War II made it impossible to preserve the core base of traditional Japanese residential architecture – connection with nature and openness to it. In his projects, this principle goes beyond the mere tribute to the historical value, but rather is performed as a main builder of the concept, shape and mass distribution.

"Voids as a part of architecture"

If the architecture can be compared to sculpture, than its fair to make a correlation with the void mass relation. Even if the observation of these two media is irrelevant, it helps to scale down the building structure and start to perceive it mainly in masses. Tadao Ando had a strong persuasion that it's essential to leave blank spaces in project design, and endow them with the same significance as the man-made intervention. The interstices should bear their intrinsic logic within the structure, and this approach enhances the value and the individuality of the architecture.

Light is an important controlling spatial factor

Tadao Ando has a focal focus on the role of light in the built environment. He believes that the architecture is not about walls, floor, and ceiling, but about the contained world outside. This space can be changed not only by the form, but also by the means of directed light. If the more grounded correlation is to be made, *the way light defines the character of the rooms resembles the fireplace in a traditional home*. The light can be manipulated in different ways to create a gentle environment for habitats.

Restricted vocabulary

This principle of Tadao Ando's works is directly perceived by every observer, even the one with no experience in architecture or any related field. The paradox of the limited use in different categories of built structure is the correlation between the level of limit-

ations and the visual and sensory effect. Moderate material palette, strictness of forms, and dignified simplicity of spatial relations result in a visually attention-getting object, also through the difference with the natural and man-made environment.

One of the most remarkable examples, that, according to the architect's words, encapsulates all of his principles and emphasizes the essence of the whole oeuvre is a Row House Sumiyoshi (Azuma House) in Osaka, Japan, constructed in 1976. The residential module is located in a dense urban environment, and its rectangular shape is divided into three equal parts, where the middle is dedicated to the open courtyard, connecting habitats with nature, exposing them to changing weather conditions every time they want to go from one part of the house to the other and emphasizing the priority of nature even in the challenging conditions. The equality of the open part and its obligatory binding function encapsulates Tadao Ando's approach to incorporate blankness.

The chosen material is unfinished concrete, which is also a substantial characteristic of the prominent architect. It creates a moderate appearance of the house, not trying to evoke warmer feelings, but rather keeping true to the material and shifting the attention to the intrinsic values and meanings. *The envelope of the Azuma House is not designed to impress; the facades of Tadao Ando's buildings do not respond to the modern expectations of superficial satisfaction in every aspect.*

Tadao Ando's philosophy is unique, and it can't be more accurately conveyed than through his words. In his essay "A Wedge in Circumstances," he explained his approach to the residential space – the house is a stage for living; therefore, the manner of entertaining and the paths are very important. He is convinced that the architectural plan shouldn't be perceived from the inside – once a visitor steps into the space, it's not important for him/her to comprehend the layout, he/she should cognitively comprehend the embraced space. That's the reason for asymmetrical, variable, and unpredictable space relations in his projects. ■

THE LONG READ JUL 8, 2026

The Sacred Spring: A Portrait of the Vienna Secession

In 1897 a handful of Viennese artists walked out on the establishment, raised a white temple crowned with a dome of gilded leaves, and declared to a startled city that every age deserves an art of its own. This is the story of the Secession – and of the restless, brilliant people who made it.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · THE LONG READ · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

In 1897 a handful of Viennese artists walked out on the establishment, raised a white temple crowned with a dome of gilded leaves, and declared to a startled city that every age deserves an art of its own. This is the story of the Secession – and of the restless, brilliant people who made it.

Imagine Vienna in the last years of the nineteenth century: a city drunk on its own reflection. The Ringstrasse glittered with palaces dressed in borrowed history – a Greek parliament here, a Gothic city hall there, a Renaissance opera in between. It was magnificent, and it was exhausted. Behind the gilt, an entire generation of young painters and architects had begun to suspect that their city was building museums to a past that had never quite belonged to it, while the present – electric, anxious, alive – went unpainted.

On the third of April 1897, a group of them stopped waiting for permission. Led by a thirty-four-year-old painter named Gustav Klimt, they resigned in a body from the Künstlerhaus, the official artists' association that controlled every important exhibition in the city. They called their new movement the Vereinigung bildender Künstler Österreichs – the Union of Austrian Artists – but history remembers them by the word they chose for the break itself: Secession.

They were not a school. They shared no single style, no common manifesto of technique. What bound them was a conviction – fierce, simple, and impossible to compromise – and they cut it in gold above the door of the building they would soon raise. It read: to every age its art, to art its freedom.

To Every Age Its Art

The Secession announced itself the way a thunderclap announces a storm – with a poster. For the first exhibition in 1898, Klimt drew Theseus slaying the Minotaur, the young hero of a new art putting the old monster to the sword, while Pallas Athene, goddess of wisdom and just war, stood guard at the margin. The censors made him add a screen of trees to hide Theseus's nakedness. It was the first of many quarrels the Secession would pick with a public that did not yet know it wanted to be provoked.

Their creed had a name too – Ver Sacrum, the 'sacred spring.' In ancient Italy it was the rite by which a people, in a time of crisis, dedicated the coming generation to a fresh start. The Secessionists borrowed the phrase for their magazine, a square, exquisite journal in which text and image were designed as one living surface. To open an issue of Ver Sacrum was to hold the movement's philosophy in your hands: that a wine glass, a typeface, a chair and a painting were all art, and all equally worth perfecting.

Der Zeit ihre Kunst. Der Kunst ihre Freiheit. – To every age its art. To art its freedom.

The White Temple

A movement needs a home, and the Secession built one unlike anything Vienna had seen. The commission went to Joseph Maria Olbrich, barely thirty, a pupil of the great Otto Wagner. What he produced in 1898 was less a building than a declaration: a cubic, white-walled temple of pure geometry, stripped of every historical ornament, crowned with an openwork dome of three thousand gilded laurel leaves. Vienna, half-scandalised and half-delighted, nicknamed it 'the golden cabbage.'

Look closely at the façade and you find the movement's spirit written in plaster: three solemn owls, sacred to Athene, and above the entrance those defiant golden words. Even the decorative details were designed by members of the group – the owls and foliage by Koloman Moser – so that the building itself became a total work of art, a Gesamtkunstwerk, in which architecture, sculpture and ornament spoke a single language.

The People

The Secession was never a one-man movement, but it began, unmistakably, with one man. Gustav Klimt was the son of a gold engraver, and gold would never leave his work. He had made his name – and his fortune – painting decorous allegories on the ceilings of the very Ringstrasse palaces the Secession would rebel against. Then, at the height of his respectability, he turned. His art grew strange, erotic, ornamental and unafraid; his patrons grew nervous; and Klimt, serenely, kept going.

In Pallas Athene of 1898 you can already see the future arriving. The goddess is armoured in hammered gold, her gaze cool and frontal, and in her hand she holds a tiny naked figure – Nuda Veritas, naked truth, holding up a mirror to a society that preferred not to look. It was Klimt's private motto made visible: the artist owes the age not flattery, but honesty.

If Klimt was the movement's heart, Otto Wagner was its conscience turned to stone and iron. Already famous, already past fifty, the professor could have coasted into a comfortable old age of neo-Baroque commissions. Instead he threw in his lot with his own students, declaring that 'something impractical cannot be beautiful' and that the architecture of a new age must be born of new life, new materials, new needs.

Wagner's buildings still stun. On the Linke Wienzeile he sheathed an entire apartment house in blossoming majolica tiles, flowers climbing five storeys into the Viennese sky – practical, weatherproof, and gloriously alive. And at Karlsplatz he built a pair of railway pavilions so elegant that the city's commuters passed each day through works of art, green iron and white marble stitched with golden sunflowers.

Koloman Moser was the movement's quiet universe. Trained as a painter, he designed everything: postage stamps, stained glass, book covers, furniture, the owls on the Secession wall, the very pages of Ver Sacrum. If the Secession believed that art should saturate ordinary life, Moser was the proof – a man who could make a letterbox as beautiful as an altarpiece.

Josef Hoffmann took that belief and built an empire on it. In 1903, with Moser and the banker Fritz Wärndorfer, he founded the Wiener Werkstätte – the Vienna Workshops – a cooperative of craftsmen determined to make objects of total quality, from cutlery to entire houses. His grids and squares were so rigorous that colleagues nicknamed him 'Quadratl-Hoffmann,' Little-Square Hoffmann. The nickname was a joke; the influence was not. His purity of line runs straight through the twentieth century into the design language we still live inside.

And Joseph Maria Olbrich, the young architect of the temple itself, gave the movement its face. He did not stay in Vienna long – the Grand Duke of Hesse called him to Darmstadt to build an entire artists' colony from the ground up – but the golden dome he left behind still crowns the city, and still keeps its promise, a century and a quarter later.

The Beethoven Exhibition

Everything the Secession believed came together, once, in a single room. In 1902 the fourteenth exhibition was conceived as a temple within the temple: a shrine to Ludwig van Beethoven, the artist as hero and prophet. At its centre stood Max Klinger's polychrome statue of the composer enthroned like a god; around the walls, twenty-one members contributed works meant to be seen together, as a single act of devotion. And along three walls Klimt painted the Beethoven Frieze – thirty-four metres of longing, suffering and deliverance.

It begins with the yearning of humankind, drifts through the temptations and terrors of the world – the giant Typhoeus, a monstrous ape, and the Gorgons of sickness, madness and death – and resolves, at last, in art and love. The frieze was painted directly on the wall, meant to be destroyed when the show closed. It survived by accident, and today it is one of the supreme achievements of European painting.

But the frieze does not end in darkness. It climbs toward a choir of angels and closes on an embrace – a naked couple locked together beneath a golden sky, and above them the words of Schiller that Beethoven set to music in his Ninth Symphony: this kiss to the whole world. It is the Secession's deepest belief, painted large: that art, in the end, is a form of love, and love a form of deliverance.

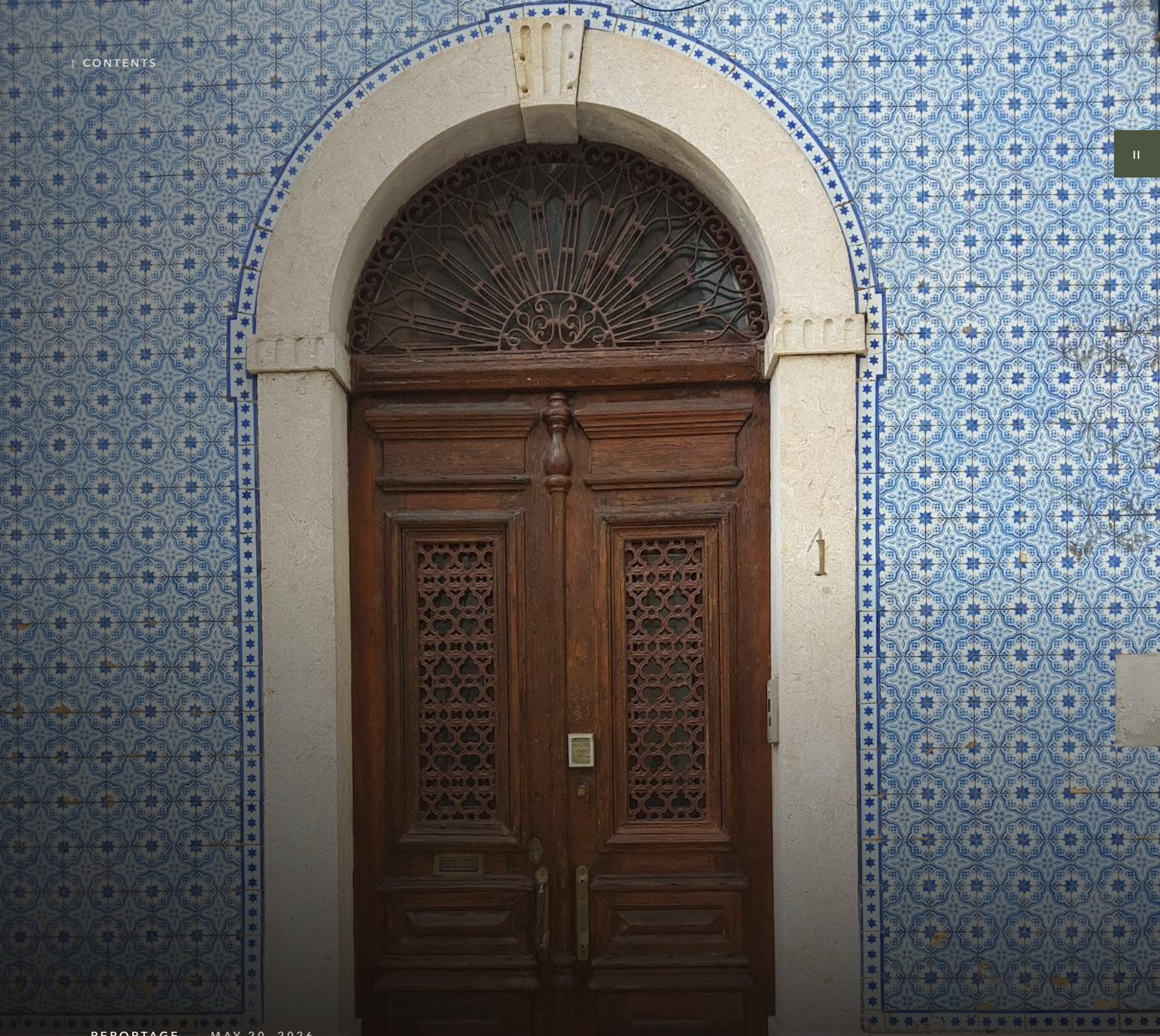
The Break, and the Gold

Movements are mortal, and the Secession's unity did not survive its success. By 1905 a rift had opened between the 'stylists' around Klimt, who wanted art and craft and commerce to fuse completely, and the 'naturalists' who feared the movement was becoming a shop. Klimt and his circle – Moser, Hoffmann, Wagner among them – resigned. The group they had founded eight years earlier went on without them; so, gloriously, did they.

For it was in the years just after the break that Klimt entered his golden phase, and painted the picture that would eclipse everything else: The Kiss. Two figures kneel at the edge of a flowering meadow, wrapped in a single robe of shimmering gold, the man's patterns hard and rectangular, the woman's soft and circular, the whole world dissolved

into ornament around them. Everything the Secession had argued for – the union of painting and decoration, the fearlessness before beauty, the gold inherited from a father's workshop – arrives here, complete. ▪

> The Secession Building still stands on the Friedrichstrasse, its dome still gilded, the Beethoven Frieze still glowing in the basement below. The words above the door have not changed in a hundred and twenty-eight years: to every age its art, to art its freedom. It remains, perhaps, the finest thing a group of young artists ever dared to promise – and one of the very few such promises that the world went on to keep.



REPORTAGE MAY 20, 2026

The Threshold of Time

Door restoration is an act of archaeological tenderness. From the carved portals of Tbilisi to Ghiberti's Gates of Paradise – a journey through the cities that refuse to let their thresholds disappear.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · REPORTAGE · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Door restoration is an act of archaeological tenderness. From the carved portals of Tbilisi to Ghiberti's Gates of Paradise – a journey through the cities that refuse to let their thresholds disappear.

There is a peculiar kind of silence that inhabits old doorways – a silence woven from centuries of hands pressing against timber, of keys turning in iron locks worn smooth by ten thousand evenings. Stand before a weathered portal in Lisbon's Alfama, and you can feel it: the grain of the wood holds the oils of five generations of palms, the hinges remember the rhythm of a family's comings and goings, and the threshold stone – scooped concave by two hundred years of footsteps – maps the topology of human habit more faithfully than any census. A door is never merely an architectural element. It is the most intimate surface a building offers to the street, the frontier between the public and the private, the place where a city's soul greets its visitors. To restore a door is to perform surgery on the memory of a place.

Door restoration is not merely carpentry. It is an act of archaeological tenderness, a conversation between the living and the vanished. When a conservator peels away layers of paint – cerulean blue over terracotta over bone white – they are performing stratigraphic analysis, reading the autobiography of a building one pigment at a time. Each colour corresponds to a decade, each crack charts a winter survived, each replaced hinge marks a family that once named this threshold home. The paint cross-section, examined under a stereomicroscope at 40× magnification, reveals not just hues but binders: the linseed-oil grounds of the eighteenth century, the lead-white primers of the Napoleonic era, the alkyd enamels of the mid-twentieth century, each layer a forensic timestamp more precise than any archive.

> A single historic door can harbour up to twelve discrete paint strata. In Saint Petersburg, conservators from the 'Dveri s Pomoek' collective have documented pre-revolutionary pigments – Prussian blue, chrome yellow, genuine vermilion – entombed beneath Soviet-era PF-115 enamel. Some of these pigments had not absorbed a photon of visible light for over a century before the scalpel exposed them.

The fundamental tension in door conservation sits between two imperatives that the uninitiated often confuse: restoration and conservation. Restoration implies returning an object to a specific historical state, which demands interpretive choices – which century's appearance do you privilege? Conservation, by contrast, aims to stabilise the object in its current condition, arresting decay without erasing the patina of time. The modern consensus, codified in the Venice Charter of 1964 and refined by the Burra Charter of 1979, leans decisively toward conservation: intervene minimally, document exhaustively, and ensure reversibility. Every epoxy fill, every dutchman splice, every re-gilded surface must be distinguishable from the original upon close inspection, and removable without damaging the host material.

The door is the first sentence the building speaks to the street. Destroy it, and you erase the opening line of a story that took centuries to compose. Replace it with a replica, and you have written fan fiction in the margins of a manuscript.

Consider the materiality of a Pombaline door in Lisbon's Baixa district. After the catastrophic earthquake of November 1, 1755 – which killed between 30,000 and 50,000 people and levelled 85% of the city – the Marquis of Pombal commissioned a radical reconstruction based on proto-seismic engineering. The resulting Pombaline architecture introduced the 'gaiola pombalina' – a flexible timber-frame cage embedded within masonry walls, designed to flex rather than fracture during tremors. The doors of these buildings were crafted from Brazilian peroba rosa (Aspidosperma polyneuron) and pau-marfim (Balfourodendron riedelianum), imported from the Atlantic colonies: dense, resinous hardwoods with an interlocking grain that resists both marine humidity and the torsional stress of seismic movement. The joinery is mortise-and-tenon throughout, with wedged through-tenons at the stile-and-rail junctions – no nails, no screws, only the geometry of wood locking against wood.

A weathered doorway in Lisbon's Alfama district – centuries of Atlantic wind, salt crystallisation, and ultraviolet degradation etched into every tangential grain.

Restoring a Pombaline door begins with a condition survey. The conservator taps the panels with a small brass mallet, listening for the dull thud of sound wood versus the hollow resonance of internal rot. Moisture content is measured with a pin-type meter: readings above 20% indicate active fungal colonisation, typically Serpula lacrymans (dry rot) or Coniophora puteana (cellar fungus). Insect damage – the sinuous galleries of Anobium punctatum (common furniture beetle) or, in tropical hardwoods, the broader tunnels of Lyctus brunneus (powder-post beetle) – is mapped with a dental probe. Only after this forensic inventory does physical intervention begin.

The treatment protocol follows a strict hierarchy. First, consolidation: a low-viscosity epoxy resin (typically a two-part system with a 3:1 ratio of resin to hardener, viscosity below 500 centipoise) is injected into delaminated panels and decayed end-grain through 2mm drill holes, penetrating the cellular structure by capillary action. The epoxy cross-links within the wood fibres, creating a composite material that retains the original surface texture while recovering structural integrity. For more extensive losses, the conservator cuts a 'dutchman' – a precisely fitted wooden insert, grain-matched to the surrounding material, bonded with a reversible PVA adhesive rather than an irreversible epoxy, so that future conservators can remove and replace it without collateral damage.

Hardware receives parallel attention. The wrought-iron strap hinges of a seventeenth-century door were not mass-produced but hand-forged: each pintle was drawn from a single bloom of smelted ore, the surface bearing the distinctive hammer-scale texture of a charcoal forge operating at approximately 1,100°C. When corroded, these elements are stabilised with a tannic acid conversion treatment – the tannins react with the iron(III) oxide to form iron(III) tannate, a stable, blue-black corrosion-resistant layer – rather than sandblasted, which would erase the forging marks that constitute the object's technological signature. Missing nails are reproduced using traditional heading tools: a nail rod is drawn through a swage plate, headed in a nail header, and given the characteristic rosehead profile by four blows of a ball-pein hammer, replicating a seventeenth-century technique documented in Moxon's 'Mechanick Exercises' of 1677.

Six thresholds, six cities: from Lisbon's azulejo-framed entries to Saint Petersburg's imperial doorways.

Travel eastward, and the doors of Tbilisi reveal an entirely different grammar of beauty – one rooted not in post-catastrophe rationalism but in the exuberant decorative traditions of the Caucasus. In the labyrinthine streets of the Old Town, Art Nouveau doors with oval stained-glass windows in lead came coexist beside austere Georgian carved panels depicting grapevines and mythical beasts, executed in local walnut (Juglans regia)

with chip-carving techniques unchanged since the Middle Ages. The celebrated Kaleidoscope entrance at 3 Betlemi Street – known locally as 'Gallery 27' – scatters Caucasian sunlight through a mosaic of coloured glass into a hundred chromatic whispers on the stairwell walls. The Shalimov House at 13 Lado Asatiani Street still guards its angel frescoes above a threshold where, legend maintains, the poet Nikoloz Baratashvili once paused to compose a verse on the nature of longing.

The Tbilisi Development Fund's 'New Tbilisi' project has systematically restored historic entrances on Atoneli Street since 2020, at a documented cost of 414,886 Georgian Lari per pair of entrances. The scope of work reads like a surgical protocol: restoration of marble floor and stair treads, conservation of wooden doors and windows (including reglazing with period-appropriate crown glass), casting and installation of missing cast-iron balustrade details from silicone moulds taken from surviving originals, and – most remarkably – the uncovering of forgotten wall paintings sealed behind plaster for decades. At 31 Atoneli Street, workers removing a layer of Soviet-era cement render discovered a polychrome mural depicting pastoral scenes, its original casein binder still viable, the pigments – earth ochres, ultramarine, and bone black – as saturated as the day they were applied.

Carved wooden balconies and painted doors in Tbilisi's Old Town – each doorway a palimpsest of Georgian, Persian, and Soviet layers.

Monumental bronze doors of Florence – where Nd:YAG laser ablation meets mercury-fire gilding.

Florence offers the most technically documented example of door restoration as high art. Lorenzo Ghiberti's Porta del Paradiso – the gilded bronze Gates of Paradise at the Baptistery of San Giovanni – underwent a twenty-seven-year conservation at the Opificio delle Pietre Dure that concluded in 2012. The challenge was formidable: five centuries of atmospheric corrosion had deposited a crust of copper carbonates (malachite and azurite), sulphates (brochantite), and chlorides (atacamite) over the original mercury-fire gilding – a technique in which gold leaf is amalgamated with mercury at approximately 350°C and applied to the bronze surface, the mercury then driven off by controlled heating, leaving a microscopically thin but extraordinarily durable gold film.

The restoration team, led by conservators Annamaria Giusti and Mauro Matteini, developed a bespoke Nd:YAG laser cleaning protocol. The laser, operating at 1064 nanometres wavelength with pulse durations of 8 nanoseconds, selectively ablated the dark corrosion products through differential absorption: the dark crust absorbed the infrared radiation and vaporised, while the underlying gold – highly reflective at this wavelength – remained unaffected. Thermal modelling ensured that the instantaneous temperature rise in the gold film never exceeded 50°C, far below the threshold that would cause micro-cracking or delamination. Where the corrosion was too tenacious for laser alone, controlled chemical poultices of EDTA (ethylenediaminetetraacetic acid) at 5% concentration in deionised water were applied through Japanese tissue paper for precisely timed intervals, chelating the copper ions without attacking the substrate. The result: each of the ten panels, depicting scenes from Genesis to the story of Solomon, emerged with the luminous splendour that Michelangelo himself praised when he named these doors worthy of Paradise.

Speed is irrelevant when you are restoring something that took three generations to build. The Nd:YAG laser removes corrosion at four square centimetres per hour. Ghiberti spent twenty-seven years casting these doors. We spent twenty-seven years cleaning them. The symmetry is not accidental – it is respect.

Saint Petersburg – that northernmost Venice of granite and fog – holds a singular position in the cartography of endangered doors. The pre-revolutionary entrances of the Petrogradskaya Side, with their linden-wood (Tilia cordata) panels and wrought-iron transom grilles, represent some of the most imperilled specimens of urban ornament in Europe. The volunteer collective 'Dveri s Pomoek' – 'Doors from the Dump' – was founded by engineers Valentina Mann and Andrei Troshkov and designer Alexander Artemyev, who met at the Tom Sawyer Fest, a grassroots festival of historic building restoration that originated in Samara in 2015 and has since spread to over sixty Russian cities.

Their methodology is forensic. When a discarded door is retrieved – often from a skip outside a building undergoing 'renovation' by developers who consider plastic replacements an upgrade – it is first photographed in situ, then transported to the workshop for assessment. The species is identified: Karelian birch (Betula pendula var. carelica) with its distinctive flame figuring, Scots pine (Pinus sylvestris) from the Archangelsk forests, or Siberian larch (Larix sibirica), the same timber used in Venetian pilings and prized for its extraordinary resistance to moisture. Paint stratigraphy is performed on a micro-core sample: each layer is catalogued against known periods of building maintenance, cross-referenced with the building's archival records when available. The restorers have documented doors with hand-painted floral cartouches – executed in casein-bound distemper over a gesso ground – that survived beneath layers of Soviet khaki enamel, the delicate petals still discernible despite decades of chemical and mechanical insult.

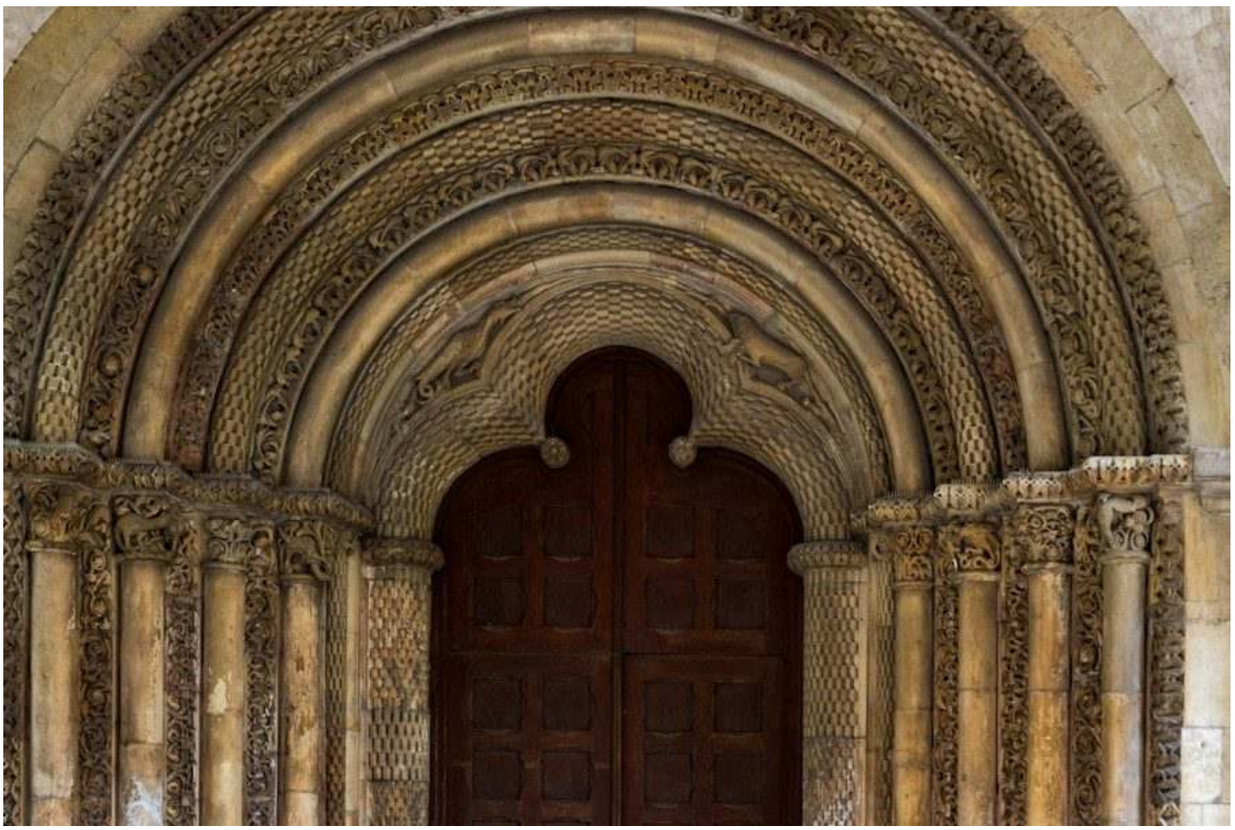
A Saint Petersburg courtyard entrance – behind these gates, volunteers of Tom Sawyer Fest salvage pre-revolutionary doors from demolition.

Mann notes a grim irony: 'The best-preserved doors are often the ones the Soviets painted over most aggressively. The very enamel that obliterated their beauty also sealed them from oxygen and UV, preserving the original pigments in a state that borders on anaerobic conservation. When we peel back the PF-115, we find colours that a museum conservator would envy.' The collective's restoration of linden-wood doors from the Kamienny Ostrov area required eleven months of patient work: chemical paint removal using NMP (N-Methyl-2-pyrrolidone) – chosen over methylene chloride for its lower toxicity and slower evaporation rate, which allows for more controlled stripping – foll-

owed by consolidation of worm-damaged areas with Paraloid B-72 in acetone at 5% concentration, and final finishing with cold-pressed linseed oil, applied in four thin coats and allowed to cure for seventy-two hours between applications.

At Durham Cathedral in northern England, the North Door presents a conservation challenge of an entirely different order: how to preserve a structure that has been in continuous functional use for nearly nine centuries. Dendrochronological analysis of the oak (Quercus robur) places the felling date of the timber between 1109 and 1144, making it contemporary with the cathedral's original Romanesque construction. The door is not a museum piece behind glass – it is opened and closed daily by tourists, choristers, and clergy, its iron ring handle worn to a mirror finish by 900 years of human touch.

The 2019 conservation by Skillingtons Workshop exemplified the minimalist philosophy that defines contemporary best practice. Phase one: dry-brushing with natural-bristle brushes and low-suction vacuuming to remove trapped particulate matter from the open grain – medieval oak, unlike modern kiln-dried timber, retains a pronounced tangential grain pattern that acts as a trap for atmospheric soot and mineral dust. Phase two: aqueous cleaning with de-ionised water and a non-ionic surfactant (Synperonic A7) at 1% concentration, tested first on a concealed section of the rebate to verify that no dimensional change or surface blanching occurred. Phase three: re-saturation with cold-pressed Tung oil (Vernicia fordii), applied in four successive coats over sixteen days, each coat absorbed before the next was brushed on. Tung oil was chosen over linseed for its superior resistance to hydrolysis and its lower tendency to yellow with age. Phase four: the corroded wrought-iron fittings were stabilised with Renaissance Wax – a microcrystalline blend developed by the British Museum in the 1950s – rather than varnish, which would have created a non-breathing barrier antithetical to the iron's long-term preservation.

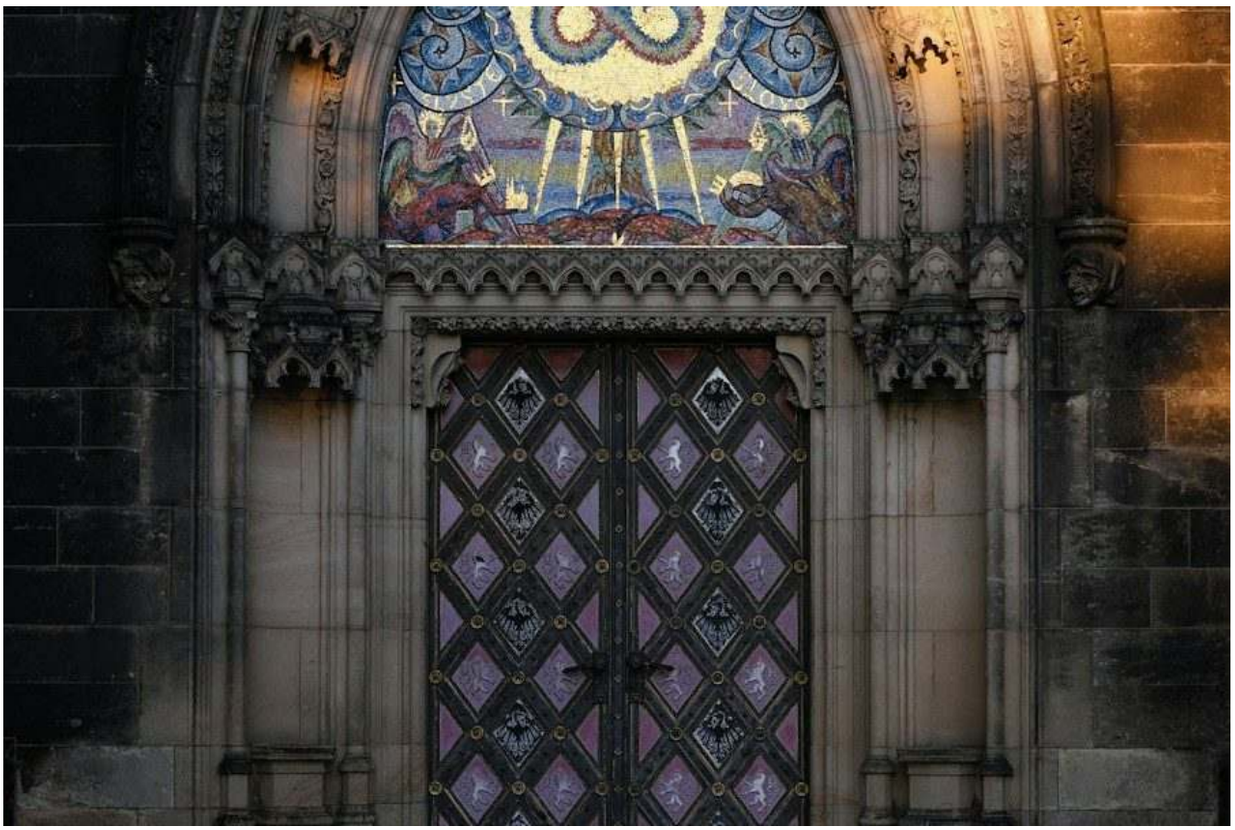


Durham Cathedral – nine centuries of English oak, iron, and faith embedded in its Romanesque arches.

In Havana, the challenge is not preservation of the ancient but resurrection of the abandoned. The crumbling pastel facades of Centro Habana conceal portals of Cuban mahogany (Swietenia mahagoni) and Spanish cedar (Cedrela odorata) – aromatic, naturally insect-resistant hardwoods that once welcomed sugar barons and revolutionary poets alike. The tropical climate imposes unique stresses: relative humidity regularly exceeds 85%, driving cycles of expansion and contraction that no temperate-climate joinery was designed to withstand. Cuban restorers – many trained at the Oficina del Historiador de la Ciudad, the heritage office established by Eusebio Leal Spengler – work with tools inherited from their grandfathers: wooden moulding planes with hand-forged blades, bow saws strung with tempered wire, and scratch stocks for reproducing ogee and cyma recta profiles. They re-carve rosettes and acanthus leaves not from measured drawings, which dissolved long ago in the tropical humidity, but from plaster casts taken from surviving examples in neighbouring buildings – a technique that preserves the local 'dialect' of ornamental carving, the subtle variations that distinguish Havana Baroque from its Andalusian ancestors.

A Cuban doorway where mahogany meets maritime humidity – the weathered blue paint a century's palimpsest of Caribbean salt and sun.

Prague's doors speak in the dialect of Central European Baroque: a language of carved limewood (Tilia europaea) featuring saints, griffins, and garlands of impossible fruit rendered with a virtuosity that rivals the altarpiece carvings of Tilman Riemenschneider. In Malá Strana, beneath the shadow of Prague Castle, the portals of aristocratic palaces bear the heraldic devices of families who have been extinct for three centuries, their carved escutcheons the last material evidence that these lineages ever existed. The Palazzo Negri in Istrian Vodnjan – restored by the Ars et Labor Foundation during the European Year of Cultural Heritage in 2018 – demonstrated how a single Didactic Workshop, staffed by volunteer conservators and funded entirely by private donors, can preserve a region's identity one door at a time. The project's ten-month timeline included complete dismantling of the Baroque door, treatment of each component, and reassembly using traditional hide-glue joinery. Their motto, borrowed from the Gospel of Matthew, is quietly magnificent: 'Knock, and the door will be opened to you.'



Ornate church entrance in Prague – where Gothic tracery meets baroque wood carving in the lanes of Malá Strana.

The economics of door conservation are rarely discussed, yet they are decisive. A custom-fabricated fiberglass replacement door for a historic building costs between €800 and €2,000; a sympathetic conservation of the original, including paint analysis, timber repair, and hardware stabilisation, typically runs €3,000 to €8,000, depending on condition and complexity. The difference is not trivial, and developers routinely invoke it to justify replacement. But the calculus is incomplete. The original door embodies what economists call 'embedded energy' – the sum of human labour, material cultivation, transportation, and craft that produced it. A linden door from 1890s Saint Petersburg required a tree that germinated during the reign of Catherine the Great; its timber was air-dried for two to five years before a master joiner shaped it. No budget line captures this temporal investment. No replacement, however skilful, replicates it.

There is a Japanese concept – kintsugi – that repairs broken ceramics with lacquer mixed with powdered gold, treating the fracture not as a flaw to be concealed but as a chapter in the object's biography. The best door conservation operates on a parallel philosophy. The 'dutchman' insert is not hidden; it is grain-matched but left legible, a frank acknowledgment that repair has occurred. The tannic-acid-blackened hinge does not pretend to be unworn; it wears its patina as evidence of nine centuries of openings and closings. The conservation report, archived alongside the door, ensures that the next conservator – in fifty years, in a hundred – will know exactly what was done, and why, and by whom. This is the opposite of vanity renovation. This is humility encoded in wood and iron.

What makes a door worth saving? Not merely the age of the timber or the elegance of the carving – though both matter. It is the accumulated weight of passage: the thousands of arrivals and departures, the lovers who lingered in the frame, the children who scratched their heights into the jamb, the mourners who paused before crossing back into sunlight. Every threshold is a palimpsest of human experience, layered as densely as the paint stratigraphy on a Pombaline panel. When we permit a developer to rip out a nineteenth-century entrance and replace it with a pressed steel door from a catalogue, we do not merely lose an object. We erase a sentence from the city's autobiography – and unlike a book, a city cannot be reprinted.

In the end, the conservator's craft is an act of radical empathy extended across time. To sand a piece of oak that a Romanesque carpenter shaped nine centuries ago is to shake hands with the dead. To mix pigments that match a Baroque painter's palette is to complete a conversation interrupted by centuries. Every door that survives is a small victory over entropy, a proof that beauty can outlast the indifference of progress. The threshold of time stands open. Our choice – the only choice that matters – is whether we walk through it with the reverence it deserves, or seal it shut with the concrete of forgetfulness. ■

FURTHER

Explore the Ars et Labor Foundation's 'Knock and the Door Will Be Opened' Project fondazionearsetlabor.org/main-door-of-palazzo-negri/?lang=en

FEATURE SEP 24, 2026

Two Ways of Looking at the Same Building - interview with Manuel Heywinkel

Architect and photographer Manuel Heywinkel on photographing a building he spent years supervising into existence, why colour and black-and-white were never separate chapters for him, and a black-and-white show on a raw construction site that had to be called off days before it opened.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

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Architect and photographer Manuel Heywinkel on photographing a building he spent years supervising into existence, why colour and black-and-white were never separate chapters for him, and a black-and-white show on a raw construction site that had to be called off days before it opened.

Manuel Heywinkel was photographing buildings before he was trained to design them. There was no year when the camera turned professional and no clean break between the two – architecture school and, later, work as a construction-supervising architect simply sharpened a habit that was already there, teaching him to notice geometry, sightlines and proportion almost without deciding to. Colour came first, for the ordinary reason that it came before digital did; black-and-white arrived later, once post-processing and then Instagram gave it somewhere to live. He treats the two as equally valid today, decided case by case, image by image.

The clearest instance of both roles meeting in one place is the LernWerk in Bocholt – the conversion of the former Herding spinning mill, where Heywinkel spent years as project lead for ACMS and photographed the building throughout construction, not after it. Cast-iron columns from the original mill were kept and picked out in colour; a new, contemporary volume was inserted in a fibreglass-mesh cladding that quietly echoes the site's textile past. Old and new, as he puts it, stay legible as distinct layers of time and still stand in relation to each other.

His exhibition record runs in both registers too. FARBRAUM, running through 30 September at Galerie im Turm in Wuppertal with guest photographer Andreas Kretzschmar, extends colour photography into the room itself with passe-partouts and backing fabrics matched to each image – a deliberate answer to 2025's all-black-and-white show at the same venue. A third show, Black & White in Unfinished Core, was planned for a raw, unheated construction shell on Moltkestrasse in Essen – fine-art prints on acrylic glass staged inside bare concrete and unfinished masonry, admission by invitation only – and had to be called off at short notice, when days of bad weather made the site too risky for visitors. The idea itself, he says, is far from finished, and he hopes to find a suitable location for it one day. Two of his staircase images independently made the jury's Top 50 at the SPC competitions – Treppe im Kunstpalast Düsseldorf in Berlin, Treppe im Museum Küppersmühle in Duisburg in Cologne – while a third, of a ceiling light in his mother's living room, took fourth place in Cologne's public vote. Docu Magazine has run two issues of his work, and one image – Tiger & Turtle, the public sculpture in Duisburg – was shown at the Black & White International Photography Awards Exhibition at One Art Space, New York, in June 2026.

We spoke with Manuel about photographing a building he was also professionally responsible for, why staircases keep pulling him back, and what a jury looks for that a public vote doesn't.

01

Two ways of seeing

Viacheslav Munister [VM]: You work on architecture both as an architect and, since long before that was your job, as a photographer. Has your eye for architecture changed in any way you can point to – and where do colour and black-and-white each come in?

Manuel Heywinkel [MH]: I've been photographing since I was very young, and architecture was one of my subjects almost from the start, so I can't name a moment when my eye for it changed fundamentally. When I was younger I also spent a good deal of time on film and video, making animated films among other things, before photography moved back to the centre.

Studying architecture, and later working as an architect, sharpened that eye considerably. You start paying much closer attention to geometry, line, vanishing points, proportion, spatial relationships – a lot of it happens automatically by now. Interestingly, before digital photography I shot almost exclusively in colour. Black-and-white came later, mainly once digital editing made it easier and then once I started posting on Instagram. Today the two are equal for me as forms of expression – I decide per image which one actually works for it.

DZ BANK, Frankfurt am Main, 1996. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

VM: Was there a specific photograph or moment where documentation stopped being enough and it became a more deliberate, composed way of looking at architecture – or were the two always tied together for you?

MH: I can't name a specific moment – the more deliberate way of seeing developed continuously rather than arriving all at once. Today I notice details much more consciously, but also the sightlines between parts of a building, or between different buildings, and the urban context around them: how a building sits in its surroundings, how it responds to them, what perspectives that creates. It's exactly out of those relationships that interesting lines, vanishing points and perspectives tend to emerge for me – and years of close engagement with architecture have made that way of looking steadily more conscious.

Potsdamer Platz, Berlin, 2024. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

02 The LernWerk

VM: The LernWerk in Bocholt is a building you supervised as an architect over years and photographed throughout that same time, not after the fact. Does watching a building you're also professionally responsible for change what you see in it – do things show up that the strictly professional view might miss?

MH: It isn't always easy in the middle of a construction site. As the architect supervising the build, you're deeply embedded in the daily process – coordinating contractors, sorting out agreements, and above all quality-checking the work that's been done. That inevitably narrows your focus to individual details and immediate tasks a lot of the time.

Which is exactly why it matters to step back periodically and see the emerging building as a whole again. My photographic eye helps with that, I think – I keep trying to take a step back and not just see the detail or the current problem, but the space, the archit-

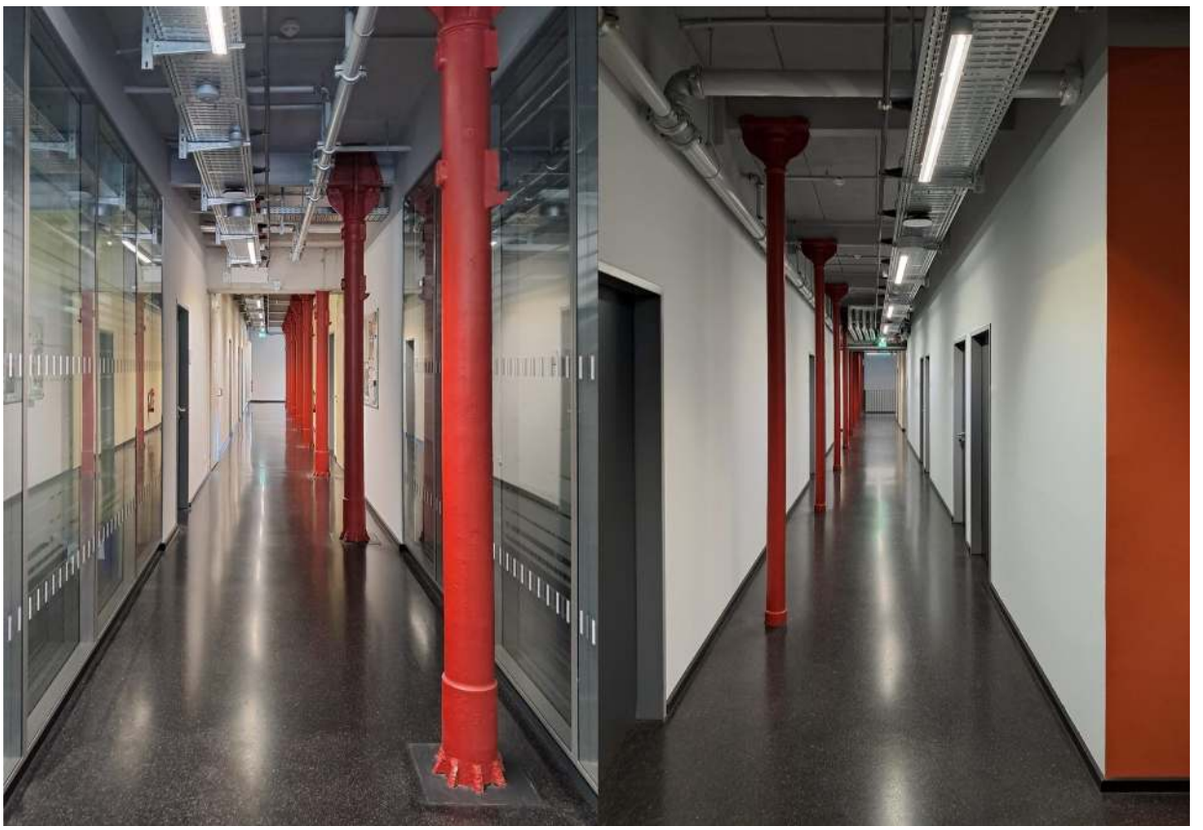
ecture, what's actually taking shape there. On a project you're following over a long stretch of time, it's easy to otherwise lose sight of how the building is developing as a whole.

LernWerk under construction, Bocholt, 2022. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

VM: Is there one image in the series where the coexistence of the old mill and the new building reads most clearly to you?

MH: That depends a great deal on the design itself first. At the LernWerk, a central idea was developing the historic fabric for a new, contemporary use and reinforcing it technically without covering over the building's history. You can see that, for instance, in the original cast-iron columns – they were largely preserved and deliberately highlighted through their colour treatment. At the same time, the newly inserted cube introduces a clearly contemporary element into the existing fabric; its fibreglass-mesh cladding in turn references the building's original use as a spinning mill.

I find exactly that juxtaposition compelling: old and new stay legible as distinct layers of time, and still stand in relation to each other.



LernWerk, Bocholt, 2025. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

VM: How do the architect's eye and the photographer's eye actually divide the work on a project like this – are there moments where one has to consciously take the lead?

MH: In the daily rhythm of a construction site, the architect's view naturally comes first – checking completed work, coordinating the process, communicating with the client and the tradespeople, and at the LernWerk, eventually with the building's future users and to some extent the public. Part of the job is also thinking ahead rather than only at the current detail: what comes next, how does one decision affect other work, how does it all come together in the end?

The shift into photographing isn't that different, actually. There too I can focus very tightly on a detail, a line, a specific situation, and then deliberately let go of it again to take in the space or the building as a whole. The two ways of seeing complement each other well for me.

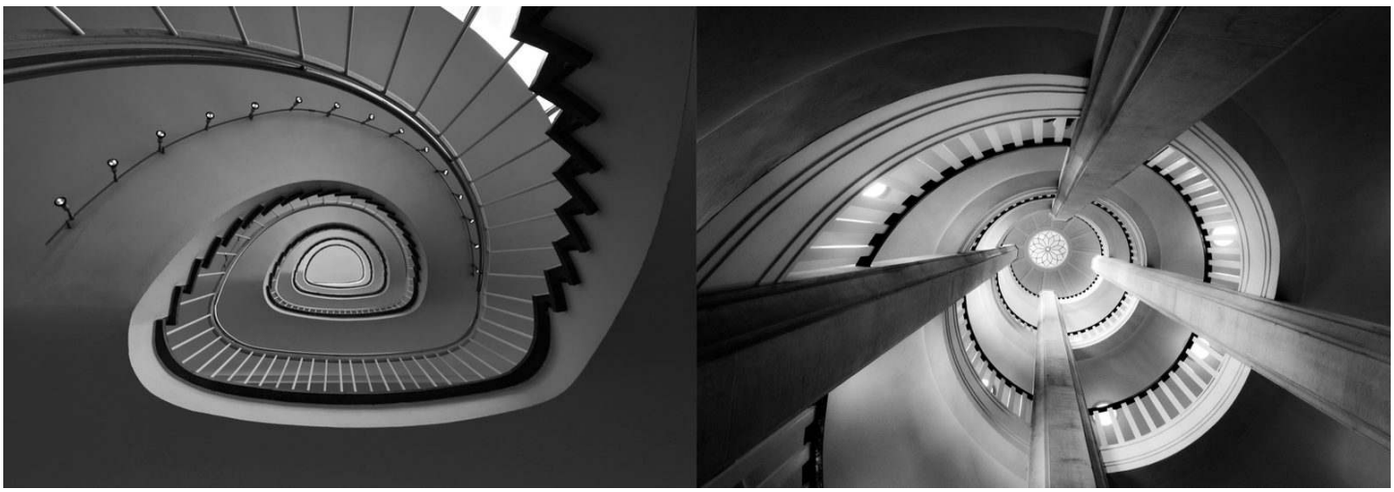
LernWerk, Bocholt, 2025. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

03 Recurring motifs

VM: Staircases keep returning across your work – Schwerin Palace, Düsseldorf's Kunstpalast, the Museum Küppersmühle in Duisburg, the Ruhr Museum on the Zeche Zollverein site in Essen. What is it about a staircase that keeps pulling you back?

MH: A staircase is far more, for me, than a building component that connects a building's levels. Historically, staircases were often deliberately staged elements of representation – in palaces especially, they could be a direct expression of power, rank and importance.

Photographically I find them just as compelling. Their construction almost automatically offers interesting sightlines, vanishing points, repeating lines and perspectives – the same staircase can look completely different depending on where you stand. Maybe that's exactly the fascination: a staircase serves one unambiguous function and, at the same time, offers an almost unlimited number of ways to interpret it, architecturally and photographically.

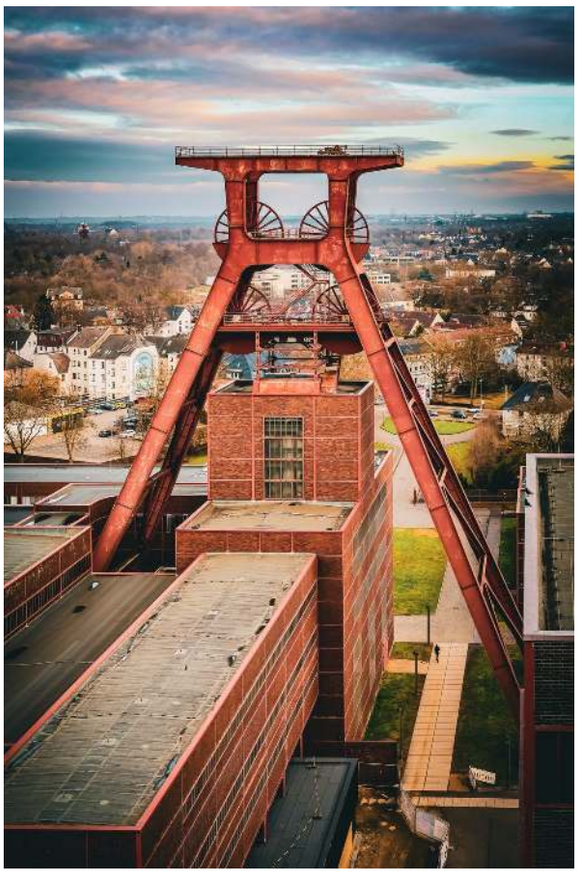


Staircases, Aachen / Schwerin, 2026. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

VM: Your Zeche Zollverein images show a place that was once industry and is now a monument – a coking plant, reflections, machinery nobody operates anymore. How do you approach a site with that much history without the picture becoming a mere illustration of it?

MH: What strikes me first about old industrial sites is the sheer scale of the engineering achievement. Looking at Zeche Zollverein, or other large industrial complexes, it's worth remembering these complex structures were planned and built at a time with no computers, no CAD – much of it was still drawn by hand at the drafting table, something I learned to do myself as a trained architectural draughtsman.

Walking through a site like that today, I often find myself wondering what function a given building, machine, pipe or structure originally served. Now everything stands still. You can only imagine the working life that went on there, and probably only imagine, at that, the physical effort some of that work demanded. At the same time, these sites are photographically extraordinary – the sheer range of structures, materials, pipework, technical detail and large spatial relationships offers an enormous variety of motifs and perspectives. Zeche Zollverein is a very good example of that.



Zeche Zollverein, Essen, 2026. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

VM: What draws you to exploring different cities photographically, and what decides which motifs from a city become a series?

MH: Cities don't interest me only for their architecture. I'm also drawn to their history – why certain things emerged in a particular place, how a city became what it is today. With Frankfurt, for instance, I'm interested in how it grew into a major trade-fair city, but also its history as an imperial coronation city with its Kaiserdom. Other cities raise entirely different questions. Bielefeld is my hometown; Freiburg has a completely different character; Düsseldorf another again. Every city has its own charm, its own vibe.

So I'm interested not just in the historic building stock or the modern architecture, but in the life in between: how people use their city, move through it, engage with the spaces available to them. That's what I try to capture, alongside the architectural photography, through street photography as well.

Street photography, Berlin / Freiburg / Nuremberg, 2024–2025. Photo: Manuel Heywinkel

04 Black-and-white and colour

VM: After your black-and-white show at FotoForum Wuppertal in 2025, your current exhibition FARBRAUM deliberately shows colour work. What led to that decision, and what does colour open up for you as a photographic tool that black-and-white doesn't?

MH: For FARBRAUM, still on show now, I decided on colour photography quite deliberately from the start – partly as a counterpoint to last year's show, where I showed exclusively black-and-white work.

My basic idea was not to confine the colour to the image itself, but to carry it into the room. I did that with passe-partouts matched in colour to each photograph, and for individual works, matching fabric behind the image as well. That way the image's colour continues into the space around it and shapes how it's perceived and its mood at the same time.

Colour matters to me as a design tool in architecture too, for what it's worth. Architecture can of course work very deliberately with a reduced, white palette and achieve a completely different effect that way. But deliberately applied colour can emphasise spaces, surfaces and proportions and change how they're perceived – with lighting conditions playing an important role there as well. That interplay of image, colour and space is the whole premise of FARBRAUM.

VM: Why plan a black-and-white show for an unfinished space rather than a conventional white-walled gallery?

MH: The underlying idea for that show, too, was to connect architecture and photography directly. I wanted to present high-quality, precisely finished architectural photographs on acrylic glass inside a deliberately unfinished setting – a raw construction shell, exposed concrete, unplastered masonry, all the traces of an ongoing build.

That contrast was exactly what drew me: the finished image inside the unfinished room. The photographs show architecture in a resolved, completed form, while the exhibition space itself was still mid-process.

Unfortunately I had to cancel the show on short notice for safety reasons. Weather conditions in the days beforehand made the risk to visitors on an active construction site simply too high. The concept itself is by no means dead, though – it's still in the back of my mind, and since I deal with construction sites regularly through my work, I'm hoping to eventually find the right location to still make it happen.

VM: What did putting together l'une et l'autre – your Cologne show with Monika Geisler – teach you about your own work that you wouldn't have noticed alone?

MH: What I found especially interesting about the Cologne show was that we combined photographs with quite different styles and approaches, and still found surprisingly strong connections between many of the pieces – in content or in form.

So we deliberately paired images, placing works side by side that look very different at first glance but engage with similar motifs, shapes or structures. A good example: Monika Geisler's photograph of a snail next to my photograph of the spiral staircase inside Berlin's Siegessäule – two completely different subjects, and yet the similarity in form creates an immediate connection.

Putting the show together, I was genuinely surprised how many such relationships emerged between individual works. It was exactly those different photographic perspectives on related forms and themes that ended up being the particular appeal of the show, for me.

05 Juries, print, a room in New York

VM: Two of your staircase images independently made the jury's Top 50 at the SPC competitions, while a third – of a ceiling light in your mother's living room – took fourth place in the public vote. What does that split tell you about the difference between what a jury looks for and what actually reaches an audience?

MH: I was of course very pleased that two of my staircase images were selected by the jury for the Top 50, even though neither placed in the actual competition. What I found even more interesting was that my image Unter der Decke – showing a ceiling light in my mother's living room – came fourth in the Cologne public vote.

A specialist jury engages with submitted work in a targeted, comparative way. Depending on the jurors' own photographic backgrounds, things like composition, technical execution, craft, or how a theme is handled can carry particular weight. With the public, the immediate personal or emotional response probably plays a stronger role – what speaks to me right away, what excites me about an image, does the motif remind me of something I've experienced or seen myself? That doesn't mean the public is blind to technical or formal qualities, of course. But a personal connection to an image can weigh more heavily in a public vote.

That's exactly why I find both forms of judgment interesting – they show how differently photographic work can be perceived.

VM: What changes about an image once you know it will be seen printed and bound, not just on a screen?

MH: I don't actually distinguish, while shooting, based on where or in what form an image will later be shown. Whether it ends up on Instagram, in a magazine, or in an exhibition is secondary at the moment of taking it – what has to work first is the subject, the composition, the way it's built.

When an image is later selected for a show or a publication, that's obviously very gratifying. I was especially pleased that my photograph of Tiger & Turtle was shown as part of an exhibition in New York – it meant something to present a piece of my own work in that kind of international setting. And I liked the thought that, with Tiger & Turtle, I was showing a motif from Duisburg – and with it, a piece of North Rhine-Westphalia and Germany.

06 Looking forward

VM: Comparing today's work to your first architectural photographs – as both architect and photographer – what's changed the most in how you look? And what are you still looking for in either role that you haven't found yet?

MH: Today I seek out and look at architecture far more deliberately than I used to. Things I might once have photographed almost in passing, as a young photographer, I now go looking for quite consciously.

I research particular buildings and places in advance and think about what might interest me photographically there. Often that's museums, but just as often other publicly accessible buildings – and, naturally, places that aren't normally accessible hold a particular appeal. My professional work sometimes opens up the chance to photograph buildings during construction, or shortly before completion – before they go into use and become accessible to the public. Photographically that's very exciting, because you get to experience spaces in a state that won't exist again once they're in use.

Next up is a joint exhibition with Petra Baumgart and Andreas Kretzschmar at the IKIGAI-Raum in Cologne, and I'll be taking part in the SPC in Cologne again. What the new year brings beyond that, we'll see. Further PhotoWalks are being planned, among other places at Zeche Zollverein and in Berlin, but for now these really are plans rather than fixed dates.

Manuel Heywinkel's photography can be seen at manuel-heywinkel.com, his work as an architect at acms-architekten.de, on Instagram at @manuel_242neo and on 1x at 1x.-com/manuelheywinkel. Images © Manuel Heywinkel unless credited otherwise; published with permission. ■

FEATURE SEP 2, 2026

The Picture Is Finished Before the Shutter - interview with Roland M Schwerdtfeger

Architectural photographer Roland M Schwerdtfeger on planning a picture until it is finished before the camera comes up, the single coloured note in a black-and-white frame, and why camera brand is the wrong question.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & ROLAND M SCHWERDTFEGER

SECTION II · FEATURE · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & ROLAND M SCHWERDTFEGER

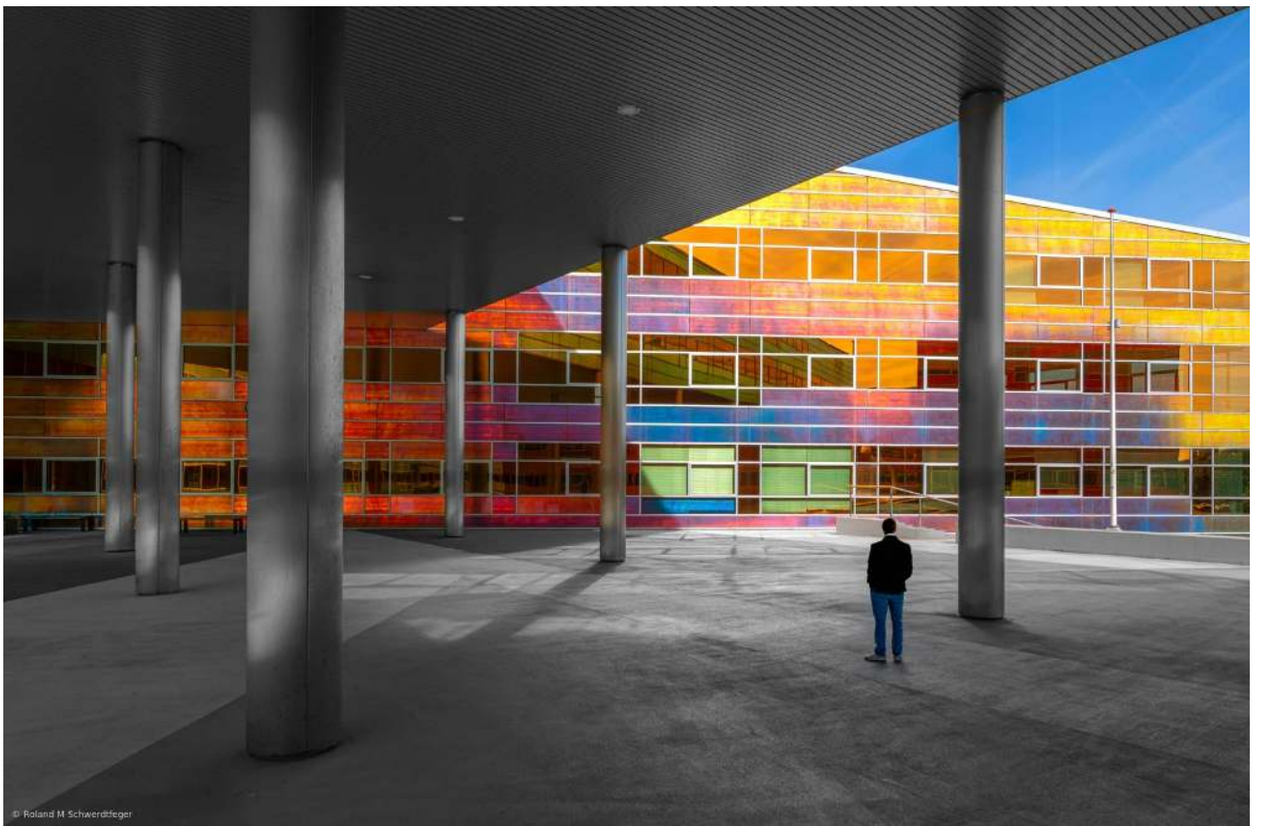
Architectural photographer Roland M Schwerdtfeger on planning a picture until it is finished before the camera comes up, the single coloured note in a black-and-white frame, and why camera brand is the wrong question.

Most architectural photography argues for a building. Roland M Schwerdtfeger's argues past it: a spiral staircase becomes Red Spiral, a bridge becomes pure shape, and the name of the architect who built it stops being the point. Line, shape, light, colour, rhythm – that is the finished list of what survives his edit, and everything else, the function, the address, sometimes even the building's own name, is what gets removed to get there.

He works from research outward. A location is scouted on Google Maps before it is ever visited, checked for orientation and the hour the light will be right, and the picture, he says, is usually finished in his head before the shutter opens at all – the title comes later, sometimes only once the image is published. It is a discipline that has drawn recognition outside his own judgment too: an EPA Platinum Award, an IPA Gold, honours from Fineartphotoawards and ND Awards, and a curator's seat on 1x, the photography platform that has accepted 442 of his images and turned away only three.

Based in Germany, he moves between company premises where a camera is often simply not allowed, museums that grant permission if asked properly, and buildings that sit outside Panoramafreiheit, the country's law protecting only what can be photographed from a public street. What comes home from those visits is edited hard in Lightroom and Photoshop – skies replaced, distractions removed, occasionally a streetlight or a figure added back in – but never, he insists, handed over to AI to compose.

We spoke with Roland about the point where planning ends and the picture takes over, the one colour he lets stand in for all the others, and why – after 442 published images – a camera's brand still tells you less about a photograph than people assume.



Chromatic Encounter, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2026. La Defense, Almere, Netherlands

01 Before the shutter

Viacheslav Munister [VM]: Your titles split in two: some keep their name and stay themselves, like Dreischeibenhaus or Schwebebahn; others lose it and become pure shape, like Red Spiral or Cubic VII. When you raise the camera, do you already know which one this will be?

Roland M Schwerdtfeger [RS]: That's an interesting question. No, when I take a photo, I don't yet know what title it might eventually be published under – once all the post-processing stages are complete. I usually prepare the locations where I take photos very thoroughly. Impressive buildings aren't exactly a dime a dozen, and you first have to find interesting subjects. I often discover my subjects through online research, but also through inspiration from other photographers on 1X, on Instagram, at photography exhibitions and the like.

Then I check Google Maps to determine the location, the surroundings and the orientation of the subject. It's important to choose the right moment to take the shot so that the light is just right. For me, planning and preparation are absolutely essential. My images usually take shape in my mind and are often already 'finished' before I've even taken the photograph. But the title only comes to me when the image is published.

My images usually take shape in my mind and are often already 'finished' before I've even taken the photograph.

Urban Lines, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2026. Trivago Headquarter, Düsseldorf

VM: A number implies an unfinished series. What earns a staircase its number rather than leaving it an outtake, and what does a spiral staircase give you that a facade never can?

RS: The number after the name is included because there are often several images with the same name, e.g. 'Staircase' or 'Window Composition'. The number simply serves to distinguish between them; it does not refer to a series. As for the subjects themselves, whilst I remain true to my passion for architectural photography, I am constantly on the lookout for new buildings and details. I am interested in both the subject itself and its effect: lines, shapes, light, colour and rhythm. Sometimes entire buildings, sometimes a staircase, sometimes details of a façade.

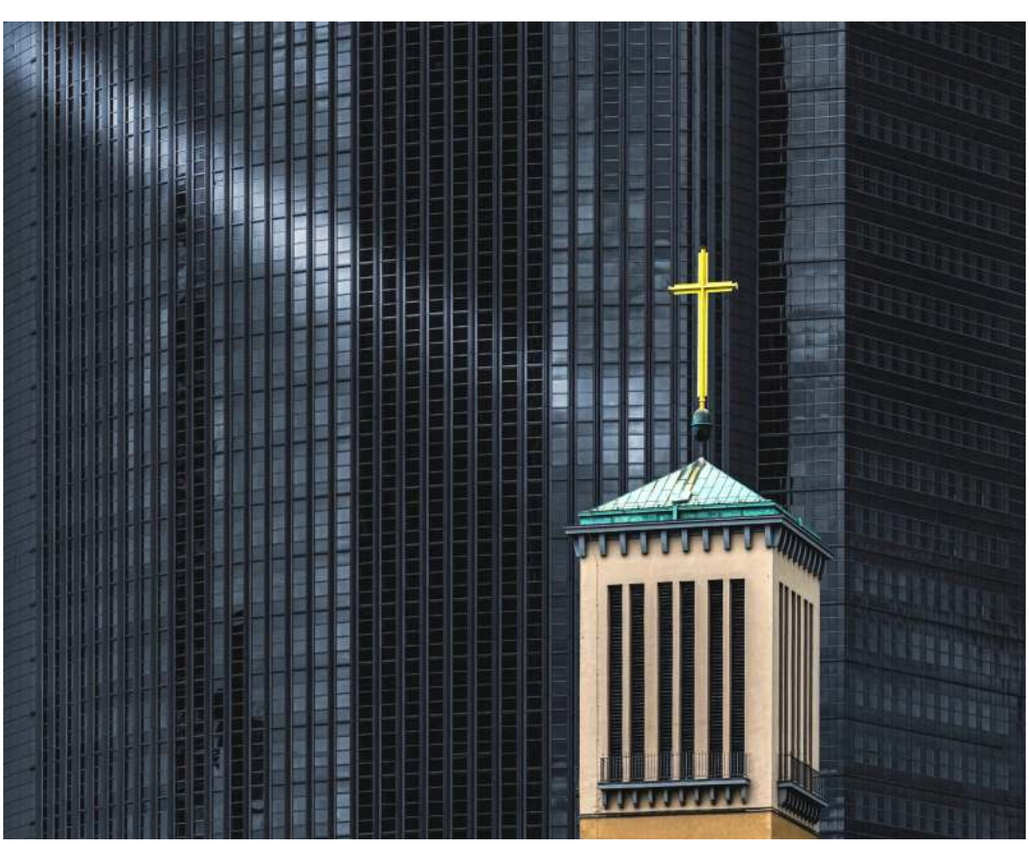
Staircase, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2026. Glashaus Office building, Krefeld

02 One colour, and where it goes

VM: A viewer on 1x compared your red to Turner's red dot. You thanked him but never said if he was right. Was he, and is there a colour you refuse to let into a frame at all?

RS: He's basically right. The coloured focal point in black-and-white photographs serves a compositional purpose – it draws the eye, provides a counterpoint to large areas of light, sky or landscape, and can thus guide the viewer's gaze. However, it doesn't necessarily have to be a point; colour keys, when used as larger areas, also make many images more attractive. Nor is red the only option. I also like orange, green and blue – depending on the subject. If a building offers no colour at all, a monochrome rendering is often better, although subtle, understated and desaturated colours can also be very attractive.

Panta Rhei, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2024. Office building, Düsseldorf



Contrasts, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2025. High-rise buildings in Frankfurt/Main

03

The architect's building, the photographer's picture

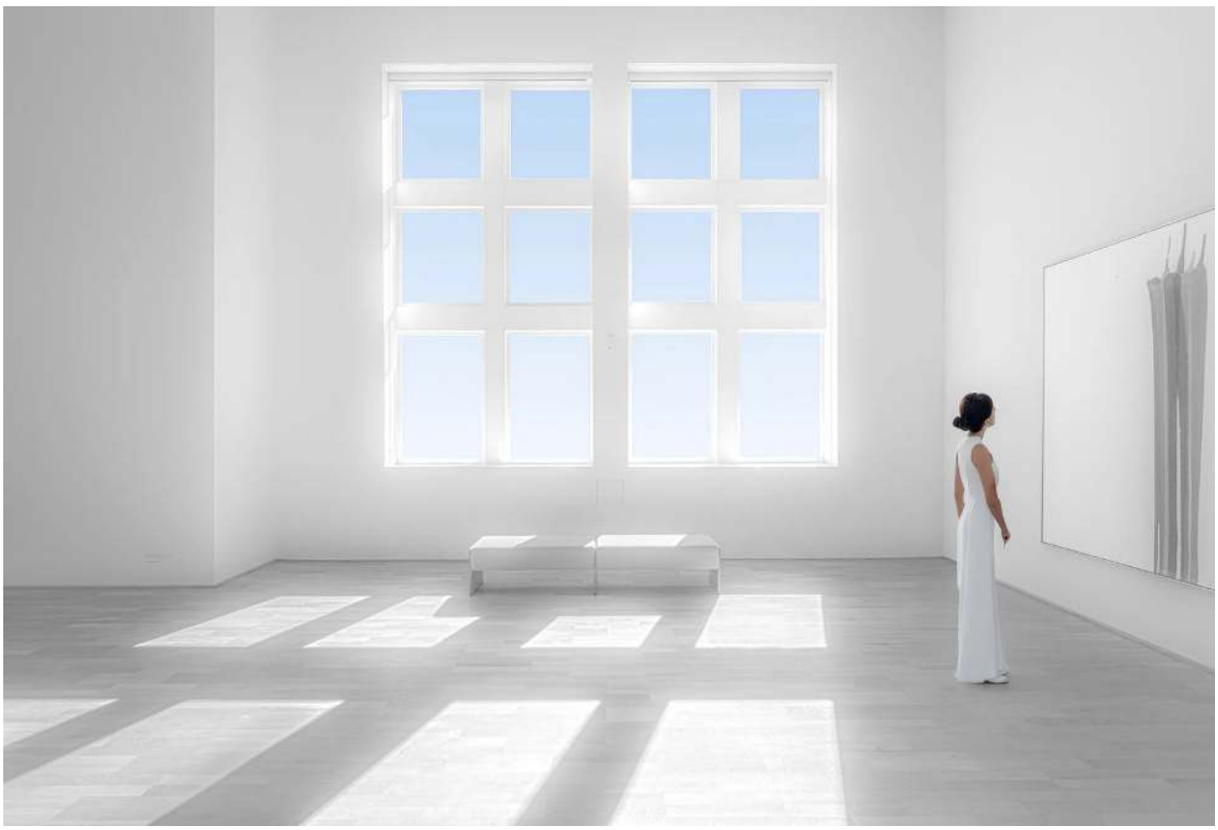
VM: An architect designs a building to be entered; you show it flat, sometimes as abstraction. Has one ever objected to what you did with their work, or thanked you for it?

RS: There have never been any objections so far. After all, artistic photography is not meant to document, but to abstract and allow aesthetics to take centre stage. Through simplification, perspective and deliberate post-processing, I attempt to remove subjects from their functional context and transform them into an independent world of fine art photography. A good art photograph should not explain, but leave room for interpretation. My images are therefore a conscious, aesthetic and personal interpretation of what I have seen and felt.

For me, photography is much more than just a hobby. It is fulfilment, a philosophy of life, work-life balance and, above all, a passion. It is an essential part of my life. Photography brings me joy. In my view, a good photograph is one that conveys a clear message and appeals to the viewer's emotions. My passion lies in art photography – the artistic aspect, not merely rationality and documentation. For me, post-processing is just as important as the act of taking the photograph itself.

Research is usually the starting point. I only head to the location once I have a clear idea of how I want to capture the subject: the nature of the building, what it looks like, and what the architect intended to express. As for the photos themselves, I usually take plenty of time to choose the right spot, the right angle, the right focal length and so on. However, I usually photograph the subject from various angles, capturing both the overall scene and the finer details. Sometimes the idea for a picture only comes to me afterwards.

A good art photograph should not explain, but leave room for interpretation.



Looking at the Picture, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2025. Museum of modern art, Münster

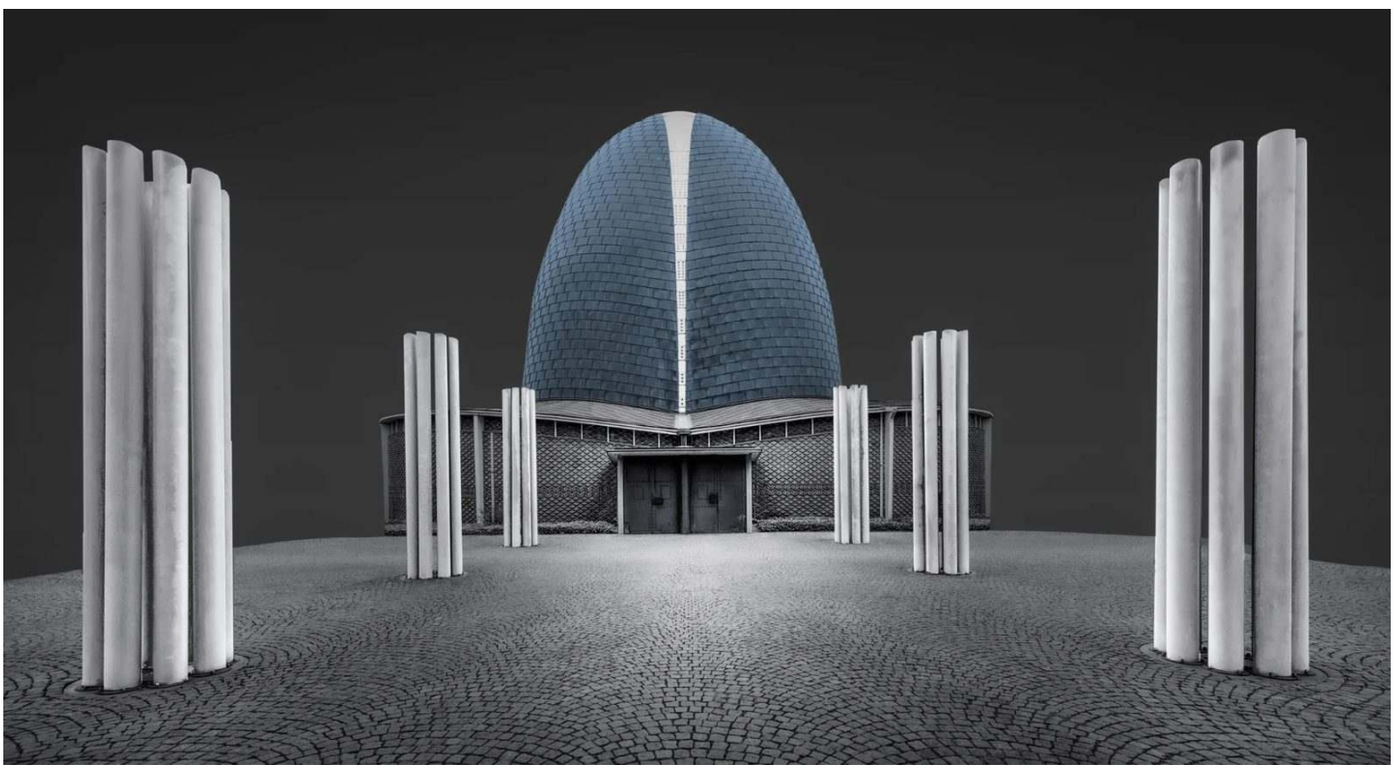
Neuer Zollhof, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2025. Frank O. Gehry building, Media Harbor, Düsseldorf

04 Asking permission

VM: Germany's Panoramafreiheit covers the street, not an interior like the MAK staircase. What is your actual rule for asking permission, and has it ever cost you a picture?

RS: When I want to take photographs indoors, for example in museums, I ask for permission to do so. This is usually no problem, especially as I generally don't photograph people in a way that makes them recognisable. In public buildings, this is normally no problem either, unlike, for example, in company premises. There, taking photographs indoors is often prohibited. And yes, that has cost me an interesting photo or two on occasion.

However, I've never had any problems so far; if you ask politely, you'll usually get a friendly reply. In the case of religious buildings or specially protected sites, you can also find out about photography permits online in advance and, if necessary, apply for them by email. If in doubt, the rule is: ask politely, point out that the photos are for non-commercial use, and then taking photos is usually no problem.



St. Rochus III, Roland M Schwerdtfeger, 2024. A small church in Düsseldorf

05 After the shutter

VM: How much of an image happens after the shutter closes? Name the line: what would you never remove from a frame, and what goes without a second thought?

RS: It really varies a lot. Every image is edited in Lightroom and Photoshop. Sometimes I only adjust the highlights and shadows, but usually I do more: I replace the sky and remove distracting elements from the image. In some cases, I add elements like streetlights or even people. However, the main subject always remains the most important element and is never removed. I do use AI, but primarily to replace individual elements; it never becomes the designer of the image.

I do use AI, but primarily to replace individual elements; it never becomes the designer of the image.

06 The jury

VM: 1x refuses most of what it receives; you have 442 accepted. What did the refusals teach you that the acceptances never did, and does a jury change how you edit, honestly?

RS: To be honest, I've only had three rejections so far, which I'm very happy about. As a curator, however, I also see a lot of negative examples and am glad that 1X is such a well-curated platform with very high standards. And no, the jury doesn't change the way I edit my photos; I take and edit photos out of passion, not opportunism. That said, I don't submit any photos that I think wouldn't be accepted. I don't have a single photo on the walls at home. There's only modern art hanging there, no photography.

07 The print on someone's wall

VM: A print becomes a physical object on someone's wall. What does an image gain in that move, and whom do you picture actually living with it?

RS: A printed photograph, set in a high-quality frame with a passe-partout, becomes an object in its own right and takes on a completely different significance compared to a photograph on a screen. In this way, the image can be elevated to the status of a work of art. By contrast, the screen offers greater brilliance, and the colours are more vibrant. A physical gallery or an exhibition opening conveys a very different atmosphere to an online gallery; the impression and the experience are entirely different. And both have their place.

Who do I picture with photos on the wall? This is certainly more than one target audience; when it comes to architectural photos, perhaps people with modern, contemporary interiors rather than traditionalists. Design enthusiasts rather than nostalgics. Yes, it has happened that photos have impressed me on screen, only to disappoint when seen as prints. The size of the print also sometimes plays a role. There are photos that have a greater impact as their size increases. Weak photos, on the other hand, do not improve with a large format…

08 Two he would take back

VM: Of 442 published images, is there one you'd take back, and what question about your work are you tired of being asked, that nobody else asks instead?

RS: Yes, there are indeed two photos that I wouldn't publish today; unfortunately, you can't delete them on 1X… I'm always happy to answer questions, and I never tire of them. Sometimes, though, I hear people say: 'Your photos are brilliant – what camera do you use?' That always makes me smile. Of course, you need a system camera and the right kit; there are lots of things you simply can't achieve with just a standard lens. But ultimately, the brand of camera doesn't matter. You can't tell from a photo which camera was used to take it.

You can't tell from a photo which camera was used to take it.

Roland M Schwerdtfeger's work can be seen at 1x.com/rolandmschwerdtfeger and on Instagram at @roland_m_schwerdtfeger. All images © Roland M Schwerdtfeger, published with the artist's permission. ■

INTERVIEW SEPTEMBER 17, 2026

Diana Aleshchenko: Safety Comes From Openness

A new architecture graduate on a rehabilitation centre without right angles, a student campus built for wartime, and a courtyard that keeps the memory of July 1917 inside a railway hub.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & DIANA ALESHCHENKO

SECTION II · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & DIANA ALESHCHENKO

A new architecture graduate on a rehabilitation centre without right angles, a student campus built for wartime, and a courtyard that keeps the memory of July 1917 inside a railway hub.

Diana Aleshchenko is from Kyiv. This year she completed her master's degree in architecture and urban planning at the Kyiv National University of Construction and Architecture (KNUBA), and her student portfolio already spans three very different briefs: a rehabilitation centre in Zhytomyr for people recovering from severe injury and trauma, a campus with student housing in Kharkiv, and a greenhouse complex at the Kyiv-Volynskyi railway hub.

What connects them is an insistence that every formal decision has to earn its place. The rounded walls in her rehabilitation centre are about wheelchairs and anxiety before they are about softness; the louvres on its façade are about who can see whom. EPRIS Journal asked her about the reasoning behind these projects, and about what it means to design for Ukrainian cities now.

Diana Aleshchenko with her project boards.

Tell us a little about yourself: where are you from, where did you study, and how did you come to architecture?

I'm from Kyiv, and this year I received my master's degree in architecture and urban planning at KNUBA in Kyiv. I don't have a unique story about a sudden childhood revelation after which I decided to tie my life to architecture. As I see it, the path took shape quite naturally and consistently: through a chain of my own decisions, a gradually growing interest in space, and specific life events that step by step brought me to where I am now.

What in your childhood or youth pushed you towards architecture in particular?

There wasn't a single childhood trigger that decided everything. It was more a gradual combination of interests in drawing, geometry and creative work, which with age simply turned into a conscious choice of profession.

How much did your studies at KNUBA shape your approach to design?

My studies gave me a clear understanding that learning never actually ends. From project to project you keep coming back to the point where you have to look for information again, research, find inspiration and endlessly rework decisions in search of form, all of it under tight deadlines. You start with one picture in your head and try to realise exactly that, but along the way everything transforms, and in the end something quite different is born, something much deeper. University taught me to keep up with that pace, to make decisions quickly and not to be afraid to let go of first ideas for the sake of a stronger final result.

With a presentation model of one of her projects.

In your rehabilitation centre in Zhytomyr you chose bionic forms and rounded corners so that patients would feel safe. How did you decide which architectural devices genuinely create a sense of protection, rather than simply looking soft?

First of all, smooth, rounded, radial walls are far more comfortable to move along for a person in a wheelchair or with a prosthesis, where every corner is a potential obstacle. Given the specifics of the facility, and after analysing typical hospital plans with their 90-degree corners, we also took the psycho-emotional factor into account. For a person with acute stress disorder or PTSD, someone suddenly appearing from around a corner becomes an additional trigger for anxiety.

The rehabilitation centre in Zhytomyr. Angled metal louvres give patients privacy from the street while keeping the view open.

The metal louvres in the same project are angled so that patients can see the courtyard while passers-by on the street cannot see them. How did this solution come about, and were there options that didn't work?

From the very beginning we intended to make open balconies, so that a patient could get some fresh air without leaving their own room. But after consultations with specialists it became clear that for people with psychological trauma this is a dangerous solution. So the team held a brainstorm, looking for a way to keep the original idea, contact with the air and the forest, while making it completely safe. We tested full glazing and ordinary blinds, but they either created the feeling of a closed cell or blocked the view of nature entirely. Rotating louvres set at an angle turned out to be the best answer. They give the necessary privacy from the street, leave the patient a direct view of the courtyard and the pine forest, and at the same time allow the room to be aired comfortably without a sense of isolation. In the end this functional safety measure became the main visual feature of the whole façade.

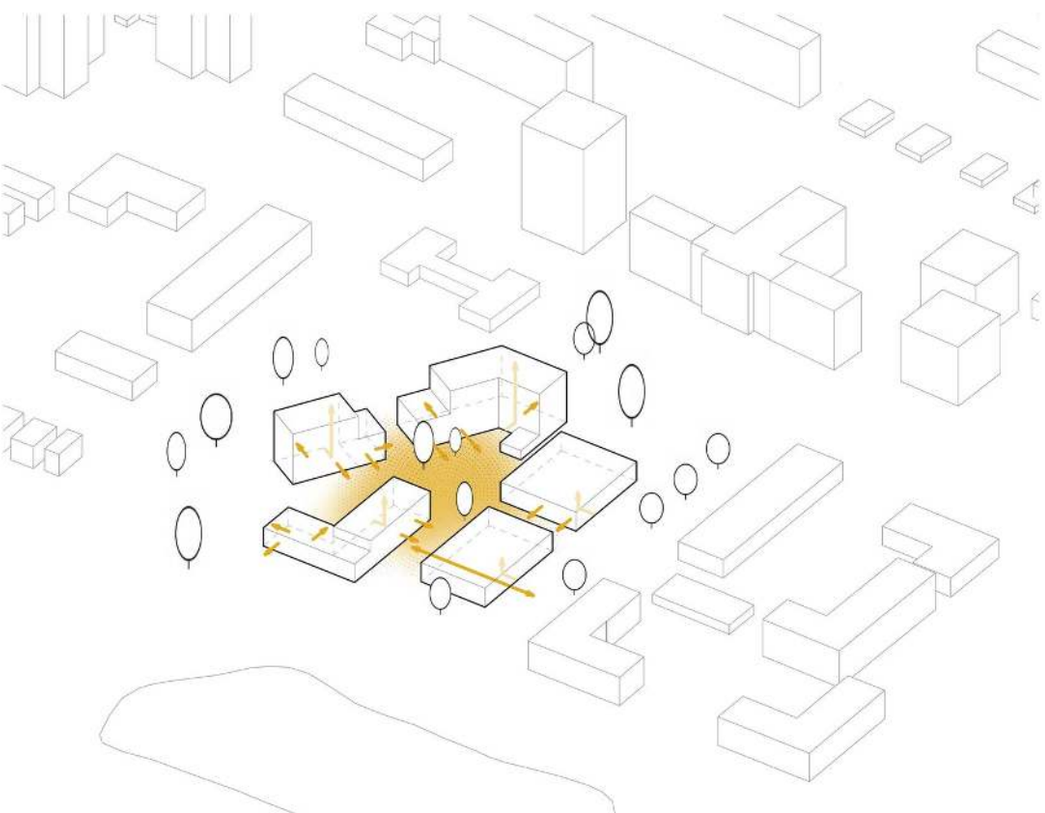
The project was developed through consultations with medical staff at rehabilitation centres. Which of their advice changed the original concept the most?

Of course, the initial conceptual decisions were strongly influenced by the specifics of the building and research into its future users. We analysed different groups in detail, their particular needs and the real practice of how such facilities are arranged. During one of the consultations we were able to talk to a person who had created and improved rehabilitation centres in practice. The main insight of that conversation was an understanding of patients' psychological state and the specifics of their safety, and as a result we abandoned open balconies entirely. For ordinary housing or a hotel a balcony seems a natural choice, but for people undergoing rehabilitation after severe injuries, open cantilevered spaces create unnecessary anxiety and risk.

Your diploma project, a campus and student housing in Kharkiv, is built on a hybrid model: the ground floor becomes open public space, and the housing above is modular. Why this typology rather than the familiar corridor dormitory?

The ordinary corridor dormitory is long outdated and offers today's young people no new spatial experience. It shuts people away in narrow dark corridors, takes away the balance between socialising and privacy, and feels cut off from life. Active ground floors have long been an absolute must in good housing, and on a student campus they are even more critical. This is where an open public environment forms, with coworking spaces, shared areas and services, where students can easily make new contacts, meet classmates, exchange ideas and find like-minded people. The upper residential floors, meanwhile, are modular, so that every student has a proper personal place for focused study and rest. This hybrid typology works as a living student co-living: active socialising and integration into city life below, and a protected, ergonomic private space above.

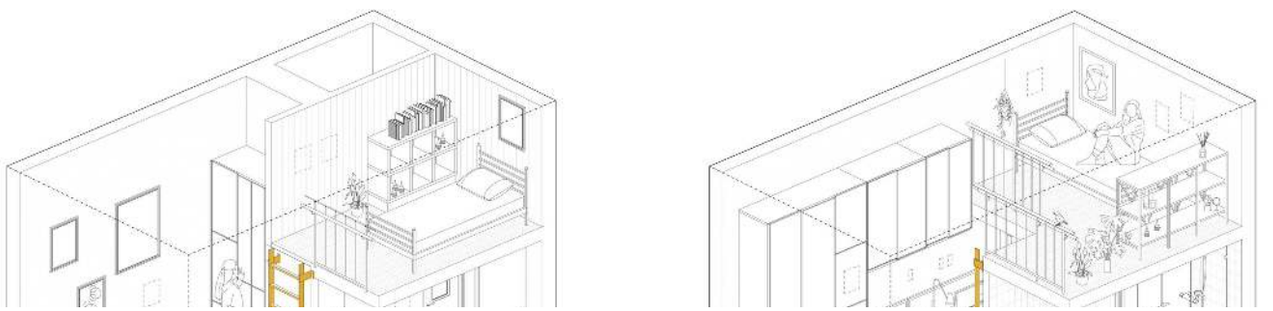
Campus and student housing in Kharkiv, master's project: an open, active ground floor with modular housing above.



Concept diagram: the shared public core of the campus among the surrounding blocks.

In one unit you place a sleeping loft to free up space for study; in another, a double, you create “vertical privacy” with a raised bed. How do you look for the balance between personal space and shared life in a student environment?

The balance between shared life and privacy starts with understanding that a person needs their own psychological territory, where their gaze and personal space do not constantly cross with others'. In a typical dormitory the beds stand on one horizontal plane, so a person is always in their neighbour's field of view, and that quickly wears you out. Vertical zoning and the sleeping mezzanine, which is the signature of the dormitory's layout, solve this problem. Raising the bed to a second level creates an individual capsule of quiet where you can completely switch off from what is happening in the room. In a single room this frees the lower level for a full workplace and for living without clutter, and in a double it gives the same vertical privacy, so that roommates don't disturb each other even within one space.



Single and double units with a raised sleeping level.

This is a diploma project about Kharkiv, a city that now lives under constant wartime pressure. How much did that reality shape decisions in the project, directly or indirectly?

Without question, the reality of war significantly shaped the work, both in meaning and in planning. Despite constant shelling and danger, Kharkiv confidently remains among the top three cities in Ukraine by number of university applicants, which only confirms how relevant the choice of site is. The city lives, and young people want to study here. But designing for such a context using the old approaches is no longer possible. Safety became the defining factor for the whole structure of the complex, so a

mandatory and fundamental part of the master's project was designing and calculating a spacious shelter. Not just a technical basement to tick a box, but a full underground space integrated into the functions of the campus.

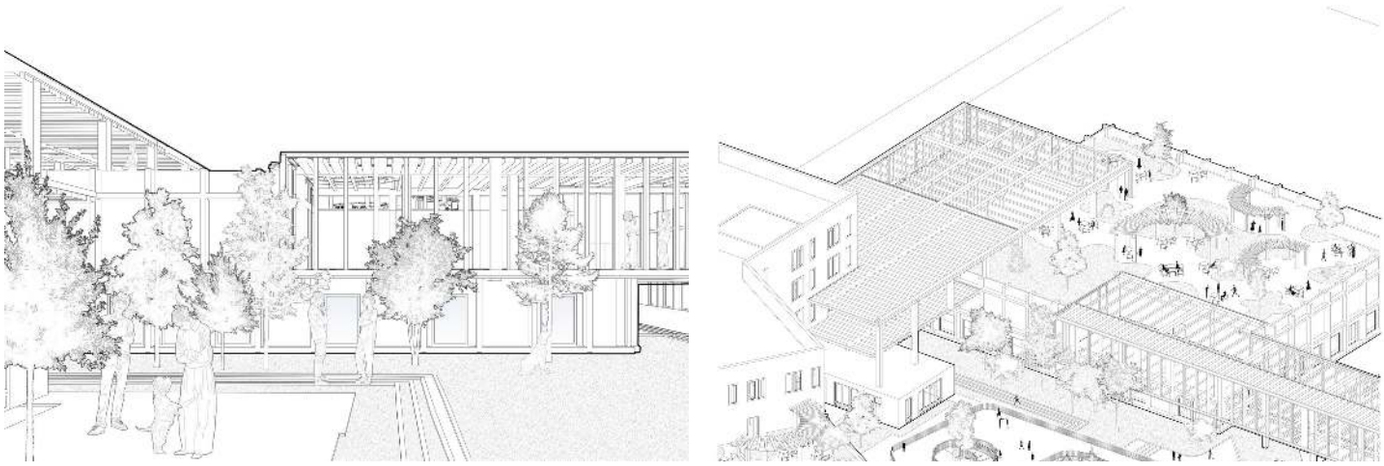
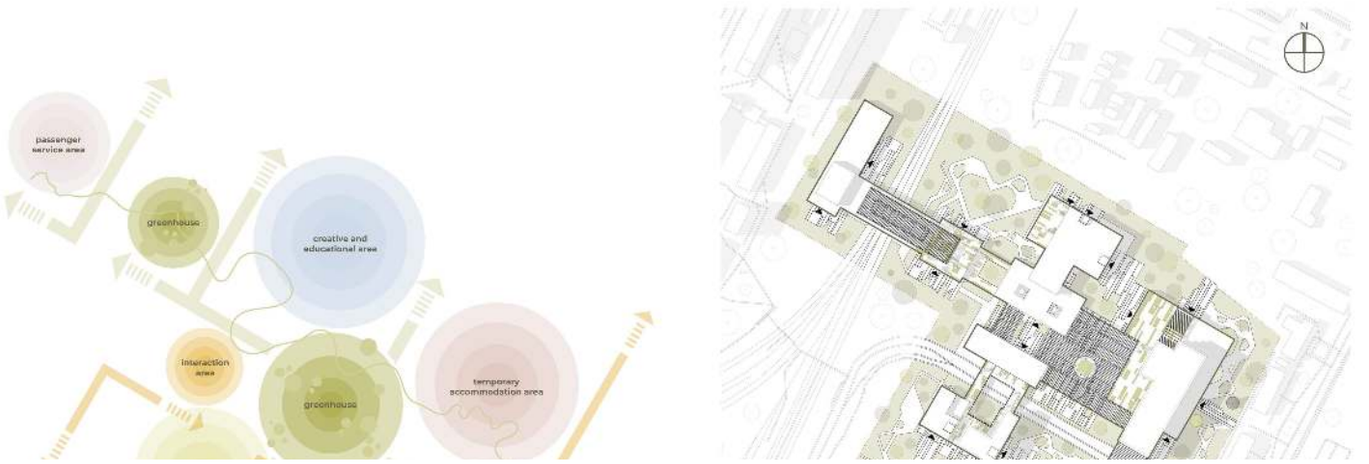


Illustration and axonometric detail from the Kharkiv campus project.

In your greenhouse project at the Kyiv-Volynskyi hub, you write about a transition from fast, noisy transit to calm and focus. How did you achieve that transition architecturally, rather than just marking it on a plan?

The transition from transit to calm is achieved above all through a clear sequence of physical barriers. Between the noisy railway and the calm that the greenhouse stands for there is not just distance. First comes a separate block of the building and an open space in front of it, which take the first wave and physically damp the main sound from the trains. Only after passing this buffer does a person come under the rhythm of pergolas and covered galleries, where the form of the complex itself begins to work as a protective contour. Low horizontal volumes and dense planting fully screen the central zone from city noise and visual chaos. The change of scale, the shade of the pergola and the green mass shift attention from the bustle of transit to quiet, creating a natural insulation around the greenhouse before a person even crosses its threshold.



The complex at the Kyiv-Volynskyi hub: functional zoning and master plan.

The inner courtyard of the same project is dedicated to the memory of the events of 1917. Where did this idea come from, and how did you work with such a sensitive subject in a space that remains a transport hub?

Any design for me begins with thorough pre-design analysis. Not only of the terrain or the surroundings, but also of the historical heritage of the site. Once I received the brief, I began my research with exactly this part of the urban analysis, looking for an initial hook from which the concept and idea of the project could develop. Few passengers realise it, but it was here, at Post-Volynskyi station, that on 26 July 1917 Russian military units opened machine-gun fire on the train of the Bohdan Khmelnytsky Regiment as it was leaving for the front. It was a tragic and symbolic starting point of the Ukrainian struggle for liberation, and it happened on these very tracks.

Working with such a subject inside a transport hub is an extremely complex and responsible task. A station lives by transit, bustle and speed. So the memory of these events and the idea of resilience are built into the heart of the complex: the inner courtyard with the greenhouse and the rhythmic structure of pergolas. This green core is the main spatial and acoustic buffer. Coming here from dynamic transit, a person finds themselves in a protected space of calm where the rumble of the railway is cut off. The greenhouse and living nature under the pergola speak of memory in the language of life, light and renewal, giving passengers the choice to rest from the noise of the city, to slow down, or to reflect on the historical weight of the place beneath their feet.

Most of your projects have very expressive graphics and atmospheric renders. Where, for you, is the line between showing architecture convincingly and letting the image become a work in its own right?

For me architectural visualisation is first of all photographic art. I don't look at it as computer graphics for the sake of special effects, but the way a photographer does who arrives at a building and looks for the right angle, feels the light, the air, the tactility of materials and the mood.

The line between being convincing and a picture that exists for its own sake runs where honesty towards the project begins. A photograph can be deep, atmospheric and artistic, but its task is to capture and reveal the real character of the environment. When a render works as an honest frame from the life of a future building, it helps a person feel the space before it is even built.

If you had to defend one of these projects before a jury asking uncomfortable questions, which decision would you defend most fiercely, and which would you admit is weak?

If I had to defend the Kharkiv campus again before a critical jury, I would most fiercely defend the decision to make the ground floor a fully active, open, multifunctional space for all residents of the city. So that a building with a sports complex or a swimming pool lives not only in the first half of the day during classes, but also in the evenings and during the holidays. The jury would probably appeal to traditional ideas about safety: that a student environment should be isolated, behind a fence. But I am convinced that closedness does not make a place safe. Safety comes from openness, from living contact with the neighbourhood, from social control and the constant presence of people on the street.

The decision I am ready to see openly criticised is the spatial optimisation of the compact units with a raised sleeping place. Although it solves the problem of privacy on a limited floor area, it is always a compromise in terms of universal inclusivity: a sleeping mezzanine suits young, mobile people, but creates a barrier for students with limited mobility.

What, in your view, distinguishes Ukrainian architectural education and the young architectural community right now?

Above all, a striking cohesion and a readiness to keep generating ideas and creating something new, whatever the external circumstances. Watching today's students, graduates, my classmates and colleagues, I see enormous inner resilience and professional courage. Our generation is being formed in exceptionally difficult conditions, but this

has not broken our interest in the profession; on the contrary, it has sharpened our sense of responsibility and the quality of the projects. Right now the Ukrainian architectural community is raising very strong, competitive and thoughtful specialists who are ready to work with the most complex spatial and social challenges.

Tell us about something that has inspired you recently: a project, a place, a person.

For me music, film and photography are not just a source of emotion but a real foundation for architectural decisions. Any creative work around you can become an unexpected impulse for a space. One recent example was the concept of one of my master's projects, inspired by Ariana Grande's album and the film of the same name, Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind. I really love that process, when a sincere personal passion turns into an unconventional architectural idea.

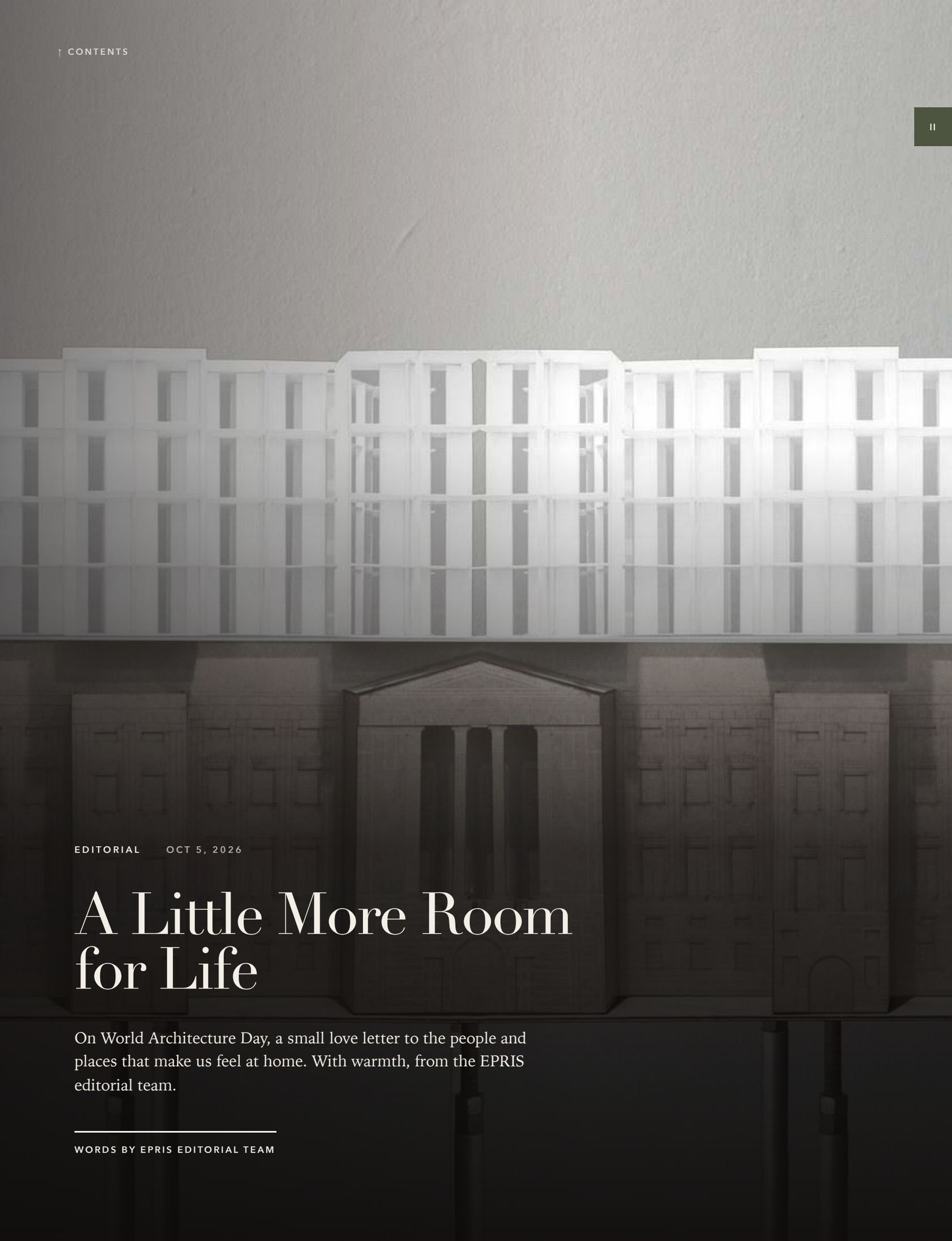
How do you see your architectural career from here?

I definitely see my future development within the Ukrainian architectural community. I want to create, to rebuild, and to do everything possible so that space in our home cities is inspiring, alive and safe for people. It matters to me to invest my experience and vision in an environment that truly matters and needs real change here and now.

What advice would you give yourself at the start of your studies?

Keep training your eye, don't stop at the first successful option and keep generating, because the best solutions often appear after you thought the search was over. And a purely practical piece of advice: move to digital tools and computer graphics as early as possible, and keep figuring out the new functions and tricks of the software. The more freely you handle the software, the more precisely and quickly you can realise any spatial idea.

Visualisations and drawings: Diana Aleshchenko. Interview conducted in writing for EPRIS Journal, September 2026. ■



EDITORIAL OCT 5, 2026

A Little More Room for Life

On World Architecture Day, a small love letter to the people and places that make us feel at home. With warmth, from the EPRIS editorial team.

WORDS BY EPRIS EDITORIAL TEAM

SECTION II · EDITORIAL · EPRIS EDITORIAL TEAM

On World Architecture Day, a small love letter to the people and places that make us feel at home. With warmth, from the EPRIS editorial team.

World Architecture Day · 5 October 2026

Dear architects, students, makers and lovers of places,

Before a building becomes part of a city, it is something small enough to hold in your hands. A pencil line. A folded sheet. A piece of card patiently cut and glued. A model turned towards the window to see where the light will fall. Architecture begins in these modest gestures – and in the extraordinary belief that an ordinary day can be made better.

Today we are celebrating that belief, and the people who keep it alive. The sketches redrawn, the models rebuilt, the questions asked one more time. The care that rarely appears in the finished photograph: a handrail that feels right, a door that opens easily, a room that leaves enough space for someone else. Thank you for the imagination – and for the patience behind it.

The idea, up close: a detail of the physical "Affordable Palace" model (2019), Opposite Office / Benedikt Hartl. Crop of the cover photograph · CC BY 4.0.

For the rooms that welcome us. For the cities that let us belong. For the people who imagine both.

The human measure

At EPRIS, architecture is close to the heart. It shapes the way we notice light, tell stories and look for meaning in a detail. We love its great gestures. But we also love the quiet ones: a shaded courtyard, a generous threshold, a bench where you can stay without having to buy anything.

This year's World Architecture Day theme, "Housing is a Human Right. Build It.", brings us back to the essential. Beauty should not stop at the image of a building. It should reach the person who lives inside it. A safe, dignified home is the beginning of that promise, not its finishing touch.

A wish from our worktable to yours

May you find collaborators who listen, clients who trust and the courage to protect a good idea. May there be fewer exhausted nights and more mornings when a difficult drawing suddenly makes sense. May your spaces hold conversations, childhoods, small celebrations and the simple relief of coming home. And may you never lose the pleasure of noticing how sunlight changes a wall.

Happy World Architecture Day.
Thank you for making a little more room for life.

With warmth,
the EPRIS editorial team. ▪

> Cover: photograph of the architectural model "Affordable Palace" (2019), Opposite Office / Benedikt Hartl. Wikimedia Commons · CC BY 4.0. Resized and compressed for the web; cover display may crop the photograph.

FURTHER

World Architecture Day 2026 – official date and theme, International Union of Architects (UIA)	uia-architectes.org/en/world-architecture-day/world-architecture-day-2026-housing-is-a-human-right-build-it
Cover photograph – Opposite Office / Benedikt Hartl	commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Affordable_Palace_Opposite_Office_4600x3450.jpg
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URBANISM & PUBLIC SPACE OCT 8, 2026

Who Needs a Museum? The Urban Design of Invitation

A museum does not find its public at the ticket desk. It finds—or loses—it through transport, pavements, thresholds and the civic life of the street.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · URBANISM & PUBLIC SPACE · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

A museum does not find its public at the ticket desk. It finds—or loses—it through transport, pavements, thresholds and the civic life of the street.

A museum visit rarely begins with art. It begins with a calculation: how long the trip will take, whether the route is legible, whether the entrance looks public, whether there is somewhere to pause, whether the building seems intended for people like us. The institution may own a major collection and charge nothing, yet still remain socially and spatially expensive. A free door at the end of an uncertain journey is not the same thing as access.

This is the central urban problem of mass culture. Museums are asked to serve a broad public, but they are often planned as singular objects: a landmark placed on a site, photographed from across a plaza and judged by what happens inside. Visitors experience something else. They encounter a chain of thresholds stretching from the timetable to the pavement, from the pavement to the forecourt, from the forecourt to security, and from security to the first room. Every threshold can convert a passer-by into a visitor – or quietly send them away.

The museum does not find its public at the ticket desk. It finds – or loses – it along the route through the city.

Who actually needs the museum?

The conventional answer is universal: everyone. It is morally attractive and operationally weak. Different publics need different things from the same institution. A tourist may need a recognisable destination and a predictable two-hour visit. A local resident may need a place that remains useful after the temporary exhibition closes. A parent needs toilets, seating and a route that works with a buggy. A teenager may need permission to enter without already knowing how to behave. A disabled visitor needs reliable information before leaving home, not an improvised solution at the door.

Participation data makes the limits of universality visible. England's 2019–20 Taking Part survey found that 51 per cent of adults had visited a museum or gallery in the previous year; nearly half had not. Later Participation Survey data continued to show strong differences by education, occupation and deprivation. Free admission can increase total attendance without automatically changing who feels entitled, informed or able to attend. The museum's public is not simply waiting outside. It is produced by transport, time, habit, social confidence and the design of the invitation.

Access is a sequence, not a radius

Urban plans often describe cultural access with circles: a museum lies within a ten-minute walk, or within a transit catchment. Distance matters, but the circle hides the journey. Recent research on perceived museum accessibility proposes a more useful sequence: pre-trip feasibility, comfort and predictability in transit, and usability on arrival. Two museums can be equally close in metres and radically different in practice. One route crosses active shopfronts and a shaded square; the other follows a blank wall, crosses six traffic lanes and ends at an entrance visible only after a security barrier.

The sequence suggests six forms of friction. Informational friction asks whether opening hours, price and access conditions are clear. Temporal friction measures the real time cost, including transfers and queues. Mobility friction includes broken pavements, unsafe crossings and missing step-free routes. Visual friction concerns whether the destination and door can be found. Social friction asks whether the approach signals welcome or surveillance. Procedural friction begins at the threshold: bag rules, ticketing, security and the uncertainty of where to go next.

No single architectural gesture removes all six. A spectacular canopy cannot repair an unreliable bus; free admission cannot make a hostile underpass comfortable; a transparent lobby cannot help if the only approach is a service road. The effective unit of museum design is therefore not the building but the complete visitor journey.

How to find a visitor in the street

The passer-by is not an empty category. Most people on a street already have a destination, a schedule and a reason for being there. To attract them, a museum must offer a low-risk interruption. The first requirement is visibility, but visibility is not the same as monumentality. A façade can be unmistakable and still conceal what entry involves. Useful visibility reveals activity: a foyer, a free installation, a café, people sitting, a route continuing through rather than terminating at the institution.

The second requirement is a reversible commitment. A person should be able to approach, look and leave without embarrassment or cost. Steps, forecourts, arcades, gardens and free halls can create this intermediate condition. The Metropolitan Museum's steps are successful not because they funnel everyone efficiently through the doors but because they also operate as seating, meeting place and urban theatre. Their civic use allows the museum to enter ordinary routines before a ticket is considered.

The third requirement is information at the speed of walking. A street-facing message has seconds, not minutes. It should answer three questions: what can I see now, can I enter without booking, and how much time or money will it require? Institutional slogans answer none of them. A programme board, a visible free zone and a clear door do more work than a campaign about openness.

Not every street can do the same job

The ideal museum street is often imagined as busy, central and mixed-use. That is only one model. A high street supplies continuous footfall, public transport and reasons to combine a visit with other errands. A park edge supplies slower movement, family use and room for outdoor work. A waterfront supplies visibility and promenade traffic but may become empty in poor weather or after dark. A campus offers repeated local users but can feel territorial to outsiders. An industrial fringe provides scale and affordability while making spontaneous attendance harder.

The question is not whether a street is universally suitable. It is whether its existing movement patterns match the museum's public mission. A venue dependent on school groups needs coach access and safe group assembly. A contemporary art hall seeking young local audiences needs evening transit, ordinary food nearby and a threshold that does not read as ceremonial. A sculpture museum can use a park as an open collection, while a fragile archive may require a more controlled edge. The programme and the street must be designed as one system.

Four street conditions are consistently valuable: a continuous pedestrian route, enough dwell space near the entrance, active uses that extend beyond museum hours, and more than one reason to be there. Footfall alone is not enough. Commuters moving through a narrow interchange may be numerous but unavailable. A smaller flow that already slows down – to sit, meet, eat, watch or cross a park – can be more convertible.

Public art is not automatically public

Large sculpture and murals are frequently asked to solve the relationship between museum and city. They can establish orientation, make a route memorable and allow contact with art without admission. But scale and outdoor location do not guarantee publicness. A work on a fenced plaza, surrounded by traffic or presented without shade, seating or a safe crossing, remains formally public and practically remote.

Public art becomes urban infrastructure when it changes what a place permits. It may create a meeting point, mark an accessible route, provide shelter, hold a memory that commercial development would erase, or connect neighbourhoods across a barrier. This is a higher standard than visual impact. It asks who can approach the work, at what hours, under whose rules, and whether lingering is treated as legitimate.

The distinction also protects art from being reduced to placemaking equipment. Not every work must produce sociability or economic uplift. Critical, difficult and even obstructive art has a public role. The urban obligation lies with the setting: the city must provide the physical and civic conditions in which disagreement, curiosity and indifference can occur without purchase.

The Bilbao problem

Guggenheim Bilbao at sunset, seen as part of the river landscape rather than as an isolated icon. Photograph by Thomas Fabian, CC BY-SA 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

The Guggenheim Bilbao remains the unavoidable case because it turned a museum into a global image of urban change. The ‘Bilbao effect’ is commonly narrated as architectural causation: commission an extraordinary building and visitors, investment and confidence will follow. The account is incomplete. The museum belonged to a broader programme of riverfront remediation, transport investment, new public space and economic restructuring. The icon was powerful because the city had altered the systems around it.

Copying the object without those systems produces cultural isolation: a destination reached by visitors but weakly connected to local life. Regeneration can also redistribute value unevenly. Rising land prices, tourist retail and the branding of former industrial districts may displace the communities whose history supplied the area’s identity. A museum can be economically successful while narrowing the social meaning of its surroundings.

The relevant question is therefore not whether a museum increases visitor numbers, but how value circulates. Do local routes improve? Can residents use the landscape without buying admission? Are small businesses connected to the new footfall? Does the institution commission locally and provide routes into employment? Does the public realm remain public when the museum is closed? These questions turn impact from a headline into an urban account.

The free room before the collection

A museum can lower the institutional threshold by placing useful public rooms before the controlled galleries: foyer, library, toilets, café, seating, project space, education room or covered passage. Tate Modern's Turbine Hall demonstrates the force of such a room. It is monumental, but its practical achievement is simpler: a visitor can enter an unmistakably cultural interior without first choosing an exhibition or demonstrating expertise.

This front room should not be confused with a retail lobby. Its success depends on non-commercial permission. If every chair belongs to a café, if security challenges people who are waiting, or if the free route is visually subordinate to the ticketed one, the promise collapses. The best threshold spaces support several durations: two minutes to orient oneself, twenty minutes to meet someone, an hour to work, or an afternoon that gradually becomes a museum visit.

Inside, the city continues

Crossing the door does not end the urban problem. Museum circulation distributes attention much as streets distribute movement. Visitors follow visible openings, other people, landmarks and perceived shortcuts. A century of visitor studies shows that path choice cannot be reduced to a universal rule such as always turning right. Layout, attraction, prior knowledge, crowding and individual purpose interact.

Good wayfinding is not the multiplication of signs. It begins with an intelligible spatial structure: a visible next destination, distinguishable routes, places to stop without blocking movement and a reliable way back. Digital navigation can assist, but it cannot repair a plan in which every threshold looks identical or the main stair is hidden. The museum should allow both a concise route for a first-time visitor and lateral choices for return visits.

The deepest connection between museum and city is therefore behavioural. Both should permit orientation without demanding obedience. A successful museum route offers enough structure to reduce anxiety and enough choice to sustain discovery. That balance is especially important for visitors who do not arrive with a learned museum habit.

Three tests for the museum edge

Three influential accounts of public life sharpen the museum's urban obligations. They do not provide a style guide. Each offers a test: whether the edge is watched and inhabited, whether life precedes form, and whether visitors can act rather than merely receive.

The inhabited edge

> "There must be eyes upon the street, eyes belonging to those we might call the natural proprietors of the street." – Jane Jacobs

Jacobs's "eyes upon the street" are often reduced to passive surveillance. Her larger point is about reciprocal confidence produced by ordinary activity. Applied to a museum, it asks whether the ground floor contributes doors, windows, work, seating and repeated local presence – or only a guarded façade. The museum edge becomes safer and more public when people have reasons to inhabit it that are not limited to exhibition attendance.

Life before form

> "First life, then spaces, then buildings – the other way around never works." – Jan Gehl

Gehl reverses the usual museum competition, in which a building is commissioned first and public behaviour is expected to follow. His sequence begins with observation: who already walks, waits, plays, works and meets here; at what hours; in what weather; and with what physical constraints? Space can then support those patterns and create new ones. The building comes last as a participant in public life, not its substitute.

From audience to participant

> "A place where visitors can create, share, and connect with each other around content." – Nina Simon

Simon's participatory museum shifts the public from demographic target to cultural actor. Urbanistically, participation begins before a workshop or comment wall. Can people appropriate the steps, hall or garden for meeting and informal use? Can local knowle-

dge enter the institution's programme? A threshold that tolerates only the behaviour designed by the museum contradicts participation even when the exhibition invites feedback.

Together, the three tests form a demanding sequence. Jacobs asks whether everyday life makes the edge trustworthy. Gehl asks whether observed human activity shaped the space. Simon asks whether the institution gives visitors meaningful agency. A museum can pass one and fail the others: it may be busy but non-participatory, beautifully scaled but socially controlled, or participatory inside while remaining forbidding from the street.

A practical test for the museum street

Before approving a cultural building, planners and institutions should walk the complete route with several users and record the points of uncertainty. Can the entrance be identified from the nearest stop? Is every crossing legal, direct and step-free? Can a person pause near the door without buying anything? Is the current programme legible from the pavement? Are opening hours and prices visible before the security line? Does the ground floor reveal a public use? Is there a reason to remain when the galleries are closed?

They should also measure what conventional attendance figures miss: how many people use the forecourt without entering, which approaches are avoided, where groups wait, when the edge becomes empty, how often passers-by ask security for directions, and whether local residents return for non-exhibition uses. These observations reveal whether the institution is a public place or merely a publicised object.

A museum becomes civic when the city can use it before deciding to visit it.

The museum as an agreement with the street

Mass art does not mean art simplified for the largest possible audience. It means the possibility of encounter is distributed broadly enough that knowledge, confidence and money are not prerequisites for crossing the threshold. Architecture cannot accomplish this alone, but it can make exclusion easier or harder. So can the bus timetable, the crossing signal, the bench, the programme board, the guard's instructions and the price of an hour.

The museum's urban task is not to capture every passer-by. It is to make approach understandable, entry reversible and return plausible. Some people will use the steps and never see the collection. Some will come for the café, the view, the toilet, the library or the shelter. This is not leakage from the institution's purpose. It is the process by which an institution becomes part of ordinary civic life – and by which a passer-by may eventually become a visitor on their own terms. ■

Sources and further reading

Research and text by Viacheslav Munister for EPRIS Journal. Statistical claims are drawn from the linked official surveys and peer-reviewed studies. Illustrations are open-licence images from Wikimedia Commons; each caption links to its source and licence record.

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INSTITUTIONS & EXHIBITIONS OCT 9, 2026

Where Wisdom Takes Form: Inside the New CCA Tashkent

In a transformed 1912 power station, HIKMAH asks whether clay, brick, thread and collective use can give Central Asia's newest art institution a language of its own.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION II · INSTITUTIONS & EXHIBITIONS · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

In a transformed 1912 power station, HIKMAH asks whether clay, brick, thread and collective use can give Central Asia's newest art institution a language of its own.

A new art centre rarely opens with a question as old as wisdom. Institutions normally announce themselves through scale, novelty or civic ambition. CCA Tashkent begins differently. Its inaugural exhibition, HIKMAH, asks what knowledge can reside in clay, brick, thread, copper, gesture and repetition – and whether a building marked by empire, industry and technological change can become an instrument for thinking rather than a neutral container for display.

The Centre for Contemporary Arts Tashkent opened on 6 September 2026 in a former tram depot and diesel power station built in 1912. Reworked by the Paris-based practice Studio KO, it is presented as the first permanent centre of its kind in Tashkent and the wider region: not a museum with a historical collection, but a producing institution for exhibitions, performance, film, music, education and research. That distinction matters. A collection stabilises a narrative. A kunsthalle-like centre must continually invent one – and persuade a public that the invention belongs to them.

CCA Tashkent is most convincing when architecture, artwork and public use are allowed to alter one another.

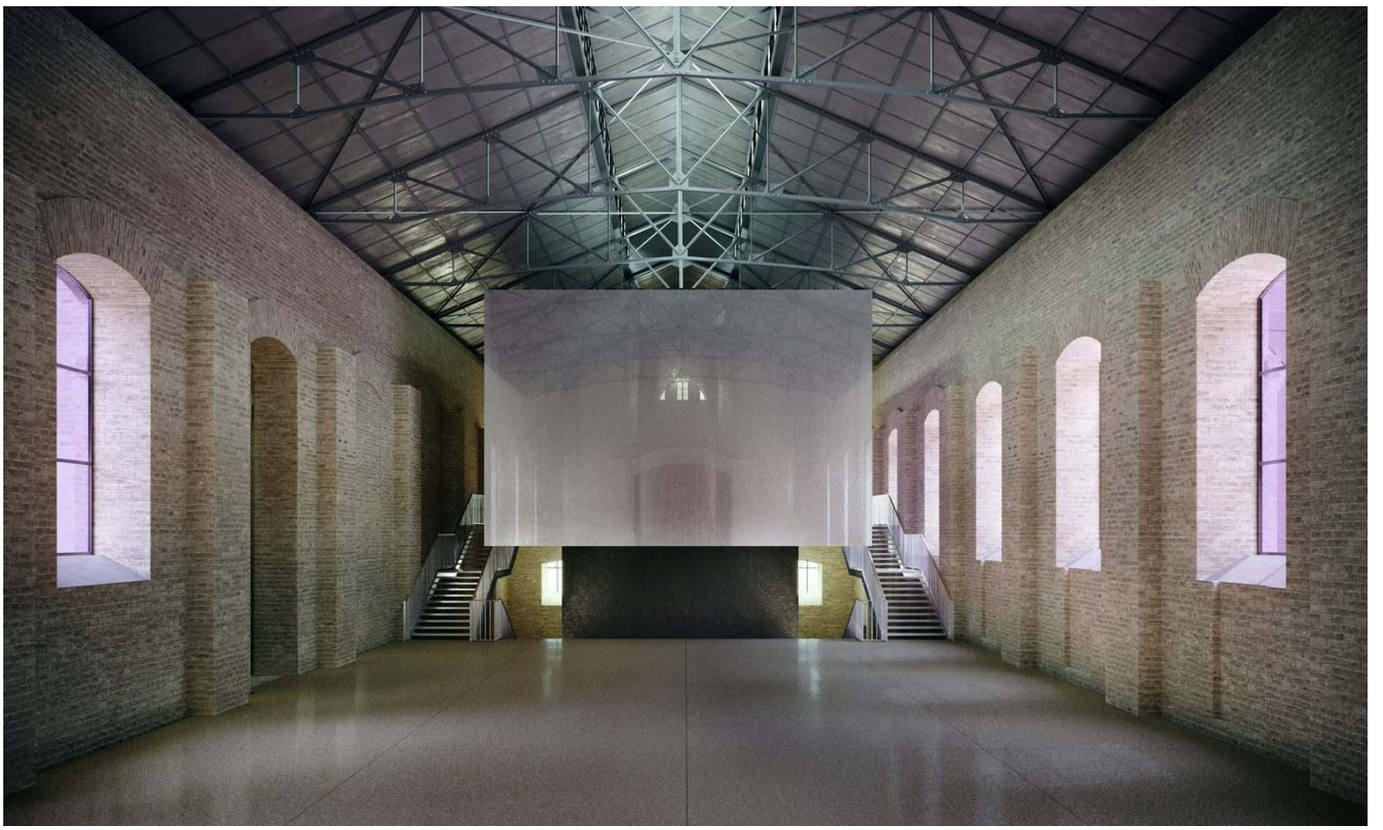
Opening day at CCA Tashkent, 6 September 2026. The circular stair became both circulation and an informal auditorium for the Centre's first public. Official photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

A power station learns a different form of energy

The building stands close to Amir Temur Square, within the composite urban fabric of central Tashkent. The city around it is already an archive of competing projects: late-imperial brick construction, Soviet monumental planning, post-independence symbols and the accelerated development of the present. The 1912 complex belongs to an early infrastructural layer. Designed for trams and diesel generation, it organised movement and power before it organised culture.

That history gives the conversion more than picturesque industrial character. Electricity and transport were technologies through which the modern city reordered time, distance and labour. The new centre inherits those histories while changing the type of energy being distributed. Its raw material is now attention: who receives it, whose work is amplified, what histories can be made visible, and how long a visitor is invited to remain.

Adaptive reuse is frequently praised as if the mere retention of old walls guaranteed cultural memory. It does not. Industrial architecture can become a luxury surface, stripped of the labour that produced its scars. Studio KO's stronger decision was to treat the surviving fabric as an active constraint. The old power hall keeps its long basilica-like volume, brick walls, arched openings and exposed roof structure. New interventions do not imitate that language. They arrive as terrazzo planes, curved circulation and dark insertions whose difference is legible.



The former diesel hall after Studio KO's intervention. Brick, steel trusses and a suspended contemporary volume remain visibly distinct. Official architectural photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

Architecture by subtraction

Studio KO co-founder Olivier Marty has described the first phase as a kind of archaeology: deciding what later additions could be removed so the 1912 composition could be read again. This is the project's central architectural intelligence. Instead of filling the plot with programme, the architects restored the value of the void. The courtyard separates the principal volumes, admits daylight and gives events somewhere to exceed the galleries. Emptiness becomes part of the institution's capacity.

Inside, circulation is unusually physical. A broad spiral stair curls around a central opening rather than disappearing into a service core. Ramps and curved walls slow the transition between levels. Terrazzo covers floors, counters and balustrades until circulation appears carved from a continuous mineral body. The effect is sensuous, perhaps almost too complete: an immaculate contemporary interior nested inside an industrial shell. Yet the generous dimensions keep the material finish from becoming merely decorative.

The terrazzo stair is conceived as a continuous public landscape rather than a concealed circulation element. Official architectural photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

The restoration also draws on materials and fabrication associated with different parts of Uzbekistan. This can easily become a familiar institutional gesture: local craft applied as a badge of authenticity to an internationally authored building. At CCA, the more productive moments occur when craft is treated as technical knowledge rather than ornamental quotation. Brick bond, aggregate, perforation, joinery and filtered light become systems of environmental and spatial intelligence. The building does not need to look folkloric to be locally made.

A centre inside a city of ruptures

To read the project only as an accomplished conversion would miss the pressure exerted by Tashkent itself. The city has repeatedly been rebuilt through rupture. The Russian imperial city developed beside the older urban fabric rather than within it. Soviet planning introduced broad avenues, monumental institutions and new systems of collective life. The 1966 earthquake accelerated another reconstruction, while the decades after independence produced a further layer of ceremonial spaces, commercial development and infrastructural change. Tashkent is therefore not a city with one stable architectural identity waiting to be protected. It is a city in which different political ideas of modernity remain physically adjacent.

The CCA occupies a useful position within that condition. It is neither an isolated cultural object on an empty site nor a museum inserted into a purpose-built civic precinct. It reactivates infrastructure that already belonged to the city's modernisation. The choice creates continuity, but not innocence. A power station speaks of collective provision and technological ambition; it also speaks of administrative control, extraction and the unequal distribution of energy. To convert such a building into a cultural institution is to inherit those contradictions rather than erase them.

This makes the Centre's threshold especially important. Many contemporary art buildings announce difference through an intimidating façade or a plaza that must be crossed before entry. Here, the sequence is more compressed. Brick walls establish historical weight, but the courtyard and multiple programmes soften the transition from street to exhibition. The success of this arrangement will eventually be measured less by architectural photographs than by habits: whether people use the courtyard without an event, whether students treat the library as working infrastructure, whether a visitor can enter for twenty minutes without feeling that specialist knowledge is required.

The surrounding centre of Tashkent already contains museums, theatres, government buildings, hotels and heavily managed public spaces. CCA adds another cultural destination, but destination status alone is not enough. A serious urban institution must also operate as a connector. It should allow routes through the city to cross it, make room for unplanned encounters and create reasons for return that do not depend on the novelty of an opening. In that sense, free admission is spatial policy as much as cultural policy. It removes one barrier, while architecture and programming must address the others.

HIKMAH is a method, not a theme

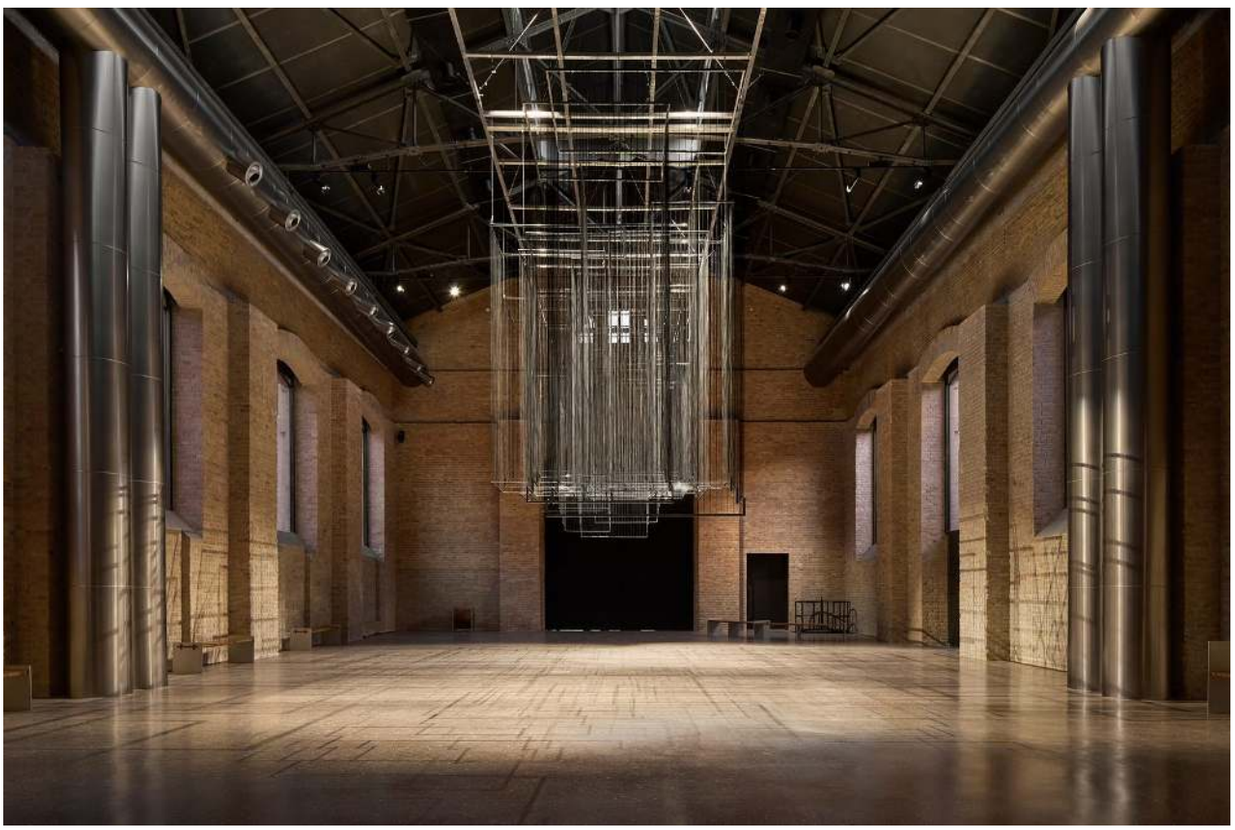
Chief curator Sara Raza defines hikmah through wisdom, material intelligence and higher consciousness. The term carries philosophical and spiritual weight across Arabic, Persianate and Islamic intellectual traditions, but the exhibition avoids reducing it to a stable definition. It uses hikmah as a curatorial method: knowledge is approached through making, bodily repetition, inherited technique and the transformations materials undergo.

"Hikmah can be reframed as an exhibition method." – Dr Sara Raza

That formulation is important because exhibitions about spirituality often drift toward atmospheric vagueness. HIKMAH is strongest when it remains materially exact. Steel is suspended according to measured outlines. Clay records pressure from thousands of hands. Found copper is allowed to oxidise. Thread, dust, resin and fibreglass hold evidence of labour and displacement. Wisdom is not illustrated; it is tested against matter.

The artist list deliberately crosses geographies: Ali Cherri, Nadia Kaabi-Linke, Kimsooja, Tarik Kiswanson, Muhannad Shono and Nari Ward appear alongside Shokhrukh Rakhimov and works by Vladimir Pan, Bakhtiyar Saipov and Daribay Saipov

from the collection of the Savitsky Museum in Karakalpakstan. The juxtaposition refuses a simple division between an international contemporary present and a regional historical background. Whether it creates equality among those positions is the exhibition's more difficult question.



The restored power hall during HIKMAH. The industrial volume is used as part of the exhibition's argument rather than hidden behind a neutral white box. Official photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

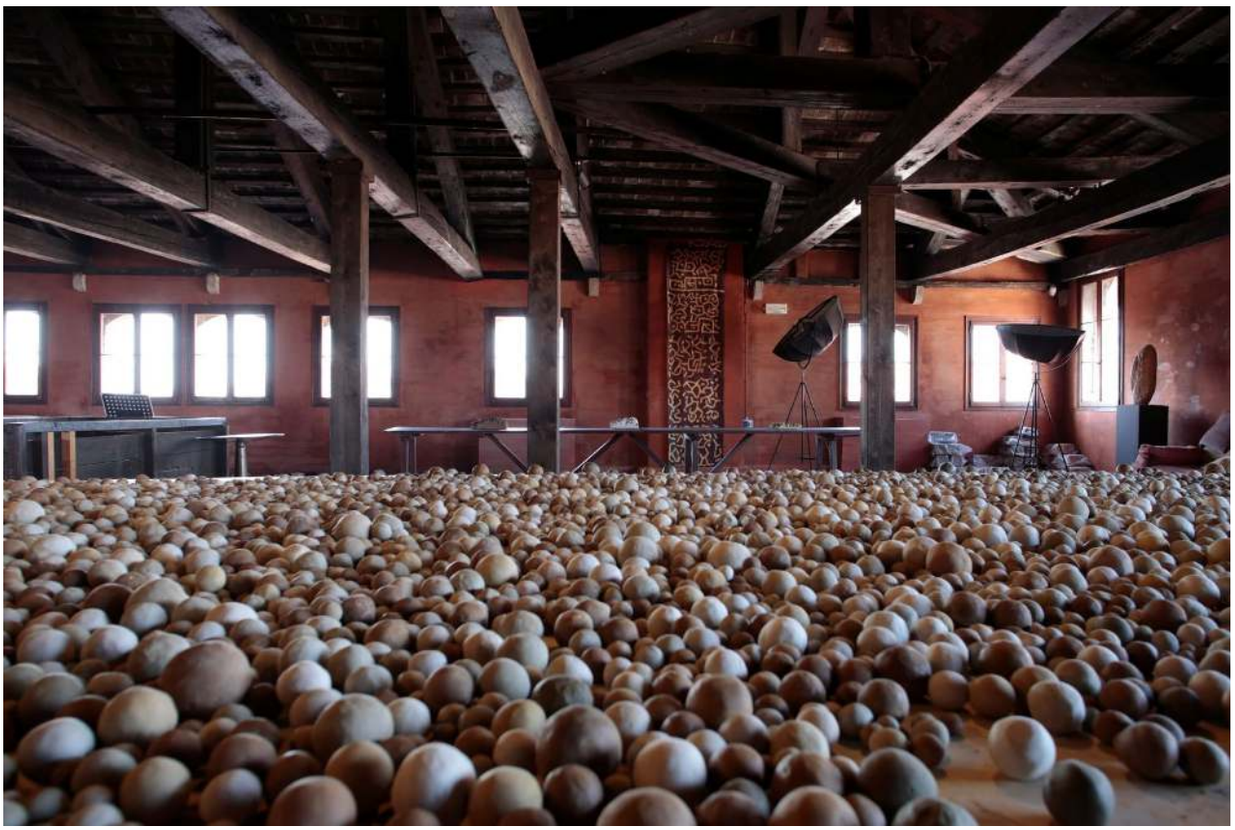
Kimsooja: knowledge made by many hands

Kimsooja's participatory Archive of Mind provides the exhibition with its clearest image of collective knowledge. Visitors sit around an immense wooden table and roll pieces of clay between their palms. Each small sphere is elementary and distinct. Accumulated by the hundred and then the thousand, they become a field whose visual order is produced without central authorship.

The work changes the visitor's position. Looking is no longer the only sanctioned activity; touch becomes a form of contribution. The sphere records time, pressure, moisture and the slight asymmetry of a particular pair of hands. Nothing about the result is spectacular in isolation. Its force arrives through duration and multiplicity – the recognition that an archive may be made from anonymous gestures rather than official documents.

Visitors forming clay spheres for Kimsooja's Archive of Mind. The work turns repetitive touch into a collectively authored field. Official installation photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

In Tashkent, the work acquires additional resonance. Clay is not an abstract universal substance here; it belongs to long architectural and ceramic histories across the region. HIKMAH does not claim that every rolled sphere transmits those histories, but it allows the material to carry more than one scale of memory: the intimacy of touch, the sociality of the table and the geological duration of earth.

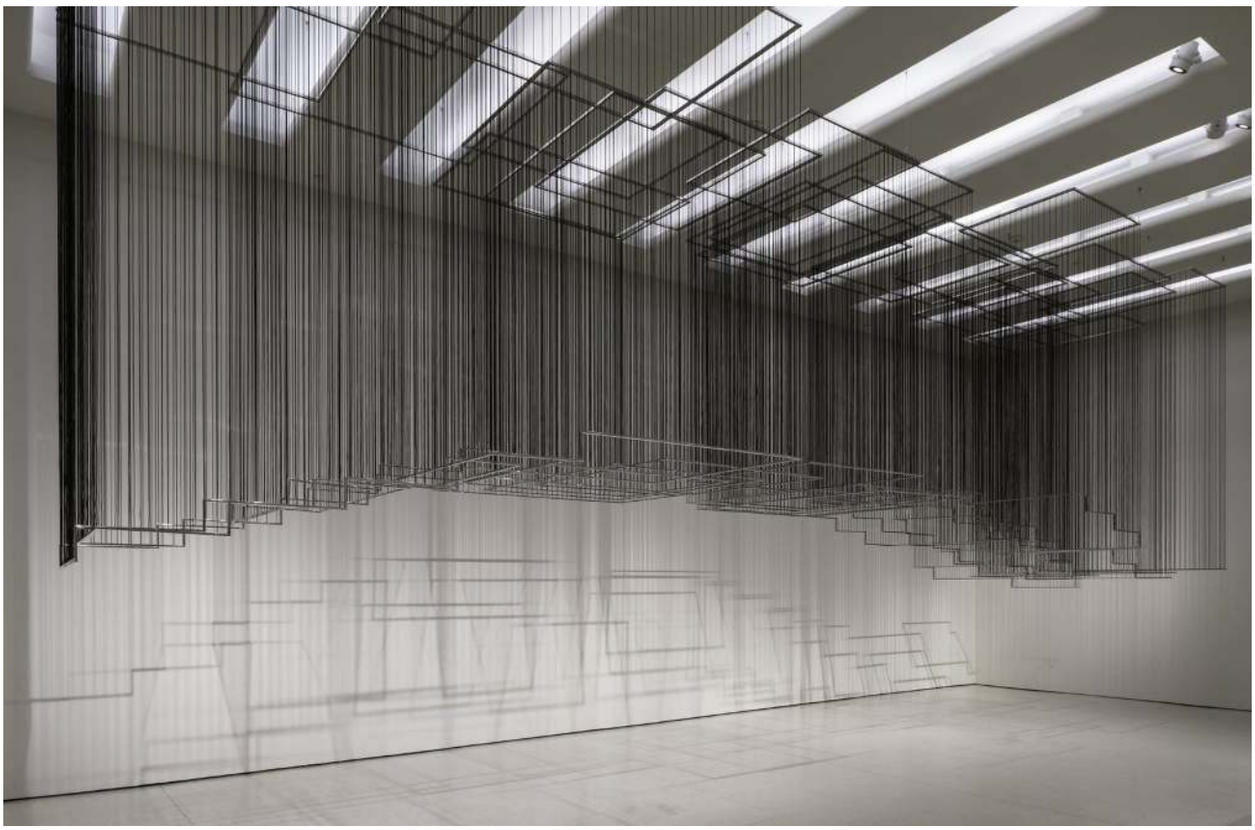


Archive of Mind extends into the older brick volume, allowing the accumulated clay forms to register against the building's industrial memory. Official installation photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

Nadia Kaabi-Linke: freedom suspended

Nadia Kaabi-Linke's Flying Carpets is visually lighter and politically sharper. The installation derives its suspended steel forms from the rugs used by migrant street vendors in Venice to display counterfeit goods. Those rugs promise the fantasy of unrestricted flight while serving, in daily life, as devices that allow precarious workers to gather their merchandise and flee the police.

Kaabi-Linke transforms the measured outlines into a hovering structure held by descending threads. From a distance it is almost architectural: bridge, canopy, cage and drawing occupy the same air. As one walks around it, the work refuses a single image. The elegance of the suspension cannot be separated from the restricted movement it describes. Mobility, one of contemporary culture's most celebrated freedoms, is shown to be radically unequal.



Nadia Kaabi-Linke, Flying Carpets, 2011, installed in HIKMAH. Suspended metal outlines translate the improvised rugs of migrant street vendors into a floating cage. Official installation photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

Installed within a centre created to connect Tashkent to international cultural networks, Flying Carpets also complicates the language of circulation surrounding the institution itself. Artists, curators and artworks travel through systems of visas, capital and professional recognition that remain far less open than the rhetoric of global exchange suggests. The work quietly asks who is permitted to move as a cultural agent and who is treated as a problem to be managed.

Found matter and local technique

Nari Ward's site-specific Tashkent Groundin was developed in dialogue with local craft traditions and the building's industrial past. Ward's wider practice has long used found material to trace migration, value and urban memory. Here, copper and patina connect material weathering with the marks left by work. The title's insistence on grounding counters the frictionless globalism that new cultural institutions are often asked to perform.

The exhibition's attention to Uzbek ceramic practice deepens this question of location. Shokhrukh Rakhimov's work, and the presence of Bakhtiyar and Daribay Saipov, position ceramics as contemporary thought rather than inherited décor. Technique becomes an argument: knowledge survives because it is repeatedly embodied, corrected and transmitted. The hand is not opposed to the conceptual; it is where the concept acquires consequence.

An installation view of HIKMAH, where floor-based material work and wall drawing resist the conventions of isolated display. Official photograph courtesy CCA Tashkent.

Tarik Kiswanson's newly commissioned Nest, made from steel, resin and fibreglass, approaches belonging from another direction. Its inward-growing form holds protection and entrapment in suspension. A nest is built to make vulnerable life possible, but it is also temporary: a structure organised around eventual departure. Within a new institution defining its place in the region, that ambiguity is particularly apt.

Muhannad Shono and Ali Cherri extend the exhibition toward erasure, archaeology and speculative memory. Cherri's moving-image work The Digger follows a caretaker guarding ancient ruins in Sharjah, refusing the heroic tempo through which archaeology is usually narrated. The patient labour of watching over fragments becomes an ethical counterpoint to institutions that treat the past as material to be rapidly packaged for a contemporary audience.

An exhibition assembled through different speeds

HIKMAH does not reveal itself through a single panoramic view. Its works ask for incompatible durations. Archive of Mind develops through repeated participation; Flying Carpets changes as the body moves beneath and around it; film requires surrender to another temporal order; ceramics may initially appear still but condense years of technical learning. The exhibition's intelligence lies partly in refusing to synchronise these speeds. Visitors cannot consume every work through the same rhythm of recognition.

This is also where the architecture performs a curatorial role. The long industrial hall creates distant sightlines, but its brick surfaces prevent the optical neutrality of the white cube. Smaller rooms contract attention. The stair turns the movement between works into a public spectacle: visitors see one another arriving, pausing and returning. The Centre's architecture continuously reminds the solitary viewer that interpretation is taking place among other bodies.

The historical works associated with the Savitsky Museum introduce another temporal complication. Their presence avoids presenting contemporary art in Central Asia as something that began with new international institutions. Yet historical inclusion carries responsibility. A small number of earlier works can become ancestry on demand, enlisted to legitimise a contemporary programme without being granted enough space to disturb it. HIKMAH points toward a richer genealogy; future exhibitions will need to expand it through sustained research, loans, translation and publication.

The same applies to the category of craft. In global exhibition culture, craft is frequently welcomed at the moment it can be described as embodied knowledge, ecological intelligence or decolonial practice. Those frameworks can be productive, but they can also convert living economies into curatorial metaphor. HIKMAH is strongest when technique retains specificity – when clay, copper or textile is connected to particular forms of labour and transmission – and weaker whenever materiality is allowed to stand in for an undifferentiated spiritual depth.

The institution beyond the exhibition

CCA Tashkent's most consequential spaces may not be its galleries. The library, workshop, cinema, courtyard, restaurant and shop establish different reasons to enter and different durations of stay. The Centre is open six days a week and admission to HIKMAH is free. On opening day, curatorial tours were joined by poetry, children's workshops, film, live performance and Shashmaqom music. This was not supplementary entertainment; it was an early statement about the kind of public the institution hopes to produce.

A non-collecting institution can be unusually responsive, commissioning new work and changing direction without the weight of a permanent display. It can also be fragile. Its memory must be constructed through archives, publications, education, repeated relationships with artists and the knowledge retained by staff and audiences. The residency programme, operating since 2024, is therefore not peripheral. It offers the possibility that international attention might support sustained production rather than a succession of imported events.

The difficult politics of a new cultural landmark

No major institution arrives outside politics. CCA Tashkent is a flagship project of the Uzbekistan Art and Culture Development Foundation, and its opening participates in a broader effort to place the country within international circuits of biennials, architecture, tourism and cultural diplomacy. The quality of the building and programme should not make that framework invisible. Public cultural investment can create genuine infrastructure while also producing an image of openness for external consumption.

The test will be what happens after the inaugural visibility subsides. How much curatorial authority will be available to artists and researchers based in Uzbekistan? Can difficult work remain difficult when it conflicts with an official narrative of cultural renewal? Will regional practitioners appear as intellectual partners rather than providers of craft knowledge and historical texture? Can a free institution remain accessible to publics beyond the internationally mobile cultural class?

HIKMAH begins to address these questions by refusing a simple showcase of national identity. Yet the balance remains delicate. An internationally legible roster and a globally recognised architecture practice bring attention; they can also establish the terms through which local practice becomes visible. The Centre's future significance will depend on whether it can reverse that direction – allowing knowledge generated in Tashkent, Nukus and across Central Asia to alter the international conversation rather than merely enter it.

What kind of public can a new institution make?

Museums often speak of attracting an existing public, as if audiences waited outside in completed form. In reality, institutions produce publics through repetition. Opening hours determine who can attend. Language determines who can interpret. Seating determines who may linger. Security determines who feels watched. Programming determines whether children, artists, students, neighbours and occasional visitors recognise the building as available to them. A public is not a demographic reached by marketing; it is a relationship built through many small institutional decisions.

CCA's opening programme understood this multiplicity. Film, workshops, poetry, performance, music and tours offered more than parallel attractions. They created several legitimate ways of being present. This matters in a context where contemporary art may still be perceived as a specialised or imported domain. The institution does not need to simplify art to broaden its audience. It needs to multiply the forms of entry while preserving the complexity of what is encountered inside.

Language will be decisive. Uzbek, Russian and English do not simply translate the same cultural field; they connect different generations, educational histories and international networks. A centre that works across those languages can become an unusually valuable site of intellectual exchange. A centre that privileges English at the level of research and global communication while treating local-language mediation as a service risks reproducing the hierarchy it claims to overcome. Translation must therefore be part of curatorial authorship, not an administrative final step.

Digital access poses a related question. Strong documentation can carry exhibitions beyond the period of display and beyond Tashkent, but an online archive should offer more than polished installation views. Commissioned essays, transcripts, artist conversations, bibliographies and records of public disagreement would allow the Centre to accumulate knowledge despite not accumulating objects. For a non-collecting institution, publishing is one of the principal ways memory becomes durable.

The Centre's urban promise finally depends on recurrence. A landmark can draw a crowd once. An institution becomes civic when the same person returns for unrelated reasons: to read, meet, disagree, see a film, attend a workshop or simply cross the courty-

ard. The most persuasive photograph of CCA Tashkent will not be an empty hall but an image, years from now, in which use has left visible traces on Studio KO's carefully completed surfaces.

A promising first proposition

CCA Tashkent is not important because it resolves the relationship between heritage and contemporaneity. It is important because its opening makes that relationship newly contestable. The building preserves evidence without freezing it. HIKMAH places spiritual and material knowledge in proximity without pretending they are interchangeable. The public programme treats the institution as a place for making, listening and gathering as well as viewing.

There are moments when the architecture's polish risks overpowering the provisional character on which contemporary art depends. There are moments when the exhibition's language of wisdom threatens to become too capacious, able to hold every work without sufficient friction. But the strongest installations push back. Clay accumulates irregularly. Suspended steel turns elegance into constraint. Found matter discolours. The old hall refuses to become silent.

> The real achievement is not a finished cultural monument, but an institution that still appears capable of being changed by use.

For a centre opening without a permanent collection, this is the correct beginning. CCA Tashkent has created a compelling architectural and curatorial proposition. Its task now is slower and less photogenic: to build trust, critical independence, institutional memory and a public that does not experience contemporary art as an imported language. Wisdom, HIKMAH suggests, is not possessed at the moment of opening. It is produced through what a place learns to hold.

Visitor information

HIKMAH is on view at CCA Tashkent, Building B, 6 Amir Temur Street, Tashkent, through 31 January 2027. Admission is free. Visitors should consult the Centre's official website for current opening hours, registration requirements and public events. ■

Sources and further reading

Research and text by Viacheslav Munister for EPRIS Journal. The review is based on official institutional materials, published architectural documentation and independent reporting. Images are official editorial photographs credited to CCA Tashkent and linked to the institutional source.

FURTHER

CCA Tashkent — HIKMAH exhibition	ccat.uz/en/programme/hikmah-exhibition
CCA Tashkent — official opening announcement	ccat.uz/en/news/the-centre-for-contemporary-arts-tashkent-cca-tashkent-has-offic
CCA Tashkent — public opening programme	ccat.uz/en/programme/programme-1788582698
e-flux — Inaugural exhibition HIKMAH	e-flux.com/announcements/6787892/inaugural-exhibitionhikmah
Studio KO transforms a 1912 tram depot — Domus	domusweb.it/en/architecture/gallery/2026/09/10/tashkent-centre-for-contemporary-art-studio-ko.html
Inside Uzbekistan's new Centre for Contemporary Art — Art Focus Now	artfocusnow.com/news/to-tashkent-for-wisdom-inside-uzbekistans-new-centre-for-contemporary-art
Nadia Kaabi-Linke — Flying Carpets	nadiakaabilinke.com/work/flying-carpets

SECTION III

Rooms & Hands

A room is finished only when someone has lived in it long enough to disagree with the plan.

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INTERVIEW SEP 22, 2026

Eight Years to a Home: Olha Wood on Building Across Distance, Pandemic and War

Interior architect Olha Wood works between Kyiv, Denmark and the UK, often without standing in the rooms she shapes. She talks about the Kyiv apartment that took eight years, one pandemic and a full scale war to finish, the house whose site was lost but whose concrete survived into another, and why every project she makes ends up reaching for the garden.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & OLHA WOOD

SECTION III · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & OLHA WOOD

Interior architect Olha Wood works between Kyiv, Denmark and the UK, often without standing in the rooms she shapes. She talks about the Kyiv apartment that took eight years, one pandemic and a full scale war to finish, the house whose site was lost but whose concrete survived into another, and why every project she makes ends up reaching for the garden.

Olha Wood describes her practice in four lines on Instagram: interior architect, high end residential, international experience, remote collaboration with UK studios and private clients. It reads like a list of capabilities. It is closer to a description of a life. The studio began in Kyiv twenty five years ago and now works between Kyiv, Denmark and the United Kingdom, frequently without its architect standing inside the rooms she is shaping until very late in the process, if at all.

Her portfolio keeps unusually honest time. One Kyiv apartment is titled, simply, *Eight Years to a Home*: commissioned in 2018, moved to a different flat in the same building before construction could begin, redesigned around a terrace when the pandemic made private outdoor space essential, then carried through a full scale war its clients chose to stay in Kyiv for. A house on the Fish Island has been listed as in progress since 2020. The Bridge House carries the dates 2017 to 2026.

We wrote to her about what happens to buildings that have to wait, about designing a room around a sofa chosen years before the room existed, and about the thing she keeps returning to in every house she names: the garden, the terrace, the bridge, the way a building reaches for the ground it stands on.

An interior from the Kyiv practice where Olha Wood's studio began.

01

A practice shaped by places

Viacheslav Munister [VM]: Your Instagram bio reads "Interior Architect | High-End Residential | International Experience | Remote Collaboration with UK Studios & Private" – four lines that describe a practice built almost entirely around distance, flexibility and movement between places, rather than around one fixed studio in one fixed city. Your own portfolio bears that out: projects photographed in Kyiv, a house extension sketched for Tuscany, an island house visualised by a studio in another country entirely, clients across the UK. Was your practice always this dispersed, by temperament or by the nature of high-end residential work – or is this geography something the last several years specifically forced you to design, the way you might redesign a floor plan around a load-bearing wall that suddenly can't be moved?

Olha Wood [OW]: I was fortunate to begin my career in one of the strongest architectural studios in the city where I was born and educated. It was an unusually good place to start. At a time when many practices were concerned chiefly with the local market, they travelled to the Milan furniture fair each year, worked with Italian furniture – including Minotti – and designed interiors and penthouses of a kind that introduced me early to a world beyond my own city.

Perhaps this is why I never learned to think of architecture as something confined by geography.

A few years later, I began my own practice. My first client was a Ukrainian pop star. The beginning was almost disarmingly easy. I did not feel that I was entering an unknown profession; rather, I seemed simply to continue walking along a road I had already been travelling for years.

I entered competitions constantly. It was not only about winning, although I did take first places in several Ukrainian competitions. I wanted the work to exist outside the rooms in which it was made – to be looked at, questioned and placed beside the work of others.

In time, one of my projects was longlisted for the Dezeen Awards in 2018, and another was published on Dezeen. Those moments mattered to me not simply as distinctions, but because they allowed the work to travel further than I could.

My first international clients were a Slavic couple living in Hamburg. They had commissioned me to create an interior around Promemoria furniture, but wanted it to possess a distinctly Western European character. It was an interesting request: how does one create a sense of belonging to a place without merely reproducing its familiar images?

I was already spending considerable time in Britain then, because my future family lived in England. I travelled back and forth, and gradually absorbed something of the country – its architecture, its proportions, its restraint, its particular relationship between old and new. Much of what we absorb from a place happens without our noticing it at the time. A window, a staircase, the colour of a painted room, the way an old house has been altered rather than replaced – these things remain somewhere in the mind.

This has become one of the reasons I continue to prefer working with international clients.

Every country has its own domestic language. It lives not only in architecture, but in the way people arrange a table, choose a chair, preserve an old floor, tolerate an imperfection, or decide what deserves to remain. I find that learning these small distinctions is as important as understanding the larger architectural context.

This year I worked for a Danish couple, restructuring their bathroom and restyling the remaining rooms through decoration. It was another opportunity to look closely at a culture I had previously encountered professionally, but now from inside a private home.

I discovered more about the Danish market, but also returned to something I have always valued in Scandinavian design: objects that do not need to announce their importance. Ferm Living and House Doctor are not about the spectacle of high-end furniture. Their appeal lies elsewhere – in material, proportion, familiarity and the accumulated feeling of a domestic life.

Perhaps this is what I have been looking for throughout my twenty-five years of practice.

Not a particular style, and certainly not a particular country.

Rather, the possibility of entering someone else's world for a while, understanding what belongs there, and making something that feels as though it could not have been made anywhere else.

02 Eight years to a home

VM: One of your project pages narrates its own timeline with unusual honesty. A home was commissioned in 2018; the clients then discovered a different apartment in the same building, with a large terrace, and exchanged their original unit for it before construction could even begin. Then COVID arrived, and – in your words – "a garden on the terrace suddenly became more than an attractive addition to the brief… having a private outdoor space, somewhere to step outside without leaving home, became essential." Then the full-scale war began, and your clients chose not to leave Kyiv. You call the project, simply, "Eight years to a Home." At what specific point across those eight

years – the apartment swap, the pandemic, or the war – did you notice yourself stop thinking of it as one job delayed by circumstance, and start thinking of it instead as a shared act of endurance between you and your clients?

OW: That is what I call responsibility – to the object, and to the people for whom it was made. It is painful to see a place intended for a family's future remain silent and unfinished. A house is not simply an object that waits for completion; it waits for the life that is meant to happen within it.

So I kept reminding my clients with inspiration that the work was not finished. Perhaps there would come a moment when we would find the strength to return to it, and to finish what we had begun.

Eight Years to a Home, Kyiv: the living and dining room, with the black Poliform cabinet by Piero Lissoni at the left.

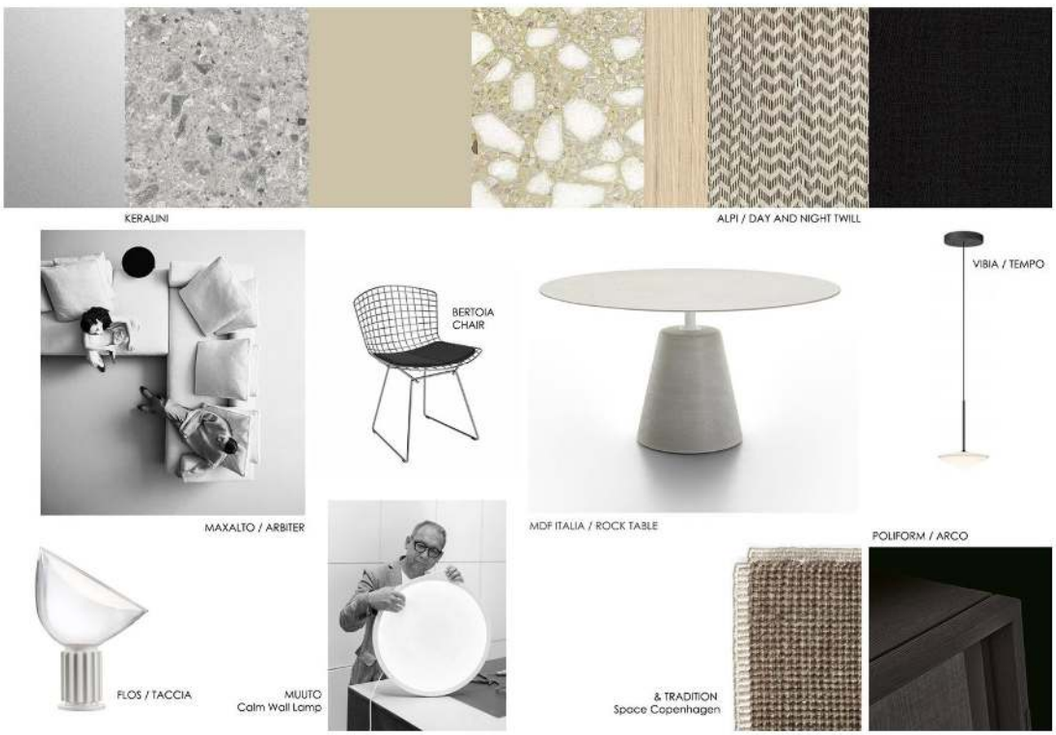
VM: That same project's brief was, as you put it, "wonderfully specific": your clients had always dreamed of particular pieces from Italian design houses – a Poliform cabinet, a B&B Italia sofa, an Antonio Lupi basin – items you describe as "not simply items on a shopping list, but part of the image of the home they wanted to create." When a client arrives already attached to the exact sofa and the exact basin, sometimes years before the room around those objects even exists, how do you design that room so it reads as something more than a frame built to justify a purchase already made?

OW: Each piece of furniture has its own history – of material, place of origin, style and suitability.

The furniture selected by the clients often told me more about the future interior than a conventional brief could. My task was to bring these individual objects into a conversation with the architecture, the views from the windows and one another, so that the interior would acquire a coherent language rather than become a collection of beautiful things.

For example, the black Poliform cabinet, designed by Piero Lissoni, led me towards black-veneered wall panels of the same architectural restraint. The colour of the B&B Italia sofa became the starting point for the bespoke kitchen, whose ceramic fronts were made in a closely related shade.

The clients had a particular affection for Italy, and I wanted to acknowledge that without making the house feel as though it belonged elsewhere. The Ukrainian landscape outside the windows remained essential. I brought its yellow and brown tones inside through yellowish terrazzo, travertine and the warm grey of Little Greene's Slaked Lime – Dark 151. The garden partly obscured the view, which I came to see not as a limitation but as something that gave the sitting room a sense of intimacy – a room held gently between the house and nature.



The material board for Eight Years to a Home: terrazzo, travertine and the warm grey of Little Greene's Slaked Lime Dark 151.

03 The projects that wait

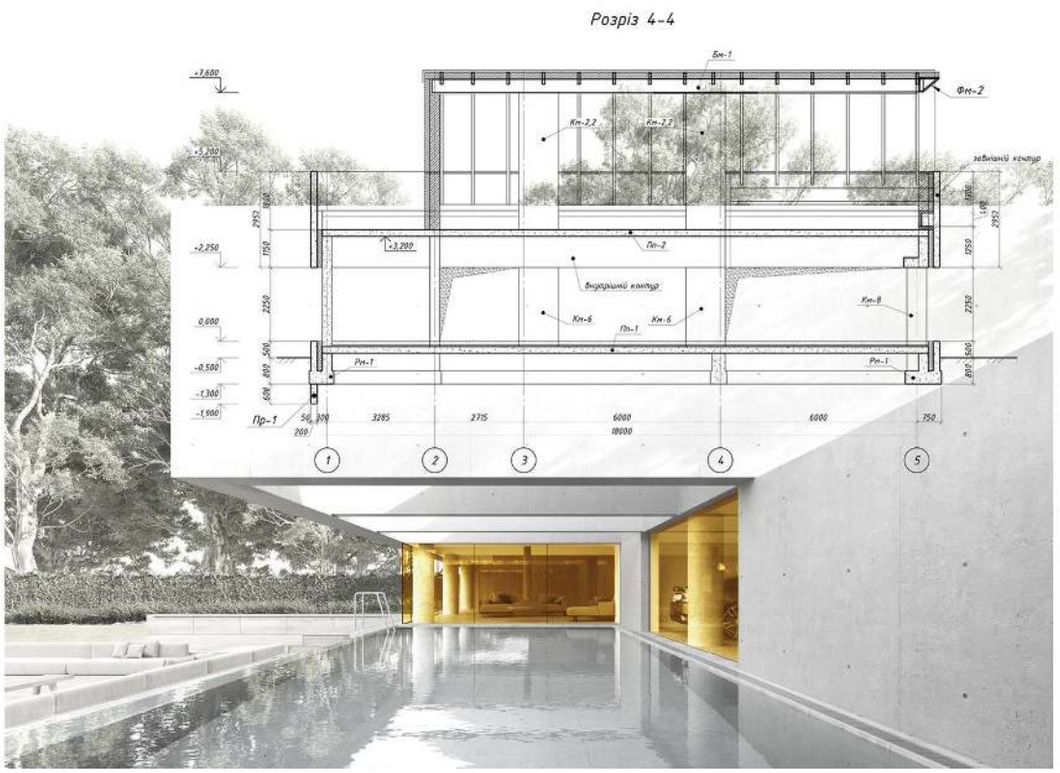
VM: Your house on the Fish Island has been listed as "In Progress" since 2020 – a 450-square-metre concrete-and-steel structure, envisioned explicitly as a prototype for several future houses to be built on the same riverbank, built around a client's very particular list: a swimming pool, a fish pond, dedicated parking for a car collection, and three bedrooms, one for each of his children. Six years is a long time for a prototype to still be a work in progress. Has the house itself changed across those six years – in brief, in detail, in what "prototype" even means for the houses that might follow it – or has the delay simply been the ordinary friction of building something this large?

OW: This is perhaps one of the more painful questions I might be asked.

The building project was cancelled when my clients lost the plot of land. There is something particularly difficult about seeing a house that has been carefully imagined never acquire the life for which it was intended.

And yet, the work did not entirely disappear. The concrete structure and its carefully resolved junctions found a second life in another house that was later conceived for the same site and exists there today.

Perhaps this is one of the quieter truths of architectural work: an idea does not always arrive at its first destination. Sometimes part of it survives, altered by circumstance, and continues its life somewhere else.



House on the Fish Island: the section cut through pool and terrace, the structure set into the hill.

VM: The Bridge House has the longest visible timeline in your entire portfolio – 2017 to 2026, described on your own site as an "evolution of the architectural concept" rather than a single continuous build. Its plan is organised as three distinct pieces: a single-level Forest Pavilion designed to nearly disappear into the landscape, a two-storey Main House built around an internal atrium for daylight and privacy, and the Bridge itself, which your notes call "more than a circulation element… the architectural symbol of the project." Between "Eight Years to a Home," the Fish Island house still listed as in progress since 2020, and now a nine-year evolution on the Bridge House – is this simply what building privately in Ukraine over the last decade has looked like for everyone in your position, or is a project that's allowed to evolve across many years actually closer to how you'd choose to work even without a war or a pandemic pushing the timeline?

OW: The Bridge House was first called The House Above an Old Road in 2017.

I do agree that, looking at it now, it appears almost as a bridge between my past career and the work I do today.

Much of what I had learned through my years of working in the Netherlands and the UK found its place in this house. But its story is not only about a timeline. There was another, more personal connection: my client had lived and studied in the Netherlands for many years.

In a way, the materials became the language through which the three of us – the architect, the house and the client – were connected to that place.

We chose MIB GeoStylistix facing bricks, concrete junctions inspired by the House on the Fish Island, and Alpi veneer, which I had first discovered in Amsterdam.

Perhaps this is why the house has always felt to me like more than a project. It carries pieces of places, experience and memory from different periods of my life, brought together in one piece of architecture.

Bridge House: the Forest Pavilion, shaped around the trees that were kept rather than cleared.

04 Unbuilt, and still alive

VM: In Tuscany, you sketched an extension – 2024 – for what your own project notes describe as a "1 Euro House": one of the abandoned homes Italian municipalities sell for a symbolic euro to buyers who commit to restoring them, in towns trying to survive depopulation. Your plan called for selectively demolishing the existing structure, removing an intermediate floor to create a double-height space, and building a new balcony to connect the old house to a new 60-square-metre extension. What drew you personally to a project built on a premise so different from the rest of your portfolio – not a client with an unlimited wish-list, but a near-abandoned building in a town that is, in its own way, asking to be saved?

OW: It was a precious time to learn and to create a house for my friends from Israel. It was a voluntary project, but it gave me something I needed very much that summer in Kyiv in 2023: a reason to create, and a way to survive the summer emotionally.

Kate, the daughter of my friend, was already dreaming of her future adult life in Italy. So I began to imagine the extension almost as a doll's house for that future life – a small world of her own, rather than simply an addition to the existing house. Her mother sent me the brief and the possible site, and I began to write a story for the future.

I studied the village from a distance, learning its details online and reading the structure of the surrounding landscape through Google Maps. I was also inspired by the quiet architecture of contemporary Tuscan wineries – their relationship with the land, their simplicity, and the feeling that the building had always belonged there.

TOSCANA HOUSE: the proposed extension to a one euro house, glazed towards the valley.

VM: "House near the Dam" is a 2019 sketch, never (as far as your portfolio shows) built: two connected volumes in Kyiv's Dam District, clad in red brick and wood to match the surrounding red pines, with a sloped roof planted with wild herbs specifically so the house would blend into the meadow rather than announce itself from the road. A living roof is a very particular kind of promise – it asks a client to accept years of upkeep for the sake of near-invisibility. What usually happens to a design like this one, that asks that much commitment for that much restraint – does it stay unbuilt because the ambition was too specific for the client who eventually came along, or because the right site and the right client for it simply haven't met yet?

OW: The house remained a sketch, as the client eventually relocated to the UK as a Ukrainian refugee. The land is still waiting for them, and the sketch – something we were both rather proud of – still exists.

House near the Dam: timber and brick among the red pines of Kyiv's Dam District.

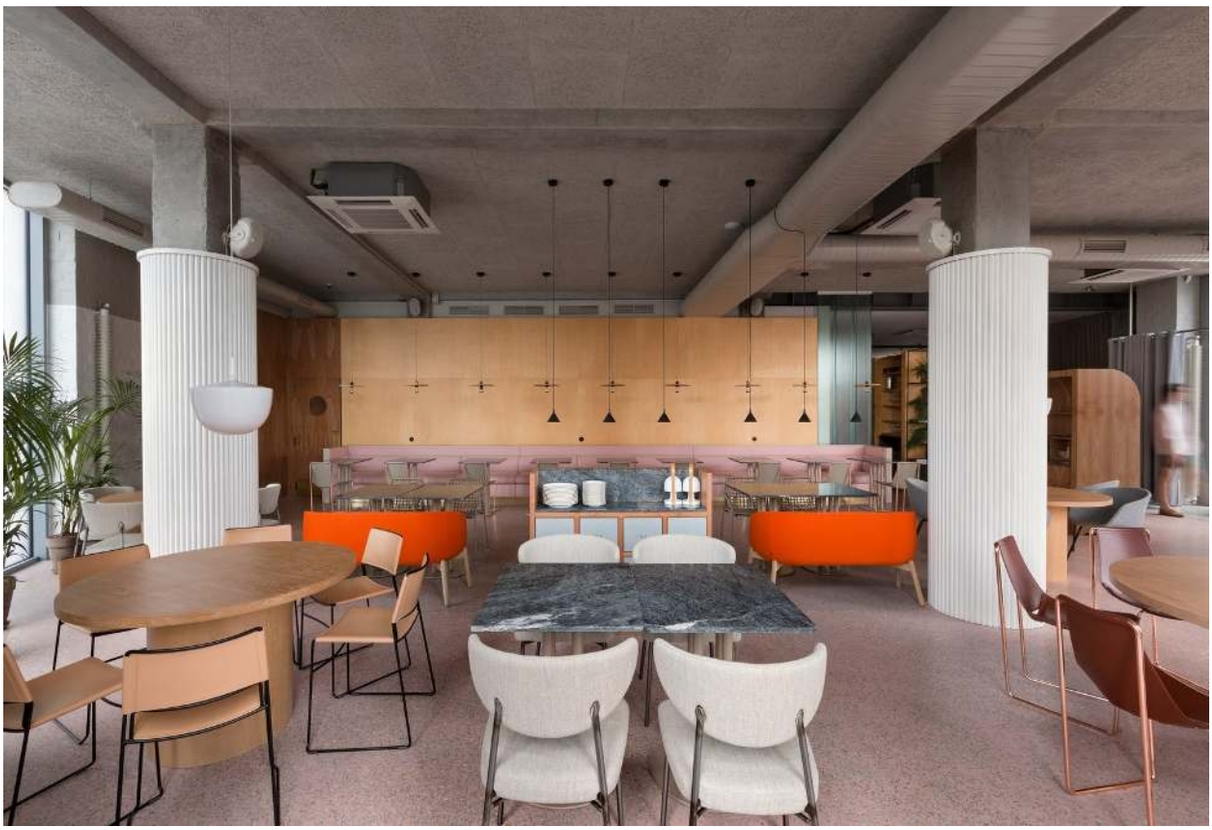
05 A restaurant, a studio, a penthouse

VM: CICADA, your restaurant and wine bar project from 2018, came with an unusual condition attached to the brief itself: the client – who had researched the restaurant industry extensively through travel across Europe and Australia – specifically wanted an architect with no previous experience designing restaurants, precisely so the process could stay collaborative and the ideas could stay unconventional. The restaurant's chef, meanwhile, had circled the world three times gathering inspiration for a genuinely multicultural menu. What does it actually feel like to be hired because you're inexperienced in a category, rather than in spite of it – and did that freedom from precedent change how boldly you were willing to work, on a project that went on to be featured in ATTITUDE Magazine?

OW: I had spent many years visiting restaurants across Europe and the UK, observing not only how they looked, but how they made one feel, how people moved through them, and how a room could shape an evening.

My work was always rooted in the client's brief, but I have never been very interested in clichés about what a restaurant is supposed to be. I wanted to understand how this particular one might live, and then allow the idea to take its own shape.

The entire project was carried out online. We spoke with builders and contractors through a screen; samples of materials travelled to me in Kyiv. At the time, it felt almost audacious to imagine that everything could be created this way – a restaurant existing, for a while, between a distant site and a desk in Kyiv.



CICADA restaurant and wine bar, designed entirely through a screen from a desk in Kyiv.

VM: You also designed the office for your own practice, Olga Akulova DESIGN – completed in 2010, photographed once that year and again six years later in 2016, and highly commended at the International Property Awards in London in 2012. That's the one project in your portfolio with no outside client to negotiate against, argue with, or ultimately answer to. Looking back at a space you designed entirely for yourself, and that still held up well enough to be re-photographed six years on – what did you learn about your own taste when there was no one else's taste to balance it against, and is there anything in that office you would design differently today?

OW: I designed my studio in three days. Perhaps because it was my own space, there was no need to explain the idea to anyone before making it happen.

Fourteen years later, I am restyling the interior as I continue to grow as an architect. New materials have appeared, new technologies have changed what is possible, and I have found a colour for the walls that feels more right now – Rolling Fog by Little Greene.

And yet the room still draws me back to Kyiv. There is the view of the garden, my own little England; the Boffi K4, around which the kitchen was shaped; and the wooden floor, which has aged beautifully over these fourteen years.

All this time, the studio has also been a kind of working catalogue of my practice. It is where I have met clients, and where they could see, rather than simply hear me describe, the junctions, materials and language of the interiors I make.

VM: Your NPL Penthouse – the 30th floor of the Novopecherskie Lipki condominium in Kyiv, bought by your client purely as an investment property – came with a brief that was really an absence of a brief: exposed concrete ceilings, full-height glass, and then almost total silence, because the client had "limited time to be involved" and asked you to complete the entire interior and fit-out independently. The project went on to be featured in Dezeen, Moroso and Leibal. When a client eff-

ectively hands you the keys and steps back entirely, is that the freest you ever get to work, or does an absent client's silence create its own, quieter kind of pressure that a demanding one never would?

OW: Exactly. The pressure created by the absence of a client was enormous. To prove to myself that I was worthy of making the project without a client's editorial hand, I brought everything I knew at that time to it, and pushed my knowledge and possibilities as far as I could.

My travels to the UK became an important part of the process. I bought some of the accessories for the penthouse in London, at the Designers Guild showroom, and the poster for the kitchen in London as well. They were not souvenirs of a journey, but things that had already found their place in the project in my mind.

My contractors worked with remarkable precision and care, following the project closely. And, eventually, the penthouse travelled further than any of us had imagined – into worldwide publications.

06 Method and motifs

VM: A project titled simply "House near the Dam" is filed in your portfolio under the single word "minimalism" – a word that can mean an empty room just as easily as it can mean a room where every remaining object had to earn, and fight for, the right to stay. When you strip a house down that far for a real client with a real life to live inside it, what is your actual working method for deciding what earns that right – and has a client ever fought you to keep something you were certain had to go?

OW: When my clients are unsure about a particular piece of furniture or an item in the project, I first try to understand what lies behind their hesitation. It may be the budget, a style they have not mentioned in the brief, or simply that my idea is more daring than they had imagined for themselves.

When we discuss a possible change, I look for something that answers their concern without disturbing the composition that already exists. The new piece still has to belong to the whole, and, most importantly, to my client at that particular moment.

That is part of the work: not persuading a client to accept my idea, but understanding when an idea needs to change – and when it simply needs to be explained.

VM: Several of your project titles read less like catalogue entries and more like private diary lines – "With a dream of KENZO," "Uplifted House," "Interior for Kate & Corgis" – the kind of phrase that usually stays inside a client's head, not on a public portfolio page. Where do these titles actually come from: are they yours, coined out of how the project felt to live through as its designer, or do they belong to the clients – a private joke, a private hope, a pet's name – that somehow made it, intact and unedited, all the way into your public-facing work?

OW: You made me smile.

I live through each project, and its name usually comes to me as a result of the work rather than at the beginning. It is almost a conclusion – the main idea that has slowly shaped the project through months, sometimes years, of working together.

Each project becomes a story in its own right. We see it afterwards in photographs, but my clients continue to live inside it. Perhaps that is why the name appears only when the story has already revealed itself.

VM: Looking at your Bridge House concept specifically – a pavilion designed to vanish into a pine forest, connected by a bridge you call the project's "architectural symbol" to a house organised around an internal garden bringing light into its own centre – how literally do you take the idea of a threshold in your work generally? Is the bridge, the terrace, the balcony that keeps recurring across your projects (the terrace in "Eight Years to a Home," the balcony in TOSCANA HOUSE, the riverside terrace on Fish Island) a functional feature you return to because clients keep asking for it, or is it the closest thing your work has to a genuine, recurring architectural signature?

OW: Bridge House.

The shape was created by the existing trees. We cherished them, rather than asking them to give way to the house.

The Eight Years to a Home.

The garden – nature itself – is the element that connects all my projects.

Toscana House.

The roof terrace and balcony were conceived as a way of bringing the house towards the mountain view.

Fish Island House.

The terrace is set into the hill to find the best possible view of the water on the site.

Perhaps this is what I could call my architectural signature: I always try to connect my clients with nature. It is the most inseparable relationship a house can have.

07 Distance, and what it costs

VM: Your work now moves between Kyiv, Denmark, and clients across the UK, frequently without you standing physically inside the rooms you're shaping until very late in the process, if at all – site visits replaced by video calls, timber and stone chosen from photographs and swatches sent by courier rather than held in your own hand. Materials like your namesake wood are famously about grain, weight, and how light actually falls across a surface in person. What does an interior architect concretely lose when a project has to be built at that kind of distance – and is there anything, unexpectedly, that the distance makes easier, clearer, or even better?

OW: Strong communication with clients – video calls, being in regular contact, friendship and empathy – can create a surprisingly close connection with a building site, even from a long distance.

Materials are now available across countries, too. And after 25 years of experience, I know how to find the right ones, work with people locally, and keep the architectural idea consistent, wherever the site may be.

VM: "Eight years to a Home" ends, in your own account, in August 2026 – the work "very close to the end" – in a Kyiv that is still, as you're answering this, a city living through war. When you finally hand your clients the keys to a home eight years, one pandemic, and one full-scale war in the making, what do you think that specific moment will actually feel like, for them and for you – and is it a feeling any earlier, easier project in your portfolio could possibly have prepared you for?

OW: The building site is still ongoing. In Kyiv, we do not have an abundance of contractors at the moment, as many of them are protecting our country.

We hope to complete part of the work this autumn. My clients can hardly wait to begin their life in the space they have dreamed of for so many years.

The garden, which was completed on the terrace a year ago, has already given them something to live with while the house is still being made. They have spent this time among the greenery, watching it grow, and hoping that soon their life in the house will

begin.

VM: You've now spent years designing homes for people staying in a country at war, for an apartment building's shared future on an island, for a nearly abandoned house in a depopulating Italian town, and for landscapes – a stream, a pine grove, a riverbank – that were there long before any client and will presumably outlast the buildings too. If a future client asked you to design something with no constraints at all – no budget ceiling, no site, no deadline – what is the one idea sitting somewhere in your unbuilt sketches, the Tuscany extension or the Dam District house or something you haven't shown anyone yet, that you would actually choose to build first?

OW: It would be wonderful to allow myself to dream about a future project.

Perhaps it would be a house in the UK – an extension to an old house at the end of a quiet road, in the forest, with a hill and a meadow opening towards the trees.

I imagine a studio for work attached to the main house, and a terrace at the top of the hill, looking across the meadow towards the forest.

Wood, glass and local stone. A house that belongs to its place rather than simply occupying it. Sustainable and energy-independent, but without making sustainability the aesthetic. It would simply be part of the way the house lives. ■

INTERVIEW SEPTEMBER 8, 2026

Abbie Downey: Collected, Not Coordinated

The founder of Feather&Fossil on visual rhythm, the difference between layered and chaotic, and why a home should read as continued rather than preserved.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & ABBIE DOWNEY

SECTION III · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & ABBIE DOWNEY

The founder of Feather&Fossil on visual rhythm, the difference between layered and chaotic, and why a home should read as continued rather than preserved.

EPRIS Journal's interview series turns this month to Abbie Downey, founder of the Devon studio Feather&Fossil and one of the designers embracing the return of colour and pattern in British interiors after a long stretch of restraint. Her rooms are dense, layered and unmistakably lived-in – which is where our conversation begins.

She is renovating a Georgian house, her second period property, and that is a useful thing to know before looking at her rooms. Feather&Fossil deals in painted stripes and blue fireplaces, figured wallpaper above blue patterned tile, a wall of framed prints and mirrors hung close. It reads as abundance. It is, on closer inspection, a set of decisions.

Recognised through Next in Design, Downey belongs to a generation of British designers rehabilitating pattern and colour after years in which restraint was treated as the only adult position. Her argument is not that more is better. It is that a room should be able to hold the people who live in it, including the parts of them that do not photograph neatly. We sent her seven questions.

Your interiors are expressive, but they never feel accidental. When you build up layers of colour, pattern and objects, what tells you that they belong together rather than simply competing for attention?

I think the difference between a room that feels layered and one that feels chaotic is usually intention. For me, maximalism isn't about simply putting more things into a room; it's about creating relationships between them. Colour, pattern, texture and objects can all be quite bold individually, but there needs to be something that connects them, a commonality. This could be a repeated colour, a shared undertone, a shape or material that appears more than once.

I also believe there is an element of instinct to bringing maximalist schemes together. We shouldn't feel afraid of elements competing for attention because I personally quite like a room that gives you something new to notice each time you look at it. But there needs to be a visual rhythm to it. I tend to stand back and look at the room as a whole rather than judging every element individually. There need to be elements of loud and quiet, light and shade, to allow a room to feel cohesive and successful.

Ultimately, I want a room to feel collected rather than coordinated. I'm much more interested in creating a sense that things have found their way together over time than making everything look like it came from the same collection.

When you begin a room, what tends to pull everything else into place? Is it usually one object, a colour, a

fabric, or is it more of a gut feeling at the start?

For me, there isn't really one formula, which is probably why I find the process so enjoyable. Sometimes it's one element that starts everything: a piece of fabric, a piece of art, a vintage find. Sometimes it's a client's must-have piece that starts the process, and often it will be centred around essentials such as the room layout or the practicalities of modern family life.

Quite often, though, it's a feeling. I'll have an instinct about the direction I want to take something before I can necessarily articulate exactly why. I think that comes from constantly absorbing interiors, architecture, travel, art and the world around me. You build up this visual library without necessarily realising it, and eventually you start making connections almost instinctively.

I also like to let a room evolve rather than trying to decide everything at once. I might know the colour palette and have one or two key pieces, but I want there to be room for the unexpected. Some of my favourite elements are the things that weren't necessarily part of the original plan.

The kitchen: figured wallpaper above blue patterned tile, with brass taps over a metal sink. Pattern is allowed to sit against pattern.

Older homes carry traces of the lives that came before us, in the architecture, the materials, the alterations, even the small imperfections. How much do you try to

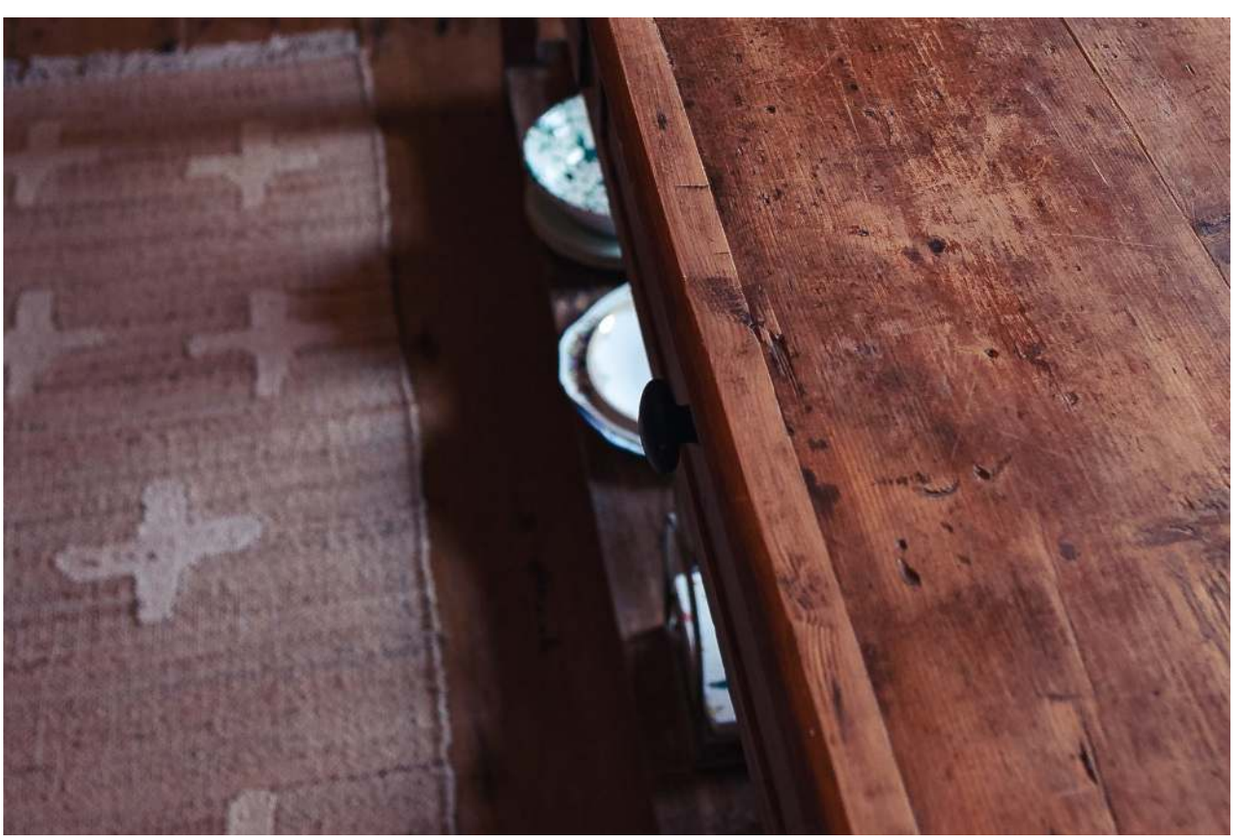
uncover that history before making new decisions, and do you see your role as preserving the story or continuing it?

I think older homes tell you a lot if you're willing to listen to them. I'm particularly drawn to Georgian, Victorian and Edwardian properties because they have a sense of identity before you've even put anything in them. The proportions, fireplaces, floors, mouldings and little imperfections all contribute to that.

I'm interested in understanding a building's history, but I don't think that means trying to turn it into a museum. Homes are meant to evolve. There will always be layers of different lives within them, and I think the most successful interiors acknowledge those layers rather than trying to erase them or preserve them to the point that it becomes impractical for modern family life.

That's something I've become particularly conscious of through renovating my own Georgian home. You start noticing all the evidence of the people who have lived there before you: the changes they made, the things they repaired, the things that have survived through good craftsmanship. I find that incredibly interesting.

So I'd say my role is less about preserving a story exactly as it was and more about continuing it. I want new interventions to feel like they belong in the conversation with what was already there.



A worn tabletop and a woven runner, photographed close: a surface that records use rather than conceals it.

The domestic interior has always been a form of self-representation, shaped by taste, memory and the objects people choose to live with. Do you see a home almost as a personal archive, and how do you translate something that private into a room?

Absolutely. The best homes, to me, are the ones where you can learn something about the people who live there simply by looking around.

I think our homes contain so much more of us than we sometimes realise. The objects we keep, the colours we gravitate towards, the things we inherit, the places we've travelled to and even the things we refuse to get rid of all tell a story.

That's one of the reasons I love working with clients. I'm not interested in imposing a particular version of what I think their home should look like. I want to understand what makes them feel at home. Sometimes that comes through in obvious ways (a collection, a piece of furniture or something with sentimental value), and sometimes it's much more subtle.

I see the design process as a kind of translation. A client might know that they want their home to feel warm, joyful, grown-up or slightly eccentric without knowing exactly how to achieve that visually. My job is to take those very personal, sometimes quite intangible things and turn them into colour, pattern, texture, furniture and objects.

The gallery wall. Prints, mirrors, postcards and a Vogue cover, hung against painted stripes.

Maximalism has long existed in tension with restraint, order and the idea of "good taste". Do you see contemporary maximalism partly as a reaction against those hierarchies?

I think there has been a long-standing idea that good taste means knowing when to stop: that restraint, simplicity and minimalism are somehow more sophisticated. Maximalism challenges that idea because it allows people to enjoy things simply because they love them.

I don't think that means minimalism is wrong, or that every room needs to be filled with pattern and colour. It's more about questioning the idea that there is one correct way for a home to look. Why shouldn't a room be joyful? Why shouldn't you display a slightly ridiculous collection simply because it makes you happy?

That freedom is a big part of what attracted me to maximalism. I love colour, pattern, vintage pieces, things with history and interiors that have a little bit of eccentricity to them. I'm much more interested in whether something feels meaningful than whether it fits neatly into an accepted definition of good taste.

For me, contemporary maximalism isn't really about rebellion for the sake of it. It's about giving people permission to trust their own instincts and to live in a space that represents them, feels like home and embraces who they are.

I want a room to feel collected rather than coordinated.

A sunburst panel over the fireplace, framed by wallpaper that refuses to recede. Nothing here is trying to be quiet.

Our sense of taste often comes from things we absorb almost without noticing: the homes we grew up in, places we visit, family objects. What do you think has shaped your own visual taste the most?

Probably a combination of places, buildings and the things I've collected along the way. I've always been drawn to older buildings and interiors with a sense of history, and I love the way colour and pattern are used in places like Morocco, Mexico, Spain and Italy. There's something about those spaces that feels incredibly instinctive: pattern sitting alongside pattern, strong colour, texture, craftsmanship and objects with a sense of age.

I'm also very influenced by the idea of things being collected rather than perfectly matched. Vintage and reclaimed pieces have always appealed to me because they bring a sense of history and individuality that you simply can't get from buying everything at once.

And then there are the homes I've lived in. Throughout my childhood, my dad would constantly be reinventing our home and rooms. He was never constrained by the style of house we lived in, but was led more by what he loved: crafting, making and experimenting. Then, living in rented, minimal new-builds through my twenties made me yearn for a home that was full of character, personality and history. This led me to renovate my first home and now my second. Both are period properties, and both have been app-

roached with a maximalist mindset that celebrates our style as a family: the things we love, little moments of joy in everyday life, and a home that feels designed to be lived in, not just to look good in a photograph.

I think a lot of our visual taste develops almost unconsciously. You absorb things from childhood, travel, books, films, buildings, people and places, and eventually all those little influences start to emerge in your own work.

A rattan chair in a small room papered floor to ceiling, with a second papered room beyond it.

Being recognised through Next in Design has brought your work into a much wider conversation. As your practice grows, is there anything about the way you work that you feel especially determined to protect?

Probably the freedom to follow my instincts.

Being recognised through Next in Design has been such an exciting moment for Feather&Fossil and has opened the door to opportunities I could never have imagined when I started. It's incredibly validating.

But I don't want growth to make the work feel less personal. I want to keep that sense of curiosity and playfulness, and I want to continue designing spaces that have personality rather than simply following whatever happens to be considered fashionable.

I also want to protect the belief that a home should feel like the people who live there. I don't want to create interiors that are perfect but interchangeable. I want to keep championing colour, pattern, vintage pieces, individuality and the slightly unexpected.

If anything, being recognised through Next in Design has given me more confidence to trust that instinct rather than less. I think the thing I'm most determined to protect is that feeling of freedom: the freedom to experiment, to be a little bit bold, and to make decisions because they feel right rather than seeking approval from others.

A working corner: an antique desk, a red glass-fronted cabinet, hanging jute baskets.

A brass pendant and a sunburst panel above a papered chimney breast. · Brass taps against blue patterned tile. · A mantelpiece with a painted mirror, two patterned vessels and a lamp with a green shade.

Photography: Paul Secker, Secker Studios. Interview conducted in writing for EPRIS Journal, September 2026. ■

ARCHITECTURE & INTERIORS OCT 9, 2026

The Luxury of What Is Not There: Winnie Tam of 28 a.m.

The founder of 28 a.m. on touch and temperature, the intelligence of shadow, and why a calm room begins with restraint rather than appearance.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & WINNIE TAM

SECTION III · ARCHITECTURE & INTERIORS · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & WINNIE TAM

The founder of 28 a.m. on touch and temperature, the intelligence of shadow, and why a calm room begins with restraint rather than appearance.

Architecture is often discussed as an image before it is understood as an atmosphere. Winnie Tam begins elsewhere: with the cool density of stone underfoot, the temperature of timber in the hand, the gradual change of daylight and the emotional force of an unfilled space. As founder of 28 a.m., an architectural and interior design studio based in London and Hong Kong, she treats calm not as a style but as a carefully constructed relationship between material, proportion, shadow and use.

The conversation centres on Fox Burrow, the studio's single-storey rear extension and interior renovation of a substantial Victorian house in Redbridge, London. Conceived as a restorative family sanctuary, the project draws on shakkei, the Japanese principle of borrowed scenery, and on Jun'ichirō Tanizaki's writing about darkness and reflected light. The result does not imitate nature or quote Japanese form. It works more quietly, through thresholds, tactile surfaces, framed views and light that is allowed to remain incomplete.

You often speak about designing through all five senses. Which sense is most underestimated in contemporary architecture and interiors?

Touch – specifically texture and temperature. Contemporary design has become increasingly image-obsessed, made to look striking on a screen rather than feel remarkable in person. We often underestimate the quiet weight of raw materials: the cool density of stone underfoot, or the gentle, unrefined drape of natural linen catching low light. True spatial luxury is not just seen; it is felt through the skin.

A close view of the timber joinery at Fox Burrow. Grain, shadow and the cool black handle make touch part of the composition. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

You describe your aesthetic as minimalist, effortlessly natural and profoundly calming. Is calm something you can design deliberately, or is it ultimately created by the person inhabiting the space?

Calm can absolutely be designed. As architects, we deliberately manipulate proportion, shadow and honest materiality to set an atmosphere. We remove visual noise to slow down the nervous system. The space sets the quiet rhythm; the person inhabiting it brings it to life. Calm is a shared dialogue between the architecture and the soul living within it.

The space sets the quiet rhythm; the person inhabiting it brings it to life.

The family room at Fox Burrow. Low light, pale upholstery and recessed alcoves produce calm through proportion rather than emptiness. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

Nature is one of the strongest references in your work. How do you translate its qualities into architecture without simply reproducing its visual language?

To avoid literal translation, we move away from visual motifs and focus on atmospheric quality. Nature is never static; it is defined by light, atmosphere and time.

We capture these qualities by designing spaces that respond dynamically to their environment. We prioritise materials that wear their history openly and age with beauty. By honouring the quiet rhythm of the natural world – its light, shadows and subtle textures – we create interiors that feel deeply organic and alive, without relying on literal representations.

At Fox Burrow, a curved ceiling recess turns indirect light into an architectural surface. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

Your work draws on Eastern philosophies. What have Japanese ideas taught you about space that you felt was missing from architectural practice in the West?

The appreciation for transition and the unfilled void. Western practice frequently treats space as something to be maximised, brightly illuminated and dressed with decorative intent. Eastern spatial philosophy revealed what was missing: the beauty of what is not there.

I am particularly interested in the luxury that lies in restraint. By celebrating subtle transitions between rooms, honouring thresholds and letting shadows play across natural surfaces, space gains emotional depth. Jun'ichirō Tanizaki's In Praise of Shadows reminds us that beauty resides not in the object itself, but in the patterns of shadows, light and darkness that one object creates against another. Embracing this principle allows our work to feel quiet, unhurried and deeply grounded.

A pendant above the stair is read through shadow before it is read as an object. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

Has contemporary Western architecture become too focused on adding more objects, more functions, more visual information rather than making space for absence?

For me, yes. Growing up in cities, I have long been overwhelmed by the availability of things. When I can no longer remember the story of an item and the reason for it to be there, it stops becoming meaningful to me. It is very much a personal choice, but I find I am most at peace when I have visual clarity, and that brings me calm.

The kitchen at Fox Burrow pairs a dark timber wall with a pale island and a precisely framed garden view. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

Could you tell us about a small detail in one of your projects that might go unnoticed visually, but fundamentally changes how the space is experienced?

I find that the most successful design details are the ones that go unnoticed. In Wave Residence, for example, we added an extension and an external window became part of an internal wall. I placed a framed alcove shelf there. The fact that it used to be a window would go entirely unnoticed if it were not mentioned.

In a recent project, the extension created a drop in ceiling height. We used that point to change the ceiling material, so the drop appeared intentional. When details are done well, they simply feel as if they belong. They do not stand out; they are quietly confident.

The wider kitchen view shows how storage, structure and circulation are absorbed into one legible composition. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

Do you think our homes can influence our habits and lifestyle, rather than simply accommodate them?

Totally. We are strongly influenced by the environment we are in. On a busy street, our hearts beat faster and we act faster. In a formal building, we are more cautious about how we walk, sit and speak. So when we design a home, we are not just designing the physical space; we are designing the lifestyle of the family inhabiting it.

Having lived and worked across London, Hong Kong, Tokyo and Paris, how have different cities shaped your understanding of what makes a place feel like home?

Each city taught me a different layer of sanctuary. Hong Kong showed me how to design tranquillity amid dense urban intensity. Tokyo revealed the emotional weight of quiet rituals and spatial discipline. London brought an appreciation for warm, tactile heritage. Together, they proved that home is not defined by geography. It is an internal feeling of quiet grounding, created when architecture honours how you live.

A quieter reading of the red room: mirror, hearth and pendant are held in a restrained, almost symmetrical frame. Photography: Nacho Rivera. Courtesy 28 a.m. Studio.

How do you balance visual simplicity with the complexity required to make a home genuinely sustainable and comfortable?

Through thoughtful integration. True comfort and sustainability – clean air systems, acoustic warmth and energy efficiency – should be built into the very bones of the house, not tacked on as visual clutter. When technical systems are designed seamlessly into the architecture, the space remains open, natural and effortlessly calm to inhabit. ■

Fox Burrow is a residential extension and interior renovation in Redbridge, London, by 28 a.m. Studio. All project photographs in this article are by Nacho Rivera and are reproduced from the studio's official project page with full editorial credit.

FURTHER

View Fox Burrow on 28 a.m. Studio 28am.studio/projects/fox-burrow

FEATURE AUG 17, 2026

In Conversation with Chora Practice

Founders of a Lisbon-based decor studio on the art of listening to your inner self, importance of resilience and favorite places in the city

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA & CHORA PRACTICE

SECTION III · FEATURE · MARIA IVANOVA & CHORA PRACTICE

Founders of a Lisbon-based decor studio on the art of listening to your inner self, importance of resilience and favorite places in the city

Creating your own project in a new country is always a bold step, where creative exploration intertwines closely with personal transformation. Elena Kuzmina and Xenia Bunina – founders of decor studio Chora Practice, based in Lisbon, Portugal – talk about how to turn any crisis into a point of growth, why there are no "uncreative" people in the world, and how to allow yourself to do what you genuinely love.

Elena Kuzmina and Xenia Bunina, Founders of Chora Practice

Chora is a creative practice. Could you tell us about your background?

Xenia: Most people who move to Portugal eventually start doing what they truly love – things they wanted to pursue in their 'past life' but were afraid to because of social expectations. The same happened to me.

After moving here, I started my own production company, working on photo and video advertising. That's how Alena and I met. Later, I discovered Arco, a contemporary art school where we were taught not so much how to draw as how to look at the world through an artistic lens. I graduated this year, it were three years of intense study.

Elena, could you tell us about your experience?

Elena: I'm from a small town in Chuvashia and trained as an English and French teacher. But I was always drawn to art – cinema, architecture, painting, crafts - everything. Before moving, I took filmmaking courses because I dreamed of making films. When I found out that Ksenia had her own production company here, I wanted to join her.

I was so nervous about reaching out that my husband Mark contacted Ksenia for me, asking if I could come by, observe, and help out. In the end, Ksenia and I became very close. She's an incredible person – always encouraging others and giving them space to express themselves. It was Ksenia who told me, 'You should go to the art school.' I was surprised: 'Me? Are you serious?' But I eventually enrolled too. It turned out to be an amazing experience: we learned to observe, create, and go through a complex, profound, almost philosophical process of discovery.

Organized by Open the Door Events | Photo by Joy Zamora

You mentioned that after moving to Portugal, you felt a sense of freedom. What exactly contributes to that?

Xenia: The environment is completely different. I love my city and my country, but St. Petersburg is huge, while Lisbon has only around 600,000 people. Because there are fewer people and the overall atmosphere is more relaxed, everything feels calmer. If you're not bothering anyone, people tend to support you. In an environment like this, it's much easier to express yourself.

Does it also have to do with the relaxed atmosphere around you, as well as the fact that no one knows you and you're free to try something new?

Xenia: I don't know if Alena feels the same, but I had this thought. Immigration can be a very intense experience, no matter how prepared you are. For many immigrants, life feels divided into two periods – the life before and the new one. If you're starting over, why repeat what you've just lived through when you have the chance to begin doing what you genuinely want?

That's a powerful thought. We often arrive at positive change by overcoming difficult experiences.

Let's talk about your decoration studio. What exactly do you do, and what are your main areas of focus?

Xenia: Our main focus is textile decor for premium weddings. Initially, we decorated restaurants, creating temporary seasonal installations for Christmas or summer. Then we did our first wedding project and thought, 'Oh, this is actually such a great field!'

Organized by Open the Door Events | Photo by Joy Zamora

Why did you decide to focus on textile design?

Elena: I think we simply aren't afraid of challenges. We dive headfirst into every project and figure things out along the way. As artists, we see fabric simply as the medium that feels right for this particular stage. We're not attached to the idea of always creating textile arches.

Xenia: I think it was more Alena's initiative. She knows how to sew, genuinely loves fabrics, and has a deep understanding of the material.

At some point, we started receiving requests for fabric installations and realized we had found an open niche. It was a combination of a rational business approach and genuine personal interest. And although installing huge arches is physically demanding, fabric turned out to be the easiest material for us to work with because we understand it so well.

Organized by Open the Door Events | Photo by Joy Zamora

How did you choose the name Chora? Is it connected to philosophy?

Xenia: It was a beautiful sunny day – I think it was August – and we were sitting in the stunning Estrela Garden brainstorming. There were three of us at the time, and we had already been trying to come up with a name for about a month.

Then we came across Plato's concept of Chora. In his philosophy, it refers to a primordial space – 'space before everything' – where matter comes into being. We found that idea very inspiring, especially because our initial concept was multisensory decor.

Then we had to decide on the format. Words like 'studio' or 'bureau' were already taken, and that's when we came up with 'practice'. We thought, 'Wait, this sounds like an art practice! That's perfect.' And that's how Chora Practice was born.

Six months later, we finally decided to find out what Chora meant in Portuguese – we hadn't actually checked. It turned out to be the imperative form of the verb chorar, meaning 'cry'.

Let's talk a little about the technical side. What does the installation process look like? Do you do everything yourselves or mainly oversee the process?

Elena: We mostly do everything ourselves.

Xenia: It depends on the project. When we created a tent for Tales [Wedding Planner], we had a team from Back UP Rentals. After a short briefing, they created an incredible draping installation very quickly. Our decorations aren't that large-scale yet, so the two of us can handle quite a lot ourselves.

The events industry is full of unexpected situations. How do you deal with crises on site?

Elena: Something always goes wrong at weddings. The main thing is to stay calm and be prepared.

Xenia: We always bring extra fabric. We try to anticipate potential problems in advance – what obstacles can occur for florists, organizers, and transportation. We think through as many possible scenarios as we can, come up with solutions, and prepare for them.

How do you deal with crises and creative burnout? What helps you recover and move forward when things get difficult?

Elena: Crises definitely happen. When I'm exhausted, I go for a walk in the forest. Nature inspires, relaxes, and recharges me enormously. I see problems as a completely normal part of the process. In fact, I'm even grateful for them because they mean we're actively searching, facing challenges, and growing."

Xenia: "I believe every business is essentially a journey from one crisis to the next. It's not a burden – it's simply part of reality. You need to be prepared for it and understand that every crisis is an opportunity. Things are going incredibly well for us now, and we're very happy, but we know another difficult period will eventually come. And when it does, we'll get through it and come out stronger.

Yes, it's difficult and frustrating. But if something frustrates you so much that you want to cry, that probably means you're just one step away from a breakthrough. Art school taught me that if you don't move toward that resistance, you lose the opportunity. So: breathe in, breathe out, and solve the problem.

@chora.practice

How would you explain a life filled with creativity to someone who isn't connected to the creative world? How you experience and perceive the world?

Xenia: "Honestly, I don't know – I've never been on the other side. I don't believe people are divided into 'creative' and 'non-creative'.

When someone says, ‘You’re creative people, but I’m more down-to-earth,’ I’m convinced that they’re suppressing something in themselves. For whatever reason – shame, fear, or social conditioning – they don’t allow themselves to recognize the artist within.

I truly believe we’re all creators to some degree. And if someone reading this thinks, ‘No, that definitely isn’t me,’ I’d suggest simply opening yourself up to the world a little more. There is definitely something inside you.

How would you suggest people reconnect with that creative part of themselves?

Xenia: There’s a practice called "Impulse". For instance, you’re walking down the street and suddenly feel like picking up a leaf or photographing a particular building. Your inner critic immediately says, ‘Why? Nobody needs this. We’re late. Please stop doing something pointless.

But that little impulse is exactly what your mind is telling you to ignore. If you listen to this impulse once, then again and again, the world gradually becomes richer – and you learn more about yourself, what you genuinely like, and what you really want to do.

The important thing is to hear that voice saying, ‘This is pointless,’ and answer: ‘Great. I’m going to do something pointless.’ That helped me enormously. It’s actually what led me to art school, because at first, studying art felt completely pointless.

Elena, do you have your own way of unlocking that creative part of yourself?

Elena: I’m a very slow person, so observation helps me a lot. I love immersing myself in the process – looking at a tree, feeling the wind. Simply observing yourself and the world around you can reveal a lot.

What is your favorite place in Lisbon, somewhere you always want to return to?

Elena: Probably the Gulbenkian Garden. It’s an incredible park and museum. It’s right in the city, but once you enter, it feels like you’re somewhere completely different. It’s a beautiful combination of nature, architecture, and art. You walk in and suddenly find yourself in your own little world. You can breathe out.

Xenia: For me, besides Gulbenkian, it’s probably Cabo Espichel. It has this incredible lighthouse and is considered by the Portuguese to be one of the westernmost points of Europe. I also love the café at Museu Albuquerque, and MACAM – Museu de Arte Contemporânea Armando Martins – has a wonderful café too. They’re all affordable but incredibly stylish. Museums often have amazing cafés.

Gulbenkian Garden · Cabo Espichel

What has been your most inspiring trip?

Xenia: I've just come back from New York, where my husband and I got married, so that's definitely my strongest impression at the moment. But I think every journey is inspiring in its own way.

Elena: Recently, it was my solo trip to Porto. I visited the Serralves Museum of Contemporary Art, explored Álvaro Siza's architecture, and absolutely loved it. The fact that I went alone also made it a special experience.

Finally, what is the one piece of advice you would give every reader?

Elena: Keep doing what you genuinely love. Despite your inner limitations, look deeply within yourself, listen to your true desires, and simply give yourself permission to pursue them.

Xenia: The main lesson I took from art school is: 'Experience resistance.' If you feel resistance toward something, you should move toward it. It means there's a huge amount of energy hidden there. Don't ignore or suppress it – look at it more closely. ■

DESIGN STUDY JUL 11, 2026

Five Rooms, One Signature

A dalmatian dot, a slab of burl, three portraits of the same painted dog, and one small cone that keeps reappearing where you least expect it – the disciplined vocabulary one apartment uses five different ways without ever repeating itself.

WORDS BY EPRIS JOURNAL

SECTION III · DESIGN STUDY · EPRIS JOURNAL

A dalmatian dot, a slab of burl, three portraits of the same painted dog, and one small cone that keeps reappearing where you least expect it – the disciplined vocabulary one apartment uses five different ways without ever repeating itself.

Walk through this apartment once and you'll clock the polka dot, the burl veneer, the pair of painted dogs watching from three different walls. Walk through it twice and you'll notice none of them ever appears the same way twice – the dot changes scale on every surface it lands on, the veneer goes from tabletop to cabinet front to a single framed square the size of a postcard, and the dogs shift from grey to black-and-white to a single cropped blue portrait, as if the same idea keeps being translated rather than repeated. That's the real subject here: not a look, but a small, disciplined set of decisions a home can apparently sustain across five very different rooms without ever repeating itself outright.

The dot at its largest scale: a full sectional, upholstered edge to edge, the pattern reading almost as texture before it reads as pattern.

Up close, this is not a printed polka dot – it's drawn, each mark an irregular blot with its own weight and edge, the kind of variation that happens when a hand repeats a gesture rather than a machine repeating a die-cut. At sofa scale that irregularity does real work: a perfectly regular dot this large would read as upholstery fabric behaving like wallpaper, decorative and slightly cheap. An irregular one reads as texture – closer to the

fur it's clearly quoting than to a print. The skirted coffee table underneath, in the same dot at a smaller, denser scale, is the one piece of furniture in the room dressed rather than upholstered – a wood disc on a fabric petticoat, a deliberately strange thing to set next to a sectional this architectural. A small metal cone sits on that table next to a stack of books – the same silhouette the bedroom lamp repeats later, at a completely different scale, in a completely different material, though nothing about this room announces that yet.

The same idea, translated five times, is a collection. The same idea, copied five times, is a theme.

The same burl veneer three ways in one shot: a low credenza, a floating shelf, a single framed square holding a photograph instead of a view.

Burl is wood at its least geometric – the pattern comes from a tree's stress response, a knot it tried and failed to grow around, so no two panels of it can ever be book-matched the way straight-grain veneer can. Using that much of it, at this many scales, only works because everything touching it is so plain: a clean-lined credenza, a cantilevered shelf with no visible bracket, a floral armchair with soft, boneless-looking arms. That chair is the one curved, patterned object let into a room otherwise built from straight edges and one wild, unrepeatable grain – the same trick the polka dot pulls next to the burl nightstand in the bedroom, just in a different material. A second cone turns up here too, catching the light on the same low round table – small enough to miss, insistent enough that once you've seen it once, you start looking for it everywhere else in the apartment.

Repeat an object enough times, in different sizes and different materials, and it stops being decoration and starts being a signature.

A third dog, a third register: black and white instead of blue-grey, posed instead of caught mid-turn, hung above a burl console instead of a wood-panelled wall.

Three paintings of the same subject, three different colour treatments, and not one of them hung as a matching set – that's the tell that this is a collection built by eye, not ordered as a triptych. The chairs here do the same quiet work as the sofa's dot: a floral fabric, blue on white, wrapped around a frame with almost no right angles in it, so the pattern reads as movement rather than upholstery. Underneath, the same burl slab from the living room reappears as a table edge, thick enough to read as solid wood rather than veneer on plywood – the one place in the apartment where the material gets to be the whole object instead of a surface on top of one. The table's legs are polished to a full mirror, which does something the burl can't: it doubles the room instead of just decorating it, folding the chairs and their floral fabric back into the reflection like a second, slightly bluer dining room underneath the real one.

The dot at bedding scale, denser and smaller again, with the curtain behind it as a fourth scale still.

This is the same fabric logic as the sofa, run through a full range of scales in a single room: one dot on the curtain, a different-weight dot on the coverlet, a third scale entirely in the woven stripe underneath it, and a fourth blue-toned dog watching over all of it from a single cropped portrait rather than a full pose. Nothing here is trying to match – the curtain's dot and the bedding's dot are close enough to belong to the same family and different enough that the eye keeps working to place them, which is most of why the room reads as layered instead of themed. Pull back and the bed itself is doing the same layering trick as the room around it: a ribbed brown blanket, a striped waffle throw, and the dot coverlet on top, three different textures stacked the way the three dog portraits are stacked across three different rooms – repetition disguised as variety, or maybe the other way around.

The one corner of the apartment where the whole vocabulary collapses into a single, small composition: dot, burl, wood, one deliberate diagonal.

A cone tapers to a point with no seam, generated by nothing more than a straight line spun around an axis. Underneath it, a hexagon built from two stacked prisms, six flat planes each, closing on itself because six is the only number under ten that divides 360 without a remainder. One shape has no edges at all; the other is almost nothing but edges – and setting the cone's point directly above the hexagon's centre is what lets two unrelated families of geometry read as a single object. Behind both, the dot grid is the strictest geometry in the apartment, fixed interval, no dot more important than its neighbour – except that up close every mark is drawn, not stamped, the same disciplined irregularity holding the whole home together at every scale it appears. By the time the cone reaches this nightstand, it has already appeared twice as a small object on two different coffee tables – which means the lamp isn't introducing a new shape into the apartment so much as finally giving one of its recurring shapes somewhere serious to stand. The lamp is the one line in the frame that refuses the grid: its shade tips toward the pillow at almost exactly the angle a person leans in to say one last thing before a room goes dark – the single object here allowed to behave like it has somewhere to be.

▪

Three coffee-table cones and one lamp aren't a coincidence. They're the closest thing this apartment has to a signature.

None of this explains why the apartment feels calm rather than styled – restraint does that, and so does resisting the urge to match anything exactly. But counting how many times the same dot, the same burl, the same cone, and the same painted dog show up in five rooms, at five different scales, is a decent way to start noticing why some homes read as collected and most just read as decorated.

ESSAY MAR 14, 2026

Home Away From Home

A pied-à-terre always catches the irreplaceable light in your eyes, but it can also spark them.

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

SECTION III · ESSAY · MARIA IVANOVA

A pied-à-terre always catches the irreplaceable light in your eyes, but it can also spark them.

Choosing a place to stay in a new destination means entrusting it with the significant moments of your life. Falling into bed after a long walk through unfamiliar streets, late-night talks filled with the thoughts and emotions of the day, planning the next breakfast at your newly favorite nearby boulangerie, sharing genuine smiles and the pure excitement of exploration.

A pied-à-terre always catches the irreplaceable light in your eyes, but it can also spark them. A flat in the city naturally blends you with those who live nearby. You are no longer a tourist, but someone who acts as if it were the most natural thing to buy lactose-free milk for your morning coffee it the shop downstairs.
And it is not a one-sided longing when we speak about pied-à-terre residences in Paris - the collection of architectural apartments in the prime location of The Moveable Feast.

Each of the apartments is a small journey within a larger one. When a space is carefully designed, you are respectfully offered so much to discover.

What feelings these walls evoke in you, how warm the textures are, how fluid the spatial organization seems, how gentle the rays of sun are in this flat, how loudly the floors creak, or perhaps the renovation has made them completely quiet. All these questions will never consciously arise in your mind, yet they will be answered silently within your body.

What I love about Pied-à-terre apartments is their complexity. The interiors are rich and confident.There is no attempt to reduce the experience of space to a minimum within your cognitive and emotional perception. Rather, the space helps you understand that sometimes valuable rest is not an introduction to emptiness, but a pleasant process of exploration That is exactly what we seek when booking flight tickets and anticipating the moment of landing in a distant place.

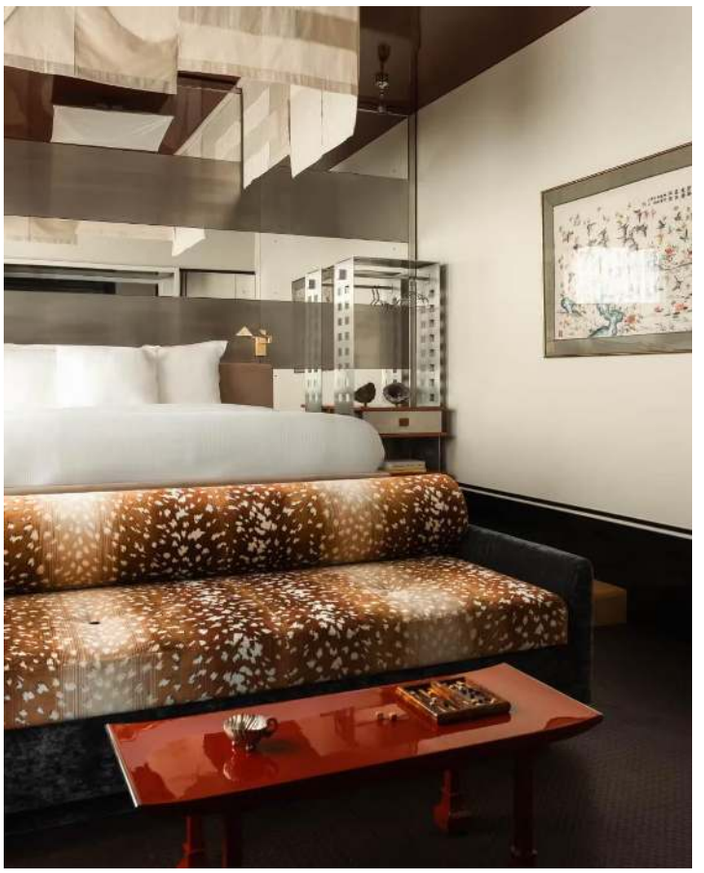
Being exposed to new memories with spiritual and material richness is nourishing for both soul and heart. I emphasize this duality because design is constructed from physical elements, yet everything within it contributes to the mental experience The perception of interconnections is more important than the mere existence of things.
In other words, we appreciate how the lily makes us feel inside, rather than the fact of its tangible existence.

Each apartment is exclusive, giving you the opportunity to choose what you want to experience.

The two-storey townhouse on the Tuileries by Necchi Architecture is a dichromatic sanctuary, gently enriched with details in a way that makes you feel calm. The elaborate visual density is created through the overlay and juxtaposition of forms. Shadows playing across the monochromatic volumes create a textured canvas for exquisite black and steel elements.

Chairs 212 by Petite Furniture recreate René Herbst's Sandows collection of 1929, standing beside the 1980s Cello lamp by Jan Wickelgren for IKEA. The integrated desk in front of the windows is accompanied by the Memmi lamp by Modenature.

The townhouse is not the only project designed by Charlotte Albert and Alexis Lamesta of Necchi Architecture. The Superior Loft on Oberkampf catches the eye from the very first second.



Oberkampf - Superior Loft

Provocative patterns, red colour, chrome, and mirrors immediately transport us to a joyful evening in a 1970s Parisian apartment. The interior is composed of accents that support each other's flamboyance, grounded by touches of black.
You can almost see how the sunlight diffuses, moving from one corner of the room to another, hitting the lacquered surfaces and slipping past the sharp corners.

One of the most compelling qualities here is its unpredictability. You slightly turn your gaze and see a completely different scene, untouched by the perspective you just left.

I have an association between a pied-a-terre and a box of exquisite chocolates.One carries orange zest, another lemon cream; the next reveals rosemary, while another holds delicate notes of jasmine.

The list continues, but once you know all the flavours, the spark of discovery is partly faded.

Explore it by yourself. ■

FEATURE JUL 24, 2026

Polish Design: Woven From Memory

How does the sensitivity of Polish designers towards cultural heritage shape the design scene

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

SECTION III · FEATURE · MARIA IVANOVA

How does the sensitivity of Polish designers towards cultural heritage shape the design scene

Contemporary Polish design has arrived at a moment of profound, quiet maturity. To walk through the studios of today's leading architects and furniture designers is to encounter a language of rigorous minimalism, tactile raw materials, and a deliberate structural honesty. Yet, this modern clarity is not a rejection of the past - it is the culmination of a century-long dialogue regarding what it means to create with a national soul.

To understand this current precision, one must look back to the Young Poland (Młoda Polska) movement of the 1890s. Emerging at a time when Poland was politically erased from the map, the movement acted as a vital act of cultural resistance. Polish artists, much like their peers in the British Arts and Crafts movement, rejected the soulless standardization of the Industrial Age. Instead, they sought to construct a national identity through the arts, fusing architecture, furniture, and textiles into a "total work of art" that was heavily steeped in local folklore, symbolism, and a romanticized connection to the land. It was a movement born from a desperate need to preserve a culture that was under existential threat.

Modern Polish design has inherited this deep-seated ethos of artisan integrity, but it has undergone a striking evolution in its execution. Where the artists of Young Poland once relied on intricate, heavy ornamentation to assert their heritage, today's designers have chosen the path of subtraction. They have systematically stripped away the romantic veneer of the past to reveal the structural skeleton underneath.

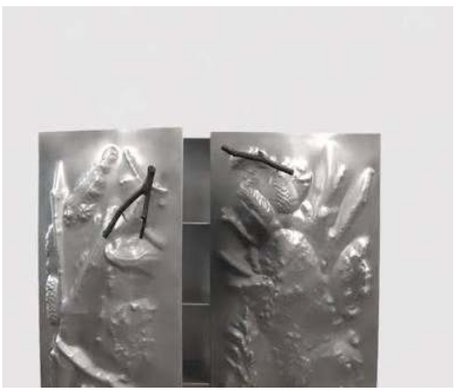
The result is a design language that feels unmistakably Polish, not through the repetition of folklore, but through an unwavering commitment to architectural discipline. In these contemporary spaces, the warmth of tradition is now expressed through the inherent quality of materials – the grain of wood, the weight of stone, and the thoughtful geometry of a form. It is a transition from the decorative to the essential.

By focusing on the quiet beauty of proportion and the tactile reality of the everyday, today's creators have moved beyond the struggle to define an identity. They have built one that is self-assured and globally resonant – a sophisticated bridge between the ancestral pride of the 1890s and the minimalist, structural reality of the present.

Wiktoria and Filip Bielicki

Wiktoria and Filip Bielicki operate at the intersection of structural rigor and tactile sensitivity, creating objects that function less as mere furniture and more as deliberate anchors within a space.

The first sight on their cabinets give us a riddle. The convex surface of the doors hide more than an abstract forms - light and shadow interplay framed the cast of branches, leaves, snags, trunks and mosses that are laid in chaotic composition. Later the intersection of natural objects are scanned in 3d for further incremental aluminum sheet forming by KUKA robot.



Technologies become an instrument of detailed stamping of fragile organic structures with elaborate surfaces, that freeze in time forever.

The visual stealthiness and modesty of represented natural elements is achieved by the use of matte mono material and simple geometrical forms of cabinets. The part of the design is allocated to light - more accurately, to the shadows caused by it - convex relief is a consistent dialogue with the environment.

The idea of preserving the nature without a direct use of materials sourced from it is an example of impressive contemporary Polish design, that prove its ingenuity deprived of radical independence from the past and the environment.

Zofia Wyganowska

Projects under the signage of Zofia Wyganowska Studio are executed with a rigorous attention to Polish heritage, bridging the gap between historical craft and contemporary restraint. The interiors are characterized by a light, airy quality, where tactile materials and contrasting volumes exist in a state of deliberate equilibrium. Operating within a strictly curated color palette, Wyganowska emphasizes clarity, allowing self-explanatory furniture - often crafted from raw, natural materials - to dictate the mood of the space.

A vital component of her signature aesthetic is the handling of surface texture. Whether achieved through intentional craftsmanship or the patient patina of time, these surfaces grant her projects a depth that feels both lived-in and meticulously composed. This commitment to materiality is matched by her active integration of contemporary Polish art and design, effectively turning her interiors into galleries of local creative dialogue.

This synthesis of tradition and modernism is perhaps most evident in her collaboration with the niche perfume store, Mood Scent Bar. Within this retail environment, Wyganowska integrates pajaki as a rhythmic counterpoint to the store's minimalist architecture. By suspending these intricate, geometric structures against the sleek, stark lines of the display shelves, she recontextualizes folk art into a striking sculptural installation.

Mood Scent Bar

Karolina Merska

Mentionig "pajaki" is inseparable with art historian Karolina Merska, who gives a renaissance to this traditional Polish element. Pajaki (*from pl.* spider) is a traditional pendant accessories made out of straw and paper, which were hanging from the ceiling in the village houses. It's believed that they bring luck, protect from evil and deliver prosperity.

As in its historical roots, pajaki continuous to bring joy in the modern interiors. Hand-crafted suspended structures with various details is embraced in dynamism. The movement of decorative accumulations with pompons, straw and flowers is a focus of attention, reminding about rich and eclectic heritage of Poland.

Yet, beyond this vibrant exterior lies a profound architectural discipline. Merska does not merely replicate the past; she refines it, distilling the complex, cosmic geometry of the pajaki into a form that resonates with contemporary silence and light. By isolating these intricate silhouettes, she forces a reconciliation between the ephemeral nature of the materials – straw and paper – and the enduring weight of cultural memory.

Ala Savashevich

Ala Savashevich's handwoven works operate as a stark, intellectual subversion of the tactile warmth we typically associate with loom-based traditions. While her choice of technique is deeply embedded in the lineage of Polish folk weaving, she systematically strips away the decorative joy of the craft to expose its underlying structural logic.

In these pieces, the act of weaving is no longer a search for aesthetic softness or domestic ornamentation. Instead, it becomes a method of mapping tension. By utilizing raw, sometimes industrial materials or monochromatic palettes, she transforms the fluid movement of the hand into a static, architectural grid.

It is here that the dialogue with Polish tradition becomes most visceral. Traditionally, the weaver's labor was a communal, stabilizing force, a way of binding the domestic environment together. Savashevich retains this binding quality, yet she directs it toward a critical examination of social and historical boundaries.

Her textiles function like blueprints of restraint – they are woven with the same obsessive precision as her sculptural objects, forcing the viewer to confront the fact that our traditions are not merely decorative overlays, but are, in fact, the very warp and weft of our ideological fabric. It is a brilliant, quiet form of resistance, where the ancient craft of the loom is turned into a lens for modern, analytical inquiry.

Ania Jaworska

Ania Jaworska is an architect and designer whose practice operates at the precise intersection of fine art and architectural theory. Having honed her craft through formal education at both the Cracow University of Technology and the Cranbrook Academy of Art, she approaches design not as mere product creation, but as a conceptual interrogation of space and behavior.

Her work is defined by a bold, reductive vocabulary – frequently utilizing geometric rigor to challenge our perceptions of utility. The SET series, showcased at the Volume Gallery, serves as a poignant example of this methodology. In pieces like the Unit 2B (Coffee Table), Jaworska moves beyond the surface-level function of furniture, instead treating the object as an archetype. By employing stark, monochromatic palettes and monolithic forms, she strips away the superfluous to reveal the essential masses.

Her design language is an intellectual exercise in balancing playfulness with profound structural discipline. Jaworska's practice is a testament to the fact that when form is executed with absolute clarity, it ceases to be just an object and becomes a deliberate, spatial statement.

Marcin Rusak

Marcin Rusak's creative practice is deeply rooted in his personal heritage as the descendant of several generations of flower growers, a background that anchors his exploration of ephemerality, nature, and the concept of beauty. This connection to Polish agricultural traditions serves as a vital bridge between the historical significance of the land and a contemporary design language that questions our modern habits of overproduction and excess consumption.

His studio acts as a laboratory for the intersection of preservation and decay, creating works that challenge the perceived permanence of our material world. By treating his projects as evolving experiments, Rusak reframes the mundane details of daily life into profound experiences, using botany as a lens to reconsider our relationship with time and aesthetic value.

This approach aligns with the broader trajectory of modern Polish design, which seeks to transcend mere decoration by imbuing functional objects with narrative depth.

Nowadays Polish Design is a quintessence of devotion to the craftsmanship, that has proclaimed the cultural identity for decades. Aspiring to create against the backdrop of utilitarian minimalism, architects and designers translate their vision, continuing to shape a unique national narrative that amazes the creatives around the world. ■

INTERVIEW SEPTEMBER 18, 2026

A Cow Made of Broken Tile

A family workshop on turning mosaic, a material invented never to move, into furniture that ships across oceans, and why a table with a cow on it is, they insist, mostly about the glass of milk you got after a day outside.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & DIHLUST

SECTION III · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & DIHLUST

A family workshop on turning mosaic, a material invented never to move, into furniture that ships across oceans, and why a table with a cow on it is, they insist, mostly about the glass of milk you got after a day outside.

DIHLUST is a family workshop in Ukraine, run by a brother and sister who build small, cube shaped side tables entirely out of glazed mosaic tile. Every piece begins as a sketch reduced to a grid, most often a pixellated cow, their signature image, though a client's logo or a pet's portrait works just as well, then gets laid, tile by tile, onto a wooden frame built to carry the weight.

Their online listings read less like a shop and more like a missing-pet notice reworked for furniture: a promise that MILK-cube is “looking for a loving family.” Mosaic has meant permanence for two thousand years; DIHLUST packs it for international courier instead. EPRIS wrote to them with nine questions built around exactly that contradiction. They answered in their own words, translated here from Ukrainian and condensed for length.

William Morris argued, a century and a half ago, that everyday objects deserve as much attention as painting, the idea the Arts and Crafts movement was built on. Tell us how DIHLUST began: why did a cube clad in mosaic, rather than a painting or a sculpture, become the object you chose to speak through?

The first reason is function. A side table is not a silent object, it is something we interact with every day: you set a coffee cup on it, put down a book or your keys. That means it can belong to any space, and it lives alongside our life. Marks get left on it, it gets used. It is a functional art object that erases the line between a certain high aesthetic and the everyday.

In Japanese folklore there is tsukumogami, the belief that an object, used long and carefully enough, eventually grows a soul of its own. Your listing "MILK-cube is looking for a loving family" says almost exactly that about furniture: factory objects are usually silent, yours seem to be looking for a home. Where does that impulse to humanise, or animalise, your own pieces come from? Do you genuinely feel each cube is a little alive, or is this mostly the language of marketing?

Of course there is a large part marketing in it, we like playing with concepts and metaphors. But every table really is unique, which makes it very easy to grow attached to it, almost like it is family.

The "loving family" listing is actually an old street form: a handwritten notice on a lamppost about a lost pet, with tear-off phone number strips along the bottom. You took that form almost literally and filled it with commercial content. What matters more to you in that gesture: irony about advertising, or a sincere attempt to make selling furniture feel as emotional as finding a home for an animal?

We carried that format over to furniture because every table of ours is unique. When you make something with your own hands, putting in tens of hours of work, it stops being just a product and takes on a character of its own, so we thought it would be great to build that into the piece in this style.

A cow and a glass of milk are a recurring motif in your work. Is that more a personal story from childhood or rural life, or a deliberate engagement with a pastoral, almost kolkhoz adjacent iconography that a lot of people in Ukraine right now either feel awkward about, or, on the contrary, are reclaiming with tenderness?

It is mainly about nostalgia. When we were thinking about which set to release first, as a family business, me and my brother, we wanted, for no particular reason, to start from where life itself starts: from childhood, from its warmest memories.

The image of a glass of milk is tied to something simple: how we would spend a whole summer day outside, running around, getting tired, and then that cold glass of milk felt like the tastiest thing in the world. Those are pure emotions and memories we

wanted to put into our work. It seems like exactly the kind of nostalgic feeling that connects most people.

Mosaic has meant permanence for millennia: the floors of Byzantine churches, Gaudí's façades, things built to outlast generations in one place. You turn it into an object that can be lifted, embraced, sold and shipped across an ocean. What breaks in the idea of mosaic itself once it stops being part of a fixed space and becomes a thing that travels?

Nothing breaks. If anything, mosaic takes on an entirely new life here. We are not destroying its permanence, we are making it mobile. We are simply rethinking it.

Your profile has a "MEET OUR TEAM" family collage. Historically, a workshop where the whole family works is closer to a medieval guild, or to the early Eames Office, than to a contemporary design studio with hired staff. Was staying a family workshop a conscious

choice, or did it simply happen that way because of scale?

It was a conscious choice, even though the whole thing was born spontaneously. We came up with the business itself in literally one day. Then we checked the market, realised nothing quite like this existed yet, and started acting right away.

Our family has always made things with our own hands: my brother paints and does plaster relief work on walls, our father can do a full renovation from scratch himself, so there was never really any doubt we could learn this too and build the picture we had in our heads. It is also a rare chance to do creative work that feeds the whole family at once, about as close to an ideal life scenario as it gets, because everything our family has ever had came through hard physical labour and a constant search for work.

Fragile tile on a wooden base, and yet worldwide shipping across oceans and customs: a material invented never to move again now has to survive a courier service. What did you actually have to change in your technique for the sake of the journey, rather than for the sake of beauty?

We had to make peace with the fact that packaging for each table ends up fairly expensive, around twenty to twenty-five percent of the table's cost. That is a sacrifice we cannot show our work to the world without, so we just accepted it as a fact. We also had to reinforce the tables from the inside, which adds weight but is about durability. They weigh sixteen to thirty-one kilograms.

Your bio has the phrase "possible realisation of your own…", meaning you are open to someone else's idea. In a traditional craft guild the master usually carried out the patron's vision and kept his own voice hidden in the execution. Is it the same for you, or does the final word always stay with you while the client only sets the theme?

We are always interpreting someone else's idea, but through the lens of our own style. All our tables stay pixellated and minimalist, but the image itself can be almost anything: a logo, a portrait of someone's pet. The final word on style and form is always ours, because that is our artistic language, but the client sets the theme and the story. We get enormous pleasure from that process, watching a shared idea turn into a recognisable pixel art table.

The Arts and Crafts movement never quite survived its own contradiction: handwork, loved for being unrepeatable, scales badly without losing exactly what made it worth loving. Have you already thought about that trap for DIHLUST, or are you prepared to stay a small workshop for as long as it takes?

We are fully aware of that trap of handwork, but in our view it is always better to raise quality and value than to chase volume of sales. Of course, if it turns out to be necessary for growth, we do plan to eventually bring in extra hands for the basic processes, to make the work more efficient.

Photographs courtesy of DIHLUST. Interview conducted in writing for EPRIS Journal, September 2026, and translated from Ukrainian. ■

SECTION IV

Objects & Time

An object becomes cultural when its material, labour and systems of value remain visible at the same time.

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DESIGN & COLLECTING SEP 29, 2026

Who Owns the Hours? Audemars Piguet and the Art of Manufacturing Time

A watch measures seconds, but a luxury brand manufactures something larger: authorship, scarcity and cultural time. Inside Audemars Piguet's radical return to collective craft.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION IV · DESIGN & COLLECTING · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

A watch measures seconds, but a luxury brand manufactures something larger: authorship, scarcity and cultural time. Inside Audemars Piguet's radical return to collective craft.

A mechanical watch is an absurd object in the most productive sense of the word. The telephone in a pocket measures time more accurately, updates itself automatically and costs a fraction of a complicated movement. Yet collectors wait years and spend fortunes for a machine that gains or loses seconds. Its value begins precisely where utility ends.

Audemars Piguet understands this paradox better than almost any modern watchmaker. The company does not simply sell instruments that tell time. It constructs a cultural system in which steel can behave like a precious metal, hand-finishing becomes evidence of authorship, scarcity becomes desire, a museum becomes a movement, and contemporary art teaches the brand how to speak beyond the wrist.

I The product that cannot justify itself by function

Luxury watches are often described as art because they are difficult to make. Difficulty alone is not enough. A jet engine is difficult; a medical scanner is difficult. Art enters when technical labour is made available for contemplation – when a solution exceeds its practical task and begins to organise attention, memory and interpretation.

The decisive material in watchmaking is therefore not gold, ceramic or steel. It is time twice over: the time indicated by the hands and the time sedimented in the object. Polishing a bevel nobody will see, adjusting a repeater by ear, or cutting a stone to fit one irregular link converts hours of labour into an almost invisible surplus. The collector purchases condensed duration.

The first century: complexity before the icon

Audemars Piguet began in 1875, when Jules Louis Audemars and Edward Auguste Piguet established their workshop in Le Brassus. The location was not picturesque branding invented later. The Vallée de Joux had developed a dispersed economy of highly specialised makers whose long winters encouraged domestic precision work. The company emerged from that network rather than from a modern factory system.

From 1882 onward, grande complication work became a continuous thread through periods when such objects had almost no rational commercial future. A grande complication combines several demanding functions – traditionally a calendar, chronograph and chiming mechanism – inside one coordinated movement. Its significance is not the number of functions but their negotiation for space, energy and reliability.

The 1899 Universelle pocket watch, now positioned at the centre of the Musée Atelier, condensed nineteen complications and 1,168 components into one object. It established an enduring AP strategy: technical density becomes cultural authority when the mechanism can be narrated as the limit of what a generation knows how to make.

II Royal Oak: when steel became an argument

The 1972 Royal Oak: Gérald Genta's 39 mm steel sports watch overturned the hierarchy between precious material and precious labour. Courtesy Audemars Piguet Heritage.

The Royal Oak, launched in 1972 from Gérald Genta's design, remains Audemars Piguet's central act of cultural engineering. Its 39-millimetre body was large for the period; the octagonal bezel, eight visible screws, integrated bracelet and patterned dial refused the discreet codes of traditional luxury. Most provocatively, it was executed in hand-finished stainless steel and positioned with the seriousness of gold.

This was not the elevation of cheap matter through marketing alone. Steel is unforgiving: alternating satin-brushed planes and polished bevels must remain exact across the case and every articulated bracelet link. The design makes finishing structural. Light travels across the watch and reveals any broken edge. Craft is no longer hidden inside the mechanism; it becomes the surface language.

Royal Oak's great invention was conceptual. It separated preciousness from raw material and attached it to design, labour and controlled difficulty. The visible screw did not pretend the object had descended intact from heaven. It made assembly part of the image. Industrial signs became luxury because they were executed with jeweller-like discipline.

Finishing is not decoration

A movement can function before it is beautifully finished. Anglage, black polishing, circular graining and Geneva stripes do not necessarily make it keep better time. Their purpose is epistemic as much as aesthetic: they expose the maker's control over surfaces at a scale where a fraction of a millimetre changes the reflection.

Anglage turns a sharp machined edge into an even, gleaming bevel. Interior angles are particularly revealing because a rotating industrial tool cannot form them cleanly; they must be approached by hand. Black polishing produces a plane so flat that it alternates between mirror brightness and apparent blackness according to the angle of light. The eye reads precision through behaviour, not ornament.

This is why transparent casebacks matter. They transform labour once reserved for a watchmaker's bench into a spectacle for the owner. The movement is no longer only an engine. It is an exhibition whose smallest surfaces carry the proof of time spent.

III

The danger of becoming your own icon

An icon solves recognition and creates another problem: repetition. The Royal Oak silhouette is so legible that colour, complication, ceramic and celebrity collaboration can be placed inside it almost indefinitely. Commercially, this is extraordinary. Culturally, it risks reducing innovation to variations on a secure outline.

Audemars Piguet's identity is therefore caught between dependence and escape. The brand must protect the object that made contemporary haute horlogerie possible while demonstrating that its imagination is larger than one octagon. The new Atelier des Établisseurs is the clearest attempt in years to reopen that space.

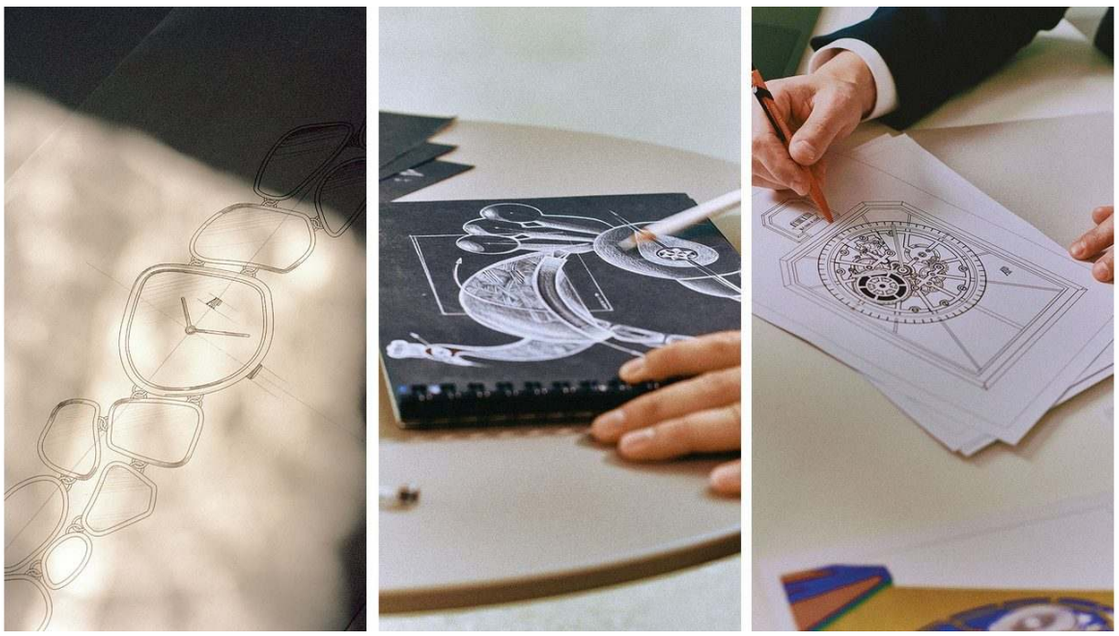
The calendar that remembers February

A perpetual calendar is a miniature model of an irregular human convention. It must distinguish 30-day months, 31-day months and February, then insert a leap day every four years without ordinary manual correction. In 1955 Audemars Piguet introduced the first wristwatch perpetual calendar to display the leap-year cycle, turning hidden calculation into readable information.

The complication is philosophically strange. The mechanism does not measure an astronomical truth directly; it mechanically remembers a calendar assembled through centuries of political and religious adjustment. A perpetual calendar is therefore a machine that performs culture as though culture were nature.

This distinction clarifies why watchmaking belongs in an art journal. Its highest achievements are not simply accurate. They materialise abstract systems – calendars, celestial cycles, elapsed intervals, musical sequences – and force them to coexist inside a wearable volume.

IV 2026: the return of the établisseur



The three inaugural Établisseurs creations – Galets, Peacock and Nomade – bring independent specialists back into a named network of collective authorship. Courtesy Audemars Piguet.

Before the vertically integrated manufacture became the dominant ideal, Swiss watchmaking depended on *établissage*: a network of specialised workshops coordinated by an établisseur. One maker produced an escapement, another a case, another a dial; the finished object was not the output of a single factory but the orchestration of distributed intelligence.

In 2026 Audemars Piguet revived that model inside the Musée Atelier at Le Brassus. The Atelier des Établisseurs connects the manufacture's watchmakers with independent engravers, enamel specialists, skeletonisers, gem-setters, lapidaries, designers and precision engineers. The radical gesture is not nostalgia. It is credit: the principal artisans behind each object are named.

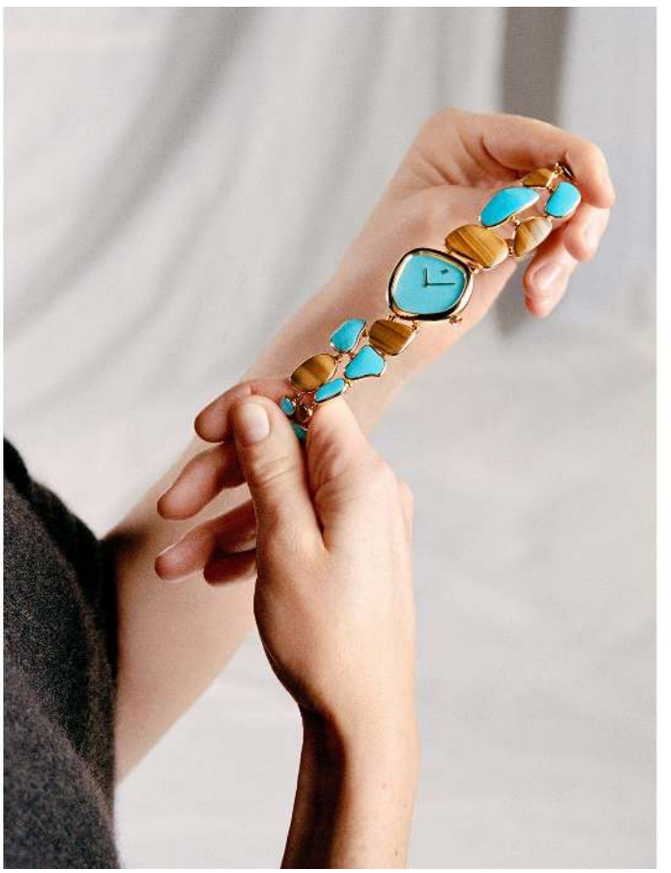
That change matters because luxury usually performs collective labour as singular brand authorship. Hundreds of hands disappear beneath a logo. By restoring names to the network, AP moves closer to the credit structures of film, architecture and contemporary art – fields in which authorship remains unequal, but collaboration can at least become visible.

Calibre 3098: engineering an asymmetry

The Galets case is not a conventional round housing given a decorative outline. Its asymmetry obliges the calibre to answer the case. Calibre 3098 was developed from the historical 3090 architecture and reshaped so that movement, case and stone composition share the same off-centre logic.

A balance oscillates at one end of this miniature landscape while bridges distribute support across the available volume. Hand-grained surfaces and chamfered edges make the movement legible without forcing it into bilateral symmetry. The achievement is integration: engineering does not correct the designer after the fact; it participates in the form.

V Galets: nature disciplined without becoming uniform



Audemars Piguet, Établisseurs Galets, presented in 2026. Natural stones turn the watch into a singular composition rather than a repeatable industrial surface. Courtesy Audemars Piguet.

Établisseurs Galets uses turquoise and tiger's eye for its dial and bracelet links. Each stone carries veining, density and colour that cannot be perfectly repeated. Its pebble-like geometry refers to the shores of the Lac de Joux, but the important fact is technical: irregular mineral matter must be cut into an exact wearable system.

The watch stages a negotiation between uniqueness and standard. Calibre 3098 is a contemporary movement developed for the piece; the asymmetric case and sapphire crystals require precise repeatability. Yet each arrangement of stone refuses total equivalence. Nature supplies difference, while craft gives difference a durable frame.

This is the opposite of merely decorating a familiar watch with an exotic dial. The oval case, the curved movement and the stone-set bracelet share one syntax. Material does not illustrate a story added by marketing. It changes the geometry of the object.

VI

Peacock: a secret watch and the theatre of disclosure

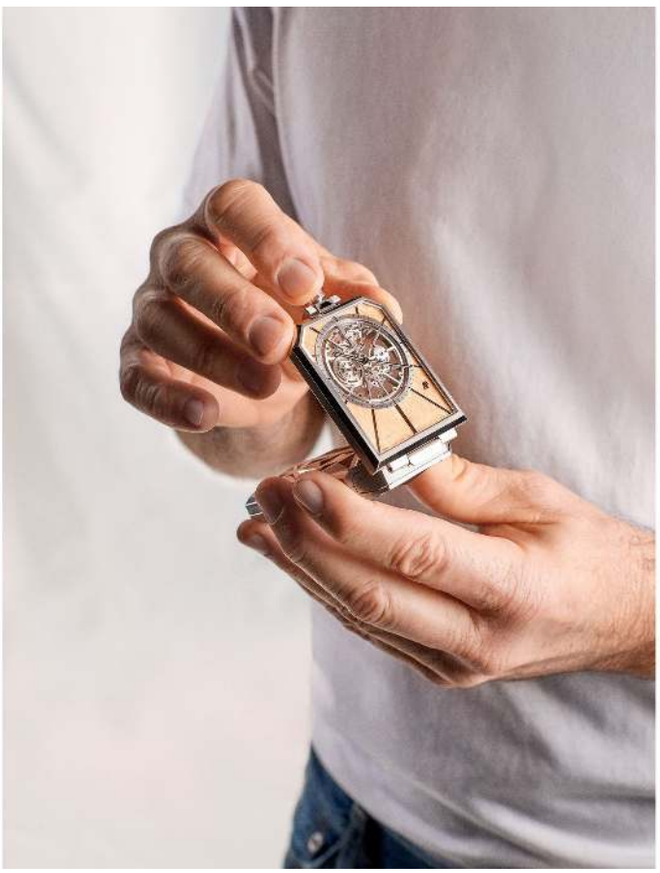
Établisseurs Peacock revives the nineteenth-century secret watch: an engraved and enamelled creature whose display appears through movement. Courtesy Audemars Piguet.

Établisseurs Peacock belongs to the history of the secret watch, in which the time display is concealed within a jewel. Designer Kenan Geraud's peacock opens into colour; engraved wings, translucent enamel and articulated gold links transform checking the hour into a small performance.

The object refuses modern watchmaking's obsession with instant legibility. Time must be revealed. That delay is not an inconvenience accidentally preserved from the nineteenth century; it is the work's central choreography. The wearer activates the piece and momentarily becomes its performer.

Here the boundary between jewellery, automaton and watch collapses. Function remains, but it has been deliberately subordinated to encounter. One does not glance at Peacock. One enters its sequence.

VII Nomade: time leaves the wrist



Établisseurs Nomade can move between pocket watch and table object. Its identity changes with its support and situation. Courtesy Audemars Piguet.

Établisseurs Nomade can operate as a pocket watch or a small table clock. This mobility recalls the long history before the wrist became time's default address. It also shifts the object from accessory to sculpture: placed upright, it occupies a room and establishes a relationship with architecture.

Its skeletonised calibre exposes depth rather than merely removing material for visual drama. Bridges, voids and hand-finished edges compose a mechanical interior that changes with viewpoint. The watch does not carry a picture; the movement is the picture, and its subject is organised energy.

One watchmaker, one chain of responsibility

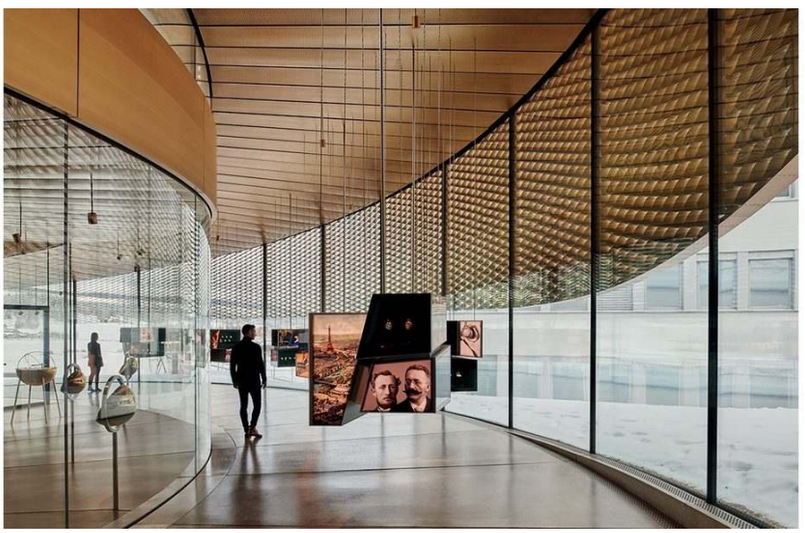
Each Établisseurs piece is assembled and adjusted by one master watchmaker. That continuity differs from a production line in which specialised operations pass anonymously from station to station. A single maker follows the behaviour of the movement through assembly, regulation and casing, accumulating knowledge of one object's particular resistances.

Individual responsibility does not mean solitary creation. Galets depends on gemmologist and lapidary Mario Senape, specialist case makers, jewellers and movement constructors; Peacock brings together designer Kenan Geraud, engravers, enameller Vanessa

Lecci and goldsmiths; Nomade requires stone cutting, skeletonisation and minute case tolerances. The single watchmaker is the final integrator of a visibly plural authorship.

The model resembles an orchestra more than the mythology of the lone artist. Specialisation increases difference, while coordination prevents difference from becoming noise. The brand's meaningful role is not to claim every gesture as its own but to sustain the conditions under which the gestures can meet.

VIII A museum shaped like a mainspring



The Musée Atelier's spiral route tightens and releases like a watch spring. Its 470-ton roof is carried by 108 curved structural-glass panels. Courtesy Musée Atelier Audemars Piguet.

Audemars Piguet's most complete self-portrait is not a watch but a building. BIG's glass spiral connects the founders' 1868 house to the contemporary Musée Atelier. Visitors move clockwise toward the centre and unwind in the opposite direction, following a path modelled on a coiled spring.

The metaphor is unusually literal, yet the engineering prevents it from becoming stage scenery. A 470-ton steel roof is held by 108 unique curved glass panes, some composed of seven layers and reaching twelve centimetres in thickness. Structure performs the same trick as haute horlogerie: great force appears as precision, and precision appears as lightness.

Musée Atelier Audemars Piguet at Le Brassus links the historical workshop to BIG's glass spiral. Courtesy Musée Atelier Audemars Piguet.

Inside, approximately 300 watches sit beside live workshops for restoration, métiers d'art and grandes complications. The museum does not merely preserve completed masterpieces; it displays labour in progress. Brand history becomes present tense.

Architecture as a regulating mechanism

The Musée Atelier's glass does structural and environmental work simultaneously. Curved panels carry the roof, admit the valley as a continuous horizon and are screened by a brass mesh that moderates light and temperature. The grass-covered steel roof adds thermal mass and manages rainwater. The apparently immaterial spiral is, in fact, a calibrated environmental machine.

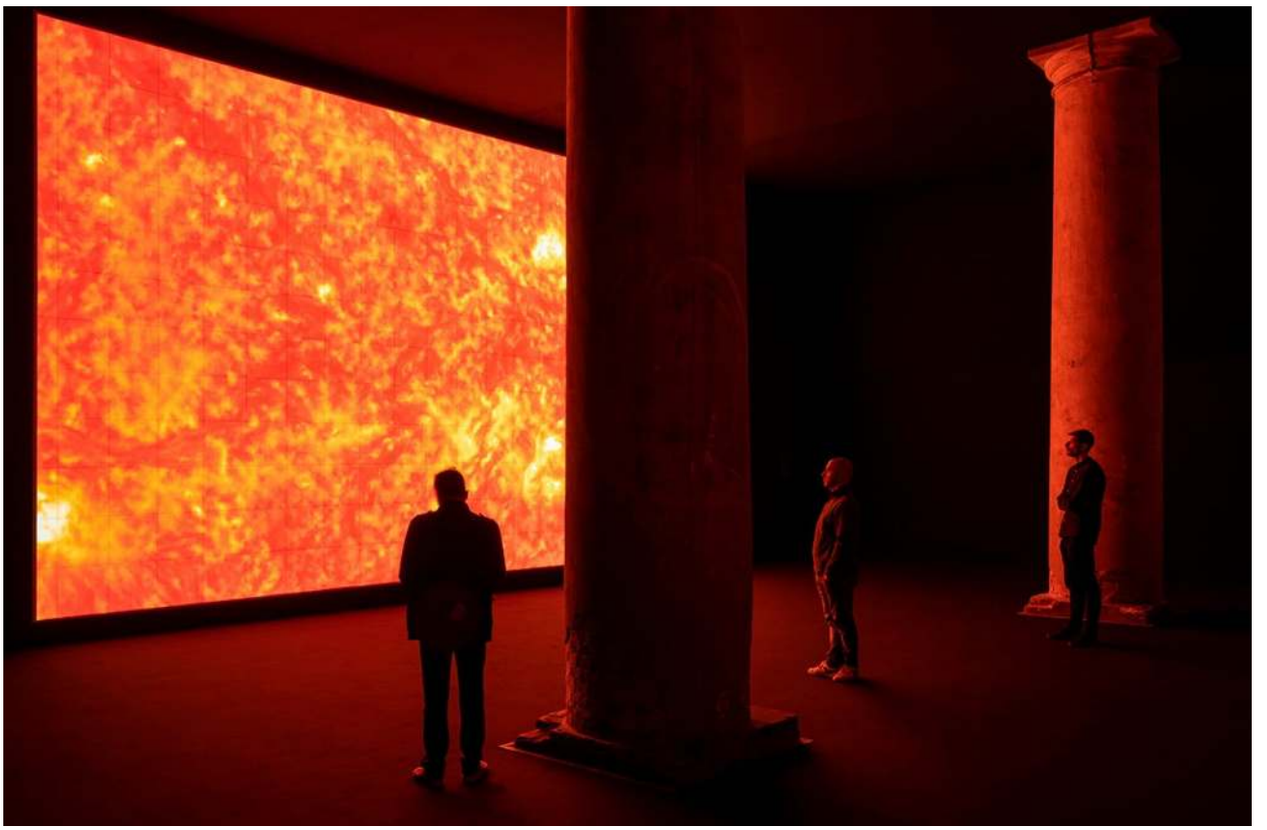
Its exhibition route also manages narrative energy. Scenographer ATELIER BRÜCKNER conceived the displays as a musical score with interludes, crescendos and a climax around the Universelle. Time is not represented by a straight chronology alone. It is paced through compression, release and recurrence.

IX

When a brand becomes a curator

Audemars Piguet Contemporary has commissioned international artists since 2012. Crucially, the resulting works belong to the artists and enter their own practices rather than a corporate collection. Two in-house curators support projects from inception to exhibition, often with partner institutions.

The programme's artists – including Cao Fei, Ryoji Ikeda, Alexandra Pirici, Tomás Saraceno, Sallisa Rosa, Yu Ji and others – are not selected to decorate boutiques with images of watches. Their works address data, ecology, performance, memory, sound and unstable material systems. The relationship to the brand is structural rather than iconographic: sustained production, technical ambition and the measurement of change.



Ryoji Ikeda's data-based practice turns measurement into an overwhelming field of perception. Audemars Piguet Contemporary commissioned works from his data-verse project. Courtesy the artist and Audemars Piguet Contemporary.

X

Ryoji Ikeda: precision beyond comprehension

Ryoji Ikeda works with numerical data at scales the senses cannot assimilate. Points, frequencies and streams are subjected to extreme formal precision, yet the result is not clarity. It is sublimity: knowledge becomes so dense that it is experienced as light, vibration and vertigo.

The affinity with watchmaking is exact and dangerous. Both fields begin with measurement; both convert systems into perceptual form. But Ikeda's work also reveals measurement's limit. More data does not necessarily produce more understanding. A perfect instrument can confront us with our inability to read the world it quantifies.

XI

Alexandra Pirici: the body as an unstable archive

Alexandra Pirici's practice seems to contradict the luxury watch. A watch promises a lasting object; performance persists through bodies, memory and reenactment. Pirici makes that opposition productive. Her living formations ask whether an archive can exist without freezing what it preserves.

For a company whose economic authority depends on durable objects and traceable provenance, supporting work that cannot be possessed in the same way is culturally significant. It allows the patronage programme to test a form of value that does not sit

comfortably in a safe.

XII Yu Ji: matter remembers pressure

Yu Ji's sculpture brings the argument back to matter. Stone, concrete, metal and organic forms appear not as passive supplies but as substances with histories of pressure, extraction and weathering. Time is registered through fracture and accretion rather than hands on a dial.

This expands the brand's preferred notion of craftsmanship. A perfectly finished watch tends to erase the violence of transformation: ore becomes alloy, stone becomes a component, abrasive labour becomes immaculate surface. Contemporary art can restore resistance to matter and ask what elegance has edited out.

What the commissions actually change

The strongest AP Contemporary projects do not translate watch components into enlarged sculpture. Ryoji Ikeda turns datasets into audiovisual environments whose precision exceeds comprehension. Alexandra Pirici uses living bodies to question whether memory requires an object. Yu Ji works with erosion and material fatigue. These practices complicate the brand's own promises of permanence, mastery and possession.

Because the commissioned works remain the artists' property, the programme avoids one common form of corporate extraction: funding a work and absorbing it permanently into a branded collection. The arrangement still produces cultural capital for AP, but it also permits the artwork to develop an institutional life beyond its sponsor.

That distinction is more consequential than visual alignment. Patronage becomes credible when it finances difference rather than demanding resemblance.

XIII Patronage is never innocent

No luxury-funded art programme exists outside marketing. Cultural association transfers prestige; Art Basel access produces clients; the language of experimentation refreshes a heritage brand. Pretending otherwise would make criticism useless.

But commercial motive does not cancel cultural consequence. The relevant questions are more exact: Does the artist retain ownership? Is the work allowed to resist the sponsor's image? Are curatorial decisions sustained beyond a campaign cycle? Does funding create work that would not otherwise exist? AP's model earns attention because its commissions remain with artists and travel through institutions rather than functioning only as branded décor.

XIV Scarcity, price and the aesthetics of waiting

The luxury watch market converts restricted supply into social energy. Waiting lists, allocation systems and auction premiums make access part of the object. Time is not only displayed by the watch; it is imposed on the buyer. Desire is administered through

delay.

The ultra-limited Établisseurs pieces intensify that economy, but they also expose its material basis. Each watch takes weeks and depends on specialists whose capacity cannot be scaled without changing the work. Scarcity can be manufactured as strategy, yet it can also be the honest consequence of refusing industrial acceleration. The two forms are often entangled.

The secondary market and the second clock

A watch has a second clock running beside its movement: the market. Auction results, discontinued references, condition reports and provenance convert ownership history into price. Patina can be valued as evidence of time, while replacement parts may reduce value even when they improve function. Collectors do not simply want an old object; they want continuity that can be authenticated.

This produces a paradox. The manufacture promises service over generations, but intervention can erase the very traces the market rewards. Restoration must decide which time to preserve: the ideal form intended by the maker or the accumulated life carried by the object. The Musée Atelier's restoration workshop sits precisely inside that ethical problem.

The best watch conservation does not return every surface to youth. It distinguishes damage from history, maintaining mechanical life without manufacturing a false past.

XV

What a brand can learn from art

Brands usually approach art hoping that art will make them appear imaginative. The more interesting possibility runs in the opposite direction: art can teach a company to tolerate outcomes it does not fully control. A commissioned work that remains recognisably the artist's – not an illustration of corporate values – is evidence of that tolerance.

The Atelier des Établisseurs applies the same lesson internally. Naming independent makers distributes credit and allows their differences to enter the object. The brand remains the organiser and beneficiary, but authorship becomes a network rather than a sealed signature.

A mechanical watch does not defeat time. It gives time a body – and then asks us to decide whose labour, memory and desire that body contains.

XVI

Verdict

Audemars Piguet is most persuasive when it stops insisting that watchmaking simply is art and instead reveals the conditions under which the comparison becomes meaningful: conceptual risk, exacting form, embodied labour, material intelligence, historical

self-criticism and authorship that exceeds a logo.

Royal Oak made steel precious by making workmanship visible. The Musée Atelier turned the spring into architecture. Audemars Piguet Contemporary moved patronage toward artist-owned commissions. Now the Atelier des Établisseurs brings individual makers back into the story of the manufactured object. Together these projects propose a demanding definition of luxury: not expense alone, but time made legible as collective human attention. ■

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FURTHER

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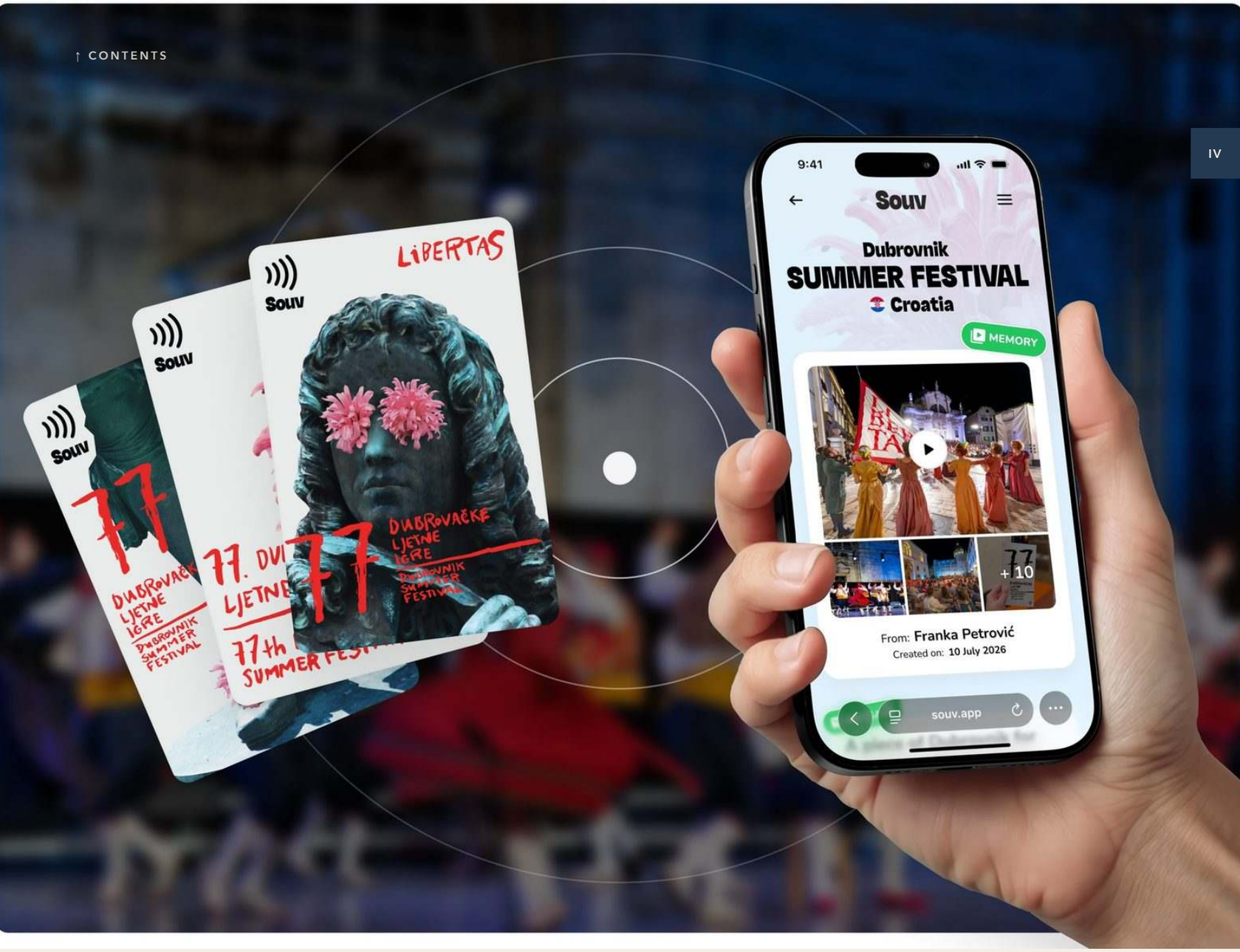
Audemars Piguet Contemporary – official programme	audemarspiguet.com/en/about/audemars-piguet-contemporary
Birth of an Icon: Royal Oak – AP Chronicles	apchronicles.audemarspiguet.com/en/article/birth-of-an-icon
The Architecture – Musée Atelier Audemars Piguet	museeatelier.audemarspiguet.com/en/about/tradition-forward-thinking.html



FEATURE AUG 25, 2026

Souv: The Souvenir That Doesn't Forget

Matej Petrić and Antonio Šeparović on turning an ordinary fridge magnet into the entrance to a traveler's own photos, why nobody actually wants to buy NFC technology, and what it took to put a laser engraver in a start-up that started as two friends and a third coffee in Zagreb.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & SOUV

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Matej Petrić and Antonio Šeparović on turning an ordinary fridge magnet into the entrance to a traveler's own photos, why nobody actually wants to buy NFC technology, and what it took to put a laser engraver in a startup that started as two friends and a third coffee in Zagreb.

Every souvenir shop sells the same promise: a small object that will remind you, years later, that you were somewhere. A magnet does this job better than almost anything else, which is exactly the problem. It remembers the fact of the trip and forgets everything that made the trip worth remembering – who you were laughing with on the ferry, what the light looked like on the last night, the wrong turn that became the best hour of the week. That richer material does not disappear. It is on your phone, buried a few thousand photographs deep, in the part of the camera roll nobody scrolls back to.

Souv, a startup out of Zagreb, was built to close exactly that gap. Tap a physical card or magnet with your phone – no app to install – and it opens a personal space tied to that specific place and trip: your own photographs, a short recap video, a note for later. The object stays on the fridge, doing what a souvenir has always done. The memory it points to stays reachable, which is the part that used to get lost.

The company started with two friends at university. Since a first pilot at a cycling event on the island of Brač, Souv has spread along the Croatian coast, into museum shops and chain retail, and has been named a finalist in the Digital Communication Design category of Zagreb Design Week 2026, where it will show at the Academy of Fine Arts this September.

We spoke with co-founders Matej Petrić and Antonio Šeparović about the third coffee in Zagreb that started it, the version of the idea they were sure would work and had to throw out anyway, and what it actually took to put colour-engraved stainless steel into production.

Take us back to the very beginning – was there a specific trip, a specific place, or a specific frustration that actually sparked the idea for Souv? Describe that moment in detail – where you were, what you were trying to do, and what wasn't working.

The funny thing is that Souv was not born on a beach, in an airport, or during some particularly dramatic trip. It started over coffee in Zagreb.

Antonio and I were sitting in WESPA, already on what he remembers as our third coffee, talking about how many photographs we take when we travel and how rarely we actually return to them afterwards. At the same time, our homes were full of physical reminders of places we had visited, especially magnets. The strange thing was that the physical object survived, while the actual experience was buried somewhere among thousands of photographs on a phone.

That disconnect became the starting point. We asked a very simple question: what if the physical souvenir could somehow carry the digital memories with it?

At first it sounded almost obvious. Tap a souvenir, open your photographs, add something about the place. Then we started asking the harder questions: what should the physical object actually be, why would someone buy it, how do you make the technology invisible, and how do you make something digital feel like a real keepsake rather than another app?

Who was on the founding team, and how did you split the early work between you? Looking back, whose idea ended up shaping the product the most, and did that person's role change once the company grew?

Souv was founded by the two of us, Matej Petrić and Antonio Šeparović. We were friends and university colleagues before becoming business partners, and both of us came from software and digital product backgrounds. That meant the early division of work was much less clean than "one technical founder and one business founder." In the beginning, both of us were doing whatever the product needed.

I also would not honestly attribute Souv to one person's idea. The initial question came out of a conversation between us, and the product was shaped by iteration afterwards. If one principle influenced the product more than anything else, it was something we learned during testing: people are not interested in buying NFC technology.

They are interested in preserving an experience. Once we understood that, the technology became quieter and the memory became the centre of the product.

What did the very first version of Souv actually look like – the card, the app, the whole experience? Which parts of that first version survived into what's sold in stores today, and which parts got thrown out entirely, maybe even something you were sure would work?

The first versions were much closer to proofs of concept than to the Souv you can buy today. The basic idea was already there: a physical card or magnet with an NFC or QR connection that opened a digital space associated with that particular object. We needed to prove that the connection between an object on your desk or refrigerator and a personal digital memory could feel natural.

What survived is actually the most fundamental part of the idea. You still tap a physical object, nothing needs to be downloaded, and that object becomes the entrance to your own photographs, videos, notes and journey.

Almost everything around that core became more refined. The onboarding became simpler, the digital experience became much less technology-led, and the physical product developed into two very different expressions: an accessible printed Eco version and a Premium object made from brushed stainless steel with colour laser engraving.

One thing we initially overestimated was the "wow" of the technology itself. We assumed tapping an object with a phone would be the part people found most interesting. It is useful, but it is not the reason they care. The important moment is when they understand what is on the other side of the tap. That changed the way we designed and explained the entire product.

Early sketches, a "Souvenirs with superpowers" flyer and a store display stand. Courtesy Souv

Walk us through the milestones that mattered most along the way – the first store, the first city outside your home base, Zagreb Design Week. For each one, what actually changed afterward – and was there a moment that felt bigger from the outside than it actually was on the inside, or the reverse?

There were several milestones, but they mattered for very different reasons.

The first time Souv was used in a real environment was particularly important. At the Uvati Vitar cycling event on Brač, participants received a personalised Souv as part of the event experience. Around 70% of the distributed Souvs were activated and filled with personal memories, and almost one in five participants shared the experience. The numbers were based on a small pilot, but internally that moment was much bigger than a press article or presentation because strangers were finally using the product without us standing next to them explaining it.

The first real-world use of Souv: a personalised card handed out at the Uvati Vitar cycling event on Brač. Courtesy Souv

The first retail location in Zagreb was another psychological shift. Until then Souv was something we had designed, tested and presented. Putting it into an actual shop meant a person who had never met us could see it on a shelf, understand it and decide whether it deserved their money.

There was not really one neat “second city” afterwards. The rollout moved quite quickly from Zagreb towards the coast, with Souv appearing across places including Split, Zadar, Dubrovnik, Šibenik, Pula, Poreč, Korčula and Brač. By August, the retail network included independent stores, museum locations and chain retail locations.

And now there is Zagreb Design Week. Souv has been selected as a finalist in the 2026 Digital Communication Design and Interaction Design category and will be exhibited at the Academy of Fine Arts from 15 to 20 September. That exhibition is still ahead of us, so we cannot pretend to know what it will change yet. But the selection itself means a lot because it recognises Souv not only as a tourism startup, but as a piece of interaction and communication design.

Interestingly, some of the moments that looked small from the outside, like watching people use Souv at the first event, felt enormous internally. Media exposure sometimes works the other way around: it looks like a major milestone publicly, while inside the company you are still thinking about the next production batch, a software bug or whether the display in a store is positioned correctly.

You call it 'not your typical souvenir.' Was there a particular souvenir – one you personally owned, bought, or were given – that you found genuinely disappointing, and did that specific object shape what Souv became?

There was not one terrible souvenir that made us say, “we have to fix this industry.”

It was almost the opposite. We actually like souvenirs, and particularly magnets, which is why the magnet became our first format. They work remarkably well as physical triggers. You see one on the refrigerator and immediately remember Dubrovnik, Paris or the island you visited five years ago.

The disappointment was that the object could only take you so far. It could tell you, “I was there,” but not what happened there, who you were travelling with, what made you laugh, or what the place actually felt like.

Meanwhile, all of that richer material existed. It was simply sitting somewhere on the 23,000-photo timeline of a phone.

So the object that influenced Souv was not one particularly bad souvenir. It was probably the very ordinary magnet that does its job quite well, placed next to a phone that contains the much better story but almost never tells it again. We wanted to connect those two things.

Each city – Zagreb, Dubrovnik, Split, Zadar, Brač, Korčula – has its own visual identity. Walk through how you actually decide what a new city's card should look and feel like, and has a local ever told you that you got their city wrong?

We try not to start with the question, “Which landmark should we put on this card?”

We start with what makes the place recognisable to the people who actually know it. That includes architecture and landmarks, of course, but also colour, local visual codes, landscape, small details, stories and the way the destination presents itself. Then we reduce that material into something that can work as an object rather than trying to fit an entire tourist brochure onto a magnet.

The design also has to survive the material. Something that looks beautiful on a screen may behave completely differently when UV printed on the Eco version or colour engraved into stainless steel, so the process moves continuously between visual design and physical testing.

Our art director Antonija has been central to developing that visual language, while destination partners give us local feedback before editions go into production.

And yes, locals have challenged details. Usually it is not a dramatic “you completely misunderstood our city” moment, but smaller corrections are extremely valuable. A motif can be technically recognisable and still feel wrong to someone who sees that place every day.

We would much rather have that conversation during development than produce a beautifully designed object that locals themselves do not believe represents them.

The visual language of a Souv card starts with what locals recognise, not with the nearest landmark. Courtesy Souv

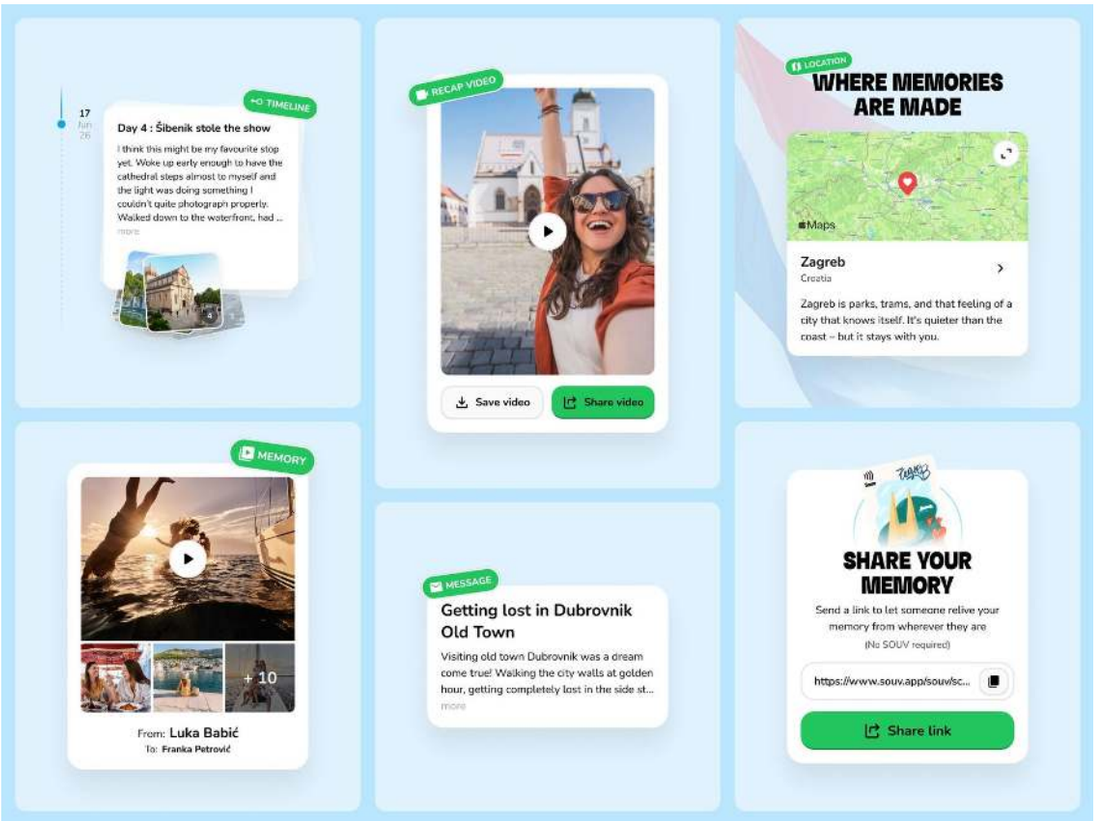
Tap. Save. Relive your trip. Describe, step by step, what actually happens in the seconds right after someone taps a card for the first time – and then what typically happens weeks or months later, once they're back home. Do you know of a moment when it genuinely surprised or moved someone?

The first tap is deliberately simple.

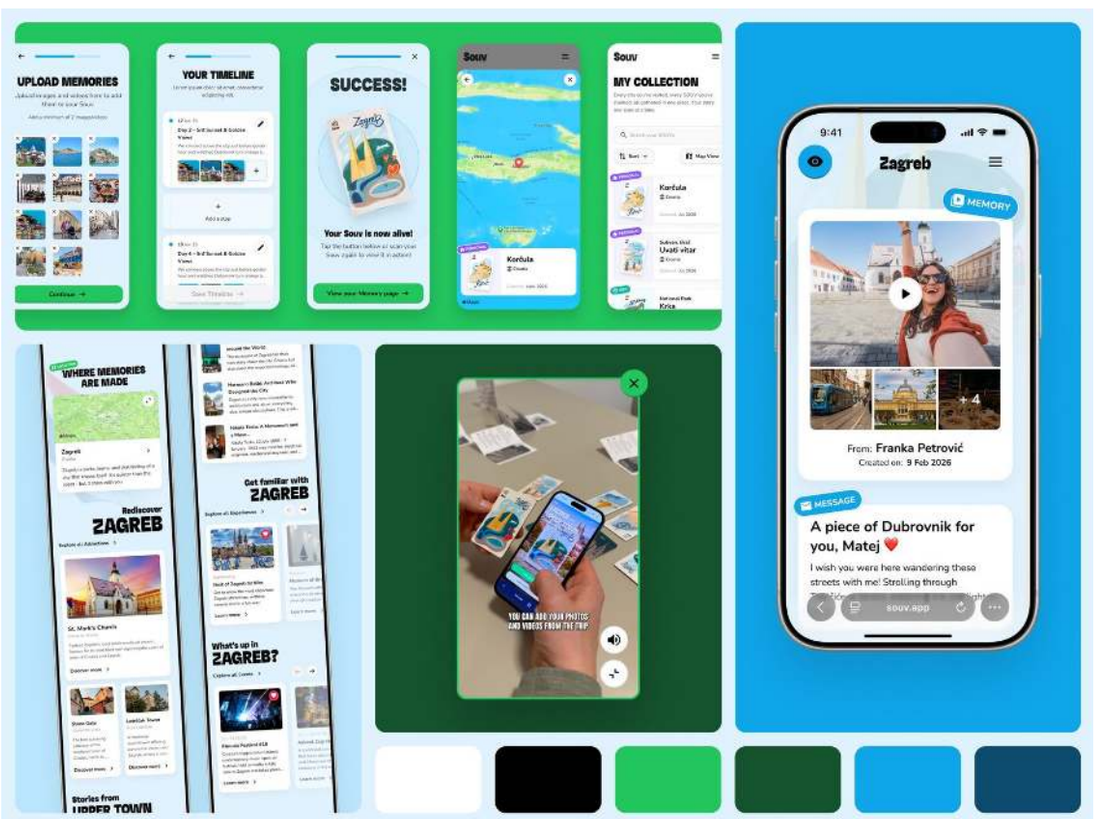
You touch the Souv with an NFC-enabled phone, or scan the QR code on the back. The experience opens directly in the browser, so there is no app to install. On the first visit, you sign in, choose whether you are keeping the Souv for yourself or preparing it as a gift, and claim that particular Souv. From there you can add your first photographs, videos or message.

Once it has been claimed, it becomes your personal memory space. You can organise the journey through a timeline, continue adding material, create a recap video and explore selected content connected to the destination.

The more interesting part happens later. Weeks, months or even years after the trip, the physical object is still there. You see it on your desk or refrigerator and tap it again. Instead of opening a generic destination page, you return to your own photographs and your own version of that place.



Inside the tap: a trip timeline, shared memories and the map of where a Souv was made. Courtesy Souv



Early interface work for the claiming flow and the personal collection screen. Courtesy Souv

The next question is about the one part of the product that could not be solved by iterating on the app: a physical object, made in batches, that has to look the same the five-hundredth time as it did the first.

What's been the hardest part of building Souv so far? Pick one concrete example – a specific technical problem, a specific design decision, or a specific logistical headache – and walk through how you actually solved it, including anything you tried first that failed.

One very concrete example is the Premium stainless-steel Souv.

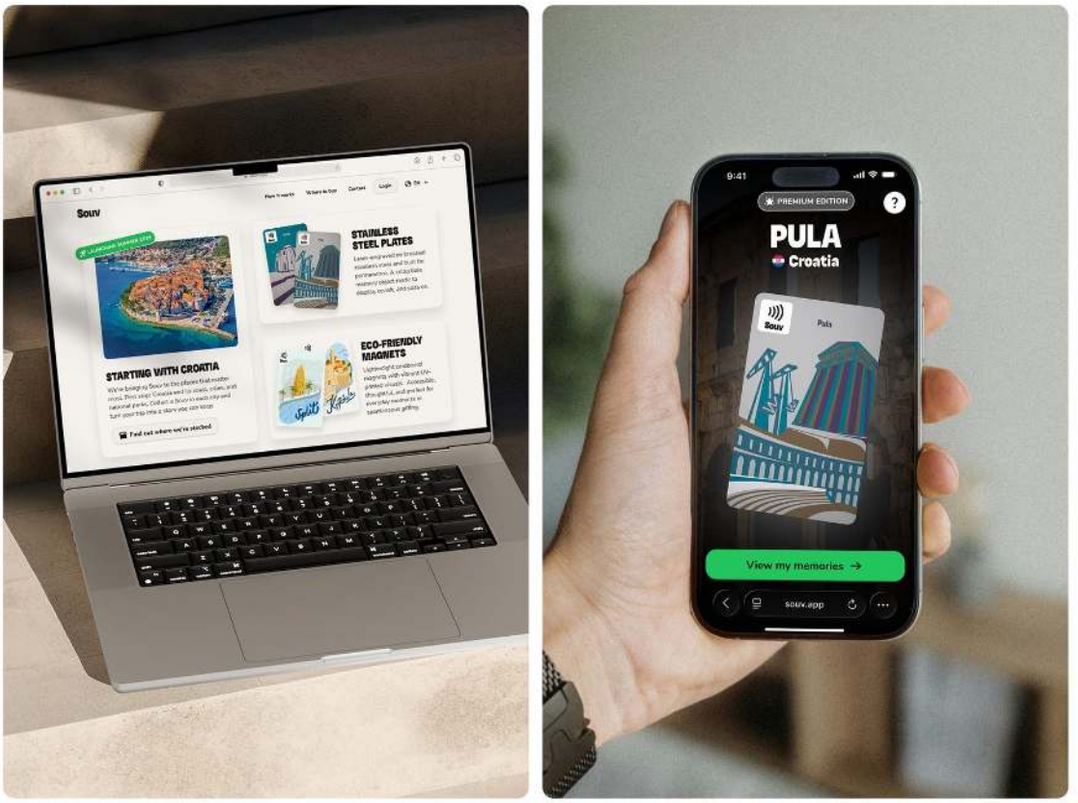
On paper, the idea sounded simple: take stainless steel and engrave the destination artwork in colour. In reality, producing that object consistently became one of the hardest parts of the project.

We tested different materials, engraving parameters, finishes, production speeds and ways of preparing the artwork. The difficulty was not producing one beautiful sample. You can spend an unreasonable amount of time making one piece look good. The real problem is creating the fiftieth or the five-hundredth piece with the same quality, within a production time and cost that makes sense for a retail product.

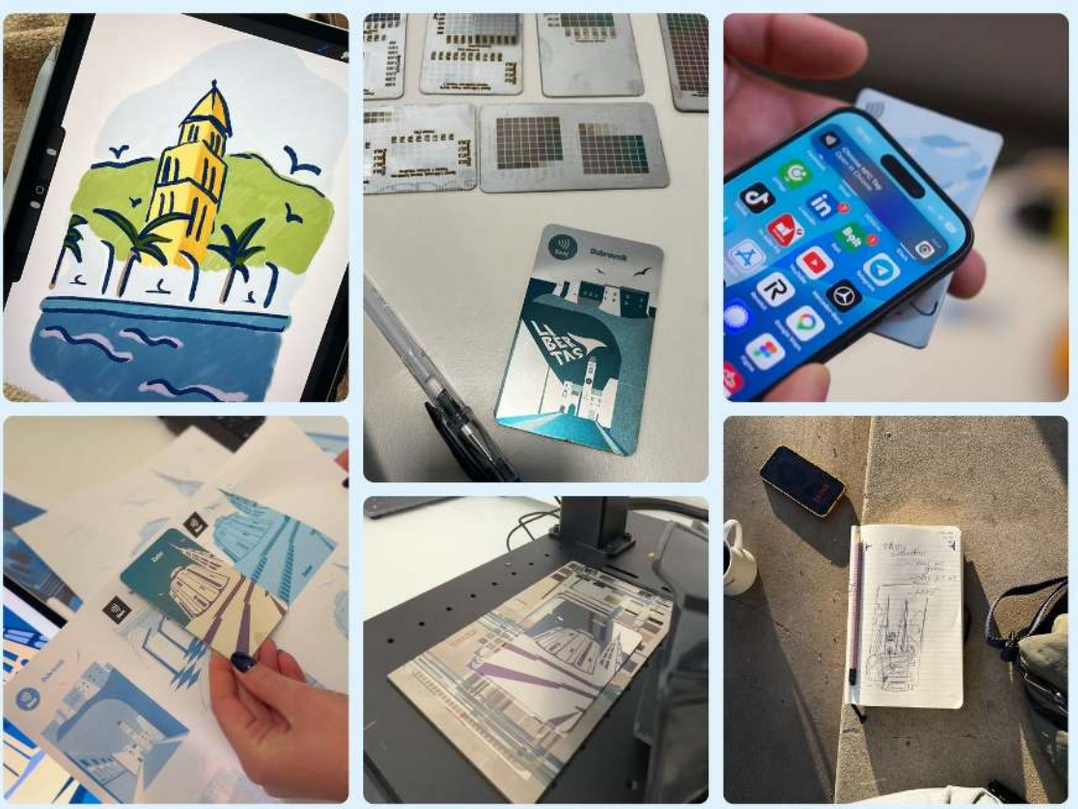
We repeatedly ran into trade-offs between visual quality, durability, repeatability and speed. Eventually we realised that we would not get the level of control we wanted if we treated production as a completely external black box.

So we brought a significant part of the process in-house and built our own small production setup in Zagreb. That was not part of the original startup plan. We came from software. Suddenly we were learning about stainless steel, lasers, material tolerances, finishing and production workflows.

In retrospect, that difficulty improved Souv. We now understand the physical object at a much deeper level because we were forced to learn how to make it ourselves.



The Premium edition: colour laser engraving on brushed stainless steel. Courtesy Souv



An early version of the Souv product, from city artwork to the engraving bench. Courtesy Souv

The last question is about scale, and the answer turns out to be less about new cities than about what Souv actually is: an object, or a layer that any object could carry.

Where do you see Souv a few years from now? Is it mainly more cities and countries, a specific new feature you're already working on, or something about the product itself you'd genuinely want to change if you could start over?

A few years from now, we would like Souv to be much bigger than a collection of Croatian city magnets.

Croatia is the right place for us to prove the model because tourism is such an important part of everyday life here, but the underlying behaviour is universal. People travel, take hundreds of photographs, buy something to remember the trip and then rarely return to most of the digital material they created.

So international expansion is definitely part of the ambition, but the more important expansion is from a single product into a platform.

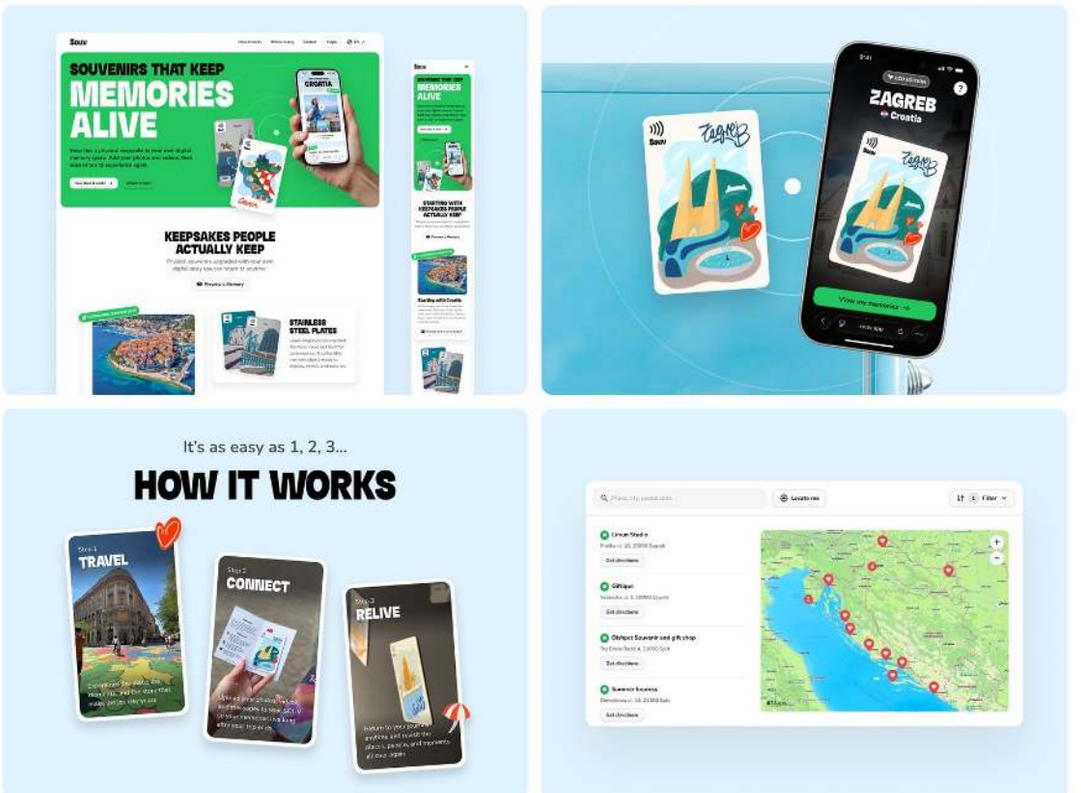
That means continuing to develop our own collectible Souv objects, but also allowing the Souv experience to live on other physical products. One direction we are already developing is a small NFC/QR Souv layer that can be integrated into an existing souvenir or its packaging. A ceramic object, book, museum product or locally made gift would not have to become "a Souv product"; it could keep its existing identity while gaining the personal memory experience behind it.

The digital side will keep growing as well: richer ways of organising journeys, gifting, collections, recap experiences and destination content that can evolve after the trip.

If we could start again, the biggest thing we would change is that we would begin with the emotional proposition much earlier and test real-world retail behaviour sooner.

In the beginning we spent too much time thinking like technologists. Today we know that the NFC, QR code and software should almost disappear.

The product is not really about tapping something with your phone. It is about giving an experience a physical place to live. ■



Souvenirs that keep memories alive: travel, connect, relive. Courtesy Souv

INTERVIEW AUG 25, 2026

Museo Nivola: A Museum, a Village and the Memory They Share

Costantino Nivola left a Sardinian village of masons for New York, worked with Le Corbusier, Sert and Saarinen, and never stopped coming back. The team of his museum, on the hill above Orani, on where a museum ends and a village begins, on the method he left behind, and on what a monographic museum can still become.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & MUSEO NIVOLA

SECTION IV · INTERVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER & MUSEO NIVOLA

Costantino Nivola left a Sardinian village of masons for New York, worked with Le Corbusier, Sert and Saarinen, and never stopped coming back. The team of his museum, on the hill above Orani, on where a museum ends and a village begins, on the method he left behind, and on what a monographic museum can still become.

Orani is a village in the Barbagia, the mountainous heart of Sardinia. A road climbs up from the valley, the houses gather along the slope, and just above them, on the hillside, a low white building sits among olive trees and looks back down at the roofs. It is one of the most quietly beautiful small museums in Italy, and it belongs, in the fullest sense of the word, to the place it stands in.

Costantino Nivola was born here in 1911, the son of a mason, and learned the trade on his father's building sites before the ISIA in Monza and a job as a graphic designer for Olivetti in Milan. In 1939 he left for New York. He met Le Corbusier in 1946, wrapped the wall of the Olivetti showroom on Fifth Avenue in a sand-cast relief in 1954, taught at the Harvard Graduate School of Design at the invitation of Josep Lluís Sert, and spent three years filling Eero Saarinen's colleges at Yale with carved concrete. And he kept coming home. In 1953 he drew a plan to link every house in Orani with vine pergolas; in 1958 he covered the facade of the village church with a graffito and carried his sculptures out into the streets for three days, with the whole village taking part.

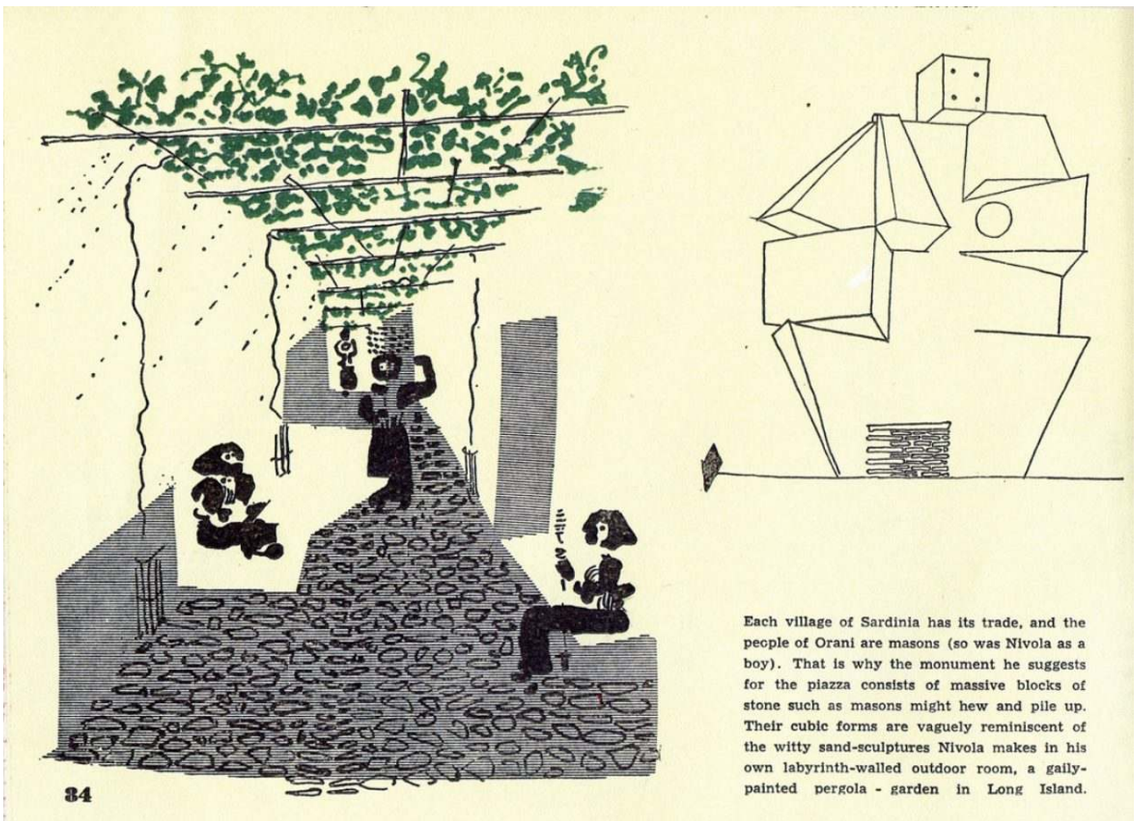
The museum that carries his name has inherited that generosity. It keeps its door open to the village, to contemporary artists, to schoolchildren and to researchers, and it does all of this with rare care and warmth. We are grateful to the team of the Museo Nivola for the time and thought they gave to our four questions: where the museum ends and Orani begins, what is still alive in Nivola's belief in the union of art and architecture, what a museum in an artist's birthplace can know, and what they hope the museum will become.

The path along the museum wall, Museo Nivola, Orani. Photo Cedric Dasesson. Courtesy Museo Nivola

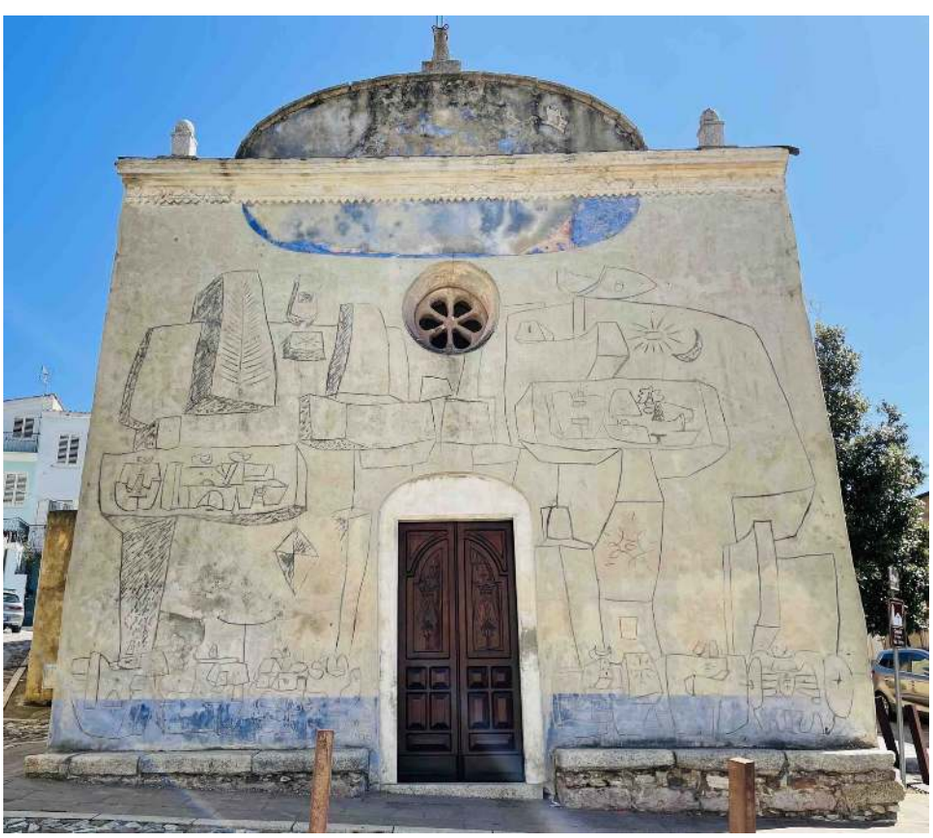
Where, in your view, does the Museo Nivola end and Orani begin? Can the village, its landscape and its inhabitants be considered a continuation of the museum space?

In a place like Orani, given its history and its nature, the border between museum and village is difficult to draw. The museum itself is born in a particular position: on the hill, immersed in the landscape and at the same time facing the slope up which the village climbs. Its architecture does not build a rupture with its context, but continually establishes relations with what surrounds it: the vegetation, the shape of the valley, the spring of Su Càntaru and, above all, the community.

This relation is deeper still if we think of Nivola's own work, because Orani is a presence that runs through all of his research and is evident in the materials, in his childhood memories, in the experience of his father the mason, in his conception of public space and of the relationship with the social life of a place. In the 1953 project *Pergola Village*, Nivola imagined connecting the houses of the village, ideally and physically, through vine pergolas, turning the streets into shared social space. In 1958, returning to Orani, he made the graffito on the facade of the church of Nostra Signora d'Itria and brought his sculptures directly into the streets, involving the inhabitants in an experience that goes entirely beyond the traditional model of the exhibition.



Pergola Village, Vined Orani, plate from Interiors, January 1953. Courtesy Museo Nivola



The church of Nostra Signora d'Itria, Orani, with the graffito Nivola made on its facade in 1958. Courtesy Museo Nivola

This is why we like to think that the Museo Nivola does not end at the threshold of the building: the village is not an extension of the museum in the sense of a musealisation of the territory, but rather a living interlocutor.

The challenge is precisely to prevent Orani from becoming a backdrop, or a kind of diffuse museum crystallised in the past. We are interested in continuing to build a relationship in which the museum is part of the life of the village and the village keeps entering the museum, through people, through memory, through educational activities, projects in public space and new forms of cultural production.

Nivola near the funeral monument to his mother and his brother Giuseppe, Orani, 1958. Photo C. Bavagnoli. Courtesy Museo Nivola

Nivola called himself a sculptor for architecture, and the phrase was not a modest one. It meant that the sculpture would not arrive after the building, like a piece of furniture.

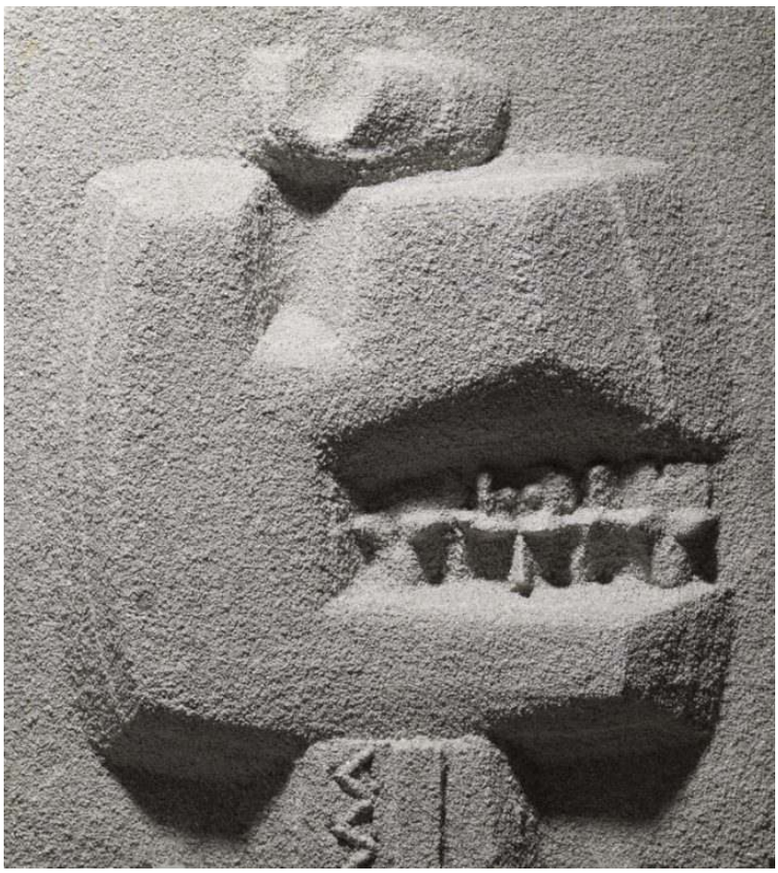
Nivola believed deeply in the integration of art and architecture. How current is that idea today, and what can it teach new generations of artists, architects and designers?

That is the great topicality of his thought. Today, perhaps, even more than when Nivola began working in this direction. For him, the integration of art and architecture did not simply mean placing a work inside a building or on its facade. It meant conceiving space, matter, function and the experience of whoever would inhabit that space all together. The famous total project.

Nivola worked with some of the great protagonists of modern architecture, trying to overcome the disciplinary separation between artist, architect and designer. His interest was directed at space as an overall experience. Sculpture could become wall, relief could become part of architecture, the courtyard a place of encounter. Even the urban plan was to be an instrument for strengthening social relations.

The Olivetti showroom on Fifth Avenue, New York, 1954. Photo H. Namuth. Courtesy Museo Nivola

Behind the idea of integration between the arts there is something wider still: a conception of art as an instrument capable of affecting the quality of collective life.



Relief for the Morse & Stiles colleges, Yale University, 1961, sandcast, concrete, 51 x 45 x 9 cm. Photo P. Pinna. Courtesy Museo Nivola

Nivola invites us to step out of categories that are too rigid. He invites us to ask for whom a space is designed, who will use it, what relations it will produce. At a moment when architecture, art and design are called to confront environmental and social questions and new ways of inhabiting, his interdisciplinary approach appears surprisingly contemporary.

It is not, of course, a matter of merely reproducing his forms and languages, but of inheriting his method: working through dialogue between disciplines, keeping attention on materials and on context, and considering space as something that can orient behaviours, encounters and forms of community; not as a neutral container.

The collection in Orani is the largest anywhere, but the case for a museum in a village of a few thousand people was never an argument about inventory.

What can a museum located in his place of origin tell us about Costantino Nivola that a major international institution could not tell in the same way?

An international institution can tell Nivola within the dimension of global art history and twentieth-century architecture, reconstruct his relationships with New York, with the Harvard Graduate School of Design, with architects such as Le Corbusier, Josep Lluís Sert or Eero Saarinen, and give back the extraordinary cultural network in which he moved.

Orani can tell something different, showing the genesis of that gaze, its anthropological reasons.

Here some of the central questions in his work stop being merely art-historical themes and acquire a concrete dimension. His relationship with matter refers back to the geology of his land, as well as to family experience and his father's trade. The attention to community, the theme of participation, take on a crucial meaning. A museum in the place of origin has access to a memory that is not only documentary. There is an oral, vernacular, everyday memory, made of people who remember him or who have gathered the memory of previous generations. There are the light, the silences, the movement of the landscape: elements difficult to restore inside an exhibition, and they require a language, a narration, a rooted and conscious approach.

Model for the Monument to the Mason of Orani, from the Building Blocks series, 1955, concrete, 63.5 x 68.5 x 34.5 cm. Photo P. Pinna. Courtesy Museo Nivola

This does not mean reading Nivola exclusively through Sardinia: that would be equally reductive, because his artistic identity is born precisely from the encounter between Orani and the world. The strength of the Museo Nivola lies, if anything, in the possibility of holding these two dimensions together. On one side, an artist fully part of the international culture of the twentieth century; on the other, a biography and an imaginary profoundly rooted in the island.

Perhaps what the Museo Nivola can offer in a unique way is exactly the possibility of understanding that these two dimensions are not in contradiction.

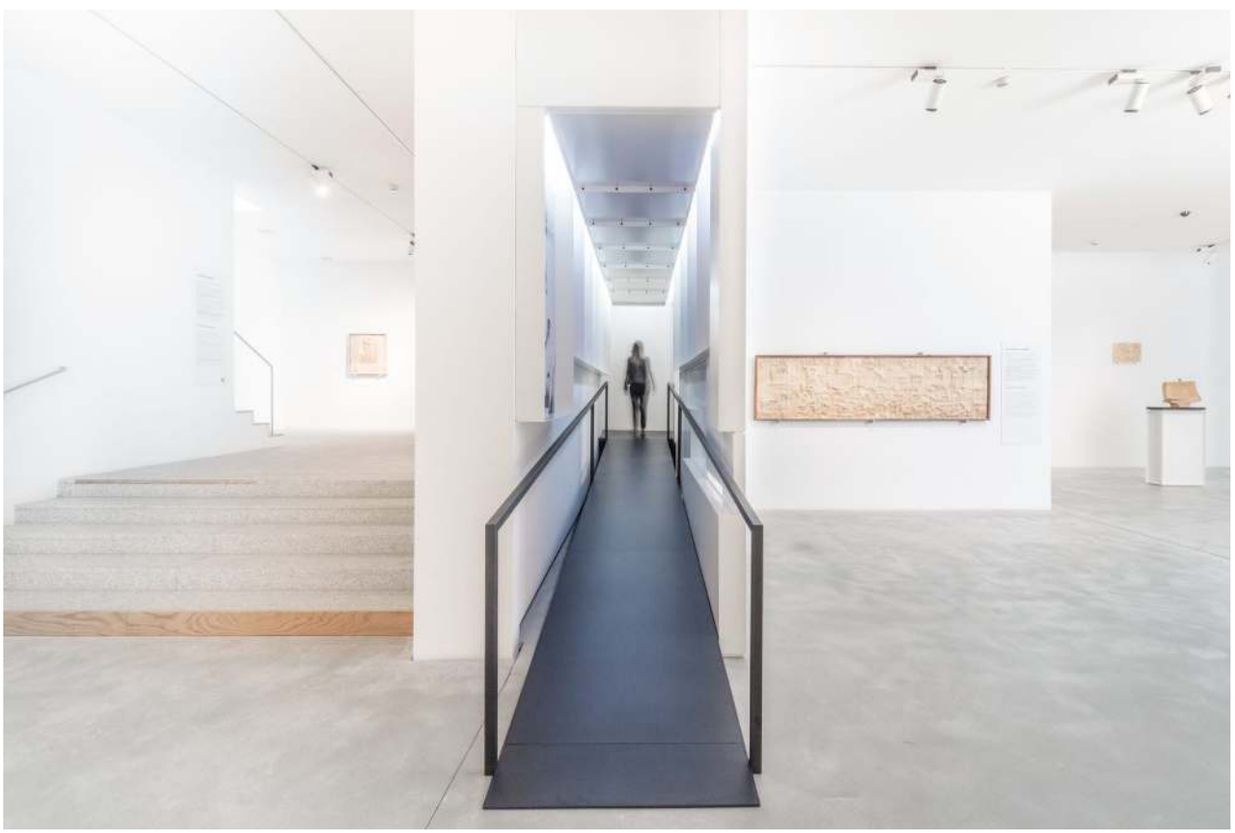
The last question is about what comes next, and the answer describes something closer to a workshop than to a shrine.

Could you tell us, as far as possible, about your plans for the future and for the development of the Museo Nivola? We were particularly struck by the way the museum goes beyond the traditional exhibition space, creating a dialogue between art, architecture, landscape and the village of Orani.

How do you imagine the next phase of its evolution?

The direction we are following is to deepen precisely this hybrid identity of the Museo Nivola: a monographic museum as a research centre, as a place dedicated to the contemporary, to architecture, to landscape, to education and, once again, to community.

The new programme *Nivola vis-à-vis* arises from that need. After a series of exhibitions dedicated to contemporary artists, our vision returns to questioning Nivola directly, placing him in relation with the figures, experiences and questions of his time. It is not a matter of simply constructing formal comparisons, but of analysing Nivola's work as a point of departure for themes that are still vital and necessary: space and the body, architecture and design, the interpenetration of art and environment. The exhibition *Nivola, Colombo e lo spazio intorno*, currently on view, reflects for example on space as physical and relational cognition. Around it orbit important reflections on what Nivola's research continues to suggest to the present. Which aspects of his work still appear open, urgent and productive? Within international debate, it is fundamental to reactivate their design potential, bringing back to the centre of current discourse the questions Nivola posed more than seventy years ago about the relationship between art and society, between education and imagination, between the project and everyday life.



The permanent collection, Museo Nivola, Orani. Photo Cedric Dasesson. Courtesy Museo Nivola

In the coming months, this work will continue through a rereading of the permanent collection. The temporary departure of some works for the exhibition dedicated to Nivola at the Triennale di Milano will become an occasion to rethink the display, to return to studying the storerooms, to present lesser-known works and to create other connections. We want scientific research to be able to speak with educational activity, every

exhibition to be able to generate an experience within public space, the heritage to be continuously reread through the "sentiment of the present", and the museum to continue to be perceived by the community as a belonging.

It is a dynamic that, in the end, already belonged to Nivola: crossing the world without losing the bond with the place one set out from. And this is perhaps the model of museum we are interested in continuing to build: not a closed place that preserves a legacy, but an organism capable of putting it back into circulation, continuously.

The exhibition Nivola, Colombo e lo spazio intorno is on view at the Museo Nivola in Orani, Sardinia. Works from the permanent collection will travel to the exhibition dedicated to Nivola at the Triennale di Milano, and the display in Orani will be rebuilt around their absence. ■

FEATURE SEPTEMBER 19, 2026

PARK3020: A Sculpture Park Dated a Thousand Years Ahead

Outside Lviv, in open fields near the village of Strilky, Ukraine's first public park of contemporary sculpture gives young artists a place to work at full scale, and gives visitors a reason to walk out into the landscape to meet them.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION IV · FEATURE · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Outside Lviv, in open fields near the village of Strilky, Ukraine's first public park of contemporary sculpture gives young artists a place to work at full scale, and gives visitors a reason to walk out into the landscape to meet them.

Half an hour's drive from Lviv, past the village of Strilky, the land opens into long, rolling fields. Standing in them, at distances that make you walk, are a white sphere with a human profile cut into it, an eight-metre ear, a brick shell and a grove of red steel trees. This is PARK3020, the first public park of contemporary Ukrainian sculpture.

It was founded in 2020 with a clear brief: to give Ukrainian sculptors, and above all young ones, institutional, financial and educational support, a place to realise large works at home and a platform from which to be seen internationally. Six years on, the park has grown from a handful of commissions into a collection, a programme of exhibitions and an indoor art hall.

A date as a programme

The number in the name is not an address or a founding year. The park calls 3020 a symbolic date of creation and, at the same time, an ambition: a park of the future that is taking the first of a thousand steps into history. It is a useful way to read the place. Nothing here is finished; the collection is meant to be added to, argued with and grown over a very long time.

That long view is built into its structure. PARK3020 began a lasting collaboration with Yorkshire Sculpture Park, Britain's leading institution for public sculpture, to bring in international expertise while the park found its feet and to develop residencies, lectures and studios together. An expert council, with curator Katya Taylor, sculptor Mykhailo Reva and Yorkshire Sculpture Park's Helen Pheby, shapes exhibitions and approves works; a supervisory board of patrons, chaired by Ihor Kryvetskyi, oversees its strategy.

The landscape around the park, near Edem Resort in the Lviv region.

Six commissions, one field

Between March and August 2020 six artists made works for the park on commission: Anna Zviahintseva, Anna Naduda, Anton Logov, Bohdan Tomashevskyi, Nazar Bilyk and Oleksii Zolotar. The brief they shared was the landscape itself, and most of the pieces answer it directly: they are about how a person stands in, looks at and listens to the world around them.

Nazar Bilyk's Space Around is the work that has become the park's image. A human outline dissolves into the perfect form of a sphere, and with it into the space around. Bilyk, who works with the negative form of white plaster, describes these contours as both object and instrument, a way of drawing the space in which a person is present.

Nazar Bilyk, Space Around.

Oleksii Zolotar's Ear rises eight metres out of the grass. It began, the park notes, with an unsuccessful selfie, and it addresses a familiar theme, from Bosch to Van Gogh, with an urgent one: the need to listen carefully to a world in the middle of physical war and emotional overload, and to choose what to take in. Anna Zviahintseva took a very different route to scale. Her father used to twist foil into small figures while he was thinking; she enlarged one of them, a pair of legs, to a four-metre object, turning a half-conscious habit into a monument to thought.

Oleksii Zolotar, Ear, and Anna Zviahintseva, Sculpture of My Father.

Anton Logov's Trees of Life grow straight through the roof of a house. The landscape reminded him of the oaks of his grandparents' region near Odesa, and of the idea that to develop, a person has to cross borders and break standards. Anna Naduda's Biomorph, from the other side of the field, joins the branching form of trees to the idealised canon of ancient Greek sculpture, proposing a single form in which the bodily and the natural are the same thing.

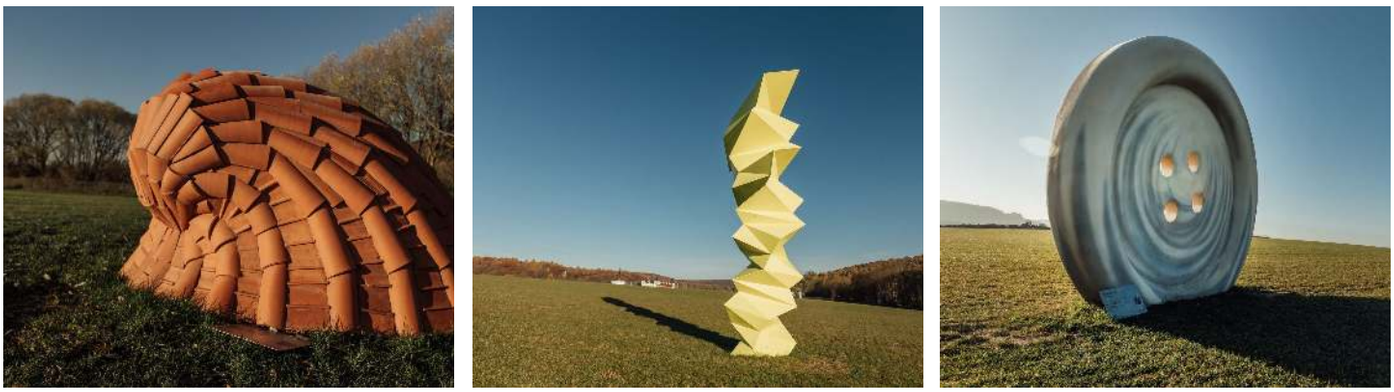
Anton Logov, Trees of Life, with a detail, and Anna Naduda, Biomorph.

Bohdan Tomashevskyi's Salamander is the most abstract of the six: black metal planes that read at once as a lizard in motion and as the ridge of the Carpathians. In the forests of Rakhiv, where he often met the fire salamander, a large population of the animal is a sign of clean air and water. Set here, it is a quiet warning to a person dazzled by technological progress that civilisation depends on nature.

Bohdan Tomashevskyi, Salamander.

Later arrivals

The collection has kept growing. Zhanna Kadyrova, who tests the aesthetic potential of ordinary building materials, made a monument to a mollusc, a shell that shuts at any sign of danger, the way a person in a big city learns to. Stepan Ryabchenko's Apparition, a folded yellow column, refers to the legend of a vision said to have appeared on the site of a Kyiv botanical garden in 1862. And the GREVIS group, Volodymyr Levis and Ernest Yemeliantsev, placed a giant button in a birch clearing: a thing lost long ago that grew along with the trees, and now belongs to the landscape as much as they do.



Zhanna Kadyrova, Shell; Stepan Ryabchenko, Apparition; GREVIS, Button.

In May 2021 the park added another way of making work: a sculpture symposium, a format that limits artists in time and material. Nine Ukrainian and international sculptors spent the month carving granite on site, and the results joined the collection in the fields.

The 2021 sculpture symposium: granite worked on site.

Indoors: from the forum to Birth

In autumn 2025 the first Global Culture Forum opened a new venue, the Art Hall, with a large exhibition of Ukrainian masters, among them Liubomyr Medvid, Ivan Marchuk and Serhii Savchenko. Alongside it ran Transformation of the Future, a show of

young artists, and Ukrainian Ceramics. Continuity of Form, which traced a line from Trypillia clay figures to contemporary ceramics.

The current exhibition, Birth, runs until 4 October 2026. It looks at the moment before a work exists, where an image comes from and how a private experience becomes a shared language, with works by artists of several generations, including Volodymyr Odrekhivskyi, Roman Opalynskyi, Volodymyr Tsisaryk, Mykhailo Demtsiu, Artur Soletskyi and Ihor Palii. It is shown together with a collection of historic Ukrainian dress from different regions and rare twentieth-century books.

Exhibition halls of PARK3020: Birth, 2026, and the Art Hall of the Global Culture Forum, 2025.

Visiting

PARK3020 is open every day from 10:00 to 18:00, next to Edem Resort in Strilky, about 30 minutes by car from Lviv; buses 747, 842 and 843 run from Lviv bus station No. 5, followed by a 30-minute walk. Guided tours, including the exhibition halls, start at 12:00 and 15:00 and last up to two hours, and you can also walk the park on your own. A standard ticket costs 600 hryvnias; children aged 6–12, military personnel, pensioners and art students pay 300, and children under six and combat veterans enter free. Dogs are welcome, and there is parking with charging for electric cars.

The best way to see the park is slowly. The distances between the works are part of the experience: you approach a sculpture from far away, lose it behind a rise in the ground and find it again from another side. For a park that dates itself a thousand years ahead, it is a fitting pace.

Text: Viacheslav Munister for EPRIS Journal. Photographs: PARK3020, park3020.com. Information on visiting as of September 2026; check park3020.com before you go. ■

VISUAL STORY SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

Inside the Victoria Museum

Ukraine's first museum of costume, founded in a restored Kyiv mansion in 2017: over 1,500 objects across seven rooms, corseted silk gowns, a gold-braided court coat, cameos cut from shell, and the small objects, lockets, scent bottles, enamel boxes, that a life actually held.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION IV · VISUAL STORY · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Ukraine's first museum of costume, founded in a restored Kyiv mansion in 2017: over 1,500 objects across seven rooms, corseted silk gowns, a gold-braided court coat, cameos cut from shell, and the small objects, lockets, scent bottles, enamel boxes, that a life actually held.

The Victoria Museum sits behind an arched doorway a few steps off Khreshchatyk, in a nineteenth-century apartment building whose stucco cornices and rusticated ground floor give away nothing of what is inside. A small plaque by the entrance reads Victoria Museum – Музей костюма та стилю, the Museum of Costume and Style, open Thursday to Sunday. I went on a whim after a walk through the city centre, and stayed for most of the afternoon.

It's a younger institution than it feels. The collector Victoria Lysenko opened it on 30 May 2017, after nine months of preparation, as the first museum in Ukraine built entirely around historical dress. The building itself is older: a mansion raised in the late nineteenth century, left derelict from around 2000, and extensively restored in 2009, with the original balcony railings on the second and third floors kept rather than replaced. What Lysenko assembled inside now runs to more than 1,500 objects across seven rooms on two floors, over two hundred of them complete garments, alongside what the museum counts as the largest collection of fans in Ukraine, more than eighty of them. In 2022 it was presented at the European Museum of the Year Award; that same spring, on the forty-fifth day of the full-scale invasion, it reopened rather than stay closed.

The museum's building, a restored nineteenth-century mansion off Khreshchatyk. · Wikimedia Commons: AlinaGusewa, CC BY-SA 4.0

A wardrobe from another century

Room by room, the museum is built around clothing: dozens of women's gowns from the second half of the nineteenth century into the 1900s, most of them shown on mannequins inside glass cases, lit like the jewellery beside them. A deep purple velvet bodice trimmed with tatted lace stands beside a slate-blue silk skirt; a few steps on, a crinoline gown in a rust-red floral print from the 1860s balloons out under its own weight, the pattern of small roses running unbroken from waist to hem. One label, in Ukrainian and English, catalogues a dark chocolate-coloured dress with floral ornaments and buttons from the 1880s in the plain language of a museum inventory, cotton, velvet, that understates how much handwork sits inside a single sleeve.

A velvet bodice, an 1860s crinoline gown, and a chocolate-coloured dress from the 1880s, shown beside a period portrait and a gentleman's uniform coat.

A full case of crinoline gowns from the 1850s–60s, each shown with its own shoes, fan or parasol and a matching portrait. · Wikimedia Commons: AlinaGusewa, CC BY-SA 4.0

Further in, the colour gets bolder. A cropped coat cut from a brown, orange and cream paisley weave, lined in dark velvet, sits under a framed photograph of the woman it may have been made for, an unusual survival: paisley was for shawls and interiors more often than outerwear, and seeing the whole pattern wrap around a body rather than lie flat changes how you read it. Two cases along, an ivory gown drops its sleeves off the shoulder into a froth of tulle roses and pearl trim, the bodice hand-embroidered with sprays of leaves in a pattern that repeats down the full length of the train, evening dress built for a room with better lighting than daylight.

A paisley coat lined in velvet, and an ivory evening gown embroidered with leaves and tulle roses.

Some pieces are display-cased tableaux rather than single garments. In one corner, a mourning dress hung with small framed photographs down its bodice stands beneath sepia portraits of the women who might have worn it, next to a folded parasol and a pale silk dress with a deep lace collar, a whole small theatre of a nineteenth-century household, assembled inside a single vitrine.

A mourning gown hung with framed photographs, beside sepia portraits and a folded parasol. · Viacheslav Munister

Silk, braid, and a court coat

The collection isn't only for women's dress. A single red wool coat, cut like a courtier's or a footman's livery, is trimmed the length of both lapels and cuffs in wide gold metallic braid, closed with a column of domed brass buttons, the kind of formal coat that would have been made to a household's own pattern, not bought off a rail. Nearby, a cream silk bodice with a high boned collar carries the same embroidered lyre-and-scroll motif repeated at the shoulders, throat and hem, the sort of detail that only shows itself under a display light.

A gold-braided court coat, and the repeated lyre motif on a cream silk bodice.

A case of men's accessories does the same close-looking trick from a different angle: a row of walking canes, their handles carved from bone and ivory into a bird's head, a lion, a laughing face, stand beside a white double-breasted summer coat with a black velvet collar, an old leather travelling bag and a single pair of high-buttoned boots, worn enough to have belonged to somebody. Two more gowns, one in dusty pink chiffon with a lace-trimmed train, one in pale cream silk with a beaded high collar, are shown against period portraits of women dressed almost identically, so the wall reads as evidence rather than decoration.

Carved cane handles and a gentleman's summer coat; a pink chiffon gown and a cream silk dress, each shown beside its period portrait.

Cameos, lockets, and small boxes

A side room is given over to what would have sat on a dressing table or travelled in a pocket: rings and brooches set with painted miniature portraits, enamelled trinket boxes in cobalt blue and gold, a scent bottle on a chatelaine chain. On one wall, more than a dozen cameos, carved from shell, onyx and sardonyx, English and Italian, mostly nineteenth-century, are mounted in a single gilt frame like a cabinet of miniature paintings: a saint on horseback, a scroll of acanthus leaves, a woman's profile turned three-quarter to the light. The museum's fan collection, the largest in Ukraine by its own count, keeps company with the same cases: a hand-painted court scene on silk, its sticks carved and gilded, folds open beside a stack of enamelled boxes on a single glass shelf.

Cameo brooches, rings and enamel boxes from the museum's jewellery cases.

Paintings and a bronze figure, for context

The clothes are hung against a backdrop of paintings and objects from the same decades: a French Madonna and Child with John the Baptist from the early nineteenth century, gilt-framed portraits of women in the same silhouettes the mannequins wear, a bronze figurine of a woman in a plumed hat holding a fan halfway to her face. None of it is didactic. There's no long wall text explaining the history of the corset or the politics of mourning dress; the museum mostly lets the objects sit close enough together to make their own argument about a period that dressed itself with tremendous, specific care.

The Victoria Museum is open Thursday to Sunday, 11:00–18:00, a short walk from Khreshchatyk. It's a small museum and an easy one to see in an hour, but I'd allow longer, the glass cases reward the kind of slow looking that a phone camera keeps interrupting. ▪

CULTURE NOTES SEP 13, 2026

Nothing Fallow About It: The Harvest Behind France's Novels and Italy's Golden Lion

A Roman mosaic already knew what September was for. Two thousand years later France still times its book industry to it, and Italy still times its cinema to it. Nobody involved would call that a coincidence.

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

SECTION IV · CULTURE NOTES · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

A Roman mosaic already knew what September was for. Two thousand years later France still times its book industry to it, and Italy still times its cinema to it. Nobody involved would call that a coincidence.

There is a month European culture never lets lie fallow. Long before anyone published a novel or projected a film, September was already booked: it is when southern Italy's vineyards come down off the vines, when the Roman calendar's own month-mosaics show two men treading grapes rather than resting, when an entire hemisphere's worth of agricultural labor gets crammed into six or seven weeks before the weather turns. Nothing about the modern versions of that instinct is new; only the crop has changed. France now harvests novels in September. Italy harvests films. Both still call the result a season.

461novels in the 2026 rentrée littéraire83rdedition of the Venice Film Festival1,800years since Rome carved the harvest into stone

A month that was never really free

The habit is older than either country's publishing house or festival jury. A third-century Roman mosaic from El Djem, in what is now Tunisia, gives September its own panel in a calendar of the months, and the panel shows two men treading grapes, not resting after summer. The tribute was to Bacchus, god of wine and, not incidentally, of the theater: the same god the Romans credited with both the vintage and the performance that celebrated it. In the south of Italy, where the heat breaks earlier, the vendemmia still runs through September; in the north, growers wait until November. The harvest and the calendar have simply never agreed to separate.

Caravaggio painted the same debt more directly, a decade before 1600: his Bacchus, now in the Uffizi, reclines with a wine glass in one hand and a wreath of vine leaves already loosening in his hair, unhurried in exactly the way the actual harvest never is. The painting has outlasted the empire that worshipped its subject by well over a thousand years. The vendemmia is older than both the empire and the painting, and has never needed either one's permission to keep arriving every September.

Bacchus, Caravaggio, c. 1598, Uffizi Gallery, Florence. · Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio, public domain, via Wikimedia Commons

France: the harvest moved from the vine to the shelf

France runs its own September harvest twice over, and rarely notices the overlap. Champagne's growers still call theirs the vendange; in 2026 an unusually mild winter and three summer heat waves pushed it earlier than anyone alive could remember, finishing by September 4 instead of dragging into the month as usual. The other harvest,

the rentrée littéraire, keeps its own, stubborn calendar. The idea was already in the air by the 1880s, when the philosopher Ernest Renan first named the pattern, and the creation of the Prix Goncourt in 1903 gave publishers their first real reason to time a book's release around it. But the rentrée as anyone would recognize it today is a postwar invention: publishers only started clustering releases into a single autumn window in the late 1950s, once enough literary prizes were competing for the same November announcements to make August a wasted month. The 2026 rentrée counts 461 novels, 344 of them written in French, 117 translated, and 68 first novels, five fewer than the year before. The volume has been shrinking for a decade, but the deadline has not moved, because the deadline was never really about the books. It is about which of those 461 titles gets to stand in front of the Académie Goncourt's jury in November, and a book that arrives in October is already too late to be considered.

Italy: the same instinct, dressed as a festival

Cinema's September ritual is younger than the vendemmia by about two thousand years and younger than the rentrée littéraire by roughly three decades, but it was built with the same appetite for spectacle Bacchus originally got the tribute for. The Venice International Film Festival opened in 1932 as an event within that year's Biennale, engineered by three men, Giuseppe Volpi, Luciano de Feo, and Antonio Maraini, who understood cinema's use as a projection of a modern, image-conscious Italy under Mussolini's government as clearly as they understood its box office. The first prize, introduced in 1934, was named the Coppa Mussolini; the festival went dark entirely from 1943 to 1945, then returned and, in 1949, replaced its old prize with the Golden Lion. The 83rd edition ran September 2 to 12, 2026, and gave that Lion to Woman Unknown, May el-Toukhy's Danish drama about a housemaid's wartime affair, under a jury led by Maggie Gyllenhaal. Ilya Khrzhanovsky took the Silver Lion for Best Director for DAU. George Clooney and Ellen Burstyn each received an honorary Golden Lion for lifetime achievement, the same honor the festival gave Werner Herzog the year before.

Werner Herzog with his Golden Lion for Lifetime Achievement at the 82nd Venice Film Festival, 2025. · Photo: Colleen Sturtevant, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

Paris will spend the next two months deciding which of four hundred and sixty-one novels get to matter. Venice has already spent its ten days deciding the same thing for a smaller, slower pool of films. Neither city would describe what it is doing as a harvest, and neither needs to: the metaphor was already carved into a mosaic in Roman Africa some seventeen centuries before either institution existed, and none of the three, the grape, the novel, or the film, has ever managed to make September optional. ▪

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ARCHITECTURE & DINING SEP 5, 2026

Dinner Inside an Advertisement

Le Train Bleu · Gare de Lyon, Paris · Marius Toudoire

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

PARIS · MARIUS TOUDOIRE · 1900–1901 · MONUMENT HISTORIQUE 1972 · PHOTO: CC0 / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Le Train Bleu does not serve nostalgia. It serves a hundred-and-twenty-five-year-old sales pitch for a train that stopped running in 2003, inside a room the French state has legally frozen since 1972 and asks you to pay, gladly, for the privilege of hearing it again.

Climb the double staircase at the Gare de Lyon and you leave the railway. Below, the platforms run on schedules measured in minutes; the trains themselves have changed shape four or five times since the building opened. Above, nothing has been allowed to change at all. You are standing inside a room built in 1900 to sell a train that no longer exists, for a company that no longer exists, to a public that has been dead for a century. The room outlived all three. It is called Le Train Bleu, it is a working restaurant with a wine list and a reservations line, and since 1972 it has also been a Monument Historique of France - a piece of advertising copy that the state now protects the way it protects cathedrals.

The staircase to the Buffet de la Gare de Lyon, photographed not long after it opened. The restaurant now called Le Train Bleu sits at the top of it. · Public domain

A brochure you can sit inside

The commission was never really for a restaurant. In 1900 the Compagnie des chemins de fer de Paris à Lyon et à la Méditerranée - the PLM - was rebuilding its Paris terminus from scratch for the Exposition Universelle, and it needed the new station to do more than move passengers through a building. It needed to convince them to keep coming back for a destination most of them had never seen: Provence, the Riviera, Algiers. The architect Marius Toudoire, who had already drawn the station's facade and its 67-metre clock tower, built in open homage to Big Ben, was asked to build a dining room that would do the selling. He built a room 26 metres long with a ceiling that behaves like a painted sky, and he covered its walls in forty-one paintings by seventeen different artists - Albert Maignan, Henri Gervex, François Flameng, Eugène Burnand among them - each one an advertisement for a city the trains below were supposed to reach. Orange, Marseille, Nice, Monaco, Algiers: you could eat your dinner and plan your whole itinerary off the walls without ever consulting a timetable.

One of the forty-one wall paintings, signed by Albert Maignan and dated 1905, labelled simply Orange - a stop on the PLM line rendered as a scene from high society rather than a photograph of a station. · Photo: Mbzt / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 3.0

This is worth pausing on, because it is easy to file the room under “ornate” and move on to the food. A photograph documents a place. A commissioned oil painting, forty of them, hung at the scale of a cathedral, does something closer to a pitch: it tells you what the place feels like to the people who can afford to be there, which is a different and much more persuasive claim. The PLM was not decorating a waiting room. It was buildi-

ng the nineteenth century's version of a full-page spread in a glossy magazine, except the spread was eleven metres tall, gilded, lit by bronze chandeliers, and structurally load-bearing.

The ceiling of the Grande Salle: painted city medallions set into stucco scrollwork, lit by the original bronze chandeliers. · CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

The measurements of an illusion

The room has a name for every part of the fiction. The Salle Dorée, the Golden Room, runs 18.5 metres long under an 11-metre ceiling. The main dining room carries the name Réjane, after the actress who was one of its first regulars. Off to one side, the Salons Tunisien and Algérien - carved dark wood, geometric Arab motifs, orientalist landscapes - were built to stage a version of French Algeria for businessmen who would never travel there, favourite rooms for lunch meetings for exactly that reason. None of these spaces pretend to be modest. The building's decoration budget alone, in 1900 francs, could have built a provincial train station of its own. That was, in a sense, the point: the PLM was competing with rival railway companies for the same wealthy passengers, and the fastest way to prove your trains were worth taking was to prove your waiting room was worth living in.

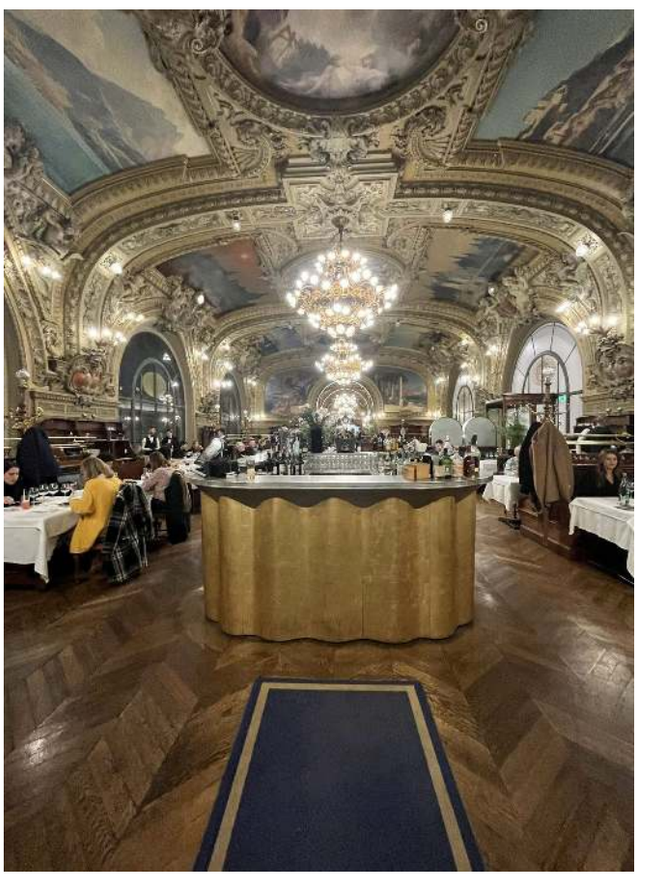
The dedication still on the wall: "Emile Loubet, Président de la République Française, inaugura ce buffet le VII avril MDCCCCI." The head of state opened a train station restaurant the way other governments open bridges. · CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

President Emile Loubet cut the ribbon himself on 7 April 1901, a detail the room still advertises on a carved plaque flanked by two mermaids, as if the opening of a station buffet required the same ceremony as a war memorial. In its first decades the room was simply called the Buffet de la Gare de Lyon - a functional name for a functional-sounding job, dining hall attached to a station. It only became Le Train Bleu in 1963, and this is where the story gets stranger rather than simpler: the overnight express it renamed itself after, with its dark-blue sleeping cars running between Calais and the Riviera, was still in service at the time - it would keep running for another forty years, until 2003. But by 1963 jet travel had already taken the glamour the train used to own; the Riviera was now a few hours away by air, and the twenty-hour sleeper had quietly slid from the fastest way to arrive into the most romantic way to be delayed. The restaurant borrowed the name at exactly the moment the real train stopped being the point and started being the legend. It has been selling a memory of travel since before the thing it named itself after had finished happening.

A monument that keeps serving lunch

In 1972 the French state made that memory official, listing the restaurant, the Salle Dorée, and the Tunisian and Algerian salons as Monuments Historiques - the same designation that protects Notre-Dame and the châteaux of the Loire. It is an unusual thing

ercial dining room that still needs working kitchens, fire exits, and a wine cellar. The paradox produced its own discipline. When the restaurant closed for three months in the summer of 2014 for a 4.5 million euro restoration - cleaning and repairing all forty-one paintings, regilding the stucco, rewiring chandeliers that had been retrofitted for electricity a century earlier - the work was led jointly by Agence Duthilleul, the practice responsible for the TGV network's stations, and an Architecte des Monuments Historiques, whose job was to make sure modernity touched nothing anyone could see. Architect Jean-Marie Duthilleul described the building's original idea as a doorway to the Mediterranean set inside Paris, its departing trains staged like ships leaving for somewhere exotic. The 2014 renovation restored that idea rather than updating it.



The Grande Salle Réjane, 26 metres of painted ceiling over a room that has not stopped serving dinner since 1901. · CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

What survived the century is not only plaster. The room absorbed a cultural afterlife it was never built to expect. Coco Chanel and Jean Cocteau took tables there in the 1920s; Colette wrote about it; Salvador Dalí, Brigitte Bardot and Jean Gabin were regulars later on. Seven films have used it as a location, from *Travels with My Aunt* in 1972 to the *Mr. Bean* holiday comedy in 2007 - a Belle Époque dining room playing itself, decade after decade, in stories that had nothing to do with railways. Each generation found a slightly different fiction to project onto the same forty-one paintings. That is what a genuinely successful piece of advertising does: it stops needing the product it was built to sell, and starts selling the feeling of having always been there.

What is actually on the table

None of this would matter if the kitchen had modernised to match the ambition of the room, and to its credit it never has. Since 2018 the restaurant has been run for its operator, SSP, by the chef Michel Rostang, and the menu he built is deliberately unfashionable: leg of lamb carved tableside from a trolley, a gratin dauphinois made without cheese or egg in the old style, Bresse chicken with tarragon cream, steak tartare mixed in front of you, rum baba finished with a pour of rum at the table. There is no attempt to reinterpret the room in the kitchen's own image, the way a contemporary chef might feel obliged to do inside a monument. The food plays the same supporting role the paintings do: proof that a version of France existing mostly in memory is, for the length of a meal, still available to order.

The station facade Toudoire designed alongside the restaurant, its arched windows still carrying the restaurant's name to the square outside. · Photo: APB11 / Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Downstairs, the trains that made the room's fortune have mostly moved on. The line to the Riviera runs faster now and stops less; the TGV that eventually replaced the original Train Bleu does not carry its name, and passengers who want the coast today are more likely to compare fares on a phone than to sit down in a dining room and be sold the destination in oil paint. The advertisement, in other words, has completely outlived the product. What is left is a room that no longer has to persuade anyone of anything, protected by law from ever having to try a different pitch, still setting a table under a ceiling built to make you believe a train ride could feel like arriving somewhere before

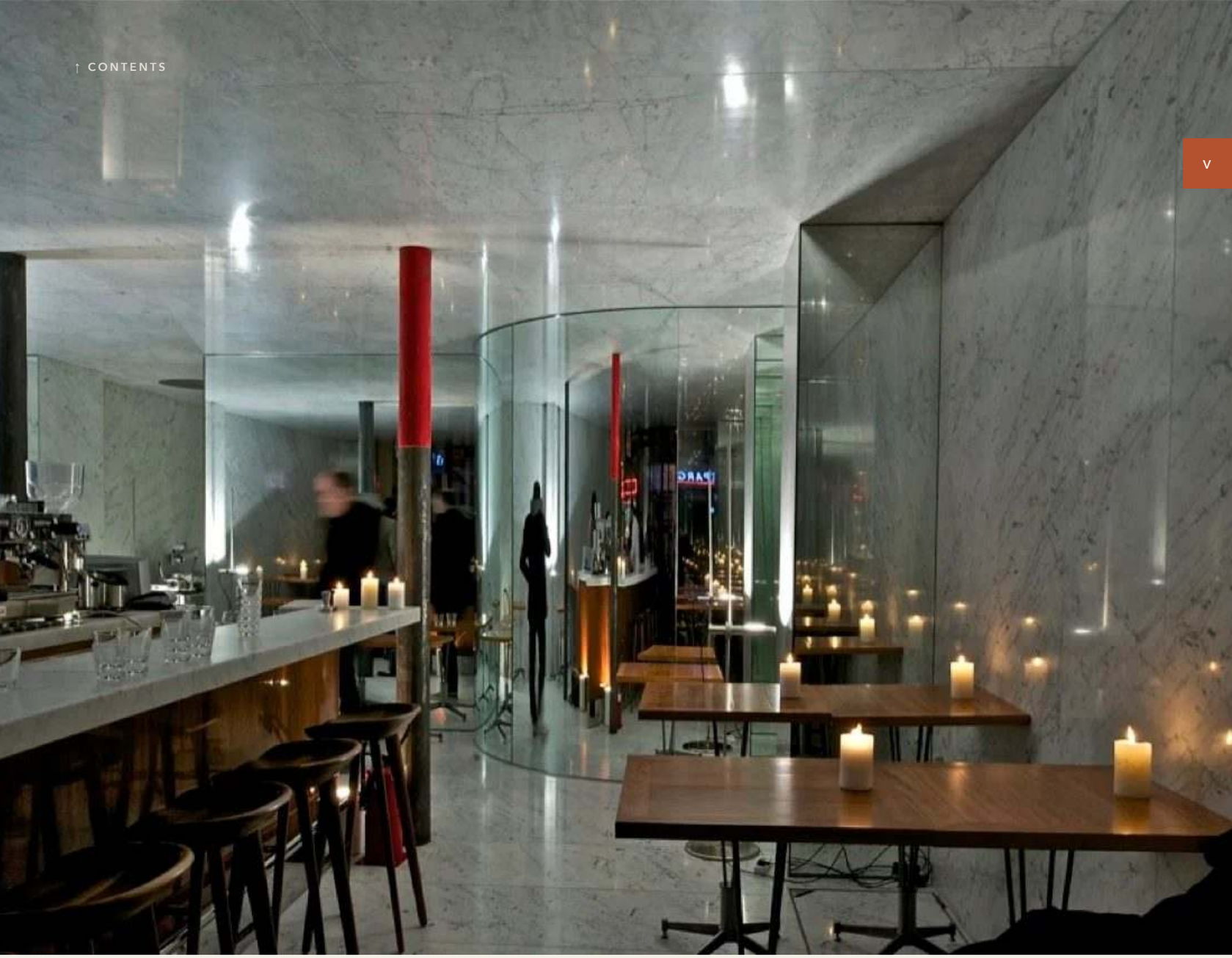
you had left. Eat there and you are not visiting the past. You are sitting inside a hundred-and-twenty-five-year-old sales pitch that the French state decided was worth telling forever, and paying, gladly, for the privilege of hearing it again. ■

FOR

- Forty-one paintings by seventeen artists turn the dining room into a functioning 1900 travel advertisement, not mere decoration
- Monument Historique status (1972) has kept the 2014 restoration disciplined — nothing modernised that didn't need to be
- The menu (Michel Rostang since 2018) plays a supporting role rather than reinterpreting the room, which is the right call inside a monument
- Rare case of a piece of purely commercial, corporate architecture — built by a railway company to sell tickets — preserved with the same rigor as a cathedral

AGAINST

- The kitchen's deliberate old-fashioned register (lamb from the trolley, tableside tartare) will read as expensive nostalgia rather than cuisine to some diners
- As a working station buffet inside an active terminus, the room trades some quiet for constant foot traffic and tourist volume



FOOD

Le Dauphine

131 Avenue Parmentier, Paris

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA

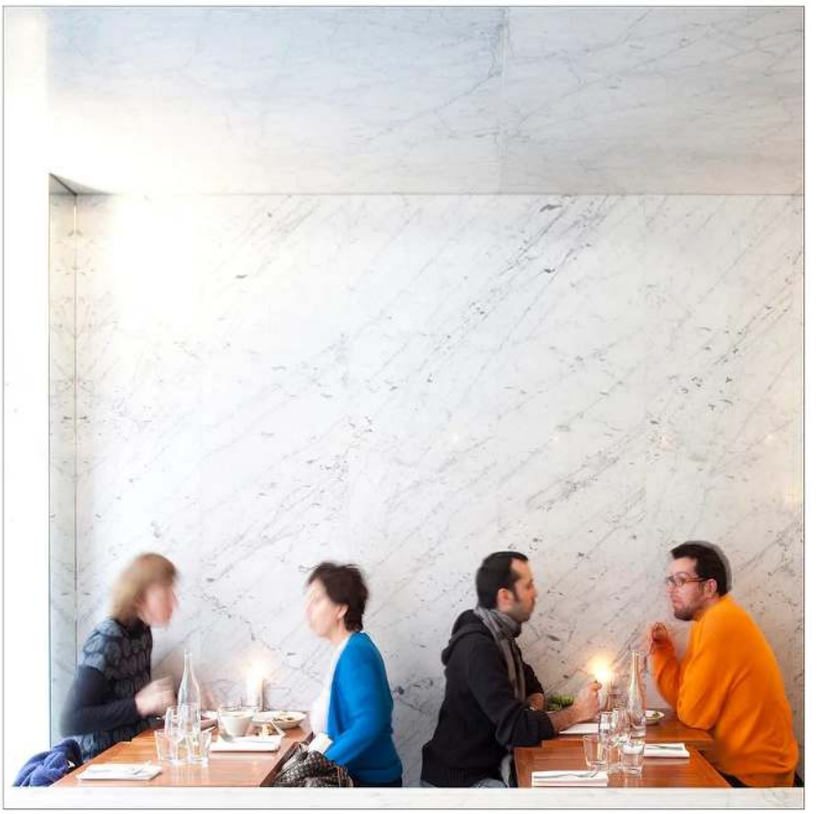
REVIEW · MARIA IVANOVA

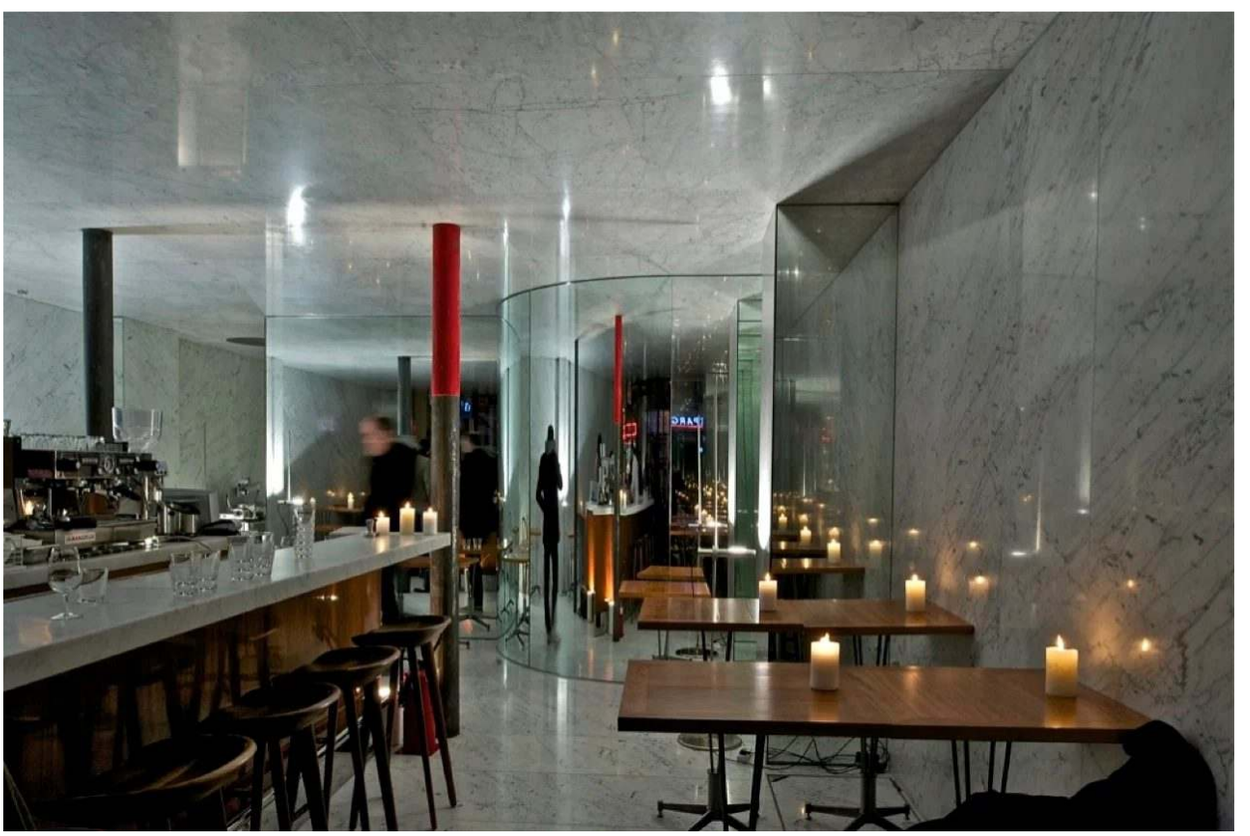
PARIS · RESTAURANT · €€€

Quality bistronomy. Le Dauphine, located in the 11th arrondissement of Paris, is an exposed, rather than a hidden gem of the city. Thanks to the architects Rem Koolhaas and Clément Blanchet, who worked on the restoration of the dining space, the entrance of the shiny and tiny restaurant features a massive white frame, embracing the glass facade and providing an open view of the magnificent interior.

The duo of star chefs – Fred Péneau and Inaki Aizpitarte – commissioned the OMA bureau and Clément Blanchet to transform less than 60 square meters into a quality bistro-gastronomy space. In 2010, Le Dauphine opened its doors, immediately gaining the attention and love of the public, both for its design and cuisine.

Surprisingly, the architects saw the place through the lens of an ancient temple – characterized by strong hierarchy and functions, which were borrowed and delicately implemented. The Naos is typified by the central bar counter – the heart of the space, covered in oak wood. Four encircled pillars amplify its relation to the ancient temple. The central counter is the heart, whose warmth contrasts with the total marble covering of the walls. The material usually associated with bathrooms defies the conventions of dining interiors and accomplishes it with great success. The whole space – from ceiling to floor – is laid in large-scale stone slabs with restrained graphic veins. Simplistic but chic – that's a perfect background for a tasteful lunch on the rush, or an unhurried dinner, when the Parisian street lights transmute the exterior into an homage to one of Edouard Leon Cortes's paintings.





The exterior frame, described in the beginning, continues the storyline of the Hellenistic Sanctuary with due honor. Serving as the transition between the exalted interior and the street, it contains the magic of an immersive experience. To stop from the mundane to the sanctuary of tastes – where every deliberate choice elevates your experience of quality – is to reinterpret the classical pronaos, separating the external world from the sacral.

DP6 Photomontage

Despite the modest area, the restaurant doesn't feel compressed – the walls are not perceived restrictively by virtue of mirror panels reflecting the bright marble, tables, and happy guests who share the delight of being in a modern urban sanctuary.

The most distinctive element adopted from the Hellenistic Temple is the feeling of monumentality – the interior exudes a solid confidence in its own independence of time and trends.

It has proven to be true – 16 years after its opening in 2010, you can still visit Le Dauphine and join the joy at the center counter on a bar stool, or reserve a table for a cozy, modern bohemian dinner with your closest one. ■

ARCHITECTURE & DINING AUG 15, 2026

Dining Inside a Watercolour

Enigma · Barcelona · RCR Arquitectes

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

BARCELONA · RCR ARQUITECTES + PAU LLIMONA · 514.78 M² · 2016 · PHOTO: HISAO SUZUKI / RCR ARQUITECTES

Enigma does not decorate a dinner. It gives the evening its own visual grammar and asks the guest to read it one room at a time.

Enigma does not greet you with a grand dining room. It begins with a shimmer, a blurred silhouette and the feeling that something is being held back. RCR Arquitectes and Pau Llimona designed Albert Adrià's Barcelona restaurant as a sequence of discoveries rather than a single interior: thresholds, veils and changing light postpone the moment when the whole place can be understood. The 514.78-square-metre project was designed in 2014–15 and built in 2015–16, yet its defining material is not glass, stone or steel. It is an RCR watercolour, enlarged and translated across ceramic floors, walls and furniture until a drawing becomes a place.

That translation is the key to Enigma's identity. A more conventional restaurant might repeat a logo, a signature colour or one photogenic motif. Here identity behaves like weather: it surrounds the guest without turning into signage. Pale mineral surfaces erase hard edges; ribbed glass makes neighbouring tables present but unreadable; suspended forms lower and expand the ceiling without announcing themselves as sculpture. Nothing shouts "brand", yet everything feels unmistakably related.

This is not neutral hospitality design. The route choreographs anticipation, exposure and retreat. A guest moves through the restaurant as a reader moves through paragraphs – never seeing the conclusion too soon. The meal can therefore change tempo without fighting the room. Seasonal cooking and spatial sequence share the same principle: meaning accumulates through succession.

There is a risk. Enigma's visual language is so total that it can feel almost clinically controlled, and anyone looking for the informal warmth of Barcelona may read its translucent boundaries as distance. Yet the discipline is also the project's achievement. RCR does not decorate Adrià's food. It constructs the perceptual conditions in which surprise remains possible.

The result is rare: an interior with a recognisable image but no single photogenic trick. Enigma is strongest not when photographed, but when crossed. Its real luxury is not marble, privacy or spectacle. It is the careful design of attention.

A room drawn before it was built

The project began with a wash of pigment rather than a catalogue of finishes. RCR's watercolour was enlarged, digitised and translated into a ceramic system that crosses floors, walls and custom furniture. At close range the surfaces are precise and manufactured; from a few metres away they lose their edges and behave like an atmospheric field. That tension – industrial control producing visual uncertainty – is the interior's

central idea. It also explains why the restaurant resists the usual hierarchy of feature wall, decorative ceiling and statement object: each plane belongs to the same continuous drawing.

The watercolour translated into a continuous interior field. Photo: Hisao Suzuki / RCR Arquitectes.

The photographs reveal how little of the room can be described by a single material name. Cast glass reads alternately as curtain, ice, rain and polished stone. Pale tables and chairs almost disappear into the reflective ground, while darker service elements collect in recesses. Instead of using contrast to clarify circulation, RCR uses degrees of opacity. Movement is guided by what remains partly visible: a glint of stainless steel, a silhouette behind ribbed glass, a warmer pocket of light beyond the next partition.

Identity without a logo

Enigma's strongest branding decision is to avoid looking branded. The visual system is built from behaviours rather than emblems: translucency instead of a fixed graphic mark, repetition without perfect sameness, cool grey surfaces interrupted by warmer light, and a route that reveals information gradually. The watercolour supplies a recognisable texture, but the deeper identity lies in how the room acts. It filters, delays, reflects and reframes. The restaurant can therefore remain coherent across architecture, furniture and table setting without reducing itself to a colour palette. This is spatial identity at its most convincing: guests may forget an individual detail, but they remember the sensation of moving through the whole.

Thresholds, veils and withheld views

Ribbed glass filters movement and turns adjacent rooms into shifting silhouettes. Photo: Hisao Suzuki / RCR Arquitectes.

Enigma is organised as a sequence of perceptual edits. Screens interrupt long views without sealing rooms; compressed passages release into wider dining zones; ceiling formations seem to descend, then dissolve. The route never offers the conventional restaurant reveal in which reception gives way to one comprehensible dining room. Each transition withholds the next scene, turning circulation into part of the tasting menu. This is architecture performing the same work as a course: isolating an encounter, controlling its duration and leaving a residue before the next begins.

The kitchen as part of the architecture

Service and dining zones share the same mineral, translucent language. Photo: Hisao Suzuki / RCR Arquitectes.

The open work areas are not presented as theatrical stages with chefs under spotlights. They are folded into the same silver-grey landscape as the dining room. Equipment, counters and storage appear through translucent layers, close enough to register as activity but abstracted enough to preserve concentration. This is an unusually intelligent answer to the open-kitchen cliché. Labour is neither hidden nor converted into spectacle; it becomes a changing depth behind the meal. Sound, reflection and movement make the kitchen present even when its exact boundaries remain uncertain.

Eating as a form of editing

The original Enigma did not merely serve a long menu in an unusual room; it cut the evening into scenes. Contemporary accounts described guests moving through a Welcome Area, wine cellar, cocktail bar, open kitchens, grill and extended dining room before ending in a darker final bar. Thirty-five to forty small dishes became a sequence of spatial cuts: stand, taste, move, sit, watch, wait. The most interesting connection between Adrià and RCR is therefore not “experimental food in experimental architecture”. It is their shared use of editing. Both remove context, isolate an encounter and then rea-

rrange the order in which meaning arrives. A translucent wall performs the architectural equivalent of a covered plate: it tells you something is close while refusing to reveal it yet.

A course isolated against white space turns plating into a pause in the sequence. Official image: Enigma Barcelona.

An identity designed to mutate

The restaurant has since changed course. Enigma's own current presentation says that little remains of the earlier format after reopening; today the tasting menu is rebuilt month by month around seasonal products and may run to roughly twenty to twenty-five dishes. That evolution makes the original identity strategy look even smarter. A logo-led concept would date the moment the menu changed. RCR's system is more elastic because it is based on sensations – blur, reflection, anticipation, coolness, release. The cooking can be rewritten while the central promise remains legible: you enter a world where the familiar is made temporarily strange. In brand terms, Enigma owns a mode of attention rather than a decorative style.

The dining room beneath its cloudlike ceiling: furniture, light and reflection merge into one field. Official image: Enigma Barcelona / Davide Groppi.

Barcelona without the postcard

There are no terracotta walls, market graphics or easy quotations of Mediterranean colour. Enigma belongs to Barcelona by refusing the postcard version of Barcelona. Its local character is carried more subtly: the culture of radical hospitality experiments associated with the Adrià orbit; RCR's Catalan habit of treating material, landscape and ritual as one problem; and a confidence that craft can look futuristic without becoming anonymous. The restaurant's official description calls the space both local and universal. That apparent contradiction is accurate. The project is rooted in a specific experimental culture, yet it communicates through basic bodily experiences – approaching, glimpsing, touching, waiting – that need no translation.

Why the space still matters

Light changes the apparent depth and weight of every surface. Photo: Hisao Suzuki / RCR Arquitectes.

Years after completion, Enigma remains persuasive because its concept is not a styling package. The interior establishes rules – continuous image, filtered visibility, choreographed sequence – and allows every detail to follow them. The result can feel cool and exacting, but that coolness is productive: it clears away the visual noise that usually competes with ambitious food. RCR and Llimona created a restaurant that cannot be reduced to a photogenic corner. Its architecture is experienced cumulatively, through steps, pauses, reflections and partial views. The building does not explain the menu; it teaches the guest how to pay attention. ▪

FOR

- Architecture choreographs the meal without becoming scenery
- A watercolour becomes a coherent and adaptable identity system
- Light, translucency and thresholds control pace with exceptional precision
- The spatial concept remains meaningful even as the restaurant format evolves

AGAINST

- Its total visual control can feel emotionally cool
- The experience depends on surrendering to a highly directed sequence

METAL AUG 2026

Marrow Deep

Mastodon · Loma Vista Recordings · 2026

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Marrow Deep does not mourn quietly. It erects a structure large enough to hold grief, and then challenges you to walk through each of its rooms.

Marrow Deep, released on August 28, 2026, is the first Mastodon album made without Brent Hinds, who left the band in March 2025 and died five months later in a motorcycle accident. The cover does not name this loss, but every review still reads the album through him, and so does this one: a band rebuilding publicly, with two new permanent members, guitarist Nick Johnston and keyboardist João Nogueira, who are integrated into the sound rather than announced by it.

What holds the thirteen tracks together is less a theme than a construction method. Critics have already employed cathedral-like language to describe it: a song that winds upward like a snake, raises a tower, and combines towers, transepts, and buttresses as it ascends. Golden Spires earns its title under these conditions. It builds not so much toward a chorus as toward a ceiling, verse stacked on verse, until a coda appears like a vault closing overhead. This is an album that thinks in sections and heights, not just in riffs.

The emotional heart of the album is a five-song suite that begins with Out Like a Lamb, the eulogy by drummer and singer Brann Dailor for his mother, whose title is borrowed from the old proverb about March weather. It is the quietest structural gesture on the album, with the bass moving beneath the vocals rather than behind them, and it lays out the foundation on which the rest of the suite is built.

With thirteen titles, Marrow Deep occasionally repeats a form it has already proven it can build, and an album that is so designed to be read as a continuous structure will frustrate anyone looking for a single crossover moment. It offers none. What it instead offers is a band that chooses architecture over spectacle to carry something so heavy, and mostly succeeds. ■

FOR

- The five-song suite centered on Out Like a Lamb turns the epitaph into architecture, not spectacle.
- New members Nick Johnston and João Nogueira are integrated into the band's sound, rather than announced through it.
- Golden Spires is built in literally ascending steps and earns the title.

AGAINST

- Across its thirteen tracks, the album occasionally repeats a form it has already proven it can build.
- The album urges you to read it as a continuous structure, offering no single transitional moment for those seeking one.

ARCHITECTURE & DINING SEP 12, 2026

The Restaurant That Painted an 18th-Century House Pink

sketch, The Gallery · 9 Conduit Street, Mayfair, London · India Mahdavi

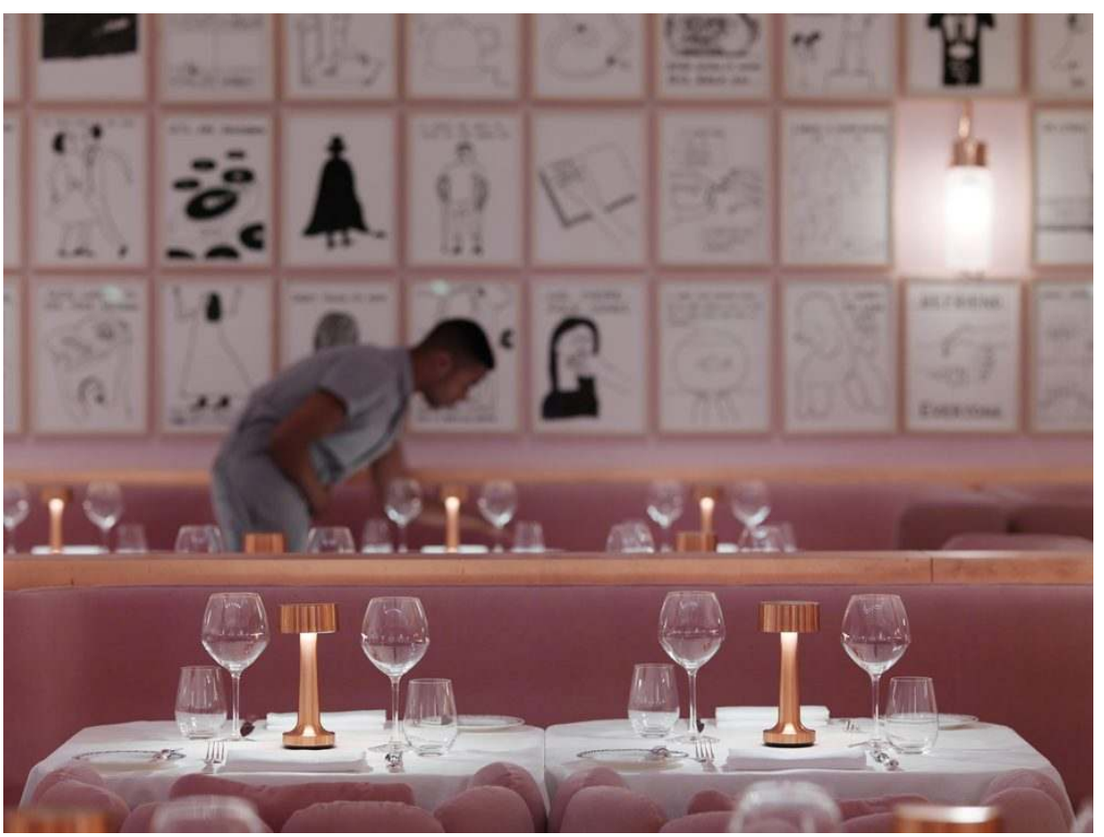
WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

LONDON · INDIA MAHDAVI, DAVID SHRIGLEY · 1779 / 2014 · PHOTO: FLODEAU

Sketch takes a Grade II listed Georgian townhouse built by James Wyatt in 1779 and paints one of its rooms the exact pink of a 1980s prom dress, hangs two hundred and thirty-nine David Shrigley drawings on the walls in a grid, and puts a rainbow-lit chamber of egg-shaped toilet pods one floor below it, and asks diners to move between all three without once explaining the joke.

Nine Conduit Street has been many things since James Wyatt designed it as a private Mayfair residence in 1779: a townhouse, a home to a cyclists' society and a balloonists' club, a meeting place for the Suffragette movement, and for a long stretch simply a building nobody had a good use for. In 2002 the restaurateur Mourad Mazouz bought it without a clear plan beyond the conviction that a Grade II listed Georgian house deserved better than sitting empty, and turned it into sketch, a single address containing several rooms with almost nothing in common except the belief that a restaurant can also be a piece of design criticism.



A table set inside the Gallery, with the Shrigley wall and one of the room's copper table lamps close enough to read individually. · Photo: flodeau.com

One colour, no exceptions

The Gallery's most disciplined decision is the one that looks the most frivolous. India Mahdavi's 2014 redesign commits to a single millennial pink across walls, ceiling, carpet and the tulip-shaped velvet banquettes that ring the room, refusing the usual designer's instinct to break up a strong colour with a neutral counterweight. The effect is less a themed room than a habitable Rothko: from the doorway, the pink reads as one continuous surface, and only up close does it resolve into fabric, plaster, marble chevron flooring and two hundred and thirty-nine individually framed drawings. Mahdavi had three months to complete the redesign in 2014; what was originally planned as a two-year installation ran for eight.

The room's corner, where the herringbone marble floor meets a wall of two hundred and thirty-nine identically framed drawings. · Photo: flodeau.com

Two hundred and thirty-nine punchlines

Those drawings are by the artist David Shrigley, whose deliberately crude, deadpan style has always worked by refusing to look expensive, which is exactly what makes it survive being hung in a room this ornamental. Gridded salon-style across every wall in identical frames, the drawings function first as texture, a uniform pattern that completes the pink room the way wallpaper would, and only on closer inspection break apart into two hundred and thirty-nine separate, absurd little jokes about failure, boredom and bad advice, the largest single body of his work ever exhibited in one place. Sketch has cycled

artists through the space since, including a 2022 redesign with Yinka Shonibare that swapped the walls to sunshine yellow, but the pink Shrigley scheme was reinstated, evidence that the combination reads as the room's real identity rather than one look among several.

Individual Shrigley drawings read up close: text-based jokes hung at exactly table height. · Photo: flodeau.com

A room built to be walked through, not just seen

Photographed empty, the Gallery can look like a stage set waiting for its cast. What the room is actually built for shows up once staff and diners are moving through it: the pink absorbs and reflects the low light so consistently that people become part of the same continuous surface as the walls and banquettes, dressed in grey uniforms that read as a deliberate, muted counterpoint rather than an oversight. Even the crockery keeps the bit going, hand-lettered in the same wry, self-referential type as the drawings, printing the restaurant's own Mayfair address onto the plate a foie gras terrine is served on, so that the joke about self-awareness reaches the food before it reaches the table.

A foie gras terrine served on crockery hand-lettered with the restaurant's own street address. · Photo: flodeau.com

The joke that follows you downstairs

What separates sketch from a merely photogenic dining room is that the design logic doesn't stop at the door. One floor down, under a barrel-vaulted ceiling tiled edge to edge in dozens of stained-glass colours, a row of sleek white egg-shaped pods holds the restaurant's toilets, each one a private capsule glowing faintly under the coloured light spilling down from above. A weaker restaurant would treat the bathroom as an afterthought once the dining room had already done the work of being memorable; sketch treats it as one more room in the same argument, that a building can be historic, expensive, slightly ridiculous and completely serious about all three at once. ■

The egg-shaped toilet pods, lit from above by a ceiling tiled edge to edge in stained glass. · Photo via NJ in LA

Staff uniforms designed for the same room: grey against the eggs' pearl-white shells and the rainbow ceiling above. · Photo: flodeau.com

FOR

- The Gallery's monochrome pink scheme by India Mahdavi covers walls, banquettes, carpet and lighting in one continuous hue rather than treating pink as an accent, which is what makes the room read as a single artwork instead of a themed dining room
- David Shrigley's 239 drawings are hung salon-style, uniformly framed and gridded across every wall, so the deliberately childish, deadpan sketches read as wallpaper from across the room and as individual jokes up close
- The building itself, an 18th-century Mayfair house that spent 220 years as a home to cyclists' clubs, balloonist societies and suffragette meetings before becoming a restaurant, is left legible under the redesign rather than gutted for it
- The egg-shaped white toilet pods, set beneath a barrel-vaulted ceiling tiled in dozens of stained-glass colours, commit to the same absurdist logic as the dining room instead of reverting to ordinary design once the joke could have safely stopped
- The tulip-backed velvet banquettes, upholstered in the same pink as the walls, were built as bespoke furniture for the room rather than sourced off a catalogue, so the seating reads as sculpture that happens to also seat people
- Even the food is drawn into the joke: dishes arrive on crockery hand-lettered with the restaurant's own street address, so the tableware keeps making the same point the walls do about a building that never stops being aware of itself

AGAINST

- A single-color room this famous photographs better than it seats: the deep booth banquettes and low lighting that make the pink glow in pictures are less comfortable for a long dinner than a conventional dining chair
- The Gallery has been repainted before, swapped to sunshine yellow for a Yinka Shonibare redesign in 2022 before pink returned, which means the room diners see today is a revival rather than the original 2014 scheme
- The toilet pods, however striking, function as a single-occupancy queue at peak hours, and the theatrical lighting that photographs so well up close reads as slightly clinical once the novelty of the first visit wears off

SCULPTURE & LANDSCAPE SEP 19, 2026

Sculpture Left Out in the Fields

PARK3020 · Strilky, Lviv region · Contemporary Ukrainian sculpture

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

STRILKY, LVIV REGION · NAZAR BILYK, ZHANNA KADYROVA, OLEKSII ZOLOTAR AND OTHERS · SINCE 2020 · PHOTO: PARK3020

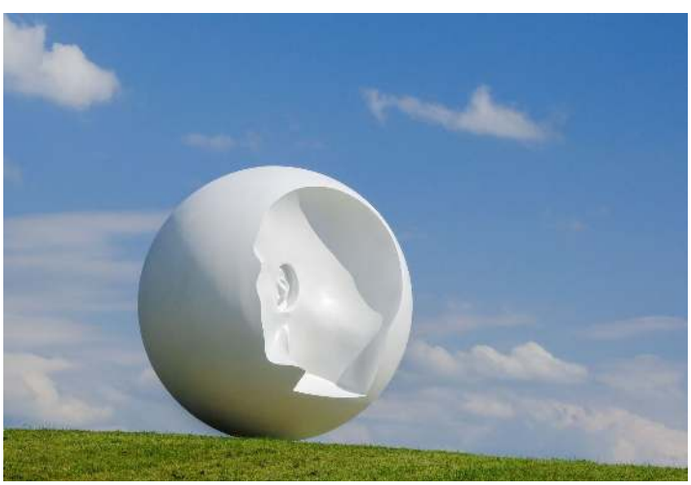
PARK3020 does not put sculpture on display. It puts it out in open fields, far enough apart that looking at art becomes a walk through the landscape, and a young national collection gets the room it needs to grow.

Half an hour's drive from Lviv, past the village of Strilky, the land opens into long, rolling fields. Standing in them, at distances that make you walk, are a white sphere with a human profile cut into it, an eight-metre ear, a brick shell and a grove of red steel trees. This is PARK3020, the first public park of contemporary Ukrainian sculpture.

It was founded in 2020 with a clear brief: to give Ukrainian sculptors, and above all young ones, institutional, financial and educational support, a place to realise large works at home and a platform from which to be seen internationally. Six years on, the park has grown from a handful of commissions into a collection, a programme of exhibitions and an indoor art hall.

Six commissions, one field

Nazar Bilyk's Space Around is the work that has become the park's image. A human outline dissolves into the perfect form of a sphere, and with it into the space around. Bilyk, who works with the negative form of white plaster, describes these contours as both object and instrument, a way of drawing the space in which a person is present.

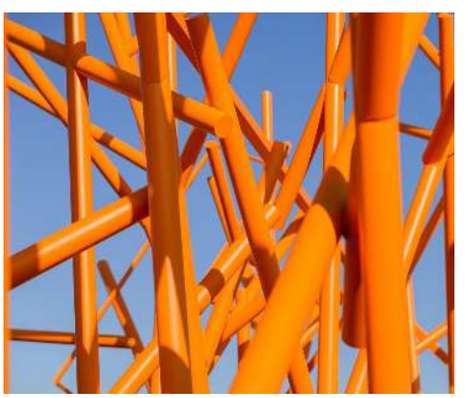


Nazar Bilyk, Space Around.

Oleksii Zolotar's Ear rises eight metres out of the grass. It began, the park notes, with an unsuccessful selfie, and it addresses a familiar theme, from Bosch to Van Gogh, with an urgent one: the need to listen carefully to a world in the middle of physical war and emotional overload, and to choose what to take in. Anna Zviahintseva took a very different route to scale. Her father used to twist foil into small figures while he was thinking; she enlarged one of them, a pair of legs, to a four-metre object, turning a half-conscious habit into a monument to thought.

Oleksii Zolotar, Ear, and Anna Zviahintseva, Sculpture of My Father.

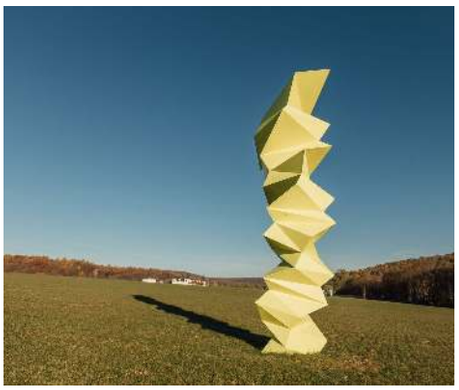
Anton Logov's Trees of Life grow straight through the roof of a house. The landscape reminded him of the oaks of his grandparents' region near Odesa, and of the idea that to develop, a person has to cross borders and break standards. Anna Naduda's Biomorph, from the other side of the field, joins the branching form of trees to the idealised canon of ancient Greek sculpture, proposing a single form in which the bodily and the natural are the same thing.



Anton Logov, Trees of Life, with a detail, and Anna Naduda, Biomorph.

The collection has kept growing. Zhanna Kadyrova, who tests the aesthetic potential of ordinary building materials, made a monument to a mollusc, a shell that shuts at any sign of danger, the way a person in a big city learns to. Stepan Ryabchenko's Apparition, a folded yellow column, refers to the legend of a vision said to have appeared on the site

of a Kyiv botanical garden in 1862. And the GREVIS group, Volodymyr Levis and Ernest Yemeliantsev, placed a giant button in a birch clearing: a thing lost long ago that grew along with the trees, and now belongs to the landscape as much as they do.



Zhanna Kadyrova, Shell; Stepan Ryabchenko, Apparition; GREVIS, Button.

Visiting

PARK3020 is open every day from 10:00 to 18:00, next to Edem Resort in Strilky, about 30 minutes by car from Lviv; buses 747, 842 and 843 run from Lviv bus station No. 5, followed by a 30-minute walk. Guided tours, including the exhibition halls, start at 12:00 and 15:00 and last up to two hours, and you can also walk the park on your own. A standard ticket costs 600 hryvnias; children aged 6–12, military personnel, pensioners and art students pay 300, and children under six and combat veterans enter free. Dogs are welcome, and there is parking with charging for electric cars.

Late light over the fields of PARK3020. · Photo: PARK3020

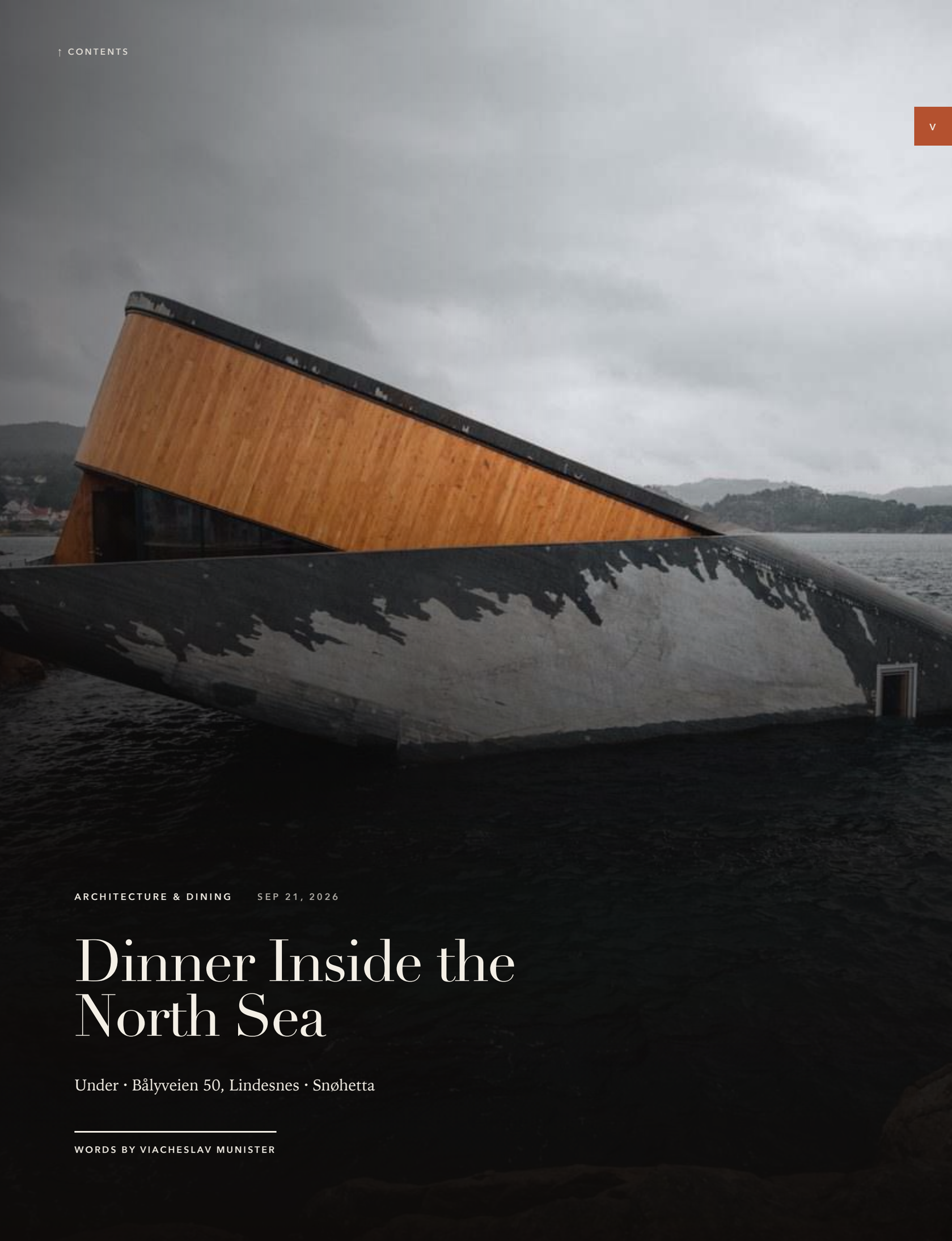
The best way to see the park is slowly. The distances between the works are part of the experience: you approach a sculpture from far away, lose it behind a rise in the ground and find it again from another side. For a park that dates itself a thousand years ahead, it is a fitting pace. ■

FOR

- The distances between the works turn every sculpture into something you approach, lose behind a rise and find again, instead of an object in a row
- Commissions such as Nazar Bilyk's Space Around and Oleksii Zolotar's eight-metre Ear were made for this landscape, not moved into it
- It is built as an institution, not an attraction: a partnership with Yorkshire Sculpture Park, an expert council, a symposium and a programme for young sculptors
- Indoor halls add a second layer, from the 2025 Global Culture Forum to the exhibition Birth, open until 4 October 2026

AGAINST

- Without a car it takes planning: a bus from Lviv followed by a 30-minute walk
- At 600 hryvnias, a standard ticket is a considered expense rather than a casual stop
- The open fields that make the park work leave little shelter on hot or rainy days



ARCHITECTURE & DINING SEP 21, 2026

Dinner Inside the North Sea

Under · Bålyveien 50, Lindesnes · Snøhetta

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

LINDESNES, NORWAY · SNØHETTA · OPENED MARCH 2019 · PHOTO: CC BY 2.0, CITY FOODSTERS / WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Under is a thirty-four-metre concrete tube laid half into the sea at the southern tip of Norway, and it does one thing better than any dining room in Europe: it puts forty people behind an eleven-metre window, five and a half metres under the waves, and lets the North Sea decide what the view looks like tonight.

At Norway's southernmost point, where the North Sea meets the Skagerrak, a slab of dark concrete comes down out of the rocks at an angle, as if a length of pipe had been dropped from a great height and left exactly where it landed. One end is clad in raw timber and sits in the air. The other end disappears into the water. There is a door in the submerged end, underwater, sealed shut; it exists for maintenance divers, not diners. Everyone else goes in from the timber end, at the top, and walks down.

The building is by Snøhetta, the Norwegian firm behind the Oslo Opera House, and it opened in March 2019 as Europe's first underwater restaurant, a title it still holds along with a fair claim to being the largest of its kind anywhere. The descent is the whole design idea: an entrance at sea level, a bar on a mezzanine where the concrete first meets the water, and finally the dining room itself, thirty-four metres in from the door and 5.5 metres under the surface, its long axis ending in a single window measuring eleven metres by three point four. The walls along the way are a metre of solid concrete, built to take the impact of a rough sea directly, and there is nothing between the last of the exposed timber above and the raw, unlit rock below to soften the fact that a great deal of weight is now over your head.

The name plays on that structure rather than decorating it. In Norwegian, *under* means both "below" and "wonder," and the building spends its entire length making the first word earn the second: you do not arrive at the wonder, you walk down into it, floor by floor, until the room itself is the seabed and the ceiling is the sea.

The dining room at 5.5 metres below sea level, all forty covers facing the same eleven-metre window. · City Foodsters, CC BY 2.0

What is outside the window is not fixed scenery. Snøhetta designed the concrete shell to function as an artificial reef, its exterior deliberately roughened rather than smoothed, so that mussels, kelp and barnacles would colonise it the way they would colonise any submerged rock on this coast. Marine biologists monitor the growth from inside, and the restaurant doubles, by design, as a research station: the same window that frames dinner is also a fixed observation point on a reef that did not exist before the building did. Diners are told, more or less accurately, that no two evenings at the window look quite the same – cod and pollack pass in loose shoals, the light shifts with depth and weather, and every season adds a little more life to the concrete that wasn't there when the restaurant opened.

The open kitchen sits at the edge of the same window as the dining room – the sea is the view from both sides of the pass. · City Foodsters, CC BY 2.0

The kitchen, under founding chef Nicolai Ellitsgaard, built a tasting menu around exactly what the building was already arguing: cold-water seafood from the coast immediately outside the window, served in courses that look assembled from the shoreline itself – a single piece of scallop set into a bowl of edible black sand, mussels served in their own shells inside a woven nest of dried seaweed, langoustine and herbs plated on beach stones. Under won a Michelin star within eight months of opening, an unusually fast recognition for a restaurant this remote, and it has held one every year since; the current guide credits chef Bernt Sæthre, who has carried the kitchen forward without loosening the coastal, almost archaeological logic of the original menu.

A course built to look like the shoreline outside the window: shellfish set into edible black sand. · City Foodsters, CC BY 2.0

Mussels, served in a nest of dried seaweed rather than on it – the plate keeps repeating the building's argument. · City Foodsters, CC BY 2.0

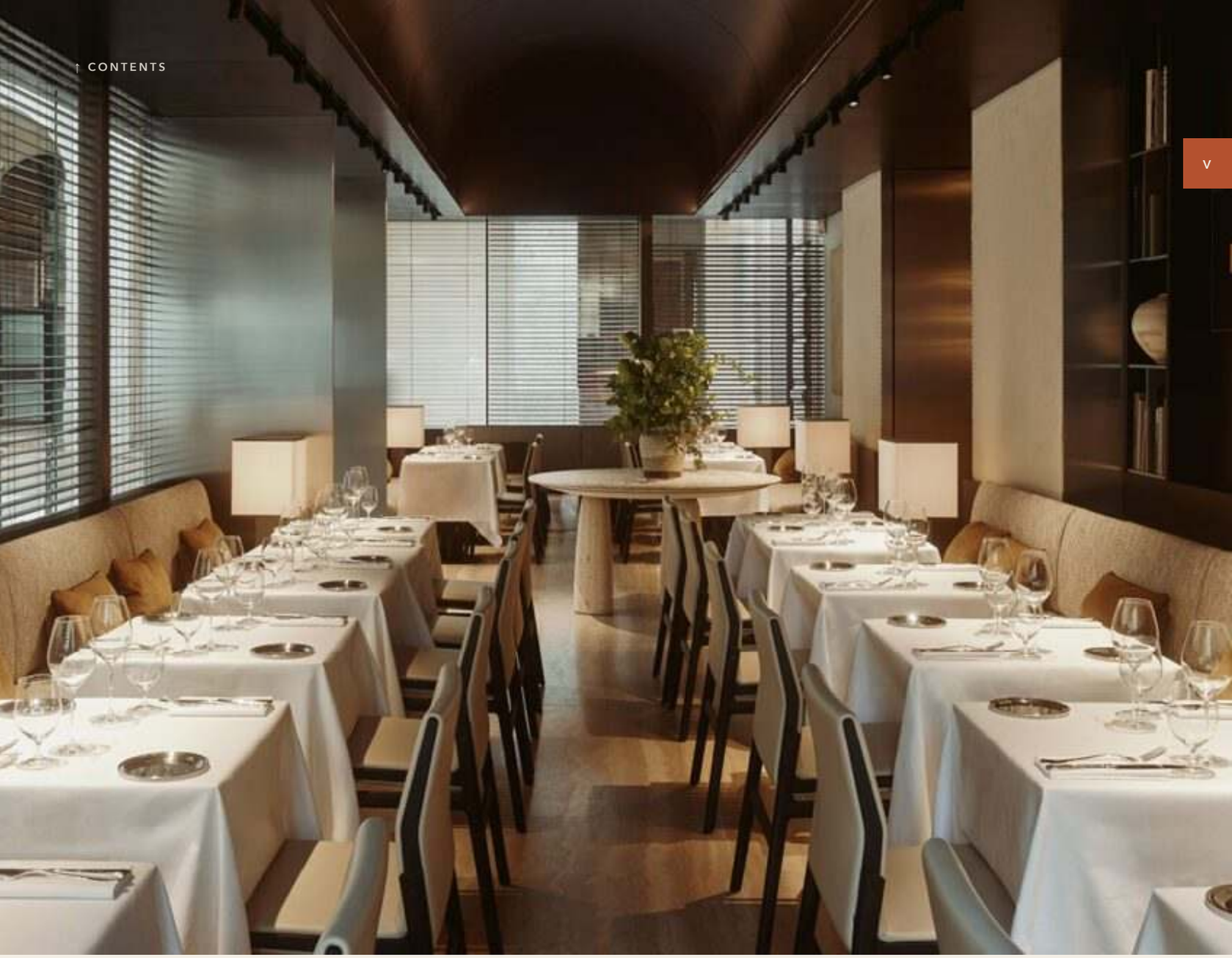
It would be easy for a building this dramatic to overwhelm whatever gets served inside it, and easier still for the kitchen to lean on the view and stop trying. Under mostly avoids both traps by refusing to treat the architecture and the menu as separate arguments. The concrete is a reef; the food is what lives on a reef. The window is fixed and the sea outside it is not, and the plates keep pointing back at the same water rather than competing with it. It is a very long way to travel for dinner, at a price that assumes you know that already. But very few dining rooms anywhere are also, quietly, a piece of long-term marine research – and fewer still ask you to sit still for two hours and watch the ocean do something no camera on the wall of a normal restaurant ever could. ▪

FOR

- The 11 × 3.4 metre underwater window is not a gimmick bolted onto a normal restaurant – the entire building is organised around reaching it, floor below floor, until the dining room is the seabed
- The name is a genuine pun in Norwegian, meaning both 'below' and 'wonder,' and Snøhetta built the whole descent to earn it
- The concrete shell is designed as an artificial reef, roughened to invite mussels and kelp, so the view outside the window changes and thickens with marine life year by year
- A Michelin star within eight months of opening in 2019, held again in the 2026 guide under chef Bernt Sæthre – the spectacle did not end up carrying a kitchen that couldn't keep up

AGAINST

- Forty seats and one nightly seating structure mean the window itself is a scarcer resource than the tasting menu – book for the view months out, not weeks
- Lindesnes is Norway's southernmost point and not on the way to anywhere: the nearest airport is Kristiansand, then close to an hour by road
- A tasting menu built this far from anywhere sits at a price that assumes the building is half the reason you came, because it is



DESIGN & DINING OCT 4, 2026

When a Furniture Brand Serves Lunch

Poliform Café · Piazza della Scala, Milan · Stefano Belingardi Clusoni & Poliform Lab

WORDS BY VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

REVIEW · VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

MILAN · STEFANO BELINGARDI CLUSONI, POLIFORM LAB · OPENED MAY 2026 · PHOTOS: POLIFORM CAFÉ

Poliform Café takes the polished language of a furniture showroom and tests whether it can survive coffee, crumbs, conversation and the daily Milanese lunch. The answer is mostly yes: this is a brand environment that understands hospitality begins precisely where perfect surfaces stop being protected.

A furniture showroom usually asks the visitor not to touch. A café asks the opposite: sit down, move the chair, leave a glass ring, stay longer than planned. Poliform Café is interesting because it puts those two instructions inside the same address. Opened in May 2026 beside the company's new flagship at Piazza della Scala, it is a forty-seat test of whether a luxury design brand can turn immaculate surfaces into an ordinary part of the city.

Poliform Café faces Piazza Ferrari through a fully glazed perimeter, turning the dining room into a visible extension of the street. · Courtesy Poliform Café

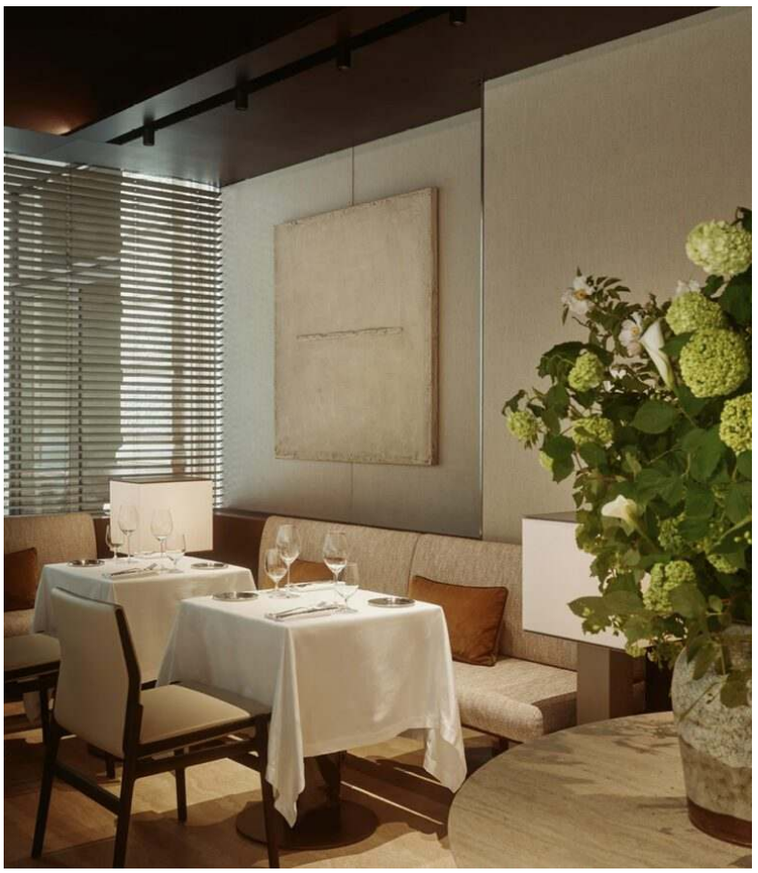
A showroom learns to be public

The café occupies an independent volume attached to Poliform's three-level flagship in a palazzo built between 1874 and 1876. The building once operated as a hotel used by singers, dancers and other artists working at Teatro alla Scala across the square; later incarnations, including fashion retail, stripped away much of the domestic interior.

Architect Stefano Belingardi Clusoni approached the wider renovation as an urban villa, using stone, light oak, glass and mirrored steel to restore continuity without pretending to reconstruct a lost nineteenth century.

The palazzo of 1874–1876, once a hotel for artists of La Scala, now holds Poliform's three-level flagship. · Courtesy Poliform Café

The café is the project's most public room. Its glass skin rejects the guarded threshold typical of high-end furniture stores. From outside, tables, diners and staff remain visible. From inside, the façades of central Milan replace the scenic wallpaper. This is not transparency as an abstract architectural virtue. It is a commercial decision: people who would never enter a Poliform showroom can still walk in for breakfast.



The forty-seat dining room uses curved seating and closely controlled lighting to soften the geometric shell. · Courtesy Poliform Café

The glazed café volume under a dark timber canopy at the corner of the palazzo. · The café front seen from the square, with the dining room visible through the glass.

Warm minimalism, with nowhere to hide

Poliform Lab designed the interior around travertine, bronze, steel and textile wall panelling. It is a familiar vocabulary of contemporary Italian luxury, but its success here comes from proportion rather than novelty. The room is compact enough for material changes to register at the scale of the hand: cool stone beneath a cup, soft upholstery at

the shoulder, reflective metal catching movement from the street. Rounded banquettes counter the rectilinear façade, while low lighting reduces the sense of eating inside a display window.

Curved upholstered seating, stone tables and custom metal details keep the palette restrained without making it visually flat.

Tables with white linen beside a pale abstract canvas and flowering plants. · Dark bookshelves with ceramics and a small framed work above set tables.

The risk is over-resolution. Every transition is composed, every finish arrives already perfect, and even the uniforms and cutlery participate in the same visual system. Older Milanese cafés accumulate character through replacement, wear and improvisation; Poliform Café begins with character fully specified. The question is whether use will be permitted to improve it. A hospitality interior should be able to age without looking like a damaged showroom.

A travertine table top with a small plant in soft light. · The backlit bar with shelves of bottles and tall stools. · Bar stools in dark wood and leather against a curved metal wall.

The menu refuses to become furniture

Chef and hospitality partner Michele De Liguoro, known in Milan for Rovello 18, gives the food a useful independence from the interior. The menu is built from recognisable Italian dishes rather than conceptual plates designed to resemble the room: saffron risotto, vitello tonnato, tagliatelle with Bra sausage ragù, Fassona beef, fish with zucchini alla scapece, fresh gnocchetti with clams and bottarga, and a deliberately exposed test of simplicity, spaghetti al pomodoro.

The kitchen stays with legible Italian recipes and seasonal ingredients rather than translating the furniture brand into theatrical plating. · Courtesy Poliform Café

That separation is important. Brand restaurants often make food subordinate to visual identity, treating a plate as another surface on which to repeat a logo, colour or design narrative. Here the stronger analogy is structural: few ingredients, careful sourcing, recognisable construction. Poliform describes its furniture through clarity and durability; De Liguoro applies the same values without making lunch explain the sofa upstairs.

From eight in the morning to nine at night

The operating hours may be the project's most convincing design decision. Open Monday to Saturday from 8:00 to 21:00, the café moves through breakfast, lunch and aperitivo instead of depending on destination dining. A room changes when the same guest can use it differently across one day: espresso at the counter, a formal meeting over lunch, a slower drink after work. Repetition is what converts branded hospitality into a neighbourhood habit.

Hospitality or brand theatre?

There is no pretending that Poliform Café is independent of corporate ambition. The café opens the brand to a broader public, gives the flagship a longer dwell time and turns hospitality into communication. A diner becomes, temporarily, a person living inside the Poliform world. But all restaurants stage an idea of how life should look. The relevant question is whether the stage leaves room for the guest.

Here, the answer depends less on the furniture than on service and time. The architecture is controlled, but not intimidating; the menu is polished, but readable; the glass façade makes arrival easier than the flagship context might suggest. The room does not disguise its commercial purpose. It simply argues that a furniture company can demonstrate its values more persuasively by letting people use them than by keeping them pristine.

The verdict

Poliform Café is not the kind of Milanese institution whose charm comes from decades of mismatched cups and stubborn regulars. It is new, deliberate and unmistakably branded. Its achievement is that the design rarely demands admiration at the expense of comfort. The café understands that the final material in any hospitality project is behaviour: chairs pulled out, tables occupied, conversations extending past the bill. If the room is allowed to collect those traces, it may become more than an elegant entrance to a flagship. It may become part of the city. ■

Independent editorial review by Viacheslav Munister. Architectural information is based on official materials from Poliform Café and Poliform, with additional reporting from Architectural Digest Italia, Wallpaper* and d la Repubblica. Official images are reproduced for editorial review; rights remain with Poliform Café and the respective photographers.

FURTHER

Poliform Café — official website poliformcafe.it/en

FOR

- The forty-seat room translates Poliform's visual language into a working café without simply arranging catalogue furniture around tables
- Travertine, bronze, steel and textile wall panels create warmth through material depth rather than decorative nostalgia
- The fully glazed perimeter opens a luxury brand space to Piazza Ferrari instead of hiding it behind the etiquette of the flagship store
- Michele De Liguoro's menu uses recognisable Italian dishes — saffron risotto, vitello tonnato, tomato spaghetti and cotoletta — rather than forcing the food into a design concept
- Breakfast-to-aperitivo hours make the café a repeatable city address, not a showroom event that only works during Design Week

AGAINST

- The visual discipline can feel over-controlled: almost every object arrives already resolved, leaving little of the accidental character that gives older Milanese bars their life
- A restaurant attached to a premium furniture flagship inevitably turns the guest into part of a brand presentation, even when the service is genuinely hospitable
- Forty seats and a central location beside La Scala make reservations sensible at lunch and aperitivo, limiting the spontaneity promised by the transparent street façade

SECTION VI

From the House

A journal is also a place. These are the doors we opened ourselves.

THE DOORS ARE OPENING: EPRIS MUSEUM AND ARCHITECTURA, THIS OCTOBER 559

THE HEART OF EPRIS: MARIA IS NOW A BACHELOR OF ARCHITECTURE 568

ANNOUNCEMENT SEP 27, 2026

The Doors Are Opening: EPRIS Museum and Architectura, This October

Every civilisation has announced itself through a door. This October EPRIS Journal opens two: EPRIS Museum, a museum without walls that never closes, and Architectura, an atlas and a school that teaches the three-thousand-year grammar in which Italy has been built.

WORDS BY MARIA IVANOVA & VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

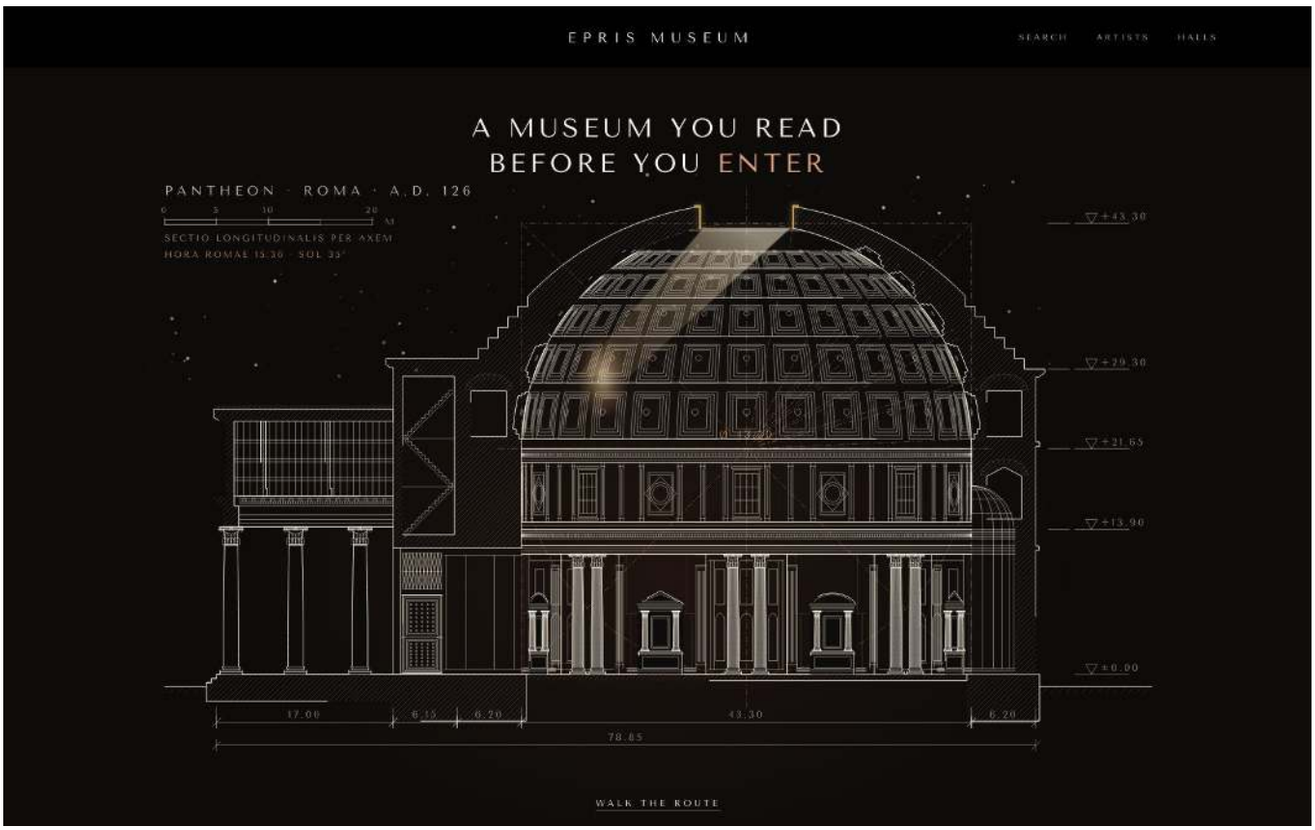
SECTION VI · ANNOUNCEMENT · MARIA IVANOVA & VIACHESLAV MUNISTER

Every civilisation has announced itself through a door. This October EPRIS Journal opens two: EPRIS Museum, a museum without walls that never closes, and Architectura, an atlas and a school that teaches the three-thousand-year grammar in which Italy has been built.

Nihil est tam populare quam bonitas. – There is nothing so much the people's as what is good. Cicero, Pro Ligario

Every civilisation has announced itself through a door. The bronze doors of the Pantheon have turned on their hinges for nineteen centuries; Ghiberti spent half his life on the doors that Michelangelo called worthy of Paradise. A door is a promise: that what lies beyond is kept, is cared for, and is meant to be entered. This October, EPRIS Journal opens two doors of its own. They are made not of bronze but of light and line, and they will not close at dusk.

The first is **EPRIS Museum**, a museum of painting, sculpture and photography with no walls, no ticket and no closing hour, at museum.eprisjournal.com. The second is **Architectura**, an atlas and a school for iPhone and iPad, which teaches the oldest grammar in Europe: the language in which Italy has been building for three thousand years. One is a place to walk through; the other a discipline to be learned. Both rest on a single conviction, which we hold as firmly as anything we publish: that beauty belongs to whoever is willing to look at it closely, and that looking closely can be taught.

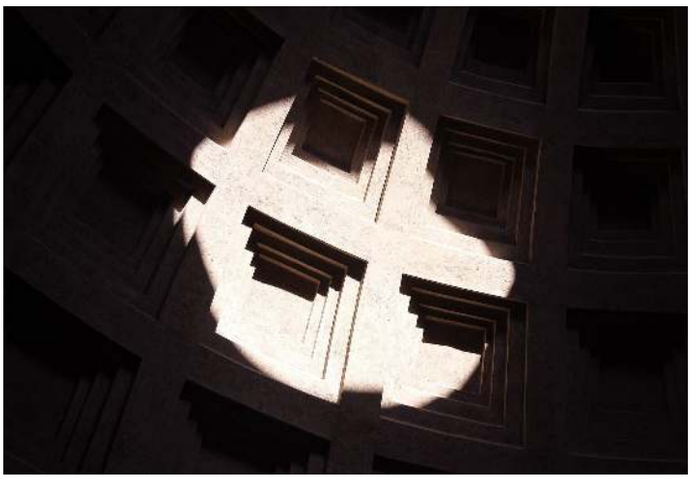


The threshold of EPRIS Museum: the Pantheon, cut through its axis. The light upon the coffers is the true sun over Rome, moving hour by hour as you read.

I Museum sine muris: the museum without walls

André Malraux dreamed of a *musée imaginaire*, a museum without walls assembled from every reproduction the century could make. EPRIS Museum is our answer to that dream. Today it holds forty-five halls, some six hundred and forty works and three hundred and seventy-five artists, from the marble of archaic Greece to photographs taken this very year. Nothing in it is borrowed on false terms: every work lies in the public domain or was given freely by its author under an open licence, and beneath every one we set down, as an act of honour, the artist, the date, the licence and the house where the original lives. The Art Institute of Chicago, the Cleveland Museum of Art and the National Gallery of Art in Washington opened their treasuries to the world; we have simply walked in and hung what they offered with the reverence it deserves.

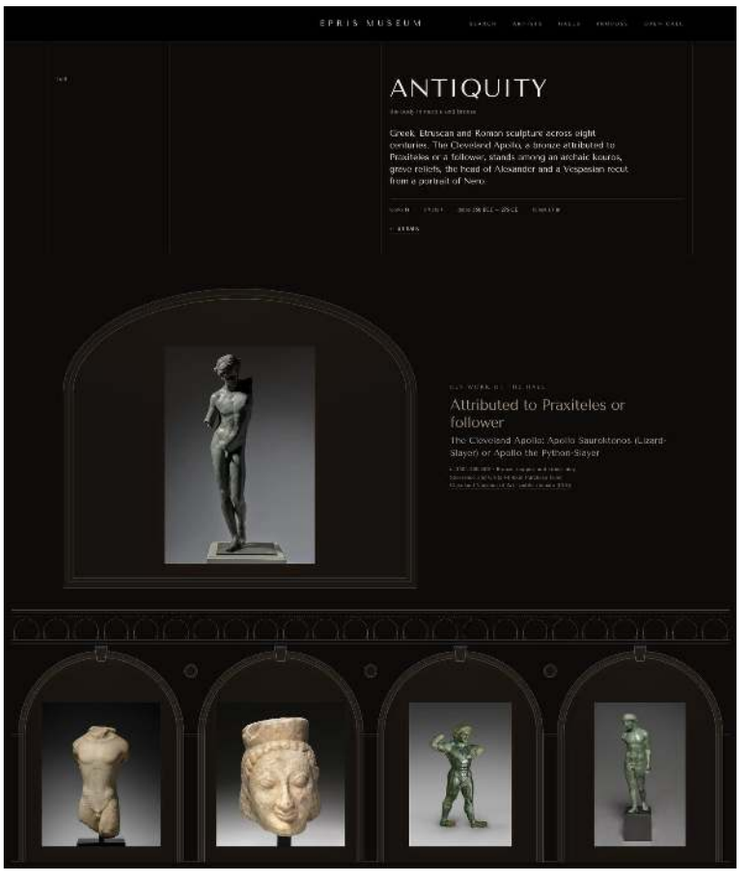
A museum without walls must still have architecture, or it is only a list. And so the visitor is received, as the Romans were received, by the Pantheon. It is drawn in section from portico to apse, its heights lettered in metres as an architect of the Académie would have inscribed them. The disc of light that falls through its oculus is no ornament: it is the true sun over Rome, computed at the very moment the page is opened. At noon it rests upon the pavement; towards evening it climbs the coffers of the dome; and when night falls over the Campus Martius, the oculus fills with stars. Further on stands the Colosseum, half façade and half section, and every one of its arches is a gate into a hall.



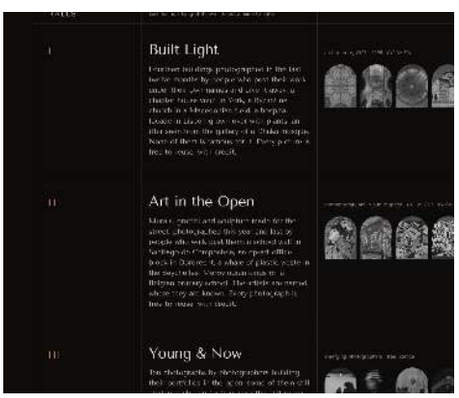
The original of our threshold: the sun through the oculus of the Pantheon. Photo: NormanB, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons · The Colosseum by night, whose arches lead into the halls. Photo: Anil Öztas, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons

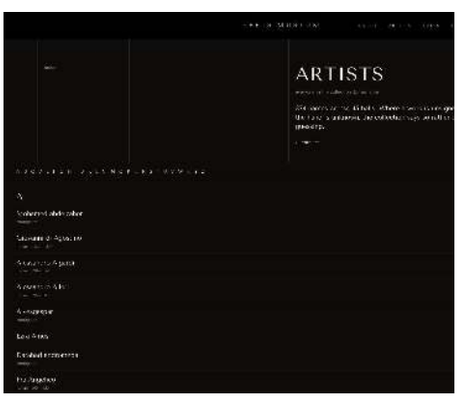
A museum should be open at any hour, and it should always tell you where a work really lives.

Within, each hall is a hang of its own, introduced by a few lines that tell you what binds the works together and leave the feeling to you. *Antiquity* gathers eight centuries of Greek, Etruscan and Roman sculpture around the Cleveland Apollo. *Built Light* offers fourteen buildings photographed in the past twelve months by people who sign their work with their own names. *The Room Itself* turns to face the architecture of the museum as such. *Stone and Memory* and *A Year of Looking Closely* hang this year's international laureates of Wiki Loves Monuments and Wiki Loves Earth. Then the halls follow the procession of the centuries, and at last there is a wall on which every work is drawn at its true size, so that a Chardin no larger than a book may stand in dignity beside a Tintoretto two and a half metres wide.



The hall of Antiquity, with the Cleveland Apollo as its key work. Every label gives the date, the material, the collection and the licence.





The halls in order, each with its text and its first works · The index of artists: every name in the collection, by surname · The open call: chosen work hangs in a hall, credited in full

And the museum is an invitation, standing and perpetual. Its open call welcomes photographers and artists from every country: to submit costs nothing, the work that is chosen is hung in a hall under its maker's name, and the author keeps the authorship entire. A modest curatorial fee of fifty cents per image is asked only after acceptance, and every term is published plainly for all to read. The halls of the future are not yet hung. Some of them are waiting for you.

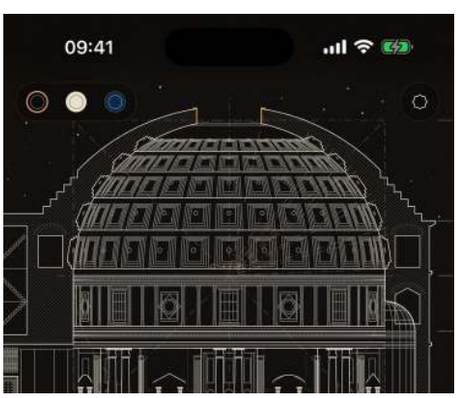
II

Architectura: Italia, linea per linea

It was the drawings that held our readers longest. They lingered over the coffers of the Pantheon, counted the orders of the Colosseum and wrote to ask the names of the small arches crowning its attic. Curiosity of that kind is the beginning of every education, and it deserves more than a caption. Architectura is our answer: the measured line drawing, that ancient instrument of the architect, placed in your hands to be held, questioned and understood.

The atlas holds forty-seven plates, and not one region of Italy is left without its monument: from the Arch of Augustus at Aosta, beneath the Alps, to the golden cathedral of Monreale and the nuraghe of Barumini, raised in Sardinia before Rome was founded. Here are the buildings the whole world knows: the Pantheon, the Colosseum, Trajan's Column, the Tower of Pisa, Brunelleschi's dome, the Palace of the Doges. And here, with equal honour, are the quieter ones: the Cattolica of Stilo in Calabria, the nine-pointed star of Palmanova, the gate of Saepinum in the hills of Molise. Milan, the city in which EPRIS is edited, receives a chapter of its own, from the Roman columns of San Lorenzo to the Bosco Verticale, with a walk that carries you through two thousand years of the city on foot.

Milan Cathedral. Photo: Francesca Milanini, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons · Brunelleschi's dome over the roofs of Florence. Photo: GiovanniPen, CC BY-SA 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons · Piazza del Campo in Siena, seen from the Torre del Mangia. Photo: Vyacheslav Argenberg, CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons



The opening page of Architectura · The Pantheon, with the sun of Rome and an hour slider · Milan Cathedral in section, up to the golden Madonnina

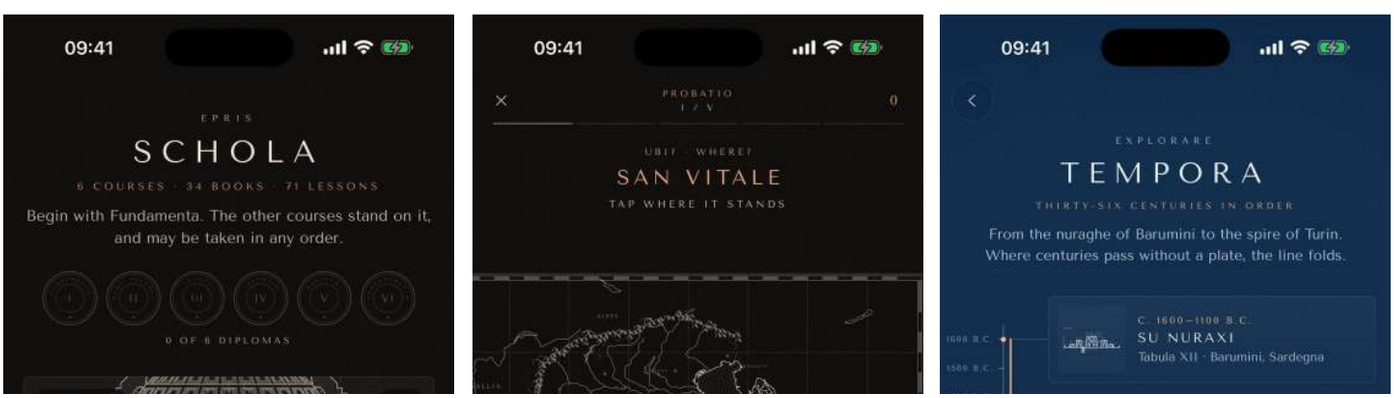
Open a plate, and it inks itself before your eyes, stroke after stroke, as a drawing grows beneath the hand of its maker. Then the reading begins. Five hundred and ninety-nine parts are marked across the atlas, and each is given its true name, the word an Italian guide would speak, a clear explanation and one fact worth carrying for the rest of your life. Touch the oculus, and you learn that it is nearly nine metres wide and has never once been glazed: the rain of Rome has fallen through it for nineteen hundred years. Touch the Torre del Mangia, and you meet the bell-ringer whose nickname the tower still bears. A narrator speaks every term first in Italian, for a word that has been heard is a word that is kept.

Architecture is a language before it is a style. Learn its words, and every city in the world becomes a book you can read.

We have written as the finest teachers speak before a building: never hiding behind jargon, never stooping to condescension. A frieze is a band of carving that runs along the head of a wall like a line of verse; an entablature is everything a column bears upon its shoulders. The facts are held to the same standard. Every date, height and name has been checked against published scholarship, and behind every plate stands a small library: its official Italian name, its place, its builders, its UNESCO inscription where it has one, and a list of books for those who would go further.

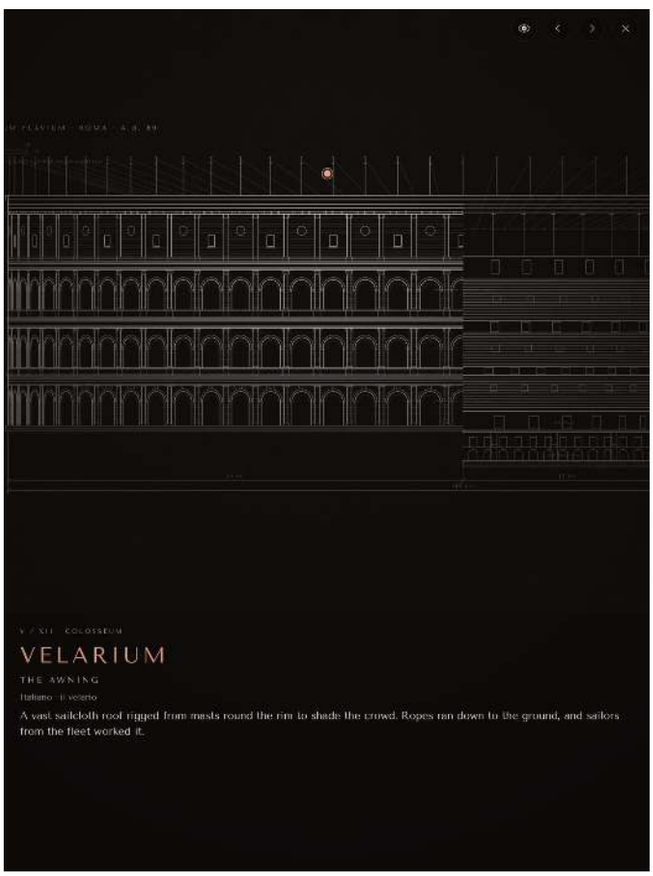
III Schola: a school worthy of the name

To look is to begin; to understand requires a path. *Schola*, the heart of the app, is a true course of study, ordered as a university orders its reading. Seven courses stand open. *Fundamenta* teaches the grammar itself: how to read a drawing, the classical orders, the arch and the dome. *Roma Aeterna* walks the Eternal City. *Italia* crosses the peninsula. *Ingenium* honours the engineers. *Magistri* tells of the patrons, architects and writers who made the buildings possible. *Peregrinatio* is a pilgrimage through all twenty regions. And *Mediolanum* is Milan, in depth. Forty books, eighty-six lessons.



Schola: seven courses, forty books · An examination: find the part upon the drawing · Tempora: thirty-six centuries on a single line

Every book closes with an examination, its questions drawn afresh each time: whose detail is this, when was it begun, how high does it rise, where does it stand. The student chooses the severity of the trial, from *Tiro*, the recruit, to *Magister*, the master, and a completed course is sealed with a diploma bearing the student's name. For those who teach, every book prints as a handout with its plates, its questions and a key; and in *Aula*, the classroom mode, a single plate fills the projector, lettered to be read from the last row of the hall, revealed one part at a time, its names withheld until the class has answered.



Aula, the classroom mode, on iPad: one plate, one part at a time, the names withheld until the class has answered.

Around the school lies an atlas in the fullest sense of the word: a map of Italy with every plate set in its place, plans of Rome and Milan, a timeline of thirty-six centuries from the nuraghi to the Bosco Verticale, and a page on which every building stands shoulder to shoulder at one scale, so that Trajan's Column may be measured against the Tower of Pisa with a single glance. And two studies reach deeper still. The first reopens the great dispute of 1391, when the masons of Milan argued over the geometry that would decide how high their cathedral should rise. The second recalls the anxious years of the 1740s, when mathematicians were summoned to judge whether the cracked dome of St Peter's would stand, and lets you test their verdict with weights, as Giovanni Poleni did.

IV

Silentium: the dignity of quiet

Neither work raises its voice. The museum speaks in a single typeface and draws its architecture in hairlines. The app is printed on three papers: *Nox*, lines of light upon the night; *Charta*, sepia and red chalk upon parchment; *Caerulea*, white lines upon the blue of an old blueprint. There are no advertisements. The app asks for no account and gathers no data; what you learn remains yours alone. It speaks English, Italian and Russian, and VoiceOver reads every plate aloud, while questions that depend on the eye are asked in another way for those who listen.

Neither is offered as a substitute for the journey. A drawing of the Pantheon is not the Pantheon, and no screen will ever give you the scale of the Colosseum or the cold of Sant'Ambrogio on a January morning. What they can do is prepare the eye, so that on the day you finally stand beneath the dome, you will know where to look, and you will know the names of the things you see. That is all we have ever wanted a journal to do.

> When and where: EPRIS Museum opens officially in October 2026 at museum.eprisjournal.com. Entry is free, at every hour, and the halls already stand open to those who wish to walk them first. Architectura: Italy Drawn arrives on the App Store for iPhone and iPad in October: free, without account, without advertising, without tracking. We will announce the App Store link here and in our newsletter on the day the doors open.

To the teachers, the students, the travellers and the simply curious: the doors are open, and they were made for you. Write to us. Tell us which building you would have us draw next, and which hall you would have us hang. *Intrate.* Come in. ▪

FURTHER

Enter EPRIS Museum	museum.eprisjournal.com
The open call for photographers and artists	museum.eprisjournal.com/open-call

FROM THE EDITORS JUL 7, 2026

The Heart of EPRIS: Maria Is Now a Bachelor of Architecture

On July 7th, Mariia Ivanova, EPRIS's editor-in-chief, officially became a Bachelor of Architecture. To mark the day – a heart built from the architecture and art that inspire her.

WORDS BY EPRIS JOURNAL

SECTION VI · FROM THE EDITORS · EPRIS JOURNAL

On July 7th, Mariia Ivanova, EPRIS's editor-in-chief, officially became a Bachelor of Architecture. To mark the day – a heart built from the architecture and art that inspire her.

Yesterday, on July 7th, 2026, something special happened in the life of the EPRIS editorial team. Mariia Ivanova – our editor-in-chief, and the person whose brainchild this journal is – officially became a Bachelor of Architecture. Years of drafting, models, and sleepless nights before her thesis defense are behind her now. A new chapter begins – and we couldn't let it pass without marking it here, on the pages of EPRIS.

It's no secret that an architect's eye runs through every issue of EPRIS – in the way we talk about space, light, and detail. Today, that eye earned its official credentials.

Those who worked alongside her on this issue know the ritual well: studio lights on late into the night, tracing paper covered in revisions, a cup of coffee gone cold beside the model she kept rebuilding until it finally felt right. That same restlessness – the refusal to settle for 'good enough' – is what has shaped this magazine since its very first page.

A Heart Made of What Inspired Her

Some of these buildings she has visited in person, sketchbook in hand. Others she has only ever seen in photographs. We hope that one day, she gets to see every single one of them with her own eyes. ▪

Architecture taught me to see the structure behind the beauty. EPRIS taught me to tell others about it. To me, they're two languages for the same feeling.

The EPRIS editorial team congratulates Mariia on her degree, and thanks her for the inspiration that lives in every issue of the journal. This diploma marks a new chapter – and we suspect it won't be the last one worth celebrating. We're glad you're reading it with us.

COLOPHON

The archive remains open

EDITOR IN CHIEF	Maria Ivanova
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EPRIS

ART · ARCHITECTURE · DESIGN · TIME

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